

The Age of Sundering

LINN NA TÌRE

The Legendarium of Dia-ùhìr

— The Age of Sundering

(An Aois Scaraidh)

being the Books of the age, the Annals of its years,
a Gazetteer of its towns, and the Appendices
the Landfall Era, LE 1 – 1,819

CONTENTS

PART ONE · THE BOOKS OF THE AGE

Chapter One: Of the Three Crews	14
I. Of the House as It Stood	14
II. Of a Word on the Quays	16
III. Of the Three Crews in the Red Hall.....	16
IV. Of the Question at the Lower Board.....	19
V. Of the Choosing Begun.....	20
VI. Of Mòrag and the Skipper	21
VII. Of the Queen at Her Window	23
VIII. Of What Stood at the End of the Year	24
 Chapter Two: Of the Boards in the Harbour-House	 26
I. Of Taigh a' Chalaidh.....	26
II. Of the Opening of the Roll.....	27
III. Of the Rule of the Whole Household.....	28
IV. Of Those Who Came	29
V. Of the First Striking-Out.....	30
VI. Of the Widow of the Strand	31
VII. Of the Harbour-House at Night	32
VIII. Of the Waiting for a Word	33
IX. Of Dòmhnall mac Chaluim and the Closing of the Boards	34
X. Of the Question His Wife Asked.....	35
 Chapter Three: Of the Queen's Word and the Queen's Sister.....	 37
I. Of the Bower in the Red Hall.....	37
II. Of the Word That Went Down the Road	39
III. Of the Reading at the Door.....	40
IV. Of Aonghas at Inis àrsaidh.....	41
V. Of the Knife	42
VI. Of the Vein-House above Muileann dhearg	43
VII. Of the Question of the Coal	44
VIII. Of the Count Made Twice	45
IX. Of Fearchar's Own Name.....	46
 Chapter Four: Of the Oaks of Doire fhionn.....	 48
I. Of a Wright Who Sewed Planks	48
II. Of the Keel in the Tellings.....	49
III. Of the Lady at Inis àrsaidh.....	50

IV. Of the Road North.....	51
V. Of Eilidh nic Ruairidh.....	52
VI. Of the Naming of the Trees.....	53
VII. Of the Felling.....	54
VIII. Of the Ox-Sleds on the North Road.....	55
IX. Of the First Keel.....	56
X. Of the Fellowship of the Strand.....	56
XI. Of the Frames Standing on the Strand.....	57

Chapter Five: Of the Hull that Lay Down.....59

I. Of the Launching of An Fhaoileag.....	59
II. Of the Following Sea.....	60
III. Of the Names Cut at Inis àrsaidh.....	62
IV. Of the Fire on the Strand.....	63
V. Of the Second Keel.....	64
VI. Of Those Who Struck Themselves Out, and Those Who Entered.....	65
VII. Of the Rope-Walks of Cuan shean.....	66
VIII. Of the Sail-Cloth of Baile àrsaidh.....	68
IX. Of the Hull that Stood Beside Her Sister.....	69

Chapter Six: Of the Star-Steersmen of Cuan ruadh..... 71

I. Of the Six Who Went East.....	71
II. Of the Steersman of Cuan ruadh.....	73
III. Of the First Trial and the Star Named on the Quay.....	77

Chapter Seven: Of the Handful for the New Hearth..... 81

I. Of the Boy Given to the Vein-House.....	81
II. Of the Petition.....	82
III. Of the Winter Burning.....	84
IV. Of the Clean Copy.....	86
V. Of the Measures Sealed.....	87
VI. Of the Masons Sent West.....	88
VII. Of the Queen on the New Stones.....	88
VIII. Of the Death of Uilleam mac Iain.....	90
IX. Of the Last Stone and the Sealing by Lamplight.....	90

Chapter Eight: Of the Grain Strife and the Forty-One Barges..... 92

I. Of the Lean Harvest.....	92
II. Of the Barred Doors.....	93
III. Of the Doors Reopened.....	96
IV. Of the Forty-One Barges.....	97
V. Of the Roll at Seann Skell.....	99
VI. Of the Hulls at the Quay.....	100

Chapter Nine: Of the Night of Lamps and the Sunwise Turn..... 103

I. Of the Queen on the New Stones	103
II. Of the Lamps on the Sills	105
III. Of Mòrag's Last Walk	108
IV. Of the Sunwise Turn.....	110
V. Of the Boundary Ditch	112

Chapter Ten: Of the Count from the Turn114

I. Of the Entry a Day Too Late	114
II. Of the Years of the Diosal.....	115
III. Of the Tidings that Reached Seann Skell	117
IV. Of the Hearths of Inis àrsaidh.....	119
V. Of the Copy that Went by Two Roads	120
VI. Of the Grain Ruling and the Bridge	122
VII. Of the Name Written the Ordinary Way.....	123
VIII. Of the Leaf Sanded	124

Chapter Eleven: Of the White Sorrow125

I. Of What Was Said at Seann Skell	125
II. Of the Second Count	127
III. Of the White Sorrow	129
IV. Of the Seven Houses	130
V. Of the Crowning at Cathair dhearg.....	132
VI. Of the Empty Place Laid Once More.....	134

Chapter Twelve: Of the Empty Harbour 136

I. Of the Boards Given Over	136
II. Of the Lamps Grown about the Berth	138
III. Of the Harbour at Half Trade.....	139
IV. Of the Word that Came and Was Not Written	140
V. Of the Watch at Ceann mhòr.....	142
VI. Of the New Name and the Old.....	142
VII. Of the Children Who Never Saw It.....	144
VIII. Of the Last Coaster and the Last Entry.....	144

Chapter Thirteen: Of the Moulds in the Fire..... 146

I. Of the Fellowship After Alasdair	146
II. Of the Last Journeymen and the Moulds Burned	148
III. Of a King's Death and a Line in the Custody-Book.....	149
IV. Of the Death of Niall mac Dhòmhnaill	151
V. Of the Coal-Breakers Below the Hill.....	152
VI. Of the Lots Drawn Among the Seven Houses	154
VII. Of the Stones Shown to a Visitor.....	155

VIII. Of the Last Entry	155
Chapter Fourteen: Of the King the Houses Made	157
I. Of Two Lines in One Book	157
II. Of a Boy at Baile Mòr dhomhain	159
III. Of the Silences in the Yard	161
IV. Of the Double Court	164
Chapter Fifteen: Of the Hawk of Acaill.....	167
I. Of the Glove at Cnoc bheag	167
II. Of the Empty Perch.....	169
III. Of Those Who Came to Hear.....	171
IV. Of the House at Ros gheal and the Flood at Seann Vell	172
V. Of the Marked Sayings.....	174
Chapter Sixteen: Of the FirLOT of Cathair dhearg	176
I. Of the Girl Who Counted the Baskets.....	176
II. Of the Crowning at Fifteen	178
III. Of Am Fuath Mòr and the Hooked Wall	178
IV. Of the Walls of Dùn dhearg and a Supper Kept Cold	180
V. Of the Quarrel over a Basket	182
VI. Of the Tally-Houses and the Long City's Market	183
VII. Of the Bridge	184
Chapter Seventeen: Of Carson an Làmh Seo	186
I. Of the Carters' Roads	186
II. Of the Grove at Muileann chiar.....	188
III. Of the House Raised at Dùn thais	189
IV. Of the Open Disputation	191
V. Of the Queen's Death and the Road Home	193
Chapter Eighteen: Of Salt and the Listing Hull.....	196
I. Of the Hull that Would Not Ride True.....	196
II. Of the Bridge-Keeper's Boyhood and the Springs on the Flats	198
III. Of a King's Death Far to the South and a Cloth Worn Nearer Home	199
IV. Of the Handful from Each Load	200
V. Of the Wells that Cracked at Cill ghlas	201
VI. Of the Hollow Man, a King's End, and the Fish of Àth fhiadhaich.....	203
Chapter Nineteen: Of the Stone that Cries Out and the Two Horses.....	206
I. Of the Net-Maker of Inis thais.....	206
II. Of the Wolf-House Roofed with Slate	208
III. Of the Harbour Shrine at Caol leathan	209
IV. Of Seann Skell Walled and the Market at the New Gate	210

V. Of Dòmhnall's Death	211
VI. Of the Two Horses.....	212
VII. Of the Fire at Tobar dhearg.....	214
Chapter Twenty: Of the Burned Tracts.....	216
I. Of the Woman Who Taught at Doire chiar.....	216
II. Of the Reading at Harvest	217
III. Of the Order from Muileann dhearg	218
IV. Of the Wood and the Road.....	219
V. Of the Copy Kept at Doire chiar.....	221
VI. Of Three Kings in a Single Generation	222
VII. Of the Second Son	224
VIII. Of the Byre at the Halfway Stage	224
Chapter Twenty-one: Of the Ferry on the Abhainn fhionn.....	227
I. Of the Bell at Muileann naomh	227
II. Of An Gàire Dubh	229
III. Of the Naming at Tobar dhreach	230
IV. Of the Child at Inis thais.....	231
V. Of Aonghas mac Iain's Death	232
VI. Of the Ferry on the Abhainn fhionn.....	233
VII. Of the Thirteen Years	235
VIII. Of the King's Death and the Houses Divided	236
Chapter Twenty-two: Of the Ford and the Fouled Wells.....	239
I. Of the Gates Shut Against All Three	239
II. Of the First Siege	240
III. Of the Ford at Àth shean	241
IV. Of Doire mhin, and of the Child Seònaid.....	243
V. Of the Second Siege	245
VI. Of Cathair dhomhain, and the Wells	246
VII. Of the Oath, and the Garrison Walking Out	247
Chapter Twenty-three: Of the Hearths Refused.....	250
I. Of the List in the Yard.....	250
II. Of the Cold Shires	253
III. Of the White Road	255
Chapter Twenty-four: Of Catriona Bhuadhach	260
I. Of the Wound That Would Not Close.....	260
II. Of the Sentence in the Yard.....	263
III. Of the Clerk and the Road	265
IV. Of the Single Day	268

Chapter Twenty-five: Of the Book of the Three Claimants	271
I. Of the Old Boards.....	271
II. Of the Witnesses	273
III. Of the Custody-Book at the Mountain	275
IV. Of the Book Made One Tale	277
V. Of the Reading at the Red Hall	279
Chapter Twenty-six: Of Manannan's Cup.....	282
I. Of the Preaching on the Quay.....	282
II. Of the Cup Carried Down the Coast.....	285
III. Of the Rule of the Headlands	288
Chapter Twenty-seven: Of the Bargain of the Counts.....	292
I. Of the Boy Set to the Tallies	292
II. Of the Wave and the Market	294
III. Of the Scribe of the Red Hall	295
IV. Of the Agreement.....	297
V. Of the Year the World Went On Without Him	299
Chapter Twenty-eight: Of the Sea-Thieves' Strand.....	302
I. Of the Boats Off the Small Islands	302
II. Of Half the Houses Standing Empty	305
III. Of the Force Asked and the Force Sent	306
IV. Of the Harvests That Would Not Come.....	309
V. Of the Roll Recopied and the Market at the Ford.....	311
Chapter Twenty-nine: Of the Crown Joined to the Vein.....	313
I. Of the Empty Hall	313
II. Of the Yard.....	315
III. Of the Joining	316
IV. Of the Mountain's Own King	318
V. Of the Hawk that Split	320
VI. Of the Fourteen Names and the Posts on the Road	322
Chapter Thirty: Of the Stair under the Hill.....	325
I. Of the Road and the Empty Pastures.....	325
II. Of the Stair under the Hill	328
III. Of the Ruins Ailean Measured.....	331
Chapter Thirty-one: Of the Thousandth Year	334
I. Of the Girl Who Kept the Tallies	334
II. Of the Letters No One Could Read.....	336
III. Of the Nets that Broke the Salt	337

IV. Of the Thousandth Year	338
V. Of the Daughter Born at the Turn of the Year	340
VI. Of the Market above the Mill-Race	341
VII. Of Baile Ghorm's Blue, and the Queen's Own Entry	342
Chapter Thirty-two: Of the Swallowing Cough	344
I. Of the Cough at Muileann dhomhain	344
II. Of the Reeve at the Ford	346
III. Of the Houses Taken by Lot	349
IV. Of the Bridge Built Anew	350
V. Of the Queen's Death	351
VI. Of the Fading Things	352
Chapter Thirty-three: Of the Table of Years	354
I. Of the Narrows and the New Harbour	354
II. Of the Millers and the Watcher in the Sea	356
III. Of the Table of Years	358
IV. Of the Gale, the Boundary and the Pilgrims	360
V. Of the Two Sons	362
Chapter Thirty-four: Of the Brothers' Peace	364
I. Of the Two Courts	364
II. Of the Burning of Ceann mhin and the Fall Below Muileann ghlas	366
III. Of the Keeper's Day	367
IV. Of the Years the Road Kept Its Peace	369
V. Of the Book, and the Meeting at the Far-Off House	371
Chapter Thirty-five: Of the Keel-Song	374
I. Of the Law That Lapsed	374
II. Of the Houses on the Circuit	375
III. Of the Hull That Filled	376
IV. Of the Fishers Who Went East, and the Lane to the South	377
V. Of Iseabail nic Lachlainn	378
VI. Of the Rope-Walk at Cuan shean	378
VII. Of the Reading at Court	380
VIII. Of the Schism, the Storm, and the New Harbour	382
IX. Of the Queen Small and the Grey Glaze	383
X. Of the Song Unexplained	383
Chapter Thirty-six: Of the Queen Who Went Round	385
I. Of the Oath of the Seven	385
II. Of the Stair Found Again, and the Dry Years	386
III. Of the Last of Clann Mhic Phàil	388
IV. Of the Queen Who Went Round	389

V. Of the Silver Refused and the Steel Lost.....	391
VI. Of the Short King and the Shut Sea	393

Chapter Thirty-seven: Of the Loft over the Mill 395

I. Of the Barge Kept on the Strand.....	395
II. Of the Widow of Muileann chaol.....	396
III. Of the Rag Paper.....	398
IV. Of the Three Copies.....	399
V. Of the North-West Counted	401
VI. Of the Loft Left to the Town	402
VII. Of the Roads, the Beasts, and the Empty Harbour Kept Thin.....	403

Chapter Thirty-eight: Of the Queen's Progress 406

I. Of the Sea-Wall of Cuan dhearg	406
II. Of the House Reopened at Dùn thais.....	407
III. Of the Death of the King.....	408
IV. Of the Progress and the Book of Grievances	409
V. Of the Silver Petition Refused.....	411
VI. Of the Last Count of Hands	412
VII. Of the Timber Out of the Mist	413
VIII. Of the Winter Burning She Did Not Come Down From	414
IX. Of the Last Lamp at Seann Skell	415

Chapter Thirty-nine: Of the Eleven and the Thinning Mist 417

I. Of the Eleven at Cidhe an Diosail	417
II. Of the Petition Laid Aside	419
III. Of the Chair Left Empty	421
IV. Of the Fisher of Ceann mhòr.....	423
V. Of the Last Winter	425

THE ANNALS OF THE AGE 429

The Years LE 1 – 100	430
The Years LE 101 – 200.....	456
The Years LE 201 – 300	461
The Years LE 301 – 400	467
The Years LE 401 – 500	473
The Years LE 501 – 600	480
The Years LE 601 – 700.....	490
The Years LE 701 – 800	496
The Years LE 801 – 900	502
The Years LE 901 – 1,000	508
The Years LE 1,001 – 1,100.....	512
The Years LE 1,101 – 1,200	517

The Years LE 1,201 – 1,300	520
The Years LE 1,301 – 1,400	525
The Years LE 1,401 – 1,500	529
The Years LE 1,501 – 1,600	531
The Years LE 1,601 – 1,700	535
The Years LE 1,701 – 1,800	538
The Years LE 1,801 – 1,819	544
 A GAZETTEER OF THE AGE	 547
 THE APPENDICES	 571
Appendix A. The Kings, the Queens and the Houses	573
Appendix B. The Orders and the Rites	583
Appendix C. The Reckoning of An Diosal	589
Appendix D. Wars, Raids and Calamities	595
Appendix E. Of Things Forgotten	601

CHAPTER ONE

Of the Three Crews

LE I

Cha chuir mi duine thairis, agus cha chùm mi duine air ais. I will
send no one over, and I will keep no one back.
— the queen's word, as the harbour songs of Seann Skell give it

I

Of the House as It Stood

In those days the island was a settled house, and it thought of itself so. The kings and queens of Dia-thìr kept their hall at Cathair dhearg on An Cnoc Ruadh¹, above the place where the mining roads came down to the Abhainn dhomhain. The custodians kept the vein under the mountain from Taigh na Fèithe² above the diggings at Muileann dhearg, which was the heir of Talla na Lasrach³, and they kept Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴ there, in which every hearth that held the right to the coal was written. At Dùn ìseal itself Brìde's flame still burned in Talla na Lasrach, and the stone cup stood on the threshold where the lords of the shares had sworn their peace, and Coimheadaichean na Lasrach⁵ came and went about it as their mothers had. Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁶ measured out an gual dathach⁷ hearth by hearth, a handful at a time, and it had not changed by a word since Fionnlagh Dall first filled the cup.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the Hall of the Flame

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

5. the Keepers of the Hall; lit. 'the watchers of the flame'

6. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

7. the coloured coal

The orders of An Creideamh Sean⁸ sat apart from one another at their own fires, and each thought itself the only true keeper. The dawn-hawk was flown at Cnoc bheag. An Fhianna kept their stone at Caol leathan. At Seann Skell in the west the harbour court swore its oaths over Manannan's cup with the scorpion on it, which breaks at a lie. Scoiltean nan Draoidhean⁹ argued over the question of the stag, and Òrd Mhacha¹⁰ read the omens of the two horses in the trees. The ancestors were fed at the hearths of the east in the old way, as they always had been. Of na h-Earrannan Mòra¹¹ into which the first king's kingdom had been parted there was little left but the stones on the bounds of the provinces, and the names of a few that the shires still answered to when the clerks were not listening.

And there was the sea. The sea was at the island's back, and nobody looked at it except to fish. The boats of Dia-thìr were sewn-plank coasters, their strakes stitched together with root and gut and caulked with moss and tallow, and they never slept a night out of sight of land. There was nothing out there that anyone wanted. An Saoghal Thall¹² lay west over the open water, the tellers said, Tìr nan Òg¹³ and Magh Meall¹⁴, with Donn's house on its rock on the way; but the living did not go there, and it did not come to them.

In that settled house there was a queen, Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill, who had been crowned in An Talla Dearg¹⁵ at fifteen, eight years before, when her mother Mòr nic Coinnich died. She was twenty-three. She had a husband, Uilleam mac Iain, who was kind and liked hounds, and as yet no child, and a younger sister, Mòrag, who was married to a steady man of the western shore and had come up to the capital that winter to be near her. And she had a scribe, Murchadh mac Eòghainn, who had served her mother and wrote a close square hand that the clerks of Leabhar a' Chùraim envied.

Into that house there came a rumour.

8. the Old Faith

9. the druid schools

10. the order of Macha

11. the nine great shares of the Division

12. the Otherworld; lit. 'the world beyond'

13. the land of the young

14. the plain of delight

15. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

II

Of a Word on the Quays

The word came first to the western quays in the deep of winter, in the moon of Faolach, when the storms walk up and down the coast and the boats lie drawn up above the tide-line. It came on 6 am Faoilleach, LE 1. Where it came from, the tellers at the hearth do not know, and they have never much minded. No one could point to the boat that brought it. It was simply there one morning on the quay at Cuan shean, as a smell of smoke is there, and by evening everyone on the waterfront had heard it: that out over the open sea, farther than any coaster had ever gone, there was a coast, and no one lived on it who was like the Dia-thirich.

The fishers of Cuan shean said it to one another as they mended nets in the lee of the rope-sheds. They said it at the fire in the long house where the crews ate. By the end of the moon they were saying it at Ros bheag, and at Inis àrsaidh, and up the coast at Ceann mhòr, where the north-west headlands run out into weather. Nobody said he had seen the coast. Everybody knew a man who knew a man.

Eachann mac Lachlainn was the skipper of a boat of six oars out of Cuan shean, a broad slow man with a grey beard cut square, who had fished the same water for thirty years and did not believe anything until he had it in his hands. He heard the tale three times in one day and laughed at it three times. Then his own sister's son, who crewed for him, said that he had been told it by a woman who had been told it by a pilot of Ros bheag, who had been blown off the land in the autumn gales and had come back after nine days with his water gone and his eyes strange; and that the pilot had said he saw the coast before the wind turned. Eachann went to find the pilot. The pilot, when he was found, said that he had seen nothing but grey water and his own death, and that anyone who said otherwise was a liar. But he said it too loudly, and he would not look at Eachann while he said it.

That was the way of it all winter. Every telling led back to another telling. Every man who might have been first said that it was not he.

III

Of the Three Crews in the Red Hall

By the moon of Samhnas it had reached the capital. The crews came up the river road from the west, as crews did when the fishing was done, to sell salt fish and seal-oil at the autumn market below An Cnoc Ruadh¹ and drink the proceeds; and they brought the tale with them, and it got into the town and up the hill and through the door of An Talla Dearg², and on 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1, the queen sent for them.

Three crews came, one after another, over the course of that moon. The first was Eachann mac Lachlainn's of Cuan shean. The second was a crew of Ros bheag, whose skipper was a woman, Oighrig nic Raghnaill, lean and quick, with a scar along her jaw where a line had once parted. The third came late, from Ceann mhòr in the far north-west, three days on the road: a crew of hard, silent men under Tòmas mac Uilleim, who looked at An Talla Dearg as though it might sink.

The queen had them in at the board after the day's pleas, one crew each night, with the fire built up and bread and ale set out, as if they were guests and not witnesses. She sat at the head of the board in her chair of black oak. Her husband sat on her right, and on her left Murchadh mac Eòghainn with his board and his pen and a leaf of good skin. The lesser household ate at the lower board and listened. Mòrag was among them, with her husband, Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh, beside her.

Eachann told it first, standing, with his cap crushed in his two hands. He told it plainly, as he would have told the price of fish. A coast lay out over the open water, he said, west and north of west, many days off. It was low and dark, with a white edge where the sea broke. There was smoke on it in places but no hall and no boat. The water there was colder than ours, and the fish were bigger. He had not seen it. He knew a man who had.

"Were you the first to hear it?" the queen said.

Eachann thought about that honestly, turning his cap. "No, lady," he said. "I was about the last."

Murchadh wrote it all, in his close square hand, and at the end of the telling he read it back aloud. Eachann listened with his head on one side, like a dog listening for a whistle, and then said, "Aye. That's it," and sat down and drank his ale, and was very much relieved.

The second night Oighrig nic Raghnaill told it otherwise. The coast lay north, she said, a long way north, past the north cape and beyond Uilebheist na Mara³'s

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

water, and it was high: cliffs, and a great river coming down white out of them, and forests running to the edge of the cliffs, taller than any oaks on the island. There was no smoke on it at all. The pilot who had seen it was her mother's cousin, and he had sworn to it on the cup at Seann Skell, and the cup had not broken. Would a man lie on the cup?

"Men have," said Uilleam mac Iain from the queen's right hand, mildly. He was fond of the harbour court's stories.

"Not that one," said Oighrig, and looked at him until he looked away.

"Were you the first to hear it?" said the queen.

"No, lady. Half of Ros bheag had it before me."

The third night Tòmas mac Uilleim of Ceann mhòr told it hardly at all. He stood with his men behind him like a wall and said, in the thick speech of the north-west, that the coast was east, over the grey water where the mist lies, and that you could smell it on certain mornings when the wind came round, a smell of pine and wet ash; and that the old men of Ceann mhòr had always said there was land there, and had said so to their sons since before there was a queen in Cathair dhearg or a hall on An Cnoc Ruadh or a cup at Dùn ìseal. The rest of the island had only now caught up with them.

"Have you seen it?" the queen said.

"Nobody sees it. It's behind the mist."

"Were you the first to hear it?"

Tòmas looked at her for a while. "Lady," he said, "we never heard anything else."

When the three crews had gone and the fire was low, Murchadh sat at the end of the board and read over what he had written on the three nights. The queen sat and watched him. He was an old man and had written down a great deal in his life, and he did not often frown at his own work; but he frowned now. At last he dipped his pen and wrote a line at the foot of the leaf, below the third telling, and sanded it, and turned the leaf round on the board so that she could read it.

They agree on the coast, and on nothing else.

Beathag read it twice, and then smiled for the first time in three nights. "That's the truest thing on the leaf," she said.

"It is the only thing on the leaf I am sure of, lady," said Murchadh.

3. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

IV

Of the Question at the Lower Board

There was one other thing said in the hall in those three nights, and Murchadh did not write it, because it was not a telling. The queen remembered it.

It was on the first night, when Eachann had finished and sat down and was drinking his ale with the sweat drying on him. The questions went round the board as they did after any plea. The queen's husband asked whether the fish were really bigger. A custodian who happened to be at court asked whether there were any coal on the far coast, and whether anyone had broken it to see what colour it was, and Eachann said he had no idea and that the man who had seen it was not the kind to go breaking stones. A lady of the household asked if the people were tall.

"There are no people, lady," said Eachann. "That's the whole of it. There's nobody there."

"There's smoke," someone said.

"Smoke is not people," said Eachann, and that was felt to be a good answer, and people laughed.

Then from the lower board Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill said, not loudly: "How many days' water would a boat need?"

Eachann turned round on his bench to see who had asked. He did not know her. "Days' water?"

"To get there. If a boat went. How much water would she carry, and for how many days, and how many would she carry, to get there and have some over."

There was a small silence at the upper board. It was not a question anyone had thought to ask. It belonged to a different kind of talk.

"No boat of ours could get there, lady," said Eachann. "A boat of ours would come apart in a night out of sight of land. She's sewn, you see. She works in a sea, all her seams working, and she wants to be pulled up on a beach every night and let dry. You couldn't get a boat of ours there."

"Then what kind of boat could?"

He opened his mouth and shut it. He was an honest man. "I don't know," he said. "Nobody's ever built one."

"No," said Mòrag. "Nobody has." And she let the talk go on to other things, and ate her bread, and did not speak again that night.

Beathag watched her sister over the rim of her cup. Mòrag was nineteen. She had been married two years, to a man of the western shore whom she had chosen herself and who adored her quietly and without fuss; she had a house at Inis àr-saidh, near Seann Skell, and no child yet; and she had the same face their mother had had, long and steady, which people called calm. Beathag had known her all her life, and knew better. She had seen that face at eight years old, looking at the ice on the mill-pond at Cathair dhearg in the moon of Faolach, the day before Mòrag walked out on it to see if it would bear her.

It had borne her. That was the trouble with Mòrag. Things mostly did.

V

Of the Choosing Begun

After the three crews went home, the tale did not go home with them.

It went down the river road into the west, and up the coal-roads into the mountain country, and along the coast in every boat that put in anywhere. By the moon of Dubhlas, the black moon at the dark of the year, it was being told at hearths from Baile chrom in the north-west to Seann Vell in the south-east. At most hearths it was told as one tells of a wonder, and then the talk turned to the price of barley. At some it was not.

An Roghnachadh¹ began then, though nobody called it that, and it began without anyone beginning it. The chronicles call it a vote, and so it is written on 8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1; but there was no day in that winter on which anyone stood up and called for hands, and no roll yet, and no rule. There was only a question that began to be asked at certain hearths, quietly, after the children were asleep: *Would we go?* And the question, once asked at a hearth, did not go away from it again.

It was asked first, and most, on the west coast, where the tale had come in and where the people knew boats. At Inis àrsaidh, the fishing town at the mouth of the river below Seann Skell, two households said aloud in the drying-shed, before the whole town, that if a boat were ever made that could get there, they would be on it. The town laughed at them. The two households did not laugh, and after a while the town stopped. At Ros bheag they argued about it in the long house till

1. the Choosing; lit. 'the choosing'

the fire went out. At Cuan shean the rope-makers, who had nothing to do with the sea except to sell it rope, said the whole thing was fishermen's nonsense and that nobody would ever build such a boat. But they said it every night.

It was asked, too, in places nobody expected. The custodians of the vein, who held the right to the coal by apprenticeship and by the long training of the hands, turned out to have more in them of the wish to see a new thing than anyone had supposed. Perhaps it was because the coal had taught them that the world had more colours in it than most people could see. Perhaps it was only that they were bored. But when the tale came to Taigh na Fèithe², some of the young custodians sat up half the night over it; and one of them, a man of the western diggings called Fearchar mac Ruairidh, went down to the capital in the moon of Dubhglas on some errand of Taigh na Fèithe's and asked, while he was there, to be told the three tellings from Murchadh's leaf.

There was no rule in it, and that is the thing the tellers find hardest to believe. Nobody drew lots. No lord told his people to go, and no priest told them to stay. Those who wished to, went on wishing; those who did not, did not. They have tried every way to find a cause in it: a dearth, a quarrel, a prophecy, a sickness in the coal. There was none. The harvest had been good. The island was at peace. It was only that a door had been opened in a wall that everyone had thought was solid, and some people found they wanted to go through it.

VI

Of Mòrag and the Skipper

Mòrag went down to Cuan shean before the moon was out.

She told her sister she was going to see to the house at Inis àrsaidh before the worst of the winter, which was true. With Aonghas and two servants she went down the river road, three short days in the rain, and saw to the house. And then she borrowed a pony and rode on down the coast the dozen miles to Cuan shean, alone, and found Eachann mac Lachlainn mending a net in the lee of a rope-shed, and sat down on an upturned tub beside him, and asked him the whole thing again.

He was surprised to see her, and then less surprised. He told it again. She asked him questions that nobody in An Talla Dearg¹ had asked: how long the pilot of

Ros bheag had been out; which way the wind had been; what the stars had been doing, if he had seen them; how a coaster's seams worked in a sea, and how long before they started, and whether a thicker plank would help, and what wood the planks were, and whether there was any wood on the island big enough for a boat that did not need sewing.

"Oak," said Eachann at last, after a long time. "If you wanted a boat that didn't need sewing. You'd want oak. Big oak, and a keel to her, like the old tellings say Rìghrean na Cloiche² boats had, and you'd want a man who knew how to set a keel. There's nobody alive that knows that."

"Somebody might learn."

"Somebody might." He tied off his knot and bit the twine. "Lady, is the queen going to send ships?"

"The queen," said Mòrag, "has said nothing at all."

That was true too. Beathag had said nothing at all, all winter. She had heard the three tellings and had Murchadh write them, and then she had gone back to pleas of boundary ditches and grain dues and a quarrel between two millers of Muileann bhàn over a stream, and if anyone raised the far coast at her board she listened politely and changed the subject. The court had decided that she thought it nonsense. Mòrag knew that she did not.

"She'll have to say something," said Eachann. "Sooner or later. If folk start meaning it."

"Yes," said Mòrag. "She will." She stood up and thanked him and gave him a silver ring off her finger for his trouble, which he tried not to take and then took, and rode back to Inis àrsaidh in the dark with the rain behind her.

Aonghas was waiting up for her by the fire. He looked at her face when she came in, and did not ask where she had been.

"There's nobody alive that knows how to set a keel," she said, sitting down and holding out her wet hands to the fire.

"No," said Aonghas.

"But there's oak."

"There's oak," he agreed. He got up and fetched her a dry shawl and put it round her, and sat down again, and after a while he said: "Doire fhionn. Up the north road. The grove there has the biggest oaks on the island. My grandfather used to say you couldn't see the tops from the ground."

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

Mòrag turned and looked at him. He was looking at the fire.

"I've been thinking about it too," he said.

VII

Of the Queen at Her Window

Beathag found out, of course. She had the reports of every reeve in the west, and a sister's movements are not a secret in a country where the queen's sister is known by sight in every harbour. A rider brought word to An Talla Dearg¹ that the lady Mòrag had been at Cuan shean, and had sat an afternoon with the skipper Eachann mac Lachlainn, and had given him a ring.

She said nothing about it. When Mòrag came back up the river road at the turn of the year, before the moon of Faolach, the sisters ate together as they always did, and talked of the house at Inis àrsaidh and the damp in its north wall, and of Uilleam's hounds, one of which had had pups under the queen's own bed. Mòrag did not speak of the coast and Beathag did not ask.

But on the morning Mòrag and Aonghas were to go back west for good, Beathag stood at the window of her bower, which looked down over the yard of An Talla Dearg to the gate and the river road beyond it, and watched them go.

It was a clear cold morning with the frost still on the cobbles. Aonghas saw to the ponies. Mòrag stood in the middle of the yard in her grey travelling cloak and talked to someone. Beathag did not know him at first; then she did. It was Eachann mac Lachlainn, the skipper of Cuan shean, who had come up the river road again with some errand of his own, or with none, and had stopped at the hall to pay his respects.

They were not talking about anything. Beathag could see that from the window. Mòrag was asking something and Eachann was answering and drawing a shape in the air with his hand, long and pointed at both ends, and Mòrag was nodding. Then she laughed, and put her hand on the skipper's arm, and walked with him to the gate as a lady walks a friend to the gate. At the gate she stopped and looked out along the river road, west, toward the sea, as though she could see down it all the way to the coast; and stood so for a long moment, not moving, with the skipper beside her waiting to be dismissed.

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

Beathag had seen her sister look at a great many things. She had never seen her look at anything like that.

She stood at the window until the ponies had gone out through the gate and down the road and round the shoulder of the hill. Then she went down to the hall, where the day's pleas were waiting, and Murchadh with his board.

"Lady," said the old man, "the millers of Muileann bhàn are here again about the stream."

"Let them wait a little," said Beathag. She sat down in the black oak chair and looked at the empty board for a while. "Murchadh. The leaf of the three crews. You have it safe?"

"In the chest, lady."

"Good. Leave it there." She was silent again. Then she said: "Write nothing of the lady Mòrag's journey to Cuan shean. Nor of the skipper at the gate this morning. None of it is a matter for the roll."

Murchadh looked at her. He had served her mother, and he had known both sisters since they were in the cradle, and he was not a fool. "Lady," he said, "it is not a matter for the roll yet."

"No," said Beathag. "Yet." And she sent for the millers.

VIII

Of What Stood at the End of the Year

So ended the first year of the age, though nobody on the island knew that an age had begun. The kings of Dia-thìr had always counted their years by their own reigns and by the harvests, and that year was written in the rolls of An Talla Dearg¹ as the ninth year of Queen Beathag, a good year for barley and a middling one for fish, and in Leabhar a' Chùrain² at Taigh na Fèithe³ as a year in which the handful was measured and burned at every lawful hearth and the galleries gave as they always gave.

Nothing had been built. No boat had been laid down, no oak felled, no roll opened, no word given. The queen had said nothing. The custodians had said nothing. The three crews had gone back to their fishing, and in the spring Oighrig

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

nic Raghnaill's boat of Ros bheag took the best catch of herring on the west coast in ten years and she forgot, for a whole moon, to talk about anything else.

But there was a question at certain hearths now, and it would not go away. At Inis àrsaidh two households had said aloud that they would go. Up at Taigh na Fèithe a young custodian had asked to hear the three tellings. On the beach at Cuan shean a skipper who had never believed anything until he held it had begun to draw, in the air and on the sand of the beach and on the planks of his own boat with a burnt stick, the shape of a hull that did not yet exist, long and pointed at both ends, and to stare at what he had drawn. And at Inis àrsaidh, near Seann Skell, the queen's sister and her husband sat up at night by the fire and talked about oak.

CHAPTER TWO

OF the BOARDS in the HARBOUR-HOUSE

LE 2

I

Of Taigh a' Chalaiddh

Taigh a' Chalaiddh stood at the head of the west quay, where the Abhainn namh widens into its river pool before it goes down to the sea. It was a long low house of grey stone with a turf roof, older than anyone could say, and it had a single door facing the water and a single window facing the town, so that whoever sat inside could see both the boats and the people who owned them. The town called it Taigh a' Chalaiddh¹, the harbour-house, and nothing else, as though there were no other harbour in the world.

In it sat the harbour scribe, and in the second year of the age the harbour scribe was Calum mac Nèill.

He was a spare, stooped man of thirty-odd with ink in the cracks of his fingers and a habit of humming through his nose while he worked, which his wife said would drive her into the river. His father had been harbour scribe before him, and his father's mother before that. The office was not a great one. He kept the rolls of the harbour: which boat lay at which berth, who owed dues and who had paid them, what came in and what went out, fish and salt and seal-oil, hides from up the river, barley down it. He wrote on boards. Leabhar a' Chùrain² at Taigh na Fèithe³ was kept on good skin, and the queen's scribe at Cathair dhearg wrote on

1. the harbour-house

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

skin; but the harbour of Seann Skell had never had so much money that it could write its daily business on anything better than planed boards of alder, which could be scraped and written again, and hung on pegs along the walls in rows.

Calum liked the boards. He liked the sound of the knife cutting the letters, a small dry sound, and the curl of the shaving, and the way a board held what was cut into it. A skin could be scraped clean and no one the wiser. A cut in a board showed.

He was not a man who thought much about the sea. The sea was where the boats went, and he wrote down when they came back.

II

Of the Opening of the Roll

The talk of the far coast had been going on in Seann Skell for a year and a half, as it had been going on everywhere in the west, when the first household came into the harbour-house and asked to be written down.

It was in the moon of Pailteach, the moon of plenty, at the end of harvest. The barley was in and the herring had not yet come, and the town was idle and restless. A fisher of Inis àrsaídh came in off the quay with his wife behind him, and stood before Calum's board with his cap in his hand, and said that he wished his household entered.

"Entered for what?" said Calum. He had a board of harbour dues on his knee and was adding it up.

"For going," said the fisher. "When the ships go."

Calum put the dues board down. "There are no ships," he said.

"There will be," said the fisher's wife. She was a sturdy woman with forearms like a baker's, and she looked at Calum as though he were being slow on purpose. "Everybody says. And when they go, there'll be a hundred wanting to go on them, and they'll want to know who asked first. So we want it written. Now. Who asked first. You write the harbour, don't you? This is harbour."

Calum looked at them for a long moment. He thought of telling them to go home. He thought of the queen at Cathair dhearg, who had said nothing all this while, and of the custodians at Taigh na Fèithe¹, who had said nothing either; and

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

it occurred to him that if he sent these two away, they would go to some other scribe, or to no scribe, and the thing would be written badly or not at all. And a harbour scribe of Seann Skell did not like a thing to be written badly.

So he got up and took down a new board of alder from the rack, and planed it smooth, and cut at the head of it, in his best letters:

Those who mean to go.

Then he sat down again and asked the fisher his name.

He wrote it on 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2. That board was the first of the roll, which Leabhar a' Chùrain² afterward called Rolla nan Deònach³, and it hung on the wall of the harbour-house at Seann Skell for longer than anyone then living would live.

III

Of the Rule of the Whole Household

he wrote more than the fisher's name. That was the first thing he decided, and he decided it before he had thought about it, with his knife already in the wood.

"Who is your household?" he said.

The fisher looked puzzled. "Me. Her. The two boys. My mother, that lives with us."

"Does your mother mean to go?"

The fisher and his wife looked at each other. "We've not asked her," said the wife.

"Then go and ask her," said Calum, "and come back, and I'll write you all, or none of you."

They stared at him. The fisher said, a little hotly, that he did not see what his mother had to do with it. Calum put down his knife and explained it, slowly, as he would have explained a harbour due, and in the explaining he found out what he thought.

The coal was the reason. Every hearth on the island that held the right to the coal was entered by Taigh na Fèithe¹ in Leabhar a' Chùrain², and every season the

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the roll of the willing

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

handful was measured out to the hearth, the whole house that sat round one fire, and never to a single man or woman. A hearth was one thing in Leabhar a' Chùrain's eyes. If half of a household went and half stayed, what then? Two hearths where there had been one, each with half a right? Or one cold half-hearth and the handful measured to nobody? The custodians would not stand for it. And a household, Calum said, was a hearth to more than the custodians. A boy did not go over the sea and leave his grandmother by the fire. Or if he did, he should have to stand in the harbour-house and say so, before the whole town, with his grandmother beside him.

"So you'll write us whole," said the fisher's wife slowly, "or not at all."

"I'll write you whole," said Calum, "or not at all."

She thought about that. Then she nodded, once, as if she had been haggling over fish and had got a fair price. "That's right," she said. "That's how it should be." And she took her husband by the arm and went to ask his mother.

They came back the next morning, all five of them, the old woman on a stick at the rear, and stood in a row before the board while Calum cut their names, one under another, joined by a line down the left side that he cut last to show they were one household. The old woman watched the knife the whole time. When he had finished she said, "Is that us, then?" and he said it was, and she touched the board with one finger, very lightly, where her name was, and went out without another word.

That was how the roll came to be written by household and never by single name. The tellers have made a great deal of it since, and said that going was a thing a family did together or not at all. So it was. But it began with a scribe who did not wish to argue with Taigh na Fèithe over half a hearth.

IV

Of Those Who Came

After the first household, the harbour-house was never empty.

They came in off the quay all through the autumn: fishers with tar on their hands and salt in the creases of their faces, who had been out past the headlands in weather and thought they knew what the sea was; boat-wrights from

the strand below the town; net-makers, rope-makers, a cooper. They came down the Abhainn naomh from the farms up the river in carts, the farm wives with a child on the hip and another at the skirt, and stood in the doorway blinking at the dark after the bright river. A shepherd came from the hills behind the town with his dog, and the dog lay down under the board and would not be moved. A young woman came alone, with no household but herself, and Calum had to decide whether one was a household; he decided that it was.

They asked him questions he could not answer. Where would they go? When? In what? Who would lead them? How many would there be? Would the queen send them, or forbid them? Would the coal go with them? He said, over and over, that he did not know, that he was only the harbour scribe, that he wrote down the harbour. They looked at him as if he were keeping something back. Some of them brought him gifts, a string of fish, a pot of honey, as if a gift would get them a better place on the board. He gave the gifts back, which offended them more than keeping them would have done.

By the moon of Damhrach there were four boards on the wall.

And they went away again. That was the part nobody had expected, and it was the part that stayed with Calum longest.

V

Of the First Striking-Out

The first to strike out was a net-maker of the town, a man of forty called Iain, whom Calum had known all his life. He had entered his household in the first week, himself and his wife and three children, in a loud cheerful voice, and stood talking in the doorway afterward about the fish they would take off the far coast, as big as calves.

He came back before the moon was out.

Late in the day, when the harbour-house was empty, he came in and stood before the board with his face grey. He did not say anything for a while. Then he said, "Strike us out."

Calum looked up at him. "What's happened?"

"Nothing's happened." Iain rubbed his face with both hands. "Nothing. I woke up in the night and lay there, and I thought: the sea. That's all. I thought of

the sea at night, with no land. And I couldn't breathe, Calum. I couldn't get my breath. My wife held me like a child. Strike us out."

Calum took down the board, and found the name, and took his knife and cut it through: one long stroke through the middle of each letter, from the first letter of Iain's name to the last of his youngest child's, and then the line down the left side that joined them, cut across at the top and the bottom.

Iain watched him do it. When it was done he said, low: "Can't you scrape it off? So nobody knows?"

Calum turned the board so that the net-maker could see it. The names were still there, every letter, with the stroke through them.

"No," he said. "I can't."

"You scrape the dues boards. I've seen you."

"When a due is paid, I scrape it, because it's done and no one needs it. This isn't done." Calum hung the board back on its peg. He did not know, until he said it, that he believed it. "You meant to go, Iain. That was true. And now you don't, and that's true too. The board will say both. If I scrape it off, it'll only say the second, and that's half a lie."

Iain stood there a moment longer. Then he laughed, not happily, and said, "You're a hard man for a scribe," and went out.

He came back the next spring and entered his household again. By midsummer he had struck it out again. Calum cut the second stroke through the second entry without a word, and the net-maker did not ask him to scrape it.

VI

Of the Widow of the Strand

There were others. There was the young couple from up the river who entered, and struck out when the wife found she was with child, and entered again when the child was born, and struck out again when it sickened. A pair of brothers, rope-makers, who entered together and then quarrelled and came in separately on the same day, one to strike and one to stay, and had to be told that they were one household and must agree or be struck together; they went out shouting at each other, and came back together at dusk, and struck. There was the shepherd, whose dog died that winter, who came in and struck out and said it would not be right to go without the dog.

And there was the widow of the strand, whose coming and going ran through the whole of that first year and beyond it.

Her name is not on any board that survives, so she will not be named here. She was a boat-wright's widow, a thin woman with white hair who lived in a hut on the strand below the town among the sawpits and the half-built coasters, and who came up to the harbour-house in the moon of Samhnas, in the first rain, to be entered, alone. Calum wrote her. She came back in the moon of Dubhlas, in the dark of the year, and asked to be struck. He struck her. She came back in the moon of Faolach, in the wolf-storms, and asked to be entered again. He looked at her a long while, and then wrote her again, on a new line, below the first entry with its stroke through it.

In the moon of Gearras, after Là Fhèill Bhrìde, she came again.

"Strike me," she said.

He took the knife. Before he cut, he said, "May I ask why?"

She looked at the board, at her own name written twice and struck once. "My husband's in the ground behind the strand," she said. "Every time I think of going, I think of him there and nobody to cut the grass on him. And every time I think of staying, I think of him there and me on the strand looking at the water all the rest of my days, and I think, he'd have gone. He'd have gone the first day. He'd have been in here before the fisher." She was quiet. "So I go back and forth. Strike me."

He struck her. And she did not come back, that spring or ever; and when the harbour scribe of a later year took down the boards to count them, he found the widow's name written three times and struck three times, one under another, like a ladder.

VII

Of the Harbour-House at Night

The roll changed the harbour-house, and it changed the town's use of it.

It had been a place where people came to pay their dues and quarrel about berths. Now it was a place where people came to say the most important thing they had ever said, in front of the harbour scribe and whoever else happened to be standing in the doorway. It became something between a court and a shrine. People came in who had no business with the roll at all, only to look

at the boards, to read the names, to see who was going and who had changed his mind. Old men sat on the bench by the door all day and watched. Children dared each other to touch the boards. Once a woman came in and read the whole roll through, board by board, very slowly, and then went and sat on the quay and wept for an hour, and no one ever found out whose name she had been looking for.

People came at night, too. The ones who could not say it by day came after dark, when the quay was empty. So Calum began to keep a lamp burning in the harbour-house late, long after the harbour's own business was done, and to sit up by it with a board on his knee, in case anyone came. His wife complained of the cost of the oil. He paid for it out of his own pocket, and went on doing it.

And they came. A man who had fought his father for a month over it, and won, and could not bear to see his father's face while he said it. A girl who was not supposed to be out of her mother's house. A custodian's servant, sent secretly by his master to read what the roll held and count it for Taigh na Fèithe¹, who confessed as much at once, and whom Calum let read, because the roll was not a secret.

VIII

Of the Waiting for a Word

All that autumn the town waited for the queen to speak, and she did not. **A** It was the first thing anyone asked a rider off the river road: had the queen said anything? And the rider always said no, and the asker always looked as though he had been cheated of something he was owed. A great many people in Seann Skell, it turned out, had been sure that the crown would decide it for them one way or the other. Some hoped she would forbid it, so that they could be angry with her and stay. Some hoped she would command it, so that they could go and blame her. Most, Calum thought, hoped she would do something, anything, so that the thing would be taken out of their own hands and they could sleep.

The talk on the bench by the door ran every way. The queen was against it and waiting for it to die down. The queen was for it and waiting for the custodians.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

The queen's sister had been seen at Cuan shean asking about boats, so the queen must mean to send her. The queen had quarrelled with her sister over it and they no longer spoke. An old man who had once carried a message to An Talla Dearg¹ and had never since let anyone forget it said that the queen was a deep one, like her mother, and would say nothing until the last moment and then say exactly the right thing; and everyone on the bench agreed with him, and none of them could say what the right thing would be.

The custodian's servant who had come to read the roll by night came again in the moon of Damhrach, and this time he brought a question from his master. How many households on the boards held the right to the coal? Calum did not know. He had not asked. The harbour roll was not Leabhar a' Chùrainn², and a fisher did not tell the harbour scribe whether his hearth took the handful. The servant went away with his question unanswered, and Calum sat a long while afterward looking at the boards, and understood for the first time that somewhere up in the mountain country, sixty miles off, men who had never set foot on the quay were counting his roll against their own, and that what they found in it would matter to them far more than it mattered to him.

It frightened him a little. He had cut the first board because a fisher's wife had told him it was harbour business, and she had been right. Now it was Taigh na Fèithe's business too, and An Talla Dearg's; and he had the uneasy sense of a man who has laid a plank across a ditch for his own use and turns round to find a cart coming over it.

He did not close the boards. But he began to write more carefully, and to ask of each household, before he cut, whether its hearth took the handful; and he put a small mark beside those that did, a notch like a flame, so that when the question came again he could answer it.

IX

Of Dòmhnall mac Chaluim and the Closing of the Boards

Calum's son Dòmhnall was his clerk that year, a quiet, serious boy of fourteen who was learning the knife. He watched the roll grow and shrink and

1. the red hall, the rich's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

grow again through that first autumn, and one night in the moon of Damhrach, by the late lamp he said what he had been thinking.

"You should close it."

Calum looked up.

"The roll," said Dòmhnall. "Close the boards. Nobody's asked you to keep them. The queen hasn't. Taigh na Fèithe¹ hasn't. You started it yourself, because a fisher came in, and now it's eating the harbour-house. You can't get the dues done for people in the doorway. Half the town's in here every day crying. It isn't harbour business. Close it and tell them to go to the queen."

Calum thought about it honestly. His son was right on every count but one.

"The queen hasn't said close it," he said. "Nor has she said open it. She's said nothing at all. And while she says nothing, who is to say whether a man may go or not? Not me. I'm the harbour scribe. I write the harbour." He laid his hand flat on the board on his knee. "These people have a right to have it written, what they mean. If I shut the boards, I've said no for them. And I'm not the one to say no."

"Then who is?"

"Nobody, maybe." Calum was quiet for a while. "Maybe that's the answer. Maybe there's no one who can say no."

Dòmhnall did not argue. But when he went to bed he looked back from the door, and saw his father still sitting by the lamp, not writing anything, looking at the boards on the wall.

X

Of the Question His Wife Asked

Calum's wife was a practical woman named Seonag, who kept geese and sold their eggs on the quay, and she had watched the roll all winter with a face that told him nothing. She did not ask him about it and he did not tell her. They talked about the geese and the price of oil and Dòmhnall's knife-hand, which was coming along.

Then, the same night, lying in the dark in the box-bed with the wind going over the roof, she said: "Would you go?"

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

He lay still. He could hear the river running past the end of the quay, and a loose board somewhere on the harbour-house knocking.

"The boards need a keeper," he said.

She did not answer that. After a while she turned over, away from him, toward the wall. He thought she had gone to sleep. Then she said, into the dark, quite quietly: "That's not what I asked. And that's the answer anyway, isn't it. You want to."

He did not say anything. There was nothing he could say that would not be a lie, and he had spent the whole winter refusing to scrape a lie onto a board.

In the morning he went down to the harbour-house as usual, and lit the lamp, though it was daylight, and sat down by it. And the first to come in that day was a boat-wright of the strand, a lean dark man called Alasdair mac Iain, who did not come to be entered. He came to read the roll. He read every board on the wall, slowly, moving his lips, and then he stood in the middle of the floor and said to no one in particular, "There's not a boat on this island that could carry the half of them."

"No," said Calum.

"Then somebody had better build one," said Alasdair, and went out.

CHAPTER THREE

OF the QUEEN'S WORD and the QUEEN'S SISTER

LE 2 – 3

I

Of the Bower in the Red Hall

Mòrag came up the river road to Cathair dhearg in the moon of Damhrach, when the stags were roaring on the hills above the Abhainn dhomhain and the first gales were stripping the rowans. She came alone but for one servant, and she did not go to the hall. She went straight up the back stair to her sister's bower, as she had done since they were girls, and knocked once and went in.

Beathag was at the window with one of her husband's shirts in her lap, sewing a patch on the elbow. She did not look surprised.

"You've come about the roll," she said.

"I've come about you," said Mòrag. She took off her wet cloak and hung it on the peg by the door, where their mother's cloak had hung, and sat down on the chest under the window without being asked. "Half the west is waiting on you. The harbour-house at Seann Skell has five boards full, and it's full of people every day asking whether the queen will send them or forbid them. Nobody knows what to do. They say the crown will decide."

"And what do you say?"

"I say decide." Mòrag leaned forward. "Beathag. Either tell them to go, and put the crown behind it, and they'll build the ships in a year; or tell them it's folly, and

forbid it, and it'll die away by Bealltainn. But say something. You can't leave them hanging on a board in a harbour-house, cutting their names in and out."

Beathag bit off her thread and looked at the patch, and smoothed it with her thumb.

"Do you know what the crown has done, in all the years since Goraidh Mòr?" she said at last. "It has kept the roads. It has kept the granaries. It has judged the boundary ditches and the millers' quarrels and the dues. It has never once sent anyone anywhere. It has never told a fisher where he might fish or a farmer where he might plough. And it has never kept a free man or woman where they did not wish to stay." She looked up. "You want me to begin now? With this? With the sea?"

"I want you to lead."

"I am leading. I am leading them to make up their own minds." Beathag set the shirt aside. "If I command it, every household that goes, goes because the queen said so. And when the sea takes them, and it will take some of them, Mòrag, you know that, their mothers will curse An Talla Dearg¹, and they'll be right to. And if I forbid it, every household that wanted to go and didn't will hate the crown for the rest of their lives, and teach their children to. And the ones who'd go anyway will go in the dark, in whatever they can find, and drown. No. The crown won't send, and it won't forbid."

Mòrag sat very still on the chest. "Then you'll let me go," she said.

It was the first time either of them had said it. Beathag looked at her sister for a long moment, and Mòrag saw her face change: not much, a tightening at the corners of the mouth, the look their mother used to get when a plea went against someone she liked.

"I'll let anyone go," Beathag said. "That's what I've just told you."

"That isn't what I asked."

"It's what I'm answering." Beathag stood up and went to the window and stood with her back to the room, looking down at the yard where the grooms were bringing in the horses. "I'm the queen, Mòrag. If I say one thing for the whole island and another for my sister, there's no word at all. It's just a queen with favourites. You're free. You're as free as the fisher of Inis àrsaidh who went in first. No freer. No less free."

"And if I go?"

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

Beathag did not turn round. "Then you'll go," she said. "And I'll be the queen who let her."

II

Of the Word That Went Down the Road

The word went down the river road three days later, with a rider of the queen's household on a grey horse, in the autumn of LE 2. It was written by Murchadh mac Eòghainn on a leaf of skin and sealed with the queen's seal, and copies of it went to Cuan shean and Ros bheag and Ceann mhòr and Baile chrom and every other harbour of the west, and to Taigh na Fèithe¹ above Muileann dhearg.

It was not long. Leabhar a' Chùraim² gives it only in substance: that the crown would send no one across the water, and would keep no one back; that any household of Dia-thìr might go that wished to, and stay that wished to; that the crown would neither help nor hinder the building of ships, but would judge any quarrel that arose from it by the old law, as it judged all quarrels; and that the queen asked the people to think long and choose with their eyes open.

Mòrag rode down behind the rider. She had not meant to. She had meant to go home to Inis àrsaidh in a day or two, by easy stages, and let the word get there before her. But she stood at the gate of An Talla Dearg³ in the grey morning and watched the grey horse go down the road with the leaf in its rider's satchel, and she found she could not bear to be behind it. She called for her pony and went.

She rode the whole twenty-four miles in one day, in rain. The road went down out of the hills along the river and through the wet fields of the lowland, past farms where the barley stubble stood grey and drowned and the cattle stood with their backs to the weather, and then along the edge of the marshes toward the coast; and all the way the rider was ahead of her, a grey shape in the grey rain, never more than a mile off and never less. She did not try to catch him up. At dusk she came down the last hill with the pony blowing, and saw the lamps of Seann Skell below her, and the river pool, and the long dark line of the west quay, and the one lit window of the harbour-house at its head.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

III

Of the Reading at the Door

The rider had reached the harbour-house before her and the reading had begun. Half the town was on the quay. They stood in the rain in a crowd round the door, with their hoods up and their shoulders hunched, and the harbour scribe Calum mac Nèill stood in the doorway with the lamp behind him and the queen's leaf in his hands, and read it aloud.

He read it twice, because the people at the back had not heard. Mòrag sat on the pony at the back of the crowd and heard it the second time, the plain words in the scribe's dry voice, and watched the faces.

She had thought they would cheer. Some of them did, a few young men near the front who had been on the boards from the first week. But most of the crowd did not. They stood in the rain and listened, and when Calum finished and lowered the leaf there was a long silence, and then a low sound that went through the crowd like wind through barley, and she understood that it was not joy. They had wanted the queen to decide for them. And she had handed it back to them, every household of them, to decide for themselves.

A woman near Mòrag said, to nobody, "Well, that's no help," and went home.

But the crowd did not go home, most of it. It stayed on the quay in the rain, talking in knots, well after Calum had taken the leaf in and hung it on a peg beside the roll. And someone in one of the knots began to say the word over, in a sing-song, as the fishers of the west turn anything into a song if they say it often enough; and someone else took it up; and by the time Mòrag had led her pony down to the water's edge to drink, there were a dozen voices on the quay saying it together, not quite in tune:

Cha chuir mi duine thairis, agus cha chùim mi duine air ais. I will send no one over, and I will keep no one back.

The queen had never said it in those words. The harbour songs of Seann Skell have said it so ever since, and they are younger than Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ and less careful, and nobody on the west coast has ever wished to hear it any other way.

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

IV

Of Aonghas at Inis àrsaidh

She did not go into the harbour-house that night. She rode on the three miles to Inis àrsaidh in the dark and came into her own house soaked to the skin, and Aonghas was up, sitting by the fire, as he always was when she was away.

He had heard. Everybody had heard by then; the word had run down the three miles of the shore road faster than a pony. He looked at her as she stood dripping in the doorway, and got up and took her cloak, and put her in the chair by the fire and put a cup of hot ale in her hands and knelt and pulled her boots off, and only then said, "Well?"

"She won't send and she won't forbid," Mòrag said.

"I heard."

"She won't say anything to me that she doesn't say to the fisher." Mòrag drank. Her hands were shaking with cold. "I asked her straight. I asked her, if I go. And she said, then you'll go."

Aonghas sat back on his heels and looked up at her in the firelight. He was a big fair man, slow-spoken, a farmer of the good land up the river behind the town, who had married the queen's sister to the astonishment of the whole west and had never once, in three years, behaved as if it were anything remarkable.

"So," he said. "Do we go?"

She looked at him. She had lain awake over this for a year and a half. She had rehearsed every argument, every way of saying it, how she would put it to him and what he would say and what she would answer. She had been ready for a fight.

"I haven't finished," she said. "I was going to ask you. It was all ready. The oak, and the keel, and how nobody knows, and how somebody will have to learn, and that the queen won't stop us, and that we'd go together or not at all, because the harbour scribe writes a household whole or not..."

"Yes," said Aonghas.

"...and that I know it's your father's land, and your mother's grave behind the house, and..."

"Mòrag," said Aonghas. "Yes."

She stopped. He was still kneeling on the hearth with her wet boots in his hands, looking up at her with his slow patient face, and she saw that he had decided long before, perhaps on the night by this same fire when he had told her

about the oaks of Doire fhionn, and had been waiting, as he always waited, for her to catch up.

She put the cup down and began to laugh, and then to cry, and he got up off the hearth and held her.

V

Of the Knife

She went into the harbour-house the next afternoon, alone. Aonghas had offered to come. She had said that the scribe would know him, and that the household was the household whether one of them stood there or both, and that she wanted to do this herself. He had understood.

It was raining again. The harbour-house was full, as it was every day now, and the bench by the door was full of old men, and the floor was full of people reading the boards, and at the far end under the window Calum mac Nèill sat at his board with his knife. She came in out of the rain with her hood up, and some of the old men on the bench looked at her and did not know her, and then one did, and nudged the next.

She stood in front of the board. Calum looked up. She saw him know her, before she had lowered her hood; she saw the knowing go through his face and out again, and his face go smooth and careful.

"Lady," he said.

"I wish my household entered," said Mòrag. "The household of Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh, of Inis àrsaidh. Two of us. Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh, and Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill."

The harbour-house had gone quiet behind her. Without looking round, and without sitting, though there was a stool, she stood and watched Calum take a fresh board from the rack, and plane it, and set the knife to it. He cut slowly, and very well.

She spelled it out for him. She knew he did not need it. Every scribe in the west knew how to spell the name of the queen's sister; it was on half the leaves that came down from An Talla Dearg¹. But she spelled it all the same, letter by letter, in a clear voice that carried to the back of the house, *M, ò, r, a, g*, and watched

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

every letter go into the wood, and then *nic Dhòmhnaill*, all of it; and then her husband's name above it, because he was the head of the household on the board; and then the line down the left side that joined them. It seemed to her that the knife was a long time about it. When the last stroke was cut and the shaving had curled away and dropped to the floor, she let out a breath she had not known she was holding.

"Thank you," she said.

Calum looked up at her. He did not say anything. Whatever he thought, he kept it behind his careful face.

She pulled her hood up again and went out into the rain. Behind her, as the door shut, she heard the harbour-house begin to talk.

He wrote nothing beside the entry. There was no rule that said he should, and he was not a man to make one. The chroniclers have written a great deal about it since, and none of them was in the room.

VI

Of the Vein-House above Muileann dhearg

Sixty miles east, up in the mountain country, the copy of the queen's word came to Taigh na Fèithe¹ by the coal-road, three days after it was read at Seann Skell, and the custodians sat down to think what it meant for them.

Taigh na Fèithe stood on a shoulder of the hills above the diggings at Muileann dhearg, where the galleries went into the mountain. It was a long hall of dark stone, older than the queen's line, with store-houses round a yard and the carriers' gate on the downhill side. In its inner room, in a niche lit by a lamp that was never let go out, stood Crom's stone, the slab that had lain on the first break of the vein. In the room beyond it, on a table of black oak, lay Leabhar a' Chùrain², which had been kept since An Aois Naomh³, and in which every hearth on the island that held the right to the coal was written. Taigh na Fèithe was heir to Talla na Lasrach⁴, where Bride's flame had first been bound; Coimheadaichean na Lasrach⁵ still kept the flame there, and the stone cup on the

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the Holy Age

4. the Hall of the Flame

threshold, but it was here, above the galleries, that the handful was measured and the book was kept, and it was here that the custodians met.

The master of Taigh na Fèithe in those years was Eòghann mac Mhuirich, an old man of Coimheadaichean na Lasrach' blood, dry and thin and very patient, who had spent sixty years in the service of the vein and had never once, the custodians said, been seen to hurry. He read the queen's word through at the table, twice, by the light of the lamp before Crom's stone, and then he folded it and said:

"We had better count."

VII

Of the Question of the Coal

They did not count at once. First they argued, through the whole of that winter and into the spring, over a question that the queen's word did not touch and that no one at Seann Skell had thought to ask.

The right to the coal was earned. That was Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig¹ as it had stood since An Aois Naomh². A custodian served his apprenticeship at the vein, seven years under a master, learning the galleries and the colours and the measure; and a hearth that held the right to the handful held it because its people had kept the coal and Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig, generation after generation. The right lived in the hands that had learned it. It was written in Leabhar a' Chùraim³ against the hearth, and Taigh na Fèithe⁴ measured to it.

Then what happened to the right when the hearth went over the sea?

Some of the custodians said it went with them. The right was in the hands, and the hands would be the same hands on the far coast as on this one. Others said that the right was to the vein, and the vein was here; a right to a thing on the far side of the sea was no right at all, and the hearth should be struck from the book on the day it sailed. And some, the old ones mostly, said nothing, but looked at each other; because there was a third question under the other two, and

5. the Keepers of the Hall; lit. 'the watchers of the flame'

1. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

2. the Holy Age

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

none of them wished to be the first to ask it. If the right lived in the hands, and the hands went away, did the vein lose something? Did it answer fewer?

Fearchar mac Ruairidh was the loudest of those who said the right went with the hearth. He was a custodian of the western diggings, a big, black-browed man of thirty with a laugh that carried through stone walls, who had been apprenticed at twelve and had spent eighteen years in the galleries and could name every colour of broken coal by feel in the dark. He had heard the three tellings from Murchadh's own leaf, the winter before last, and had been talking about them ever since.

"The coal knows the hands," he said, at the long table in the hall, in the moon of Gearras, with the wind hammering on the shutters. "You all know it. You've all felt it. You put your hand on a broken face and it's warm to you and cold to the lad beside you. That's not in the book. That's not in the vein. That's in us. Wherever we go, it goes."

"Then take your hands over the sea, Fearchar," said an old custodian of the southern galleries, "and see if the far coast has a vein in it for them to warm."

There was laughter. Fearchar laughed too. But Eòghann mac Mhuirich, at the head of the table, did not laugh, and after a while the others noticed, and stopped.

"We'll count," said Eòghann. "We'll count first. Then we'll know what we're arguing about."

VIII

Of the Count Made Twice

They sent to Seann Skell for a copy of the roll. The harbour scribe sent it willingly, board by board, copied onto skin by his son, with a small mark like a flame beside each household whose hearth took the handful. It came up the coal-road in the spring, and more boards after it, for the roll went on growing all that year, and in the high summer, in the moon of Lùghnas, the custodians sat down at the long table with the copy of the roll on one side and Leabhar a' Chùraim¹ on the other, and counted.

It took them nine days. They went hearth by hearth, household by household, the roll's name against the book's name, reading aloud and ticking. Eòghann sat at

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

the head of the table and did not count; he listened. Fearchar read the roll aloud, because he had the loudest voice. A young custodian of the capital's diggings read the book. Two clerks ticked.

On the ninth day, in the evening, the clerks added their ticks and looked at each other, and added them again, and gave the figure to Eòghann on a slip of skin.

He read it, and read it again, and looked up at the custodians round the table, who were watching him.

"Nearly one in five," he said.

Nobody spoke. One hearth in five of all the hearths on the island that held the right to the coal was on Rolla nan Deònach². Not one in fifty, which was what most of them had expected; not one in twenty, which was what the pessimists had said. Nearly one in five. Fishers, farmers, weavers, boat-wrights; and custodians, many custodians, whose hands the vein had answered, whose apprenticeship had been seven years at these same galleries; and the queen's own sister.

"That's wrong," said someone.

"Count it again," said Eòghann.

They counted it again. It took them seven more days, because they were faster now and angrier. They changed the readers round, so that no one could say a tired voice had skipped a name. Fearchar read the book this time, and the young custodian from the capital read the roll. The clerks ticked.

On the sixteenth day, on 14 an Lùnastal, LE 3, they gave Eòghann the second slip. It was the same figure, within a hearth or two.

He sat and looked at it for a long time. Then he took his pen and wrote it in Leabhar a' Chùraim, in his own old careful hand, under the day; and beside it he wrote that the count had been made twice, because the first figure had not been believed. By whom, he did not say; there was no need.

IX

Of Fearchar's Own Name

When he had finished writing, Eòghann laid down the pen and said, without looking up: "Is there anything else?"

2. the roll of the willing

There was a silence. Then Fearchar mac Ruairidh stood up from the long table.

He had not said anything for sixteen days that was not a name read aloud. He stood with his big hands flat on the table and his black brows drawn down, and he looked, for once, like a man who did not know how loud to be.

"My household is on the roll," he said. "Fearchar mac Ruairidh, of the western diggings, and his wife and his two daughters. It's on the fourth board. I went down to Seann Skell in the moon of Samhnas and had it cut. I counted my own name twice, reading it, and ticked it, and said nothing." He swallowed. "I should have said before we began, and didn't. The figure was what I wanted first. I wanted to know whether I was one of a handful of fools or one of a great many." He looked round the table. "Now I know."

Nobody said anything. The young custodian from the capital was staring at him. The old custodian of the southern galleries, who had laughed at him in Gearras, had put his face in his hands.

Eòghann mac Mhuirich did not look up from the book. He sat with the pen laid down beside it and his old dry hands folded on the table in front of him, and he looked at the figure he had just written as though it were a stranger.

"Sit down, Fearchar," he said at last, quite gently.

Fearchar sat.

The master of Taigh na Fèithe¹ turned the leaf of Leabhar a' Chùrain², very carefully, so as not to smudge the ink, and wrote the date at the head of the next leaf, and the words *the handful for the season*, in the same hand as before; and began to read the names of the hearths aloud, one after another, as he had read them every season for sixty years, for the measuring. And the custodians round the table, one by one, took up their pens and followed him, and none of them looked at Fearchar, and none of them looked at each other, and the lamp before Crom's stone in the next room burned steady and small, as it always had.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

CHAPTER FOUR

OF THE OAKS OF DOIRE FHIONN

LE 3 – 5

I

Of a Wright Who Sewed Planks

Alasdair mac Iain was a boat-wright of the strand below Seann Skell, and in the fourth year of the age he had never built anything that could not be carried up a beach by six men.

That was what a boat was, on Dia-thìr. The wrights of the strand built coasters and fishing boats as their grandmothers had: they split their planks from oak and ash with wedges, and shaped them with the adze, and laid them edge to edge on a frame of bent ribs, and sewed them together with split root and twisted gut through holes bored along the edges, and stopped the seams with moss and tallow. A good sewn boat was light and supple; she gave in a sea, every seam working, like a basket in a stream. She wanted to be pulled up every night and let dry, and her stitching looked to, and her moss renewed. She would take a crew of six along the coast from headland to headland in a day and bring them home loaded with fish. Three nights on the open sea would have killed her.

Alasdair had built perhaps forty such boats. He was a lean dark man, not tall, with a long jaw and a way of looking at a piece of timber that made the other wrights of the strand fall silent, as though he were listening to it. He was known on the strand as the best of them at a hull's lines. The strand knew him too as a man who asked too many questions, who would stand for half a morning looking at a sea running up the beach and not say what he was thinking.

What he was thinking, from the day he read the roll in the harbour-house, was a keel.

II

Of the Keel in the Tellings

There was no keel on the island. There were keels in the tellings.

The old tellers of the west said that the boats of Rìghrean na Cloiche¹, in An Aois Ailein², had been built on a spine of oak: a single long timber down the middle of the bottom, and the ribs rising out of it on either side like the ribs of a beast from its backbone, and the planks fastened to the ribs with wooden pegs, not sewn. Such a boat, the tellers said, stood stiff in a sea and cut the water where a sewn boat rode it, and she could stay out for days. Rìghrean na Cloiche had sailed round the whole island in such boats, the tellers said, and to the islands off the coast; and then, as the tellers always said of everything in An Aois Ailein, the making of them had been forgotten.

Alasdair did not know whether to believe it. But he had noticed, as a boy, that the old coasters on the strand, the ones built by the grandfathers of the men who built them now, had a thicker plank down the middle of the bottom than the others, a plank that was more than a plank, shaped out of a single long timber with a ridge along its underside; and that the wrights who built them now left it out, because it was heavy and hard to make and nobody could say what it was for. He had thought, then, that it was what was left of something.

So through the winter after the queen's word, and all the next year, he built small hulls on the strand, no longer than his arm, on spines of oak. He built them with pegs, and with nails of hardwood, and with his own sewing, one way and another. He floated them in the river pool and pushed them over with a stick to see how they came up. Then he took them down to the mouth of the river where the sea came in and let them go on the ebb and walked along the shore to see where they came ashore, and how. The other wrights laughed at him, and then stopped laughing, and then began to come and stand beside him on the shore with their hands under their arms and watch.

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

2. the Age of Ailean

By the end of the fourth year he knew four things. A keel would make a hull stiff. A stiff hull could be bigger. A bigger hull could carry water and stores for many days. And the keel would have to be made of a single timber longer than any oak he had ever seen.

III

Of the Lady at Inis àrsaidh

he went to the queen's sister, because there was no one else to go to. The queen had said she would neither help nor hinder. The custodians had said nothing, and were said to be quarrelling among themselves. The harbour-house kept the roll, but it had no money and no timber. The households on the roll were fishers and farmers and wrights, and none of them had anything to give but their own hands. But the lady Mòrag of Inis àrsaidh had been on the roll since the autumn of the queen's word, and she had asked the Cuan shean skipper about oak, and she had silver of her own.

She received him in the house at Inis àrsaidh, by the fire, with her husband. She had a child now, a boy of a few moons, who lay in a basket by the hearth and watched the flames. Alasdair stood awkwardly with his cap in his hand and told them about the keel.

He told it badly, he thought. He was not a talker. But Mòrag listened without interrupting, and when he had finished she asked him three questions: how long the keel must be, how many such timbers the fleet would want, and whether he knew where to find them. He answered the first two. To the third he said that he did not.

"Doire fhionn," said Aonghas, from the other side of the fire.

Alasdair looked at him.

"Up the north road," said the big farmer. "Forty-odd miles. There's a grove there, on the hill above the village, older than any of the Doires. My grandfather took me to see it when I was a boy. He said the oaks had been standing since before Rìghrean na Cloiche¹. You couldn't see the tops from the ground." He was quiet a moment. "It's the grove the village is named for. They won't like it."

"They'll like it less if we don't ask," said Mòrag. She looked at Alasdair. "Go and look at them. If they're what you need, come back and tell me, and I'll pay for

the felling and the hauling, and the households of the roll will give their labour. If they're not, come back and tell me that, and we'll look somewhere else."

"And if the village won't give them, lady?"

"Then we'll ask the village what it wants," said Mòrag, "and see whether we can give it."

IV

Of the Road North

he set out at the turn of the fifth year, in the moon of Gearras, after Là Fhèill Brìde, when the hearths had been swept and relit and the days were beginning to lengthen. On foot and alone he went, with a pack and a staff and a coil of line with knots in it every arm's length, for measuring.

The north road went up out of the Seann Skell country along the river, and then over the long low hills toward the north coast, through a country of small farms and peat-moss and scrub birch, with the wind always in his face. He made fifteen miles the first day and slept in a byre. The second day it rained, and he made less. On the third day, in the afternoon, he came over a rise and saw below him a village of grey houses in a fold of the hills, with a stream running through it and smoke going up; and on the hill above the village, on its eastern side, a darkness against the sky that he took at first for a cloud.

It was the grove.

He stood on the rise and looked at it for a long time. He had seen oaks all his life. The strand below Seann Skell was built of oak, and every boat he had ever made was oak. These were something else. They stood on the crown of the hill in a ring, perhaps sixty of them, with a few lesser trees about their feet, and they were so high and so broad that the hill itself looked small beneath them, and their bare winter crowns made a black net against the grey sky that shifted as the wind went through it. He could hear the wind in them from where he stood, a mile off: a low roar, like surf.

He went down into the village as the light was going, and asked at the first door for the keeper of the grove.

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

V

Of Eilidh nic Ruairidh

The keeper of the grove was an old woman called Eilidh nic Ruairidh, who lived in the last house of the village at the foot of the grove hill, with a cow and a great many cats. She was small and bent and brown as a nut, and her eyes were very clear. She had kept the grove for fifty years, she told him, as her mother had before her. It was not a hard office. The grove kept itself. The keeper walked round it at Na Ceithir Fèilltean¹, and saw that no one cut the living wood, and gathered the fallen boughs for the village hearths, and told the children not to climb.

She listened to him with her hands folded on her stick. When he had told her what he wanted, and why, she did not say anything for a long while.

"Come up in the morning," she said at last. "I'll show you."

In the morning they went up the hill together, slowly, because she was slow. The grove was bigger close to than it had looked from the rise. The trunks were so thick that three men could not have joined hands round the smallest of them, and they went up straight and grey and furrowed for sixty feet before they branched. The ground under them was deep in old leaves and mast, and very quiet. Even the wind, which roared in the crowns, did not come down to the floor of the grove. A few birds moved in the high branches. Nothing else.

Alasdair walked from tree to tree with his knotted line, measuring. He put his hands on the bark. He looked up each trunk, along its length, the way he looked along a plank for a warp. Eilidh walked beside him and said nothing.

When he had been round the whole ring he came back to her and said, "These are what I need."

"I know," said Eilidh.

"I need a score of them, or near it, for the keels. And the frames from the others, and the planks. I'd need most of the grove."

"I know that too." She stood leaning on her stick, looking up into the crowns. "Well. You'd better tell me which."

He did not understand her. She turned and looked at him with her clear eyes.

"You'll not take them as a crowd," she said. "Not in my grove. If they're going, you'll choose them, one by one, and you'll tell me why that one and not the next,

1. the four quarter-feasts

and I'll tell you its name. They've all got names. My mother gave me the names and her mother gave them to her. And when you've chosen, you'll know what you've taken. That's my price."

VI

Of the Naming of the Trees

It took them two days. He had thought it would take an hour.

He went from tree to tree again, with the old woman beside him, and at each one he stopped and said whether he wanted it and why. This one, because it was straight for seventy feet, and would make a keel with no scarf in it. This one, because it had a great branch coming off low down at the right angle to make the stem-post of a hull, the timber that rises from the fore end of the keel. Not that one; it was hollow at the heart, he could hear it when he knocked. This one, for frames, because it was crooked, and its crooks were the shapes of ribs.

And at each one Eilidh told him its name. The Grey Mare. The Old Man's Knee. The Two Sisters, which were two trunks grown out of one root, and which he took both of. Crom's Finger. The Bent Back. The Eyrie, because a hawk had nested in it every spring for longer than anyone remembered. The Drowned Woman, for a reason Eilidh would not tell him. The Queen, which was the biggest in the grove, and which he stood under for a long time, and at last said he would take for the first keel.

He had not meant to feel anything about it. He was a wright; he felled oaks every year. But by the end of the second day he had a list of names in his head that he could not get out of it, and when he came to the last tree of the ring, a young one, no more than two hundred years old, standing a little apart, and said that he did not need it, he found that his hands were shaking.

"That's the Child," said Eilidh. "You'll leave it?"

"I'll leave it."

"And the others?"

He looked round the ring. Of sixty-odd trees he had chosen fifty-four.

"The others go," he said.

Eilidh nodded. She did not seem angry. She looked, if anything, relieved, as though a thing she had been waiting a long time to hear had been said at last, and it was worse than she had feared and not as bad as she had dreamed.

"It won't grow again," she said. "You know that. You can cut an ash and it comes up from the stool. An oak like these, you cut it, it's gone. There'll be nothing on this hill but the Child and the stumps, and the Child will never be what these are, not in my time nor yours nor anyone's we'll know." She was quiet. "And the village will still be Doire fhionn. The fair grove. It'll keep the name. It won't have any reason to."

He had no answer. He stood in the silent grove with the knotted line in his hands and could not think of one.

"Well," said Eilidh at last. "Go and tell your lady. And tell her to send men who know how to fell a tree so that it doesn't smash itself. I'll not have the Queen broken for want of care."

VII

Of the Felling

They came in the moon of Sìolach, the seed-time: eighty men from the households of the roll, fishers and farmers and wrights, with axes and saws and wedges and ropes, and a dozen yoke of oxen from the farms up the Abhainn naomh, and Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh at their head, because he knew oxen. Mòrag's silver paid for their bread and the village's barley and the fodder for the oxen. The village of Doire fhionn stood in its doorways and watched them come up the road, and did not speak to them.

The felling took most of the summer. Each tree was felled toward the downhill side, onto a bed of cut brush to break its fall, with ropes on its crown and men on the ropes to guide it. Alasdair was there for every one. The Queen went last. It took two days to bring down, and when it fell, in the evening, with a long tearing groan and then a crash that shook the ground under the village and brought the cows lowing out of the byres, the men on the ropes stood still and did not cheer, and some of them took off their caps.

Eilidh nic Ruairidh did not come up the hill while the felling went on. But at the end of each day, when the men came down to the village to eat, she was sitting in her doorway with her cats round her, and Alasdair would stop and tell her which tree had gone that day, by its name. She would nod, and say nothing, and he would go on.

After the Queen fell, he stopped at her door as usual. She was not in the doorway. He looked in, and saw her sitting by her cold hearth in the dark with her hands folded on her stick, and did not go in.

VIII

Of the Ox-Sleds on the North Road

A keel-timber seventy feet long cannot be carried. It must be dragged. They built sleds of lesser oak, low and broad, with runners shod in ash, and rolled the great trunks onto them with levers and ropes, and yoked the oxen six pair to a sled, and dragged them south down the north road toward the sea. It was forty-two miles. With a keel-timber on the sled, the oxen made three miles in a good day and one in a bad one. They broke two sleds on the first hill. They had to widen the road at every bend, cutting back the banks and the birch scrub, and at the stream below the village they had to build a causeway of stone before the sleds would cross it. The farmers along the road came out and stood at their gates to watch the trunks go by, and some of them cursed, because the road was ruined for their carts, and some of them brought out ale.

It went on all that summer and into the autumn. The sleds went down one after another, strung out along the road for twenty miles, with the drovers walking beside the oxen and the wrights walking beside the trunks, and the sound of it could be heard, the farmers said, a mile off on a still day: the groan of the runners on the stones, and the drovers' cries, and the oxen blowing.

Nearer the sea, on the shore of Loch chrom below the capital, there was a wood of wild oak, rough and crooked, that had never been anyone's grove; and in the same summer a party of woodcutters from the roll went there and built themselves huts at the wood's edge, to fell crooked oak for frames and knees that the fleet would need in hundreds. The huts did not outlast the felling; the woodcutters went home to the roll when the last knee was hauled out, and the bracken came up through the floors. The wood kept its name, Doire fhiadhaich, the wild grove, and the tellers of that shore say still that timber for the fleet was felled there.

IX

Of the First Keel

The first keel came down to the strand below Seann Skell in the moon of Teasach, the hot moon, in high summer. It was the Queen.

Alasdair had cleared a length of the strand above the high-water line, and dug a saw-pit beside it, and laid a bed of heavy oak blocks in a long straight line on the shingle, level to a hair, which he had spent a week getting right with a line and a trough of water. The oxen dragged the sled down onto the strand and along beside the blocks, and fifty men with levers rolled the great trunk off the sled and onto the blocks, and it lay there, grey and furrowed and enormous, seventy feet from end to end.

Then they began to shape it.

It took them the rest of that moon and half the next. They split the trunk down its length with wedges, and hewed away the sapwood with axes and adzes, and squared it, and shaped it: flat on top where the frames would sit, and deeper at the middle than at the ends, and with a ridge along its underside, like the ridge on the thick bottom plank of the old coasters that Alasdair had wondered at as a boy. He shaped the ridge himself. He did it by eye and by the feel of the adze in his hands, walking up and down the length of the timber a hundred times a day, sighting along it, stooping, laying his palm on it, and cutting a little more. No one on the island had ever done this before, and there was no one he could ask.

On 14 an Lùnastal, LE 5, it was done, and he stood at the fore end of it and looked along it to the after end, and saw that it was straight and true; and the men of the strand stood round it in a ring and looked at him, and at it.

"Well," said one of them. "What's it want now?"

"Ribs," said Alasdair. "Then planks. Then as many more of it as there are oaks on the sleds."

X

Of the Fellowship of the Strand

he could not do it alone, and he could not do it with a crowd. He needed wrights who would learn it as he had learned it, and keep it, and not wander off to their fishing when the herring came.

So in the moon of Lùghnas, at the feast of Lugh, he called the wrights of the Seann Skell strand together on the shingle beside the first keel, all of them, masters and journeymen, some forty men, and asked them to bind themselves to the fleet: to work at it and nothing else until it was built, and to take apprentices, and to share what each of them learned with all the others. He asked it badly. He was no talker. But they had all stood on the shore with their hands under their arms and watched his little hulls come up out of the water, and most of them said yes.

They made it a fellowship. Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ gives its name as Comann nan Saor-luinge², the fellowship of the ship-wrights. They took the custodians of the vein for their pattern, because the custodians were the only fellowship on the island that anyone respected: every apprentice was to be bound for seven years, as a custodian's apprentice was bound to the galleries, and was to learn the whole craft and swear to keep it and teach it. A custodian came down from Taigh na Fèithe³ to swear the apprentices, a grave young man in undyed wool who did not know one end of a boat from the other and said so, and heard their oaths all the same over a coal from the vein in a clay dish, as Taigh na Fèithe heard its own.

The first apprentice sworn was a boy of the strand called Coinneach mac Fhearghais, fourteen years old, the son of a coaster-wright, with big hands and a stammer, who had been hanging about Alasdair's little hulls for a year. He knelt on the shingle with his hands on the coal and swore to the fellowship in a voice that cracked on every other word. When he stood up he looked at the keel, and then at Alasdair, and grinned, and Alasdair found that he was grinning too.

X I

Of the Frames Standing on the Strand

By the end of the moon of Pailteach they had the first frames up. They rose out of the keel on either side in pairs, one pair for each arm's length of its seventy feet, curved crooks of oak from the Bent Back and the Old Man's Knee and the wild wood by Loch chrom, pegged into the keel with treenails of heart-oak and joined across at the top by beams. From the harbour-house at the head of the west quay, the town could see them over the roofs of the

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the shipwrights' fellowship

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

strand: two long rows of curved grey timbers standing against the sky, bare and pale, with the light coming through between them.

The town came down to look. People stood on the shingle in the evening and stared at the thing on the blocks. It was bigger than any boat they had ever seen, and it did not look like a boat. It looked, the harbour scribe Calum mac Nèill wrote on a board that night, like the ribs of a great beast lying dead on the shore, picked clean by the birds. He meant it kindly. He did not know how else to say it.

Alasdair heard none of it, walking up and down the length of the keel inside the frames, as he walked it every evening, with his palm running along the top of each rib as he passed, feeling for the fair curve.

He thought of the old woman at Doire fhionn, sitting in the dark by her cold hearth with her hands on her stick. And he thought of the Queen, the biggest oak in the grove, lying under his feet now, shaped and squared and pegged, with the ribs rising out of her. He thought that he had never made anything in his life that had cost so much, and that he did not yet know whether it would float.

The Child was still standing on the hill above Doire fhionn, alone among the stumps. Word of that came down to the strand later in the year with a drover, who said the village had built a low wall of stones round it, and that the old keeper went up every evening and sat beside it until dark.

CHAPTER FIVE

OF the hull that Lay Down

LE 6 – 9

I

Of the Launching of An Fhaoileag

Through the rest of that fifth year, and into the sixth, the frames on the strand below Seann Skell filled in. The town that had come down to stare at the bare ribs came down again to watch the planks go on, one strake and then the next, pegged to the frames with treenails of heart-oak and caulked with tow and pitch in the old way, though nothing else about her was old. Alasdair mac Iain walked her length every evening still, his palm on the wood, and by the moon of Gearras she had a deck, and a mast stepped through it into the keel he had laid with his own hands, and rigging that the rope-walks of Cuan shean had sent west by cart, coil on coil.

They called her An Fhaoileag¹, the gull, because she rode high and pale on the water when she was floated off the blocks, and because a boy on the strand said she looked like a bird about to go up. Alasdair had wanted no name at all, or a plainer one, but the wrights had built her and the wrights named her, and he did not argue it.

The mast went in on a cold, still morning with the whole fellowship standing round the step and Coinneach mac Fhearghais, oldest now of the first apprentices though he was not yet twenty, holding the foot of it steady while four men walked it up on sheer-legs of borrowed spruce. It went home clean, no binding, no easing

1. the Gull, the first finished hull, lost off Ros àrsaidh

with a maul, and the wrights took that for a good sign, the way wrights on the strand had always taken such things for signs, though none of them could have said what god or luck they meant by it. Rigging came down from Cuan shean in coils on a cart that took two days on the road, hemp still smelling of the fields it had grown in, and the strand spent a fortnight reeving it through blocks that had never held a rope so heavy, learning as they went which of their old coaster's knots would bear the strain and which would not.

On the morning of her launch the whole strand and half the town stood along the harbour-house wall to see her go down. A custodian of the vein came, at Mòrag's asking, and set a coal from Taigh na Fèithe² in a clay dish at her step, as was done for a house's first hearth, because a ship going out onto open water for the first time was thought to want the same blessing as a house standing up for the first time. Calum mac Nèill wrote in his roll that day that the harbour-house had never held so many people at once, not even for the reading of the queen's word.

She took the water clean, without a shudder, and rode the wash of her own launching like a thing that had done it a hundred times. Alasdair stood at the harbour wall with his hands under his arms, as he had stood since he was a boy watching other men's boats, and for the length of that morning he let himself believe the thing was finished.

It was not finished. It had not yet begun.

II

Of the Following Sea

A trial crew of fourteen took her down the Abhainn naomh three days later, to try her in open water before ever a household's goods went aboard her.

Alasdair would not sail in her himself; he never went to sea in any hull he had built, and no one on the strand thought to ask him why. He walked instead along the north bank of the river with the tide, and came out at last on the headland above Ros àrsaidh, the point where the boats of Inis àrsaidh had always put out to the open sea, and stood there with his hands jammed under his arms in the wind off the water.

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

His sister's boy Tormod Beag was aboard her. He was fifteen that year, all wrist and elbow, and he had begged a place on the trial crew for a month before Alasdair gave it to him, more to be rid of the begging than for any other reason. Alasdair had told him to keep low and hold on and do nothing that was not asked of him. Tormod had grinned and said he would.

She came down out of the river mouth with the ebb under her and turned her head into open water, and for a while she went as well as any hull Alasdair had ever watched, better. The wind was out of the south-west, no more than the sea took every day of that season, and she carried it easily, heeling a little and coming up again. Two coasters out of Inis àrsaidh stood off to watch her pass, their crews idle on the oars, and one of the men called across the water that she went like something that had done it before, and the trial crew laughed and called back that she had not, not once, and the laughing carried clear to the headland where Alasdair stood. Alasdair began, against every rule he set himself, to be glad of her.

Then a sea came up astern of her, bigger than the ones before it, the kind that gathers itself out of nothing on a coast that has been building weather all week without quite letting it fall. He saw her stern lift to it. He had seen a hundred small boats lift to a following sea and come down again, and he waited for her to come down.

She did not come down soon enough. Her stern rose and her bow went under, and the water that should have run off her deck did not run off fast enough, because she was deeper and heavier and slower to shed a sea than any boat the island had ever built, and no one, not even Alasdair, had known that until that morning. She hung a moment with her bow buried and her stern high, and then she went over on her side as a tired animal lies down, not fighting it, folding into the water she had ridden so well an hour before.

There were fourteen heads in the sea and then there were fewer. Alasdair went down off the headland at a run, over ground he did not remember afterward crossing, shouting to the strand before he was near enough for shouting to do any good. Men came off the headland and off the strand at Inis àrsaidh in every boat that could be got into the water in time, oarsmen still buttoning their coats as they ran the boats down the shingle, and they brought back three living and the bodies of eight of the drowned; three more were never found at all, and the sea gave up nothing more of them that year or any year after. Tormod Beag was among the eight brought back. Alasdair carried him up the beach himself, though the boy weighed nothing at all by then, nothing a man his age should have been

able to feel as light, and he did not let anyone else take the weight from him the whole way up to the boat-shed.

III

Of the Names Cut at Inis àrsaidh

Inis àrsaidh kept no roll of its own like the harbour-house at Seann Skell; it had no need of one before that week. But it kept a board, as every fishing town on that coast kept a board, for the names of those the sea did not give back whole, and the old woman who kept it, whom the village called the roll-keeper though the office had no other name, brought it out and set it against the wall of the boat-shed and cut eleven names into it that night by the light of two lamps, working slowly because her hand was not steady and because there had never before been eleven names cut on one night.

The village sat up with her while she cut them. That was the custom, though no one could have said when it began: the cutting was not to be done alone, in case the knife slipped, or in case grief slipped, and there was no telling the two apart in the dark. Alasdair sat with the rest, on an upturned creel, and watched his nephew's name go into the wood letter by letter, and said nothing, because there was nothing he had any right to say that would not have sounded like an excuse.

They keened the eight that were found in the old way, the women's voices going up together and falling together, on the shingle where the boats were drawn up, with the bodies laid out under sailcloth and a lamp at each head. Alasdair's sister could not keen for her own son; she sat by him dry-eyed and silent while the other women's voices rose around her, and it was an aunt of the boy's father, come over from Ros bheag, who keened in her place, because the custom held that the loudest grief in a house is not always the one closest to the loss, and someone must carry it who still has a voice to carry it with. For the three that were not found there was no body to keen over, and the village did what was done in such a case: it lit a lamp on the shore all the same and let it burn down alone, and no one sat with that one, because there was no one to sit with.

Alasdair's sister did not come near him that night, and he did not go near her. He learned afterward, from his sister's husband, that she had said only one thing when the word reached her, which was that the boy had never once, in fifteen years, been given anything he had to ask for twice; she had thought, she said, that

the asking might have been a kind of protection, and it was not. Alasdair carried that sentence a long way, and it did not get lighter with carrying.

He stayed at Inis àrsaidh three days, doing whatever was asked of him and nothing that was not, mending a net, hauling water, standing where he was told to stand. On the third day the roll-keeper found him sitting by the board in the daylight, reading the eleven names as though he had not already read them a hundred times in the dark, and she said to him, not unkindly, that a board could be read by a man once and remembered, and that reading it again and again was a way of staying somewhere a person had already left.

He went back to Seann Skell that evening, by the inland path rather than the road along the strand, where the second frame stood waiting for him under its canvas, so as not to see it until he was ready.

IV

Of the Fire on the Strand

Eleven days passed before he was ready. On the twelfth, at night, with no one told he was going, he walked down to the tide-line below the blocks and built a driftwood fire, and sat by it with a stick, and began to draw a keel in the wet sand.

He drew the first one as he had built it: straight, deep, true along its whole length, a spine with the ribs rising square off it on either side, drawn on the day he laid it as the only honest line a keel could carry. He looked at it a long while. Then he rubbed it out with the flat of his hand and drew it again, and this time he took the straightness out of the forward third of her, where she met the sea first, and let it curve up and in, hollowing what had been full and filling what had been hollow toward her middle, so that the water coming at her from ahead would be turned aside along her sides instead of gathered up under her counter and carried aft to break her stern down as it had broken An Fhaoileag's¹.

He could not have said, that night, in words another wright could have taken away without watching him do it, what exactly he had changed. No single measurement carried it. The whole run of her forward body carried it, an inch here and half an inch there, multiplied along thirty feet of timber until the sum of it

1. the Gull, the first finished hull, lost off Ros àrsaidh

was a different animal. He rubbed it out a third time and drew it once more to be sure his hand had not lied to him the first two times, and it had not.

He sat by the fire until it burned down to nothing and the tide came up and took the sand smooth again, and by the time it did that he no longer needed the drawing. It was in his hands the way a tune is in a fiddler's hands after he has played it enough times to stop thinking about the notes, and it would stay there, and he would teach it to no one by writing it down, because there was no way he knew to write it down, only to show it, plank by plank, to the men who worked beside him until it was in their hands too.

V

Of the Second Keel

The second keel was laid before the spring turned, on the same bed of oak blocks above the tide-line where the first had lain, cut from a timber of the Doire fhionn oaks that had been kept back, against Alasdair's own advice at the time, as too short for a deep keel and fit only for framing. It was not too short for what he needed of it now. The new run forward took less length to cut than the old, because the fault he was correcting lay in her lines and not in her size.

He would not let the wrights call her anything until she was planked. Some on the strand wanted to call her for Tormod Beag; Alasdair heard of it and said, through Coinneach mac Fhearghais, that the boy's name was not going onto a hull until a hull had been built that would not need to earn forgiveness for it. No one argued with him. Coinneach, who was seventeen that year and the steadiest of the young wrights, took over much of the day-to-day setting of frames that season, because Alasdair was often at the shed with the drawing rather than on the blocks, going over the new run again and again with a batten and a straightedge before he would trust his own hands a second time.

Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill sent silver down from Inis àrsaidh again that spring, as she had for the felling of the oaks, though no one had asked her a second time. Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh carried it himself, and stood a while on the strand watching the new frames go up before he said anything of why he had come. He told Alasdair, plainly, that his wife had heard of the drowning within the week and had slept badly since, her own household being one that meant to sail aboard

some hull of this same fleet, and that the silver came as a bargain rather than a charity: build her right, and build her sound, and Mòrag would answer for the timber and the cordage for as long as the fellowship needed either. Alasdair took the silver and said less than he was asked, which the strand had come to know as his way of saying yes.

There were wrights who doubted the new run before they had planked a foot of her, men who had built sewn boats all their lives and trusted a keel that lay straight the way a man trusts a rule he was taught as a boy. Alasdair did not argue with them either. He set two of the doubters to plank her forward sections, where the change ran deepest, and let the wood make the argument for him; by the time the garboard strake was hung and fair along her new run, fitting the frames without the wedging and forcing that a poor line always asks for, the doubt had gone quiet, though it had not, in every man, gone away.

By midsummer An Dara Fhaoileag¹ stood in frame on the strand, lower in the bow than her sister had stood, fuller amidships, narrower where she met the water first. The town, which had come down twice before to stare at the ribs of a beast, came a third time and said less about it. They had learned, in the space of one season, that a hull on the strand was not a promise.

VI

Of Those Who Struck Themselves Out, and Those Who Entered

Word of the drowning reached the harbour-house at Seann Skell before the bodies had finished coming ashore, carried by a man of Inis àrsaidh who had run most of the way. Calum mac Nèill wrote it into his roll that night in four lines, dated, and under it, because he did not know what else to do with a thing that size, he ruled a line across the whole leaf.

In the weeks after, eleven households struck themselves from the roll. None of these were the households of the fourteen who had sailed, most of whom had never been on the roll at all, being crew hired for the trial and no more than half-committed to the crossing; these were households from up and down the coast who had heard the telling and found that what had been a season's talk was now a

1. the second gull, the hull built to the changed keel pattern after the loss of An Fhaoileag

thing that could happen to a son sent out to try a boat that was not even the ship that would carry him across the water. Calum cut the strokes through their names himself, as the rule required, and left the names standing to be read, as the rule also required, because the net-maker Iain's household had struck itself twice and been read, and the rule did not bend for grief any more than it had bent for anything else.

But in those same weeks eleven other households entered, the number was remarked on at the time and is remarked on still, though no one has ever found a reason for it beyond the coincidence of the count. Among them was a fishing household of Inis àrsaidh itself, kin of one of the three men brought back alive, who came to the harbour-house and gave their names and said, when Calum asked them why now of all times, that they had watched the sea take what it wanted once already and saw no more reason to fear it for waiting. A widow of Ros bheag entered too, a woman with no husband left to lose and two grown daughters who had asked to go before the drowning and been refused; she told Calum only that a mother who forbade the sea one week and could not answer for it the next had no business forbidding anything, and gave the names of all three.

Calum wrote both counts, the eleven struck and the eleven entered, on facing pages, and drew no line connecting them, and no comment under either. It is the one page in the whole roll where a later reader can see the shape of the thing without being told what to think of it.

VII

Of the Rope-Walks of Cuan shean

At Cuan shean, a dozen miles down the coast, the news reached the harbour front within the day, and when it did it changed nothing that Iain Ròpaire could see in the work of his rope-walks, which had been going on from first light to last since the queen's word first came down.

Cuan shean had given over its hemp fields to the fleet the year the keel was laid, and by the sixth year of the age its harbour front was three long rope-walks end to end, each the length of a good cable, where the spinners paid out hemp from bundles at their waists and the walkers went backward down the walk with it, twisting the strands together at a steady pace that a man could keep up from

dawn to dark if he did not think too hard about it. The walks ran from first light because hemp twisted best with the morning damp still in it, and by noon the whole harbour front smelt of it, green and sharp, a smell the older fishermen of the town said they would carry to their graves and be glad of. Iain had walked a rope-walk himself since he was younger than Tormod Beag had been, and he was master of all three now, a broad, slow-spoken man who counted his own steps under his breath without knowing he did it, and whose hands, from thirty years of the hemp, were harder across the palm than the sole of a boot.

The trouble, when it came, had nothing to do with the hemp; it was a trouble of ignorance. A rope-maker at Cuan shean knew his cordage the way Alasdair knew his timber, by hand and by eye, but he had never seen a keel or a frame or a mast-step, and he made his rope to lengths and weights that a written order gave him, without knowing what the rope was for or where the strain would fall on it. Two shroud-lines sent west that spring parted at the deadeye within a season, and the wrights sent word back up the coast, not a complaint exactly, more a puzzlement, asking why rope that had held on a coaster for ten years should fail on a hull that had not yet crossed open water once.

Alasdair sent two of his wrights north to Cuan shean that summer to answer it, Coinneach among them, and they did what neither side had thought to do before: they walked the rope-walks themselves, end to end, and named the parts of a hull to the spinners and the walkers as they went, stem and sternpost, garboard and futtock, the standing parts and the running, what took the ship's whole weight and what took only the wind's. Iain Ròpaire, who had never in thirty years thought of his trade as needing another man's trade explained to him, found that once he knew what a shroud held up he made a different rope for it without being told a different measure, and that the walkers, who had always kept their pace by nothing but habit, began without anyone teaching it to them to set the hull's own words into the rhythm of their feet, stem, stern, garboard, keel, over and over down the length of the walk, so that the work went no faster but somehow sat easier in the hand.

Iain never wrote any of it down. He had no cause to. But he took to walking the middle rope-walk himself again that summer, though he had not walked one in years, master's work being mostly standing and watching by then, because he wanted the words in his own feet before he trusted them to anyone else's. His wife asked him why, at his age, he was coming home with rope-burn on his palms like a boy's, and he told her only that a man who gave an order ought to know what it

cost to carry it out. The households of Cuan shean, when they told each other years afterward how the town had come to make the fleet's best cordage, told it as the year the rope-walks learned the names of a ship.

VIII

Of the Sail-Cloth of Baile àrsaidh

A little north of Cuan shean, in the shire of Baile àrsaidh, the levy on woven cloth had been running since the year the second household struck itself from the roll at Seann Skell, though it had no name yet beyond what the shire seat's tally-keeper called it in his own book: a length, close-woven, from every household that wove, owed once and reckoned against nothing, neither rent nor tithe.

He kept it on tally-sticks in the old way, a notch for a length delivered and a second cut for a length short, and by the ninth year of the age he had cut more notches than he had thought the shire held households that wove at all, because women who had never sent so much as a hank of thread to the shire seat before sent their close-woven lengths that year, some of them households with no one on the roll and no thought of ever being on it. He asked one such woman, an old weaver of a hill farm a long day's cart-ride inland who had not seen the sea since she was a girl, why she troubled to send cloth for ships she would never sail in and never see. She told him that her granddaughter had married into a household that had gone, and that a sail was the one part of a ship a weaver's hands could put something of herself into, and that she would rather her granddaughter went dry than went in a boat with a stranger's thread in her sail.

He cut her notch and said nothing to that, because there was nothing in his book for it, only a length and a date. He kept the sticks in a chest at the shire seat, one for each year of the levy, bundled with a thong and a wooden tag scratched with the year, and by the ninth year the chest wanted a second lid to close over the first. The tallies survive; how many households paid, and how many like the hill weaver paid for reasons the notch does not carry, is not now to be known, and the tally-keeper never thought to ask a second time, having learned from the first that the answer would not fit on his stick.

I X

Of the Hull that Stood Beside Her Sister

By the ninth year of the age An Dara Fhaoileag¹ was planked from keel to sheer and stepping her mast, and Alasdair, who had not let the wrights name her, at last let them, and they called her An Dara Fhaoileag, the second gull, because no better name came to hand and because the strand had grown used, by then, to naming its hulls for what they were rather than for what was hoped of them.

She stood on the strand where the first had stood, lower forward, fuller in the belly, narrower at the bow than any hull the island had built before her, and every wright who worked her hull now worked to the pattern that had been drawn once in wet sand and rubbed out twice before it was trusted. Alasdair walked her length in the evenings as he had walked the first, his palm on the wood, and if he still would not sail in any hull himself, no one asked him why any longer.

The rope for her rigging came down from Cuan shean already knowing, in the walkers' hands if nowhere else, what strain it would be asked to bear. Her sail-cloth had come, close-woven, from households up and down a shire whose weavers had never seen a mast go up. Eleven names stood cut into a board at Inis àrsaidh that the tide never reached and the weather was already beginning to soften at the edges, and would go on softening for as long as anyone thought to keep the board upright. On the harbour-house rolls at Seann Skell, eleven strokes lay across eleven names on one page and eleven fresh names stood uncrossed on the facing one, and Calum mac Nèill had still found no comment that belonged under either.

Alasdair stood at the harbour wall in the last light of that ninth year and looked at the hull standing there, lower and fuller and, he believed, honest in a way the first had not been, and did not let himself be glad of her, not yet, not the way he had let himself be glad once before. He only trusted her, which was a smaller thing and, he had learned, a safer one, and it would have to do until the sea had had the chance to prove him right or wrong a second time.

Coinneach mac Fhearghais found him there after the light had gone and the strand had emptied, and asked him, since he had never once been answered the first time he asked it, three years before, whether the fleet would truly be finished

1. the second gull, the hull built to the changed keel pattern after the loss of An Fhaoileag

within his own lifetime, or whether it was a thing being built for other men's sons to sail. Alasdair looked a long while at An Dara Fhaoileag, and past her at the black shape of the shed where the third already stood framed under its canvas, and said only that he did not know, and that not knowing was the one honest answer he had given anyone about any of it since the day he first read the roll in the harbour-house. Coinneach asked nothing further, and the two of them stood together at the wall a while in the dark, listening to the tide work at the stones below the new quay, until the cold sent them both in.

CHAPTER SIX

OF THE STAR- STEERSMEN OF CUAN RUADH

LE 11 – 18

I

Of the Six Who Went East

Catrìona nic Iain was eleven years old the first night she went out with her father's boat past the Ros àrsaidh bar and did not know, coming home, which way the harbour lay until the smell of the smoke told her.

She never forgot it. She was a pilot of Ros bheag by the time she was sixteen, one of a handful of young ones who could bring a boat home along the coast in fog by the fall of the swell alone, and she thought herself good at her trade. Then the roll opened at Seann Skell, and the wrights began to lay down hulls no coaster's pilot had ever been asked to steer, and it came out, in the talk on the quays, that none of them, not the oldest, not the best, had ever held a course out of sight of land after dark. A coaster hugged the shore and put in before dusk. A hull bound for a coast three weeks off the mist could do neither.

The custodian Fearchar mac Ruairidh, who by then went about the west coast on the households' business more than he sat at Taigh na Fèithe¹, put the question to the harbour-masters of four ports in one season: who, on this coast, has ever steered by the stars alone? The answer came back the same from all four. No one

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

now living. But there were tellings, thin and half-believed, of steersmen away on the eastern shore, at a town called Cuan ruadh, who still did.

It was a hundred miles off, by the map that hung in the harbour-house at Seann Skell, drawn crooked from an older one and marked in Alasdair Saor's own hand where the roads ran; and no road ran straight to it. A man would go up the coal-roads into the mountain country, and down again on the far side, and a week on foot was thought a fast crossing.

Six were chosen to go: two from Ros bheag, two from Ceann mhòr, one from Cuan shean, and Catriona, because she had asked to be sent before anyone had thought to ask her. She was the youngest of the six and the only woman, and the master of the Ros bheag boats, an old man who had taught her the coast himself, told her plainly to her face that a season away from her own harbour would lose her half her custom.

"Then I'll get it back," she said, "and something with it."

The other four she came to know on the road better than she had known them at their own quays, the way a fortnight's walking will do. The two Ceann mhòr men were brothers, broad and slow-spoken, who had never in their lives been more than a day's sail from Faire a' Chinn²; the Cuan shean man was a rope-maker's son who had gone to sea only twice and admitted it, on the third day, without shame; and of the second Ros bheag pilot, a lean, silent woman named for a grandmother nobody living remembered, Catriona learned only that she had lost a brother at sea and had asked to go east for reasons she never once spoke of the whole journey.

They went out in the moon of Bealltach, when the roads were driest, with staffs and packs and a little silver among them from Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill's own purse, sent by a rider with word that the lady of Inis àrsaidh wished them well and asked to be told, when they came home, what they had learned. They went up the coal-road past Muileann dhearg, where Taigh na Fèithe stood black on its hill and the custodians looked out at them from the gate and said nothing; and over the shoulder of the mountain country the road gave out into a track between screes, where the wind never stopped and the going was a mile in an hour over broken stone. On the fourth night the weather turned on them above the last of the lochs, a cold rain driving level off the moor with no shelter in it anywhere, and they spent the dark hours crowded under an overhang of rock with their backs to

2. the watch of the headland at Ceann mhòr

each other for warmth, and in the morning the Cuan shean man's feet were so cut about with the stones that the Ceann mhòr brothers had to carry his pack the rest of that day between them.

They went down again by a country none of them knew, of heather and small lochs and cairns whose names they did not have, and on the seventh evening they came over a last rise and saw the sea again, grey and enormous, with a town at the water's edge and boats drawn up along a strand that faced, for the first time in any of their lives, east, out over open water with no far shore in the telling of it at all.

Cuan ruadh smelled different from any harbour on the west coast. Catriona noticed it before she noticed anything else: no weed-smell of low tide flats, but a clean cold reek of open water, as though the town stood at the very edge of something with nothing beyond it but distance. The boats drawn up were narrow and deep for their length, built, she saw at once, on a different rule than any coaster she knew, sewn like the rest but with a thick shaped plank down the middle of the bottom, of the kind the old men of the west said their grandfathers' boats had carried.

"They go out of sight of land here," said one of the Ceann mhòr brothers, low, as they stood looking down at the strand. "They always did."

Nobody at Cuan ruadh made much of them. A boy took them to a byre where they might sleep and a woman brought them fish and barley bread without asking who had sent them, as though six strangers off the mountain road were a thing that happened often enough not to need remarking on; and it was only the next morning, when Catriona asked at the well where the steersman lived, that the woman drawing water looked at her a long moment before she answered, in the way of someone deciding how much a stranger deserved to be told.

II

Of the Steersman of Cuan ruadh

The man they were sent to was called Seumas Reultach. It was a by-name the town had settled on him so long ago that no one now living had heard the name his mother gave him. He was old, older than any of them had reckoned an old man could be and still climb a cliff path without a staff, and he received them at his own door with no surprise at all, as though six strangers from the far side of the island turned up asking to be taught the stars once in every gen-

eration, which, it came out over the following days, was very nearly true: his own grandmother had taught two men from the north coast, long before any of them were born, who had gone home and, so far as Seumas knew, taught no one.

"You'll have to come at night," he told them, "for the stars aren't out by day, whatever else you may have heard," and it was the only joke Catrìona ever heard him make in all the months that followed.

They came at night, every clear one, up a path above the town to a headland where the wind stripped every sound but its own, and Seumas Reultach, wrapped in a sealskin that had been his father's, taught them to stand still and look up until the sky stopped being a scatter of light and became a shape.

The first night he taught them nothing at all. He walked them up the path in the last of the dusk, sat them down in a half-ring on the cold grass with their backs to the lights of the town, and told them to be silent and to look up, and for the better part of two hours nobody spoke and nothing was named. The ropemaker's son grew restless and was told, once, without heat, to be still; the lean woman from Ros bheag did not move at all. When at last Seumas rose and said that was enough for one night and led them back down, the Cuan shean man asked him, aggrieved, what they had learned.

"You have learned that it takes a while," said Seumas, "before a man stops seeing points of light and starts seeing a sky. Come back tomorrow if it's clear."

He began, on the second night, with what he called the wheel: how the whole sky turned, slow as a millstone, about a fixed point low over the northern sea that never moved though everything else did, and how a man who found that point and kept it always at his shoulder, whichever way the boat's head lay, need never be lost in the dark. The star that stood nearest it, low and steady above the water on a clear night, he named to them: Reul na Stiùire¹. From three others set in a line he showed them how to find it, so that on a cloudy night, if even one showed through a gap, a man who knew the shapes could still find his star by where the others would have stood.

Catrìona had thought, before that first night, that she already knew the sky a little, from six years of putting to sea before dawn. She learned, on the headland above Cuan ruadh, that she had known nothing: not one true name, not one bearing, not the difference between a star that held its place the whole night through and one that only seemed to, low near the water, and set within the hour.

1. the steering star

Seumas taught them the whole turning year of the sky as a farmer taught a son the turning year of the fields: which stars stood over the stern at Samhnas and which at Teasach, how the wheel itself shifted its whole aspect between the black months and the bright, so that a man steering the same course by the same star in winter and in summer must know to look for it in a different quarter of the sky or lose his heading entirely. He taught them to read the smell of the dark, the particular cold that came before a change of wind, the look of the water under starlight when a swell was building that the eye alone, in daylight, would have missed. Most of it he gave them only as it was given him, mouth to ear, night after night, with nothing written, because there was nothing to write it on that would survive a sea crossing and because, he said once, a thing carried in the hand is more easily lost than a thing carried in the head.

The lessons did not always go easily. There were nights of cloud when nothing could be taught at all and the six sat idle in the byre while the rope-maker's son grumbled that they had come a hundred miles to learn nothing; there was a week in the first winter when the lean woman from Ros bheag fell sick of a fever off the crossing and Seumas himself came down from his house each evening to sit by her, not to teach, only to sit, until she was well; and there was a night, deep in that same winter, when one of the Ceann mhòr brothers, cold and homesick and tired of being corrected, said aloud on the headland that a man could learn to fish by starlight for twenty years on the west coast and never need a word of any of this, and that they had been sent on a fool's errand by a custodian with too much silver and not enough sense. Seumas let him finish. Then he asked him, quietly, how he meant to find his way home across open water once the last headland of Dia-thìr had sunk below the sea behind him, and the man had no answer, and came back to the headland every clear night after that without being asked again.

Catrìona asked more questions than the rest of them together, and it was to her, more than to any of the others, that Seumas began after the first winter to speak of things beyond what he set out each night to teach: the names his own teacher had given the stars, some of them older, he thought, than the town; a telling of steersmen from an age before Rìghrean na Cloiche² who were said to have gone west of the sunset and not come back, which he would neither say he believed nor quite say he did not; and once, on a night of no cloud when the wheel stood very clear, the plain admission that no one now at Cuan ruadh, him-

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

self least of all, any longer sailed by night as their grandfathers had, because there was nowhere left on that coast that the daylight coasting trade could not reach before dark, and the knowledge had gone on being taught, generation after generation, to fewer and fewer, for the sake of the teaching and not because anyone still needed it. "Until now," he said, and looked at her, and said nothing more that night.

In the second winter Fearchar's rider came again, with word that the ships were being laid down in earnest now and asking whether any part of the teaching might be set down, that it should not all ride on six heads and the chance of the sea. Seumas thought about it three days. Then he sent for a scraped hide and an awl, and set his own granddaughter, whose hand was steadier than his own had ever been, to cutting the marks as he named them to her by the fire: the wheel, Reul na Stiùire and the three that found it, and the four turning marks of the year. Catriona watched the girl's awl go into the hide, stroke by careful stroke, and thought it the strangest thing she had yet seen at Cuan ruadh, stranger than the deep-keeled boats or the wheel of the sky, that a thing which had lived only in old men's mouths for as long as anyone could tell should be made, in one winter evening, to hold still.

When it was done, and no more, the Cuan shean man asked why not the rest of it, the swell-reading and the wind-smell and the hundred small signs that had taken two winters to teach. Seumas Reultach looked at him a long while and said that some things a hide could hold and some things only a life could, and that he had given them the first kind and meant to go on giving them the second kind as long as he had breath, and after that it would go the way such things went.

He had less breath than any of them knew. In the third spring, in the moon of Faolach, in the wolf-storms, he took to his bed with a cough that would not leave him, and for a fortnight the six of them took it in turn to sit with him, for there was little else by then to teach and much, Catriona thought, that they still owed him. He rallied enough, on the first clear night after the fortnight's rain broke, to insist on the cliff path once more, leaning on two of them going up and refusing, at the top, to be helped to sit. He named the wheel to them one last time, as though they might have forgotten it, and fell silent, and they thought he had only gone quiet the way he sometimes did. When the others thought at last that he had gone in out of the cold as he always did, he had not. They found him at the top of the cliff path in the morning, sitting with his back against the stone he always

leaned on, his sealskin drawn close, his face turned up to where the wheel had gone round while he sat there and left Reul na Stiùire exactly where it always was.

They buried him at Cuan ruadh, among his own people, with the whole town come down to the graveside though none of the six had ever seen more than a handful of its people at once before; and his granddaughter gave the hide with its marks into Catriona's keeping, saying only that her grandfather had meant it to go west, and that she herself could read it as well as any of them and had no need to keep it. Catriona said afterward that of all the things she had been taught that winter the truest was the one nobody had set out to teach her: that a man could hold a whole sky in his head and pass almost none of it on, and that whatever they carried west out of Cuan ruadh, hide and memory both, it would always be less than what he had known.

III

Of the First Trial and the Star Named on the Quay

They went home in the moon of Faolach still, still six, for Seumas had never been one of them to lose; over the mountain country by the same track, with the same wind, carrying nothing on the outward road that they had not carried in, and everything that mattered on the road back in their own heads, and the hide, wrapped against the wet in a fold of the lean woman's cloak because she alone among them thought to ask for the driest place to carry it.

At Ros àrsaidh, where the coast lay open enough for a night's sailing without much risk of the rocks, they held the first trial that summer, and half the town came down to the strand to see it fail. Two boats went out after dark: one steered the old way, close along the shore with a man forward calling the water at every length, lanterns swinging at bow and stern so the watchers on the cliff could follow her the whole night; and one by Catriona alone, with two of the Ros àrsaidh men to work the sail and say nothing, out past the headland into open water and every lantern doused, with nothing to go by but Reul na Stiùire¹ held at her shoulder as Seumas had taught her, and the smell of the wind, and the set of the swell under the keel. For the first hour, she said afterward, she was as frightened as either of the men with her, listening for the sound of a wave breaking on rock

1. the steering star

that she could not see and trusting, against everything her years on that coast had taught her, that the star at her shoulder and not the black loom of the land was the thing to steer by. Then the fear went, the way it had gone on the headland above Cuan ruadh once she had stopped listening to what she thought she knew and started listening to what she had been taught, and the rest of the night she held her course as easily as she had ever held one along a shore she could see.

She brought her boat back before the other one, and put it exactly where she had said she would the evening before, at first light, on the tide she had named; and the two men who had gone with her, sick with fear the whole night through by their own later admission, would not say a word against it afterward, though one of them would not go out with her by night again for a year.

Word of the trial went along the coast faster than Catrìona could follow it herself, and by the next year she had more asking to learn from her than she and the other five together could teach, and no time to teach them, for the harbour-house was calling in the households of the roll that spring, and every one of the six pilots had entered long since, and was wanted.

She reached Seann Skell in the moon of Siolach, late, having stopped a fortnight at Ros bheag to see her mother, who was old and would not be going, and to leave with her what little silver she had, and to say the kind of goodbye that neither of them named for what it was. The harbour road into Seann Skell was busier than she had ever known it, carts and barrows and whole families afoot with what they could carry, and the town itself, when she came down into it at last, smelled of pitch and sawdust and woodsmoke in a way it never had in her girlhood, so that for a moment, tired from the road, she hardly knew it. When she came down at last to the harbour front she found the boards already crowded and the town talking of nothing else: the households of the roll had met, it was said, and chosen who should lead them, and it was done, though nobody she asked could say quite how, only that it was Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, the queen's own sister, and Fearchar mac Ruairidh of Taigh na Fèithe², and that the two of them were even now down at the new stones of the west quay looking over the first hulls.

She found them there in the evening light, the queen's sister in a plain grey cloak with the wind pulling at it, and the custodian beside her with his hands behind his back, the two of them standing where the stonework was still raw and

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

pale and the tide had not yet worn it, looking at a hull that stood half-ribbed on its frame like the bones of something not yet grown its skin. Along the strand behind them the town went on with its evening as though nothing had changed in it at all, boats coming in, nets spread to dry, a woman calling a child in to supper; and Catriona thought, standing a little apart with her pack still on her shoulder and the hide from Cuan ruadh wrapped inside it, how strange it was that a choosing which the whole harbour was talking of should have left the harbour looking exactly as it always had.

"You're the one who went east," said Mòrag, before Catriona had said who she was.

"I am."

"And you came back knowing the stars."

"I came back knowing some of them. There was more to know than any six of us could carry."

Mòrag looked at her a moment, the way, Catriona thought afterward, a woman looks at a thing she has been waiting to be given without knowing its shape beforehand. "I have a hull," she said. "An Ròn Glas³. She'll carry my own household and I don't yet know how many more, and she'll need someone at the steering oar who can hold a course the night the coast goes out of sight for good, because after that there'll be nothing else to hold it by. Will you be her pilot?"

Fearchar said nothing, but he was watching Catriona's face as if the answer mattered to him nearly as much as it did to Mòrag, and afterward, when it was too late to ask him, she wondered whether it was because he already knew, better than anyone else on that quay, how few of them there would ever be who could do what she could do. He had, she remembered later, counted households on a copied roll and found them fewer than he wished; he was a man used to finding that a thing the venture needed came in short measure, and used to taking what there was of it without complaint.

"I will," said Catriona, and found, saying it, that she had known her own answer since the headland above Cuan ruadh and had only been waiting, without knowing it, for someone to ask her the question in words.

Mòrag nodded, once, as though a thing long uncertain had at last been set down in its right place, and turned back to the hull. But before she did, Catriona, not quite knowing why she said it, lifted a hand toward the darkening sky over

3. the Grey Seal, the hull that carried Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill's household

the river mouth, where the first stars were beginning to show through the last of the light, and found the one she wanted without having to search for it, as she no longer had to search for anything in that part of the sky.

"That one," she said. "Low, over the water. That's the one I'll be steering by, my lady, the night the coast goes."

Mòrag looked where she pointed, and said nothing for a while, and the light went on failing over the river, and the star Catriona had named stood where it always stood, the one point in the whole turning sky that never moved.

CHAPTER SEVEN

OF THE HANDFUL FOR THE NEW HEARTH

LE 19 – 31

*Dòrlach airson an teallaich ùir, is an seann teallach fhatbast blàth. A
handful for the new hearth, and the old hearth still warm.
— a couplet written beside the ruling in Leabhar a' Chùraim*

I

Of the Boy Given to the Vein-House

 onnachadh mac Thormoid was nine years old when his father walked him up the coal-road to Taigh na Fèithe¹ and left him there, the way a man leaves a lamb with a shepherd he trusts and does not look back at, for looking back is thought to unsettle the lamb. It was the custom, by then, to swear a boy or a girl to the vein's service for seven years if the household could spare the hands and Taigh na Fèithe would have them, the same manner in which the wrights of the strand at Seann Skell had begun to swear their own apprentices; and Tormod, who cut turf for three households on the moor above Muileann dhearg and had five children and not much land, thought his youngest son's hands better spent at a desk than on a spade. He said as much to the boy on the road up, not unkindly. Donnchadh remembered the words for the rest of his life, though he came in time to doubt his father had meant them as a kindness at all, only as the truth, plainly given, the way a poor man gives a true thing to a child because he has nothing softer to give.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Taigh na Fèithe stood black on its hill above the diggings, built of the same dark stone the galleries were cut from, so that from a distance it seemed less built than grown, a knuckle of the mountain that had learned to keep a roof. Within, it smelled of tallow and cold stone and, faintly, always, of the coal underneath, a smell Donnchadh never afterward could smell anywhere else without seeing the low black door of the custody-room and the shelf where the book was kept. He was set to sweeping at first, and to carrying water for the elder clerks, and only after the better part of a year to holding a stylus at all, and then only to copy, letter after letter, the names already written by better hands, until his own hand no longer shook doing it.

The master of Taigh na Fèithe in those years was Eòghann mac Mhuirich, an old man even then, stooped from sixty years bent over Leabhar a' Chùrainn², who had written the figure of the counted households in the third year after the word of the far shore and, as the tale went among the clerks, had not looked up from the page for the length of a hundred breaths after he wrote it. He kept Donnchadh at his own elbow more than the other boys, not, Donnchadh came to think, because he showed any particular gift, but because Eòghann liked a quiet hand nearby and Donnchadh had learned early not to talk while a man was thinking.

It was in his first winter at Taigh na Fèithe, before he had held the stylus at all, that Donnchadh saw Fearchar mac Ruairidh come up the hill on a grey horse with mud to its hocks, and heard, crouched by the door with an armful of kindling he had no reason to be slow about carrying in, the middle of a trouble that had already run four years and would take two more to settle and that he would, in the end, be given the pen to close.

II

Of the Petition

Fearchar mac Ruairidh had gone, by then, from a custodian who sat at Taigh na Fèithe¹ board twice a season to a man who was hardly ever off the road: down to Seann Skell to see the boards, out to the shire seats to hear

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

how the levy of sail-cloth was going, up again to Taigh na Fèithe with word of what the harbour needed and what the households of the roll had asked of him, though none of them, strictly, had any right to ask him anything at all, the roll being a thing of household and hearth and not of office. He had taken the asking on himself, the clerks said, the way a man takes on a debt nobody has billed him for, because somebody had to carry it and he found himself standing nearest when it fell.

What he wanted, that first day and for six years after, was simple to say and hard, it turned out, to grant. The departing would go with what they could carry on their backs and in their hulls: tools, seed, cloth, the small worth of a household uprooted. They would not go with fire already in their hands, unless the island gave it to them, and there was only one fire on the island that was not any man's own to give: the coal of the vein, which Leabhar a' Chùrain² measured out hearth by hearth under Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig³ and had never, in all the years since Fionnlagh Dall filled the cup, measured out to anything that was not a hearth standing still on Dia-thìr.

"Let each hull that is fit to sail carry a measure," Fearchar said, the first time Donnchadh heard him say it, standing in the yard with his hat still in his hand and rain running off his shoulders, to Eòghann and two of the elder custodians who had come out to hear him because it was raining too hard to make him wait outside. "One measure. Sealed, counted, entered in the book like any other hearth's. I ask for no more than Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig already gives a household that stays."

"Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig measures a hearth," said one of the custodians, a heavy man named Cailean whom Donnchadh came later to know as a hard voice at every board and a soft one at every sickbed, "not a keel. A hearth stands where it stood. It does not go anywhere. What you are asking, Fearchar, though you dress it kindly, is that the vein answer for a fire it will never see burn and never see go cold, on the far side of I know not what water, for I know not how long. This is a new law, and none of us here has the right to make one."

"Then I ask you to make one," said Fearchar, "or else to tell the households of the roll plainly, before they go, that the coal they have held the right to since their grandmothers' grandmothers will end, for them, the day they step aboard. I

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

would rather they heard it now, from you, than found it out cold, three weeks past the mist."

Nobody answered him that day. Eòghann sent him down the hill with a cup of broth against the rain and a promise that the matter would be put to the board at the next burning, which was Taigh na Fèithe's way, Donnchadh learned, of saying that a thing was too large to be settled standing up in a wet yard.

III

Of the Winter Burning

It was not settled at the next burning, nor the one after. Donnchadh grew a hand's width and lost two milk teeth and buried his mother's brother, who died of a fever that went round the coal-breakers' cots below the hill, in the years Taigh na Fèithe¹ argued Fearchar's petition back and forth across its own board without coming any nearer an answer than it had been the day he stood dripping in the yard. He came to know the shape of the argument the way he knew the shape of the hill from his window: Cailean and two or three others holding that the coal had never crossed water and never should, that a measure sealed and sent out of sight of Taigh na Fèithe was a measure Leabhar a' Chùrain² could no longer answer for, gone from Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig³'s keeping into nobody's; and Fearchar, with a smaller knot of custodians who had come round to him one by one, holding that Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig measured hearths because hearths were what the island had ever had need of measuring, and that a hearth crossing open water was still a hearth, only a stranger one, and deserved no less than any other.

The winter burning of the year Donnchadh turned eleven was the one Taigh na Fèithe remembered afterward, because it was the one at which the argument, having worn itself thin over six years, finally wore through. Donnchadh was eleven that winter, old enough to be let sit at the back of the hall with the other clerks' boys while the custodians spoke, though not old enough to be asked his own mind on anything, and he remembered the hall by its cold more than by anything said in it for the first hour: a long low room cut into the hill, lit by rush-lights that

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

guttered whenever the door opened, with the custodians ranged along both sides of the board and Leabhar a' Chùraim lying closed at its head, as it always lay when a matter touched what was written in it.

Cailean spoke longest, and hardest. "We are not asked to give a handful of coal," he said, near the end of it, when his voice had gone rough with two hours of being answered. "We are asked to say that Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig follows a household wherever a household chooses to go, though it go past the edge of everything Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig was ever made to answer for. If we say it once, for a ship, we may be asked to say it again, for I do not know what, and I would have us think three times before we hand away the one thing on this island that has never once been given past its own bounds."

"And if we do not say it," Fearchar answered him, quiet now himself, all the road-weary force gone out of his voice and something flatter and more tired left in its place, "then I will stand on the west quay the day the fleet goes out, and I will watch fires kindled on those decks with wood alone, and I will know, better than any man in this hall, which households among them held the right to the coal their whole lives and go without it now for the first time, because we would not answer a small thing simply because it frightened us to answer it. I have counted those households, Cailean, with my own hand. Better to answer for a measure of coal gone where none of us can follow it than answer to them, one day, for why we let them go cold out of pride in Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig, that was never made to be proud of anything."

There was a silence after that which Donnchadh remembered as longer than it can truly have been, the kind of silence in which a room decides something without any one voice being heard to decide it. Eòghann, who had said almost nothing the whole evening, put both hands flat on the board at last and said that he would have Leabhar a' Chùraim opened, and the question put to writing, and that they would vote it as they voted any other matter that had been talked enough. They voted before the rush-lights burned out. Donnchadh did not, at eleven, understand every word of the ruling as it was first spoken aloud, but he understood, from the way the hall emptied afterward, quiet and a little spent, like a house after a birth that has gone on too long and come out well at the last, that something had been decided that would outlast the argument that made it.

IV

Of the Clean Copy

The ruling was simple enough, once it was written plain, though it had taken six winters and one long night to arrive at: each hull that should be found fit to sail might carry one sealed measure of the coal, no more than a single household might burn in a season under *Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig*¹, entered in *Leabhar a' Chùraim*² as any hearth's measure was entered, and sealed by *Taigh na Fèithe*³'s own mark so that no man could say, after, that it had been taken rather than given. It answered for no hearth once it was gone past the mist, and promised no more fire after that one measure than the household would have found in its own grate at home in a single ordinary winter: exactly the size of thing *Leabhar a' Chùraim* had always measured, *Donnchadh* thought later, and no bigger. *Fearchar* had asked for a hearth's worth and been given, in the end, precisely that, dressed up in six years of argument to make it look larger than it was.

He was fifteen, and six years at the desk, when *Eòghann* called him at last to make the fair copy; the ruling had lain four years in rough marks, for the master would let no entry into *Leabhar a' Chùraim* in a hand he did not trust. His hand was not the finest in *Taigh na Fèithe*; the ruling had been argued and voted and set down in rough marks by an old scribe's cramped fingers, and somebody young enough to sit a whole day without his back giving out was wanted to render it clean for the book that would stand, unaltered, for as long as *Taigh na Fèithe* kept records at all. It was his first entry in *Leabhar a' Chùraim* proper, and he remembered every line of it afterward the way another man remembers his first field ploughed alone.

He copied it letter for letter, the sealed measure, the single household's season, *Taigh na Fèithe*'s mark; and when he had finished, and sanded the page, and sat back to let the ink set, he noticed a thing that nobody in the hall, arguing six winters over whether the coal might go at all, had thought to argue over: that the ruling, in giving the coal, gave nothing else with it. Every other entry he had copied that year, weddings recorded for the dowry-right, deaths recorded for the inheritance of a hearth, opened or closed with some small word of *Taigh na Fèithe*'s own, a blessing on the hearth, a wish for its long burning, the kind of thing a

1. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the vein-house above *Muileann dhearg*

scribe wrote as much from habit as from instruction. This entry had none of it. It measured the coal and said nothing over it. Donnchadh sat a long while with his sanded page before him, deciding whether that was an oversight to be mended or a thing the custodians had meant, without saying so aloud, and in the end he copied it exactly as it had been given him, with no blessing added, because it was not his place to add one, and because, he thought, turning it over afterward on the walk back to his own cot, perhaps a hall that could not agree for six winters whether to give the coal at all had simply had no blessing left in it to spare.

V

Of the Measures Sealed

The measures themselves were made the year after: not counted out against any tally of hulls, for nobody at Taigh na Fèithe¹ yet knew, or claimed to know, how many hulls the strand at Seann Skell would in the end put in the water, but sealed as they were asked for, each one against the words *for each bull that shall be ready*, a phrase Donnchadh had copied into the ruling himself and had not, until he watched the first measures made, understood the weight of. It meant that Taigh na Fèithe had bound itself to a number it could not know in advance, open-ended as a debt with no term set on it, and that every measure sealed that year and the years after would go down the coal-road to Seann Skell without any man at Taigh na Fèithe ever adding up how many had gone, because the ruling had never asked for a count, only for readiness.

He watched the first of them sealed on a grey morning in the moon of Dubh-las, in the low room off the custody-hall where Taigh na Fèithe kept its scales: a store-clerk weighing out the coal against the same stone weights used for any household's handful, no more careful and no less, and Eòghann himself pressing the mark into the wax while Fearchar stood by, hat again in hand, saying nothing at all, as though he had used up every word he had on the matter in six years of asking and had only silence left to spend on seeing it done.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

VI

Of the Masons Sent West

The queen sent no household of her own to the roll, then or ever, but some years after the first measures were sealed, when the hulls on the strand had grown too deep for the old staging, she lent the harbour's trade something Taigh na Fèithe¹ could not give it: hands. A gang of masons out of the capital, under a man named Ailean mac Nèill, a broad, sun-browned mason not yet thirty who had cut his teeth dressing stone for An Cnoc Ruadh²'s own walls, came down the river road to Seann Skell that spring with wagons of squared stone and the queen's word that they were sent for the harbour's trade and for no other reason the rider would name. It was said afterward, at Taigh na Fèithe as everywhere else, that Beathag had sent them for the fleet and called it trade because trade was a thing a queen might send masons for without anyone asking whom she had sent them to help; but it was also said, by those who had watched her rule since her mother's day, that she had never once, in more than thirty years on An Talla Dearg³'s high seat, called a thing by any name but the truest one she could give it without breaking her own word, and that if she called it trade, then trade, in some fashion known best to herself, was what she believed it to be.

Ailean's gang lengthened the west quay through that summer and the next, dressed stone laid course on course where the old timber staging had done duty since before anyone living could remember, so that the deep hulls building on the strand above might one day lie alongside at low water without grounding their new keels on the mud the old quay had never needed to clear. It was hard, wet work, the tide taking back at every ebb what the masons had set at every flood, and Ailean, the harbour-house's own scribe Calum wrote that year in a note that came up with the coal-tallies and that Donnchadh, still a boy at his desk, read twice for the pleasure of a line written plain, "curses the sea in three tongues and lays stone against it anyway, which is more than most men do against anything."

VII

Of the Queen on the New Stones

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

3. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

It is told that Beathag herself rode down to Seann Skell in the second summer of the quay's building, the only time in all the years of the fleet's making that she is known to have gone to see it with her own eyes, though her sister's household had been on the roll more than twenty years by then and the hulls as long abuilding on the same strand. She rode the twenty-four miles in a day, with a small following and no herald sent ahead to have the town made ready for her, and stood a while on the new-laid stone in the evening light, watching the tide come in against courses that had not yet worn smooth, while Ailean's men, who had not been told a queen was coming and would not have known her by sight if a rider had not named her quietly among them, went on laying stone within a few yards of her as though she were any woman come down to watch the work.

Mòrag came to her there, on the stones, the two sisters standing together where the masonry was still raw and pale and the tide had not yet worn it, and it is told that they spoke a while of nothing that mattered: of a horse Mòrag had lately sold, of a leak in a roof at Inis àrsaidh that had taken three tries to mend, of the queen's son, grown too tall for the low doors of An Talla Dearg¹. Neither sister spoke, that evening, of the coal, or the roll, or the half-built hulls standing along the strand behind them; it was, the harbour-house's own note of that day says, as though each had decided, without a word passing between them to decide it, that an evening might be spent as an evening and not as a leave-taking, though it is also told that when the queen rode home the next morning she looked back once, from the top of the harbour road, at the stones and the half-built hulls and her sister standing among them, and did not look back a second time.

Donnchadh never saw that evening; Taigh na Fèithe's² business kept him on the hill that whole summer, sealing measures against tallies that came up from Seann Skell in a hand he did not know. But the note of it came to him with the coal-figures, as most news of the coast did, folded into the same rider's pouch as a tally of barrels and a line about the weather, and he copied the line about the queen's visit into Leabhar a' Chùrain's³ own margin, where such things were sometimes kept though they answered to no ruling and no law, because it seemed to him, turning fifteen that year and beginning to understand that not every true thing needed a ruling to be worth the keeping, a fact Taigh na Fèithe ought not to let go unwritten.

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

VIII

Of the Death of Uilleam mac Iain

In the last days of that same year, in the moon of Damhrach, word came up the coal-road that the queen's consort, Uilleam mac Iain, was dead: a man who had never sat at Taigh na Fèithe's board nor asked it for anything in his life, kind, it was said, and fond of hounds, who had given Beathag her son and had stood, by every account Donnchadh ever heard, quietly behind her through more than thirty years of a crown that was never his own to wear. He had been ill through the summer, the rider said, and had not mended.

The queen kept the funeral small: no great muster of the shires, no feast that would have cost the granaries a season's worth of grain in a year the harvest had been thin, only An Talla Dearg's¹ own household and the few custodian heads whose presence courtesy required, gathered a single day at Cathair dhearg and gone home again before the week was out. It was remarked on, at Taigh na Fèithe as everywhere the tidings travelled, that a queen who had refused to send her own sister anywhere and refused, with the same breath, to keep her back, should bury her own husband as quietly as a crofter buries a wife: no more show made of her grief than Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig³ made of a hearth's handful. Eòghann, who was by then very old and had himself less than a year left to him, said only, when the tidings reached Taigh na Fèithe's board, that a queen who measured everything else in her kingdom by what it truly was and not by what it might be dressed to look, would hardly begin dressing up her own sorrow at the one moment in her life least suited to the dressing.

IX

Of the Last Stone and the Sealing by Lamplight

Ailean mac Nèill's gang set the last stone of the lengthened quay in the following spring, a plain block no larger than any other in the whole course, laid at the seaward end where the new masonry met the old timber staging and the two were bound together with an iron cramp that Ailean himself drove

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

home, the harbour-house's note says, with three blows and no more, as though he grudged the stone a fourth. There was no ceremony made of it that the tellings remember: the tide came in over it that evening exactly as it had come in over every stone before it, and a boy of the strand, running the new-laid course end to end because a boy will always run the length of a new thing before an adult thinks to stop him, was the only soul on the whole quay who marked, aloud, that it was finished.

On the same evening, though neither of them ever knew the other's hour, Donnchadh sealed a measure of coal by lamplight in the low room off the custody-hall at Taigh na Fèithe¹, alone but for the store-clerk who weighed the coal against the stone weights, pressing Taigh na Fèithe's mark into the wax with a hand that no longer shook at all, sixteen years old and seven years come from a nine-year-old led up a hill by a father who had not looked back. He had by then sealed a good many measures and copied a good many entries, and this one, so far as he knew, differed from the last only in the number written against it in the book; but he found himself, that evening, holding the lamp a moment longer than the sealing needed, over a page that gave, as every page like it had given since his own fair copy first set the words down plain, a handful of coal and no blessing, to a hearth not yet built, on a shore no one at Taigh na Fèithe had ever seen and no one there, by then, much expected to.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

CHAPTER EIGHT

OF the GRAIN STRIFE and the FORTY-ONE BARGES

LE 37 – 39

I

Of the Lean Harvest

Tormod mac Coinnich had kept the granaries at Àth shean for eleven years before the harvest failed under him, and in all that time he had let no petitioner leave the store-house door without a plain answer, yes or no, said to his face. It was the only pride he owned to. He was not a clever man, by his own reckoning, and he had never once been asked to sit at An Talla Dearg¹'s board; but he could tell to the bushel what a granary held, and he had buried, as a boy, two brothers and a sister in a year when the barley failed and the reeve of that day had answered every petitioner with a smile and no grain, and he had never in his life forgotten the smell of the empty store-house in that spring, which was of nothing at all, of swept stone and mouse-droppings and cold.

He kept the memory of that spring the way another man might keep a scar: not spoken of, not forgotten, touched now and again in the dark to be sure it was still there. He had been seven years old that year. The store-house at Àth shean, he remembered, stood open and swept and empty, while the reeve of that day, a smiling man named Uisdean whom the shire had trusted for twenty years and trusted no more after, told petitioner after petitioner that there would be grain enough

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

by the new moon, and the new moon came and went with no grain in it. He remembered his mother boiling the last of the seed-barley rather than let it go to the following year's planting, because a planting a family does not live to see does a family no good; and he remembered, most of all, the particular nothing-smell of an empty granary in a hungry season, swept stone and old dust and a cold that seemed to come up out of the bare floor, which he had gone back to smell, deliberately, more than once in the years since, on ordinary days when the stores stood full, as a man touches an old wound to be certain it has healed and to remember, at the same time, exactly how it had felt when it had not.

In the autumn of LE 37 the barley came in thin across the shires south of the mountain, the fourth-poorest harvest of Tormod's eleven years by his own tally-sticks. The granaries at Àth shean, well kept, would carry the country through to the green without much pinching, so long as nothing else was asked of them. Something else was asked of them.

The word came down from Cathair dhearg in the moon of Damhrach, carried by a rider who had ridden two days and slept badly: the fleet at Seann Skell must be fed for its crossing, and the grain for it would come, in whatever measure the council settled on, out of the south shires' stores, because the south shires' stores were the fullest on the island and the nearest to the rivers that ran to the coast. Tormod heard it read out at his own door and said nothing to the rider beyond thanking him for his trouble. That night he sat a long while at his own table with the tally-sticks laid out in their rows, running his thumb along the notches as though he might read something in them beyond what was cut there, and his wife watched him and did not ask what he was thinking, because she had been married to him twenty years and knew.

II

Of the Barred Doors

The council at An Talla Dearg¹ divided on the question through that whole dark season, and divided, by every account that ever reached Àth shean, along no line a plain man could follow. Some of the queen's own councilors held that a household could not be sent out onto open water without bread

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

enough to see it through the crossing, whatever that crossing cost the island behind it; others held that *Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig*² measured a hearth and had never measured a granary, and that grain given to the departed was grain the island's own children would not eat the following spring. The queen herself, it was said, sat through the sessions with her hands folded and gave no opinion that any rider carried south, which was, by then, well known to be her custom in matters she had not yet decided to settle by her own word alone.

What was decided, and by whom, and on what day, Tormod mac Coinnich never learned, then or after. He only knew that no ruling came, week on week, while the rivers ran high with the autumn rain and the barges that would have carried grain to the coast sat idle at their moorings, and the petitioners for the fleet's stores began to come to his own door at *Àth shean* asking for grain on the strength of a council that had, so far as he could tell, not yet spoken.

He turned the first of them away with a plain no, as was his custom, and thought that would be the end of it. It was not. Within the week a second petitioner came, with a sealed leaf from a captain of one of the hulls that Tormod could not read and did not trust, and after him a third, and by the turn of the moon there were men at his gate most mornings, some civil and some not, asking for measures of barley on no authority he could name. He remembered the reeve who had smiled at his mother with an empty store-house behind him, and on a morning in early *Samhnas*, with no ruling yet come from the capital and the granaries at *Àth shean* the last full ones south of the mountain, Tormod mac Coinnich barred the store-house doors himself, set a watch of four men on them day and night, and told the next petitioner, and every one after, that the grain would move when the council's own seal came down and not a day before.

It was not a popular thing to have done. A captain's steward, a broad man with a fleet's own urgency in him and none of a shire's patience, climbed the granary steps on the third day of the bar and asked Tormod straight out whether he meant to let households starve at sea for the sake of his own tallies.

"I mean to let no one starve, here or at sea," Tormod told him, "which is why the grain stays counted and under a roof until I am told, by someone whose word I can write down, how much of it is to go and where. I have watched a granary opened on a smiling man's word before. I will not watch it again."

"You'll answer for this at *An Talla Dearg*."

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

"I have answered for worse to worse men than sit there," Tormod said, which was not, strictly, true, but the steward did not know that, and went away down the steps red in the face, to the plain satisfaction of the watch, who told the tale in the town that evening with more relish than the moment had held.

Worse than the steward, by far, were the quiet ones. A woman of the south shires came one grey morning with a basket over her arm as though she meant only an ordinary errand, and asked Tormod, in a voice that never once rose, whether her own son's household, entered on the roll and waiting at Seann Skell with two small children, would go hungry on the crossing for Tormod mac Coinnich's stubbornness. He gave her the same answer he gave every petitioner, that the grain would move when the council's seal came and not before, and she heard him out, and thanked him with more courtesy than the steward had shown, and went away down the road with her empty basket still on her arm; and it was she, and not the steward, whom Tormod thought of on the cold watches of that winter, turning her quiet voice over in his mind at an hour when there was no one to answer it and nothing to be done but stand by a barred door and wait for a word that did not come.

The watch stood through Samhnas and Dubhlas and on through the black months after, four men at the granary doors in every weather, relieved every third day, eating from the same stores they guarded because Tormod would not have it said that his own watch went hungry while it kept a full store shut. He walked the round with them himself most nights, more from restlessness than from any doubt of the men he had set there, and came to know the sound the wind made off the river against the granary's north gable better than he knew, by then, his own wife's step on the stair.

Riders came from the capital twice that he counted, once with a leaf that named no figure and satisfied no one, once with nothing written at all, only a spoken word that the matter was still before the council. He read the leaf by lamplight at his own table and set it aside and did not sleep well that night. His own doing gave him no trouble; what kept him awake was a slower doubt, that no one above him at all knew what should be done, and a granary reeve who has begun to think that has nothing left to stand on but his own tally-sticks and his own memory of an empty store-house, which is a narrow thing to build a winter's stand on.

He was not a man given to speech, and he made none to the watch beyond the ordinary business of the round; but on one bitter night near the turn of the year,

with the four of them huddled under the granary eave out of a sleet that had not let up since dusk, the youngest of them, a lad not yet twenty who had taken the watch mostly for the extra measure of barley it earned his own mother's house, asked him outright whether he thought the grain would ever move at all, or whether they would stand there the rest of their lives guarding a door nobody meant to open.

"It will move," Tormod said, "when someone above me stops being afraid of his own decision and puts his name to one." And then, because the boy looked so cold and so young standing there in the sleet, he added, more gently than he had said anything to anyone that whole hard season, "It is not your fear to carry, lad. Stand your watch and go home to your mother when it's done, and leave the rest to older backs than yours."

The boy said nothing more that night, but he told it afterward, many years on, as the truest thing he had ever heard said of that whole strange winter, and the only comfort anyone had offered him in the whole of it.

III

Of the Doors Reopened

One morning in early Siolach, with the frost still on the ground and the year's first green not yet showing along the ditches, a single rider came down to Àth shean with no leaf at all, only a word for Tormod's own ear: that the grain might move, at such a measure as the council had fixed, and that the reeve of the granaries was thanked for his care of them. Nothing was said of how the matter had been settled, nor by whom, nor why that morning and not another; the rider, when Tormod asked him plainly, said only that he had been sent to say what he had said, and no more, and Tormod, who had asked harder men harder questions all that winter and got no better answer from any of them, let it go.

He took the bar down from the store-house doors with his own hands, though it was work for two men, and stood in the open doorway a while in the cold with the granary dark and full behind him, before he called the watch off and told the waiting carters they might load. The rider who had brought the word lingered long enough to take a cup of small ale against the cold of the road ahead

of him, and Tormod, pouring it himself, asked once more, plainly, whether the rider truly knew no more of the matter than he had said.

"I know less than you think, reeve," the rider told him, not unkindly. "I was given a word to carry and a road to carry it on. What was said at An Talla Dearg¹ to make that word, I was not in the room to hear, and if I had been, I doubt I'd have understood the half of it. They argue there the way rivers argue with their own banks, all winter, and then one morning the ice goes out and no one can say which thaw broke it." He finished the ale, thanked the reeve for it, and rode on north before the light failed, and Tormod never afterward learned so much as his name.

He felt, standing in the doorway once the rider had gone, less like a man vindicated than like a man who has held his breath a long time and is only now allowed to let it out, with no one troubling to say whether he had held it for anything at all.

No one asked him back to his office that spring. A new reeve was named to the granaries at Àth shean before the barley was in the ground again, a younger man with better friends at the capital, and Tormod mac Coinnich, who had kept the stores of the south shires for eleven years and shut them for the better part of one hard winter on his own reckoning and no one else's, packed what was his own out of the reeve's house and walked home to the farm his father had left him, a morning's walk south of the town. He worked it the rest of his life without complaint, and without once, so far as anyone who knew him ever heard, saying a word against the council that had left him to stand a winter's watch alone and never told him why.

IV

Of the Forty-One Barges

The barges went down that spring the way grain had always gone from the south shires to the capital, on the broad slow water of Abhainn dhomhain, low in the water and heavy, poled and towed by turns where the current ran against them, each one carrying what forty households might not eat in a sea-

1. the red hall, the reeve's hall at Cathair dhearg

son laid up against the crossing of households that would eat none of it on the island again.

On Drochaid Cathair dhearg¹ a woman named Mairead nic Iain kept the tally that spring, as she had kept it most springs of her working life, cutting a notch in a fresh hazel stick for every laden hull that passed beneath the bridge going down toward the sea. It was not thought a hard office, nor a great one; she sat on the parapet with her legs over the water in fine weather and under the lee of the bridge-house in foul, and she had counted salmon boats and wool barges and the ordinary traffic of the river for so long that the counting had long since become a kind of restfulness to her, a thing her hands did while the rest of her watched the water and the gulls and, that spring, the strange low broad-bellied barges that she had never counted before and would, she suspected, though no one had told her so outright, never count again.

She began her tally on the day the first barge came down, low and slow under the bridge's middle arch with two men poling and a third asleep in the bow, and she kept it faithfully as the days went on and the barges followed one another down, sometimes three in a morning and sometimes none for two days together, until the season's grain had all passed under her and gone on, by the coast road of the water, past Ros àrsaidh and up the Abhainn naomh to the waiting quay at Seann Skell.

The bridge-keeper, an old man who had held the toll there longer than Mairead had been alive, came out to lean on the parapet beside her most mornings that the barges ran, and between them they made a kind of game of guessing, before each one came under the arch, whether it would ride high or low, empty going up or full going down; and it was he who first remarked, watching a barge pass with its gunwales scarcely a hand's breadth above the water, that he had never in all his years on that bridge seen so much grain moved south to north in a single season, not even in the famine years when the capital had gone hungry and the shires had sent everything they could spare. Mairead said nothing to that, only cut her notch and watched the water settle again behind the barge's wake, because it was not her place to have an opinion on what the grain was for, only to count it as it passed.

When the last of them had gone by, a week and more after the first, she cut her final notch and counted the sticks in her lap, and made the whole of that spring's grain, from the shires south of the mountain to the fleet's own stores, forty-one

1. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

barges, and told the bridge-keeper so, and he wrote it in his own book, and neither of them thought there was anything more to be done with the number than to write it down.

She never learned, then or after, what had been argued over the grain at An Talla Dearg² that winter, nor why the doors at Àth shean had stood barred so long, nor what word had opened them again; she only knew, from where she sat on the bridge parapet with her sticks in her lap, that the river had carried what it was asked to carry, and that forty-one was the number of times it had done so that spring, and she set that down as the whole of her own part in the matter, which, in her own reckoning, it was.

V

Of the Roll at Seann Skell

At Seann Skell, that same season, in the moon of Pailteach when the barley was in and the last of the barges from the south had not yet reached the quay, Calum mac Nèill cut a household onto Rolla nan Deònach¹ that he had feared, since the day the boards were first opened, to see standing before his own board, and had put off imagining, in his own heart, for as long as he could manage it.

It was his own daughter's household: Mairead nic Chaluim, a grown woman of five-and-twenty, born ten years after the boards were first hung on their pegs, and her husband Dùghall mac Iain, a fisher of Inis àrsaidh whom she had married against no one's wishes and with everyone's blessing, six years gone. They came to the harbour-house together on an ordinary morning, no different in their dress or their manner from any of the hundreds of households that had stood before Calum's board in the years since the roll was opened, and Mairead gave her own name and her husband's and the names of their two children in the same clear voice she had used, as a small girl, to recite her letters for him at their own hearth, and watched his knife the whole time it was in the wood, the way every one of them watched it, as though the cutting were the thing that made the going real and not the choosing that had come before it.

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

1. the roll of the willing

She had brought the two children with her, a boy of four holding fast to his father's hand and a girl not yet two on Dùghall's hip, and it was the boy, more than the parents, who watched the whole business with the frank interest of a child who has been told a thing is important and means to see for himself what makes it so; he asked, in the small silence after his mother had given the last of the names, whether the boat they would sail on had a name of its own, and Dùghall told him, low, that it did, though he did not yet know which of the hulls at the quay would be theirs, and the boy seemed satisfied with that, as children often are with the promise of a thing rather than the having of it.

Calum's son Dòmhnall, who kept the boards with him still and had grown from the quiet boy who had once asked his father to close them into a quieter man who no longer asked, stood at his father's shoulder that morning and said nothing at all, and it was Dòmhnall, not Calum, who reached first for the cup of ale that was kept, by then, for every household's first entering, and set it in his sister's hands. He held her a moment by the shoulders after, the way a brother will who does not trust himself to say anything worth the saying, and let her go again, and it was the only part of that whole ordinary morning that anyone standing in the harbour-house doorway thought worth remembering afterward.

Calum wrote the household in the same hand he had used for every entry before it, steady, without a tremor that any watcher could have named, and it was only after his daughter and her husband had gone back out onto the quay, and the harbour-house stood empty a moment in the ordinary business of the morning, that his own hand, laid flat on the board where the ink was drying, was seen by no one but himself to be shaking, and he stood a while with it so, and then went on to the next entry waiting in the doorway, because the boards, as he had told his wife long before, needed their keeper, whatever the keeper himself might be feeling that morning, and the queue at the door did not know, and had no cause to know, whose name had just gone onto the wood.

VI

Of the Hulls at the Quay

By the spring of LE 38 the fleet lay complete at Seann Skell, the whole length of the new stone quay taken up with hulls that had not existed, any of them, when the first crew of Cuan shean had walked up the river road

with its tale of a far shore. Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ at Taigh na Fèithe², when its clerk came down that season to make the reckoning, wrote the number as nineteen; a later hand, in the margin of the same leaf, made it twenty-one; and no one, then or since, has ever been able to say with any certainty which of the two counts was the truer, or why they should have differed at all over a fleet lying, the whole of it, in plain sight against one short stretch of stone.

Calum's grandson Niall, Dòmhnall's boy, was nine years old that spring and had grown up entirely within sight of the roll and the boards and the quay his grandfather kept, so that the fleet, to him, was less a wonder than a fact of the world he had been born into, the way the river was a fact, or the harbour-house. He had a habit, that spring, of running the whole new length of the quay after his lessons were done, from the old stones at the east end where the fish-boats still lay to the new dressed stone at the west where the deep hulls rode, touching each hull's timbers with his hand as he passed as though he were counting them the way his grandfather counted households onto a board, though no one had asked him to count anything at all.

He never once, that spring or the next, brought the count out even. It would begin well enough at the east end, one, two, three, murmuring the numbers under his breath the way Dòmhnall had taught him his letters, and somewhere past the tenth hull, or the twelfth, a gull would go up off a mast, or a rope-maker would call across to a wright he knew, or the light on the water would catch his eye and hold it a moment longer than he meant, and when he came to himself again he no longer knew whether he stood at the fourteenth hull or the fifteenth, and had, every time, to choose whether to go back to the beginning and start the whole count fresh, or to let it go and simply finish his run to the western stones and stand there a while, breathing hard, looking out at the whole fleet riding together against the new quay in the spring light, with the losing of the count already forgotten in the plain pleasure of having run the length of it.

Once, near the end of that spring, one of the older wrights caught him at it, hand flat on a strake, lips moving, and asked him, not unkindly, what number he had reached. Niall told him honestly that he did not know, that he had lost it somewhere past the pitch-sheds, and the wright laughed, a short surprised bark of a laugh, and said that he himself, who had helped lay four of the hulls with his own hands, could not have told the boy the true count either, not to save his life,

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

and that Niall was in good company in his not knowing. The boy turned that over a good while afterward, walking home along the quay in the last of the light, and found, somewhat to his own surprise, that it pleased him more than a straight answer would have done, though he could not then, and never later, have said quite why.

His grandfather, watching him from the harbour-house door on one such evening, said nothing of it to the boy, then or later; but it is told that Calum remarked once, to his wife Seonag, that there might yet come a year when no one on the island could say for certain how many hulls had lain at that quay, and that he did not know, himself, whether that was a thing to be sorry for.

CHAPTER NINE

Of the Night of Lamps and the Sunwise Turn

LE 39 – 40

*Dòrlach airson an teallaich ùir, is an seann teallach fhatbast blàth. A
handful for the new hearth, and the old hearth still warm.*

I

Of the Queen on the New Stones

Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill came down to Seann Skell in the moon of Siolach, when the barley stood green and short in the strips above the river and the last of the fleet's rigging was going up on hulls that had, the year before, been only frames on the strand. She came with a small household, six riders and a groom and no more, and she had told no one at the harbour-house to expect her; the first word Niall mac Dhòmhnaill's father had of the queen's coming was the queen herself, standing in the door of Taigh a' Chalaidh¹ out of the rain with her hood still up, asking whether the harbour scribe was within.

He was. Calum mac Nèill had kept the boards of Seann Skell for thirty-nine years by then and had stood before three kings and one queen at An Talla Dearg² in that time, and he still, his son said afterward, went white to the lips when he saw who stood in his own doorway. He gave her the chair kept for the reeve when the reeve came to check the rolls, and stood himself, and she let him stand, because there are things a queen does not trouble to change in another man's house.

1. the harbour-house

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

She did not ask to see the boards. She had had copies of the roll sent to Cathair dhearg every season since the boards were first hung, and she knew, better than most men at An Talla Dearg, how many households had gone onto them and how many had come off again; there was nothing in the wood that the copies had not already told her. What she asked for, when Calum had got his voice back enough to ask what she wanted of him, was to walk the quay.

He walked with her himself, a half-step behind and to the side as the custom of the harbour-house had it, past the fish-boats at the old stones and out along the new dressed work the masons had laid nine years before, and the hulls of the fleet lay against it the whole length of the walk, nineteen or one-and-twenty of them, riding a little high yet for want of their full stores, their new-cut timbers pale against the darker, salted wood of the coasters moored further down. Beathag stopped at no one hull longer than another. She walked the length of the quay once, from the fish-stones to the western end where the water ran deep enough at low tide for the largest of the keels, and stood there a while with the wind off the sea working at the edge of her hood, and said, to no one in particular, that she had not thought, when the first crew came up the river road with its tale of a far shore, that she would live to see so many hulls built on an island that had never built one.

Calum said nothing to that. It did not seem a thing that wanted an answer.

She found her sister on the way back, though whether she had come down to Seann Skell to find her, or had only known she would, Calum could not afterward have said, and did not ask. Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill was on the strand below the new quay with a coil of rope over one shoulder, helping a rope-maker's boy stow gear against the weather that was coming in off the water, her sleeves rolled and her hands as roughened, by then, as any fisherwoman's on that shore; and when she straightened and saw who stood above her on the stones, she came up the slip at her own pace, neither hurried nor slowed, wiping her hands on her skirt as she came, the way she might have come up to greet any traveller who had asked for her at the harbour-house door.

The two sisters stood together on the new stones a little apart from Calum and from the queen's household, and what passed between them there, no one who stood by ever told, not Calum, who did not go close enough to hear, and not the two riders who stood at the queen's back with their eyes on the weather and not on the queen. It was not a long conversation. Leabhar a' Chùrain³, when it

comes at last to speak of that day at all, gives it in one line: that the queen came to Seann Skell in Sìolach and was seen upon the quay with her sister, and went home again before the sailing, as her word of long before had bound her to do.

It is told, though not in *Leabhar a' Chùrain*, that Beathag put her hand once to the back of Mòrag's head, the way an elder sister will to a younger one who has not stopped being the younger one no matter how many years or how many miles come between them, and that Mòrag let her, and that neither of them wept where Calum or the riders could see it, whatever was done with the weeping once the queen's household had ridden back up the river road and Mòrag had gone down again to the rope-maker's boy and the gear that wanted stowing before the weather came in.

Beathag did not stay the night. She had told Calum, on the walk out to the western stones, that she would not be at Seann Skell for the sailing, whenever it came, because a queen who has sworn to send no one over and keep no one back has no business standing on a quay to watch her own sister taken from her by a promise she made herself; and Calum, who had thought a great many things about the queen's word in the thirty-seven years he had kept it written above his own door, thought that the truest thing he had yet heard said of it. She rode north before dusk, in the rain that had held off all day and came down at last as her household cleared the last houses of the town, and Niall, who was ten that spring and had watched the whole of the queen's visit from the harbour-house step with his grandfather's hand on his shoulder to keep him from getting underfoot, remembered afterward chiefly the sound of the horses going away up the river road in the wet, and his grandfather standing a long while in the doorway after the sound had gone, looking at nothing that Niall could see.

II

Of the Lamps on the Sills

The fleet's full stores went aboard through the whole of Bearnach, the gap-moon between the last of the winter's keep and the first green of the year, when the granaries stand at their lowest and every household on the island counts what is left in the barrel and reckons how far it will stretch. Niall was elev-

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

en that Bearnach, and had grown, in the two years since he had run the quay counting hulls and losing the count, into the age at which a harbour scribe's grandson is given work rather than only allowed to watch it; and the work his grandfather gave him, on the last evening before the sailing, was a hazel stick shaved clean along one face and a small knife with a worn horn handle, and the instruction, given once and not repeated, that he was to sit on the wall of the west quay when the fleet went out in the morning and cut one notch for each hull as she passed, and no talking.

He had heard, by then, every telling there was to hear of why the count mattered and why no one trusted a single teller's word for it alone; the harbour-house kept three tallies of everything that passed its boards, his grandfather had told him more than once, because two men's memories never agreed and a third was needed to settle which of the first two lied, though neither, as often as not, had lied at all, only remembered differently. Niall took the stick and the knife with both hands, the way he had been shown to take anything his grandfather gave him that was not a toy, and did not ask what would be done with his tally once it was cut, because a boy of eleven who has grown up in a harbour-house learns early that some questions get no answer and are better not asked twice.

That evening, as the light went, every house along the Seann Skell waterfront set a lamp on its sill, and kept it burning. No one had told them to. It began, so far as anyone could afterward say, at the fish-stones end of the quay, where a widow whose only son was going out with the fleet lit her own lamp early against the dusk and left it burning past her own bedtime because she had nothing else that evening to do with her hands; and it went on from house to house along the strand the way a rumour goes, without any one person carrying it, until the whole curve of the harbour was pricked with light from the fish-stones to the new western stones where the fleet lay. Niall's grandmother Seonag lit their own lamp at the harbour-house window without being asked, and when Niall asked her why, she said only that a lit window was a thing a body understood without being told what it meant, and that some things were better left at that.

Niall went down to the quay before the lamps had all been lit, because he could not sit still in the house that evening and his grandfather, for once, did not tell him to. The hulls lay close against the new stones, so close in places that a boy could have dropped a pebble onto a deck without much trying, and the whole length of the quay smelled of pitch and wet hemp and, under both, the tallowy reek of the sheep's fat the crews had been rubbing into the blocks and running-

gear all that week against the salt to come. Somewhere aboard one of the nearer hulls a woman was singing under her breath, some working song with no words Niall could catch, and a man's voice told her, not unkindly, to hush, and she did, and started again a little later when he had gone forward.

He found his aunt Mairead's household aboard the third hull from the western end, a low broad-waisted ship named, so far as anyone had told him, for nothing he had heard, her deck crowded with barrels lashed down under oiled hide and her people moving about the business of a last evening with the particular quiet haste of those who mean to be done with the loading before dark. Mairead saw him on the quay wall and came to the rail, her sleeves rolled to the elbow and a smear of pitch on one wrist, and asked him, in the ordinary voice she had always used to him, whether his grandfather had given him a proper task for the morning or meant to leave him idle on the wall like any other spectator.

He showed her the stick and the knife. She looked at them a moment longer than the showing needed, and then she said that he was to cut a good deep notch for her hull when it came, whichever number it fell at, so that whatever else the tally lost or kept, hers would be cut clean; and she reached down over the rail and put her hand once, briefly, on the top of his head, the same gesture, though he had no way of knowing it, that the queen had used on her sister on the new stones two moons before. Then her husband Dùghall called her back to the lashings, and she went, and Niall sat on the wall a while longer with the stick across his knees, watching the lamps come out along the whole curve of the strand behind him, one and then another, until there was no dark house left between the fish-stones and the western end.

His grandfather found him there past full dark and did not send him home. Calum stood beside him a long while without speaking, his eyes on the lit windows behind the hulls rather than on the hulls themselves, and it was Calum, in the end, who spoke first, saying only that he had kept the boards of that harbour for near forty years and had thought, when the first name went onto them, that he understood what the roll would cost the town; and that he had been wrong about the size of it, though not, he thought, about the shape. Niall did not understand all of what his grandfather meant by that, and did not ask him to explain it, because the night did not seem to want explaining. They sat together on the wall until the cold drove them in, and behind them, the whole length of the waterfront, the lamps burned on into a night that no one along that shore, by every later telling, slept much through at all.

III

Of Mòrag's Last Walk

Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill walked the waterfront of Seann Skell alone that same night, from the fish-stones to the western stones and back again, twice over, though no one had asked her to and she told no one she meant to do it.

She had spent the whole of that Bearnach at the harbour, seeing her own household's gear stowed and her husband Aonghas's and, in the last days, the gear of her grown daughter Beathag Òg's household besides, for Beathag Òg had married into a Ros bheag family two years before and had brought her own name onto the roll within the year, mother following daughter as often, by then, as daughter followed mother; and Mòrag had not, in all that season's labour, found an hour to walk the quay simply to look at it, the way a person looks at a room she means to leave the following morning and will not see again.

She did it that night instead. The lamps were lit along every sill by the time she started out, and she walked past them slowly, naming the households to herself as she passed each house. She needed no reminding who lived where; it seemed to her, she told her husband afterward, a thing worth doing once before she could no longer do it: to walk a street she had known the whole of her life and put a name to every lit window on it, as though the naming were itself a kind of leave-taking that the sailing in the morning would not have room for.

She found Catriona nic Iain on the deck of An Ròn Glas¹, the hull that would carry Mòrag's own household and Aonghas's and a dozen more of Cuan shean's people besides, coiling a line at the foot of the steering oar with the particular unhurried care of a pilot who has done the same work a hundred times and means to do it once more, correctly, before it matters. Catriona had been made pilot of that hull at Seann Skell the year before, on the quay, the same evening she had first named Reul na Stiùire² to Mòrag by its Dia-thìris name, and the two women had not, in the year since, had much cause to speak beyond the ordinary business of a hull being fitted for sea; but Catriona straightened when she saw who stood at the rail, and said, without being asked, that the oar answered well and the ship rode true in the little chop of the harbour, and that whatever else the morning brought, it would not bring a fault in the steering.

1. the Grey Seal, the hull that carried Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill's household

2. the steering star

Mòrag thanked her for it, and stood a while at the rail looking down the length of the deck where her own people's gear lay lashed among Cuan shean's, and asked Catriona, once, whether she was afraid. Catriona thought about it before she answered, which Mòrag afterward said she had liked in her more than any answer the girl might have given straight off, and said at last that she was less afraid of the sea than of the not-knowing what lay past it, and that she supposed those were, in the end, close to the same fear worn two different ways. Mòrag said she thought that was true of most of them on the roll, and left it there, because there did not seem, that night, to be a better thing to say about it than the plain truth already said.

It was on her second pass along the strand, going back toward the fish-stones in the last of the evening light, that she saw the man standing by his cart at the head of the slip below the harbour-house, a tall man in a carter's coat with a horse still in the traces beside him, neither loading the cart nor unloading it, only standing, the way a man stands who has come to a place to decide something and has not yet decided it. She knew him, a little, the way a household of the roll comes to know the carters who bring goods down to the quay for those still packing; his name, she had heard once and did not forget, was Fionnlagh, and he had brought loads down to the western stones three times that season without, so far as she had ever seen, putting his own name to the boards.

She did not go to him, and he did not come to her, only passed within a stone's throw of where he stood, close enough to see that his cart was empty, and that he watched the lamps along the strand with the same stillness with which she had, herself, watched Catriona's hands on the coiled line. Something in the set of him, she said to her husband that same night, told her plainly enough that here was a man who had already made his choice and stood at his cart only to be certain of it one more night before the boards closed for good. It did not seem, then, a thing a stranger should interrupt, so she walked on without speaking to him; and in the morning, when the fleet went out, his cart stood in the same place, and he stood beside it still, and did not go aboard any hull that passed.

Mòrag went back to the house she had taken near the fish-stones as the last of the light went, and sat up late with Aonghas over a fire that neither of them let go out, and said little of what she had seen or felt on her two walks along the strand, because there did not seem, between two people who had already said everything that could be said about the morning to come, to be much profit in saying it twice.

IV

Of the Sunwise Turn

On 19 an Giblean, LE 40, in the grey before sunrise, with the lamps along the waterfront burned low but none of them yet gone entirely out, the fleet of the willing went out from Seann Skell.

Niall was on the wall of the west quay by the time the first grey showed over the eastern hills, the stick and the knife in his lap and his knees drawn up under his chin against the cold that comes off water before the sun is properly up. The town had gathered along the whole length of the strand behind him, more people than he had ever seen crowded onto that stretch of stone at once, and yet, he remembered afterward, it was a quiet crowd, quieter than a market day or a feast day, as though everyone on the waterfront had agreed, without a word passed between them, that there was nothing that morning that wanted shouting about.

The first hull came off the quay a little before the sun cleared the hills, warped out from the stones on lines that a dozen hands ashore paid out together, and swung her bow round, away from the straight run down the river toward the open water, toward the head of the pool where the Abhainn naomh widened below the town before narrowing again to the sea. Niall had heard his grandfather say, more than once in that last week, that the fleet meant to go out sunwise round the pool for the luck of it, the way a man walks sunwise round a well he means to drink from, or round a house new-built before he sleeps his first night in it; but seeing it done was another thing from hearing it told, and he watched the first hull swing wide and slow with something closer to wonder than to the grief he had half expected of himself.

He cut his first notch as she passed him, close enough along the quay wall that he could have named half her crew by sight, and did not look long at any one face among them, because his grandfather had told him, the one instruction given twice that whole week, that a counter who looks too long at faces loses his count, and Niall meant, that morning above every other, not to lose it.

An Dara Fhaoileag¹ came after her before the first had gone half round the pool, and the third close on the second, until the whole fleet was strung out across the water in a long curving line, nineteen hulls or one-and-twenty, going round the pool sunwise in the grey light with the town silent along the strand behind

1. the second gull, the hull built to the changed keel pattern after the loss of An Fhaoileag

them. Niall cut his notches steadily, one, two, three, murmuring the count under his breath the way his grandfather murmured a leaf's entries while he wrote them, and did not let a gull's cry or a call across the water turn his eyes from the stick and the passing hulls the way it had turned them, two years before, when he had tried the same count for no better reason than his own idleness. He knew An Ròn Glas² when she came, by the grey seal cut into her stem-post, and cut her notch no deeper and no shallower than any other's, though he looked, for the length of one breath only, at the woman standing at the steering oar with her hand steady on the loom, and thought that he had never before seen anyone look so entirely at ease doing a thing he himself could not have begun to do.

His aunt Mairead's hull went by third from the last, low in the water with her full stores aboard, and Mairead stood at the rail with Dùghall and their two children and lifted a hand to the quay, not waving exactly, only holding it up a moment the way a person does to be seen rather than to signal anything in particular, and Niall, remembering what she had told him the evening before, cut her notch deep, deeper than his grandfather's instruction strictly wanted, and did not think, that morning, that anyone would ever come to check the depth of one notch against another on a stick kept, in the end, for no purpose he was ever told.

At the foot of the pool the fleet straightened out of its long curve and turned down the Abhainn naomh toward the sea, hull after hull falling into the line, and it was there, his grandfather told him afterward, that the harbour-house's own written account of the sailing came to its end, because a scribe can write only what passes before his door, and the river beyond the pool's foot passed beyond any door Seann Skell had. Niall kept his count a while longer, watching the sterns go small down the river between the willows, and could not, in the end, have said with any certainty whether his own stick agreed with his grandfather's or with the tallies any other counter along that strand was cutting that same morning; only that he had cut one notch for every hull he had seen pass, and had not once, that morning, let his eyes wander long enough to lose the number.

When the last hull had gone from sight round the first bend below the pool, the crowd along the strand stood a while longer looking at the empty water before it began to disperse, and it was some little time before anyone on that whole long strand moved to go home. The harbour songs, sung on later anniversaries of that morning by people who had not themselves stood on the quay to see it, tell that a

2. the Grey Seal, the hull that carried Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill's household

mist came down on the water behind the last hull as she cleared the river's mouth, and did not lift again until she was gone from any watcher's sight; whether that mist stood there in truth, or only in the songs that were made afterward to close the telling properly, no one who was on the quay that morning ever afterward could say for certain, Niall least of all, who had kept his eyes on his stick and not on the weather.

He put the stick inside his shirt, against his skin, before he climbed down off the wall, though no one had told him to keep it rather than hand it over, and no one, that day or afterward, ever asked him for it back.

V

Of the Boundary Ditch

At Cathair dhearg that same morning, in An Talla Dearg¹ above the river, Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill sat the ordinary court of the day and heard, among the first matters brought before her, a dispute between two farmers of the shire nearest the capital over a ditch that marked the boundary of their two holdings, which one of them held had shifted its course in the spring floods and the other held had not shifted at all, only been dug a little wider by a neighbour with more land than sense.

It was not a great matter, and the court did not treat it as one. The queen heard both farmers out in turn, asked the elder of the two clerks present what the boundary stones of that parish showed, and gave her ruling before noon, that the ditch should be walked and marked again by the parish reeve within the month and the stones set where the walking found them, whatever either farmer might say of floods or neighbours; and the two men, neither wholly satisfied nor wholly aggrieved, thanked her in the manner the court required and went back out to the yard to find their horses.

No rider had yet come up the river road from Seann Skell that morning, nor would one come for two days more, for the distance was four-and-twenty miles and no rider rode it faster than a long day's going even with the best of horses under him; and so the queen who had stood on the new stones at Seann Skell in Siolach and taken her leave of her own sister without ceremony, as her own word

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

had bound her to do, sat that morning in her own hall and heard a boundary dispute between two farmers she had never met and was not likely to meet again, and gave it the same weight and the same care she had given every such dispute brought before her in all the years of her reign, because a queen who has sworn to send no one over and keep no one back has, on the morning her own sister goes over, no other work to do that the day will let her leave undone.

It is told that she asked, once, near the end of that day's court, whether any word had come up from the coast, and that the clerk at her elbow, who knew as well as she did that no word could yet have come, told her only that none had, and that she said nothing further about it, and turned to the next matter on the roll.

That evening the harbour scribe of Seann Skell walked the length of the west quay alone, from the fish-stones to the new western stones where the fleet had lain the night before, and found the berths standing empty along their whole length for the first time since the masons finished them, the water lapping at stones that had known nothing but hulls; and it is Calum's own words, given to his son Dòmhnall that same night and kept afterward in no book but the family's own memory, that a harbour is a strange thing to walk empty, being built for nothing else but to be full, and that he did not think, walking it that evening, that he would ever again see it as anything but a place where something was missing, whatever ships came afterward to lie against those same stones.

OF THE COUNT FROM THE TURN

LE 40 – 46

I

Of the Entry a Day Too Late

Leabhar a' Chùraim of Taigh na Fèithe¹ above Muileann dhearg was kept in a hand steadier than most, and the hand that kept it in the autumn after An Diosal² belonged to a clerk of six-and-twenty named Donnchadh mac Thormoid, who had been given the leaf and the ink-horn ten winters before by a master who was dead within the year of the giving, and who had gone on keeping them since because no one above him had troubled to say he should stop.

He was not the man who had counted the hulls; that had been a boy on a harbour wall sixty miles off, with a hazel stick and a knife, and Donnchadh had never met him and never would. What came to Donnchadh, in the ordinary course of Taigh na Fèithe's business, was a leaf carried up from Seann Skell by a rider who did not know, or did not say, why the leaf had been so long on the road, and it was Donnchadh's office, not his curiosity, to enter what the leaf told him into the great book of the custody and ask no more of it than the book required.

The leaf told him that the fleet of the willing had gone once round the river pool at Seann Skell sunwise, as a man walks round a well for luck, and had gone down the river after and out past the north cape, and that this had happened, by the harbour scribe's own hand, on a day the leaf gave plainly enough. What

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

troubled Donnchadh, turning the leaf over by the light of Taigh na Fèithe's lamp with his master's old rule laid open beside it, the rule by which every entry in Le-abhar a' Chùrain³ was dated against the feasts of the turning year, was that the day the leaf gave fell after Samhain, and by every account he had ever had of the sailing, of the last stores laid in and the last measures sealed and the three tellings that had first brought word of a far shore to the queen's own board, the fleet had gone out long before that, in the spring, in the gap-moon of Bearnach, with the barley scarcely green.

He was a careful clerk, and carefulness in a clerk is a kind of honesty that asks no questions it cannot answer. Turning the leaf a second time and a third, holding it near enough the lamp that the pitch-smoke stung his eyes, he found in it nothing that explained the gap between the day the fleet had gone and the day Taigh na Fèithe was told of the going: no word of a delay on the road, no note that the first leaf had been lost and this one written after in its place, no apology from the harbour scribe for a silence of half a year that no one at Seann Skell, so far as the leaf showed, had thought worth accounting for. A rider might have been sent back down to Seann Skell to ask. None was. It was, he told himself, setting the ink-horn to the page, a clerk's business only to copy the leaf faithfully into the great book, gap and all, and let the book stand as the book had been given to him.

So he wrote it: the turn of the fleet, entered under the day a full turning of the moon and more after the feast of Samhain, though every other account he had of the matter set the sailing in the spring. He signed the entry with his own mark, as his master had taught him, closed the book, and banked Taigh na Fèithe's night fire himself, because the boy whose office that was had gone home early with a fever, and thought no more of the gap that night than a man thinks of a stone he has stepped around a hundred times on a familiar road.

II

Of the Years of the Diosal

Four years passed at Taigh na Fèithe¹ much as the four before them had, in the reckoning of hearths and the sealing of measures and the slow corres-

³. the custody-book of the vein-house

¹. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

pondence, letter and counter-letter, between the custodians of Muileann dhearg and An Talla Dearg² at Cathair dhearg over matters that the histories of great houses call small and the households they touch call everything: a gallery's roof timbered too thin, a widow's right to her dead husband's handful, a boundary stone moved a foot by a neighbour's ox-sled and moved back by night.

Donnchadh kept Leabhar a' Chùraim³ through all of it, and kept also, by then, a second book that was his own and answered to no one, a plain thing of scraped hide bound with cord, in which he set down, for his own convenience and no other man's, the sums and the debts and the running totals that the great book's formal hand had no room for. It was in this private book, in the fourth year after the turn, that he first found himself wanting a single fixed point from which to count forward, because the island's own way of dating things, by the reign of a queen or the year of a feast or the season a gallery was opened, served Leabhar a' Chùraim well enough but served his own sums badly, requiring him each time to look up how many years a given reign or a given gallery had already run before he could set two figures against each other at all.

He chose the turn. It was, of all the fixed points he had to hand, the nearest and the strangest, a day already written into the great book under a date that fit no other account of it, and it had at least the merit, in a clerk's eye, of being an ending rather than a beginning, a single day after which nothing further needed to be asked of the fleet, whatever might yet be asked of everything else. He began to write, in the margins of his own book only, the year of An Diosal⁴ beside the year of the reign, first for the year then running, which he called the fourth of An Diosal, and then, working backward with a patience that cost him the better part of an evening, for every year in his own book since the turn, so that the private ledger of a clerk of thirty came, without ceremony and without anyone above him ever asking that it should, to be the first place on the island where the years were counted from an absence rather than a reign.

He told no one. It did not occur to him that the habit was worth telling, being no more, in his own reckoning, than a clerk's shortcut for his own sums, and if any other hand at Taigh na Fèithe noticed the odd figures in the margin of his private book, no one troubled to ask him what they meant, and he was not a man who offered explanations that were not asked for.

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

4. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

There was, besides, a plainer reason he kept the habit to his own book and no further, one he would not himself have put into words if asked, though it sat behind the choosing all the same: a reckoning that began from the turn was a reckoning that began from a loss, and Donnchadh, who measured hearths and galleries for his trade and had learned early that a measure is only as good as the men willing to trust it, did not know whether the custodians above him, who had lost sons and daughters and whole households to that same turn, would thank a junior clerk for fixing their years to it in a book that anyone might read. His own book no one read but himself. He kept the count there, and there it stayed, a private arithmetic run alongside Taigh na Fèithe's public one, the two agreeing in every figure that mattered and differing only in the one thing that, to Donnchadh's mind, mattered to no one but him: from what day the years were said to run.

He found, working the count backward and then forward again through that fourth year, a small and useless satisfaction in the plainness of it, that a thing so large as the going of a fifth of the coal-right's households could be made to sit, in a clerk's own ledger, beside the price of a barrel of sealed measures or the wages owed a mason for a season's work on Taigh na Fèithe wall, one figure among many, asking no more of the page than any other figure did. It was not, he would have said if pressed, that the going meant no more to him than a barrel's price; only that a ledger has no way of saying which of its figures broke a household and which merely counted one, and he had long since made his peace with a trade that could not tell the difference.

III

Of the Tidings that Reached Seann Skell

That same year, word came to Seann Skell of the fleet, though by what road it came, or in whose mouth, or aboard what small boat put in at the old stones below the harbour-house, no one who was there that autumn ever afterward agreed well enough to say.

It fell to Calum mac Nèill to receive it, as it fell to him to receive most things that came to the harbour-house wearing the shape of news, and he was an older man by then than he had been when the boards were first hung on their pegs, grey through the beard and slower in the hand, though his hand, when it came to the actual forming of letters, had not yet begun to fail him. His wife Seonag had

taken to saying, of late, that he sat too long over the boards for a man his age, and he had taken to answering, when he answered at all, that the boards had had a keeper his whole life and would want one after him, and that there was no sense training a new keeper's hand while the old one still held its line.

The word, when it came, came as broken speech rather than as a leaf already written, a telling passed from a boat that did not stay to be questioned to a fisherman of the strand who could not himself say afterward which of the boat's crew had spoken or in what tongue, and it fell then to Calum to set that broken speech down in the harbour-house's own hand before it broke further in the passing. He did it that same evening, by lamplight, with his hand, his wife noted afterward, less steady over that leaf than she had seen it over any other in forty years of watching him write, so that the letters toward the leaf's foot ran smaller and closer together than at its head, as a man's hand will when he is hurrying to set down what he fears he may otherwise lose before he has it whole.

What the telling gave him, so far as his shaking hand caught it, was this: that the fleet, or some good part of it, had come at last to a shore across the open water, and that it had come to two shores and not to one, two separate landfalls reached by hulls that had not, it seemed, all held together the whole of the crossing, though whether storm had parted them, or purpose, or some quarrel among the crews that the telling did not touch, Calum's leaf did not say and Calum did not pretend to know. The telling ran on a little further, naming, or seeming to name, some particular of the second shore that might have settled the matter one way or another, and it was there, at the leaf's very foot, in the smallest and most hurried of all the hand's letters, that it simply stopped, with no mark of an ending, as though the teller had been called away, or the listener's patience had failed, or the leaf had been torn and the torn part lost before ever it reached the boards.

Calum read it over three times before he judged it fit to send on, and found, each time, that it told him no more at the third reading than it had at the first, and that the not-knowing sat worse with him than a plain bad tidings would have done, because a plain bad tidings, however hard, is a thing a man can grieve and be done with, and this was a thing that asked to be carried unfinished a good while longer, by him and by whoever received it after him.

He did not sleep well that night, and Seonag, waking once to find him sitting up with the lamp still lit and the leaf still before him though he had long since finished the copying of it, asked him plainly what more there was in it that he had not yet set down. There was nothing more in it, he told her; that was the whole

trouble with the thing, that it had stopped where it had stopped and left him with no more right than any fisherman on the strand to guess at what lay beyond its torn foot, and yet he was the one whose hand had carried it, and a hand that carries a tale unfinished, he said, feels the weight of the unfinished part as much as of the part it actually holds. Seonag, who had kept house with a harbour scribe long enough to know when an answer was the whole of what she would get, blew out the lamp herself when he would not, and left him to sit a while longer in the dark with the leaf under his hand, which he did, by his own account afterward, until the sky over the water had begun to grey.

In the morning he read the leaf once more before he sealed it for the rider, and it was then, turning it over a last time by the grey early light, that he noticed what he had been too tired the night before to mark: that the hand which had first spoken the broken tale to the fisherman on the strand had used, in the one clear phrase Calum's own leaf preserved whole, a word for the second shore that the island's own tongue did not commonly use of any coast it had seen with its own eyes, a word more often kept for a shore known only by report. He set that observation nowhere in the copy he sent on, judging it, on reflection, too slight a thread to hang a further guess from, and it went with him, unwritten, to his grave some fourteen years after, one more thing the harbour-house's own boards would never show.

IV

Of the Hearths of Inis àrsaidh

The telling did not stay long behind the harbour-house door. It went out, as such things do in a fishing town smaller than its harbour, along the strand and up the lanes before the ink on Calum's leaf was fully dry, carried by the fisherman who had first heard it and by every mouth that heard it from him after, each mouth losing a little of the whole and adding a little of its own, until the tale that reached the hearths of Inis àrsaidh, an hour's walk down the river, bore only a family likeness to the leaf Calum had written.

It was heard hardest at Inis àrsaidh because it was from Inis àrsaidh, more households than from any other single place on the roll, that the fleet had carried its people, and there was scarcely a hearth in the fishing town that autumn without some cousin or son-in-law or a whole young family gone in one of the

nineteen hulls or one-and-twenty, the number no one there had ever settled either. An old net-mender of the strand, who had given two grandsons to the roll and kept, since, a lamp of her own on her sill though the custom had not yet spread beyond Seann Skell's own waterfront, was heard to say, when the tale of two shores reached her, that two shores were better than none, and was heard also, not an hour later, by the same neighbour who carried her the tale, to say that two shores were worse than one, since a man does not know, now, which of the two to grieve toward or which to hope toward, and must do both at once with a heart no bigger than it was before.

Nothing in the tale, as it reached Inis àrsaidh, told anyone which of the two coasts held which household, and the town did what towns do with a tale too broken to answer the one question every hearth in it wanted answered: it kept both halves of the tale alive at once, telling it one way at one hearth and another way at the next, until the not-knowing became, in a manner Calum would have understood better than most, the whole of what there was to know.

V

Of the Copy that Went by Two Roads

Calum's leaf, once it was judged fit, did not stay at Seann Skell. A fair copy of it went by rider up the river road to Cathair dhearg, where the queen's own scribes kept the roll of what the crown was told, and a second copy, made from the first by Calum's own son Dòmhnall in a hand less hurried than his father's, went the sixty miles east to Taigh na Fèithe¹, where it came, in the course of things, to the same board at which Donnchadh mac Thormoid had four years before entered the turn under its unaccountable date.

He read it standing, Leabhar a' Chùrain² still open on the board before him from an earlier entry, and set the two leaves side by side without quite meaning to, the old entry of the turn and the new copy of the tidings, and saw between them a silence of four years that neither leaf so much as gestured toward, the fleet gone out one grey morning and nothing more heard of it, so far as Taigh na Fèithe's own book showed, until this. He entered the tidings as he had entered the turn,

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

faithfully and without comment, copying Calum's broken telling into Leabhar a' Chùrain's formal hand exactly as it stood, torn end and all, resisting, as he had resisted before, any temptation a lesser clerk might have felt to smooth the gap where the leaf gave out or to guess, in the book's own voice, at what the missing end might have said.

At Cathair dhearg the other copy went, as such things did, before the queen's own council in An Talla Dearg³, and there it fared rather less quietly than it had at Taigh na Fèithe's plain board. The council of Dia-thìr had never yet had to weigh a piece of news it could neither confirm nor disprove, and it did with this one what councils do with such things: it argued. One custodian of the old houses held that two shores meant the fleet had prospered, having found land enough for all its hulls though not all in the one place; another held the opposite, that two shores meant the fleet had failed to hold together at all, and that a fleet scattered on a strange sea was a fleet in worse case than one that had never sailed together to begin with. A third asked, and was not answered, which of the nineteen or one-and-twenty hulls the tale meant by its second shore, and whether the queen's own sister's hull, Mòrag's own Ròn Glas with the pilot of Ros bheag at its steering oar, had held to the first landfall or been carried to the second, and it was at this question, more than at any other put that day, that the whole board turned, as one body, to look at the queen.

Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill sat at the head of the board through the whole of the argument with her hands folded on the wood before her and said, by every account of that day that came down afterward, nothing at all. She had the leaf brought to her once more when the council's voices had run themselves out, and read it over herself, alone, by the light from the hall's high windows, and set it down again exactly where it had lain, and gave no order that it be answered, denied, or sent further, so that the council, having nothing else to do with a silence from its own queen, let the matter drop where it lay and turned to the business the day had actually brought it: a dispute over a ditch between two farms on the river, no different in its particulars from a hundred such disputes the hall had settled before and would settle again.

She kept the leaf by her a good while after the council had gone on to its ditch, longer than the ditch took to settle, and it is told that she had it copied once more in her own hand that same evening, a thing she did for no other piece of business

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

that year, and that the copy she made agreed word for word with the one Calum had sent, down to the place where the telling stopped, so that whatever she had hoped to find by setting the words down again herself, in her own letters, she did not find it, and put the copy away with the rest of the year's leaves where it lay, so far as anyone at An Talla Dearg ever afterward saw, unread again. In the council's hearing she had asked nothing of which shore her sister's hull had reached, though it was known to every custodian at that board that the third man's question was the one that concerned her before all the rest, and it was said of her by those who served her closest that a queen who forbids herself a question in front of her own council does not therefore stop asking it once the council has gone.

VI

Of the Grain Ruling and the Bridge

The two years that followed brought An Talla Dearg¹ the ordinary weather of a kingdom's business, the kind that fills the greater part of any council's year and the smaller part of any chronicle that troubles to be honest about it. A dispute over the grain owed by the upland shires to the crown's own granaries, long argued and longer delayed, was at last settled in the second of those years in the queen's own favour, the upland reeves agreeing to a measure they had refused for three seasons running once it was put to them, as it had not been put before, in the queen's own hand rather than a steward's. In the same season the bridge at Àth shean, whose middle pier had stood cracked and shored with timber since a flood two winters before, was at last mended in stone by masons sent down from the capital, the last of the timber props pulled clear on a morning cold enough that the masons broke the ice on the river to set their final course.

Between the grain ruling and the mending of the bridge, in the ordinary order of the council's business, with no greater weight given to it than to either, the queen made one further entry in the roll of the house of Dia-thir, an entry that her own scribes wrote, when the day came, in the same plain hand they had used for the grain and would use for the bridge, no larger, no darker, set apart by no mark that a reader turning the leaf idly would have paused at.

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

VII

Of the Name Written the Ordinary Way

It was Murchadh mac Eòghainn who held the pen that day, as he had held it since before the three crews first walked up the river road with their tale of a far shore, an old man now, older than any other hand still serving at An Talla Dearg¹, whose eyes had begun to want more light than the hall's high windows gave even at noon and whose fingers, in the cold months, had to be worked a while by the fire before they would close properly round a quill.

The queen gave him the words herself, standing at his shoulder rather than sitting, as she did for no other entry he had written that year, and the words, when he had them whole, struck him, though he gave no sign of it and asked no question, as being fewer than the matter seemed to want and plainer than any matter he had ever set down at that board before: that Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, and the children of Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, were struck from the order of succession to the crown of Dia-thìr, as persons no longer on Dia-thìr.

He wrote it as he had been given it, in the ordinary hand, and it was only in the forming of the name itself, Mòrag's own name, that his pen slowed by the smallest degree a watcher might have caught, not faltering, not blotting, only slowing, the way an old man's step will slow over ground he has walked a thousand times before without ever once, until that day, having cause to feel its particular shape beneath his foot. He wrote the name in the same letters he had given it every time he had written it before, in the roll of the first tellings, in the entry of Mòrag's own household onto the harbour boards, in a dozen ordinary mentions of the queen's sister across four decades of a scribe's ordinary business, and it was, in the end, exactly that, the name written the ordinary way, that seemed to trouble him longest after the ink had dried.

The queen did not stand over him again once the entry was made. She read it once where it lay, gave him no word of thanks and no word of anything else, and went out of the hall by the same door she had come in by, and it was left to Murchadh, as it was left to no one else in that hall or any other, to close the book on a name he had written a hundred times before and would, so far as the roll of the house of Dia-thìr was ever afterward concerned, never write again.

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

VIII

Of the Leaf Sanded

he sat a while after she had gone, the pen still in his hand though there was nothing further that day for it to write, and did at last what he did at the end of every entry he had ever made in that book, no more and no less: he took the fine sand from the box that had stood at his elbow at that board for forty years and more, and shook it evenly across the wet ink, and let it lie a moment, and tipped it off again into the box for the next leaf's use, an old man's hands moving through a motion so long practised that they needed, by then, no more of his mind's attention than his own breathing did.

The hall was near empty around him by then, the day's business done and the light going long and low through the high windows, and if any of the few who remained thought to watch him at it, they saw only what they had seen him do at the close of a thousand ordinary days: an old scribe closing his book, sanding his last leaf, and setting both aside for the morning, in a hand that gave away, to any eye that did not already know what the leaf held, nothing at all of what had just been written under it.

Of the White Sorrow

LE 50 – 55

I

Of What Was Said at Seann Skell

Nothing was known of the fleet after the tale that stopped at Calum's torn leaf, and a thing not known does not stay empty long in a harbour town.

By the fiftieth year of the count men who had never crossed water further than the fishing grounds off Cuan ruadh spoke of the crossing as though they had stood at the rail of it themselves, and the harbour-house at Seann Skell, which kept the only leaf anyone could point to and call a record, was asked so often what it knew that Niall mac Dhòmhnaill's father took, in the end, to answering every asker the same way, tired of hearing his own silence mistaken for a secret: that the boards held what the boards held, and a man who wanted more than that should go and ask the sea.

The tale that took hold hardest, and outlasted every other, was told first, so far as anyone could afterward say, by a coal-carrier's widow who had never in her life set foot on a hull, and it ran that the children born to the departed on the far shore came into the world with less in their hands than their parents had carried away, and the children born to those children less again, until by the third generation over the water there would be nothing left in a family that Dia-thìr would know for its own. No one could say how the carrier had come by it, and she herself, pressed on it at the fair the next spring, only shrugged and said that a thing does not have to be seen to be felt, and that a mother knows when her milk is thinner than her own mother's was, whether or not a physician can explain to her why. It was not a tale that could be tried against anything Seann Skell held. There

was no letter from the far shore to set beside it, no child of the crossing to measure, only the shape of the tale passed mouth to mouth along the strand and up the lanes, gathering, as such tales do, a little more certainty with each telling than the last mouth had given it.

A custodian of the coal, down from Taigh na Fèithe¹ on the shire's business that same year, heard the carrier's tale told over a jug in the harbour-house taproom and gave it an answer of his own that the taproom liked better, or at least argued over longer. The coal, he said, plainly enough that a man three tables off could hear him, was not a thing carried in the blood the way a chin or a temper was carried; it answered to the hand that had learned the galleries and kept Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig², and a hand once away from the vein for a lifetime, let alone two, would forget the galleries the way any hand forgets a trade it does not practise, whatever blood ran in it. The strength was not thinning in the departed's children, on his reckoning. It had simply been left behind at Muileann dhearg, the way a man leaves a tool in a shed he no longer visits, and a tool left long enough in a shed is a tool a man's own son will not know how to use: no one has put it in his hand and shown him.

The two tales did not agree, and nobody at Seann Skell troubled overmuch to make them agree, for both said, in their different ways, the one thing the harbour town most wanted said: that something in the departed, or their children, was growing less than it had been. A third telling, heard less often and never in the taproom but sometimes from an old woman at a hearth, held that nothing was lessening at all, that the far shore had simply never had the coal to answer to in the first place, so that the children born there were exactly what any child would be, no thinner and no lesser, only unremarked because there was nothing on that shore to remark them against; and this telling, though it troubled fewer households to argue over, was, for reasons no one who told it could have named, the one that most often silenced a room rather than filled it, and was therefore told least. Of the three, or the dozen half-tales that stood between them, nothing was proved and nothing disproved, for there was no one aboard any hull who could be asked, and Taigh na Fèithe, which alone might have spoken with authority on what the coal answered to and what it did not, said for some years nothing at all in public, keeping its own reckoning, as it kept everything, inside its own walls.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

II

Of the Second Count

It was Taigh na Fèithe¹'s own reckoning, made once more thirteen years after the sailing and set down without a word of what the harbour towns were saying, that in the end carried more weight than any tale told over a jug, though it travelled less far and to fewer households, for a custody-book is not a thing that passes mouth to mouth. Eòghann mac Mhuirich, who had counted the households of the coal-right once before the fleet sailed and once again the autumn Rolla nan Deònach² closed, was dead these many years by the fiftieth season of the count, and the counting fell, as most things at Taigh na Fèithe now fell, to younger hands under an older name; but the custom of the count had not changed, and in the thirteenth year past the turn the custodians sat down once more with the roll and Leabhar a' Chùraim³ open side by side, as they had sat down twice before, to see what stood and what did not.

Donnchadh mac Thormoid was thirty-nine that year, no longer the boy who had written his first fair copy by a winter fire, and it was his hand, steadier now than any other at the table, that carried the greater share of the tallying, column against column, hearth against hearth, Rolla nan Deònach checked off one name at a time against the households that remained on the coal-right. It was slow work and dull work, the kind that asks nothing of a man's judgement and everything of his patience, and it took the better part of a season before the figure stood plain before them: one hearth in five of all the hearths that had held the right to the coal at the turn was gone from the coal-right now, neither more nor fewer than the fifth that had gone aboard the fleet, so that the going, whatever else it had done, had at least done nothing further to the number left behind. It was the figure the older custodians round the table had half expected and had none of them, Donnchadh noticed, troubled to say aloud before the count was finished, as though naming it early might somehow alter what the counting found.

He wrote the figure into Leabhar a' Chùraim in his own plain hand, one hearth in five, and beneath it, where a lesser clerk might have let the matter rest, he set down a second line that no one at the table had asked him for and that he had thought a long while, by his own account afterward, before he let himself

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the roll of the willing

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

write. He had gone back, in the slow weeks of the counting, over every measuring Taigh na Fèithe had made since the turn, and had found in them nothing that answered to the tale carried about the taproom at Seann Skell or to the custodian's tale of a tool left in a shed. The vein, he wrote, answered no differently now, to the hands of those who had stayed, than it had answered before the turn; the handful measured true against every hearth that held the right, exactly as it had always measured, and if some thinning was at work upon the children of the departed on whatever shore they had reached, it was at work there, on that shore, and not here, upon the coal or the hands that remained to serve it. It was a small line in a large book, four sentences among ten thousand others, and it settled nothing that the taproom at Seann Skell had been arguing over for a decade, since it spoke only of what stood on this side of the water and said nothing at all of the other. But it was carried up to Cathair dhearg with the rest of that season's reckoning, as every reckoning was, and it came, in the ordinary course of An Talla Dearg's business, before the queen.

Beathag read the figure once, standing at the window of the small room off the hall where she kept the season's leaves before they went to the council, one hand in five, a figure she had carried in her own reckoning, unwritten, since the roll had closed thirteen years before and had never once, in all that time, let herself say aloud to anyone. She read Donnchadh's second line beneath it, the note that the vein answered no differently for those who had stayed, and stood a while with the leaf in her hand before she read it again, more slowly the second time than the first, as though the sentence might give up something on a second reading that it had withheld on the first. It gave up nothing more. It was, she saw when she had read it twice, exactly what it had seemed at the first reading, a clerk's plain observation, offered without comfort and without cruelty, that whatever was becoming of her sister's children on their far shore, it was becoming of them there and not here, and that the coal itself, the thing every custodian at Taigh na Fèithe had spent his life learning to serve, held no opinion at all on who had gone and who had stayed. She set the leaf down on the pile with the rest of that season's business, in its place, neither above the grain figures nor below them, and told her scribe, when he came in, that the council might have the whole of it at its next sitting, and said no more of it to him or to anyone else that day.

4. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

III

Of the White Sorrow

It was in the same year, or the one after, that the queen first wore the undyed wool, and the court, which had grown used by then to reading its mood in Beathag's dress the way a farmer reads weather in the sky, marked the change before any word was given for it.

She had worn colour at Cathair dhearg all her reigning life, the deep blue the house of Dòmhnall had kept since before her mother's time, and on the morning she first came into the hall in wool taken plain from the fleece, undyed and uncarded fine, the whole board fell silent before she had crossed half the floor, for a queen does not change the colour she has worn for sixty years without a household somewhere reading it for grief. She gave the court no announcement, taking up the day's first petition as she always took it, a boundary dispute between two farms on the river no different from a hundred such disputes the hall had settled before, and saying nothing at all about the wool, so that for the length of that first morning the hall was left to guess, in the low voices men use when the person they are guessing about sits ten feet from them, whether the queen mourned a death not yet announced, or a death long past that had only now found its proper dress.

It was her own steward, in the end, who gave the court what word there was to give, and he gave it plainly, having asked the queen directly, as few others at that board would have dared to. She mourned, she told him, her sister, who was ten years and more beyond any word reaching Cathair dhearg and would, by every reckoning a sensible woman could make, remain beyond it now; and she had chosen, since there was no grave to stand at and no body to wash, to mourn as she could, in the only cloth that seemed to her to hold no lie in it, since undyed wool asks no dye-master's skill and tells no story about the house that wears it beyond the bare fact of the wearing.

She set, besides the wool, one place at her own table that no one sat at: a cup, a trencher and a straight knife, laid at the board's foot every evening the queen dined in hall, whether she dined alone or with the whole council about her, and left untouched through the meal and cleared away after with the rest, as though the person for whom it was laid might yet, on any given evening, come late to the hall and take the seat. No one at court asked who the place was laid for. There was no need to ask. It was laid, plainly enough for every eye in the hall to read, for

Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, who had gone from the same hall fourteen years before with a promise between the sisters that neither had spoken of since, and who would not, by any road the hall could imagine, ever come late to a meal at Cathair dhearg again.

The court did not at first know what face to keep before it. A death it could have mourned in the old way, with black and a wake and an ending that let grief run its course and be done; but this was a grief with no ending fixed to it, a sister neither known to be dead nor known to be living, mourned in a rite that asked the whole hall to sit each evening beside an emptiness that gave back no word either way, and more than one at that board found, in the weeks after the queen first sat down to it, that they did not know whether to speak of the empty place at all, or to pass it in silence as they might pass any other piece of the hall's furniture, and settled, most of them, on the second course, since it asked less of a man than the first.

It did not stay only at Cathair dhearg. The court called it, before the year was out, an Tùrsa Geal¹, the name settling on it the way names settle on a thing that answers to no better one, and within a generation, so it came to be told afterward at more hearths than An Talla Dearg²'s own, a household anywhere on the island that had given someone to the fleet might keep the same rite in its own small way, undyed wool for the season of the mourning and a place laid empty at the table, cup and trencher and a knife laid straight, for whoever of theirs had gone and not been heard from since. It asked no priest to keep it and no vein-house to license it. A household that had never sat within a hundred miles of Cathair dhearg and had never heard the queen's own name spoken twice in a year kept it all the same, in whatever manner its own hearth could manage, because the emptiness it answered to was the same emptiness in every house that kept it, high or low, and a rite that answers a true emptiness spreads on its own account, needing no crown behind it and no law.

IV

Of the Seven Houses

1. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

The fifteenth year past the turn brought Taigh na Fèithe¹ a piece of business that had been coming toward it, by every custodian's own reckoning, since the year the roll first closed, though no one had troubled to name it plainly until that year was upon them.

A fifth of the coal-right's households were gone, and the coal-right, whatever else it might be, was above all a thing that had to be served: galleries walked, the handful measured, Leabhar a' Chùrain² kept true against every hearth still standing on it, and a fifth fewer hands to serve it than had served it at the turn. The custodians who remained had spent the years since the turn stretching the old apprenticeship thinner than it had ever been stretched, a master taking two pupils where he had once taken one, a gallery walked by a single custodian where two had walked it before, and it had held, after its fashion, for fifteen years; but it was Donnchadh mac Thormoid, now Taigh na Fèithe's senior clerk and no longer its youngest hand at any table, who said first, at a sitting called for another matter entirely, that a rule built for the numbers of the old apprenticeship had gone as far as the older custodians' own stretching could carry it, and that Taigh na Fèithe owed itself, if it owed nothing else, an honest look at what remained rather than a continued pretence that nothing had changed.

What Taigh na Fèithe found, when it looked honestly, was seven kindreds among the remaining custodian households large enough, and old enough in the coal's service, to answer for a share of the galleries between them without waiting on a new apprentice's seven years to grow into the work: the households that had stood, at the turn, under the names of Muirich, Fearchar, Ìomhar, Ragnall, Tor-mod, Coinneach and Lachlann, each with enough hands left to it, counted across its whole kindred and not household by household, to keep a gallery's measure true on its own account. It was not, the older custodians were careful to say among themselves before the matter ever came to a full sitting, a thing done lightly or done because seven was a number the island's tellings favoured; it was done because seven kindreds, and no more nor fewer, were found, on the plain evidence of the roll, to hold between them hands enough for the work that fifteen custodians the year before the turn had needed to hold.

The sitting that set it in order ran the better part of two days, the longest Taigh na Fèithe had held in Donnchadh's own memory, and it was not without its arguing, for a custodian whose household stood outside all seven kindreds, of

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

an old name that had kept a single gallery honourably for three generations but stood too small, after the turn, to answer for a share on its own account, spoke long and with some bitterness against a rule that would fold his household's right into a neighbour's kindred rather than let it stand, however narrowly, on its own feet as it always had. He was heard out to the end, as the custom of the sitting required, and answered by an old woman of Clann Thormoid who said only that she had buried a brother and two nephews to the same roll that had thinned his own household, and that she would sooner see her own right folded into a larger house that could still walk every gallery it answered for, than see it stand alone and proud over galleries it could no longer properly serve; and it was her answer, more than any argument the master of Taigh na Fèithe himself made, that the sitting was afterward said to have turned on.

The right passed, from that year, by house and no longer by the apprenticeship alone: a custodian born into one of the seven, Muirich, Fearchar, Ìomhar, Raghannall, Tormod, Coinneach or Lachlann, held a claim upon the coal's service that an outsider still had to earn by the seven years' apprenticeship as before, but held it now as a birthright of the kindred rather than as a thing each hand had to prove afresh from nothing. The seven heads, chosen by their own kindreds and sworn at Taigh na Fèithe before Crom's stone in the same week the sitting closed, took an oath none of them had taken before, since none of the island's older Laws had ever asked a custodian to answer for a whole kindred's hands rather than his own two, and Donnchadh, who wrote the oath into Leabhar a' Chùraim in the same plain hand he had used for every entry of his working life, found himself, when the seven had sworn and the book lay open to dry, thinking less of Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig³ than of the fifth of hands the sitting had never once, in two days of arguing, troubled to name aloud: the hands that were not there to be stretched or folded or sworn to anything, because they were fifteen years and a whole sea away, on a shore Taigh na Fèithe's own book had no line to enter them against any longer.

V

Of the Crowning at Cathair dhearg

3. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill was seventy and six years old in the summer Taigh na Fèithe¹ swore its seven heads, older by a decade and more than any ruler of her line had lived to be at Cathair dhearg within living memory, and had sat An Talla Dearg² for one-and-sixty years, since a girl of fifteen had been crowned in a hall too large for her, before the fleet was so much as spoken of on the western quays. She had outlived the consort who had stood beside her at that first crowning and the sister who had sailed from beneath her own promise, and she had governed, through all of it, in the plain manner the court had come, over six decades, to call simply the queen's way: neither sending nor keeping back, neither swearing to a grief nor forbidding the swearing of it, a hand that measured a boundary ditch on the same morning it measured a fleet's departure and gave neither more of itself than the other seemed to want.

She died at Cathair dhearg that same summer, in the season when the barley stood green and short in the strips above the river, much as it had stood the year she came down to Seann Skell to walk the new quay; and the court, which had watched her grow slow and then slower over the two years before it, was told afterward that she had held the boundary petition of that very morning to its usual end, hearing both farmers out and giving her ruling in the plain voice she had always used for such matters, before she went to her own rooms and did not rise from them again. Seventy and six years old, she was the oldest of her line to sit An Talla Dearg since the years when a ruler's age had meant something other than what any other man's or woman's age meant, and no one at that court thought to remark upon the number, for by then a long life was simply a long life, and a queen who died at seventy-six after one-and-sixty years upon the hall's stone floor had lived and reigned exactly as long, and no longer, than any woman of good health and hard use might reasonably hope to.

Her son was crowned in the same hall within the month, Raghnaill mac Uilleim, son of Beathag and of Uilleam mac Iain who had died at the hall six-and-twenty years before, a man of seven-and-forty himself by the year of his crowning, grey already at the temple and no stranger to An Talla Dearg's business, having sat at his mother's board through the greater part of two decades and heard more of the coal-right's disputes and the shires' grain reckonings than most men twice crowned elsewhere on the island ever heard in a lifetime. He was crowned, as his mother had been and her mother before her, in the plain rite of the house of

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

Dòmhnall, no more and no less than the setting of the old circlet upon his head by the eldest custodian present and the reading of his name into the roll of the house; and it was noted, by more than one at that crowning, that he wore, beneath his own crowning colours, a strip of undyed wool at the wrist, worn quietly and without remark, as a man might wear a thing he had grown up watching his mother wear and had never once, in seven-and-forty years, thought to ask her leave to wear himself.

VI

Of the Empty Place Laid Once More

They kept the wake for Beathag nic Dhòmhnail three nights at Cathair dhearg, as the house of Dòmhnall had always kept its wakes, the hall lit end to end and the court coming and going through the small hours as custom asked of it, and it was on the second of those nights that the queen's own steward, grown old himself in her service and near the last of those who had served her from her own youth, did the thing that afterward the whole court spoke of longest, though he did it quietly and without any word of ceremony to mark it.

He had the cup, the trencher and the straight knife brought out once more and laid at the board's foot, exactly as they had been laid every evening the queen dined in that hall since she first put on the undyed wool, and left there through the whole of the wake's second night, untouched, as the place had always been left, while the court passed it going to and from the queen's own bier at the hall's head, and few among them, that night, could have said with any certainty which of the two sisters the place was laid for.

It might have been laid, as it had always been laid before, for Mòrag, gone these fifteen years and further from any word reaching Cathair dhearg than she had ever been; the steward himself, asked afterward, would say only that he had laid it as he always laid it, in the manner the queen herself had kept, and that he had not thought, doing it, to lay it for any different reason than the one that had first set it there. But it stood that second night at the foot of a board where the queen herself now lay cold at the hall's other end, and more than one who passed it going to the bier found their eye caught by the small emptiness at the board's foot before it was caught by the greater emptiness at the board's head, and could not, standing between the two, have said honestly which absence weighed the

heavier on them, the sister fifteen years across an unanswering sea, or the queen not yet a full day gone from the hall she had sat for one-and-sixty years, both alike unreachable now by any road the living court could travel, and both, that one night, kept in the same plain wool and the same untouched place, as though the hall, having mourned one so long in this fashion, had found in the end that it knew no other way to mourn the second.

OF the Empty Harbour

LE 56 – 67

I

Of the Boards Given Over

Calum mac Nèill kept the boards of Taigh a' Chalaigh¹ for fifty-six years, and in the last two of them his eyes wanted so much light to read a leaf by that his son Dòmhnall took to holding the lamp close over his shoulder whenever an entry was made, so close that the old man complained, more than once, that his own son meant to set his hair alight before his years did the rest of the work themselves. He died in the between-moon of the fifty-eighth year of the count, at Seann Skell, in the room above the harbour-house where he had slept every night of his keeping, and it is told that the last thing his hand reached for, before it stopped reaching for anything, was the corner of the board nearest his bed, the one on which the earliest names of the roll still stood, cut through where they had been struck and plain where they had not.

He had kept a promise that no one had asked him to keep twice: the boards would not be closed while the queen had not closed them, and they were not closed at his death either, though there was no roll left open on them by then for any household to enter or strike its name from, the fleet eighteen years gone and no new leaving to be counted. What Calum's boards had become, in the years since An Diosal², was less a roll than a wall that the town looked to and did not read closely, the names on it grown as familiar and as little regarded as the har-

1. the harbour-house

2. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

bour-house's own stones, until a stranger asked after one of them and the whole town remembered, for the length of the asking, what the boards were for.

The harbour-house did not go to Dòmhnall, who had held the lamp for his father and had expected, without ever quite saying so aloud, that the office was his by the same right it had been his father's, passed from a scribe before Calum in its turn. It went instead to Niall mac Dhòmhnail, Dòmhnall's own son, a man of nine-and-twenty who had been eleven years old on the night of An Diosal and had stood on the west quay wall with a hazel stick and a knife, cutting a notch for every hull that went round the pool. Calum had never told the town, in so many words, which of the two men he meant to follow him, but he had begun, in the year before his death, to send for Niall rather than for Dòmhnall whenever a difficult entry wanted a second hand, and the town of Seann Skell, which watched such things closely because it had little else that season to watch, had drawn its own conclusions some while before Calum's will was read aloud at the harbour-house door.

Dòmhnall took it as well as a man takes such a thing when he has had a year to see it coming and no year at all to make his peace with it. He stood at his father's shoulder through the reading of the will, said nothing while it was read, and afterward, alone with Niall on the harbour strand, said only that the boards were the queerest inheritance a man could be passed over for, since no one living had ever grown rich or great from keeping them, and that his father, whatever else he had been, had never once in fifty-six years asked whether the work he gave his whole life to was worth the giving. Niall answered that he did not know either, and that he meant to keep them all the same, and father and son, who had lived in the same house under the same lamp, worked the harbour-house together civilly enough for the rest of that year and every year after, Dòmhnall keeping the trade rolls and the harbour dues, Niall keeping the boards that no household entered any longer and the knife that no hull now needed counting.

He took the stick down from the shelf where it had stood since the night of the turn, the hazel stick with its row of notches cut too fast and too many to be read again for any true count, and he did not put it back. It stood from that day at his own elbow when he sat to write, in the same place his grandfather's ink-horn had always stood, though he used it for nothing and could have told no one, asked, exactly why he kept it there rather than on the shelf with the rest of what Calum had left behind him.

His grandmother Seonag, the goose-keeper Calum had married before Niall's own father was born, outlived her husband by less than a year, and in the months between the two deaths she came down most mornings to the harbour-house to sit by the fire while Niall worked, saying little, watching him form the letters at the board her husband had sat at for fifty-six years. She told him once, in one of those quiet mornings, that Calum had never once in all his keeping told her whether he thought the boards worth the life he had given them, and that she had stopped asking him after the first few years of their marriage, having come to believe that a man who kept such a question to himself that long meant to keep it there for good. Niall did not ask himself, aloud or otherwise, whether his own answer would differ from the one his grandfather had never given, but he noticed, in the years that followed, that he had stopped expecting anyone to ask him.

II

Of the Lamps Grown about the Berth

No one had ordered a rite kept at the quay the ships had sailed from, and no one, so far as Niall's own boards or his grandfather's before them ever showed, could name the year it began, only that by the time Niall took up the pen it had already the settled shape of a thing long kept rather than newly made. On the eve nearest the day of An Diosal¹, as near as the harbour-house's own dating let anyone reckon it after so many years without a fixed count, the households of Seann Skell that had given someone to the roll, and a good number that had not, brought down to the west quay whatever small light they could carry, a rushlight, a fish-oil lamp, a coal from the hearth wrapped close in a clay pot against the wind off the water, and set it along the stones where the fleet had lain, and stood a while, and went home again without a word said over it that anyone thought worth remembering.

Niall had gone down himself, the first autumn of his keeping, more from a scribe's habit of wanting to see for himself what he might one day be asked to write of than from any devotion of his own, and had stood at the edge of it with his grandfather's stick, which he had brought without quite meaning to, held loose in one hand. The rite was not large by then, a few dozen lamps along stones

1. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

that had once held the whole west quay's worth of light on a single night, and half those who kept it were old enough to remember the sailing themselves, or old enough at least to have been told of it young by someone who did. He watched an old woman he did not know set her lamp down at the very edge of the stone where the ships had lain, closest of any that were set that night, and stand over it a long while with her lips moving and no sound coming from them that he could make out, and when she had gone he asked a boy nearby, one of the harbour-house's own runners, whose lamp it had been, and the boy said only that it was old Mairead's, that she came every year, and that no one now living knew for certain which of her kin the lamp was kept for, since she herself, asked, gave a different name most years.

He wrote it into his own leaf that night, not because any board required an entry of a rite the crown had never ordered and Taigh na Fèithe² had never asked after, but because it seemed to him, turning the matter over by his own late lamp, that a harbour scribe who wrote down every dispute over a cracked hull and every barrel landed at the quay and said nothing of the one night in the year when half the town came down to the water with a light in its hand, was keeping a stranger kind of silence than any his grandfather had ever kept before him. The entry he made was short, and it named no one, and it has outlasted every longer thing he wrote that year.

III

Of the Harbour at Half Trade

Murchadh mac Raghnaill, harbour-master of Seann Skell, was of an age with Niall and had held his own office a year longer, having been given the berths and the dues of the harbour by a predecessor who retired to his daughter's house up the Abhainn naomh rather than die at his post as Calum had. It was Murchadh's business, not Niall's, to count what trade the harbour carried, and in the sixth year of Niall's keeping he brought his own count to the harbour-house door and set it beside the boards for anyone to read, a plain reckoning of the berths that stood empty against the berths that stood full on an ordinary market morning, and it showed, without any softening he cared to give it,

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

that the harbour of Seann Skell carried, that year, not much more than half the trade it had carried before An Diosal¹.

It was not a mystery to either man why this should be so, and Murchadh did not write it as though it were one. The fishing households that had crewed the greater part of the fleet's boats before the turn, and had gone in no small number aboard the fleet itself, had left both fewer hands to work the harbour's boats and fewer mouths at Seann Skell to buy what those boats brought in, and the rope-walks along Cuan shean's stretch of the waterfront, which had once kept every hand they could hire twisting hemp against the fleet's endless want of cordage, found themselves that same year with more rope made than the harbour's remaining trade could use, and let hands go for the first time in the memory of anyone still walking the walks, old men who had twisted rope there since before the sailing and had never once, in all those years, seen the walk's own master turn a willing hand away.

Murchadh's reckoning was matter-of-fact where a lesser clerk's might have reached for grief, and Niall, reading it over at the harbour-house board, found himself wondering, not for the first time, whether the harbour-master's plainness came from a harder heart than his own or only from a kind of mercy that wore the shape of bookkeeping. He copied the figures into his own boards without comment, as his grandfather would have done, and set Murchadh's leaf beside Rolla nan Deònach² on the same wall, the names of those who had gone and the count of what their going had cost the harbour they left behind, side by side on stones that had room enough, by then, for both.

IV

Of the Word that Came and Was Not Written

In the seventh year of his keeping a boat put in at Seann Skell from up the coast with a hand aboard, a man Niall did not know and never learned the name of, who told it in the taproom of a house near the strand, over the second cup rather than the first, that he had heard from a cousin who had heard it from a trader out of Ceann mhòr that a second fleet, smaller than the first and

1. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

2. the roll of the willing

gone by a different season, had put out from somewhere on the island's own shore in the years just after An Diosal¹, and had likewise never been heard from since.

It reached Niall the following morning, brought to him by the same runner who had told him whose lamp burned closest to the quay-stone, the boy repeating it with the particular relish of someone passing on a thing he has been told twice already and half believes for the telling's own sake, and Niall listened to the whole of it standing at his board with his pen already in his hand, as he had a hundred other pieces of harbour gossip in his years of keeping. He asked the boy who the man was and where his boat had gone, and got no clear answer to either, and asked whether anyone else in the taproom had heard the same tale from any other mouth before that night, and got, again, nothing he could set his hand to.

He did not write it. In seven years at the boards he had written a great many things a stranger might have judged smaller and stranger than this: a dispute over a landed catch's true weight, a fight between two carters over a berth neither had paid for, the exact hour a lost child was found asleep under an upturned coble. A tale with no name behind it and no second mouth to confirm it, he judged, was not a harbour matter at all, whatever else it might be, and the boards, his grandfather had taught him before he could properly hold the pen, were not the place for a thing a scribe could not stand behind. He thought of it again, once or twice, in the weeks after, turning it over the way a man turns over a ring he is not sure is good silver, and each time set it aside unwritten, until the thinking of it, too, grew less frequent, and at last stopped.

Dòmhnall, told of it over the trade rolls one evening, asked his son outright why he would not set down even so much as the hearing of it, a rumour being a fact of a kind in its own right, whatever the truth or falsehood of what it rumoured, and Niall answered that a boat's dues were a fact of that kind and a rumour was not, and that he did not mean to spend the rest of his life discovering where the difference between the two ran thin. Dòmhnall let the matter drop, as he had let a good many matters drop between them since the will was read, but it is told that he repeated the tale once or twice after, in the ordinary way of a man passing on harbour gossip, careful each time to say that the harbour-house's own scribe had heard it too and set it aside, as though Niall's silence carried a kind of authority the tale could be hung on.

1. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

V

Of the Watch at Ceann mhòr

Twenty miles up the coast at Ceann mhòr, in the same year the rope-walks let their first hands go, a fisher's daughter named Seonag nic Dhùghaill climbed the headland above the town at first light on a morning no different, so far as anyone could afterward say, from any other morning, and stood there through the whole of the day's turning, looking out over open water, and came down again at dusk having seen nothing but gulls and a change of weather coming in from the west.

She had lost no one to the fleet herself, her own family being newer to Ceann mhòr than the sailing was old, but she had grown up on tellings of it from older fishing folk of the town who had, and she said afterward, when asked why she had gone up, only that it seemed to her a thing someone ought to be doing, and that she did not see why it should not be her. Other households of Ceann mhòr, hearing what she had done, began within the season to take a turn of their own on the headland, a day at a time, household by household, so that by the year's end there was scarcely a week the headland stood unwatched from first light to dusk, and the custom, which had no name at its beginning beyond "Seonag's watch", came in time to be called simply *Faire a' Chinn*¹, by fisher-folk up and down that stretch of coast who had never met Seonag herself and knew her only as the woman who had started it.

No sail was ever seen from that headland in Seonag's own lifetime, nor, so far as the harbour-house at Seann Skell ever had report of, in the lifetime of anyone who kept the watch after her, and it is told that she herself, asked late in her years whether she still believed a sail might come, said only that a watch kept for a sure thing was no watch at all, and that she had climbed the headland the first morning expecting nothing, and had found, in the not-finding, reason enough to climb it again.

VI

Of the New Name and the Old

1. the watch of the headland at Ceann mhòr

By the eighth year of Niall's keeping the old name of the west quay, the plain harbour name it had carried since before the roll was ever opened, had begun to fall out of common mouths at Seann Skell in favour of a newer one that no one could point to a single day of coining, *Cidhe an Diosail*¹, spoken now by carters and fish-wives and children too young to have known anyone who sailed from it, as though the stones had never been called anything else. The harbour-house's own boards had kept the old name a while longer than the town's own mouths had, out of a scribe's habitual caution about changing what stood written, but in the ninth year, with the old name gone so thoroughly from ordinary speech that a stranger asking after it by its old form was as likely as not to be misunderstood, Niall entered the new name into *Rolla a' Chalaigh*² himself, in his own hand, *Cidhe an Diosail*, and let the old name stand beside it once, crossed through but not scraped, in the manner his grandfather had taught every apprentice of that board: a struck name stays visible.

The name that passed out of use at the west quay found a use elsewhere. *Cidhe an Iar*, the west quay's own old name, was taken up that same year by the fishers of the new wharf built at the strand's north end to handle the catch that no longer had the old quay's room to land at, and within a season or two the fishers who worked it used the name for their own wharf without, so far as Niall could tell, any sense that they had inherited it from anywhere, or any thought at all for where it had come from.

It was in the same years, and in no entry Niall could point to as the first, that he began to notice *Rolla a' Chalaigh* using a word he had grown up hearing spoken only with an object, *roghnaich*, to choose this or that, now standing alone in a clerk's hand, a household *roghnaich*, chose, with nothing following it that any reader needed told, since every reader by then knew well enough what a household that had chosen, unqualified, had chosen to do. He used the word so himself, once or twice, before he noticed he had done it, and when he did notice, he let the usage stand in his own leaf rather than correct it to the fuller, older form, judging, as his grandfather might have judged before him, that a scribe's business was to write the tongue his town actually spoke rather than the tongue it had once spoken and no longer troubled to.

1. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

2. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

VII

Of the Children Who Never Saw It

Niall had, by the ninth year of his keeping, three children of his own grown near enough to grown that they helped about the harbour-house on a market day, and none of the three, nor any child born at Seann Skell in a dozen years and more before them, had ever seen the west quay with a fleet of nineteen hulls, or one-and-twenty, lying at it, waiting on a tide. To them the sailing was a thing told rather than a thing remembered, a story their own father kept the boards of and could point to the stones of, no different in its bones from any other tale an old woman might tell a child at a winter hearth, save that this one had a harbour-house full of leaves to back it and a wall of names a child could run a finger along and ask, of any one of them, who that had been.

His eldest daughter, a girl of ten that year, asked him once, watching him enter an ordinary day's dues, whether he himself had seen the ships go, and he told her that he had, that he had stood on the very wall she was leaning against with a stick in his hand cutting notches for the counting of them, and she looked at the wall a long while after he had told her, as though trying to see upon it something her own eyes could not find there, and asked no more that day. He did not correct whatever she had imagined in the looking, and did not know, himself, what it was she had hoped to see.

VIII

Of the Last Coaster and the Last Entry

Alasdair mac Iain, Alasdair Saor, who had laid the first deep keel any hand on the island had ever laid, and had redrawn it in sand by a driftwood fire after the first hull lay down and drowned eleven souls off the headland, and had bound the wrights of the Seann Skell strand into one fellowship and seen a boy of that fellowship sworn before a custodian in the manner of the vein, was by the sixty-seventh year of the count an old man bent nearly double over the same strand he had first walked to Doire fhionn from as a young one, and still, to the last season of his life, unwilling to let a hull leave his yard that he had not laid a hand to himself.

His last work was a small thing beside the deep-keeled hulls of the fleet, a sewn-plank coaster of the old kind built for a fish merchant of Inis àrsaidh who wanted nothing grander than a boat that would carry his catch to market and bring him home again dry, and Alasdair built it that spring as he had built every boat before it, going down himself to check the set of every plank though his hands by then shook too much to hold an adze steady for more than a few strokes at a time, leaving the finer work to the journeymen he had trained and trusting, as he had trusted the fellowship's oath for sixty years, that a hand he had taught would not betray the eye that had taught it.

The coaster was launched at Inis àrsaidh in the last days of the moon of Teasach, and Alasdair died at Seann Skell before the week was out, at the end of that same summer, in the yard where he had laid the first frames of the fleet's first hull like the ribs of a beast on the open strand. Niall entered his death the same day the word of it reached the harbour-house, in the ordinary hand he kept for every death the town brought to his boards, and set beside it, on the same leaf, in the same sitting, the entry he had been putting off making for the better part of a year: that the west quay, called of old by a plainer name, stood now and would stand hereafter in *Rolla a' Chalaidh*¹ as *Cidhe an Diosail*², and that the name it had given up passed, by the town's own usage rather than any order of his, to the wharf at the strand's north end.

He sat with the two entries a while after the ink of both had dried, the old shipwright's death and the quay's new name, set down one above the other on a leaf no different in its ruling from any other leaf in the harbour-house's long keeping, and it is told that he said to no one in particular, closing the book, a line the harbour folk of Seann Skell were already saying of their own accord by then, of one thing and another, though he may have been the first to set it down: *is fhada an cuan, is goirid a' chuimhne*. Long is the sea, and short is memory. He banked the harbour-house's night fire himself, the boy whose office it was having gone home early, and set his grandfather's stick back in its place at his elbow for the next day's writing, exactly where it had stood every night since the boards were given over to him.

1. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

2. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Of the Moulds in the Fire

LE 68 – 109

Beathaich an seabhag, ach na sàsaich e. Feed the hawk, but do not
glut him.

— the first saying in Leabhar an t-Seabhaig

I

Of the Fellowship After Alasdair

Coinneach mac Fhearghais had been the first apprentice Alasdair Saor ever swore, a boy of fourteen with a stammer and hands too big for the rest of him, and he was the last of that first swearing left alive when the old man's yard passed to him. He kept the stammer into old age, worse when he was angered and gone almost entirely when he was easy, and the wrights of the fellowship had long since stopped remarking on it, the way a household stops remarking on a low door once every member of it has learned to duck. He took the mastership of the fellowship of the strand as Alasdair had held it, by the plain fact that no one else living had built so many hulls under the old man's own eye, and he kept the fellowship's oath and its coal exactly as it had been kept before him, swearing no fewer apprentices than the yard could rightly feed and turning away, more than once, a father who came with a willing son and no craft in the boy's hands to show for it.

There was less for the fellowship to build by then than there had been in Alasdair's day, no one on the island wanting a hull that meant to lose sight of land,

and the yard at Seann Skell that had once laid three keels at a time to the fleet's own hunger kept, in Coinneach's years, to one coaster at a season and sometimes none, the wrights filling the slack months with the mending of fish-boats and the cutting of oars for households that had never owned a boat worth the name. Coinneach never complained of it where any apprentice could hear him. Niall, who came down to the strand most autumns to enter the yard's launches in his boards, noticed that the old man had taken to standing longer than the work wanted over each new keel laid, running a flat hand along the wood the way another man might run a hand along a horse he did not expect to keep much longer.

Niall asked him once, the autumn he came down to enter a coaster no grander than any of the season's before it, whether a small boat built to carry a fish merchant's catch to market gave a wright the same satisfaction a deep-keeled hull once had, and Coinneach was a long while answering, turning the question over the way he turned over a plank before he trusted an adze to it. He said at last, the stammer catching only on the first word, that a boat was a boat whatever water it was built to cross, and that a man who could not find his satisfaction in a coaster well built had likely never had much satisfaction in a hull's building at all, only in the size of the thing he had built, which was a different pride and a smaller one. Niall wrote none of that down, judging it a wright's own business rather than the harbour-house's. He remembered it all the same, and in the years that followed set the same question to more than one man who complained to him of smaller work than he had once been given.

In his seven-and-seventieth year he told his eldest journeyman, a quiet man named Griogair who had been with him since before his own beard came in grey, that he did not think he would see another spring's launching from the strand himself, and he said it without any weight in his voice that Griogair could afterward point to as grief, only as a fact set down the way Coinneach set down every fact, plainly and once. He died the following winter, in the between-moon that comes some years to true out the count with the sun, in the same house on the strand where he had lived since his marriage, and it is told that his last words, got out whole and without the old stammer for the first time in years his family could remember, were that the fellowship's coal was to go to Griogair and to no one else, whatever any elder journeyman might claim by right of years alone. Niall entered the death the day word of it reached the harbour-house, and set beside it, from old habit rather than any instruction from the boy himself, the note that

Coinneach mac Fhearghais had been the last man living who remembered kneeling on the shingle with Alasdair Saor's own hand over his.

II

Of the Last Journeymen and the Moulds Burned

Griogair kept the fellowship sixteen years more, and it is told of those sixteen years only that they were quiet ones, the yard laying its one coaster a season as before and losing, each year, an apprentice or two to households that had work nearer home and no patience left for an oath that fed a man no faster than the sea did. In the eighty-fourth year of the count Griogair called what journeymen the fellowship still had to the strand at the season's turning and told them, without ceremony, that there was not craft enough left in the ordering of the island's own boats to keep an oath sworn for the building of a fleet, and that he meant to release every man there from it and close the fellowship's coal himself, being the last to hold it and having no wife's son to pass it to. The journeymen took the release as men take a thing they have half expected for years and half hoped would not come in their own time: some went to the rope-walks at Cuan shean, some to farm the strips their fathers had left them, and one, a young man called Tòmas who had sworn only two years before, walked the whole way to Doire fhionn to learn the woodward's craft among the stumps of the old grove, saying to anyone who asked that a trade with a future in it, however small, was worth more than the memory of one that had none. Griogair kept for himself only his own tools and the last coaster laid before the release, a boat he finished alone over the following winter with no journeyman left to hand him a plank, and sold it at spring to the same fish merchant of Inis àrsaidh whose father had bought Alasdair's own last hull, saying nothing of the fellowship's ending to the merchant beyond that the price would be a little higher, there being no apprentice's wage to spread the cost across any longer.

Niall entered the fellowship's closing in the boards the day Griogair brought him word of it, and found, setting down the entry, that he did not know what heading to give it under, Rolla a' Chalaidh¹ having no place kept for the ending of an oath that no one had thought to enter as a beginning, Alasdair having sworn

1. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

his first apprentices on the open shingle with no scribe there to write it down. He set it, in the end, under the same heading he had used for the launching of every hull the fellowship had ever built, judging that an ending belonged with its beginnings whatever the boards' own ruling said, and let the matter stand.

The following winter came in hard and early, the worst any living at Seann Skell could remember, and in the depth of Faolach, the storm-moon, with the town's own store of driftwood and cut peat running thinner than any household cared to own to its neighbours, someone went into the shed on the strand where the fellowship's old patterns and keel-moulds had stood since the fleet's own building, untouched by anyone in years, and carried the whole of it out board by board to be burned. No name was ever set to whose hand did the carrying, and none of the households that burned that wood in their own hearths that winter thought, so far as anyone afterward owned, that they were burning anything more than seasoned oak cut to no purpose any man living still had use for. Murchadh mac Raghnaill, the harbour-master, noted in his own reckoning that the fellowship's shed on the strand had come down that winter and its ground stood empty, and wrote nothing of what the shed had held, the moulds and patterns by which every hull of the fleet had been laid true having by then passed so far out of any use that their going seemed to him no more a loss than the pulling-down of an old fence. Niall, reading Murchadh's leaf at the harbour-house board, thought of asking after it, and did not, telling himself that a scribe who chased down every burned plank in a hard winter would have no ink left for anything else the town wanted written.

III

Of a King's Death and a Line in the Custody-Book

Word came to Seann Skell some weeks late, as word from Cathair dhearg generally did, that Raghnaill mac Uilleim, who had held An Talla Dearg¹ since Niall was a young man, had died in his eighty-fifth year, and that the heads of the shires had crowned his son Raghnaill mac Raghnaill in his place without dispute, the new king seven-and-forty years old and already grey at the temples when the crown was set on him. Niall entered the death and the

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

crowning on the same leaf, as Leabhar a' Chùrain² at Cathair dhearg was said to have done before him, one line for the reign that had just closed and one for the reign beginning, and found, turning the matter over afterward, that he could not himself recall a single thing the old king had done in the whole of his seven-and-thirty years on the hall that a harbour scribe at Seann Skell would have had cause to write down. It was not, he thought, that Ragnall mac Uilleim's reign had wanted for length; it was that it had wanted, so far as the west coast ever heard of it, for anything happening in it at all, the vein measured out as it had always been measured, the shires kept as they had always been kept, and Rolla a' Chalaith³ of Seann Skell no fuller nor emptier for a change of crown than they would have been for a change of season.

The town kept no rite for the old king's death beyond what any household kept for its own dead, a light set out and a word said, and the taprooms along the strand talked more, in the weeks the news was fresh, of the hard winter just past and the fellowship's burned shed than of the man who had worn the crown for seven-and-thirty years and left it, by every account that reached the west coast, exactly as he had found it. Niall wrote the new king's name into the boards under the old one and did not, this once, add anything of his own beside it, judging that a scribe who had nothing to say of a reign owed that reign at least the honesty of his silence.

Dòmhnall, keeping the trade rolls at the same board, said once, reading the two lines over his son's shoulder, that a king who left nothing behind him for a harbour scribe to write was perhaps the kindest king a coast so far from An Talla Dearg could hope for, since every king the west coast's own tellings remembered with any weight had cost it a war, a levy, or a fleet, and Niall allowed that this might be so, though he added that he would not himself care to be remembered, when his own boards were closed, by two bare lines and nothing beside them. Dòmhnall answered that a harbour scribe's own boards were a different matter entirely from a king's reign, being read by fewer eyes and closer ones, and the two men let the question drop there, as they let most questions drop by then, having worked the same board together long enough to know which ones were worth pressing and which were not.

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

IV

Of the Death of Niall mac Dhòmhnaill

Niall kept the harbour-house boards six-and-forty years in all, ten fewer than his grandfather Calum had kept them, and in his last years his own hand grew as unsteady over a leaf as Calum's had been, though it was his sight that held and his fingers that failed him, the opposite trouble from the one he had watched close in on the old man in the room above the harbour-house when he himself was a boy holding the lamp. He worked to the very end of his strength, entering a small dispute over a landed catch's weight in the same careful hand he had used for every dispute of forty years before it, and it is told that the entry stands unfinished in the boards to this day, the last stroke of the last letter trailing off where his hand stopped rather than where the sense of the sentence did.

He died in the season of Bealltach of the hundred-and-fourth year of the count, at Seann Skell, five-and-seventy years old, in the harbour-house rather than in any bed, having been carried there by his own wish when it grew plain to those about him that he would not see the next morning out. In the last hours anyone sat with him he asked for his grandfather's hazel stick to be brought and set in his hand, the same stick he had carried down as a boy of eleven to the west quay wall on the night of An Diosal¹, and he held it a long while without speaking, running his thumb along the row of notches cut too fast and too many to be read again for any true count. Those who sat with him afterward could not agree, comparing what they remembered of that night, whether he had said anything at all in the hours before the end, or whether the working of his lips they took for speech had been no more than the working of an old man's breath. What is agreed is that he never once, in six-and-forty years at the boards nor in the hour of his death, told any living soul the number he had come to, privately, in all the years since that night, for the hulls that went round the pool at the turn; and the stick passed, at his own asking, into the ground with him rather than to the shelf, so that whatever count it had held for him, cut too fast on a boy's knee in the dark, went with it.

His eldest daughter, grown by then to a woman with children of her own about the harbour-house, asked him once, in the last year of his life, whether he

1. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

had ever settled the count for himself, having heard him spoken of all her childhood as the boy who counted the hulls. He told her, she said afterward, that a man who had spent forty years keeping other men's counts honest owed his own the same honesty, and that an honest count, once cut in haste on a dark quay by a boy of eleven with cold hands and a bad light, could not be mended by an old man's wishing at his own fireside forty years on, whatever number the wishing might land on. She did not ask him again, and the boards of Seann Skell passed, in the season after his death, to hands the harbour-house had already chosen against the day, the office running on as offices at Seann Skell had always run on, one keeper's leaf taken up where the last one's had stopped.

V

Of the Coal-Breakers Below the Hill

At Muileann dhearg, below Taigh na Fèithe¹ where the coal-road came down off the hill, a man named Eachann Briseadair had for some years kept a shed of his own, of a different kind from the fellowship's, where the raw coal brought down from the galleries was broken and sorted before it went out to the shires under Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig²'s own measure. He had learned the breaking from his father, who had learned it from a custodian of Taigh na Fèithe two generations before either of them, and he was, by the seventieth year of the count, the only man on the hill whose own household did the whole of the work rather than hiring it out season by season to whoever's hands were free.

It is told at Muileann dhearg that Eachann built his first house of stone below Taigh na Fèithe's own gate in the two-and-seventieth year, his sons and their wives building three more beside it within the decade, so that what had been a scatter of turf shielings at the foot of the hill became, before Eachann himself was an old man, a settled row of houses with its own well and its own smith, known at first only as the coal-breakers' row and in time, once it had grown past what any one word for a scatter of houses could properly hold, by the name Taigh na Fèithe had long given the whole of that ground: Muileann dhearg, the red mill, for the colour the dust of the breaking left on every stone and every hand that worked there.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

Eachann lived to see it a town in more than name, with its own reeve answering to Taigh na Fèithe rather than to any shire, and died in it at sixty, in the same shed where he had broken his first load of coal as a boy at his father's side, his own sons by then old enough to keep the work without him and his grandsons already learning it at their fathers' hands, the way the breaking had come down to Eachann himself.

He was buried, at his own asking, on the rise above the shed rather than within it, where a man standing at his grave could see the whole of the row he had raised and the coal-road climbing past it to Taigh na Fèithe gate, and it is told that his eldest son set no stone over him beyond a lump of the coal itself, unbroken, judging that his father would rather be marked by the thing his hands had spent a life breaking than by anything a mason could cut for him. The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe, hearing of it, sent down no objection, the coal being Eachann's by Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig's own measure to burn or to keep as any household chose, and the stone-that-was-not-a-stone stood on the rise above Muileann dhearg for longer than any household there could afterward say, weathering no differently than Taigh na Fèithe's own walls did.

Donnchadh mac Thormoid, who had kept Taigh na Fèithe's own boards since he was fifteen years old and had by the seventieth year of the count grown into the office as fully as any man grows into a coat cut for him young, entered Eachann's first house in his own leaves the season it was raised, and it was in that same season, or near enough to it that Donnchadh himself could never afterward be certain which had come first, that word reached Taigh na Fèithe from Cathair dhearg that the crown's own scribes at An Talla Dearg³ had begun to date their rolls by the count he himself had kept alone at Muileann dhearg for near thirty years, setting aside the reckoning by any king's reign for the turning he had first set his own hand to as a clerk of thirty with no one asking him to. He said nothing of it to anyone about him when the word reached him, only sat a while at his own board with the leaf before him unmarked, and it is told that he wrote, at the foot of that day's ordinary entry, a single line that named no pride and claimed no credit, only that An Talla Dearg now counted its years as Muileann dhearg had long counted its own, and let the matter stand at that.

3. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

VI

Of the Lots Drawn Among the Seven Houses

Na Seachd Taighean that held the right to the coal under Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig¹ had each, since the houses were made, kept a claim on this gallery or that within the vein without any settled order to which house's claim ran deepest, and disputes over a gallery's true bounds had grown, in Donnchadh's own years at the boards, frequent enough that the custodians of Taigh na Fèithe² judged the matter could not be left to grow any older before it was settled once for all. In the hundred-and-ninth year of the count, a generation after the fellowship at Seann Skell had released its last journeymen, the heads of Na Seachd Taighean³ were called to Muileann dhearg and set, each in turn, to draw a stone from a covered bag before the custodians and the whole household of Taigh na Fèithe looking on, each stone marked in a hand none of the houses' own heads could read, so that no house might afterward claim its gallery had been given rather than drawn.

Donnchadh kept the boards that day as he kept every day, but he wrote afterward, in his own private hand rather than in Taigh na Fèithe's formal rolls, that he had never in all his years at Muileann dhearg seen seven grown heads of houses stand so still nor speak so little as they stood and spoke while the bag went from hand to hand, each drawing his stone and reading its mark aloud to the custodian before any other man in the hall was let see it. The galleries fell as the stones fell, some houses drawing deep and rich ground and others drawing thin, and it is told that not one head among the seven, in all the years that followed, was ever heard to say aloud that his own house's stone had wronged it, whatever might have been said of it in private at his own hearth. The stones themselves, once every gallery was claimed and entered, went back into the same bag they had been drawn from, and the bag was hung on a peg in Taigh na Fèithe's own hall rather than broken up or put away, so that any man who doubted the drawing might come and see the very stones that had made it.

1. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the seven houses of custody

VII

Of the Stones Shown to a Visitor

That same year Donnchadh was an old man in his own right, the youngest apprentice at Taigh na Fèithe¹ calling him, without any unkindness meant by it, the oldest thing on the hill after the coal, and it fell to him more often than to any custodian to show a visitor about the hall when one came, Taigh na Fèithe's affairs by then running largely on the memory of a scribe who had kept them longer than anyone else living. A grandson of Eachann Briseadair's, a boy of ten sent up from the coal-breakers' row on some errand of his father's, found himself waiting a while in Taigh na Fèithe's hall for the custodian he had been sent to, and Donnchadh, seeing him stand alone and plainly curious rather than put a task in front of him, took the bag down from its peg and let him hold it.

The boy asked what the stones were for, and Donnchadh told him, in fewer words than the telling had ever taken him before, of the day the seven heads had stood in that same hall and drawn them, and of how no house since had ever been heard to say the drawing had wronged it. He did not tell the boy which stone had fallen to which house, judging that the boy's own family, being coal-breakers and not among the seven, had no more claim on that knowledge than any other visitor might, and the boy, turning the stones over in the bag with the plain interest of a child handling a thing older than his own grandfather, asked only whether the stones were magic, and Donnchadh told him, honestly, that he did not know, having never asked a custodian the question and not meaning to begin asking it now, in his own last years, when the not-knowing had served him well enough for fifty. He hung the bag back on its peg before the custodian came, and the boy went off to his errand having learned, so far as Donnchadh could tell, only that Taigh na Fèithe kept old stones in a bag and an old man who would talk of them if a boy stood still long enough to be talked to.

VIII

Of the Last Entry

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Donnchadh wrote, in the same season the boy had come and gone, the last entry Taigh na Fèithe's own boards ever received from his hand: the season's burning of coal, household by household, in the measure Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig² had held since Fionnlagh Dall, set down in the same careful order he had set it down every season since he first took up the boards at fifteen, beginning with Na Seachd Taighean³ in the order their galleries had fallen at the drawing and ending, as it had always ended, with the coal-breakers' row that answered to Taigh na Fèithe rather than to any house's claim. He died that same season, at Muileann dhearg, in the room above the hall where he had slept since his father first walked him up the coal-road as a boy, and it is told that a custodian, comparing the last leaf of his hand against the first he had entered at fifteen, could find no difference between them that any stranger to both would have thought worth remarking, the same careful order and the same plain hand at five-and-ninety that had been set down at fifteen.

No one at Muileann dhearg troubled to say, over his grave, anything grander than that the boards had lost the only hand that had ever kept them, since none living could remember another, and Taigh na Fèithe went on, in the season that followed, exactly as it had gone on through every season of his keeping, the coal broken and measured and carried down the road below the hill to the row of houses that bore his own count in their gate as surely as the crown itself now bore it in An Talla Dearg⁴'s rolls. The bag of Clachan a' Chrannchuir⁵ hung where it had hung since the drawing, on its peg in Taigh na Fèithe's hall, and no hand troubled to take it down again for some while after, the boy from the coal-breakers' row being the last, for a long season, to have held it and turned it over and set it, unread, back in its place.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

3. the seven houses of custody

4. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

5. the stones of the lot

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Of the King the Houses Made

LE 125 – 211

I

Of Two Lines in One Book

At Cathair dhearg in LE 125 King Ragnall mac Raghnaill died in his eightieth year, and Leabhar a' Chùraim¹ gave him, as it had given his father before him, a single line: the name, the year, and no more. His son Ìomhar mac Raghnaill was crowned in the same hall the same season, three-and-thirty years old and already the father of a boy of his own, and it is told that the old men of the court, remembering the father's crowning three-and-thirty years before, said there was little to choose between the two days beyond the faces, the same silver cup passed from hand to hand and the same oath said in the same words over it. The reign that followed was long and it was quiet, and a quiet reign, as the harbour scribes of the west coast had already learned to say of Ragnall mac Uilleim's, is the kind that leaves the least for any book to hold.

Yet the years were not empty, only unhurried, and a teller who wishes to be honest with them must find room for what filled them, small as it was beside a crowning or a death. At Muileann chiar, where a seam of silver had been worked since An Aois Naomh² within four families who called themselves the smiths of the seam, LE 149 saw the fellowship's oldest craft turned at last to a use beyond its own trade: rings of the pale metal, broad enough to sit close about the throat,

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the Holy Age

beaten out for the heads of Na Seachd Taighean³ to wear at Taigh na Fèithe⁴ and at An Talla Dearg⁵ alike, so that a stranger new to the court might know a custodian from any other lord by the collar at his neck before a word was said. Inis mhòr in the north, in those same years, put barges on the Abhainn ghorm to carry its grain down to Caol bheag and along the coast to Cnoc bheag, sewn-plank boats of the old pattern that never lay a night out of sight of land, for no one on the island since the fleet had wished to be out of sight of it; and it is told that a boy of Inis mhòr, watching the first barge loaded, asked his father why a boat so laden should not simply go the shorter way across open water, and got for his answer only a look, and no word at all.

In LE 156 a coughing sickness ran through Caol fhiadhaich on the south-west coast and killed some ten of its people before it burned itself out, fewer than a hard winter alone might have taken, and the reeve of that shore held, afterward, that it was the shared meal kept through the whole of the sickness, every household eating at the one board rather than shutting its door against its neighbours, that had kept the number so small. It is told that the reeve's own wife was the first to fall sick, and that she herself would not let her own door be barred against the board, saying that a household that ate apart out of fear would go on eating apart long after the fear had any cause, and that a shore so small could not afford the habit. She lived, and the custom lived after her: the board was still shared at Caol fhiadhaich, sickness in the shore or none, when the cough was remembered by no one but the reeve's own book, and it is told there, in a hand grown old, that the meal had by then outlived the memory of why it was ever begun.

Whether the meal or the mercy of the season deserved the credit for how few the cough took, no one at Caol fhiadhaich troubled to settle, holding that a shore glad of its own dead being few had better things to spend its arguing on than the reason for it.

It is in the leaves of Taigh na Fèithe, not An Talla Dearg's, that the fullest word of those years is kept, for Ìomhar's own reign left the crown's scribes little to enter beyond the ordinary turning of the shires, while the custodians of Muileann dhearg went on measuring the handful, hearth by hearth, exactly as Fionnlagh Dall had first measured it, Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁶ untouched by a change of king

3. the seven houses of custody

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

5. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

6. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

any more than the tide is touched by one. The scribe who kept those leaves after old Donnchadh mac Thormoid — a younger cousin of his own line, trained at Donnchadh's own elbow in his last years and given the boards on his death — wrote of King Ìomhar chiefly that he came up to the mountain twice in every year to see the galleries walked and the measures sealed, as the kings of his line had done since Beathag's day, and asked, each time he came, after the health of whichever house's head happened to be standing nearest him, a small courtesy that cost him nothing and that more than one house remembered of him long after they had forgotten anything else he had ever said or done.

He is remembered at Muileann dhearg, too, for one habit no king before or after him is recorded as keeping: he would stand at the mouth of whichever gallery was being walked that day and ask the youngest hand present, whether a bound child of seven years or a journeyman of twenty, to name for him the parts of the working he could see from where he stood, the prop, the cut, the tally-mark on the wall showing how far that season's measure had already gone. Some of the custodians thought it a king's idle amusement and no more; Taigh na Fèithe's own scribe, who watched him do it a dozen times across as many years, wrote once that it seemed to him less amusement than a kind of counting of his own, a king who had no child to leave the hall to making certain, gallery by gallery, that the hands who would go on working it after him at least knew what they held in them. He never said as much himself, and no one thought, while he lived, to ask him.

II

Of a Boy at Baile Mòr dhomhain

Fearchar mac Lachlainn was born in the house of Clann Fhearchair at Baile Mòr dhomhain, the elder son, and yet the one who, by every reckoning his own family made in his boyhood, was least likely ever to be asked to carry anything heavier than his own name. His younger brother Iain was the one their father set, from the time either of them could walk, to keep the house's hall when he should be gone; Fearchar was given instead to Taigh na Fèithe's own custom, a boy's seven years bound to a custodian's household to learn the galleries and the

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

measures as every child of Na Seachd Taighean² was meant to learn them, whether or not he was ever to sit at the head of his own table. He came home from that binding at fourteen knowing the weight of a sealed measure by its heft alone and the sound a gallery makes when its timbering has begun, quietly, to fail, knowledge that served him, in the years that followed, rather better than anyone in his own house had thought to expect it would.

He kept, into his own old age, one memory of those seven years that he told often enough to his own children that it passed down in the house of Clann Fhearchair as a small story of its own: a night in his eleventh year when the custodian he was bound to woke every hand in the gallery, the boy among them, because a timber had begun to sing, a low steady note none of the older men could place until the custodian herself set her ear against the wood and named it, and had the whole gallery cleared before the prop gave way an hour later with no one beneath it. Fearchar remembered standing outside in the cold with the other bound children, none of them told plainly what the noise had meant, and understanding all the same, from the set of the grown faces around him, that the vein answered to more than a measure and a season, and that a house's right to the coal was worth exactly as much as the care the house put into listening for what the coal had to say. It was a lesson, he used to tell his own sons afterward, that no crown he ever wore taught him any better than a mountain gallery had taught a boy of eleven standing in the dark.

He was seven years old, by his own later telling, when word came to Baile Mòr dhomhain that Am Buabhall Fortanach, the old road-house on the mountain road, had burned to its footings in LE 164, and that its keeper Eilidh nic Chaluim meant to raise it again in stone rather than in the timber it had always stood in before. He remembered, or believed he remembered, riding out with his father to see the new walls going up, and being given, by Eilidh herself, a bowl of the jugged buffalo the house was already known for before its own roof was finished, and thinking, as a boy of seven thinks of such things, that a house built to outlast fire was a fine thing for a man to leave behind him, better than a crown, which he had not then any reason to think about at all.

Thirteen years old, Fearchar heard his father's letters tell the house of Clann Fhearchair that King Ìomhar's only son, Ragnall Beag, had died of a fever at Cathair dhearg, a boy not much older than himself, and he remembered his father

2. the seven houses of custody

saying, low, over the letter, that a king with no other child was a house with one wall standing, and that the wind would find it sooner or later whatever anyone did. Fearchar did not understand, at thirteen, what his father meant by it, and did not ask, judging correctly enough that a boy who asked too many questions of a letter that troubled his elders was likely to be sent from the room before he got an answer.

The spirit-house the keepers of Na Seann Spioradan³ raised at Dùn ìseal in LE 179, where the dead of the eastern shires had their names cut new on wooden posts each generation as the old posts rotted away, was a thing Fearchar came to know only at second hand, for Baile Mòr dhomhain kept its own dead by its own older custom and sent no names east to be cut on another shire's posts; but it is told that he visited it once as a young man, on a journey with his father to the eastern coast, and stood a long while before the posts reading names he knew nothing of, and said afterward only that a shire that cut its dead's names in wood rather than stone must trust its own memory further than he would care to trust his.

He was three-and-twenty, newly married and settled to what he believed would be the whole of his life, keeping his own small share of his house's galleries and answering to his brother Iain in every matter that touched the hall, when word reached Baile Mòr dhomhain in LE 180 that King Ìomhar mac Raghnaill had died at Cathair dhearg with no living child, the line that ran back through Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill and the queen who had neither sent her sister nor kept her ended in a single sentence in Leabhar a' Chùrainn⁴, and that the heads of Na Seachd Taighean were summoned to the capital to choose, for the first time since An Diosal⁵, a king the crown's own blood had not simply handed down to them.

III

Of the Silences in the Yard

Iain went up to Cathair dhearg as the head of Clann Fhearchair's own house, for their father was three years dead by then and had named him to the headship, and Fearchar went with him only as an elder brother who kept the gal-

3. the Old Spirits

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

5. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

leries and had no more claim on the meeting than any other custodian. He remembered the yard of An Talla Dearg¹ as smaller than he had pictured it from his father's tellings, and colder, the seven neck-rings of Muileann chiar catching what little sun there was as the heads stood in a loose ring about the well and said, for the better part of a morning, nothing at all that any of them could afterward be brought to repeat in full.

It was the head of Clann Ìomhair who broke the silence first, saying only that the line of Beathag had held the hall a hundred years and more and that no house among the seven had any better claim to it than another, which was less an argument for any one name than a plain statement that the argument, once begun, would not end quickly; and it was the head of Clann Mhuirich, the oldest of the seven present and the one whose own house had given most of Coimheadaichean na Lasrach² in An Aois Naomh³, who said, after a further silence, that a hall so long kept by inheritance might do better kept, this once, by choosing, since a house chosen rather than born to the crown would know from its first day what it owed the six that had chosen it. No one answered her directly, but the silence that followed her words was of a different kind than the one before it, and Iain, standing at his brother's shoulder, felt the meeting turn, though he could not afterward have said on what hinge.

They spoke Iain's own name before the day was out, as head of a house whose galleries ran deep and whose dealings with the other six had never once, in living memory, come to open quarrel, and it was Iain himself who turned it aside, saying plainly that a man who kept one house's hall well enough might yet keep a kingdom's poorly, and that he for one would rather be remembered as a fair head of Clann Fhearchair than a middling king of Dia-thìr. A murmur went round the ring at that, less agreement than the sound seven tired people make when a hard morning has at last produced one sentence plain enough to hold onto, and it was into that murmur that Iain named his own brother, standing beside him in the yard with nothing to say for himself, a custodian of no particular note who had spent his own seven years among the galleries and knew, better than any man born to a hall, what Taigh na Fèithe⁴ asked of the houses that answered to it.

Fearchair felt every face in the ring turn to him at once, and remembered afterward that his first thought, before fear or refusal or any grander feeling had time

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the Keepers of the Hall; lit. 'the watchers of the flame'

3. the Holy Age

to reach him, was a plain wish that he had worn a better coat, having ridden up from Baile Mòr dhomhain expecting nothing of the day beyond standing at his brother's shoulder and going home again unremarked. The head of Clann Raghnaill, a broad man with a scar across one brow who had said nothing at all until then, asked him outright, in the flat way of a custodian asking after a season's measure, whether he could read a gallery's timbering by ear, and Fearchar, too startled to judge whether the question was mockery or something else, answered honestly that he could, or had been able to once, as a bound child, and had had no cause since to test whether the ear for it stayed with a man once his seven years were done. It is told that the head of Clann Raghnaill said nothing further to that, only nodded once, as a custodian nods when an answer has satisfied a question he did not trouble to explain the reason for asking.

Fearchar's own account of what followed, given years later to his son and kept in the family's own memory rather than in any leaf of *Taigh na Fèithe*, was that he tried three times to refuse before the heads would hear him refused, saying first that he was a younger son with no training for a hall, then that his own house had a better claim in his brother, and last, when neither answer moved them, that he did not want the thing, which he judged, and rightly, to be the one argument likeliest to move seven heads who had spent a whole morning weighing a crown too heavy for any one house to want alone. It was the head of Clann Mhuirich who answered that last refusal, saying that a man who did not want the crown was, of the men in that yard, the only kind she would trust to wear it, and it is told that no one spoke again after she had said it, the seven neck-rings catching the last of the light as the heads, one after another, bent their own heads to a man who had not asked to be chosen and could give them no better reason to choose him than that he had not asked.

He was crowned at Cathair dhearg in 19 an Gearran, LE 182, five-and-twenty years old, the first king in Leabhar a' Chùrain⁵'s own memory set on the hall by Na Seachd Taighean⁶ standing in a cold yard until their silence turned, of its own weight, into a name, rather than by the blood of the hall before him. No silver cup was found ready for the rite, the last having been put away at Ìomhar's death with no clear order for its keeping, and it is told that the head of Clann Mhuirich sent a servant running to her own lodging for the cup her own house kept, a

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

5. the custody-book of the vein-house

6. the seven houses of custody

plainer vessel than the crown's own would have been, so that Fearchar mac Lachlainn drank his first oath as king from a cup that belonged, strictly, to none of Na Seachd Taighean and to one of them alone, a small confusion no one thought worth correcting once the oath was said.

IV

Of the Double Court

he kept the crown nine-and-twenty years, and it is told at Baile Mòr dhomhain, though seldom at An Talla Dearg¹, that he never once in all those years stopped thinking of himself as a custodian who happened to sit a throne rather than a king who happened to know the galleries. He divided his court from the second year of his reign, keeping the greater part of each year at Cathair dhearg as every crowned ruler before him had done, and a lesser part at Baile Mòr dhomhain among his own house and within an easy ride of Taigh na Fèithe², so that no matter that touched the coal need wait on a rider's journey to reach him. The double court settled, by LE 194, into a custom his own house kept for as long as it held the crown, and it was Iain who kept Clann Fhearchair's hall at Baile Mòr dhomhain whenever the court was away at the capital, a headship within a headship that suited him, by his own account, a great deal better than a crown ever would have. The two brothers wrote to one another through every season of the division, letters that a later hand at Baile Mòr dhomhain gathered and kept as one leaf-book rather than let scatter through the house's leaves, and it is from those letters, more than from anything An Talla Dearg's own scribes set down, that the plainer texture of the reign is known: a dispute over a boundary stone between two shires settled by Fearchar in three lines and referred back to Iain to see enforced; a petition from a widow of Muileann dhearg for a second season's measure after a bad year, granted; a complaint, more than once repeated in Iain's own hand, that the capital's cooks put too much salt in a dish that had never wanted it at Baile Mòr dhomhain, over which the two brothers seem to have corresponded at greater length than over any single matter of the coal in the whole of the reign.

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Fishers of Àth fhiadhaich, on the eastern coast, joined in one fellowship in LE 209 after a season of losses no single household could carry alone, three boats lost in one autumn's weather and two households left with neither boat nor the timber to build another, sharing boats and nets thereafter among families who had fished the same waters apart from one another for longer than any of them could say why. A fisherman of that shore, sent up to Baile Mòr dhomhain the following spring on some ordinary errand of tribute, was brought before the old king almost by accident, the household he lodged with having mentioned, in passing, that he came from the coast where the new fellowship had lately been made, and Fearchar kept him a full hour asking after the manner of it: how the boats were shared, whose name a catch was entered under, what was done when one household's boat failed and another's held. The fisherman, by his own account given, years afterward, to his own grandchildren, had expected a king's questions to be grander than a fellowship's own accounting, and found himself instead answering much the same questions any custodian might have asked of a gallery's sharing among Na Seachd Taighean³, and it was only riding home that it came to him what the old king had truly been asking after all along: the fellowship, and whether a thing built from loss could be trusted to hold once the loss was forgotten.

The founding was read out, when word of it first reached Baile Mòr dhomhain, as a small thing beside the coal and the crown, though Fearchar himself is said to have remarked, after that hour with the fisherman, that a fellowship made from loss rather than plenty was likely to outlast one made the easier way, having already proved, before it was a year old, that its members would stand by one another when standing by one another cost something. It was a saying his own house kept after him, said sometimes of the coal-right when Na Seachd Taighean' own dealings grew strained, though never, so far as the leaf-book records, in his own hearing.

He grew old at the work slowly and without complaint, riding between his two halls until the riding grew hard, and in his last years he kept, more than any other habit of his reign, the one he had carried up from his own boyhood among the galleries: he went on asking the youngest hand at any working he visited to name what stood before him, prop and cut and tally-mark, though by then his own knees would no longer let him crouch at a gallery's mouth to hear the answer, and a custodian would crouch for him and repeat the child's words up into

3. the seven houses of custody

the light. His own son Fearchar Donn, brought to the mountain young as his father had been, was asked the same question at seven years old as every other bound child was asked it, and gave, by the account kept at Muileann dhearg, an answer no better and no worse than any other child's, which the old king is said to have called, laughing, the first honestly ordinary thing his own house had produced in two reigns.

He died, in the end, at Baile Mòr dhomhain in LE 211, among his own house rather than at An Talla Dearg, four-and-fifty years old, his brother Iain at his bedside and his own son, called Fearchar Donn for the colour of his hair, already a grown man ready to take the hall without dispute from any of the seven. He asked, in his last days, that no coal be burned beyond the ordinary handful for any rite made over him, saying that a custodian who had spent a lifetime measuring the vein for other households had no wish to be measured out of it more generously than any tenant of his own galleries would be, and Taigh na Fèithe kept the asking to the letter, so that the fire lit for the old king's own rite was, by every account, no larger than the fire any house of the seven lit for its own dead that same season. They buried him, as his own father had been buried, in the ground of Clann Fhearchair rather than in any royal tomb at the capital, and it is told that Na Seachd Taighean sent their heads to stand at the grave, each still wearing the neck-ring of Muileann chiar his own house had worn since before Fearchar was crowned, and that not one of them, in the whole of the burying, was heard to say that the choosing made in that cold yard nine-and-twenty years before had been anything other than the right one. Fearchar Donn was crowned at Cathair dhearg within the season, without dispute from any house, the first son to follow a father the houses themselves had made, and so the crown, having once been chosen rather than inherited, went back, as if it had never left it, to the plainer road of a son following a father into the hall.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

OF the Hawk of Acaill

LE 215 – 251

I

Of the Glove at Cnoc bheag

At Cnoc bheag, up the river from the coast where the dawn-hawk rite of An Aois Naomh¹ had been kept without a break since before the fleet, the mews stood on the shoulder of the hill above the shrine, and the keeping of it had passed, as far back as anyone at Cnoc bheag could say, from father to child and never once to a stranger. Artair had kept it since before his own daughter was born, and by the time this telling opens he was five-and-sixty years old and had kept it the better part of his life, his hands grown too stiff in the cold mornings to knot a jess without help and his knees no longer equal to the climb from the shrine to the mews block before first light. His daughter Gormshuil climbed it for him now, most mornings, and had done since she was a girl old enough to carry a hawk on her own wrist without her arm shaking, though it was still Artair, sitting on the bench below with a blanket over his knees, who called up which bird was to fly and in what order, as his own father had called it up to him.

The shrine below the mews was a plain thing, a ring of standing stones no higher than a man's shoulder about a bare patch of turf worn down to the earth by feet, with a single stone taller than the rest set at the eastern edge for the sun to clear before the flying began. It drew, in the ordinary way of things, the households of the hill and the river-bend below it, coal-cutters and their wives come up before the day's work to stand in the cold and watch a bird cross the grey sky and come back to a glove, and go down again to their fires no wiser for it than they

1. the Holy Age

had come, save that a morning begun at the shrine was reckoned, by long custom, a morning less likely to end badly. Gormshuil had known most of those faces her whole life, and could have named, without troubling to think, which households sent their eldest daughter to watch and which sent a servant in their place, and what each family's coal-right at Taigh na Fèithe² came to that season, for the talk on the shrine's ledge before the flying ran as often to the size of the next handful as to the bird.

It was a young bird, not yet a full year in the mews, that gave them the lesson Gormshuil would carry the rest of her life, though neither of them thought it more than a bad morning at the time. A novice keeper new to the mews that season, eager to see the bird fly well before the rite's watchers, had fed it heavy the evening before, thinking a full crop would make for a calm bird and a steady flight. It made instead a bird that sat on the block at first light with its feathers loose and its eye half shut, and when Gormshuil raised her glove and called it, it looked at her, and looked away, and would not come. She called it twice more. The third time Artair, without being asked, said from the bench below that there was no use calling a bird that had already eaten its fill of the day before it began, and that she might as well save her wrist and let it sit.

"It will not fly hungry either," said the novice, red in the face, thinking he was being corrected for a fault rather than told a fact. "I have seen a starved one snap at the glove."

"You have seen right," Artair said, "and wrong in the same breath, which is the whole trouble with hawks and most other things besides. Feed it too little and it turns on the hand that starves it. Feed it too much and it will not leave the hand at all. There is one measure between the two, and it is not a wide one, and it is not the same for every bird or every morning, which is why the keeping of it is a craft and not a rule a man could write once and be done with." He looked up at his daughter, who still stood with her arm out and the sullen bird ignoring her. "Bring it down and don't fly it today. Let the novice sit with it and learn its crop by his own eye instead of by his fear of being wrong in front of the shrine."

Gormshuil brought the bird down, and said nothing at the time of what her father had said, turning it over instead in the weeks that followed the way a person turns over any true thing said carelessly, testing it against other true things until it either breaks or holds. It held. She had grown up hearing the shrine's telling that

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

the hawk of the dawn rite was no common bird of the mews but stood for one far older, one the keepers before her father's father's father had called Mòd, and said to be as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, eldest of men, who remembered all things with him from before there was a shrine to keep or a mews to keep it in; she had heard that telling so often it had worn as smooth in her mind as a step worn hollow by feet, a thing repeated rather than thought. It was her father's plain word about a young bird's crop, not the old telling, that first made her think hard about the measure rather than the bird that carried it.

Three years on, Artair's knees had failed him for the climb entirely, and it was Gormshuil, not the novice nor any other keeper of the mews, who went up alone in the grey before dawn and called Mòd down from the block for the first time with no one but herself to answer for the flight. She was three-and-thirty years old that morning, by her own later count, and she would say afterward, to the few who asked her directly, that she had gone up frightened of the bird and come down frightened of something else, though she was slow for a long while to say what. Her father, watching from the bench with his blanket over his knees, said only, when she came down to him, that Mòd had flown as well for her as for any keeper he had watched in a long life, and that a bird cared nothing at all for whose wrist it left so long as the wrist knew the measure, which was the last thing of any weight he told her before his own strength failed him further and his talk turned, as an old man's talk will, to smaller things: the weather, the state of the mews roof, whether the novice keeper had learned yet to judge a crop by his own eye instead of by fright.

II

Of the Empty Perch

Artair died at Cnoc bheag five years after the morning of the overfed bird, in his own bed above the shrine with his daughter beside him, three-score and ten years old, and the mews he had kept the better part of his life passed to Gormshuil without dispute, as it had passed to him and to his father before that. They buried him on the hillside above the mews, in the plain way the hill's own households buried their dead, wrapped in undyed cloth and laid with his face to the shrine rather than to any house of the departed the coast might have kept for him, since a keeper of the mews was reckoned, on that hill, to be-

long to the birds and the standing stones before he belonged to any other rite. The coal-cutters and their wives who had stood so many mornings on the shrine's ledge came up in numbers greater than the ledge had ever held for a living rite, and it was noted afterward, by those who noted such things, that not one household of the hill sent a servant in its own stead that day.

The shrine kept its rite the morning after his burying as it kept it every morning, because a rite that stops for a death is a rite that will stop again for the next one, and Gormshuil went up to the block in the grey light with her father not two days in the ground and called Mòd down herself, dry-eyed at the flying and not dry-eyed after it, alone on the hillside where no one from the shrine below could see her face.

It was in the weeks of her mourning, when the watchers who came to the shrine asked her, as was the custom, to say a few words over her father's empty place on the bench, that she first put into open speech what she had turned over quietly since the overfed bird. She told them her father's plain word about the measure, and then, because the watchers waited for more and she found she had more to give them, she told them that the hawk of the rite was Mòd himself, old as Fionntan mac Bòchra and remembering with him all that the island had forgotten of its own beginning, and that the vein under Muileann dhearg, which fed every hearth on the island its handful and no more, was a hawk of that same kind: a hungry hawk, to be fed the measured handful and starved of nothing it truly needed, but never once glutted past what the giving hand could spare. A hawk overfed will not hunt, she told them, and a hawk starved will turn on the hand that starves it, and the keeping of the measure between the two was not a rule written once at Taigh na Fèithe¹ and left to stand, any more than a bird's crop could be judged once and trusted for every morning after. It wanted watching, the way her father had watched it, all his life and to the day his knees gave out under him.

The watchers who heard her that first time were mostly her father's own people, keepers and their households who had come to the shrine for years and would have listened to Gormshuil nic Artair out of long habit whatever she had said over the empty bench. But she said the same thing again the next season, and the one after, shaping it a little further each time without changing what stood at the centre of it, and it began, in the slow way such things begin, to be spoken of

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

beyond the shrine's own households, still nameless as a teaching, only a thing the hawk-keeper's daughter at Cnoc bheag said over the bird, worth a morning's walk to hear for oneself.

III

Of Those Who Came to Hear

Word of it reached the north coast before it reached the capital, carried, as such things were carried on the island, by the ordinary business of trade rather than by any messenger sent for the purpose: a wool-buyer of Bàgh an t-Seabhaig¹ who had business at Cnoc bheag over a debt of hides heard Gormshuil speak one dawn while he waited for the shrine's steward to finish the shrine's own accounts, and carried the telling home with the hides, embroidering it a little in the carrying as such tellings are embroidered, so that by the time it reached the hawk-keepers of the coast it had already begun to sound less like a woman's plain word over her father's empty seat and more like a teaching worth sending someone to hear at first hand. Three keepers of the coastal shrines came inland that same year to judge it for themselves, and stayed a week, sleeping in the mews steward's own house and rising each dawn to stand at the back of the shrine's ledge among the coal-cutters' wives, saying little until the week was nearly out. The eldest of the three, a woman near Gormshuil's own age who had kept a shrine on Bàgh an t-Seabhaig since before Gormshuil was a hawk-keeper's daughter at all, asked her on the last morning whether she had ever herself gone hungry enough to know the second half of what she taught, or only ever watched a bird do it for her. Gormshuil answered that she had gone hungry twice in her life that she counted, once as a child in a hard winter and once the week her father died, and that she had disliked the lesson both times and kept it both times besides, which the elder judged, after turning it over a moment, answer enough. The three went home saying the teaching had lost nothing in the carrying after all, which was unusual enough to be remembered on its own account.

Within a few years more, and without Taigh na Fèithe²'s own scribes troubling themselves over what was said at a hillside shrine two days' walk from the capital,

1. the Hawk bay

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

the watchers who climbed to Cnoc bheag for the dawn rite had grown from the handful of her father's own households to a congregation the shrine's ledge could no longer easily hold, and Gormshuil, who had never asked to be more than her father's daughter keeping her father's mews, found herself asked, more mornings than not, to say the teaching whole rather than in the pieces it had first come out in. She gathered it, in the end, into the shape it would keep for the rest of her life and after it: that Mòd, Seabhag Acaill³, was old as Fionntan mac Bòchra and remembered with him what the island no longer remembered of its own first years; that every hearth's coal was a feeding of An Seabhag Acrach⁴ beneath the mountain, owed the measured handful and no more; and that the craft of keeping the measure, in a mews or at a vein-house both, was a watching that wanted doing fresh each time, never a law fixed once for every morning after, just as her father had watched a young bird's crop rather than trust a rule written the year before.

Those who heard the teaching whole, gathered under one roof rather than caught in pieces on the shrine's ledge, called themselves before long a house rather than a congregation, and in LE 229 they set about raising one: a low hall of timber and dry stone below the mews block, roofed before the following winter, that took the name Taigh an t-Seabhaig⁵, the house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁶, and gave the old dawn-hawk rite of Cnoc bheag, for the first time in its long keeping, a hall of its own rather than an open hillside and a shrine ledge worn hollow by generations of standing feet. Gormshuil kept the mews as she always had, and kept the house besides, though she said, more than once to those close enough to hear her say it, that she would rather have gone on calling Mòd down to an empty hillside than to a hall full of watchers waiting for her to speak, and was believed by those who knew her, and not quite believed by those who did not.

IV

Of the House at Ros gheal and the Flood at Seann Vell

The teaching did not stay at Cnoc bheag. Among the watchers who had climbed the hill in the years the house was building were two of

3. the Hawk of Acaill, whom the Hawk order calls Mòd

4. the Hungry Hawk

5. the house of the Hawk

6. the Hawk order

Gormshuil's own pupils, a brother and sister of a coastal household at Ros gheal, who asked her leave to carry the dawn rite down to the shore rather than make every fisher's family of that coast walk two days inland to hear it. She gave them the leave, and something more besides: she went down to Ros gheal herself in LE 239, the season the second house was raised, to see the first rite kept there and to judge, as her father had once judged a young bird's crop by his own eye, whether the teaching had travelled whole or had thinned on the road the way a telling carried by a wool-buyer will thin. The rite at Ros gheal was kept on a spit of rock above the tide-line rather than a hillside turf, its ring of stones half salt-eaten already, and a wind off the sea made the hawk's flight a shorter, harder thing than the still air of Cnoc bheag's morning; the fishers who stood at the ledge there smelled of net-tar and brine rather than of coal-smoke, and asked the pupils, when the flying was done, after the size of the season's catch rather than the size of any hearth's handful. Gormshuil judged the teaching had travelled whole enough for all that, though the sea air and the salt-caked stone of the coast gave it a harder edge than the hillside's had, and she came home content to let the house at Ros gheal keep its own measure of it rather than ask it back to Cnoc bheag word for word. Between the two houses, her pupils took on the country that lay between the coast and the hill, so that a shire that had once sent every dying hearth's household two days inland for the rite could now walk half a day to the shore instead.

It was a pupil of the Ros gheal house who brought her, some years after, the report she remembered longest of any that reached her at Cnoc bheag, though she had no part in the flood and never travelled far enough south-east to see it with her own eyes. In LE 244, a wet spring, the river at Seann Vell, far off on the south-east coast, rose in a night past every bank the mill-wrights had trusted, and carried the lower mills of that town away whole, wheel and stone and all, so that the millers of Seann Vell had to build again on the higher ground the following season, cursing, as millers everywhere curse, a river that had kept its banks faithfully for longer than any living miller could remember and chose that one wet spring to break them. The pupil who brought the report to Cnoc bheag had gone to Seann Vell on other business and stood on the higher bank himself, watching the new mills go up, and he told Gormshuil, half in earnest and half hoping to please her, that the flood was a kind of overfed hawk: a river fed too full too fast, turning on the hand that had trusted it. She heard him out, and told him plainly, in front of the others who had gathered to hear the report, that a river was a river and not a

hawk, and that a teaching stretched to cover every misfortune under the sky stopped, before long, covering anything at all; a keeper who saw the measure in a hawk's crop and nowhere else had understood it better than one who saw it everywhere and had therefore, in the end, seen it nowhere. It was remembered afterward, among her own pupils, as one of the harder things she ever said to a young man trying to flatter her, and one of the truer. She sent him back to Seann Vell before the season turned, not with any correction to carry to the millers, who wanted none, but with a plain instruction to stand a while longer on the higher bank and watch how the new mills were set before he judged a whole river by one wet spring; he went, and came back the following year saying only that the wheels turned as well on the higher ground as they ever had on the lower, which she thought, though she did not say so to him, the better report of the two.

V

Of the Marked Sayings

Gormshuil kept the mews and the house both into her own old age, calling Mòd down from the block most mornings until her hands, like her father's before her, grew too stiff for the climb, and after that sitting on the bench below where her father had once sat, watching a younger keeper fly the bird and saying, when she was asked, no more and no less than the measure wanted. She grew, in those last years, sparer of speech than she had been as a younger woman gathering the teaching into its shape, as though she had come to trust that the shape once given would hold its own weight without her standing over it every dawn to prop it up, and those who sat with her on the bench in the cold remembered her as often silent as speaking, watching the flight with the same close, unhurried eye her father had once turned on a young bird's crop.

She died at Cnoc bheag, two-and-sixty years old, in the same season the house at Ros gheal marked its own eighth year, and was buried, at her own asking made long before, on the open hillside above it, beside her father, rather than within the new hall she had raised, where the dawn rite had been kept before there was any roof over it at all.

Among those who had sat longest at her teaching was a young man of the house named Ùisdean mac Pàdraig, who had come to Cnoc bheag as a boy to be apprenticed to the mews and stayed to be apprenticed, in the end, more to the

teaching than to the birds. It fell to him, in the years after her death, to gather what she had said into a single book, so that a teaching that had travelled by wool-buyers and pupils and half-remembered reports for thirty years might be kept in one hand rather than scattered across every household that had ever heard her speak. He set himself, before he wrote a word of it down, one rule he never afterward broke: that every saying he set on the leaf without having heard it from her own mouth would be marked as such, plainly, so that no reader coming after him would mistake another keeper's memory of her for his own. To fill the book at all he had to travel further than he had ever travelled in her lifetime, down to the salt-eaten shrine at Ros gheal and along the country between it and the hill, sitting with pupils grown old themselves now and asking them, patiently, to give him back word for word what they remembered her saying, and marking, more often than not, that two households a day's walk apart remembered the same saying in two different shapes, so that he was left to choose which shape to set down and mark the choice as his own rather than hers. He kept the rule to the letter for all that, and when the book was finished the marked sayings, gathered from every house and shire the teaching had reached in her lifetime, far outnumbered the few he had heard for himself, standing at the bench below the mews block on mornings when he was too young to know he was hearing anything worth marking at all.

He finished the book in LE 251 and called it *Leabhar an t-Seabhaig*¹, and set at its head, before any of the sayings he had gathered from other hands, the one he had heard himself, standing below the block on an ordinary morning with the mews still smelling of the night's straw and Gormshuil's voice carrying down to him no louder than she needed it to carry, the whole of the teaching folded, as she had once folded her father's plain word about a young bird's crop, into a single line short enough for a child to carry home unbroken:

Beathaich an seabhag, ach na sàsaich e. Feed the hawk, but do not glut him.

1. the Book of the Hawk

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

OF the Firloṭ of Cathair dhearg

LE 254 – 289

I

Of the Girl Who Counted the Baskets

Sileas nic Fhearchair was eleven years old when she first understood that a king's word was only as good as the thing it was measured against. She stood that day at her father's elbow in the market below An Talla Dearg¹ at Cathair dhearg, where two women had come near to blows over a basket of barley. One swore it held its full weight; the other swore it did not, and that she had been cheated by the same basket twice before at the same stall. King Fearchar Donn, grown heavy and slow with age by then and disliking to be drawn from his hall for such things, sent a steward to weigh the grain against the palace's own measure and settle it. The steward came back and said the baskets did not agree: the market's was smaller than the hall's by the width of two fingers across the rim, and had been for longer than anyone selling there could remember.

"Then whose is the true one?" Sileas asked, before anyone had thought to ask it of her.

Her father laughed, not unkindly, and said that was a question for men older than either of them, and led her away by the hand. She did not forget it. That night at supper she asked him again, in front of the steward, whether the market's basket or the hall's was the true one, and the steward answered that the hall's was, being the elder measure, and her father said only that it hardly mattered which

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

was elder so long as folk agreed on one, and went back to his meat. She turned the two answers over in her head for days, the steward's and her father's, and could not make them into a single thought, and kept trying anyway, for she was a child who did not like leaving a thing half understood.

She was a quiet child, given to watching rather than speaking, and the court took her silences for shyness until it learned better. Her mother had died birthing her; the one brother she had been born after had died a child, and she had no sister, only her father's slow decline and the hall full of men who spoke over her head as though she were a stool set in the wrong place. She learned early to sit very still at the edge of a council and be forgotten, and to carry away afterward more of what had been said than any of the men who had said it would have credited a girl of her years with keeping.

Fearchar Donn had reigned since he was a young man, son of the first king the custodian houses ever chose, and he wore his last years like a coat too heavy for the season. His last ride north to Muileann dhearg, to see Taigh na Fèithe's² winter burning as every king before him had gone at least once, fell in his fifty-ninth year, and he never made the ride again. He sat in An Talla Dearg and let the shires send their disputes to him on skins and boards, and answered them slower each year, until the answers came so slow that the shires had generally settled the matter themselves before the king's word reached them.

In the spring of LE 256 he took to his bed with a cough that would not leave his chest, and did not rise from it again. Sileas sat with him through the worst of it, thirteen years old, dry-eyed because she had already grieved him in pieces over the preceding years and had none left to spend on the last of him. He died in the month of Bealltach, sixty-eight years old, and was carried up to be laid among the kings at the burying-ground behind the hall.

She was not crowned that year, nor the next. The custom the houses kept, and had kept since the choosing that made her grandfather's line, held that no one too young to be answered for their own oath should be crowned to make one, and thirteen was reckoned too young. The heads of the seven custodian houses, who had sworn to keep the vein and the right to it in the year of an Tùrsa Geal³, took it in turn to sit the hall in her name, a month at a time, and quarrelled among themselves over which of their number should have her ear. She learned in those two

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

years to tell a man's true business from the business he gave as his reason for coming, and she learned it well, for she had nothing else to do but listen.

II

Of the Crowning at Fifteen

She was crowned in the moon of Damhrach, LE 258, fifteen years old, in the same hall where her father had died and his father before him. The cup that was passed hand to hand at a crowning was old beyond any teller's naming of it, worn thin at the lip where generations of royal mouths had touched it, and the oath said over it was the same oath, word for word, that had been said over Fearchar mac Lachlainn when the houses chose him. Sileas said it in a clear voice that carried to the back of the hall, and an old woman near the door, who had heard four crownings in her life, said afterward that the girl's voice had not shaken at all, which the old woman took for a good sign and was not wrong to.

She did not weep, and she did not smile. She took the cup, drank from it, and handed it on, and the heads of Na Seachd Taighean¹ came forward one by one and put their hands between hers and swore to hold the vein and its right as it had always been held. Their faces she watched as they did it, the way she had learned to watch faces in the two years of the regency, and marked which of them meant it and which of them were only saying words that custom required, though she said nothing of what she marked, then or for years after.

That night, alone in the chamber that had been her father's, she found the old market steward's tally of the two baskets, still among his leaves where no one had thought to clear it. She kept it. It was a small thing to keep, a scrap that answered nothing by itself, but she was a girl who kept small things until they came useful, and this one came useful sooner than she expected.

III

Of Am Fuath Mòr and the Hooked Wall

1. the seven houses of custody

In the autumn of her second year crowned, a storm out of the north broke over the harbour of Seann Toll, on the island's north coast, that the fishers there came to call Am Fuath Mòr¹. It came in the black of night with no warning the watch could give, and it took the old harbour wall down in one working of the sea, stone from stone, and with the wall went forty boats at their moorings and eighteen men and women who had gone down in the dark to try to save them. The town buried its dead on the headland above the ruined wall, in a row so long that the reeve who kept the count lost his place twice and had to begin it again.

The reeve was a young man named Raghnaill mac Nèill, thirty-four years old that winter, who had held the office only four years and had never buried so many at once. He had gone down to the strand himself in the worst of the storm, roused by a boy pounding on his door, and had stood in water to his knees hauling on a rope with three other men to bring in a boat with two children still lashed inside it, and had not been quick enough with two more ropes that broke before they were ever thrown. He carried that failure with him the rest of his life and never once, in any letter or telling that survives of him, laid the blame anywhere but on the wall.

That spring he wrote to the capital, not asking for grain or silver, which the crown could ill spare after a hard season, but asking leave to send to the masons who had built the queen's own bridge and ask them what a wall might be built to, that the sea could not take down twice.

Sileas granted it without a council, which some of the older heads thought unqueenly of her, a girl of seventeen deciding a matter of stone and mortar on her own word. She had read Raghnaill's letter twice and noted that it asked for nothing but knowledge, and thought that a request worth granting on its own account. The masons went north and stood a long while on the ruined headland with Raghnaill, turning stones over with their boots and arguing among themselves in a tongue of angles and courses that the fishers standing about could not follow. What they gave him in the end was a plan for a wall built higher than the old one and turned at its outer end in a hook, so that the worst of the sea's push broke against the curve of it and spent itself before it could reach the harbour behind.

It took three years to raise, stone hauled from a quarry two days inland by cart and sled, and every able hand in the town given over to it in the slack months

between one catch and the next. There were those in the town who grumbled that a hook at the wall's end was a strange shape for honest stone, more suited, they said, to a fish-trap than a harbour, and would not believe it until they saw the first winter gale come on and watched the sea's whole strength break against the curve of it and slide away spent, no higher at the harbour's throat than on a calm evening. Ragnall stood on the finished wall the day the last course was set and put his palm flat against the stone, the way a man tests a beast's flank before he trusts it, and it stood through every storm that came after, in his lifetime and long past it.

IV

Of the Walls of Dùn dhearg and a Supper Kept Cold

The same year the mason's plan went north to Seann Toll, Sileas took a consort of her own choosing: Dùghall mac Ìomhair, a young man of the eastern hill-house Clann Ìomhair, whom she had known since the two years of her regency, when his father had sat the hall in her name for one of the twelve months and brought his son along to the capital because there was no one else to leave him with. Dùghall was quiet in a way she found she liked, slow to speak and slower to promise, and where the other heads' sons had courted her with gifts and verses she had never asked for, he had once, in her sixteenth year, simply told her which of the men speaking to her in the hall that day meant what they said and which were only speaking to be seen speaking, and been right about all six. They were married at Cathair dhearg in the month of Faolach, with Na Seachd Taighean¹ heads in attendance and Ragnall mac Nèill's letter about the wall arriving, by chance, the same week, so that the wedding feast and the granting of the masons were spoken of together for a season after, as though one had somehow caused the other. At the feast Dùghall's father rose and made the kind of speech a father makes at such a thing, full of the honour done his house and the long friendship between it and the crown, and Sileas, watching him say it, thought she heard under the honour a note of a man reckoning what the marriage had bought

1. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

1. the seven houses of custody

him, though she could not then have said what she thought he meant to spend it on.

It was not a full year later that word came from the east that Clann Ìomhair had begun to wall their own seat at Dùn dhearg in stone, without asking the crown's leave to do it. No custodian house had raised walls of its own before; the crown had always been asked, if only as a form, and the form had always been granted, but this time no one had asked. Sileas heard it first from a rider and said nothing for the length of a held breath, then asked only how far along the work stood, which told the rider she meant to let it stand rather than to send men to pull it down, though she gave no word either way that day.

She summoned Dùghall's father to An Talla Dearg² that season, on some other business that both of them understood to be a pretext, and had a supper laid for him in the hall's smaller chamber, the one kept for guests who were neither strangers nor quite family. It was a good supper, by every account that survives of it: fowl and barley bread and the last of the summer's fruit, laid out with proper care, and good candles burned rather than the tallow the chamber usually made do with. No one who was in the room that evening ever called it a warm one. Dùghall sat between his wife and his father and said almost nothing through the whole of it, turning his cup on the board without drinking from it, and his father, for his part, ate well and spoke of the roads and the harvest and never once mentioned the stone going up around his own hall, and neither did the queen. Twice the old man asked after her health with a warmth that fooled no one at the table, and twice she answered him with the same warmth, in the same measure, and both of them understood exactly what was being said by everything that was left unsaid.

When the meat was cleared the old man made as if to speak of the roads a third time, and Sileas set down her own cup with enough plainness that he heard it, and asked him instead how the quarrying went at Dùn dhearg, since she had heard the stone there cut cleaner than the stone at Cathair dhearg's own quarries. He allowed that it did. She said she was glad to hear a custodian house so well provided in its own hills that it need trouble the crown for nothing, not even leave, and let the silence that followed sit as long as it wished to. When the old man rose to go, she walked him to the door herself, which was more courtesy than the evening had otherwise shown him, and told him only that a house wise

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

enough to wall itself was wise enough to remember whose land it stood on. He bowed and said nothing to that either, and the walls of Dùn dhearg went up all the same, and stood, and no crown's men were ever sent against them.

V

Of the Quarrel over a Basket

It was in that same year, riding to the market below the hall on some ordinary business she no longer troubled to remember afterward, that Sileas came on a quarrel over a basket that put her in mind of the one she had watched as a child of eleven. She did not get down from the cart. She sat above the crowd and watched a woman selling oats and a farmer buying them come near to open blows over whether the basket between them held what it was sworn to hold, and heard, under the shouting, the same complaint she had heard as a girl: that the baskets of the market were not the baskets of the shire seat, nor the shire seat's the same as the next shire's, and a man might be cheated or might cheat without either party quite meaning it, simply because no two measures on the island agreed.

That same evening she sent for the old steward's tally, the scrap she had kept since her crowning night, and set it beside her on the table while she wrote out, in her own hand, what she meant to do. There would be one measure, and one only, cut to a fixed size and bound in iron so that no season's swelling or shrinking of the wood could cheat it, and copies of it, exact to the width of a finger, sent to every shire seat on the island, so that a basket weighed true at Cathair dhearg would weigh true anywhere a Dia-thìrich stood to sell or buy. She had the first of them made by the capital's own coopers, oak staves bound with three iron hoops, and had her own mark burned into the base of it before it left her hands, so that no one could ever claim a later copy was truer than the standard it was copied from. It went out from Cathair dhearg by cart, one to each shire seat, through the summer and autumn of that year, and the shires came to call it, simply, the firLOT of Cathair dhearg, for they had no other name to give it and needed none.

It did not end every quarrel over a basket; nothing so simple ever does. But within a handful of years a man buying grain a hundred miles from the capital could set his own basket against the shire seat's firLOT and know, without argument, whether he had been cheated or had cheated, and where before the answer

to that question had depended on which of the two disputants shouted longer, it now depended on nothing but the iron-bound oak, which shouted at no one.

The first quarrel it settled outright, and the first that was ever written down as settled by it and nothing else, was at Àth shean, the granary town, some nine years after the firlots went out. A carter and a miller had fallen out over a load of oats, each swearing the other had shorted him, and had gone on swearing it in the open street until the reeve, tired of the noise, sent for the town's firlot and measured the load out in front of both of them and the crowd their shouting had drawn. It came out exact to the mark. The carter, who had been the louder of the two, said nothing further and went home; the miller, more graciously, offered to stand the reeve a cup for his trouble, which the reeve accepted, and the reeve's own account of the day, which survives among the granary's older boards, ends by noting that the whole matter had taken less time to settle than the quarrel itself had taken to shout.

VI

Of the Tally-Houses and the Long City's Market

her son Uisdean was born in the twelfth year of her reign, a quiet, watchful child who watched the court the way she had watched it herself as a girl, and she found she could not decide whether that pleased her or unsettled her, and did not try very hard to decide.

The firlot solved the size of a basket, but it did not solve what a man was owed for what the basket held, and by the twenty-sixth year of her reign she had turned her mind to that harder question. A weaver of the capital might bring cloth to the granary and take grain for it, and swear afterward that the grain given was less than the cloth was worth, and there was nothing but memory and temper to prove either side of it once the goods had changed hands and both parties had gone their ways. She set a tally-house in each of the crown's own granaries, a plain room with a table and a box of hazel sticks, where a clerk sat through the market days and cut a notch for every measure of grain given over for cloth, or salt, or a day's labour on the roads, splitting the stick lengthwise so that each party to the trade kept half and neither half could be altered without it showing against its match. It was the first reckoning of trade that ran the length of the island in one hand, and no coin passed through any of it, for the island had none and did not

yet know it wanted any. A trader from the long city in the south, watching the first sticks cut at the granary of Cathair dhearg, remarked to the clerk that he had never in his life seen a bargain that could not be argued about afterward, and the clerk answered, without looking up from his cutting, that this was rather the point of it. The trader asked what was to stop a man simply cutting a false notch on his own half after the fact; the clerk held up the two halves of a finished stick, showing how the grain of the wood ran unbroken from one to the other only when they were laid together true, and said that a man was welcome to try, and welcome to explain the false cut to whoever held the other half.

The long city was Cathair fhada, on its ridge in the south, and it was there, three years on, that Sileas granted the charter the merchants of that country had been asking for since before her father's day: a market on the ridge at every full moon, with its own tally-house for the trade of the south, so that the honey and hemp and wax and pottery that had gone north by ones and twos, whenever a single trader found the road worth the walking, might now go up together, a company at a time, timed to the moon so that no one need travel the road alone. The first full-moon market was held in the month of Ògach, and drew traders from three days' walk in every direction; the reeve of Cathair fhada, an old woman who had petitioned for the charter longer than anyone else living, stood at the ridge's edge that whole first day and would not be persuaded to sit down, though her family begged her to, saying she had waited twenty years to see it and meant to see all of it standing up.

VII

Of the Bridge

In the one-and-thirtieth year of her reign the old stone bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain at Cathair dhearg, which had stood since before her grandfather's grandfather and had never in living memory been wide enough for two loaded carts to pass each other without one backing to the bank, was widened at last, the masons cutting new stone in against the old so that the join could hardly be told from the road above it. It was, by then, an ordinary kind of work for her to order; she had ordered walls and wharves and granary floors in every shire on the island by that year, and thought little more of a bridge than she thought of any of them.

She rode down to see it finished on a grey morning in Bearnach, with Uisdean, nineteen now and already carrying himself like a man who expected one day to be asked for his own judgment on such things, riding beside her. The masons had cut her name into the downstream parapet, low down where a woman leaning over the rail to watch the water might find it without looking for it, in letters plain enough that a child learning them could read them without help. She had not asked for this, and stood a long moment looking at it, the water going by beneath, brown and quick with the spring rain, before she got down from her horse and put her hand flat on the stone and ran her thumb along the cut of her own name, feeling the edges of the letters the way a blind woman might read a thing by touch rather than by sight.

She said nothing to Uisdean about what she was thinking, and he, watching her, asked nothing, having learned that much from her already. Behind them the carts that had waited on the near bank began to cross, two abreast for the first time in the bridge's long life, and neither of them turned to watch them go.

OF CARSON AN Làmh Seo

LE 300 – 324

I

Of the Carters' Roads

Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn had walked the roads of the middle shires for the better part of forty years before he ever thought to stop walking them, and by his own account he might have gone another forty had a question not caught up with him on the way and refused, at last, to be carried any further on foot.

He was a druid of the schools of Flidais, lady of the deer, one of a scattered handful who kept no fixed hearth but went from house to house and hall to hall teaching what the schools called Feallsanachd an Fhèidh¹, the stag's teaching: that the vein answered a hand for some measure in it, a measure the schools themselves had never agreed how to name. It was old work, older than any house he taught in, and it suited a man who liked roads better than roofs. He carried little: a stick worn smooth at the grip, a satchel of hide with his writing-boards in it, and the coat he had worn so many winters that it had come to feel, to him, like a second skin he could not have shed even had he wished to.

In the summer of LE 304 the roads brought him south to the high passes above Imrich nam Pantar², where the herders of that country kept the days of the panthers' crossing as carefully as any feast of the crown or Taigh na Fèithe³. He came down off the hill road on the second of those days and found the whole val-

1. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

2. the panthers' crossing

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

ley emptied of flocks: no sheep on the slopes, no goats on the rock, every gate along the panthers' path standing open and every herder's dog shut up indoors, so that a man walking the valley that morning might have thought some plague had taken every beast on it at once. An old herdsman he shared a fire with that night told him the great cats had crossed the mountains at the same season for longer than her grandmother's grandmother could number, coming down from the high passes and going on to the southern fens, and that the valley's dead who had ever tried to keep a flock on the path that week were remembered by name still, though none of them by more than a line. "We do not ask why they cross where they cross," she said, working a knot from a length of cord as she said it. "We only know that they do, and we get out of the way." Coinneach thought about that a long while after the fire had burned down, turning her plain sentence over the way he turned most things over, and found in it, though she had not meant it so, something close to the schools' own oldest teaching: that a thing might be true and useful without any man alive being able to say why it was so.

He came north again by the carters' road above Inis mhòr, and stopped, as he had stopped a dozen times before on that stretch of road, at the road-house called An Leòmhann Buidhe⁴, in LE 304 as in every year before it, where the coal-carters of the northern mining road broke their journey for oatcakes fried in linseed oil and the barley spirit they called fire water. The keeper that year was a broad, red-faced man who watered his fire water more than his custom deserved and had been fined for it twice, and said so himself, cheerfully, to anyone who asked, as though the fining were a kind of fame. The carters who drank there talked, as carters everywhere talked, of the roads and the weather and the loads on their carts, but Coinneach, sitting apart with his own cup and listening more than he drank, heard something under the talk that year that he had not heard so plainly before: an old carter complaining that the coal came slower off the northern galleries than it once had. The ground held coal enough, the man swore; what it lacked was hands the vein would answer quickly, so that Taigh na Fèithe had taken to setting two men to a face where one had sufficed in his father's day. Coinneach said nothing to this. He had heard its like at a dozen road-houses over a dozen years, always in passing, never dwelt on, a grumble among grumbles about weather and loads. But he had begun, without quite deciding to, to keep a private count of how often he heard it.

4. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

He kept that count the way another man might have kept a tally-stick, cutting no notch that any eye but his own would ever read, only a private mark on the inside of his own memory each time the complaint came round again: a vein-house steward at a naming feast saying the same of the western galleries; a woman selling combs at a market fair who told him, unasked, that her own grandfather had worked a face alone that it now took two men to answer at all; a boy of no more than ten who asked him outright, at a hearth where Coinneach had stopped for the night, why the vein loved some hands and hated others, and whether it might simply be running short of the hands it loved best. He answered the boy as he answered every such question on the road, with the schools' old careful phrases about measure and merit that satisfied no one, least of all himself, and walked on the next morning turning the boy's plain word, hated, over in his mind for the better part of a week.

II

Of the Grove at Muileann chiar

From An Leòmhann Buidhe¹ the road ran on to Dùn thais and, a little beyond it, to the sacred wood the schools kept at Muileann chiar, Coille Naomh Muileann chiar², where Flidais's white stag was said still to be seen on quiet evenings by those patient enough to stand still for one. Coinneach had been coming to that grove since he was a boy sent to learn his letters from the schools' own teachers, and he came to it now, in the autumn of that year, an old man by the reckoning of most trades though the schools counted their own differently, to sit among the oaks with three or four of the older teachers and speak of what he had heard on the roads.

They were not surprised by it. One of them, a stooped woman named Beathag nic Ruairidh who had taught in that grove longer than Coinneach had been alive, said only that the schools had always known the question was there, under the teaching, waiting to be asked whole rather than caught in pieces the way Coinneach had been catching it for years: whether the fleet that went out in the days of the Roll had carried away, along with a fifth of every household's right to the coal,

1. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

2. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

something of the very measure the schools claimed to teach. "You have been asking half a question your whole life," she told him, not unkindly, "on every road you have ever walked, one carter at a time. A half question asked a thousand times is still a half question." She was the one who first said to him what he did not, in the end, forget: that the schools had always taught by scattering their teaching one hearth at a time, as a sower scatters seed, and that a question of that size and that danger wanted a different ground to grow in, a fixed hall where it could be turned over by rule rather than by chance, among pupils who had come to argue and not merely to be fed and housed for a night.

Coinneach walked the bounds of the sacred wood alone the following spring, the way the schools' teachers walked it once in a lifetime to mark it in their own memory before they died, tracing the old boundary stones through bracken and standing stands of birch, and came out at the far side with his mind made up, though he could not afterward have said the exact hour it had been made. The question would not be carried hearth to hearth any longer. It would have a house, and a rule, and be argued properly by those who came to argue it, rather than go on leaking out sideways in a road-house over cups of fire water, half heard and half denied before the words were even finished.

III

Of the House Raised at Dùn thais

he chose Dùn thais for the house, a walled town on its hill a day's walk from the grove and near enough the carters' road that pupils would not have to leave the road far to find it, and near enough Caol bheag and the coast towns beyond it that word of a fixed hall, once it had a fixed hall to carry word of, might travel without a druid's own feet to carry it. In LE 314 the house went up: a long hall of grey stone with a turf roof and one door, built by masons of the town in trade for a season's teaching of their own sons, with benches down both walls and a hearth at the far end and, before the hearth, a table where the master of the house would sit. Coinneach had the old question of the schools cut into the lintel over the one door before the roof was even finished over it, Carson an làmh seo?, why this hand, in letters deep enough, the mason promised him, to outlast three generations of thumbs tracing them. Taigh na Deasbaid¹, he called it,

and when the mason asked what a house needed such a hard question over its door for, he told him only that a door was as good a place as any to keep a question where every soul who came in or went out would have to pass beneath it.

The first pupils were few: two boys of Dùn thais itself, a girl from a farm within a morning's walk, and an old shepherd who had heard Coinneach teach once at a hearth twenty years before and had never stopped turning the memory over since. Coinneach set them a rule that first winter that the house kept ever after: that a question, once set, would be argued on the benches through the turning of a full year, by whoever chose to sit them, with no answer given from the master's own chair until the year was out, and sometimes not then. It was slow going. The old shepherd complained, more than once, that a man of his years had not much year left to spend arguing one question at a time, and Coinneach told him that this was precisely why the rule stood: that a question worth a year's arguing was worth more than an answer swallowed whole in an afternoon and never tasted again.

Word travelled slower than Coinneach had hoped, and faster than he had feared. Within a few years pupils were coming from as far as Caol bheag, three days' walk along the coast road and the carters' track that joined it, sent by parents who had heard, from a trader or a carter or a fisher who had heard it from someone else again, that there was a hall at Dùn thais where a hard question was argued properly and not merely swallowed. One of them, a fisherman's son of no more than sixteen, walked the whole distance with nothing but a sack of oatcakes and a borrowed cloak, and told Coinneach, when he was asked why he had come so far for one question among the schools' many, that his own village priest had set the question once at a naming feast and then refused, when pressed, to say any more about it, which the boy had taken, rightly enough, for a sign that there was more to be got at Dùn thais than at home. Coinneach kept him, as he kept every pupil who arrived hungry enough to walk that far for an argument rather than an answer, and the house grew a bench's width at a time through those years, never crowded, never empty, the register of questions kept in a plain board book that lay open on the master's table for any pupil to read back through. The fisherman's boy, whose name was Aonghas mac Nèill, stayed on past the year of his own first question and became, in time, the pupil Coinneach trusted to keep the register straight when his own eyes tired of the board in poor light, and it was Aonghas

1. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

mac Nèill who once remarked that a stranger reading through those first years of questions set and argued would have found nothing in the book to trouble a single one of Na Seachd Taighean²: whether a hall raised without a hearth-fire kept was truly a house; whether a debt owed to a dead man could be owed still to his line; whether a question, once answered wrongly for a generation, was better mended slowly or torn up and asked again from nothing. Good, solid questions, argued a full year each on the benches, and set down in the register with no more danger in them than a fair.

Beathag nic Ruairidh came down from the grove once in those years to see what he had built, walked the length of the hall with her hand trailing along the cold stone the way she might have tested a wall's mortar, and sat through a full evening's arguing without speaking a word of her own. She told him afterward, on the road back toward the grove, that he had built exactly the ground she had told him a question of that size wanted, fixed and ruled and patient, and that she had not doubted he would, only wondered how long he meant to let the house grow comfortable arguing safe things before he set it the one question it had truly been raised for. He told her, honestly, that he did not know, and she said that this, too, she had expected of him, and left it there.

IV

Of the Open Disputation

Ten years the house stood before Coinneach set, at last, the question he had been carrying since the valley where the panthers cross and the fire at the herdsman's hearth. He had turned it over on every road he had walked since, to the knock of his own stick, and it had grown no safer for the turning; if anything it had grown harder, for he was an old man now, two-and-sixty that winter, master of a house with a growing register and a growing name, and a man with a name to lose thinks longer before he risks it than a young man with nothing yet built to risk.

He spoke of it once, and only once, to Aonghas mac Nèill, the night before he set it, the two of them alone in the hall after the benches had emptied and the last candle had been let burn down rather than snuffed, for neither of them wanted to

2. the seven houses of custody

sit in the dark while they spoke of it. Aonghas asked him plainly whether he meant to ask it the next night, having guessed as much from the way his master had gone quiet over supper, and Coinneach told him he did, and that he had put it off eleven years past the year he had first meant to ask it, and could not honestly say the eleven years had made him any braver, only older. Aonghas asked him what he feared would come of the asking. Coinneach said that he did not know, which was true, and that this not-knowing was itself the whole reason the house existed, to hold a question open in a room built for nothing else until whatever came of it came. Aonghas said nothing further, banked the fire himself so his master would not have to rise and do it, and went to his own bed leaving Coinneach alone at the table with the register, where he sat a long while before he, too, went to sleep.

He stood up in his own hall to ask it in the winter of LE 324, on a night when the benches were as full as he had ever seen them and the air inside the door had gone thick with wet wool drying at the hearth and the smoke of tallow candles burned low. The night itself he had chosen without telling anyone so, waiting only until the hall was full enough that the asking, once made, could not be quietly forgotten by the few who happened to be present. He stood by the table with the register closed beneath his hand and let the hall settle before he spoke, the way he had taught every pupil who ever sat those benches to let a silence settle before an answer, and found, when the room was as still as it would get, that his own voice came out steadier than he had expected it to.

"We ask why the vein answers this hand and not that one," he said. "Then let us ask it of the hands that went. Were they the hands it answered best? And if they were, does it answer fewer now?"

No one spoke. A bench creaked as someone shifted on it. Somewhere at the back of the hall a young man laughed, once, a short startled sound with no mirth in it, and then thought better of it and went quiet, and two or three heads turned to find him and did not. Coinneach waited, as the rule of his own house bade every master wait, for someone on the benches to take the question up. When no one did, when the silence had stretched long enough that even the old shepherd, three years dead by then in the register's memory of him but still spoken of on those benches, would have called it answer enough, Coinneach sat down, opened the register, and wrote the question into it in his own hand, dated, unanswered, exactly as every other question the house had ever argued was written.

He had expected argument. He had not, in truth, expected the answer that came instead, which was silence of a different kind, carried out of the hall by whichever of the pupils that night had kin among the seven custodian houses and repeated, shire by shire, until it reached every one of the seven halls before the winter was out. The houses did not send anyone to Dùn thais to dispute the question, and did not send anyone to close the house, and raised, so far as the record of that year shows, no voice against Coinneach himself. What they did, each in its own hall and in its own time, was forbid the question at their own tables: told their households, plainly, that it was not to be asked at a meal where a head of the house sat, nor answered if some fool asked it despite the telling. It was remarked afterward, by more than one clerk who kept a house's accounts of such things, that the seven had forbidden deeds before, walls raised without leave and oaths sworn without witness and grain hoarded against a lean season, but never before a question, and that a forbidding of this new kind unsettled more than one house that had thought itself settled.

V

Of the Queen's Death and the Road Home

The same year that Na Seachd Taighean¹ carried their ban to their own tables, word reached Dùn thais, by the same slow chain of carters and traders that had once carried Coinneach's own fame there, that the shires of the northern plain around Baile Mòr mhòr had, in the last of LE 324, taken in so many families from the failing upland farms in the run of poor seasons just past that the town there had all but doubled within the memory of pupils not yet grown, and that its reeve had been forced to divide the common grazing anew to make room for flocks that had never grazed it before. Coinneach heard the report the way he heard most things that reached him at the house those years, sitting at his own table with the register open before him, and thought, though he set nothing of the thought down, that a country losing its upland farms one poor season at a time and a schools' house losing its old certainty one question at a time were perhaps not so far apart as the two reports, arriving on the same cart, made them sound. The carter who brought the news of Baile Mòr mhòr had walked the road

1. the seven houses of custody

himself that spring, on other business, and told Coinneach that the reeve there had stood in the mud of the newly divided grazing with a stick of his own, much like Coinneach's, and marked off shares with it for households that had never held a share of common land in their lives. The reeve had said to no one in particular, loud enough for the carter to hear it, that a shire could take in every family the hills sent down to it and still, in the end, run short of grass. Coinneach thought that a plainer way of saying what he himself had spent ten years working up the courage to say in one hard sentence, and told the carter so, and the carter, who had no idea what his master meant by it, agreed pleasantly and asked whether the house had any oatcakes to spare a hungry man before he took the road on north.

It was in the same season, before the year was fully out, that the harder news came: in LE 324 Queen Sileas nic Fhearchair had died at Cathair dhearg, in An Talla Dearg² where she had reigned longer than any ruler the record kept before her, one-and-eighty years old and more than fifty of them spent on the crown her father had left her too young, by the houses' own custom, to take at once. Her son Uisdean, himself no young man by then, was crowned in her place before the season turned again, and the crown's scribes, in the way of scribes everywhere, wrote his crowning and his mother's death on the same board, one line after the other, as though the two were a single piece of news rather than a life's whole ending and a life's whole beginning set side by side. Coinneach had never sat in An Talla Dearg nor spoken a word to the queen in the whole of her long reign, but he had cut the firlot's mark once, idly, into the corner of his own writing-board years before, the way half the island had, and found, reading her death off a passing cart's board at the foot of his own hall's steps, that the news struck him harder than he would have expected news of a stranger to strike a man his age. A reign that had run the whole length of his own walking life, road-house to road-house, grove to grove, had ended in a single line on a board, and would be argued over by clerks for a season and then, like most such lines, be carried by the next thing worth carrying.

He walked out from Dùn thais alone that evening, along the carters' road he had walked a hundred times before the house was ever built, past An Leòmhann Buidhe³'s low lamp and on into the dark beyond it, an old man now with a stick worn smoother at the grip than it had been forty years before and a house behind

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

him with his own question written into its register in his own hand, unanswered, and forbidden, by his own reckoning, at every table on the island but the one bench he had raised for it himself. Walking, he thought that he had wanted the question argued, not silenced, and had got instead a silence larger and better organised than any he had broken by asking it: a silence with Na Seachd Taighean behind it now instead of one old habit of not asking. A long while passed before he turned back toward the house and its one lit window, and he told no pupil, that night or any night after, what he had thought on the road, though more than one of them noticed, in the years that followed, that their master had grown a shade quieter than he had been before that winter, and put it down, as pupils will, to the plain count of years, and were only half right to.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

OF Salt and the Listing hull

LE 344 – 394

I

Of the Hull that Would Not Ride True

Ruairidh mac Artair had been a merchant of Inis àrsaidh four-and-forty years old and prosperous in a small, steady way, buying wool in the western shires and selling it on down the coast, when he first began to say to anyone who would listen that a deep hull, built as the fleet's own hulls had once been built, would carry twice the wool of any sewn-plank coaster and outrun the weather besides, and that a man willing to pay for the building of one stood to make back its cost inside three seasons. He had never himself seen a deep-keeled hull afloat, the last of them long since broken up or rotted at their moorings, but he had heard the old tellings of the fleet from his grandmother as a boy, and he had a merchant's confidence that a thing once done could be done again by any man willing to pay what the doing cost.

He found wrights enough willing to try it, the coast still keeping a handful of men who called themselves shipwrights though none now living had built anything deeper than a coaster, and he laid out silver and salt and a season's patience on a keel set down on the strand below the town in the manner, as near as the wrights could reconstruct it from the shapes of old broken timbers still lying half sunk in the shallows, of the hulls Alasdair Saor had once laid there himself. What none of them had, and what none of them thought to ask after until the hull stood built and ready for the water, was the particular scarfing of the keel's long

timbers end to end that had let Alasdair's own hulls flex a little in a following sea rather than fight it; that lore had gone into the ground with the last of his fellow-ship's journeymen, unwritten, a thing carried in the hand rather than on hide, and no one now living had the hand it had been carried in.

The hull went down the strand on a morning in LE 344 with half the town come to watch, Ruairidh himself standing at the water's edge with his arms folded and his chin up, and it took the water well enough for the length of ten heartbeats before it began, very slowly, to lean. It did not lie down as An Fhaoileag¹ had once lain down off Ros àrsaidh, with men drowning under it; it only leaned, and kept leaning, past what any hull under sail could be trusted to right itself from, until the wrights standing knee-deep beside it called out that she would not ride true loaded nor light, and that was the whole of it. No one died. Ruairidh stood a long while looking at his hull canted over in the shallows like a beast that had lain down to die on its own ground, and then he told the wrights, in a voice that surprised those who heard it by its steadiness, to break her up for the timber, since good oak was good oak whatever shape it had been cut to and he did not mean to lose the whole of what he had spent on her.

One of the wrights, an old man named Coll who had spent forty years building nothing deeper than coasters and had taken the work on Ruairidh's silver more from curiosity than from any confidence in his own hand, stood a long while beside the leaning hull before the breaking-up began, running his palm along the keel's underside where it lay bared to the air, and said, to no one in particular, that the wood was as good as any he had ever cut, and that the fault lay somewhere he could not put a name to, a way of setting one timber against the next that his own master had never had to teach him because no one in his own lifetime had ever asked a keel to do more than a coaster's keel needed to do. He said it again, differently, to Ruairidh himself, when the merchant came to settle the wrights' wages: that a man could see a joint had failed without being able to see, in the failed joint, the shape of the joint that would not have failed, and that this not-seeing was a harder thing to carry away from a season's work than any silver lost. Ruairidh paid him in full and said nothing to that, judging, as he judged most things by then, that there was no profit in an old wright's grief over a craft that had gone out of any living hand before either of them was born.

She came apart over the following fortnight, plank by plank, and the oak of her went into byres and cart-frames and, in the end, a good deal of it into the

strengthening of a granary roof at Inis àrsaidh that stood the better for it for years after. Children of the town came down for a season afterward to play among the ribs of her before the last of the timber was carted off, running the length of what had been her spine and counting her frames aloud for the game of it, losing the count each time and starting again, meaning nothing by it beyond the game itself. Ruairidh never spoke of building another. He went back to buying wool and selling it on by coaster as he had before, a little poorer and, those who knew him said, a little quieter than the man who had stood at the water's edge that morning with his chin up, and it was some years before anyone else on the coast thought to try a deep hull again, and longer still before anyone succeeded.

II

Of the Bridge-Keeper's Boyhood and the Springs on the Flats

Some eighty miles to the north-east, on the river above Ros fhionn, a boy named Iain mac Ùisdein kept his father's toll at the stone crossing the district called Drochaid Ros fhionn, whose mason, generations dead, was remembered only by the hearth-sign cut sharp into its keystone. Iain was nine years old the first year he was set to sit at the bridge's north end with the tally-stick and watch the carts go over, and he grew up on that bridge the way another boy grows up on a farm or at a forge, knowing the sound of every cart's wheels before he saw them and the particular groan the third plank from the south end gave under a laden ox-cart that it never gave under an empty one.

The district he watched over was a poor one in those years, a scatter of farms and turf-cutters' holdings on the flats above the river, and the bridge itself carried little enough traffic that his father had time, most days, to teach him his letters between carts, holding the tally-book open on his knee and making the boy copy out the day's crossings twice, once for practice and once for the true record. The bridge itself Iain came to know the way another boy knows a field he has walked every day of his life: the particular lean of the north parapet where a flood two generations back had shifted a single course of stone and no mason since had thought it worth the cost of setting right; the swallows that nested each spring under the third arch and would not be driven off however many carts crossed above

1. the Gull, the first finished hull, lost off Ros àrsaidh

them; the deep pool below the second pier where the district's boys swam in Teasach and where his own father had taught him, holding him under the arms in water that never quite lost its chill even at the height of summer. He learned to read a carter's face before the cart came into sight, whether the man was one who paid his toll without argument or one who would try, as two or three along that stretch of road always tried, to talk the toll down by a claim that his load was lighter than it looked, and his father taught him to answer such men by walking round the cart once, slowly, and naming its weight within a stone or two by eye alone, a trick that shamed more than one careless dealer into paying what he owed without further words wasted on either side.

It was on the flats below the bridge, in the summer Iain turned fifteen, that a farmer digging a new drainage ditch struck water that came up warm to the hand and tasted, when a curious neighbour dipped a finger in it, unmistakably of salt.

Word of it went first to Ros fhionn's own reeve and from him, within the season, to men who understood such things better than a farmer digging a ditch, and by the following spring, in LE 354, the flats above the town held a dozen shallow pans laid out to catch the brine and let the sun and wind do the rest, tended by the same farmers and turf-cutters who had dug for nothing better than dry ground for their oats. Iain, still sitting his father's bridge most days, watched the first carts of white salt go over southward that same year, and it did not occur to him then, a boy of fifteen with a tally-stick and no thought beyond the next laden ox-cart, that he was watching the beginning of the one thing that would, before he was an old man himself, make the bridge under his feet worth more than any bridge on that stretch of river had ever been worth before.

III

Of a King's Death Far to the South and a Cloth Worn Nearer Home

The tidings that had reached the bridge not long before, carried by a rider bound for the shire seat who stopped only long enough to water his horse and pass on what he carried, concerned nothing nearer than Cathair dhearg: that Uisdean mac Dhùghaill, who had held An Talla Dearg¹ since he was a

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

man of four-and-fifty and was himself the son of Sileas nic Fhearchair who had reigned sixty-six years before him, had died in his two-and-eightieth year, and that his own son, Uisdean mac Uisdein, a man already thirty years old and long past needing any regency to hold the hall for him, had been crowned in his place without dispute. Iain's father set the tidings down in the margin of the tally-book, as he set down anything worth remembering that the bridge had no better place to keep, and the two of them talked of it, father and son, for the length of one evening's supper, and then talked of it no more, An Talla Dearg and its business being to a bridge-keeper's household on the northern flats a thing that happened, as the seasons happened, somewhere too far off to be altered by any word either of them might have had about it.

Nearer home, and to Iain's own family a thing of more weight, the weavers of Baile gharbh had by then been some years at a heavy cloth, undyed, woven close enough to shed a season's rain without oiling, that had begun to spread out from Baile gharbh across the whole of the north-east as the common cloak of anyone who worked out of doors in the wet months. Iain's mother had one herself, bought at the Ros fhionn market from a Baile gharbh carter for less than a dyed cloak would have cost and worth twice the price for the rain it turned. It was in that same undyed grey, 18 an t-Sultain, LE 361, tells, that the district first began to mark its mourning, a household that had lost someone wearing the plain wool rather than any dyed thing until the season turned, in the manner, the old women of the flats said, of an Tùrsa Geal² the whole island had once worn together for the fleet, though none of them now living had seen that mourning themselves and knew of it only as their own mothers had told it to them. Iain's grandmother died that winter, and his mother wore the grey cloak a full season after, and it was the first mourning the boy himself remembered closely enough to carry with him, the particular grey of an ordinary rain-cloak turned, by nothing more than a household's own silence in it, into something else.

IV

Of the Handful from Each Load

2. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

By the time Iain had his father's own place at the bridge, the salt of Ros fhionn had become, as the flats' own saying had it, worth more than its weight in argument, for there was scarcely a load crossed south over Drochaid Ros fhionn in those years that was not salt or bound for the salting of something, and the district's shire seat, casting about for some due it might fairly lay on a trade that had made the flats rich almost overnight, settled at last, LE 369, on granting the bridge's own keeper a handful from every load that crossed, to be kept and sold on the bridge-keeper's own account in place of any toll in kind, salt being worth more on that stretch of river than anything else a farmer was likely to carry.

Iain kept the handful honestly, by his own strict reckoning of what a handful was, never grasping a second time at a sack that had already given up its share, and it became known along the whole road that Ros fhionn's bridge-keeper took no more than his due and no less, which was, among carters who had dealt with less scrupulous men at other crossings, a kind of fame. One carter, a heavy-set woman named Beitris who ran salt down to the shire seat twice a season and had once had a whole extra fistful taken from her at a crossing farther south by a keeper who closed his hand quick and opened it slow, took to stopping at Iain's bridge a full quarter-hour longer than her business required, simply, she told him once, to watch him take his handful in the open, in full view of her and anyone else on the road, and count it back into his own box before her eyes, because it did a body good, after the other crossing, to be robbed honestly for once, in plain daylight, by a man who wanted nothing from her but what the shire seat had granted him. He built, in the second year of the toll, a stout box of oak beside his stool at the bridge's north end, iron-bound against damp, and it filled faster than he had thought any box could fill, so that within a handful of years the carters along the road had begun to say, half in jest and half not, that Iain's salt-box held more against a hard winter than some whole villages of the flats could claim to have laid by, and the saying outlived the man who first made it and passed, as such sayings do, into the common speech of the district.

V

Of the Wells that Cracked at Cill ghlais

In LE 379 the earth moved, one night in early autumn, under the hills about Cill ghlais, a small village far to the south-west of the bridge, in Taigh na Fèithe's own country, and the shaking, brief as it was, brought down a byre and cracked three of the village's wells so that their water ran brown for a season after and had to be carried in from farther off until the ground settled and the springs found their own course again. The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe, hearing of it within days, as any tremor near their own hill was a thing they made it their business to hear of quickly, sent men down into the galleries below Cill ghlais to see what the shaking had done there, and found, to the relief of everyone from the master of Taigh na Fèithe down to the least of the diggers, that the galleries stood exactly as they had stood before, not a prop shifted nor a wall so much as scored, the whole force of the tremor having spent itself on the village's own wells and roofs and left the deep workings, driven true and shored well by generations of custodian craft, untouched.

Word of it reached Drochaid Ros fhionn within the week, as word of anything touching the vein reached every corner of the shire sooner or later, and Iain, hearing it from a carter bound for Cill ghlais with a load of the very salt that had made his own box so heavy, thought little of it beyond a passing wonder at how a village's wells could crack while the ground far beneath it, hollowed out by generations of digging, held fast; and it was some years before he heard, from the same carter returning the other way, that the diggers who had gone down that autumn had said among themselves, though never where the master of the store could hear it, that they had felt the shaking reach them even below, a long slow groan through the rock that none of them cared to speak of twice.

The carter, a broad, slow-spoken man who had made the Cill ghlais run for the better part of twenty years, told it to Iain over the second telling much as he had told it the first time, standing his ox at the north parapet while the toll was reckoned and taking his time about the story the way a man takes his time about anything he does not often get to tell to a fresh ear. The village, he said, had lost nothing worse than the byre and the three wells and a season's worry over brown water, and had rebuilt the byre by the following spring with stone hauled, at the custodians' own offer, from Taigh na Fèithe's surplus, a small kindness that the village had not looked for and did not soon forget, Taigh na Fèithe's custodians being known along that stretch of the shire for counting a coal-right more care-

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

fully than they counted a debt of neighbourliness. Iain took his handful from the carter's own load, as he took it from every load, and thought, watching the man drive on south with his ox leaning into the yoke, that a shaking felt through solid rock by men working half a mile under a hill was a stranger thing to carry home to a wife than any bridge toll he had ever had to reckon.

VI

Of the Hollow Man, a King's End, and the Fish of Àth fhiadhaich

The shepherds who ran their flocks on the high pastures of the Doire uaine hills, far off in the mountain country, had kept, for as long as anyone on the flats could remember, one custom that no reeve had ever managed to argue them out of: they lit no fire on those pastures after dark, whatever the cold, for the old carvings cut into the rock there told of a thing called Marbh-bhed¹, that walked the hills without breath and fell upon any who lit a light within its sight. A reeve had been sent up from Muileann chiar once, 26 an Giblean, LE 394, a sensible man who thought the shepherds' custom a foolishness that cost them dear in cold nights, and had gone up to argue them out of it in person; he came down again before dark the same day, and no one who asked him why ever got a clear answer, only that he had seen enough of the hills by daylight to have no wish to test them by night, and the shepherds went on lighting no fires, as they had before, and as they would after. Iain heard the whole of it from the reeve's own mouth, some years on, the man having taken to stopping at the bridge on his rounds and being, by then, willing enough to talk of it to a bridge-keeper he had known long enough to trust with the telling, though not to any stranger who might carry it back to Muileann chiar as a tale against his own good sense. He had gone up, he said, meaning only to walk the pastures by daylight and judge for himself whether the carvings were worth the fear the shepherds spent on them, and had found the carvings plain enough, old work, weathered past any clear reading of what they had first meant to show; what had turned him back before dark, he said, was nothing in the stone at all, but a stillness in the whole of that high ground that he had not met on any other hillside he had walked in thirty

1. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

years of riding the shire, a stillness with no birds in it, and he had judged, standing in the middle of it with the light beginning to fail, that a man's own good sense was worth less on that particular ground than the shepherds' fear was, and had come down. He never went back to argue the point again, and the shepherds, hearing of his single visit and his single retreat, took it for a confirmation of their custom rather than any defeat of it, and lit no fires the more firmly for it ever after.

It was in that same season, the district's own count agreeing near enough with the count kept at An Talla Dearg², that word came south along the road that Uisdean mac Uisdein, who had held the hall two-and-forty years since his father's death, had himself died at two-and-seventy, and that his son Aonghas, a young man of two-and-twenty, had been crowned in his place at Cathair dhearg with less dispute than any crowning the district's own memory held, being the first king, so the rider who carried the tidings said, taught his letters as a child by a tutor set over him for the purpose, a woman named Mòr nic Nèill, LE 394, rather than left, as kings before him had mostly been left, to pick up his letters as he could between other business. Iain, by then a grown man with sons of his own old enough to sit the bridge in his place on the days his knees would not carry him down to the stool, thought of his own father teaching him his letters between carts on that same bridge, and found something in the tidings of the young king's tutor that pleased him more than the crowning itself, a plain thing he understood better than he understood the business of crowns.

That same year, or near enough to it that the district's own tellers never troubled to separate the two, word reached the bridge that Àth fhiadhaich, a fishing town some way south that had salted its catch poorly and lost more of it to spoiling in a bad season than any town ought to lose, had begun sending carts north for Ros fhionn salt rather than trust its own poorer workings any longer, 23 an t-Ògmhios, LE 394, and from that year the mining shires further south, which took their fish salted from Àth fhiadhaich as they had for generations, ate it cured with salt that had first crossed Iain's own bridge, a handful of it left behind in his box each time, though neither the fishers of Àth fhiadhaich nor the diggers who ate their catch ever thought to wonder, buying or selling it, how many hands and how many bridges a sack of salt had passed through before it reached a miner's own board.

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

Iain kept his father's toll at Drochaid Ros fhionn the whole of his working life, and the box beside his stool, iron-bound and never quite empty, held by the end more salt than any single winter of his own household could use, so that he gave the surplus away each spring to whichever of the flats' families had come off worst in the hungry months, judging, as his father had judged before him, that a handful honestly taken owed something back to the road it was taken from. He never built a deep hull, nor wished to; he had heard, once, as a boy, the tale of Ruairidh mac Artair's hull that would not ride true, carried up the road by some carter or other the way all such tales were carried, and it had struck him even then, sitting his stool with the tally-stick in his lap, that a keel laid without the hand that once knew how to lay it was no better than a bridge built without a mason's true eye for the stone, and that a man did better, on the whole, to keep what his own hands had actually been taught than to reach after what his grandmother's tellings alone could give him. He kept that thought, along with the salt, and passed both down, in the end, to his own sons at the same stool, with the same box between them.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Of the Stone that Cries Out and the Two Horses

LE 400 – 446

I

Of the Net-Maker of Inis thais

Dòmhnall mac Ailein mended nets for a living at Inis thais, on the strand below the citadel where the boats came up at low water, and he had done so since he was a boy at his father's knee, and would have gone on doing so, by his own account given late in life, if he had not one morning found himself with more idle hours than herring to mend and a mind that would not let a plain thing lie plain.

The plain thing was the stone that stood a little back from the tide-line, grey and long as a man lying down, which the town had always called Clach and left alone, and around which a handful of old families still kept a watch by turns, as their fathers had kept it before them, road-guards once, in some telling now half forgotten, who had sworn themselves wolf-sworn on a carved stone at another town's gate and had brought the name south with them, or had it already, no one now living could say which. Dòmhnall was thirty-five years old, a spare man with a net-maker's hands, thickened and scarred across the palms from years of twine, and he had never in his life been taken for anyone the town would gather to hear. He began by talking to the men who mended nets beside him, because they were there and would not walk off while his hands were still moving.

He told them the stone was watching, and that it would cry out one day beneath the man or woman who by right should sit An Talla Dearg¹ at Cathair dhearg, as a hound knows its own master's step among a crowd of strangers' steps; and that the families who watched it kept a household still under oath, wolf-sworn still, whatever the wolf they had first sworn against, no mere custom grown stale with age. Their proper name, the name their oath deserved, was an Fhianna², who keep the whole island as a wolf keeps its range, walking the bounds of it though no one has asked them to and none but themselves remembers why. Some of the net-menders laughed at him the first day, not unkindly. By the second day fewer laughed. By 28 am Màrt, LE 409, there were men and women come down from the upper town as well, standing at the edge of the net-menders' work to hear a man they did not know for a teacher say plainly what half of them, it turned out, had half believed since childhood and never once said aloud.

One of the old watching families, hearing a net-maker put words on a duty they had kept without words for three generations, sent their eldest down to the strand to ask him plainly what right he had to name a thing he had not sworn to. Dòmhnall answered, by the account still told of it at Inis thais, that he had sworn nothing and claimed no watch of his own, and that the naming was not his to give or withhold; he had only said aloud what the stone had already been doing under their own hands for longer than any of them could count, and if the name displeased them they were free to keep the older silence and let him talk to the empty air instead. The old man went back to his family and reported, so it is told, that the net-maker was either a fool or telling the truth, and that he could not himself tell which, though he came back down to the strand the following morning to hear him again, and brought his own sons with him the morning after that.

He never claimed to have made anything new. He said only that he had put a true name on an old thing, the way a man finds the right word for a smell he has known all his life and never named, and from that day the ones who stood to hear him, growing by ones and threes through that year and the next, called themselves the first gathering of Òrd na Cloiche³ at Inis thais, though the order, as the older men among them were careful to say, was no younger than the hall built about the wolf-stone at another town's gate, generations before any of them were born. Dòmhnall did not correct them when they called him a founder, and did not

1. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

3. the order of the Stone

claim the word for himself either. He went on mending nets. He only did it now with people standing near.

II

Of the Wolf-House Roofed with Slate

What his hearers wanted, once they were past the first summer of standing on the strand in whatever weather came, was a roof, and Dòmhnall, who understood twine and rope and very little of timber or stone, let the ones among them who understood such things see to it. A shipmaster of the town, a woman named Beathag nic Raoghnaill who had carried wool and hides along the southern coast for twenty years and had never once thought herself religious, offered to fetch the roofing herself rather than trust it to a stranger's hold, and sailed north and came back a season later with a hull low in the water under the weight of northern slate, blue-grey and heavier by far than the thatch the town was used to laying.

They raised the hall about the stone through that year and the next, a plain building of undressed stone with the slate laid close above it, and it stood, when it was finished, 16 an Dùbhlachd, LE 419, the first roof on the whole coast built to outlast the man who built it, or so the town said of it afterward, half in wonder and half in complaint at what the slate had cost to bring. Dòmhnall stood under it the day the last course was laid and put his hand flat against the wall beside the stone, and said to Beathag, who had brought the slate and stayed to see it laid, that a roof built to last past its builder was a kind of oath, though a duller one than a man swore with his own mouth, and she said back to him, being a plain woman and no teacher, that a roof built to last was mostly a roof that did not leak, and that she would leave the oaths to him.

The families who had watched the stone before Dòmhnall ever spoke of it took their old watch under the new roof and called themselves, from that year on and without argument among themselves, an Fhianna¹, and kept a horn there that was blown at the turn of every tide, morning and evening, the way the boats themselves were called and released. Children of the lower town, who had grown up half afraid of the grey stone and its silent watchers, began instead to set their

1. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

morning's business by the horn without a thought for what it sounded for, the way any horn, once it has sounded long enough, is heard before it is remembered.

The horn fell, by lot among an Fhianna's own households, to whoever's turn it was that season to keep the tide-watch, and the blowing of it became, within a few years, a small honour that passed from house to house the way the old road-watch had once passed, so that a child of Inis thais might grow from a boy who feared the stone to a young man who blew its horn and back to an old man again without the town ever once needing to write down whose turn came next. Dòmhnall's own hearers, once they had a roof to gather under, began to travel: a fisherman of the town who had heard him twice went inland one winter to sell hides and came back having told the naming to three villages he passed through, none of which he ever visited again, so that the stone's true name went out from Inis thais the way water goes out from a spring, in threads too small and too many for anyone to trace back afterward to their single source.

III

Of the Harbour Shrine at Caol Ieathan

Not every town took the naming so easily. At Caol Ieathan, where the wolf-stone's own hall had stood since before any of Dòmhnall's hearers were born, there was a shrine down by the harbour that the priests of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹ had also long claimed, a low stone house above the tide where offerings of both faiths had been laid, uneasily, side by side, for longer than either order cared to reckon.

It came to a head, as such things do, over a feast day that fell the same year for both: the hawk's own reckoning marking it a day for flying the young birds down to the water for the first time, Òrd na Cloiche²'s marking it a night an Fhianna³ kept vigil against no enemy either could name. Both orders arrived at the shrine door on the same morning to find it wanted for the same hours, and neither would give way, Òrd an t-Seabhaig's priests saying their reckoning was the older, an Fhianna saying the stone did not reckon by the hawk's moons and never had.

The king's reeve at Caol Ieathan, a level-headed man named Murchadh mac Ailpein who had settled land disputes along that coast for a dozen years and had

1. the Hawk order

no patience left over for the disputes of gods, walked down to the shrine himself and stood between the two crowds until they consented, more from weariness than agreement, to hear him. He proposed nothing new: only that the shrine's days be halved between the two orders as the sacred woods of an older age had once been halved between rival claimants, each order keeping what hours were its own and neither trespassing on the other's, 29 am Faoilleach, LE 429. Both sides took it sourly at first, Òrd an t-Seabhaig's priests muttering that half a shrine was no shrine at all, an Fhianna saying much the same in different words, but the division held, through that year and every year after. Neither order ever came to love it; they only found, in all the years that followed, no better quarrel to replace it with.

Murchadh himself, asked by his own clerk why he had troubled to walk down to a shrine dispute at all when the crown's business at Caol leathan ran to harbour tolls and fish-weirs and rarely to gods, answered that a harbour town with two faiths quarrelling over one roof was a harbour town that would soon enough be quarrelling over its weirs and tolls as well, whatever the first quarrel had been about, and that a reeve who let the small fire burn unwatched had no business complaining of the larger one later. He wrote the division down on a single strip of hide, one side for Òrd an t-Seabhaig's hours and one for an Fhianna's, and nailed it to the shrine door himself, and it hung there, replaced twice as the hide wore through, for as long as the division held.

IV

Of Seann Skell Walled and the Market at the New Gate

In those same years the northern town of Seann Skell, on the bay the hawk-keepers called their own, put up a wall around its own streets for the first time, the old open harbour town having grown past what an unwalled shore could keep safe of its own goods, and the crown granted a market inside the new landward gate where the amber of that coast was sold alongside whale-oil, honey, and the wool of the northern moors, 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 435.

The amber-workers of the bay, who had for two generations sold whatever rough stone washed up along their own shingle to whichever trader offered first,

whether inside a wall or out, swore among themselves, as the price of the gate's protection, to sell no rough amber outside the walls from that year forward, so that the crown's own toll-takers might see every piece pass and take their due of it. One of them, a young man named Ailig an Òir who had never in his life paid a toll on anything and saw no reason to begin, was caught within the year selling a season's gathering to a passing trader on the open shingle a mile short of the gate, and was made, by his own guild before the crown's reeve ever heard of it, to forfeit the whole of that season's take to the market fund inside the walls; and he paid it, by every account that reached the town after, without argument, judging that a guild's own anger was a costlier thing to cross than any single season's amber.

The market, once it was a season or two old, kept its own small order of business without much help from the crown's toll-takers at all: honey-sellers set up nearest the gate, where the smell of it might draw a buyer in off the road before he had thought to look for anything else, and the whale-oil men kept to the far corner by the wall, downwind, where the lamps that burned it through the winter dark could be filled without the whole square smelling of the trade. Sheep from the northern moors came down twice a year, at the two turning feasts, driven in by drovers who slept the nights before and after in the lee of the new wall and grumbled, as drovers everywhere grumbled, that a walled town charged more for a night's shelter than an open shore ever had, and paid it anyway, because the wall kept the wind off as well as it kept the amber counted.

V

Of Dòmhnall's Death

Dòmhnall mac Ailein taught on the strand at Inis thais for five-and-thirty years past the day he first opened his mouth to the men beside him, and never once, in all that time, took up any office the order might have given him, saying that a net-maker who called himself a priest was worth less to the stone than a net-maker who went on mending nets. In his last years his hands grew too stiff for the finer twine-work, and he sat instead on an upturned creel at the edge of the strand while younger hands mended what he could no longer mend himself, and talked, when anyone stopped to listen, of nothing more than

3. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

the tide and the weather and, now and again, of the stone, in much the same tone he used for the tide and the weather, as though the three had never seemed to him three separate subjects at all.

He died in his seventieth year, not long before the fire that would take the roofs of a village he had never seen, quietly, in the small house he had kept his whole life within sound of the tide-horn he had never asked anyone to blow, and an Fhianna¹ carried him to the shrine themselves and set him down before it, not within it, judging, as he would himself have judged, that the stone's own watch belonged to those still living to keep it. It is told at Inis thais that Beathag nic Raoghnaill, by then an old woman herself, stood longest at the grave of anyone in the town, and said to no one in particular that she had brought a roof to shelter a man who wanted no roof of his own kept over him, and did not know, to her own dying day, whether that had been a kindness or a joke the tide alone understood.

The old man who had once sent his eldest son down to question Dòmhnall's right to name the stone came to the shrine that day too, bent now with age past what his own sons had been on the morning of that first asking, and stood a long while before the grey stone with his hand on it, saying nothing that anyone thought worth carrying home afterward. He had blown the tide-horn himself, in his own turn, more mornings than he could any longer count, and it was noticed, though not remarked on at the time, that he was the last to leave the shrine that evening, after even the dead man's own household had gone home to their supper.

VI

Of the Two Horses

At Cathair dhearg King Aonghas mac Uisdein, seven-and-forty years crowned and come nine-and-sixty years old himself by then, had watched the quarrels of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹ and Òrd na Cloiche² from An Talla Dearg³ with the wariness of a man who owed his own crown to neither order and

1. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

1. the Hawk order

2. the order of the Stone

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

meant to keep it that way. He had grown, in his father's house and his own, alongside a third rite altogether, older on the northern moors than either the hawk's flight or the stone's watch: Òrd Mhacha⁴ rite of Macha, kept by families who tended two horses foaled of one mare on one night, Liath Macha the grey and Dubh Sainglenn the black, yoked from their first spring to a single chariot pole so that neither ran without the other.

It was said among Òrd Mhacha, and Aonghas had heard it said at his own father's table before he had any crown to weigh it by, that the two horses were two powers kept always in balance, one light and one dark, neither swallowing the other, and that the vein under the hill at Muileann dhearg belonged to both alike, fed by dark labor and bringing up bright fire, and that a house or a crown that forgot to keep the two yoked together would find, sooner or later, one horse running loose and the chariot broken behind it. He remembered, from a boy's own memory and no clearer than a boy's memories usually are, being lifted onto his father's shoulder once at such a rite to see over the heads of the grown worshippers of Òrd Mhacha, and asking why there were two horses and not one, and his father telling him that one horse pulling alone always pulls a chariot in a circle, and that it takes two, pulling together and never quite agreeing, to pull it straight.

Aonghas had no love of quarrels; he had watched, these forty years and more, the priests of Òrd an t-Seabhaig and an Fhianna⁵ divide a single shrine's hours between them and count it a victory, and he had begun to think, as an old man thinks slowly toward a decision he cannot quite date the start of, that a crown ought to keep something that did not need dividing. When he first told his own household he meant to ride out to Òrd Mhacha' rite himself, one of his older councillors, a man who had served his father before him and had buried two wives and outlived most of his own objections to anything, said only that a crown was free to keep whatever custom pleased it, but that a crown seen kneeling to a moor-custom might find Na Seachd Taighean⁶ asking, before the year was out, why a crown could not be seen kneeling to their own custom instead. Aonghas answered that he did not mean to kneel to anything, only to put his hand where the rite asked every hand to go, and that a house wanting the same honour need only send its own hands to stand at a yoke-pole, since Òrd Mhacha, so far as he had ever heard, turned no one away who came to pull.

4. the order of Macha

5. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

6. the seven houses of custody

He rode out to Òrd Mhacha' own rite the spring he turned nine-and-sixty, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441, a man come to stand at a yoke-pole among the families who had kept the rite since before his own house held the hall, rather than a king come merely to be shown a wonder, and he took the near pole in his own two hands when the horses were brought up together at dawn, one hand to the grey side and one to the black, the way the rite asked of anyone who meant to stand in it and do more than watch. The court that had ridden out with him, seeing their king at a yoke-pole in the wet grass like any wood-watcher's son, did as courts do, and within the year half An Talla Dearg's own household had taken up the rite alongside him. So Òrd Mhacha, which had kept to its own moors and its own quiet families for longer than any crowned house had troubled to notice it, became from that year the order of Cathair dhearg and of the crown, without a single quarrel fought over it, the way a stream that has run quietly along a field's edge for years becomes the field's only water once a dry summer comes.

VII

Of the Fire at Tobar dhearg

That same year, in the season Òrd Mhacha¹ call the between-moon, a fire ran through the thatch of Tobar dhearg, a small place among the southern quarries where the roofs had always been thatch because the quarries near it cut building stone and had never troubled to cut slate, and it took most of the village before the last of it was beaten out with wet sacking and river water carried up in whatever would hold it, 28 am Màrt, LE 446. No one died in it, though three families lost the whole of what stood over their heads, and the village's own headman, walking the black ground the next morning with his boots already through to the ash beneath, said only that a roof was easier lost than a life and that the village would build again before the winter found them without one.

They built again in slate, this time, the quarries near Tobar dhearg holding, as it turned out, stone fit for roofing as well as for building, once a man troubled to look for it there, and word of it went as far as Seann Skell within the year: that a village burned to the ground in the spring had roofed its houses again in stone before the first frost, and had never once gone back to thatch. Tobar dhearg was

1. the order of Macha

known, from that year on, along the whole of the southern road, for its slate roofs, the way another town was known for its wool or its market, a plain fact that outlived, as plain facts do, the fire that had made it true.

One of the three burned-out families, a quarryman's household that had lost a byre and half a season's stored grain along with its roof, took the new slate first of any house in the village, judging, as the quarryman himself put it to whoever would listen, that a man who cut the stone for a living had less excuse than any neighbour to go on sleeping under straw. His own children slept that first slate-roofed winter, so the family told it afterward, more soundly than they had slept since before the fire: less for any particular warmth the stone gave than thatch had not, than for the plain unfrightening weight of it overhead in a bad wind, a weight thatch had never had and had never been missed for until the night it was gone.

Aonghas heard the tidings of the fire at An Talla Dearg² and sent what the crown's own granaries could spare south before the winter closed the roads, and then, the following spring, rode out again to Òrd Mhacha' rite as he had the year before. A thing done once by a king and never repeated is no rite, only a single day's fancy, and he meant this one to hold. He came to the yoke at dawn as the horses were brought up, Liath Macha pale as the mist off the northern sea and Dubh Sainglenn dark as the coal Taigh na Fèithe³ sent up by the basket-load, and he set his hand to the pole again, one side and then the other, an old man now by any village's reckoning though not yet by his own house's long custom, and stood there a while in the wet grass with a hand on each yoke-pole, the grey horse and the black quiet under his two hands together.

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Of the BURNED TRACTS

LE 450 – 509

Cha do chaill sinn blàr, ach chaill sinn an teine. We did not lose a
battle, but we lost the fire.
— a verse of the cold shires

I

Of the Woman Who Taught at Doire chiar

Eilidh nic Iain was born at Doire chiar, a village of turf and grey stone set among birch and low hazel where Taigh na Fèithe¹'s own writ ran thin and the coal had never been found worth the digging, and she was called Eilidh Dhubbh from girlhood for hair black as a crow's wing rather than for anything darker in her, though those who did not love what she taught said it, before she was old, with more than one meaning. Her father kept bees and a scatter of goats on the hill above the village and had no more learning than his letters, but her mother's mother had been one of the last to sit under a teacher of the rival school, the school of An Aois Naomh² that held the vein answered labour and not birth, and the old woman had kept the teaching in her own head the way a house keeps a coal banked under ash, needing only breath to wake it, and had given it whole to her granddaughter before she died.

Eilidh was thirty years old, unmarried and settled to nothing anyone in the village could name, when she began to say the teaching aloud at the well and afterward under the gable of her own house, to whoever of the village came to stand

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Holy Age

and listen: that the vein under the hill belonged to no house by right of blood, that a custodian's son was no more owed a gallery than a collier's, and that Na Seachd Taighean³ who now wore the neck-rings of Muileann chiar had kept, over four generations, a measure meant for all of them alone, calling it custom and calling custom law. She did not shout it and did not dress it in threat. She said it the way a woman says a thing she has turned over long enough to trust, plainly, at whatever hour the listening came to her, and within a year she had written down, in a hand her mother had taught her, the whole of what she said, so that those who could not come every evening might have it read to them by whoever among them had letters.

The tracts, as they came to be called, were no more than a double handful of sheets by the second year, copied and copied again by whoever in the village or beyond it wanted a set of their own, on whatever scraped hide or planed board could be found, so that no two copies in the whole country agreed exactly in their wording though none, by every account, disagreed in their sense. Eilidh herself never wrote a fair copy twice the same, saying that a teaching kept too carefully to one form of words was already halfway to a law, and a law was the last thing she meant it to become.

II

Of the Reading at Harvest

It was at the harvest gatherings that the tracts travelled furthest, carried by pupils who went from Doire chiar to whatever gathering their own kin kept that season, in the north-east where the grain came thin off stony ground and every household's harvest was a shared labour before it was ever a shared feast. A gathering at Muileann chiar, LE 484, heard the tracts read for the first time by one of Eilidh's own pupils, a young man named Coinneach Odhar who had learned his letters from her expressly so that he might read where she herself would not travel, and it is told that the head of the household hosting the gathering, a woman of no love for Taigh na Fèithe¹'s seven, let him stand on her own threshing floor to do it, the grain still unwinnowed at his feet, and gave him be-

3. the seven houses of custody

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

sides a bowl of the harvest's own new ale when he had finished, which he took as thanks enough for the walking.

Not every household took to it so easily. At a gathering nearer Muileann dhearg a farmer's wife, hearing the tracts read out over her own supper, said aloud that a teaching which told a collier he was owed a custodian's gallery was a teaching that would get colliers killed for believing it, and that Eilidh Dhubh, whatever the truth of her words, might have kept them for wiser company than a harvest table with children at it. Coinneach Odhar, by his own later telling, had no answer ready for her and gave none, and walked the two days home turning the woman's words over as carefully as he had ever turned Eilidh's own.

Eilidh heard of the exchange within the season, harvest news travelling as fast as harvest grain along the same roads, and said to Coinneach, when he told her of it, only that the woman was not wrong to fear for her sons, and that a teaching a body could not afford to believe out loud was not therefore a teaching that had stopped being true; the fear and the truth were two different debts, and a teacher's business was with the second, though she never claimed the first was small. She went on reading it herself wherever she was asked, and let her pupils carry it further than her own legs would go, and in this way, by LE 484, the tracts of Doire chiar were known, by name if not by the whole text, from the eastern hills to Cnoc bheag itself, though not one copy had yet been shown to anyone at Taigh na Fèithe.

III

Of the Order from Muileann dhearg

It could not stay unshown forever. A journeyman of the seam who had heard the tracts read at a gathering carried word of them, meaning no particular harm by it, to a cousin who kept Taigh na Fèithe's own store at Muileann dhearg, and the store-keeper, being a cautious man in a cautious office, passed the word up the gallery to those whose business it was to be troubled by such things. The order that came down within the month was plain and, by Taigh na Fèithe's own lights, moderate: every copy of the tracts of Doire chiar was to be brought to Muileann dhearg and given up, and no penalty would fall on any household that

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

gave one up freely; only a household found still holding one after the season's end would answer for it.

The carriers who went from house to house collecting them, two custodians' clerks and a reeve's man riding with them for the look of the crown's own authority, found the giving up easier than any of the three had expected, and afterward not one of them could say for certain whether that ease came of fear or of indifference, since a copied sheet, however dear the teaching on it, cost little to write again once it had been read aloud in a hundred households and carried in as many memories. Some hundred sheets were brought to Muileann dhearg that season, more than the store-keeper's own reckoning had guessed the whole country held, and they were burned in Taigh na Fèithe's own yard on a still morning with the smoke going up straight before the gathered custodians and, at the edge of the crowd, Eilidh Dhubh herself, who had walked the day and a half from Doire chiar to see it done rather than have it done and told to her after.

She said nothing while the sheets burned, and nothing was asked of her, and when the fire had burned down to a black smear on the yard's own stone she turned and walked the day and a half home again, and within the fortnight was teaching at her own gable as she had every evening for eleven years, a fresh sheet of the tracts already begun in her own hand before the ash at Muileann dhearg had properly cooled. No custodian of the seven ever gave an order against her person, then or after; whether that mercy came of Taigh na Fèithe judging her too old, too poor, or too plainly harmless to trouble with a heavier hand, or of some custodian among the seven who had heard her once and could not afterward bring himself to move against her, is not told, and Eilidh herself, asked once by a pupil why she thought she went unpunished when her own words had gone to the fire, said only that a teaching burned once and taught again the next morning had already answered the question better than she could.

IV

Of the Wood and the Road

The country beyond Doire chiar's own gable was, in those same years, quietly settling a handful of older claims that had nothing to do with a woman's teaching, and a teller who follows only the tracts would miss how much else, that generation, was being handed from one keeping to another

without a blow struck over any of it. At Cnoc bheag Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹, held in common since An Aois Naomh² by more claimants than any one custody-book had ever troubled to name in full, passed by royal grant to the priests of Macha alone, LE 471, and the other claimants withdrew from the wood within the season, without protest that any scribe of An Talla Dearg³ thought worth setting down; why they went so quietly, whether from a weariness of sharing a single grove among too many hands or from some understanding struck away from any hall's hearing, is not told, and no teller since has been able to say more of it than that.

Scoiltean nan Draoidhean⁴, who had held no ground of their own since An Aois Naomh's own quarrels scattered the last of the great teaching-houses, took up in those same years the keeping of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁵ at Muileann chiar, walking its bounds once in every year in a procession that began as no more than a handful of the schools' own masters and grew, within a decade, into the one rite the schools still kept open to any who cared to walk with them, LE 479. It was a smaller thing by far than the schools had once been, in the tellings that still reached Doire chiar from older men who remembered older tellings still, but it held, year on year, without any house of custody troubling to forbid it or any priest of Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁶ or Òrd na Cloiche⁷ troubling to claim the wood for a rival rite, and a schoolman who walked it in his old age was heard to say that a single rite kept faithfully a hundred years running was worth more, in the end, than a hundred rites let lapse in the first hard season.

On the drovers' road east of Muileann dhearg, where cattle had been walked over the hills to the mining towns for longer than any single family could claim to have begun the practice, the drovers of Àth chiar took, in the same span of years, to marking their own road with cairns, a stone set at every day's stage so that a beast lost in mist or a driver new to the trade might find the way again without asking, LE 484, the first roads on the whole island so marked, and within a generation every drover from the eastern hills to the mining towns knew the cairns of

1. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

2. the Holy Age

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

4. the druid schools

5. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

6. the Hawk order

7. the order of the Stone

Àth chiar by name and by number, though not one of them, asked, could have said which drover had set the first stone or in what year.

None of these three things touched Taigh na Fèithe⁸'s own quarrel with Doire chiar, and none of the three, set down together, made so much as a single line in Leabhar a' Chùrain⁹; but a country that grants a wood, opens a rite and marks a road, all in the span of a single generation and none of it fought over, is a country quietly rearranging what it keeps and how, and it was the same generation, and very often the same few years, that watched the tracts burned at Muileann dhearg and a fourth copy already begun before the ash had cooled.

V

Of the Copy Kept at Doire chiar

One copy the carriers never found, kept whole from that year on in a hollow beam of Eilidh's own house, in her mother's own hand rather than her own, the single sheet the old woman had set down before her own death and given to no household but her granddaughter's, LE 484. Eilidh showed it to no one outside her own kin for the whole of her life afterward, saying that a teaching needed a living voice more than it needed a written one, and that the sheet in the beam was kept less for the country's sake than for her mother's, a thing to be shown, if it was ever shown at all, only when the living voice at last fell silent.

The years after the burning brought no second order and no second search, Taigh na Fèithe's own attention turning, as a household's attention will, to nearer and louder troubles: a bad season on the eastern seam that same year, and beyond it the crown's own house shaking under three deaths inside a single generation, of which more is told below. Eilidh taught on at Doire chiar for twenty years more, growing old in the same house she had grown up in, her pupils growing old alongside her and their own children coming in turn to sit under the gable in the evenings, so that by the last years of her teaching she had buried more than one of the first who had ever stood to hear her as young men and women, and had grown, without ever asking for it, into the kind of teacher whose pupils no longer

8. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

9. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

troubled to write down every word she said, trusting, as a village trusts a well it has drawn from all its life, that the water would go on rising however little thought anyone gave to where it came from.

She died at Doire Chiar in her seventy-fifth year, LE 505, in the house where she had been born, with three pupils at her bed and a fourth sheet, unfinished, on the board beside her; she had been teaching, by every account of that last evening, within the hour of her death, a young woman of the village a point of the old argument she had made a thousand times before and never once, her pupils said afterward, in quite the same words twice. She was buried in the ground behind her own house rather than in any consecrated plot of Òrd an t-Seabhaig² or Òrd na Cloiche³ or Macha's own priests, none of the three orders having ever claimed her nor she them, and her pupils raised over her no stone at all, judging, as she would herself have judged, that a teaching kept alive in the mouths of the living needed no monument the weather might in time wear blank. Coinneach Odhar, by then an old man himself, read the tracts at her own graveside from the copy he had carried these thirty years, and it is told that more of the village came to hear it read that one time than had ever come to hear Eilidh read it living, a thing he remarked on afterward with no bitterness that anyone could find in him, only a kind of tired wonder that a country waited so often until a well ran dry to learn how deep it had been.

VI

Of Three Kings in a Single Generation

While Doire Chiar kept its own quiet quarrel with Taigh na Fèithe¹, An Talla Dearg² at Cathair dhearg was losing, in the same span of years, three kings where an ordinary generation loses one. King Aonghas mac Uisdein, who had taken up Òrd Mhacha³' rite of Macha in his own old age and set it, before he died, as the crown's own custom, died at seventy-eight years old, LE 450, and Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴ gave him, as it gave every crowned head before

2. the Hawk order

3. the order of the Stone

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the order of Macha

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

him, a single line: the name, the year, and no more, though the harbour scribes of the west coast were heard to say among themselves that a reign which had joined Macha's rite to the crown's own household without a blow struck over it deserved a longer line than the book allowed it.

His son Aonghas, called Aonghas Òg though he came to the hall no young man, was crowned the same season at fifty years old, already grey and already, by his own admission to the men who crowned him, no longer certain his own knees would carry him through a rite so long as his father's had been. He kept the crown thirty-four years, a reign remembered afterward for little beyond its own length and its own quiet, Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁵ and Òrd na Cloiche⁶ having settled, in his father's day, into a peace neither order troubled to disturb again, and Taigh na Fèithe's own quarrel with a woman of Doire chiar being, in An Talla Dearg's own reckoning, too small a thing to trouble a king's attention at all. He died in the winter of his eighty-fourth year, LE 484, the first king of the line to be carried to his grave by the rite of Macha rather than by any older custom of the hall, his own household standing at the yoke-poles of two horses he himself had ridden out to see brought up together every spring of his reign, and it is told that Òrd Mhacha who led that first royal burying under their own rite were themselves uncertain, until the day was nearly done, whether a king's body wanted the same ordering as any wood-watcher's own dead, and settled it, in the end, by giving him exactly that ordering and no more, judging that a rite which bent itself new for every man it buried was no rite worth keeping.

His son Iain mac Aonghais came to the hall at forty-nine years old, already a man with two sons of his own, the eldest a young man grown, and reigned twelve years only, a reign Leabhar a' Chùrain called short even while it was being lived, dying in his sixty-first year, LE 496, of no sickness any teller afterward could put a name to beyond the ordinary wearing-out of a man who had come late to a crown and found little joy in the wearing of it. The houses swore, within the same season, to his eldest son Tormod mac Iain, called Tormod Bàn for hair gone white before he was forty, crowned at thirty-six years old without a single house of the seven raising a question over the succession, a plainness An Talla Dearg's own scribes noted with something close to relief after a generation that had buried three kings in the time an ordinary house buried one.

5. the Hawk order

6. the order of the Stone

VII

Of the Second Son

The second of Iain mac Aonghais's three sons, a boy named Aonghas after his grandfather, was seven years old when his father was crowned and nineteen when his father died, old enough by then to stand at the yoke-poles himself at his brother Tormod's own crowning, though he stood, as a second son stands, a pace back from the hall's own centre and said nothing that any scribe thought worth the setting down. He had grown up, by his own later account given to his own daughter, in the half-attention a second son learns to expect and to make peace with: taught his letters alongside his elder brother but never quite so carefully, given a horse of his own but never the pick of the stable, loved well enough by a father grown old and tired in the office but never once mistaken, by that father or by anyone else in the hall, for the son the crown would fall to.

It was in the thirteenth year of his own life, LE 490, that his father took a second wife, his first having died some years before, and gave the household a third son, a boy called Dùghall for no uncle or grandfather that any of the household could afterward agree on, born at An Talla Dearg¹ rather than at any lesser house, the first of the three brothers to be born under a crown his father already wore. Aonghas, by his own telling, held the child once in the first week of his life and thought little of him beyond the ordinary wonder any young man feels holding an infant too small yet to hold anything back, and could not have said, holding him, what the boy would grow into.

Aonghas mac Iain took no office at his brother's crowning beyond the ordinary place of a king's own kin at An Talla Dearg, and within a few years had settled to the life of a younger son of the crown's own house: a modest hold some way from the capital, a wife of a lesser house of custody, and a house at Inis thais that his wife's kin had kept for three generations.

VIII

Of the Byre at the Halfway Stage

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

In those same years the central mining road, which carried the ore and the coal of the eastern hills down toward the capital and carried, in the other direction, the grain and salt the mines themselves could not grow or draw, had long depended for its winter traffic on a single road-house at its halfway stage, a place the ox-drivers had for two generations simply called the great house, kept since before living memory by whichever family held the ground it stood on. In LE 509 its keeper, a careful man named Iain mac Mhurchaidh who had held the house from his own father and meant, by every sign he gave, to hold it a good deal longer yet, judged that a single byre no longer answered the traffic the road now carried, the ox-teams of the mountain having grown, over his own father's lifetime and his, from a handful of wagons in a hard season to a train that some winters filled the yard to its gate before the first snow had properly settled.

He raised a second byre that same year against the far wall of the yard, of the same undressed stone as the first, and began, the winter it was finished, a book of his own: which team lodged which night, whose ox went lame and was nursed back on the house's own fodder, whose driver owed a debt of lodging still unpaid come spring, kept in a hand that grew steadily surer through that first winter as he found the shape the keeping wanted. It was no grand thing, the book, no larger a matter to the country than any careful man's private ledger, and no scribe of An Talla Dearg¹ ever asked to see it nor any custodian of Na Seachd Taighean² troubled to learn it existed; but the ox-drivers who passed that way, winter on winter, came to trust the book's own memory better than their own, a driver more than once settling an argument over whose ox had lodged where the previous season by asking the keeper to look it up rather than trusting either man's own account, and in this small way the great house at the halfway stage became, without any of the crown's own notice, the one place on the whole central road where a plain fact, once written down, was believed over a plain man's word.

The worst of that winter's snow closed the road for the better part of three weeks, and the yard held, at the height of it, eleven teams and their drivers crowded into the two byres and whatever floor space the house could spare, fed on stores Iain mac Mhurchaidh had laid in against exactly such a season and had, by his own admission afterward, never quite believed he would need in full. He kept them fed, and kept his book through every night of it besides, by the same fire the drivers themselves sat around telling whatever news the road still carried

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the seven houses of custody

before the snow had closed it: of a woman at Doire chlar not four years dead whose sayings a driver's own cousin still kept by heart; of a king thirteen years crowned without dispute; of a second son of the crown's own house said to be settling, quietly and without complaint, into a life no history would trouble to write down. The fire burned low before the last of them slept, and Iain mac Mhurchaidh, closing his book for the night, judged, as he judged every winter after, that a country's true weight was carried less by what An Talla Dearg's own scribes thought fit to set in *Leabhar a' Chùrain*³ than by the small, careful, unwitting keeping of a hundred houses like his own, each holding its own little ledger against the loss the years would otherwise make of it.

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

Of the Ferry on the Abhainn Fhionn

LE 510 – 552

I

Of the Bell at Muileann naomh

Tormod mac Iain had been eighteen years crowned when the bell-founders of Muileann naomh asked him to stand at the casting of the first bronze bell ever made on Dia-thìr for a hawk-house, and he went south to see it, partly because a king who is asked ought to go, and partly because he had heard the founders' own account of the mould and wanted, before he grew too old to care about such things, to watch metal take the shape of sound.

He was four-and-fifty that year, and had been called 'Tormod Bàn since before he was crowned, for hair gone the colour of good wool while he was still a young man; his father's line ran to early grey, and he had made his peace with it the way a man makes peace with weather. He stood at the founders' pit at 6 an t-Sultain, LE 514, with the vein's own custodians beside him, the households of Clann Fhear-chair, Clann Raghnaill and the rest come down to see a thing none of them had seen before, and watched the bronze poured and cooled and the bell hoisted and hung and rung for the first time under a clear sky, a sound none of the hawk-keepers present had ever heard from anything but a human throat or a struck stave. It cracked in its first hard frost that same winter, a fault low in the lip that no one had thought to test for, and the founders cast a second the following spring, thicker at the waist, and that one held, and rang for the burning that year and every year after.

Tormod said little at either casting. He was a king who had learned, watching his own father and grandfather's short reigns pass one after another through a house that had buried three kings in the span of his own youth, that a crown which spoke seldom and watched closely outlasted one that spoke often; and Muileann naomh, in the years that followed, became known the length of the south coast as the house where Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹ had first put its call into bronze, and rang its bell at every measured burning long after the manner of casting it had passed out of anyone's living memory but the founders' own sons.

It became something more than that within a dozen years. Hawk-houses further north, on the coasts where Òrd na Cloiche² or the sting-oath of Manannan pressed close against Òrd an t-Seabhaig's own ground, had begun by then to let their teaching thin from one generation of keepers to the next, a rite kept out of habit more than conviction in towns where half the young no longer troubled to learn the old questions; but at Muileann naomh the teaching held as firmly as the bell held its note, 13 an t-Sultain, LE 526, so that the house came to be counted, by common report up and down the coast, the southernmost place where Òrd an t-Seabhaig's own word was still said in full and believed in full, and pilgrims who wanted the old teaching plainly given, without a northern town's newer softening, began to come to Muileann naomh from towns a week's walk further south than any hawk-house had drawn from before.

His household by then was a small one for a king's: a queen, Oighrig nic Dhùghaill, of a western house that had given the crown no trouble in three generations, and two sons born in the early years of his reign, both alive and grown by then into the ordinary business of being a king's sons, which was mostly waiting. He had, besides them, a brother nearer his own age than either boy, Aonghas mac Iain, settled at Inis thais on the south-west coast with a household of his own, and a half-brother younger than both of them, Dùghall, whom their father had got on a second wife of Baile Mòr dhomhain and who kept, by his own choice more than anyone's decree, to that house and its country rather than to An Talla Dearg³. Tormod had never quarrelled with either of them. He had watched enough of his own line's short reigns to know that a house which quarrelled among its own brothers before it needed to was a house asking to be quarrelled with later, and he meant, so far as any king could mean such a thing, not to be that kind of fool.

1. the Hawk order

2. the order of the Stone

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

II

Of An Gàire Dubh

Five years on, in the moon Òrd Mhacha¹ call Sìolach, a storm the south-coast rolls name An Gàire Dubh², came up out of the west in a single night and drove the sea clean over the waterfront of Cuan dhearg, the other Cuan dhearg, on the red cliffs of the south, and spoiled the whole season's salt fish where it hung drying on the racks below the town.

The tidings reached Cathair dhearg nine days later by a rider who had ridden two horses to death getting there, and Tormod heard them in the hall at 5 am Màrt, LE 519, standing rather than seated, which his own scribes remarked on afterward as a thing he did only when a report troubled him past sitting still for it. He sent grain south before the roads closed for the winter, not because Cuan dhearg's reeve had asked for it — no rider had come with any such asking, only the bare report of the wave — but because he judged, as he told his household plainly enough that a scribe wrote it down, that a town which had just lost a season's food had better things to spend its breath on than begging for what any king with eyes could see it needed.

Cuan dhearg rebuilt that winter and the spring after, a full street back from the old waterfront this time, on ground the sea had never yet reached in any telling the town's oldest households could call to mind, and it held. Tormod rode down himself the following summer to see the new street laid, the only time in three-and-twenty years of kingship, his scribes noted, that he had gone anywhere on the strength of a storm alone rather than a war, a crowning, or a rite the crown was bound to keep.

He walked the new street with the town's reeve, an old salter named Pàdraig Odhar who had lost his own drying racks to the wave and rebuilt them with the rest, and asked him, as they came to the end of the street where the ground began to fall back toward the old waterfront, whether the town had thought of building further back still, out of the wave's reach entirely rather than merely out of this one wave's reach. Pàdraig Odhar said that a fisher who builds too far from the water spends his life walking to it and back, and that a street a street further back was as far as any salter of Cuan dhearg meant to walk for the rest of his days, wave or no wave. Tormod said nothing more of it, judging, as he judged most things by

1. the order of Macha

2. the Black Laugh

then, that a king who had never salted a fish in his life had less business telling a fisher how far from the sea to live than a fisher had telling a king how far from the vein to dig.

III

Of the Naming at Tobar dhìreach

It was the custom of Tormod's house to have every child born into the king's own household named at Tobar dhìreach, among the wells that claim the mason's crack, rather than in An Talla Dearg¹ at Cathair dhearg, a custom his mother had brought into the family and that none of her sons had troubled to break; and in the moon of Bealltach, nine-and-twenty years crowned, he rode south again, this time for the naming of a steward's son, the child of Ailean mac Lachlainn, who had kept the king's own horses and hounds since before Tormod was crowned and asked, as was his right, for his newest boy to be named under the same slab as the king's own children had been.

A reciter of Clann na Ceiste² came down from the keepers' house to say the boy's line over him, as their order had done for every child named there since before Tormod's grandfather was crowned, and the reciters of that kindred kept, among the lines they knew, more than one thread a listener might be given: most often, for a child of the king's own household, the line of Rìghrean na Cloiche³, whose names the hearths of the east still knew in part. This reciter, an old man named Muireach mac Ailein who had said the naming over Tormod's own children and thought himself long past being asked to choose anything new, stood over the boy a long moment with his hand not yet raised to begin, and then said, to the mild surprise of the household gathered and the plain unsurprise of no one at all, the line of An Clachair⁴ instead: Neachdan and those who came after him, back to Teine a' Chlachair⁵ taken from the burnt vein.

Nobody asked him why. It was not the custom to ask a reciter why one line came to his mouth before another; the lines were held, Clann na Ceiste's own

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the Children of the Question

3. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

4. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

5. the mason's fire, the first fire

teaching ran, not chosen, and a reciter who felt one line rise in him over another said what rose. Tormod, standing at the back of the household with his own two sons beside him grown men now and both a head taller than their father, thought little of it beyond the ordinary pleasure a king takes in a well-said naming for a servant who had earned one. Muireach mac Ailein himself, asked once by a younger keeper of the house why Clann a' Chlachair⁶ and not Rìghrean na Cloiche' had come to him that day, said only that a reciter does not choose his own mouth's business any more than a river chooses which bank it wears away, and that the boy's own line, whatever it carried, was his to grow into and no one else's to read ahead of him.

IV

Of the Child at Inis thais

The next year, in Faolach, word came from Inis thais that Aonghas mac Iain's wife, Mairead nic Ailein, had borne a daughter, the first child of that marriage to live past her own naming, and Tormod, who loved his brother more plainly than he had ever managed to say to him outright, rode the sixteen miles down to the coast himself rather than send a rider with the crown's ordinary good wishes.

He found his brother's household in the small stir any first living child brings to a house that has waited for one, Aonghas himself more pleased than Tormod had seen him in years and no less awkward for it, holding the girl as a man holds something he is half afraid of dropping and wholly unwilling to hand to anyone else. They named her Catriona, for no reason either brother could afterward remember clearly enough to write down, and Tormod stood at the naming with his own two grown sons beside him, come south with their father as they had come to Tobar dhìreach the year before, both a little restless at a rite that was, to their eyes, no more than a cousin's ordinary naming and no business of theirs to stand still for.

Aonghas asked his brother, that evening, over the kind of talk two brothers have when the day's business is done and neither is yet ready to sleep, whether a girl born to a king's brother carried any weight in the world beyond her own fath-

6. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

er's house. Tormod said he did not know, and did not think it mattered much either way, since the crown sat well enough on his own two sons and would sit on their sons after them, the gods and the ford willing; and Aonghas, hearing that, said nothing more of it, and the two of them sat a while longer by the fire talking of lesser things, a good catch that season and a dispute over a boundary ditch that Tormod would have to settle before the moon was out.

V

Of Aonghas mac Iain's Death

Aonghas mac Iain died four years later, at Inis thais, in his fifty-fourth year, of a wasting that took him slowly enough that his household had time to send word to Cathair dhearg and Tormod time to ride down and sit with him three days before the end, though not long enough for either brother to say all that two brothers who have never quarrelled might still wish they had said.

Tormod buried him at Inis thais rather than bringing the body north, judging, as he told Mairead nic Ailein when she asked whether the crown would want its own brother laid at An Talla Dearg¹, that a man who had chosen to live his whole life on that coast had earned the right to lie in its ground rather than in soil his own feet had rarely troubled to stand on. He rode home slower than he had ridden down, by his own scribes' account, and was heard to say once on the road, to no one in particular, that a king buries his father and his brothers and learns nothing from either burying that a farmer does not learn from his own, save that a king's grief has a great many more people standing about to watch him carry it.

Catrìona, four years old that spring, was too young to be told plainly what had happened to her father and was told instead, in the way households tell such things to the very young, that he had gone on ahead of them to wait, and she asked, for some years after, when the household might be going to join him, until she grew old enough to stop asking and to understand the answer she had already half worked out for herself.

Her mother kept the household at Inis thais rather than take her daughter north to An Talla Dearg, though Tormod offered more than once to have them both come and live under his own roof, judging, as she told him plainly enough

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

on the one occasion he pressed it, that a fatherless girl raised in a king's own household would grow up thinking herself owed something no one had yet agreed she was owed, and that she would rather Catriona grew up a shipwright's neighbour and a fisher's neighbour than a king's ward with a claim nobody had named aloud. Tormod did not press it again, though he rode down to see them twice every year for as long as his own legs and the roads allowed it, and it was noticed, by those of his household who rode with him, that he never once, on any of those visits, spoke to the girl about her father in any way she could later have called an answer.

VI

Of the Ferry on the Abhainn fhionn

Four years after that, in the wet end of Damhrach when the Abhainn fhionn ran high with the season's rains, Tormod's two sons, well into their thirties by then and neither yet married to a house that suited every custodian's liking, rode north together on the crown's business, a dispute between two shires over a fishing weir that neither elder brother nor younger had much taste for settling but that their father had sent them to settle together, judging it past time the two of them learned to carry the crown's small business between them before either was asked to carry anything larger.

The ferry that crossed the Abhainn fhionn at the ford-keepers' crossing had carried carts and cattle and kings' messengers across that water for longer than any ferryman then living could say, a broad flat hull worked by a rope strung bank to bank, and the ferryman that day, a man named Iain Odhar who had worked the rope himself for eleven years and lost neither man nor beast off it in all that time, judged the water high but not past crossing, as he had judged it a hundred times before in a hundred wet ends of Damhrach, and brought the hull out into the current with the two king's sons, their four horses, and a farmer's cart of wool besides.

The elder of the two, by every account gathered after, had stood near the rope himself for most of the crossing, asking Iain Odhar the ordinary questions a man asks a ferryman he does not often ride with, how deep the channel ran at this height of water and how the rope held against a current that strong, more from the plain habit of a man who liked to understand a thing than from any fear of

the water; the younger stood further back with the horses, keeping them quiet, for the elder was always the one who talked to strangers and the younger the one who minded the beasts, a division of the work between them that had held since they were boys and that neither had ever troubled to question.

What came down the river that morning, from higher ground than any of them could see, was a spate the water above had not shown any sign of an hour before, a wall of brown water carrying broken timber and the wrack of some upstream bank, and it took the ferry broadside before the rope could be run in, tipped the flat hull on its beam, and put every soul and beast aboard into water running too fast and too cold for swimming to matter much either way. Iain Odhar came ashore a quarter mile below the crossing, half drowned and clinging to a length of his own rope, and lived another thirty years telling, when anyone asked and a good many times when no one had, that he had reached for the elder of the two boys and had the young man's sleeve in his own hand for the length of three strokes before the current took it from him.

The bodies were found two days apart, the younger downstream on a gravel bar within the day, the elder not until the second morning, caught in driftwood a mile further down where the river widened before Loch chrom. Tormod was at Cathair dhearg when the first rider came, and it is told there that he heard the man out standing, as he had stood to hear the tidings of Cuan dhearg's storm years before, and said nothing at all until the rider had finished, and then asked only which son, and was told it was not yet known which, since only one body had yet come ashore, and stood a while longer with that not-knowing before he asked anything else. 18 an t-Ògmhios, LE 534, is the day Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ sets against it, though the finding of the second body came two days later, and Leabhar a' Chùrain, for once, notes both dates rather than choosing between them.

He had the ferry rope cut and burned that same week, and ordered a second ferry built a mile upstream where the ford-keepers judged the crossing safer in spate, though he never crossed the water again by either rope, in all the years he had left to him, without a rider going ahead first to test how the current ran.

Iain Odhar came to Cathair dhearg himself that winter, on foot, to say before the king what he had already said before the ford-keepers and the shire's own reeve: that he had judged the water as he had judged it a hundred times, that no spate of that height had ever come down without warning in his eleven years on

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

the rope, and that he asked no pardon, since he did not hold himself guilty of anything a hundred crossings before it had not already proven safe to do. Tormod heard him out standing, in the same way he had heard the first rider out, and told him at the end of it that a king does not pardon a man for a river's business, since the river had asked no leave of either of them; and he gave the ferryman a small holding of land above the new crossing, not as payment for the two lives the old crossing had taken, which no holding could pay for, but as a keeper's fee for a man who would watch the new rope the rest of his days more closely than any king's order could make him. Iain Odhar took the land and the office both, and watched the new rope, by every account, more closely than any king's order could have made him for the thirty years he had left to keep it.

VII

Of the Thirteen Years

he had no other child, and no brother living now but Dùghall, whom he had never distrusted and never quite loved either, the two of them being too far apart in their mothers and their years to have grown close as boys, and too settled in their separate lives as men to grow close afterward. The houses did not press him to name an heir in the first year, out of what plain kindness a court can manage toward a man burying two sons within a week of each other, but by the second year the custodians of *Taigh na Fèithe*¹ had begun, quietly and among themselves at first, to reckon who stood nearest the crown should the king die without naming one, and by the fourth year the reckoning was no longer quiet.

Three names came to stand nearer than any others. Dùghall, the king's own half-brother, had a following at *Baile Mòr dhomhain* that owed him rather than the crown its first loyalty, built up over years of holding that country's own small disputes without troubling *An Talla Dearg*² to settle them. Catriona, Aonghas's daughter, grew up at *Inis thais* under her mother's roof, the last of the old king's own blood by his brother's line, and though no one had yet said the word claimant to her face, she had begun, by the time she was fifteen, to notice how the

1. the vein-house above *Muileann dhearg*

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at *Cathair dhearg*

households of that coast spoke to her with a weight they did not spend on other girls of her age, and to wonder, without yet asking anyone plainly, what that weight was for. And Ragnall Ruadh, head of Clann Raghnaill, was made master of Taigh na Fèithe at Muileann dhearg in the year Catrìona turned fourteen, the custodians choosing him over two older men of longer service because, as one of them put it to a colleague afterward, a vein-house that might soon answer to no clear crown at all had better answer, in the meantime, to the steadiest hand available; and Ragnall took the office and Leabhar a' Chùraim³ both, and said nothing at all, in the years that followed, about any claim beyond the one he already held.

A councillor who had served him since before the ferry asked him plainly, in the seventh year, whether he meant to name one of the three before age chose for him, and Tormod answered that he had buried two sons who had done nothing to deserve the water that took them, and that he was not minded to hand a crown to a niece, a half-brother or a vein-master while there was still breath in him to hold it himself a while longer, whatever the custodians whispered among their own counting. The councillor did not raise the question again, and neither, in the years that followed, did any other man of An Talla Dearg, though the counting went on regardless of what was or was not said to the king's own face.

Tormod watched the three of them grow into whatever they were growing into, from An Talla Dearg, grown quieter each year, and did what a childless old king does who cannot bring himself to choose among three claims he has not yet been asked to choose among: he ruled the small business in front of him, a boundary here, a grain dispute there, the yearly burning kept as it had always been kept, and let the larger question stand unanswered, telling himself, in the years he still had strength to tell himself anything, that there was time yet, and that a crown decided in haste was worse than a crown left, for one more season, undecided.

VIII

Of the King's Death and the Houses Divided

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

Tormod Bàn died at Cathair dhearg at seven-and-eighty years old, 8 an t-Sultain, LE 547, in his own bed and by no hand but age's, having named no heir in all the years he had left after the ferry, and it is told at An Talla Dearg¹ that his last clear words, said to the scribe sitting with him, were an order that the boundary dispute at Àth Chiar, still unsettled after three seasons, should be given to the custodians to finish rather than left for whoever came after him to inherit along with the crown.

He was one-and-fifty years crowned, among the longest reigns his house had seen, and the scribe who wrote his death into Leabhar a' Chùrain² noted, in a line no one had asked him to write and that he might as easily have left out, that the king had outlived his brother and both his sons, and had ruled the small business of a kingdom faithfully to the very end of a life that had given him, by any household's ordinary reckoning, more to grieve than to rule.

Na Seachd Taighean³ met within the month, as the custom of a vacant hall required, and found that no house among them could bring itself to name one of the three claimants over the other two, Dùghall having the loyalty of the country about Baile Mòr dhomhain, Catriona the old blood and a growing following of her own along the south-west coast, and Raghnaill Taigh na Fèithe⁴ and Leabhar a' Chùrain both in his keeping. So the houses held the hall in common: the custodians sitting together in An Talla Dearg in the crown's stead, keeping the small business of the kingdom moving, the grain rulings made and the yearly burning kept, while the larger question sat over all of it unanswered, the way a debt sits over a household that has agreed among itself only that it must, eventually, be paid.

It could not hold. In the fifth year of the common council, within the same season, messengers came from Baile Mòr dhomhain, from Inis thais, and from Muileann dhearg, each naming the same crown for a different head, and the custodians, who had held the hall in common as long as holding it in common was possible, found that it no longer was. 21 an Giblean, LE 552: three claims stood laid before the houses at once where one crown had stood a generation before, and Na Seachd Taighean, which had kept a common council for five careful years

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the seven houses of custody

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

rather than choose among the three, chose at last, each house for itself, and found themselves divided.

Of the Ford and the Fouled Wells

LE 552 – 557

I

Of the Gates Shut Against All Three

When the three claims were laid at once before the houses, in the year Le-abhar a' Chùrain¹ calls the year of the three crowns, there was one town on the capital shore that did neither. Seann Warr stood on the western water with its salt-pans steaming in the cold and its citadel above the harbour, and when the heralds of Catrìona nic Aonghais, of Dùghall Garbh and of Raghnaill Ruadh came one after another to its western gate, each was met by the same woman, and given the same answer.

Mairead nic Ruairidh had held the reeve's staff of Seann Warr for eleven years, mostly for settling disputes over the flax fields and the price of salt, and had never expected to hold it for anything harder. The town she governed was a small one as the capital shore counted towns, its wall built in An Aois Naomh² against raiders who had not come in generations, its citadel more often used for storing salt-fish than for standing a watch; but it sat on the one road that ran the whole length of the western shore, and every cart that went from the salt-pans to the capital's own market passed under its gate, so that a claimant who wished to move grain or men along that shore had first to reckon with whoever held the bar across Seann Warr's road.

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the Holy Age

She heard the first herald out in the gate-house, standing, with her arms folded in her shawl against the wind off the loch, and when he had finished naming his claimant's right she said only that Seann Warr answered to no house until the houses could agree among themselves which one it answered to, and that the gate would open to trade and shut to hosts. The herald, a young man of Cathair dhearg with a good horse and a better opinion of his own errand, told her that this was no answer a reeve of a town so small had any right to give three claimants to a crown. She told him that a town so small had exactly the right its wall could hold, and that his own claimant was welcome to come and find out how much that was.

She said the same to the second herald that afternoon and the same to the third the day after, word for word, so that afterwards men said she had learned it by rote before the first ever came, though she had not; she had simply found, each time, that it was still true, and had seen no reason to trouble herself with new words for an old fact.

20 an Cèitean, LE 553, is the day Leabhar a' Chùrain sets down her answer, though it came, in truth, three times over three days, and was the same answer each time. The bar went up across the western gate that evening, and the men of the town's own watch, farmers and salters who had never carried more than a fowling spear, stood it in turn through that winter and every winter after. Few of them loved one claimant over another; they stood the gate because Mairead nic Ruairidh had told them plainly what would happen to Seann Warr if it chose wrong, and none of them could tell her she was mistaken.

II

Of the First Siege

ùghall Garbh came first, in the moon of Faolach the following year, with a host of some four hundred, and sat down before the walls a fortnight, cutting the road east and turning back the carts of salt that were the town's whole trade. He did not want the town badly enough to burn it; what he wanted was for it to open for him rather than starve, and he waited to see which it would do.

It did neither. The salt-pans went on steaming inside the walls, for a town with the sea at its gate does not go hungry as a landward one does, and the brine

springs behind the reed marsh gave up more salt than four hundred idle men could eat fish to trade for. Mairead nic Ruairidh sent word out on the ninth night, by a boy who swam the loch shallows below the wall, that the town would give Dùghall's host bread for silver at the market rate and nothing else, and that his men were welcome to buy it standing in the road like any other traders. Some of them did. By the fortnight's end his own carters were grumbling louder than her townsfolk, and he took his host east again, having spent more silver feeding it before Seann Warr's wall than the town's whole autumn trade was worth.

"You have made a fool of him," said her steward, watching the last of Dùghall's spears go up the road.

"I have made nothing of him," Mairead nic Ruairidh said. "He made a fool of himself, coming to sit before a town that keeps its own salt. I only told him the price of bread."

III

Of the Ford at Àth shean

It is told at Cathair dhearg, from Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ and from the men who carried the tale home, how Dùghall Garbh and Raghnaill Ruadh met at the northern ford of Àth shean in the spring of the third year of the war, each having heard that the other meant to cross there, and neither willing to let the other hold the crossing first.

Raghnaill Ruadh came to the ford by the straight road, in good order, and made his camp on the near bank in the last light, meaning to force the crossing at first light before Dùghall's host, coming by the longer eastern way, could reach the far side in strength. What he did not know, and what the ford-keepers of Àth shean, who owed him no love after two winters of Taigh na Fèithe²'s silence toward their town, did not trouble to tell him, was that the river ran a mile of shallows above the town where a man could wade it dry-shod at low water, and that Dùghall's guides, drawn from among the drovers who had used that shallows for forty years to move cattle without paying the ford toll, had told him of it three days before.

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Dùghall crossed there in the last watch of the night, in silence, in a column two men wide, the water at the shallows no higher than a man's waist and running cold enough that the drovers who led the crossing had told his men beforehand to bind their weapon-belts high and their breath low, for a man who gasped at the cold could be heard across still water a long bowshot off. It took the better part of two hours to bring four hundred men over dry enough to fight, and Dùghall stood on the far bank the whole while, counting them across in the dark by touch as much as sight, because he had given his word to no man that the shallows would hold and meant to be the last one over if they did not.

They came down on Raghnaill's camp from the landward side an hour before dawn, while Raghnaill's own watch stood facing the ford and the empty road beyond it, looking for a crossing that was not going to be made where they were looking for it. What followed at the ford was not a battle so much as a breaking. Raghnaill's host, caught between the river and a host it had not seen come, went for the water in the dark, some to swim, most simply to be away from the spears, and the ford took more of them than Dùghall's men did. Men who had crossed that ford on market days their whole lives, who knew its stones by their bare feet, went into it in the dark not knowing which bank they were swimming for, and Leabhar a' Chùrain's own account, taken from survivors on both sides in the weeks after, says that more than one man drowned within a spear's throw of solid ground because he had turned himself about in the water and could no longer tell which way the current ran.

Leabhar a' Chùrain counts three hundred dead the next morning when the bodies had come down onto the gravel bars below the town, and says plainly that it could not count how many more the river carried on to the sea uncounted. Raghnaill Ruadh himself got away with perhaps a third of his host, riding, they say, without a cloak, having left it and much else on the near bank in the dark, and did not stop riding, by his own men's account, until he had put two days between himself and the ford.

22 an Gearran, LE 554, names the day. Àth shean buried what came ashore in its own ground that spring, in a long grave above the water-meadow, and for two generations after, the town would not sell fish taken above the ford.

Word of it reached Catrìona nic Aonghais at Cathair dhomhain nine days later, where she lay before the walls with her own host, and she heard it standing in the door of her tent with the morning's report of the siege lines still in her other hand, and said nothing for the length of time it takes a man to walk twice

round a small fire, and then asked only whether Dùghall meant to press east after Raghnaill or turn south. The messenger did not know. She sent him back with an answer for Dùghall that named no ally and asked for none, only that if he came south of the ford he should come knowing that Cathair dhomhain held for him, not for her, and that she would not thank him for taking it out from under her while her lines were dug.

IV

Of Doire mhin, and of the Child Seònaid

Raghnaill Ruadh's men, going south from the ford in the days after, three hundred short of the host they had been and with no silver, no grain and no standing anywhere on the road home, came in the evening to the granary village of Doire mhin, which had given carts and coal both to Taigh na Fèithe¹ without complaint for as long as anyone there could remember, and had done nothing at all to deserve what it got that night, save stand on the road they had to pass.

They took what grain the granary held, which was less than they needed, and fired the granary and a dozen houses about it before they went on. Leabhar a' Chùrainn² gives them small credit for hatred; they burned the place, it says, so that whoever followed them south, whether Dùghall's men or Catrìona's, should find nothing there to feed on. 24 an t-Sultain, LE 555, is set against it, the second burning of Leabhar a' Chùrainn records in that war and, as it turned out, the last.

Doire mhin had never been a large village, forty-one households at the fire-count Taigh na Fèithe kept of it, set in a fold of good barley land with a granary at its centre built of stone against fire and flood both, and had given its grain and its coal-carts to the crown's stores for longer than any household there could trace in its own memory. Coinneach mac Ailein farmed eleven acres of it, barley and a strip of flax by the stream, and had two things he was known for on the village green: a temper slow enough that men said you could walk to the granary and back before it rose, and a daughter who asked more questions in a day than the priest asked in a season.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

Seònaid nic Coinnich was six years old and asleep when the first of it came through the wall of the house. She remembered afterward, when she was old enough to write it down herself, very little of the fire and a great deal of her father's hands: how Coinneach mac Ailein had her under one arm and a sack of the year's seed-corn under the other before she was properly awake, and ran with her out through the smoke into the yard, where her mother already stood with the two younger children and nothing else, the byre door standing open behind her and the cow already loose and gone into the dark, because a beast, her father said afterward, has better sense in a fire than most men.

They stood at the edge of the near field and watched the granary go, and Seònaid, who did not yet understand what a granary going meant to a household that lived by it, asked her father why the men with the spears let it burn. Coinneach mac Ailein gave her no answer that night. He answered her years later, when she asked him again as a grown woman with a clerk's stylus in her hand, and by then he could say it plainly: those men had come to burn, and a man who has come to burn does not stop for a bucket.

They walked south for six days, with what neighbours had lost the same and no more, forty households or near it, carrying children and seed-corn and very little else, sleeping the first two nights in a byre a farmer three miles off let them share with his own cattle, and the rest under whatever hedge or wall the road offered, because word of the burning had run ahead of them and few doors opened easily to forty households with nothing to trade for a night's floor. Seònaid's mother carried the youngest the whole way and would not be carried herself, though she had been on her feet since before the fire and her own feet, by the fourth day, had begun to bleed through her shoes; Coinneach mac Ailein carried the seed-corn on his back the whole distance and would not set it down even to sleep, because it was, he said, the only thing that stood between the household and a second winter as bad as this one, whatever a first winter without a granary was going to be.

They came at last to Cathair mhòr, where the temple of Macha stood open on the market square and its priests, who had fed the burnt-out and the plague-struck of that shore for longer than the temple's own records ran, took them in without asking whose claimant they had voted for, because the temple had never asked that of anyone and was not going to begin for a war it had not made. The temple's own roll, set apart from Leabhar a' Chùrain's numbered days, records forty-one households sheltered at Cathair mhòr that winter on the temple's grain,

Coinneach mac Ailein's among them, and gives their names in a hand that runs on for the better part of a page.

Seònaid remembered the temple floor as warmer than the house had been, which puzzled her all her life, since the house had had its own hearth-coal and the temple floor had none to speak of; she came to think, later, that it was only that so many bodies lay close together on it, and that this was itself a kind of answer to the question her father would not answer, though it took her another twenty years to see it as one.

V

Of the Second Siege

Dùghall Garbh, having broken Raghnaill at the ford, spent the two years after in the slow, grinding work of holding what the ford had won him, and came to Seann Warr a second time, better provisioned and in no mood to buy his own bread at the market rate, and sat before it a full month.

Mairead nic Ruairidh did what she had done before, save that this time the town had less salt trade to spare and the winter came on hard behind the siege, so that by the month's end there were nights when the watch on the western wall stood without dry boots and the town's own children went without the second meal. What broke the siege, in the end, was a rider from the east, three days from Cathair dhearg at speed, who brought Dùghall word that Catrìona had sat down at last before Cathair dhomhain's own walls in earnest, closing its water gate as well as its land gate, and that if he meant to have any voice in the fate of a city that had held for him five years, he could not spend the winter sitting before a town that had never once opened a gate to him and plainly never would.

He took his host east a second time, and Seann Warr did not open its gates to any of the three claimants in the whole ten years of the war that followed, though it buried, by the war's end, more of its own townsfolk to cold and short rations than it ever lost to a spear. The salt-pans never stopped steaming through either siege, winter or summer, because Mairead nic Ruairidh held that a town which let its own trade go idle for another man's war had already lost something no gate could keep out; and it is told that on the worst nights of the second siege, with the watch standing the wall in wet boots and half the town's children crying with hunger, she walked the wall herself before dawn each morning with a lantern.

There was little to see by it in the dark; the watch stood easier only for watching her carry it.

Mairead nic Ruairidh held the reeve's staff another twenty years after the war's end, through the crowning and the quiet that followed it, and when she died the town buried her, by her own asking, standing in the gate-house doorway, facing the road, so that she should go on watching it, her steward said, whether or not there was anything left on it worth the watching.

VI

Of Cathair dhomhain, and the Wells

Cathair dhomhain had declared for Dùghall Garbh in the second year of the war, chiefly because its harbour-master had once carried grain for him as a young man and thought well of him, and Catriona nic Aonghais came against it in the autumn of the sixth year with a host she had held together, through two lean winters, on little more than her own word that she would not disband it while a rival crown stood claimed against her own.

The city stood well for a siege: walled in An Aois Naomh¹, its citadel above the river mouth, its granaries deep enough to hold two winters' grain against one summer's siege, and its harbour open behind it to the loch, so that at first Catriona's lines along the landward wall did nothing at all but let the city go on feeding itself by water, while her own men grew thin on requisitioned oats and the households of her own following began, quietly at first and then less quietly, to ask her captains how much longer a siege that fed the besieged better than the besiegers was worth keeping.

She called her captains to her tent on the seventieth night of it and asked them, one by one, what they would do in her place, and had from most of them the same counsel: raise the siege, or storm the wall while the host still had the strength to storm it, for a siege that starved no one was no siege at all. Only her harbour-master, a fisher's son of Inis thais who had come to her following for no better reason than that his own boat had been burned in the war's first year, said that the wall could be starved as easily as the granaries, for a wall's real weakness lay less in its stone than in its water; and it was from him, a man bred to boats and

1. the Holy Age

never to sieges, that she took the notion that broke it. She broke it in the eleventh week by sending her own boats, sewn coasters borrowed and begged from every fishing household on the near shore, out onto the loch by night to close the water gate as her lines closed the land gate, and after that the siege began to be a siege in earnest.

It ran forty days from the water being shut. Leabhar a' Chùrain² gives the figure plainly and gives no other: forty days, and no battle in them worth a name of its own, only the slow grinding-down that a siege is, worse for those inside a wall than for those camped before it, because those camped before it can at least walk away from their own dead. Cathair dhomhain buried its dead of the siege, at first, in the ground beyond its own walls where custom set the burying-ground; but a city under close siege cannot always spare the men, the daylight, or the ground beyond the wall for burying, and toward the end the dead of the siege lines, its own soldiers fallen at the wall and those Catrìona's engines had reached within it, were laid nearer the well-heads than any custom would have allowed in a season of peace, because there was nowhere else near enough to lay them.

The wells fouled in the fifth week of the closer siege. It began, as such things do, quietly: a taste in the water that the brewers noticed before anyone else, and then a sickness of the gut that ran first through the youngest and the oldest in the crowded inner streets, and then through the garrison itself, so that men who had held the wall a month against Catrìona's engines began to fall to something no engine had thrown. The garrison's captain, Niall Mòr mac Leòid, held the wall another nine days after the sickness took hold among his own men, because he had sworn to hold it and did not, in his own account of it afterward, know how a man unswears an oath once it is given; but by the thirty-ninth day he had buried more of his garrison to the water than to Catrìona's spears, and on the fortieth he sent to her lines under a branch, asking terms.

VII

Of the Oath, and the Garrison Walking Out

Catrìona nic Aonghais received his herald standing in the door of her own tent, as she had stood to hear the news of the ford three years before, and

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

this time she did not send the man away with a short answer. She asked him, first, how many of the garrison still stood, and he told her, and she was quiet over the number longer than the length of time it takes to walk round a small fire.

"Tell your captain," she said at last, "that I will take the city, because it has held five years for a claim I do not mean to let stand. But I will not take it over the drowned wells of forty days, and add his men's names to the stone the priests will raise for the well-sickness. Let him march his garrison out under arms, with their own wounded carried and their own dead named, and swear before my whole line that they will not take the field against me again while this war runs, and I will let them go to their own homes, wherever those stand."

The herald asked what surety she would take for the oath, since Niall Mòr mac Leòid had, after all, held the city five years for her rival.

"His word, given before my whole host with his own wounded watching him give it," Catriona said. "A man does not swear falsely with his own dying men at his back to hear him. If I am wrong in that, I will have learned something worth the learning, and it will not be the first city I have to take twice."

Niall Mòr mac Leòid marched his garrison out of Cathair dhomhain on the forty-first day, some three hundred left of the six hundred that had held it, between two lines of Catriona's host drawn up silent on either side of the road, and swore the oath standing with his own carried wounded set down behind him where the whole line could see them, in a voice, those who heard it said, that did not shake though the man himself, by then, could barely stand from nine days without proper food or sleep. Catriona rode the length of both lines afterward, alone, and said nothing to any man in them until she came to where Niall Mòr stood, and there she got down from her horse and took his hand in both of hers before the whole host, garrison and besiegers together, and told him he had held the city better than most kings hold a kingdom, and that she hoped, when this war was done, to have the use of a man who kept his oaths that well.

He did not take service with her then; he went home first, to whatever was left of a household five years' siege had not seen, and it was two years more before he came to her at Cathair dhearg and offered his sword for what remained of the war. But it is told at Cathair dhomhain still, and was told to Seònaid nic Coinnich herself when she gathered the old men's memories of that war for her book, that the garrison walked out between the two silent lines with the wells still fouled behind the wall they left, and that not one spear was raised against them the

whole length of the road, though there were men in Catriona's own lines who had buried brothers to arrows shot from that same wall not a fortnight before.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Of the Hearths Refused

LE 558 – 560

I

Of the List in the Yard

Eòghann mac Dhùghaill had kept the store of Muileann dhearg for eleven years, and in all that time he had done one thing only: he had measured out the handful. A household came up the white road with its sealed stick, and he weighed the coal against the notches on the beam, and he wrote the weight in the book, and the carrier went down again with the basket on his back. That was the whole of his work, and his father's before him, and it had not changed since the law was old.

He was standing in the yard before first light, stamping to keep the blood in his feet, when Ragnall Ruadh came out of the hall with a board under his arm.

The carriers were already gathering at the gate, breath standing white above them, the baskets stacked and the measures laid out on the trestle as they were laid out every morning of the world. Beyond the gate the road went down grey and empty into the grey shires, and somewhere below the mist a cock was crowing at a fire that had not yet been lit.

Ragnall's clerk had drawn the board up by lamplight; Eòghann could see, even across the yard, that the man had barely slept, his hand shaking a little as he held it out to his lord for a last look. Ragnall took it, and read it through once in the thin light, his breath going out slow through his nose, and then he crossed the yard and put it into Eòghann's hands.

It was a list of shires. Eòghann knew most of the names on it: the granges above Doire mhin, the temple of Macha at Cathair mhòr, three market towns that had never done him any wrong, half the households along the Abhainn fhionn. Every hearth and every temple hearth in the shires that had held for Ca-triona or for Dùghall, in one column, in the clerk's small cramped hand, with the amount each had drawn last winter written beside it, as though the winter before had been an ordinary winter, and could be totted up like any other.

"None of these," said Raghnaill Ruadh.

Eòghann looked at the list, then at him. Nine sons of the store had held this yard before him, back past his father's father to a man whose name was only a mark in *Leabhar a' Chùrainn*¹, and none of them, so far as the book showed, had ever measured a lie into the beam, and none of them had ever measured nothing. *Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig*² was older than any king who claimed the crown of it. It did not know how to withhold.

"Lord," he said, and did not know how to go on.

"None of these," Raghnaill said again, in the same voice, as if the first time had not been heard, and he turned and went in out of the wind, and the door of the hall shut behind him with the ordinary small sound a door makes, which seemed to Eòghann, standing there with the board cold in his hands, a very great deal too small a sound for what had just been done.

He stood a while with the list. Then he went to the trestle and told the first carrier in the line, a girl from one of the near granges he had weighed for since she was old enough to carry, that there was nothing for her house this week, nor for the temple at the crossroads, nor for her aunt's hearth at the mill. She did not understand him at first; she thought he was making some kind of joke that store-masters did not make, and asked him twice, and the second time he heard his own voice come out flatter than he meant it, reciting the names off the board the way he had been taught to recite the weights, because it was easier to say a list than to say a reason.

By noon the yard was three-quarters empty of baskets. The store still had coal in it, heaped black under the roof, more than enough; that was the thing Eòghann could not get past, all that day and for a long time after. Nothing had failed. Nothing had run short. A man in a hall had looked at a board and said a

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

word, and the wealth of the mountain sat exactly where it had sat the day before, only now it belonged to no one who needed it.

He weighed the handful for the households still on the board until the light went, because that at least the law still let him do, and then he banked the store's own fire for the night, and stood a moment at the gate looking down the white road with its churned tracks going nowhere in particular, half of them turned back on themselves where a carrier had come up hopeful and gone down again with an empty basket. Somewhere down there, in shires he had never seen and mostly never would, some several hundred hearths that had burned every winter of his life, and his father's, and further back than the book troubled to say, were about to go without.

He did not sleep well that night, nor for many after, though the store went on exactly as before: the beam, the notches, the book, the weighing of what was allowed to be weighed. He kept the list. Why he kept it he could not have said, except that it seemed to him a wicked thing to throw away, as if the names on it deserved at least to be kept somewhere, since they could not be kept warm.

A month into the refusal he broke a habit of eleven years and left the yard himself, on the pretence of counting a grange's stock in person, though the store had never once in his time needed his hands to count what the notches already told him. He walked down the white road past the turn-back tracks to the mill at the edge of the nearest cold shire, and found the girl from the trestle there, the one he had told first, sitting with her mother by a hearth built of nothing but hedge-cuttings and a little dried dung, smoke going up thin and bitter and not much warmth in it that he could feel from the doorway. He had meant to say something to her, some word of the kind a man carries down a road for a month rehearsing, and found when he stood in the doorway that there was nothing in it that would not sound like an excuse.

"You'll tell your notches I came," the girl's mother said to him, not unkindly, only tired past the point of anger, "and they'll not warm us any the more for it."

He went back up the white road with nothing said that he had meant to say, and weighed the handful the rest of that day for the households still allowed it, and found that his hands, at least, still knew the beam even when the rest of him did not know what to do with a law that had stopped, for a season, being a law at all.

II

Of the Cold Shires

Seònaid nic Coinnich was nine that winter, and she had already learned, at Cathair mhòr, that a fire has more than one kind of life in it.

There was the hearth-fire, which her mother tended in the byre-house where they had lodged since Doire mhin burned, banked low at night and built up at dawn with whatever the priests of Macha allowed a family that owned nothing and had brought nothing away but its names and its grief. There was the temple fire in Macha's low stone house by the market, which the priests kept for the rites of planting and the rites of the dead, and which every family of the burned granges had come to think of, without quite saying so, as the true fire of the town, the one that could not go out because it had never gone out, not in anyone's telling.

It went out that winter, in Dubhlas, on a morning so still that the smoke from the last coals stood up straight before it thinned and was gone.

She was in the market when word went round. It went the way such word does, from one mouth to the next faster than a runner could carry it, and by the time it reached her it had already grown a shape: 'Taigh na Fèithe' had shut its gate on the coal, all of it, to every hearth in every shire that had not declared for Ragh-nall Ruadh, and Cathair mhòr had declared for Dùghall in the second year of the war and so Cathair mhòr's fires were among the first refused.

Her mother did not weep, which frightened Seònaid more than weeping would have. She only stood in the doorway of the byre-house with her arms folded into her shawl and looked toward the temple, where a thin crowd was already gathering around a cold hearth as if looking at it hard enough might light it, and said, "We had a fire once too, and lost it once too," meaning Doire mhin, and went in to see how long the wood they had gathered from the hedges would last them, since wood was a thing no one's law could measure out or take back.

It was a hard winter for that alone, without the coal; the moss-cutters said afterward that it was no colder than other winters, only that a house without the black stone felt every ordinary cold twice over, because it had grown used, in a generation, to not needing to feel it at all. Children coughed who had not coughed before. An old woman two doors from them, who had come out of

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Doire mhin on the same day as Seònaid's family and had never really warmed since, was found dead in her bed on a morning when the frost had drawn flowers on the inside of the shutter. No one said the cold had killed her; that is a thing left unsaid of an old woman in a hard winter. But everyone who carried her out knew it, and said nothing, which came to the same end.

The priests of Macha did what they could with wood alone, and it was not little; they sent boys out along the hedgerows with billhooks from first light, and kept a common pot going at the temple door for any household whose own hearth had failed, and one grey-headed priest whose name Seònaid never learned told her mother, more than once, that Macha's own rites did not need the black stone, only the fire itself, of whatever the fire was made. But a common pot feeds a family; it does not warm a house through a night, and Seònaid came to know the particular sound a door made when someone went out before dawn to walk the hedgerows for themselves rather than wait on the priests' boys, a sound she heard from her own family's door more mornings than she liked to count.

It was in that season that the verse went about the cold shires, sung low over the mended hearths and the unmended ones alike, by no one whose name was kept:

Cha do chaill sinn blàr, ach chaill sinn an teine. We did not lose a battle, but we lost the fire.

Seònaid heard it first from a carter's boy in the market, who did not know where he had learned it either, only that everyone seemed to know it by the second telling, the way a tune is known before it is thought about. She never afterward heard anyone claim to have made it. It seemed, she thought later, to have come up out of the cold shires themselves, the way water comes up out of ground that has held enough of it.

Her own family's hearth went grey twice that winter and was built up again on borrowed wood both times, once by a granary man who had known her father, once by strangers who asked no thanks and gave none of their names. She watched her mother measure out the last of the good turf on the coldest night, dividing it by eye into portions no bigger than a fist, the way, she thought without yet having the word for it, the store at the mountain measured its own handful, except that her mother's measure was made out of love and the mountain's, that winter, was made out of something else.

Being nine, she did not yet understand that she would spend the rest of her life explaining that winter to people who had not lived it. What she understood, standing at the temple with the crowd that would not disperse from the cold hearth even after the priests had gone in, was only this: that a fire withheld does more work in a shire than a fire burning ever does. A burning fire is only warmth. A withheld one is a lesson, said over and over to everyone who stands and watches it not be lit, about who may give and who may not, and who has decided that they, and not the law, will be the ones to decide it.

III

Of the White Road

Catriona nic Aonghais heard the verse of the cold shires before she heard the full account of what had made it, and she understood at once, hearing only the first line sung by a woman selling barley at Cathair dhomhain's gate, that the war had changed its shape under her without her leave.

Six years she had fought for a claim she still, in her own mind on quiet nights, was not wholly sure was better than her cousins' claims. No one had been broken at the ford who had not first broken at her; Cathair dhomhain had been taken only because it would not open, and its garrison let go free because there seemed to her no honour in doing otherwise to men who had only held a gate they were told to hold. She had told herself, through all of it, that she fought for a right that was hers by blood and no worse than her cousins' rights, and no better either, and that the houses would decide it in the end the way the houses decided everything, slowly, and with much talk, and eventually.

Ragnall Ruadh had put an end to that manner of thinking for her, and, she came to believe, for every house on the island, on the morning he handed a list to his store-master.

The word reached her at Cathair dhomhain within the month: Taigh na Fèithe¹ shut. It was shut to no enemy's host, only to an enemy's hearths, granaries she had never besieged going cold because their reeve had once declared the wrong way, temples that had held the same coal-rite since before there were kings, now cold on the same law's authority that had lit them. She had grown up on Lagh an

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Loscaidh Bhig² the way she had grown up on the tide; it had simply always been there, a thing that measured and did not choose. To see it turned into a weapon in one man's hand frightened her more than any field had.

Her clerk read her the tally of shires that had gone cold, town by town, and she made him stop before he had finished. She did not doubt the count. It had only begun to feel, hearing it read out in a level clerk's voice as though it were any other tally, like another siege, laid on her behalf, in her name, by a man she had never once met on a field. She had sat forty days at Cathair dhomhain's wells and told herself the dead there were the war's ordinary cost; she found she could not tell herself the same of hearths going grey in towns she had never marched near, in shires whose only fault, so far as she could learn, was to have once sent word that they held for her, or for Dùghall, or simply had not troubled to send word that they held for Raghnaill.

Dùghall Garbh came to her camp himself, in Faolach, with six men and no herald, which she took, rightly, as a kind of oath before he had said a word. He was near the age her father would have been, grey through the beard, and he had lost the enthusiasm for the crown that she remembered in him from the first year of the war; what was left in his face, she thought, looking at him across her own hearth-fire, was something plainer and harder to argue with.

"He has made it so that none of us can have it now," Dùghall said, without preamble, meaning *Taigh na Fèithe*, meaning perhaps the crown itself. "Whichever of us wins it after this, we win a right that can be shut like a door. I would sooner lose to you than let that stand."

She did not answer him at once. She thought of the wells at Cathair dhomhain, fouled with her own dead and his allies' dead together, and of forty days she did not enjoy remembering; she thought that a woman who had done that for a claim of blood had no great room to be shocked that another claimant had done worse for the same claim. But she thought too of the verse the barley-seller had sung, unbidden, to no one in particular, and understood that a claim which had to be enforced by cold hearths was no longer only a quarrel among three houses; it had become everyone's quarrel, in every shire that burned coal, which was every shire on the island.

They joined their hosts in the same season, without ceremony beyond the joining itself: two war-bands that had spent six years in rival camps now making

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

one camp, uneasily, old wounds still being counted on both sides. A man of Dùghall's who had lost a brother at the ford stood a long while the first night looking across the fires at the men who had broken it, and it was Catriona herself who went and stood beside him and said nothing, only stood, until he went in to his own fire without doing whatever it was he had been minded to do.

The march north was slower than either host would have made alone, hampered by its own mistrust as much as by the snow, and it went through shires that had gone cold themselves, where the marching men, whichever banner they had followed into the war, found themselves giving up rations at doors they passed rather than be seen by their own captains eating well before people with nothing in the pot. No order was given for it. It happened all along the line of march, in ones and twos, and by the time the host came in sight of the mountain it had fed, by Catriona's own later reckoning, more mouths than it had killed men to get there, which she thought, when she had leisure to think of it, was as strange an arithmetic as she had ever kept.

They came on Ragnall below Muileann chrom on 14 am Faoilleach, LE 560, snow lying thick enough on the ground that the hosts could be tracked by it afterward for a mile in either direction, black lines through white where men and horses had gone down. Catriona remembered little of the fighting with any order; she remembered the noise of it going strangely flat in the cold, as though the winter swallowed half of it before it could reach her; she remembered Dùghall's standard going down and coming up again in another man's hand within the same breath, and not knowing, in the moment, whether that meant he lived or had only been carried off to die somewhere she could not see. He had lived, that day; the wound that would carry him off within the year was taken on that field, though no one there judged it more than a hard cut at the time, one among many.

Ragnall Ruadh was killed before the light failed. She did not see it done, and was glad, afterward, that she had not; she heard only that it was quick, and that his own men, when they knew it, did not press on for him. By dark the field was theirs, and she stood on it a long while in the last of the light with the cold coming up through her boots, looking at the shape of a battle already going still and ordinary under the snow, the way any field looks the day after, whatever was fought over it.

The next morning, before she had sent any order of her own to Taigh na Fèithe, its gates opened from within. Raghannall's own custodians, the men who had measured and weighed and written in *Leabhar a' Chùrainn*³ all through the winter of the refusal, came out and struck off the seal Raghannall had put on the store, without waiting to be told which claimant now held the mountain, because, as one of them said plainly to her clerk, the law had never asked them to wait for that; it had only ever asked them to measure the handful, and they had gone a season without doing the one thing the law had ever asked of them, and were glad, that morning, of an excuse to do it again.

Eòghann mac Dhùghaill was among them at the gate that morning, the board still kept in the store where he had set it that first day, face to the wall, unwilling to scrape the names from it and unwilling to hang it up. He did not show it to the custodians, nor to Catriona when she came up to the yard some days after and thanked the store for its work as though the refusal had been a hardship visited on the store as much as on the shires, which in its way it had been. He kept the board a long time after, years past the point when anyone but himself remembered what had been written on it, and never scraped it clean; he found, to his own surprise, that he never forgot a single name on it either, whether the board was clean or not.

The carriers who had turned back at the gate two winters running went up the white road once more, and this time came down it loaded, baskets on their backs, breath white in the cold morning the same as every ordinary morning of the world, going down toward shires that had learned, that winter, exactly how much they depended on a road they had never before had cause to think about.

Word of the first hearth relit reached Catriona at the mountain, brought by a rider who had ridden through the night to bring it, as though it were news of a battle rather than the small quiet thing it was: a temple fire at Cathair mhòr, built up again from a carrier's basket by hands that had built it up from borrowed turf and hedge-wood all that winter, catching at last on coal that was, once more, simply coal, and not a lesson.

She thought of the verse then, the one line of it she had by heart, and thought that whoever had made it unmade, without knowing they were doing it, had left out the other half of the telling: that a fire can be lost without a battle, but it can also, as this one was, be won back without one, by men who had only ever wanted

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

to go on weighing the handful the way their fathers had, and by two claimants who had learned, at last, on the same field, what it cost to let the mountain be turned against the shires it was meant to warm.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

OF CATRÌONA Bhuadhach

LE 561 – 604

I

Of the Wound That Would Not Close

Word came to Catrìona nic Aonghais in Faolach, twelve days after the field below Muileann chrom, that Dùghall Garbh was dying at Baile Mòr dhomhain of a cut he had taken in the fighting and had told no one, that day or for a week after, was more than a graze.

She had not seen the wound herself. She had seen him ride from the field with his standard up again in another man's hand, and had taken that, as everyone in her own camp had taken it, for a sign of nothing worse than a hard day; men lost standards and found them again in a battle without losing much else. It was only afterward, from the mouth of a rider sent ahead of the litter, that she learned the cut had gone in under the arm where the mail gapped, and that Dùghall had bound it himself with a strip of his own shirt and said nothing of it to his own physicians until the fever was already three days old.

"He would not send for you," the rider told her, standing in the doorway of the house she had taken for her lodging, snow melting off his shoulders onto the floor. "He said there was nothing to send for."

She went anyway, and was three days on the road behind him, and arrived at Baile Mòr dhomhain to find the thing already over. Dùghall Garbh had died in the night, in the same low stone hall where his father and his father's father had held their own court apart from the crown for three generations, with his own

physician asleep in a chair beside him and no one else in the room. They told her, those who had been in the house, that he had asked once, near the end, whether Taigh na Fèithe¹ gates were open, and been told they were, and said nothing further that anyone had thought to write down.

She stood a long while over him before they closed the hall to strangers, a man she had fought six years to beat and then one season to save, grey through the beard as she remembered him from the camp-fire where he had first come to her with six men and no herald, older now only by the stillness. She had not loved him, and had not, she thought, even wholly trusted him, not in the season they marched together, watching each night to see which of his captains still eyed her own with the old war's suspicion. Yet she had believed him, in the one thing he had said to her that had mattered, that a crown enforced by cold hearths was a crown that belonged to no house at all, and looking down at him she understood that he had believed it to the very end, past the point where believing it cost him anything but his own life.

She sat with him a night before the hall was closed, though there was no longer anyone to sit with, only a body laid out in the manner his own house kept, feet to the door, a cup and a straight knife set beside him that no one had thought to take away though he had no more use for either. A servant of the house brought her a bowl of broth she did not eat and a blanket she did not use, and stood in the doorway a while as though waiting to be dismissed before she understood that the queen meant to sit the whole night through and left her to it. Catriona found, sitting there, that she could not settle her mind on grief exactly, nor on triumph, though either would have been a simpler thing to carry out of that room than what she did carry, which was closer to a kind of exhausted gratitude, that the war had found an ending that did not require her to be the one who ended it by killing the last man who might have carried it on.

His captains came to her camp within the fortnight, not as men surrendering — there was no field left to surrender on — but as men arriving somewhere they had already decided to be. Their spokesman was an old man named Artair mac Lachlainn who had fought at the ford against Raghnaill's host and lost a son there, and he laid no terms before her at all, only said that Dùghall Garbh had told them, before Muileann chrom, what he meant to do if the battle went their way, and that he saw no reason a dead man's word should bind them less than a living

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

one's. In the weeks after the field she had expected to spend a season yet gathering in a house whose lord had died without naming who should have his men, not to spend it, instead, sitting in a borrowed hall listening to captains who had killed men of hers not two winters before tell her, plainly and without much ceremony, that the war they had all three been fighting was over, and had been over since the morning Taigh na Fèithe gates opened from within.

She rode to Cathair dhearg in LE 562, to An Talla Dearg² her uncle's line had held since before her birth, and was crowned there in a ceremony she remembered afterward, when she thought of it at all, chiefly for how little of it there was. No old king sat in the hall to hand her the crown as his own had been handed to him; the crown itself had lain fifteen years in a strongbox in Taigh na Fèithe's custody, no one quite sure whose to keep it was until the custodians themselves sent it down under guard with a note, in a clerk's hand, that the crown of Dia-thìr was the crown of Dia-thìr whoever wore it, and Taigh na Fèithe claimed no more of it than that. The heads of Na Seachd Taighean³ swore to her one after another, in the order the old rolls gave them, and she watched their faces as they knelt and understood, better than she let herself say aloud that day, that not one of them knelt to her because they believed her the rightful queen. They knelt because the war had gone on ten years and killed enough of their own sons that none of them, not even the houses that had held for Raghnaill to the last, could find in themselves the appetite to ask whether a fourth claimant might do better.

She was called Catrìona Bhudhach from that year, Catrìona the Victorious, and she came, in time, to find the name harder to carry than the crown. A victory won because the losing side had exhausted itself first was not, she thought more than once in the quiet of the years that followed, a thing a person ought to be praised for as though it were a feat of arms; and yet the name stuck to her the way names do, said so often by so many mouths that in the end even she began to answer to it as though it were simply hers, the way a scar becomes simply part of a face.

At Muileann dhearg that same winter, Eòghann mac Dhùghaill kept the store as he had kept it through the whole of the refusal, and did not scrape clean the board on which Raghnaill Ruadh's list still stood, face to the wall in the storeroom where no visitor saw it. When word of the coronation reached the mountain he sent down, with the season's ordinary account, a single line that the new queen's

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the seven houses of custody

household never saw and that he never explained to anyone who asked: that the store had gone one whole season without doing the one thing the law had ever asked of it, and would not do so again while he held the beam.

II

Of the Sentence in the Yard

Three years a queen taught her more of the shape of her own kingdom than ten years a claimant had. She rode the shires that had gone cold in the refusal and found some of them slow to trust a coal that had once been taken from them by a man wearing the same office she now wore; she rode the shires that had stood by Raghnaill and found some of them slower still to trust a queen who had beaten their lord in the field. What she came to understand, riding between the two, was that the war had not truly ended at Muileann chrom. It had only stopped being fought with hosts. It went on being fought, in a smaller and more patient way, every time a reeve in a formerly hostile shire wondered aloud whether the new queen might, in a hard winter, do to his hearth what the old master of Taigh na Fèithe¹ had done to another's.

She went up to Muileann dhearg in LE 565 to put a stop to the wondering, and found the seven heads of the houses less willing than she had hoped to have their own power bound in the same stroke that bound the crown's.

They met in the same yard where Eòghann had stood seven years before with the list in his hands, because Catriona had asked for it to be the same yard, and had said, when one of the heads suggested the hall would be warmer, that the law they meant to write belonged to the place where it had been broken, not to a fire and a bench. It was a cold morning even for the mountain, the beam and the trestle still standing where they always stood, the measures hung on their pegs, and Eòghann himself sent for and set to stand at her shoulder, not to speak unless spoken to, only to be seen standing there while the houses argued over words.

The argument went three days. Every head agreed, in the first hour, that no crown ought to be able to do again what Raghnaill Ruadh had done; agreement on that much cost nothing, since Raghnaill was dead and none of the seven wished to be thought his heir in spirit. It was the second half of the sentence that

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

cost something, and Catriona had known, before she rode up the mountain, that it would. A law that bound only the crown left every house free to do, within its own galleries, exactly what Ragnall had done from Taigh na Fèithe's own store; and three of the seven, when she said so plainly, went quiet in a way she had learned by then to read as houses doing arithmetic about their own galleries rather than about the law.

"You ask us to bind our own hands," said the head of Clann Ìomhair, an old woman named Beathag nic Uisdein who had held for Ragnall to the last field and lost two sons doing it, "for a wrong none of us has done."

"None of you has done it yet," Catriona said. "Ragnall had not done it either, the morning before he did it. He had kept the store honestly for years before that morning. I do not ask you to swear you would never become him. I ask you to write it down so that if any of you ever does, the writing itself will already be older than the wrong, and no one will be able to say the law only learned to forbid it after the fact."

They wrote, and struck out, and wrote again, through the better part of three days, a clerk of Taigh na Fèithe setting each draft on a fresh board and the seven heads picking at it word by word the way Catriona had once seen carpenters pick at a joint that would not sit true, testing every phrase for the gap a future Ragnall might slip through. Eòghann was asked, on the second day, to say plainly what Ragnall had said to him in the yard, and did, in the same flat voice he might have used to read out a season's weights, and something in the flatness of it did more to settle the argument than any of the queen's own words had. A man who had stood where he stood, and could still say only "he gave me a list, and I measured no lie into the beam before that morning, and none after," was harder for any house to argue against than a queen with a claim to press.

What they set down at the end of the third day was one sentence, no longer than the one Ragnall had spoken in the yard seven years before, and Catriona thought, hearing Taigh na Fèithe's clerk read the final draft aloud in the cold, that there was a kind of justice in that, a wrong undone in exactly as many words as it had taken to do it: that no claimant, house or king might withhold the measured handful from any lawful hearth. The seven heads set their marks to it one after another, Beathag nic Uisdein last and longest, her hand steady enough on the board but her face, Catriona thought, that of a woman signing away something she had not fully decided she wished to give up. It was Riaghailt an Teallaich,

Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig³ the record kept that bound the custodians themselves and not only the households that came to them, and it went into Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴ beside Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig it was written to guard, in the same hand, on the same page, as though the two had always belonged together.

Eòghann kept his own copy of it, in his small cramped store-hand, and hung it on the peg beside the board that still faced the wall, and told no one, then or later, which board he meant a visitor to read first if ever he showed them the room.

Catrìona rode down from the mountain that third evening in a snow that had begun again in the afternoon and did not let up before she reached the low country, and found herself turning the sentence over in her own mind the whole way, testing it the way the houses had tested it, for the gap she might herself have left in it without meaning to. She had wanted, going up, a wall no future Raghannall could climb; what she had instead, she understood by the time the lights of the first shire town showed through the snow, was a fence with seven gates in it, one for each house, each gate held shut for now by seven heads who had watched what the withholding did to a mountain full of men no better and no worse than their own tenants. A fence was not a wall. She thought, riding through the dark, that it would have to serve, since no queen who had spent ten years learning what a crown could and could not compel was fool enough to believe a wall could ever truly be built at all; the most any law could do, she had come to think, was to make the breaking of it loud enough that the next generation would hear the noise before it happened again, not merely read of it after.

III

Of the Clerk and the Road

A girl of seventeen came to An Talla Dearg¹ the following year, sent up from Cathair mhòr by a Macha priest who had taught her her letters on the strength of nothing but her own asking, and stood in the yard a whole morning before anyone thought to ask her business. Her name was Seònaid nic Coinnich, and her father, Coinneach mac Ailein, a farmer of Doire mhin, had

2. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

3. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

come through the two winters of the refusal with a cough he never afterward lost; she did not tell the queen this outright, that first morning, only that she could read and write in a fair hand and had walked from Cathair mhòr on the strength of a rumour that the household of a queen who had fought for the cold shires might have use for a clerk who remembered what the cold shires were.

Catrìona took her in without much ceremony, partly because the household's old clerk was failing and partly, she admitted to herself only once the girl was already settled in the scribes' room, because there was something in being served by a daughter of Doire mhin that felt to her like a debt being paid rather than a favour being given. Seònaid proved quick with a pen and quicker with a question, and within a year had made herself useful enough at the ordinary business of the household — tallies, petitions, the endless small grain of a court's paperwork — that no one thought any longer to remark she had come up from a burned granary with nothing but her letters.

The queen's own household, in those years, held its griefs quietly and in order, the way a well-run house holds everything. Her husband, Iain mac Eachainn, whom she had married in the second year of the war more for the alliance his house brought than for any great warmth between them, and had come in the years after to be genuinely fond of, in the unhurried way two people grow fond of each other across a shared table over enough winters, died in LE 594 of a wasting in the chest that no physician in the hall could name or slow. He had never much liked to be spoken of as a king; he had kept, all his years in An Talla Dearg, to the smaller business of the household, the granaries, the stables, the endless small disputes among the servants, and left the larger business of the crown entirely to her, and she found, in the months after his death, that she missed most precisely that smallness, the sound of him settling some trifling quarrel between two grooms in the next room while she sat with a petition she could not settle at all.

Seònaid was not the only one of the cold shires' children the household took in during those years, though she was the one who stayed longest and rose highest; two others, a boy from Cathair mhòr and a girl from a burned granary near the ford, were given places among the household's servants and left again within a few years for households of their own, and Catrìona, who kept a rough tally in her own head of how many such places she had filled since her crowning, thought of it less as charity than as a kind of quiet accounting, a debt the crown owed the shires whose hearths a claimant's war had once cost, paid out a place at a time rather than all at once. Seònaid herself never spoke of the debt in those

terms, not to the queen and not, so far as anyone in the scribes' room ever heard, to herself; she asked, in her first winter at the hall, only to be shown Leabhar a' Chùrain²'s oldest entries, and spent whatever hours the ordinary work of the household left her copying out, in her own fair hand, the tallies of the refusal from the winters her own family went cold, a labour no one had asked of her and that she never fully explained, though the queen, coming on her at it once by lamplight, asked no questions either, only let her be.

She threw herself, that year and the years after, into the one piece of work that felt to her like it might outlast her own reign in a way no ruling of a court ever quite did: a road. Her own town, Inis thais, lay a hard two days from the capital by the old cart-track, a road that turned to a mire from Bealltach to Lùghnas and stranded carts to the axle every wet spring, and she had grown up hearing her own kin at Inis thais complain of it the way people complain of weather, as a fact of the world rather than a thing that might be mended. She had the stone laid herself, in the years between LE 565 and LE 584, south from the capital by a market town on the old track and past Am Buabhall Fortanach at Doire shean, the old hostel Eilidh nic Chaluim had rebuilt in stone four centuries before, all the way down to her own gate at Inis thais; and she rode the whole length of it herself twice while it was building, in a cart with iron-shod wheels she had had made for no other purpose than to feel, under her own body, whether the stone held.

It came to be called Rathad na Banrighinn³, though she had never asked for the name and could not, when a courtier first used it to her face, remember having given anyone leave to use it. The first carters to run the whole length of it did so within the year the last stone was laid, salt-carts and grain-carts that had once taken three days where the road now let them do it in two, and one of them, an old man who had driven the mire road for forty years before the stone came, told a rider of the household, in words that were carried back to her and that she kept, in her own way, longer than she kept most compliments, that he had driven the new road with his eyes shut half a mile at a stretch, only to feel the cart go steady under him the whole way, a thing he had never once been able to do on the old track without losing a wheel to it.

The building of the road cost her more of the treasury than any single work of her reign, and more than one head of house asked her plainly, in council, why a queen should spend so much stone on a track to her own town when the mire

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the queen's road

road had carried grain and salt well enough for three generations before her. She answered them, the one time the question was put to her outright, that she had not built it for her own town at all, though she did not trouble to hide that she was glad it reached her own gate; she had built it because a kingdom bound together by a law written in a cold yard on a mountain ought to be bound together, too, by roads that did not fail every spring, and that a house which could not be reached in the wet season by anything heavier than a laden mule was, in every way that mattered to a hearth in winter, as far from the crown as the far coast the fleet had gone looking for. Whether the council believed her reasons or only tired of arguing against a queen who had already begun laying the stone before the question was put to her, the road went on being built, mile by mile, through the years Taigh na Fèithe⁴'s ruling was still settling into Leabhar a' Chùrain's habit.

To Seann Warr, that had shut its own gates against all three claimants and been besieged twice for the shutting and taken by neither, she granted, in LE 594, the right to keep its own gates and take its own tolls, a thing no other town on the island held of the crown; and when the grant was cut over the landward gate in stone letters a mason's apprentice had spent a season shaping, she rode down to see it done and stood a while reading her own name in a hand not her own, thinking, as she had thought at her own coronation, that there was a kind of victory in a town's stubbornness that deserved more honour than her own had ever quite earned, since Seann Warr had held to nothing but its own gates, and never once had to be forgiven for choosing wrongly.

IV

Of the Single Day

She grew old at An Talla Dearg¹ the way her uncle Tormod Bàn's line had grown old before her, without the long unnatural years the first children of the island's oldest houses had once been given and had, one by one, been made to give up; she counted six-and-thirty years at her crowning and eight-and-seventy at her death, and never once, in all the years between, heard anyone re-

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

mark on the length of her reign as though it were a wonder, only as though it were simply what a long life looked like, now, on Dia-thìr.

She died at Cathair dhearg in LE 604, in the same hall where she had been crowned with so little ceremony, and left behind her a son, Lachlann mac Iain, not yet forty, who had spent the better part of his own life at the edges of her court learning a trade he had never much sought and could not now refuse. He had been, by his mother's own choosing, kept away from Taigh na Fèithe²'s business until he was old enough to understand what it had cost his mother's generation to bind it, and he came to the crown, in the weeks after her death, with a caution Catrìona herself had never had the leisure to learn slowly; he had learned it, instead, all at once, from watching what the writing of one sentence in a cold yard had taken out of his mother.

She had told him once, the only time he ever asked her outright what it had cost to write Riaghailt an Teallaich³, that the hardest part of the three days on the mountain had been the waiting afterward far more than the arguing, the years spent not knowing whether seven marks on a board would hold when the next hard winter came and tested them; and that a king who inherited the ruling already made would never know that particular waiting, which she counted, in her own way, as a mercy she had bought him at some cost and was glad to have bought. He remembered the saying, standing at her grave in a cold that reminded more than one of the older mourners of the yard at Taigh na Fèithe forty years before, and thought that he understood it a little better now than he had when she first said it, though he would go on, in the quiet way of a man newly come into an office too large for him, understanding it better still for years afterward.

The seven heads swore to him within a single day of her burial, a thing the household's clerks remarked on at the time and Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴ set down afterward as worth remarking, since no crown in living memory had passed so quickly or so quietly from one hand to the next. Beathag nic Uisdein, grown very old herself by then, was the first to kneel, and was heard by more than one witness to say, low, as she rose, that she knelt this time to the son of the woman who had made her put her own mark to a law she had once thought bound only her enemies, and had come, in the years since, to be glad of the binding.

Seònaid nic Coinnich stood at the back of the hall that day, no longer the girl who had walked up from Cathair mhòr with nothing but her letters but a woman

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

near sixty herself, grey and steady, kept on through three changes of clerk beneath her because no one in the household could be found who knew the old rolls half so well. She had spent the two years before the queen's death gathering, at Catrìona's own asking, the memories of everyone still living who had fought in the war of the three claims — an old man who had stood at the ford, a store-master's son, a woman of Doire mhin who still remembered the cold with a plainness that made even Seònaid, who had lived it too, wince to hear it set down; and she stood in the hall that day of the swearing with the beginning of that work already half written in a chest in the scribes' room, and thought, watching the seven heads kneel one after another in the space of a single afternoon, that she was watching the last event her book would need before she could call it finished, though she did not yet have the last of its words.

It is told that she counted the swearings as they happened, without meaning to, the way a clerk counts anything set before her in order; that she reached seven and found herself still standing, listening to the new king's voice give its first answer in a hall that had heard four changes of ruler go far less smoothly than this one had; and that she went back to the scribes' room that same evening, before the feast that marked the day was even lit, and wrote at the top of a fresh leaf the opening words of the history of the war, in a hand she meant to be steady enough that no one who read it after her would doubt a single line of it.

Of the Book of the Three Claimants

LE 605 – 650

I

Of the Old Boards

Sèonaid nic Coinnich had counted the hours of the swearing at Cathair dhearg the way a woman counts a fever, waiting for it to break into something she could name, and when it broke into nothing more than a new king sitting where an old queen had sat, she found she did not know what to do with the counting afterward. She had been Catrìona's clerk for thirty-eight years. She did not know how to be anyone's clerk who was not Catrìona's.

Lachlann mac Iain kept her on, as his mother had told him to before she died, though he did it, Seònaid thought, the way a man keeps a piece of furniture whose use he has not yet worked out: with respect, and no particular purpose. She had a chest in the scribes' room already, and in the chest the beginning of a work the old queen had set her to two years before her death: an old man's account of the ford, a store-master's son's account of his father's board, a woman of Doire mhin's account of the cold. She had taken them down quickly, in the odd hours a court leaves a clerk, and had known even as she wrote them that they were only a beginning, three voices where a war had had thousands, and that a thing set down quickly is not the same as a thing set down whole.

For the better part of a year after the swearing she did nothing about the chest at all, copying grants and witnessing seals and sitting at the foot of a council table where the talk went on around her as if she were the table itself. Petitions came up

from every corner of the shires that summer, a broken weir here, a boundary quarrel there, the small unending grain of a kingdom that has just settled a crown and finds it still has to be fed and watered like any other year; and Seònaid, copying them into the record hour after hour in a hand grown steadier than her own thoughts, began to feel the three leaves in the chest at her back the way a person feels a door left open in a cold room, a draught she could not place until she finally turned and looked at where it came from. It was in that year, doing work that did not much matter, that she understood the three accounts she already held were only a doorway, and that most of the men and women who had lived through the war she had lived through as a girl were dying, one by one, without anyone having gone back to ask them anything further.

She went down to Seann Skell in Bealltach on business that was not, in truth, business: a grant of the harbour dues that could as easily have gone by rider, and did not need a clerk to carry it in her own hand. The harbour-house stood where it had always stood, low and long above the strand, its lamp lit though it was mid-day, out of a habit no one now living could account for.

The scribe who kept the boards that year was a spare, careful man named Ailean mac Mhurchaidh, the fourth or fifth to hold the office since the roll was first opened, though he could not himself have said which; the line of scribes before him had not troubled to number themselves, only to keep the boards. He received her grant, read it, and set it aside without excitement, and when she lingered he seemed to understand, without being told, that she had not come for the grant at all.

"You'll want to see the old boards," he said. It was not a question.

He brought them out from the back room where they were kept, wrapped in oiled hide against the damp off the strand: a dozen of them, the wood gone dark with age and handling, the writing on the nearer ones still sharp, the writing on the far ones softened almost to shadow. He laid them on the counting-table one by one and let her look without saying anything more, which she thought afterward was the kindest thing anyone had done for her in that whole grey year.

She had heard Rolla nan Deònach¹ spoken of all her life, the way one hears of a flood or a fire that happened before one was born: as a fact, worn smooth by telling, with no particular weight to it. She had not understood, until she stood over the boards with her own hands not touching them, that it was a list of

1. the roll of the willing

names, ordinary names, struck through in some places with a single decisive line and left standing in others, and that every stroke and every name left standing had once been a household deciding something in a room she would never see.

"That one," said Ailean, laying a finger an inch above a name near the board's edge, not touching the wood itself, "is the first that was struck. A net-maker, it's said, who asked the scribe of that day to scrape his name out so no one would know it had ever stood there. He wouldn't do it. Struck through, he told her, so a man may know a decision was made and unmade, but not scraped clean, as if it had never been made at all. Every board since has kept the rule."

Seònaid looked at the line through the name for a long while. She thought of her own father, who had never once, in the whole of his life, told her whether he had thought of going, in the days before she was born when a fifth of the island still could; he had come through the refusal with a cough that never left him and died of it before the old queen, and she had never asked him, and now there was no one left to ask.

"Who keeps the count of what's on these," she said at last, "against what's lost?"

"No one," said Ailean. "The boards are the count. When they're gone, so's the roll."

She rode back to Cathair dhearg with the grant delivered and forgotten, and a different errand taking its place in her without her having chosen it.

II

Of the Witnesses

She went back, in the winter of that year, to the men and women whose voices already sat in her chest, and found that a second asking drew more out of each of them than the first hurried asking, made in the margins of a busy court, had ever done.

The first was a man named Fearchar Ciar, who had fought at the ford under Raghnaill Ruadh's banner in the year Leabhar a' Chùraim¹ counted some three hundred dead, and who was, by his own account, one of perhaps a dozen still living who had stood in the water that day and come out the other side of it. What

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

he had given her two years before, hurried, had been little more than that the water was cold and the noise had gone on longer than he expected and that he had lost a brother he did not care to speak of. Now, with no queen's business waiting on either of them, Seònaid sat with him three afternoons running, asking nothing, only listening, before he told her, on the fourth, of the moment the line broke and which way the men had run and how he had known, from the sound alone before he saw it, that the ford had turned against his side.

She wrote it down that night by her own lamp, and read it back the next day, and found that half of what he had told her did not match Leabhar a' Chùrainn's account of the battle at all: the book gave the numbers and the day and the outcome, but nothing of which way a man had run, or what the water had sounded like, or that the fighting had gone on, by Fearchar's memory, well past the hour the book gave for its ending. Both accounts she kept. Setting them side by side on the same leaf, she did not think either was a lie.

The second witness she went back to with more purpose than the first. Dòmhnall mac Eòghainn was the son of Eòghann mac Dhùghaill, who had been master of the store at Taigh na Fèithe² in the year of Na Teallaichean Fuara³ and had kept, until his own death, a board with the names of the shut-out shires written on it, face to the wall, never scraped clean. He had told her of the board once already, briefly, in the last year of the old queen's life; this time, asked to bring it out again, he did so with the same unwillingness his father had shown in showing it to anyone, though he did, in the end, turn it to the light and stand while she copied it in full, where before she had only been let glance at it.

"He never told me why he kept it," Dòmhnall said. "I asked him once, when I was young enough to ask things plainly, and he said only that a man who has done a thing owes it to the doing to remember it, whether the thing was done to him or by him or only in front of him. He wasn't sure, by the end, which of the three it had been, for him."

She copied the names from the board, all of them, though she never learned what use, if any, she would make of a list of shires that the war itself had already listed elsewhere, in its own harder ledger of the dead. She copied it, she told herself, because Eòghann mac Dhùghaill had thought it worth keeping unscraped for the whole of his life, and she did not think it was her place to be the one who finally let it go.

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the cold hearths

The third witness was the one whose first telling, two years before, had cost Seònaid the most to hear and the least to write. Mairead nic Aonghais was a woman of Doire mhin near enough Seònaid's own age that the two of them had been girls in the same winter, in the same charity at the same temple, though neither had known the other then; and what she had given the old queen's clerk the first time, hurried and half against her own will, had been three sentences and a look Seònaid still remembered better than the sentences. Seònaid sent word to Doire mhin, and in LE 618 rode down herself to Cathair mhòr rather than ask the woman to make the journey a second time, and sat with her the better part of a day at the temple whose fire had gone grey and been relit in Seònaid's own childhood.

"I don't remember you," Mairead said, looking at her plainly across the table, "and you don't remember me, and I think that's as it should be. We were none of us paying much attention to each other, that winter. We were paying attention to the fire."

She told it as Seònaid herself would have told it, had anyone thought, at the time, to ask a child: the undyed wool cut down for a girl too big for last year's cloak and too small for a grown woman's; the particular hunger of a cold hearth's second week, food enough in the store and none of it fit to eat, because nothing among it would properly cook; the exact sound, which Seònaid had forgotten until Mairead named it, of ice forming overnight in a water-jar left too near a wall with nothing behind it to warm. Seònaid wrote almost nothing while Mairead spoke; she found, for the length of that afternoon, that she did not need to, because she already had it, had always had it, and had only needed someone else's voice to give her leave to write it down as more than her own single memory.

III

Of the Custody-Book at the Mountain

S

he went up to Muileann dhearg in LE 619, a journey she had not made since she was a girl too young to remember it, carried up the white road once, so her mother had told her, on a matter of the family's own right to the coal that had been settled and forgotten long before the refusal ever touched them. She went now on a different errand: to set the leaves she had gathered against Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ itself, the record the crown and every house trusted above any single voice, and to find, where she could, the places where a witness's memory and the book's plain word did not agree.

She found more such places than she had expected, and fewer than she had feared. The book gave the day the ford broke as one day; Fearchar Ciar had sworn to her it was two, the fighting resuming at first light after a night neither side had thought worth entering in any ledger. The book gave the dead at the ford as some three hundred; it did not say, because no clerk of that year had thought to ask, how many of the three hundred had drowned before a blow was struck at them at all, carried under by their own mail in water that had, by every witness's telling, been running high with the spring melt. No book alone could settle such a question. She set both figures down side by side in her own leaves, Leabhar a' Chùrain's count and the water's, and let a reader who came after choose between them, or hold both, as she herself had come to do.

The clerk who kept the book that season was a careful young man, new enough to the office that he still checked his own entries against an older clerk's before he trusted them, and he watched Seònaid work with an interest she found, at first, faintly unsettling, until she understood that he had never before seen anyone treat Leabhar a' Chùrain as a thing to be questioned rather than simply copied. "It's not wrong," he said to her once, defensively, when she pointed out a date that could not be squared with another entry three pages on. "It's only what the clerk of that year was told, and wrote down as he was told it."

"I know it," Seònaid said. "I don't think it's wrong. I think it's a book kept by one man in one room, the same as mine will be, and I'd rather say so plainly than let the next clerk after me believe it fell from the sky whole."

He let her sit three days in the room where the book was kept, under the same low roof cut into the hill that Catrìona had once stood beneath with the seven heads arguing a single sentence into existence, and she found, working there, that the yard outside still kept the beam and the trestle much as it must have stood on

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

the morning Raghnaill Ruadh brought his list out into the cold; the carriers still came up the white road with their sealed sticks, stamped their feet against the same cold, went down again with baskets that were never, now, sent back empty. No one in the yard remarked on the history of the place to her, or seemed to think it needed remarking on; a thing that has become ordinary again, she thought, watching them, is very often the truest sign that it was once terrible, since only the terrible ever needs so thorough a forgetting.

She asked, before she left, to see the board Eòghann mac Dhùghaill had kept, thinking it might still hang somewhere in the store, and was told it had gone south with his son years before and was hers to ask after there, which she had, of course, already done. She rode down from the mountain with her leaves no more numerous than when she had climbed it, but surer, in a way she found hard to put into words even to herself, of which of the numbers she carried were the war's and which were only the book's; and she thought, on the road, that this difference was very nearly the whole of the work she had set herself, though she would not have known how to say so plainly to anyone who asked her outright what her book was for.

IV

Of the Book Made One Tale

By Ògach of the year Leabhar a' Chùraim¹, copied at Cathair dhearg, gave as LE 624, Seònaid had more leaves of testimony than she had months left, by her own private reckoning, to make anything of them, and she understood, sitting one evening with the boards from Seann Skell, the store-master's tally, the old soldier's account and the temple-girl's memory all spread before her on the same table, that she had a choice to make that no one before her had had to make in quite the same way.

Leabhar a' Chùraim told the war as Leabhar a' Chùraim told everything: an entry for each year, a name, a number, a date, no year touching the year before or after it except by the plain fact of coming after. It was the record the crown trusted, and it was, she thought, turning its pages against her own gathered leaves, no more the war than a tally of a hearth's coal was the fire it had fed. She had read it a

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

hundred times and could not, from it alone, have said which way Fearchar Ciar had run at the ford, or what a cold hearth had sounded like to a girl too young to be told why it was cold.

She resolved, in that year, to write it whole, as one telling and not as the book had always kept it, entry by entry with each year a stranger to the year before it: from the drowning of the two princes in the river's spate through the swearing of the houses to Catriona's son in a single day, with every witness's voice let into it where she had one, and Leabhar a' Chùraim's plain word standing in where she had none. She did not know, beginning it, that no one on the island had ever done such a thing before; she found that out only afterward, when others told her so, and she was never sure, to the end of her life, whether it was a thing to be proud of or only a thing that happened to fall to her because she was the one still living who had both the leaves and the leisure.

She wrote through the spring and into the summer, at a table in a room off An Talla Dearg² that had been Catriona's own study, working by the queen's old inkstand because it was there and no one had thought to give it to anyone else. Lachlann came in on her once, unannounced, and stood reading over her shoulder longer than she was comfortable with before he said anything.

"My mother is in here," he said at last, meaning the pages, not the room.

"She is," said Seònaid. "So is your uncle Dùghall, and Ragnall Ruadh, and a good many people neither of us ever met."

"Will it say what she was like? Not the queen. The woman."

Seònaid considered the question longer than its length deserved. "It will say what she did," she said, "and what was done because of what she did, and what people who stood near her at the time believed she meant by it. I don't know that any book can do more than that for anyone, king or clerk."

Lachlann looked at the page a while longer, and then went out without answering, and she never learned whether he had found the answer wanting or had only had nothing further to ask.

It was in that same summer, while she worked, that word came down from Inis chrom on the south-west coast of a spotted fever that had begun among the fisher households and was killing, by the time the word reached Cathair dhearg, some forty of the town's people. An Fhianna of an Fhianna³ stone, whose house stood nearest the sickness, went in among the dying where the town's own folk

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

would not, and buried as many as they nursed, and lost, before the fever burned itself out, a number of their own that the messenger who brought the news could not say with any certainty, only that it was more than a few. Seònaid set down her pen for that fortnight and wrote nothing. The fever had no part in her book. It seemed to her, hearing of it, an ill thing to go on writing an old war's dead while a new town's dead were still being carried out, and she judged, rightly or not, that the two griefs should not share an ink-well.

She took the pen up again after, and finished the last of the war's telling — the ford, the burned granary at Doire mhin, the forty days at the fouled wells, the list at the yard gate, the field below Muileann chrom, the swearing in a single day — on 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 624, and sat a long while afterward with the finished leaves in front of her, not reading them, only looking at the height of the pile, which seemed to her a strange measure for the whole of a war and yet was the only measure she had.

V

Of the Reading at the Red Hall

No hand but her own ever copied the book while she lived. Seven years after the last leaf was written she died at Cathair dhearg, in LE 631, of no illness anyone named as remarkable, only the ordinary failing of a body that had gone eighty-two years without once, so far as anyone could tell, resting from its work; and the last thing she is recorded to have said, to the clerk who sat with her, was that the boards at Seann Skell wanted a better roof over the back room, because the damp would have the far ones illegible within a generation if no one saw to it. It was, her sister said afterward, exactly the kind of thing she would say, and exactly the kind of thing no one else would have thought to say, and between the two the sister was not sure which she found harder to bear.

The book she left behind was read into the record at An Talla Dearg¹ the following spring, at Lachlann's own order, by a clerk with a clearer hand than hers had become in her last years, while the king sat and listened without once, those present said, interrupting to correct a fact or soften a memory, though there were passages, concerning his own mother and his uncle and the man his grandfather's

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

rivals had been, that another king might have wished told differently. When it was done he said only that it should be copied again, and kept, and that no copy of it was ever to be made shorter than the one before it, a ruling Taigh na Fèithe²'s own clerks found strange at first, until it was pointed out to them plainly that a shortened history is a history with someone's choosing already baked into it, and that Lachlann, whatever else might be said of him, had wanted the choosing to stay visible, the way a struck name stays visible on a board, rather than be scraped away in the name of tidiness.

Of the smaller things that had gone on around her in those same years her own book, a history of the war alone, says nothing at all; but Leabhar a' Chùrainm³ and Rolla a' Chalaigh⁴ kept them, as they kept everything. At Doire shean on the southern shore, in the year the crown's scribes counted as LE 634, a village that had until then lived by its nets alone laid out beds for oysters in the shallow water of its own bay and found, within a few seasons, that the trade made it rich enough to sit as a shire seat, a thing its own elders would not at first believe of a food that had always before been gathered free off the rocks for anyone who cared to wade for it. And at Seann Tarr in the north-east, where the crowds that gathered for the great feasts at the ancestor shrine had always gone home again with nothing more than what they had brought, the crowds of LE 644 began instead to hold a market on the three feast days, chiefly of honey and of the beeswax that fed the shrine's own lights, so that within a few years more wax was burned at ancestor shrines the length of the north-eastern coast than had ever been burned there before, and no one troubled to remember that a market had not always stood where the feasts stood.

Seònaid nic Coinnich never saw either. She had not gone to Doire shean since she was carried past it as a child on the road east from the burned granary at Doire mhin, and she had never in her life gone to Seann Tarr at all. What she had seen, in the last year given to her, was a book finished, and a king who did not flinch from it, and a scribe at a harbour-house a day's ride off who had shown her, without being asked twice, boards that no one before her had thought worth asking to see.

It is told at Cathair dhearg that when her book was read a second time, some years after the first reading, an old man at the back of the hall who had fought at

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

4. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

the ford under a banner that lost said, when it was finished, that it was the truest account of the war he had heard, though it had made his own side out no better and no worse than the winning one, which he had not expected of a history written by the winning queen's own clerk. He was asked what he meant by truest. He said only that he had been there, and it sounded like being there, and that no one had thought to ask him that of any telling before.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

OF MANANNAN'S CUP

LE 650 – 699

Is fhada an cuan, is goirid a' chuimhne. Long is the sea, and short is
memory.

— a saying of the western shore

I

Of the Preaching on the Quay

Mànas mac Ruairidh had grown up under the shadow of the harbour-court at Seann Skell, in a house so near the water that his mother used to say the tide kept better time than his father did, coming and going by a reckoning she never once had to keep and never once caught lying, which was more, she said, than could be said of most husbands. His father Ruairidh had sworn the old oath of the quay in his own youth, the sting-oath the western merchants kept among themselves to bind their word in a trade where a man's whole living might ride on another man's honesty and no scale or measure could weigh that; and he kept, all the years Mànas knew him, a strip of tarred rope hung by the door in token of it, though he never once told his son plainly what the oath bound a man to, saying only that it was enough that it bound, the way the tide was enough without a boy needing to know why it rose.

Mànas asked him once, at twelve, sitting on the sill while his father mended a creel by lamplight, what he had sworn on, exactly, to make the mark that never faded from his palm. His father set the creel down, held up his hand so the lamp caught the old scar full on, a mark gone the colour of weathered wood and shaped, if a boy looked at it long enough, something like a fork of lightning strik-

ing down into the wrist, and said only that the mark answered better than his mouth ever could, and that a boy who wanted to know what a sting-oath cost a man would do better to watch how carefully his elders spoke, all his life, than to be told it once and think the telling was the same as the knowing. He let that be the end of it, and went back to the creel, and Mànas, watching him work by the small light, understood without being told again that there were questions in that house that a father answered with his hands and never with his tongue.

He grew to a young man who could splice a rope and gut a fish as well as any on the strand, and had, besides, a voice that carried further over open water than most men's carried over dry land, a gift he discovered by accident one wet morning hailing a boat in from a squall that had half the harbour shouting itself hoarse and unheard, and put, for some years after, to no grander use than calling men in from the rocks to their dinner. By thirty, having buried his mother two winters before and watched his father grow slow and stooped over the same creels, he stood up one still morning on the harbour stones at Seann Skell and said aloud the thing that had been gathering in him, he told those who asked him afterward, since he was a boy on a sill watching a scarred hand answer for a mouth that would not.

He chose, whether by his own design or only because it was the ground he had always stood on, the same stretch of quay where the old sting-creed of An Aois Naomh¹ had first stood up, longer ago than any living memory reached, and called itself, before any other order on the island, the one true faith; and it was there, on 1 an t-Sultain, LE 654, with the tide going out and a handful of fishermen mending net within easy earshot, more from idleness that morning than from any intent to listen, that Mànas named the power he had come, at last, to preach. He named Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, raising his voice only a little, for it carried without needing to be raised: not the stone at Inis thais, not the hawk at Cnoc bheag, not the ancestors under their posts at Dùn Ìseal. Cupa na Firinne² of Truth would not hold a lie spoken over it, he said, and broke, so the old telling had it, in the very hand of the man who tried; and it bore, worked into its rim, the yellow scorpion for its sign, sting and truth being, he said, closer kin than most men supposed. It was Manannan, and no other power under any name the island kept, who had drawn his mist across the eastern sea behind the fleet that had once gone out from this same quay; and what that fleet had done, the go-

1. the Holy Age

2. Manannan's Cup of Truth

ing out past every sight of land and star and known shore, must never, while the mist held, be tried again by anyone who called himself faithful to the god whose sea it was.

The net-menders did not stop mending net while he spoke, not at first, and he had sense enough, even new to speaking, not to ask it of them. But before he had finished, one of them had stopped, and it was his own father, who rose from his creel and crossed the wet stones with the rope-mark still plain on his upturned palm and knelt, an old sworn-man on wet stone in front of his own son, and said only, low enough that few beyond Mānas himself ever swore they had heard it, that a mark on a hand was one kind of oath and a thing spoken plain in daylight was another, and that he had waited the whole of his life, without knowing he was waiting, to hear which kind his son would choose to make. Six others knelt after him before the tide had gone out much further, fishermen and net-menders who had known Ruairidh's son since he was a boy hailing boats off the rocks, and it was those seven, the old sworn-man and the six who came behind him, that the harbour afterward remembered as the first of Òrd Mhanannain³, though Mānas himself, asked afterward who had truly been first, would only say that a father owes his son that much attention and leave the rest of the honour unclaimed.

Word of it did not travel fast in that first season, no faster than any other quay-talk carried on a wet wind, and Mānas kept mostly to preaching where he had always stood, growing neither rich nor grand on it, sleeping still under his father's roof and eating what his father's nets, and increasingly his own, brought in. It was five years on that the first boats were brought up for blessing at the berth the harbour scribes had begun, a generation before, to call Cidhe an Diosail⁴: a dozen coasters brought in one after another on a still morning, their skippers standing bareheaded on the stones while Mānas, no longer so young himself, passed a cup of harbour water over each hull in turn and spoke the words that would, within his own lifetime, harden into the fixed form of the rite. He used no vessel finer that first year than a plain wooden bowl, having no silver and wanting none, and when one of the skippers, a man better off than most, offered to have a proper cup made and gilded for the purpose, Mānas told him that Cupa na Firinne had never needed a smith's hand to make it true, and that a bowl which had held nothing but harbour water and honest words was nearer Cupa na Firinne than any gilded thing a smith could raise.

3. the order of Manannan

4. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

The harbour-court, whose own sworn-men had kept the sting-oath at Seann Skell since long before Mânas's father wore the mark, did not welcome the new teaching as readily as the net-menders had, and for some years after the first kneeling the court's own scribe, a careful man named Donnchadh mac Ailein who had no particular quarrel with Manannan but a settled one with any change to the harbour's old order, refused to enter the order's blessings in Rolla a' Chalaiddh⁵ alongside the tallies of hulls and cargoes, saying that a rite was not a hull and had no business on a board kept for hulls. Mânas never pressed the matter, and told his own congregation, when one of them grumbled at the scribe's refusal, that a rite recorded on a board and a rite kept true in a man's own dealings were not the same thing, and that he would rather have the second without the first than the first without the second. It was not until some years after Mânas's own death that the harbour-house began, of its own accord and without any order from the court, to note in its margins when a hull had been blessed at Cidhe an Diosail, a small mark beside the entry that later harbour scribes kept without ever troubling to ask why it had begun.

In the month after that first preaching on the quay, word came up the coast road that Lachlann mac Iain had died at Cathair dhearg, eighty-nine years old and quiet to the last, fifty years on the throne his mother had left him without, so far as the harbour ever heard, doing anything a quay would trouble to remember; and that his daughter Anna, fifty-four years old and long past any waiting for it, had been crowned in the same hall. Mânas heard the tidings the way the town heard most tidings, from a rider who stopped at the horse-trough by the harbour-court to water his horse and talked while it drank, and he is not recorded to have said anything about it at all, which the harbour took, rightly or not, for a kind of answer of its own: that the sea's governance and the crown's were, to his mind, two different powers entirely, and that the death of one king, however long his quiet reign, was the crown's business to mark and not the tide's.

II

Of the Cup Carried Down the Coast

5. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

The teaching went where the fishing went, which was down the coast before it went anywhere else, carried less by Mānas's own feet, which stayed mostly within a day's walk of Seann Skell to the end of his life, than by the fishing families themselves, who traded catch and net-twine from harbour to harbour and, riding along with them in the same creel, whatever a man had lately taken to believing. By the time Mānas was an old man it had reached Ros bheag down the coast and Cuan shean beyond it, both of them towns that had given their strand and their labour to the building of the fleet in the years before a' Scaradh¹ and had never, in all the years since, quite stopped listening for word of anything to do with the sea beyond their own headlands; and it was at Cuan shean, among the rope-walks that had once measured cable enough for keels no one now living had seen launched, that the teaching took hold hardest and earliest of anywhere beyond Mānas's own quay.

An old rope-walker there named Tormod Ciar, who had walked the same length of ground backward twisting strand into cable since he was a boy too young to be paid a man's full wage for it, was among the first of Cuan shean to kneel, and he did it, by his own account, not for any word Mānas had ever spoken to him in person, for the two men never once met in this life, but because a travelling net-mender stopped under the eaves of the rope-shed one wet evening, waiting out a squall, and told the walkers gathered there what the preacher at Seann Skell had said of the mist and the fleet and the sea that must not be tried again. Tormod, who had spent the whole of his working life laying rope for ships that no longer sailed anywhere beyond sight of their own shore, and had never once, in all his years at the walk, been given a reason for it beyond that the fishing did not need longer cable than the fishing needed, found in the net-mender's telling the first account he had ever heard that made any sense of why his own trade had shrunk, year on year, without ever once, in his lifetime, growing back to what the old wrights' fellowship had once built it for. He swore Cupa na Fírinne² before his fellow rope-walkers on the walk itself the following morning, with no priest of the order nearer than Seann Skell to hear him, cupping harbour rain in his own two hands for want of a bowl, and told them afterward, more than once, that he had sworn it to the sea and not to any man standing on dry ground, and that the sea, unlike a man, had never yet broken an oath it was given honestly.

Mānas himself grew old at the harbour he had never left, and the house the order raised in those years, Taigh Mhanannain³, stood not far from the harbour-

court his father had sworn to, low and plain and built of the same grey stone as the quay, so that a stranger walking past it on a grey morning might have taken it, at first glance, for one more shed of nets and tar rather than the house of a growing order. He kept the rite the same each year he had strength left to stand for it, the bowl grown at last to a proper cup of plain silver that his own congregation had raised the silver for without his asking, and he is remembered by those who were young when he was old as a man who spoke less as the years went on rather than more, having said, he told one of his own who asked him plainly why an old teacher should fall so quiet, most of what he had ever had to say in the first years of his preaching, and seeing no good cause to say it twice over merely because he had lived long enough to be asked.

In the last winter of his life, when he could no longer stand the whole length of the blessing without a younger man's arm under his own, a woman of the order named Beathag nic Dhonnchaidh, who had kept his house those last ten years and would keep the order's house after him, asked him one evening by the fire whether he feared the mist would lift before the island had properly learned what Manannan had shut it in from. He answered, she told others afterward, that a fisherman who feared every squall before it rose would never once put out from the strand, and that a teacher who spent his last strength fearing a thing that had not yet come was a poor steward of the strength Manannan had given him to spend on the thing that had. He died soon after, at Seann Skell, in the house he had raised, within sound, his own people said, of the same water he had preached beside for six-and-thirty years, and was buried, at his own asking, under a plain slab, cut with no name, set facing the harbour mouth, so that the tide he had spent his whole life speaking of would be the last thing, and the first thing after, to pass over him. Those who came to Taigh Mhanannain in the years right after his death found it kept much as he had kept it, by men and women, Beathag nic Dhonnchaidh foremost among them, who had never once heard him preach with their own ears and knew his teaching only at second and third hand, the way the island, by then, knew most of what it believed.

1. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

2. Manannan's Cup of Truth

III

Of the Rule of the Headlands

Beathag nic Dhonnchaidh, who had kept Mànas's house and, after him, kept the order's, lived to see the teaching carried further than the old man had ever thought to carry it. The priests who rose up after him at Ros bheag, where the teaching had taken almost as deep a root as at Mànas's own quay, met through the better part of a winter to debate, by all the later order kept of it, not whether the sea beyond the headlands was Manannan's to forbid, which none of them doubted, but how far a boat might go before the forbidding took hold; and it was an old priestess of that house, one who had herself, as a girl, watched the last of the pilots die without finishing what he meant to teach, who argued the debate down at last to a single plain rule, that no boat of the faithful might go where the headland could no longer be seen from its own deck. In LE 694 it was laid down so, on pain of standing before Cupa na Firinne¹ and answering for it, and the rule held on the west coast, once it was made, for longer than any one preacher's lifetime could have hoped to account for. It was not, those who kept it afterward always insisted, a fear of the sea itself, which Manannan's own faithful were taught to hold in a kind of grave and working affection rather than dread, but a fear of what the sea beyond sight of land had already once been made to carry away, and what it might, if the mist should ever thin, be asked to carry away again.

The rule was tested within its own first year, off Ros bheag, by a skipper named Coinneach mac Sheumais who had fished the same grounds for thirty years without troubling any priest's opinion of where his own boat might go, and who, on a clear still morning with the headland still just visible astern, no more than a low grey line, took his boat a little further out than he had ever taken it before, chasing a run of fish that seemed, that particular day, well worth the chasing. He was turned back before noon by two of the order's own boats, crewed by men he had drunk with his whole life, who came up on either side of him and told him plainly, not unkindly, that the rule made no exception for fish however plentiful, and stood off his bow, oars shipped, until he brought his own boat about and ran before the wind back the way he had come. "I could still see the headland," Coinneach is said to have told them, and the elder of the two boats' skippers is said to

1. Manannan's Cup of Truth

have answered only that the rule did not ask what a man could still see, only how far off the land he stood when he saw it, which silenced Coinneach more thoroughly than any longer citing of the rule could have done. He never fished that far out again, and told his own sons, afterward, that he had not minded the turning back nearly so much as he had minded finding out, in front of two men he had known since boyhood, that he had been wrong about how far a headland could still be seen once a man had already made up his mind to go past it.

What the rule cost the west coast, over the span of years it held, was harder to see in the turning back of a single boat than it was seen weighed whole, as those who came after had cause to weigh it. The steering of a course by the stars, already half lost on that shore since the pilots who had carried Seumas Reultach's own teaching west had sailed with the fleet and left behind them only what little they had passed to others in the years before, went out entirely where it had never before, in all the years since the fleet's building, had the chance to be forgotten so completely, for there was no longer any voyage sailed on the west coast long enough, or dark enough, or far enough from a known headland, to need it kept. A pilot's grandson at Ros bheag, a boy named Griogair, was asked one evening by a visiting priest of the order which star his grandfather, a man once counted among the last on that shore who could hold a course by night, had steered by. The boy, who had heard his grandfather's name spoken all his life with a kind of respect he had never fully understood the grounds of, only that the old man had once, before Griogair was born, gone further out on the water than any boat now went and had come home again, could not answer, and stood a while working at the question as though it might yield to being stared at hard enough before admitting, plainly, that he did not know. Nobody in his own house, it came out in the asking, had thought, while there was still anyone alive who remembered it, to write the star's name down or teach it onward, having had, each of them in turn, other and nearer things to teach a boy first.

At Àth shean, further inland and further still from any water Manannan's priests troubled themselves to bless, the royal granaries that had stood since before a' Scaradh², low buildings of timber and old stone that had weathered the tallies of a hundred harvests, were pulled down in LE 699 and built again from their own foundations, in dressed stone this time and on raised floors set well clear of the ground, against the rats that had for years been getting into the lower bins

2. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

faster than any night-watch could keep them out. The tally-house went up new beside the granaries in the same stone, and the reeve who oversaw the rebuilding, an old man named Fearchar mac Phàdraig near the end of his own long service, walked the finished floors once with a lamp held low to the new stone and said only, when he was satisfied, that a granary built to outlast the rats might, with a little luck, outlast the reeve who had seen it built as well, and went back to his tallies without further comment on a labour that had taken the better part of three years and left the shire's grain, that first winter, dry from wall to wall without a single sack lost to damp or gnawing, a thing no man then living at Àth shean could remember having happened before.

It is told at Seann Skell, where the order kept its house and its rite long after the man who had begun both was laid under his plain slab facing the harbour mouth, that a keeper of Taigh Mhanannain³ in those same years was asked by a stranger passing through, a merchant of no particular faith who had heard the teaching only as one more curiosity of the west coast worth a traveller's idle question, whether the order held that the mist would lie over the eastern sea for ever. The keeper is said to have answered that Ceò Mhanannain⁴ had been drawn once, for a reason the order did not claim to know in full, and that it would lift, if it ever lifted, in its own time and by no persuasion of theirs, and that in the meanwhile Cupa na Firinne asked only truth of those who swore to it and left the sea's own intentions to the sea alone. The stranger asked nothing further and went on his way, and the keeper, watching him go, is said to have thought, though not to have said it aloud to anyone, that a boy at Ros bheag who could not name his own grandfather's star had already answered the merchant's question, without meaning to and without knowing he had done it, as well as any priest of the order ever could.

Rolla a' Chalaigh⁵ say nothing of the boy Griogair afterward, for a boy who does not follow the sea leaves no mark on a harbour board, and Manannan's own keepers, unlike the harbour scribes, wrote down oaths sworn and boats blessed and little else beside. It is told only, at Ros bheag among those who kept the priest's question and the boy's silence as a small cautionary tale of their own, that Griogair grew to a man who worked the land above the harbour rather than the water below it, and that when he had sons of his own he taught them, whatever

3. the house of Manannan

4. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

5. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

else he judged worth a father's teaching, the names of every headland visible from the shore before he taught them anything of what lay beyond it, having decided, so far as anyone could later say for him, that a thing worth keeping was a thing a man ought to write down or speak aloud the first year he knew it, and not wait, as his own house had waited with his grandfather's star, for someone else's asking to prove the waiting had already cost him everything there was to lose.

OF THE BARGAIN OF THE COUNTS

LE 700 – 769

Cha do chuir mi cunntas air an fhirinn, ach air an aonta. I set no
count upon the truth, only upon the agreement.

— said to be Eòghann mac Pheadair's own saying, kept afterward at
Muileann dhearg

I

Of the Boy Set to the Tallies

Eòghann mac Pheadair was born in the shadow of the hill at Muileann dhearg, in one of the low stone houses the coal-breakers had raised at the hill's foot two generations before his own, and he grew up knowing the sound of Taigh na Fèithe¹'s bell for opening and closing the galleries before he knew his letters. His father cut coal in the lower workings and never rose from it, and would have set his son to the same labour without a second thought, had the boy not shown, at seven or eight, a memory for numbers that the men about him came to think worth more than a strong back. It was the old scribe of Taigh na Fèithe, a stooped, dry man named Murchadh Beag who had kept the tallies of Na Seachd Taighean² galleries for thirty years and complained of his eyes every winter, who first noticed the boy reciting back a whole day's cartage, load for load, without once looking at the board where Murchadh had chalked it; and it was

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the seven houses of custody

Murchadh who went to the boy's father and asked, not for the first time in his life, whether a household might spare a son from the coal-face for a scribe's stool.

He was set to it at seven, sweeping Taigh na Fèithe floor and mixing the ink before he was let touch a leaf, and Murchadh, who owned to no patience for a boy's questions during the day's proper work, would answer any question at all once the leaves were put away and the lamp burned only for the two of them: why a gallery's number changed when a house divided, why the same household might be entered twice in different years under different names, why the vein answered some galleries better than others though the custodians swore they worked them alike. Eòghann learned, by nine, to save his questions for that hour and no other, and Murchadh, who had buried a wife and outlived two apprentices before this one, came in time to keep the lamp burning a little longer than the work alone required.

By fourteen he could keep a day's tally as well as Murchadh himself, though not yet, the old man said, as fast, and it was that year, LE 714, that word came up from the coast to Taigh na Fèithe of a thing Eòghann was set to enter on the general leaf without at first understanding why it mattered to anyone away from the coast: that Cuan shean had taken up half its rope-walks and sown the ground with barley. Murchadh explained it to him plainly enough, once, and never again, for he was not a man who liked to say a thing twice: the rope had been laid for the fleet, and after the fleet for the fishing, and the fishing had never once, in all the years since, needed cable of the old length; so half the walks stood idle years on end, and idle ground, on an island that had grown to more mouths than it once fed, was a waste no reeve would suffer forever. The boy asked whether it did not grieve the rope-walkers, to break up ground their own fathers had walked, twisting strand, for a fleet none of them had ever seen sail; Murchadh said that grief was not a scribe's business to enter on a leaf, only the fact of the barley and the year it was sown, and that a scribe who let himself grieve every trade the island outgrew would have no ink left, by forty, for anything the living still needed written down.

Eòghann wrote it as he was told, a line among many, and thought no more of it for years, save that he had, without being asked to, begun to notice that every leaf he copied told the same story from some other angle: a trade shrinking here, a family moving there, all of it circling back, sooner or later, to the fleet that had sailed before any man now living was born. He asked Murchadh once more, the winter he turned sixteen, whether Taigh na Fèithe's own leaves said anything of

where the fleet had gone, and Murchadh told him only that Leabhar a' Chùrain³ held what it held and no more, and that a boy who wanted the rest of that story would have to go looking for it in the harbour songs, which Eòghann never did, having by then more tallies of his own to keep than hours left over for songs.

II

Of the Wave and the Market

he was four-and-twenty, and had Murchadh's old stool as good as his own though the old man had not yet the grace to die and leave it to him outright, when the report reached Muileann dhearg of the wave at Cnoc chaol on the south coast: a great swell that rose with no storm behind it to explain it, ran the drying racks off the beach, and carried off two children with them before any hand on the shore could reach them, 22 an Gearran, LE 724. Eòghann entered it on the general leaf as he entered every disaster that touched a household of the coal-right, cold and plain, the way Murchadh had taught him a scribe must enter grief if he meant to go on being of any use to the living: the names, the place, the day, and no word beyond what the day itself would bear. He asked Murchadh once, copying it fair, whether it did not seem a strange thing that a wave should rise from a flat sea with no wind in it, and Murchadh told him that the sea did what the sea did, and that a scribe who wanted an explanation for every strange thing the sea sent up would do better to find another trade, for there were more strange things in the tally-books of a coastal island than any one man's lifetime could account for. Cnoc chaol set its racks higher up the shore after, and Taigh na Fèithe¹'s leaf recorded, the following season, that the household of one of the drowned children had struck itself from its old gallery and taken up a new one further from the water, which Eòghann understood, better than Murchadh's explanation had made him understand the wave, without needing to be told.

It was some years later, near his thirty-first year, that the master of Taigh na Fèithe sent him east on his own feet for the first time, to Baile Mòr dhìreach, the citadel on the straight eastern road, to stand witness for Na Seachd Taighean² when the crown's grant of a market there was read out and the boundary stones

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the seven houses of custody

of its ground were set, 11 an t-Samhain, LE 731. He had never before gone further from Muileann dhearg than a day's walk would carry him, and the road east, which took the better part of a week, showed him a coast he had only ever known as names on a leaf: the fish and sail-cloth of the shore towns coming up to meet the furs and hides and dyes of the hill country, the dyers of a neighbouring town selling colours he had never seen a colour merchant in the west carry, all of it converging on a market ground that had, the week before he arrived, been nothing but rough pasture with four stones sunk in it to mark its corners.

He slept the nights of that journey in road-houses he had never had cause to know by name, at tables set with strangers who asked him, once they had his trade out of him, what the vein answered these days for a household's handful, a question he had fielded a hundred times from custodians and never once, until that week, from a stranger who owned no gallery at all and only wanted, it seemed, to know that the thing still burned steady somewhere behind the hills he had never travelled to. Oddly, he found he did not mind the asking nearly so much as Murchadh had always claimed to; there was a kind of easiness, he thought, in a question that wanted nothing written down after it.

He stood at the reading with the other witnesses, said the words Taigh na Fèithe had sent him to say, and watched the first stalls go up the same afternoon, traders who had clearly been waiting only for the word to be spoken before they set their goods out, as though the market had existed in every mind but the law's for a year before the law caught up to it. A dyer of the hill towns spread lengths of cloth dyed a red Eòghann had no name for across a trestle not ten feet from where he stood, and told him, unasked, that the colour came from a root that grew nowhere lower than the high pastures and had never before had anywhere on the coast worth the carrying it to; and Eòghann, who wrote tallies all his working life and had rarely had cause to look twice at a colour, found himself standing longer at that trestle than his errand from Taigh na Fèithe had any need of him to stand.

He walked home slower than he had walked out, by his own account afterward; the weariness of the road was in it, but more of it was that he found, for the first time in his life away from a stool and a leaf, that he wanted to look at things a while before he wrote them down.

III

Of the Scribe of the Red Hall

he was eight-and-thirty, keeper of Taigh na Fèithe's leaves in his own right by then, Murchadh eleven years in the ground and the stool unambiguously his own, when a rider came up from Cathair dhearg in 23 am Màrt, LE 739 to say that a scribe of the crown's own household was coming to Taigh na Fèithe on An Talla Dearg's business, and would the master of Taigh na Fèithe grant her Leabhar a' Chùrain³ for a day, or as many days as the matter took. The master, who had dealt with the crown's scribes before and found them, on the whole, no worse than any other visitor with a warrant, told Eòghann to give her whatever the book held and to mind his tongue about the rest of it, by which he meant Na Seachd Taighean⁴ own accounts, which were not the crown's business and never had been.

The scribe was a woman not much past thirty herself, Mòrag nic Ìomhair, who arrived on a hired horse with a satchel of her own leaves and the particular brisk courtesy of someone who had ridden the thirty-nine miles from Cathair dhearg expecting Taigh na Fèithe to be difficult about its book and was pleasantly, visibly surprised to find it was not. She wanted, she told Eòghann plainly enough once the courtesies were done, to set the crown's reckoning of Bliadhnaichean an Diosail⁵ against Taigh na Fèithe's own, for An Talla Dearg's clerks had lately found, comparing an old grant to an old debt in the same year's business, that the two offices' counts did not agree, and nobody at Cathair dhearg could say with any certainty which of them, if either, was right.

She had brought her own bread and a small hard cheese wrapped in cloth, meaning, she said, to trouble Taigh na Fèithe's kitchen as little as its book, and ate it standing at the north window on her first evening, looking down the hill at the coal-breakers' town below, while Eòghann fetched Leabhar a' Chùrain from its chest and blew the dust from its cover in a way he had not troubled to do for a visitor in years. Watching him set it down, she asked him whether the book had ever left that room in all the years it had been kept, and when he told her it had not, not once, she said that a book which had never once been carried out into weather to be tested against another book's claim was a strange thing to call a record at all,

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

4. the seven houses of custody

5. the years of the Diosal, counted from the sunwise turn

and that she meant no offence by saying so, only that it was, in her trade, a kind of loneliness she had come some distance to end.

The two of them spent the better part of three days at the long table under Taigh na Fèithe's north window, each running a count forward from An Diosal⁶ by their own office's method, comparing tallies of burnings and gallery-openings and the ordinary business of years that each side had kept for its own purposes and never once, in all the years either count had been kept, set beside the other's. It was on the second evening, both of them ink-stained to the wrist and neither yet willing to say aloud what the columns had already told them, that Mòrag laid her leaf down next to his and said only that she counted An Diosal a year longer than his book did, and asked him plainly whether he could find the year in his own reckoning where the difference had crept in.

He could not, and told her so without pretending otherwise, which she said afterward was the thing that made her trust his count at all: that a scribe capable of admitting his own book might be wrong in a place he could not point to was worth more to her, in that hour, than one who would have sworn to every figure on the leaf sooner than own a gap in it. They went back through both counts a second time, by lamplight, the master of Taigh na Fèithe looking in once and going away again without a word when he saw how the evening stood, and found, near the end of it, that the fault lay nowhere either of them could finally lay a finger on: a year, somewhere in the first generation after the turn, entered twice by one office's habit or once by the other's, so far back and so quietly done that no leaf either of them had brought could say which office had erred, or whether either truly had.

IV

Of the Agreement

They settled it, in the end, not by proof, for neither count could furnish proof the other would accept, but by agreement, which Mòrag said, and Eòghann came in time to agree with her, was worth as much to the living as proof would have been and a good deal easier to come by. In the end they took the crown's count for the reckoning that would go forward from that day, since

6. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

the crown's business touched more households across more shires than Taigh na Fèithe's own and a single count serving the whole island was worth more than either office's pride in being first; and Eòghann wrote Taigh na Fèithe's agreement to it himself, in his own hand, on a fresh leaf, with the master of Taigh na Fèithe's mark set under his and Mòrag's own office's mark set under that, so that whoever read the leaf afterward would see two hands and two seals and no claim beyond what the leaf plainly said: that the offices had differed, and had agreed, and neither pretended the agreement was anything more than what it was.

The same days settled a second matter that had waited, unresolved, behind the first: the day of the year on which Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh² should properly fall, which the two counts had also placed a little apart from each other for the same buried reason, and which every harbour from Seann Skell round the coast had until then kept each after its own custom, a day or two either side of its neighbours, without much troubling over the difference. Mòrag proposed, and Eòghann saw no cause to refuse her, that the same agreement that fixed the count should fix the day, so that a rite meant to be kept by the whole coast together might, from that year forward, at least be kept on the same day by all of it, whatever the coast might privately go on believing about which count had been the truer one before the two offices sat down together.

She rode back to Cathair dhearg with her copy of the leaf in the same satchel she had brought empty, and Eòghann kept his in Leabhar a' Chùraim³, between two older leaves that had never expected to have a stranger's mark folded in among them. He said to the master of Taigh na Fèithe, when he was asked how the crown's scribe had been to deal with, that she was a hard woman to argue a figure past and an easy one to agree a figure with, which the master took, correctly, for the highest compliment Eòghann had it in him to pay another scribe. The two offices wrote to each other now and again in the years that followed, mostly on ordinary business, but Eòghann kept, folded inside his own working leaves for the rest of his working life, the short note Mòrag sent him the winter after, saying only that the coast had kept the rite on the agreed day without a single harbour writing to complain of it, which she counted, she said, a better proof than either of their books had managed to furnish on their own.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the rite of the empty harbour

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

V

Of the Year the World Went On Without Him

he was an old man by the time the question the two of them had settled with a leaf and two seals was taken up again, at Inis mhòr in the north, by younger minds who wanted more than agreement and asked, in a house of disputation the pupils of Dùn thais had founded there, whether the vein answered any true count of years at all or only the custom of counting it; the house's first master was remembered afterward, by those who studied under him, for refusing every answer he was offered rather than for giving one of his own, and word of it reached Taigh na Fèithe¹ the way most northern news reached Eòghann in his last years, at second hand, by a rider glad of a fire and a cup and willing to talk while he warmed himself.

The rider, a young man who plainly relished the telling more than he understood the argument, said the pupils at Inis mhòr had gone so far as to ask whether a gallery worked faithfully by a house with no claim of blood to the crown answered any worse than a gallery worked by the oldest of the seven, and that their master had refused that question along with every other, saying only that the vein did not trouble to answer a question it had never once been asked. Eòghann heard it out, said that a house built to refuse every answer sounded a restless sort of house to keep, and went back to the leaf in front of him, for whatever the pupils of Inis mhòr chose to argue about the vein, the vein itself still wanted its tallies kept daily whether the argument was settled or not; though he owed to the rider, before the young man rode on the next morning, that he would not himself have minded hearing the master refuse a question or two in person, had his legs still been equal to a journey of that length.

That same year the crown at Cathair dhearg passed, without any disturbance that reached as far as Taigh na Fèithe's own hill, from the fifth ruler of the house of Catriona, a woman Eòghann had never once in his life laid eyes on, to her granddaughter, a girl of eighteen crowned to an Gearran, LE 769, in the same hall her grandmother had held for near fifty years; Na Seachd Taighean² sent their custodians down to Cathair dhearg to see the crowning done, as the compact required, though the master of Taigh na Fèithe went in Eòghann's stead, for by then a journey of thirty-nine miles was more than his legs would answer for in a single

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the seven houses of custody

season, and he said so to the master plainly, without the shame a younger man might have felt owning it. He heard the crowning described to him afterward, the neck-rings of the seven heads catching the hall's lamplight, the new queen's voice, they told him, steadier than her years had any right to make it, and thought, hearing it, less of the girl herself than of the leaf he had once carried between two seals: that whoever sat in An Talla Dearg³, the count the leaf had fixed would go on running under her reign exactly as it had run under her grandmother's, needing no crowning of its own to keep it true.

It was that same year, too, that the bath-house over Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁴ below Muileann ruadh was raised again in dressed stone by the house that kept it, and opened its doors one day in seven to the sick of any household, whoever they were sworn to; and it was to that bath-house, in the last cold turn of that same year, that Eòghann let himself be carried on a cart he would have refused, a few years before, as an old man's fussing, his chest gone tight in a way no winter before it had ever quite managed.

The physicians of the house that kept the springs asked him, before they would let him into the water, the ordinary questions they asked every stranger carried to them: his years, his trade, what house his gallery answered to; and Eòghann, giving the answers, found he could not keep himself from adding, as no physician had asked him to, that he had once made an agreement with a woman of the crown's own household over a difference of a single year, and that the difference had never once, in all the years since, been proven either of them wrong. The physician, a woman near his own age who had plainly heard a hundred old men's stray remembrances at that basin's edge and had long since stopped being surprised by any of them, told him only that a single year, set beside the water he was about to sit in, which had come up out of the same mountain warm since long before either count of years began, was a small thing to have carried folded in his working leaves for thirty winters, and helped him down the steps without further comment.

He sat in the warm water with men and women of houses he had spent his whole working life keeping separate on a leaf, coal-breakers and salt-carriers and a shepherd's widow from the hills, none of them minding, in that water, whose gallery any of the others answered to, and thought, before he let his eyes close a while against the steam, that it was a strange late lesson for a man who had given his

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

4. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

whole life to counting differences to be taught, in a stone basin at the far end of it, how little the water troubled to keep them.

He kept, to the very end of that year, the leaf folded among his working leaves where he had kept it since the evening he and Mòrag nic Ìomhair had set their two counts down side by side and found neither of them equal to proving the other wrong; and it was that leaf, and not the crowning at Cathair dhearg nor the disputation at Inis mhòr nor even the warm water that had eased his chest a while, that he showed a young scribe he had lately taken to teaching his own trade, the way old Murchadh had once taught it to him, when the boy asked him, as boys will, what the finest thing was that he had done in a life spent mostly at a stool. Eòghann unfolded it for him without ceremony, the ink gone the brown of old peat-water and two seals still legible under it, and told him only that it was not the count itself the leaf was worth keeping for, since no leaf on the island could prove a count true past what its own scribe chose to believe, but the agreement written under it in two hands and sealed by two offices that had never, before that week, sat down at the same table; and that a boy who learned to write an honest agreement, he said, folding the leaf away again, would have learned more of the trade than any boy who only learned to write a stubborn count.

Of the Sea-Thieves' Strand

LE 775 – 835

I

Of the Boats Off the Small Islands

Coinneach mac Nèill had held the reeve's board at Baile chrom for eleven years before the first coaster came in short. It had been, until that summer, the post of a quiet man: he weighed the grain dues, he witnessed the marriages, he settled the small quarrels of a small town, and he went home each evening to a wife who teased him, gently, for the care he took over sums that would have troubled no one else in the shire. Baile chrom sat low on the north-west shore where the land ran out into a scatter of small islands, more rock than soil, and the town had lived the whole of its life off the strip of grey water between them: barley from its own thin fields, fish and grey seal-oil traded down the coast, and a peace so old that no one now living could have said when it began.

His father had held the same board before him, and his father's father before that, so far back as the town's own memory ran, and Coinneach had grown up under the low roof of the reeve's house believing, without ever having cause to examine the belief, that a reeve's chief labour was patience: patience with a fisherman who swore his catch had run smaller than it had, patience with a widow who could not pay her dues until the barley was in, patience with the slow turning of a year that asked, on that shore, little more of a man than that he keep faith with the tide and the season and not trouble himself overmuch with what lay beyond the small islands. He had taken a wife from a boat-building family two coves

along, Beathag nic Artair, a woman with a dry tongue and a steadier hand at accounts than his own, and the two of them had settled into a life he expected, those first eleven years, to grow old and unremarkable in, much as his father had before him.

The town he kept that tally for was not large even in its best years, a few hundred souls strung along a single street above the strand, with a temple no bigger than a byre and a harbour that held, on a full market day, a dozen boats at most. It asked nothing grand of a reeve, and Coinneach had given it, in return, nothing grand: a fair weight on the scale, an honest word at the boundary disputes, and an ear that did not tire of hearing the same complaints season after season. He had thought, before the boats came, that this was the whole of what the office would ever ask of him.

It ended, so far as anyone in the town could afterward fix a beginning to it, on a still morning when the coaster out of Ros bheag came into the berth two days late and a third short in her hold, her skipper white about the mouth and unwilling, at first, to say why. She had been boarded off the small islands, he told Coinneach at last, sitting in the reeve's own kitchen with a cup of barley spirit he had not touched, by three boats that came out of a channel he had fished all his life and had never once thought to watch. The men who took her grain wore no mark and gave no name, and they had not troubled to hide their faces, which the skipper found, telling it, stranger and worse than any violence they had offered him, for it meant they did not fear being known.

The skipper's fright stayed with Coinneach longer than the loss did, which the town could and did absorb, a third of one coaster's hold being no great matter against a whole season's trade. He sat that night at his own table turning the strangeness of it over with his wife, who had heard the skipper's account through the kitchen wall and had her own reading of it ready before Coinneach had finished his. Men who hid their faces feared to be known, she said, setting down her needle; men who did not hide them had already reckoned that being known would cost them nothing, and a reeve who wanted to understand what he was dealing with would do better to ask himself why that reckoning might be a sound one on this particular stretch of coast, this particular year, than to ask who the men were. Coinneach had no ready answer for her that night either, and slept badly, turning the question over until the tide had gone out and come in again without his noticing either.

They were known, within the season. Rolla a' Chalaidth¹ of the coast towns began, that year and the next, to set down names against the losses: not the names of strangers off some unmapped shore, as a body might have hoped, but names that half the reeves of the north-west could have matched, without much searching, to a face they had watched grow up. 24 am Faoilleach, LE 784, the first full count of the takings went up to Cathair dhearg, and it named among the sea-thieves a man of Baile chrom, a fisherman's son Coinneach had known since the boy was small enough to be carried on his father's shoulders down to the strand. His name was Aonghas mac Ruairidh, and his father Ruairidh had fished the same grounds as Coinneach's own father before either of them was born.

Coinneach went to the boy's mother himself, because he judged it a thing that ought to be done by the reeve and not left to Rolla a' Chalaidth to say for him, and found her at her door with the salt wind working at a strand of grey hair she had given up pinning back. She did not deny it. She said only that a young man who watches the fish thin out of his own home waters, season on season, for reasons no reeve and no priest has ever once explained to him, will in time go looking for a living where the living still is, and that if the living was to be found only in another man's hold, then another man's hold was where a hungry young man would go looking for it. Coinneach had no answer that satisfied either of them, and he walked back to his own house that evening turning over, more than the theft, the plainness with which she had said it, as though she had long since stopped expecting the world to be other than it plainly was.

He asked, that same week, at every house along the street where a young man had gone missing from his own boat without any word to his kin of where he had shipped instead, and found more such houses than he had let himself expect before he began asking. Some of the fathers would not speak to him at all, closing their doors on him with a civility colder than any rudeness could have been. One old fisherman, a man named Eachann who had fished beside Coinneach's own father, told him only that a reeve who came asking after another man's son should first go home and ask his own conscience how many seasons running he had watched the catch fall and done nothing but write it down smaller in his own book each year. Coinneach carried that home too, and found no more of an answer for it than he had found for Aonghas's mother.

1. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

Of Half the Houses Standing Empty

The raiding did not slacken, and within a few years the town Coinneach had inherited a quiet post in was a town visibly thinning under his own eyes, the way a fire someone forgets to feed burns down slowly, house by house, to embers, never going out all at once. Families who had fished the same water for generations began, that stretch of years, to load a cart with what it would carry and go inland before the coast road closed for the winter mud, judging a hard life among strangers a smaller risk than a certain one on a shore the sea-thieves had made their own hunting ground. Coinneach counted the going as carefully as he had once counted grain, because it was, after all, the same board he kept the tally on, and by the time he made his report to the crown's own scribes, 26 an Dùbhlachd, LE 789, he could set down in his own hand that half the houses of Baile chrom stood empty, their thatch going to moss, their doors shut on rooms no one would sleep in again that year or any year he could then foresee.

He watched the going of one family in particular that stayed with him longer than the rest: a boat-wright named Murchadh and his wife and their three children, who loaded a single cart on a morning of thin rain with everything the cart would bear and stood a while at the edge of the street before they set off, looking back at a house Murchadh's own grandfather had raised. Coinneach walked down to see them off, as he judged a reeve owed at least that much to any household leaving his charge, and Murchadh, shaking his hand at the cart's tail, said only that a boat-wright with no boats left worth building for could build a cart instead, and had, and that he hoped Coinneach would forgive him for not staying to watch the town finish emptying around him. Coinneach told him there was nothing to forgive, and meant it, and watched the cart out of sight along the coast road before he turned back to a street that had, that morning, six fewer feet walking it than it had the evening before.

He wrote the report himself, sitting up two nights over it by a single lamp while his wife Beathag nic Artair sat opposite mending nets that fewer and fewer hands in the town still had any use for, and he wrote it plainly, without the flourishes a lesser reeve might have reached for to make his own trouble sound larger than his neighbour's, because he judged, rightly as it turned out, that the crown's scribes had trouble enough of their own to weigh without a reeve's vanity added to it. He asked only that the grain dues on the houses still standing be lightened,

since a town paying dues reckoned for twice its present hands could not long keep bread in the houses that remained, and he sent the report south by the same rider who carried the coast road's other business, not troubling to send it apart, or to mark it urgent, judging that a true thing said plainly would carry its own weight without his help.

The answer came back before the winter closed the road, shorter than his own letter and written, he could tell from the hand, by a scribe who had many such letters that season to answer and little leisure to spend on any one of them: the grain dues of Baile chrom were remitted, from that year forward, to a sum reckoned by the households that stood, not the households that had once stood, and the reeve was thanked for a count taken, the letter said, with care. Coinneach read the letter twice through at his own table and then folded it away in the chest where he kept such leaves, and told his wife only that the town would not starve on the dues it could no longer pay, which was, he judged, as much as any reeve on that coast could honestly claim to have won that year.

III

Of the Force Asked and the Force Sent

he did not ask for more, not at first, holding to the same plain reckoning that had served him with the dues: a town remitted of what it could not pay might yet feed itself, given time, on what its remaining hands could still bring in from the water. But the boats out of the small islands grew bolder as the coast grew emptier of eyes to watch them, and a season came when they no longer confined themselves to coasters caught alone on open water but put in, twice within the same moon, to strands within sight of Baile chrom's own harbour and took what stood in the drying-sheds before any hand in the town could be raised against them. It was after the second of these, in the same season the dues remission was scarcely settled in the crown's own ledger, that Coinneach sat down and wrote the letter he had put off writing as long as his own conscience would allow him to put it off, asking this time for a force outright, no longer for lightened dues alone, since a reeve with a tally-stick and a handful of fishermen too old or too young to have gone raiding themselves could no longer hold a coast that men of his own shire, grown desperate or grown greedy or grown both together, had made their hunting ground.

The letter went south in the last good weather of the year and the answer, this time, was slower in coming, for the crown had its own troubles to weigh, and a reeve's petition from a thinning shore on the far side of the island was not, Coinneach understood without needing to be told, the first leaf on any scribe's board that season. He waited through a winter and into the spring that followed, and he was still waiting, mending his own nets now beside his wife in the evenings for want of hands enough in the town to hire, when word came at last that a force under a captain named Iain mac Thormoid had been raised and was coming north by sea, sent, the letter said, on the queen's own word.

He read that line to his wife three times over before he set the letter down, less from any doubt of what it said than from a wish, he admitted to her, to hear it said aloud a third time and see whether it still sounded as unlikely to his own ears as it had the first. Beathag told him, not unkindly, that a man who had spent a whole winter fearing his letter had gone into a scribe's chest and been forgotten ought to allow himself an evening of believing it had not, before he went back to his habit of expecting the worst of every answer the capital sent him. He allowed himself the evening, and little more, for the spring brought planting before it brought ships, and a reeve with half his fields untended could not stand idle on the strand waiting for a sail that might yet be a season in coming.

Eilidh Bhàn had held the throne at Cathair dhearg two and thirty years by then, crowned a girl of eighteen and grown, in the reigning, into a woman the north-west knew mostly by the letters her scribes wrote in her name, for she had never once, in all those years, travelled so far from the capital as the coast her own force was now bound for. Iain mac Thormoid's ships put in at Baile chrom on a grey morning of driving rain, and Coinneach, standing on the strand to meet them with half the town's remaining hands at his back, found himself, for the first time in eight-and-twenty years as reeve, glad of a thing he had asked for that had actually arrived.

Iain mac Thormoid was a spare, weathered man who asked more questions in his first hour ashore than any capital officer Coinneach had dealt with before him, wanting to know the set of the tides among the small islands, which channels ran dry at the ebb, which coves a boat might lie hidden in through a whole daylight and never be seen from the open water. Coinneach answered what he could and sent for the town's own boat-men to answer the rest, and by the second evening the captain had a chart of the raiders' ground drawn out on the reeve's own table

in charcoal, corrected twice over by men who had fished those waters since before Iain mac Thormoid was born.

They found the sea-thieves' own strand within the week, on Baile chrom's own fishermen leading the way, for there was not a man left in Baile chrom who did not, by then, know the channel among the small islands as well as he knew his own doorstep. 27 an t-Samhain, LE 801, the boats went in at first light on Eilean dhubh, and Coinneach, who had asked to go and been allowed to, on the plain ground that a reeve who knew the men by name might yet talk some of them down before it came to burning, found when the fighting was over that talking had bought him nothing at all. The landing was over faster than Coinneach had let himself expect, the sea-thieves having kept no proper watch on a shore they had held unchallenged for the better part of a decade, and most of the fighting, such as it was, went to Iain mac Thormoid's own men, better armed and readier for it than Coinneach's own fishermen, who had come along, most of them, to point out a channel and not to bear arms in earnest. Coinneach himself carried nothing heavier than the knife every man on that coast carried for gutting fish, and he used it for nothing that morning but cutting a length of rope from a burning hull's mooring, judging, once the fighting had truly begun, that an old reeve with a fish-knife had better make himself useful at some smaller task than stand about getting in a soldier's way.

Aonghas mac Ruairidh, thirty-one years old that spring and grown into a man Coinneach would have known nowhere except the strand where he had once been a boy, went down with a spear through him defending a hull he had likely never set foot in as an honest fisherman, and Coinneach, kneeling over him on the wet stones with the boats burning at his back, found he had no words ready for the mother he would have to tell of it, though he had had a full winter and spring to prepare some. He held the boy's hand a while, though he judged from the stillness of it that there was no longer anyone left inside it to feel the holding, and one of Iain mac Thormoid's own men, passing, asked him gently enough whether he had known the dead man. Coinneach answered that he had carried him on his own shoulder once, down to this same water, when the boy was too small to walk it himself, and the soldier, who had likely heard harder things said that morning, said nothing further and went on to the next of the fallen.

Uilleam Ruadh, who had led the sea-thieves for the better part of those years and was known, by then, up and down the whole north-west coast by name and by a red beard no disguise had ever troubled to hide, was taken alive off the strand

and carried south to Cathair dhearg in irons, in the same ships that had burned his boats. He was six and thirty years old, and he was hanged there before the season turned, the crown's own scribes setting the day down without ornament in the rolls Coinneach afterward read at secondhand, a man's whole life closed in fewer words than Coinneach's own report on the emptied houses had run to. Coinneach felt no triumph in the reading of it that he could afterward account for, only a tiredness that sat in him, he told his wife, the way damp sits in a wall after a long wet season, never felt at any single hour, and never afterward quite gone.

IV

Of the Harvests That Would Not Come

The raiding ended with Uilleam Ruadh's hanging, or near enough to ended that the coast road carried no further tidings of it, and for a handful of years Baile chrom's trouble was, at least, a trouble Coinneach recognised: the slow, ordinary work of a small town trying to fill again the houses a bad decade had emptied. It was not given the years to do it in. The harvests that should have carried that work began to fail, one on the heels of the last, in a run that the oldest hands in the town, asked, could not match to any dearth they themselves remembered, and by the ninth or tenth year of it the shared-meal custom that had always, in Coinneach's own lifetime, carried Baile chrom through a single bad season could no longer be stretched to carry a run of them.

He kept the custom himself as long as any grain remained to keep it with, standing at his own board each market day and dividing what the town's diminished fields had brought in as evenly as his own hand could manage it, and he told those who came to him, in the years the custom still held, that a shared hunger was at least a hunger a man need not carry alone. He remembered, of those market days, one old woman, Mairead, who had buried a husband and two sons to the sea before the dearth ever touched her, coming to his board with an empty basket and telling him, when he weighed out her share, that she had lived through three bad harvests in her own girlhood and had thought, until this one, that she had already learned everything a hungry year had to teach a body. She had not, she said, and neither, she suspected, had he, and she was proven right in that before either of them saw the end of it.

Coinneach kept his own account of the failing harvests the way he had once kept his account of the emptying houses, a column of numbers in the same chest of rolls, and he could have told, had anyone still cared to ask him, that the barley yield of his own charge had fallen by more than half across those years, and the fish catch with it, for the boats that remained had too few hands between them to work the grounds a full crew had once worked. He wrote no further letter south asking for relief, having learned, from the long wait over the force, that a plea for grain from a coast already known to the crown as thinly held and further thinning would travel no faster than the last one had, and judging, besides, that grain itself, unlike soldiers, was not a thing the capital could simply raise more of by the asking. But a hand, however fair, cannot divide what the ground has simply failed to give, and LE 819 the last of the households that had held on through the sea-thieves' years began, in ones and twos and then in whole families at once, to load their carts and go, as their neighbours had gone a generation before them, inland and east toward shires that still had bread to share. Coinneach's own wife Beathag died that same hard winter, of a chest complaint the town's one physician judged no different from a dozen such complaints she had seen through in better years, save that a body weakened by two thin harvests running had less in it to fight a fever with than a body fed as it ought to have been fed.

Coinneach buried her on a morning with the ground half frozen and stood afterward at his own door a long while, by his own account to the few neighbours still near enough to hear him say it, working out for himself, he said, not whether he ought to follow the others east, which he judged by then past deciding, but only how long a man owed a post before the post no longer owed him anything in return. He held the board a further year, more from a settled habit of duty than from any hope left in him that the holding served a purpose the town still needed served, keeping the tally of a shire that had, by then, scarcely enough hands left in it to need a tally kept at all. Old Eachann, who had spoken hard to him once about a fallen catch and a reeve's slowness, came to him that year and told him, gentler than he had ever spoken to him before, that a man could grieve a wife and hold a board both at once for only so long before one or the other of them began to suffer for it, and that Eachann, for his own part, had watched enough men on that coast try to outlast a grief with work alone to know how the trying generally ended. Coinneach thanked him for the saying and did not, that year, act on it, telling himself there was still a use in him yet.

V

Of the Roll Recopied and the Market at the Ford

The crown's own business went on, in those same years, at a distance the north-west shore had long since stopped expecting to feel. LE 829 the queen's scribes at Cathair dhearg took down the old Clàr nan Rìghrean¹ from its resting place and copied it afresh onto new hide, adding to it, as the old roll had never troubled to, every ruler since the fleet had gone, and setting the new copy's beginning at An Roghnachadh² rather than at the sailing, a small labour of a few scribes in a hall the width of the island away from any door a Baile chrom hand had ever knocked on. And some years after that a market grew up on the strand at Àth fhionn, where the coast road crossed the clear river, trading north-coast fish and the oil of stranded whales to a country that had, by then, stopped looking for either from the harbour Coinneach had spent his own working life keeping. Àth fhionn's strand grew loud with barter on market days in a way Baile chrom's own strand had not been loud in years, and the fishers of the north coast, Coinneach heard it said by a rider passing through, no longer troubled to carry their catch the longer road south to Inis mhòr at all, having found, in the new market, a nearer and readier hand to sell it into.

He heard both tidings the same way he had heard most tidings in his last years at the board, at secondhand, from travellers who stopped to water a horse and talked while it drank, and he set down neither of them in any report, judging, by then, that a reeve with fewer households under him than the roll now carried names for had little left worth reporting. It struck him, hearing of the market at Àth fhionn, that he had spent eleven good years and a score of hard ones keeping a harbour that a coast now further along than his own had simply grown past the need of, the way a man grows past the need of a coat that once fitted him, without any unkindness meant by the growing and none taken; and it struck him too, though he did not say this aloud to the rider who brought the tidings, that a market on a strand he had never once visited would go on trading fish and whale-oil for years after Baile chrom's own harbour stones had nothing left on them but gulls. He held the board through one further harvest, thinner than the one before it, and found, come the following spring, that he had at last worked out for himself the answer to the question he had stood at his own door asking on the morn-

1. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

2. the Choosing; lit. 'the choosing'

ing he buried his wife: that a man owed a post exactly as long as the post still asked a true thing of him, and no longer.

He went from house to house that had a soul left in it, the morning he chose to go, and said what there was to say to each, which was little enough after so many years of saying it in smaller pieces across a market board. Old Eachann was among the last he called on, and told him only that he had been right, a full year late, and that being right late was still a kind of being right. Coinneach said he supposed it was, and left him with the last of the dried fish from his own stores, since a man who no longer had a household to feed had no further use for it and a man who still did might.

He set the reeve's own chest of rolls and tallies in order, for whoever might come after him, though he no longer much believed anyone would, setting the grain counts and the boundary leaves and the long, thinning column of households each in its own place, as though a careful ordering of a record no one would likely ever open again were still, somehow, worth a morning's labour. The hearth he swept clean himself, which his wife had always done before him, telling the one neighbour who watched him do it that a man ought to leave a room as he would wish to find one. Last of all he took down the strip of netting Beathag had left half mended in her own basket, and folded it, and set it on top of the chest, unable to bring himself either to finish it or to leave it lying loose upon the floor.

Then he shut his own door behind him, and set the road east under his feet, an old man by then in everything but the years any roll had ever troubled to count against his name, and did not look back at Baile chrom again before the road bent and the strand went out of sight behind him. It is told at the road-houses along that stretch of the eastern way that a grey-haired man walked in that year asking after no kin and no trade, only after a shire that would still have a use for a hand that had once kept a tally, and that when he was asked, as a stranger on that road is always asked, what town he came out of, he answered plainly, and then said nothing further about it that any who heard him thought worth carrying on.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

Of the Crown Joined to the Vein

LE 841 – 939

Is buan a' bheinn, is goirid an rìgh. Lasting is the mountain, short is the king.

— said at Muileann dhearg of every ruler since

I

Of the Empty Hall

Queen Eilidh Bhàn died at Cathair dhearg at ninety years old, on 21 an Giblean, LE 841, in An Talla Dearg¹, where she had been crowned at eighteen, and with her the house of Catriona, six rulers and near three hundred years, came to its end. She left no child living and had never named one to come after her; the clerks of An Talla Dearg, who had served her seventy-two years and thought they had prepared for every ordinary grief a crown could bring, found they had prepared for nothing at all for this one, and stood about the hall for the better part of a day not knowing whose office it now was to give an order. One of them, an old man who had cut her own coronation roll as a boy of twelve, was heard to say that he had buried five clerks under her and had never once thought to ask who would bury the queen herself, since he had somehow supposed, without ever putting the thought into words, that she would simply go on.

Riders went out that same evening to Na Seachd Taighean², as riders had gone out at every death of a ruler for two centuries, each carrying the same plain sum-

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

mons; and it is told that Na Seachd Taighean did not meet at Cathair dhearg to settle what should follow, as the custom of two hundred years might have led a stranger to expect, but rode instead to Muileann dhearg, up to Taigh na Fèithe³ above the mountain, and sat there among the galleries and Clachan a' Chran-nchuir⁴ and the old smell of tallow and coal-dust rather than under An Talla Dearg's own roof. No one wrote why, and Leabhar a' Chùraim⁵, when it came at last to enter the matter, entered only the fact and not the reason. A scribe of Taigh na Fèithe who was young that year and very old when she told it afterward said that the head of one house had proposed An Talla Dearg first, as custom asked, and that another had answered him, not unkindly, that a house with no ruler in it was no fit place to make one, and that the mountain, at least, had never once in all its years stood empty of an office worth the sitting in. Nobody argued the point a second time. It seemed to every head who rode up the hill, she said, a plainer thing to choose a king among Clachan a' Chrannchuir than among the tapestries the house of Catrìona had hung, and nobody thought to question it further because it felt, from the first hour, less like a choosing than like a homecoming.

They sat first nine days in the long room under Taigh na Fèithe's north window, the same table at which Eòghann mac Pheadair and the crown's own scribe had once laid two counts of years side by side and found neither able to prove the other wrong. The capital sent no word and asked for none; a runner rode down twice a week with grain prices and boundary pleas for the clerks to hold against whatever hand should next take them up, and rode back again each time having settled nothing, for there was nobody yet at Cathair dhearg with the standing to settle it, and the clerks learned to keep the pleas in a growing stack rather than pretend an office existed to answer them. The houses rode home from that first sitting with nothing settled, and rode up again at each season's turning for five years, while An Talla Dearg stood empty and the stack of pleas grew. The sittings are not told entire in any leaf that survives, save that they were quarrelsome for the first years and quiet for the last, that two heads left the table more than once vowing they would not return and returned each time before the evening meal, and that in the fifth year a name was spoken that had not been spoken among Na

2. the seven houses of custody

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

4. the stones of the lot

5. the custody-book of the vein-house

Seachd Taighean in living memory, and was not spoken down again once it had been raised.

II

Of the Yard

Dòmhnall Ruadh was a man of Muileann dhearg in one sense and of the eastern hills in another, for his own household held its galleries and its house both at Muileann chrom, a morning's ride below the mountain, where snow still lay thick some winters on ground his own great-grandfather's father had once held before a battle changed whose it was. He was fifty-six that year, a quiet, careful man, heavier in the shoulders than in the face, who had spent most of his life managing three galleries of the coal-right and disputing boundary stones with neighbours who had long since stopped expecting to win an argument with him, for he kept his tallies as honestly as any custodian on the mountain and would give up a claim as readily as press one, if the measuring told against him. He had ridden up to Taigh na Fèithe¹ at the second summons not because he thought the matter concerned him — he said as much, more than once, to the men who rode beside him — but because every head of every house that held so much as a gallery's worth of the right had been asked to come and be counted among the voices, and Dòmhnall Ruadh did not think it his place to be the one man absent from a table his own house had a lawful seat at.

The last morning of the last sitting found him standing in the yard among perhaps forty men and women who had ridden up for the same counting and had nothing else to do with the waiting but stand in the cold and talk of anything but the choosing itself, when word came down from the hall that the houses had settled on a name; some little while passed before he understood, from the way the men nearest him had gone quiet and turned to look at him rather than past him, that the name was his own. He said afterward, to the one clerk who thought to ask him plainly what he had felt in that moment, that he had felt mostly a kind of embarrassment, standing in a yard he knew as well as his own threshing floor, in his working clothes with mud still dried grey on his boots from the ride, being looked at as though he had done something remarkable, when he had done noth-

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

ing that whole morning but come when he was asked and wait his turn like any other man of the coal-right.

It was an old man among the custodians, one of the last few alive who could remember his own father speaking of it, who took Dòmhnall Ruadh a little apart from the others and told him, plainly and without much ceremony, whose yard he was standing in: that it was the same stones, worn no smother in nearly three hundred years, on which another man of his own house, Raghnaill Ruadh, had once stood before a season of refused hearths and a war that killed him, and had taken a board of claimants' names from a shaking clerk's hands and said, of every name on it, *none of these*, and turned and gone in and shut the door with a sound the old man's own father had called, all his life, a very great deal too small a sound for what had just been done. Dòmhnall Ruadh had known the story his whole life, as every child of Clann Raghnaill knew it, half as a shame kept low at table and half as a thing nobody in the house had ever quite managed to be ashamed enough of to stop telling; he stood a while with his hand on the same stone gatepost the old man pointed to, and said only that he hoped he would prove a different sort of answer to the same question the mountain had once been asked, and the old man told him that hoping so, standing where he stood, was a better beginning than most men who had ever been offered a crown were given.

He sent that same afternoon for his wife and his two grown sons to come up from Muileann chrom, and it was his wife, by every account, who wept at the news and Dòmhnall Ruadh who did not, sitting up late that first night going over, aloud and to nobody in particular, which of his neighbours he could trust to keep his own galleries measured honestly in his absence, as though the crown of Dia-thìr were one more piece of land he had been handed to manage and nothing grander. He was crowned nine days later at Cathair dhearg, in the hall his own house had never once, in nearly three hundred years, been asked to enter as anything but petitioners with a board of names and a plea; and the crown sat, those who were there said, a little awkwardly on a man who had spent the whole ride down from the mountain more troubled about a boundary quarrel he had left half-settled at Muileann chrom than about who would keep the kingdom he was riding to receive.

III

Of the Joining

Through the first years of his reign he kept two households running side by side and badly, the crown's business at Cathair dhearg and Taigh na Fèithe¹'s business at the mountain, riding the thirty-nine miles between the two so often that the road's own keepers came to know his horse before they knew his face, and complained, in the way of men whose work has grown easier for a king's habits, that they had never in their lives shod one animal so many times in one man's service. The first winter he tried to hold court at Cathair dhearg for half the season and sit with the custodians at the mountain for the other half; by the second winter he had found that a boundary quarrel at the mountain waited no better on a king's absence than a grain plea at the capital, and that a man could not, in truth, be two rulers wearing one crown between two houses forty miles apart.

It was his reeves, not he, who first wrote the plain remedy into *Leabhar a' Chùrain*², on 6 an t-Ògmhios, LE 859: that the ruler of Dia-thìr was, from that day, also master of Taigh na Fèithe, and that the two offices, which had grown up under different roofs since before any ruler now living remembered a time they were not separate, should from then on be kept under one seal and answered for by one hand. Dòmhnall Ruadh read the entry, when it was set before him for his own mark, a long while before he set it, and said to the reeve who had drafted it that it read less like a new law than like a plain account of a thing that had already, in practice, been true since the morning he stood in Taigh na Fèithe yard; the reeve answered that most of the best laws he had ever copied were exactly that, and Dòmhnall Ruadh laughed, which those who knew him said he did rarely enough that the reeve remembered it the rest of his own life.

The heads of Na Seachd Taighean³, who had chosen him at the mountain and not at the hall, took their old office and carried it with them into the new arrangement without much debate, for it cost them, in the end, little that they had not already been doing in one form or another since the roll of the coal-right was first drawn. They sat thereafter as the king's own council at whichever of the two houses the business of the day required, and *Leabhar a' Chùrain* and the crown's rolls, kept apart for near three hundred years on separate shelves under separate roofs, were from that season copied by the same scribes onto the same shelves, a labour that took Taigh na Fèithe's clerks the better part of two years to finish and

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the seven houses of custody

left, by the end of it, not one leaf of either record that a stranger could tell at a glance from the other.

The seal was cut that same year at Muileann dhearg, by a metalworker of the mountain town who had never before been asked to cut anything grander than a gallery-marker or a boundary stake, and who took, by his own telling afterward, near a season over the die where a marker would have cost him a morning. He complained, more than once, in the hearing of the custodians who came to watch him at it, that the gold would not sit as he wished it against the blue, and set the wax to the fire and cooled it and set it again more times than any of them cared to count; but what he cut, on 1 an t-Ògmhios, LE 865, was, when it was finished, judged by every custodian who saw it to be Taigh na Fèithe's own old device exactly, unaltered in its bones: the trellis of gold that the custodians read as the galleries of the mountain, laid on a field of blue, and over it the hollow stone, the mascle, for the slab that had covered the first break long before any ruler's name was written anywhere on the island. Across the whole of it, at the crown's own asking and at nothing more, he set a single band of white, thin as a finger's width, running the field from side to side. Dòmhnall Ruadh, looking at the finished die before it was ever set to wax, turned it over once in his hands and said that he could find nothing in it that was properly his to add, and the master of Taigh na Fèithe, an old woman who had buried three custodians and outlasted two kings before him, told him that a ruler who wished to add nothing to another man's seal was, in her own long memory of rulers, the rarest kind there was.

From that seal forward every letter the crown sent bore the mountain on it as plainly as it bore the crown's own arms, and no clerk at Cathair dhearg, writing out a grant or a summons in the years that followed, needed telling twice why a trellis and a hollow stone stood over the king's own name where once only a plainer mark of the house of Catrìona had stood.

IV

Of the Mountain's Own King

he reigned five-and-twenty years, most of them, by his own account late in life, spent doing at An Talla Dearg¹ exactly what he had once done at

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

three galleries in Muileann chrom: walking boundaries, hearing disputes between neighbours who each believed the other had moved a stone, keeping a measure honest that others were forever tempted to lean on when they thought nobody was troubling to check. He never moved the seat of the crown to the mountain, though more than one of the seven heads pressed him to in the early years, saying plainly that a king who was also master of Taigh na Fèithe² belonged among the galleries and not among the tapestries the house of Catrìona had left behind; he answered, each time he was asked, that a crown kept too near its own coal soon forgot it had ever been asked to answer for anything else besides the coal, and that he meant, so long as he held it, for it to go on being asked to answer for a great deal more.

A quarrel came before him in his ninth year that those who served him remembered longer than most: two households of Muileann chrom, his own old neighbours, disputing a boundary stone that had stood, by both sides' account, exactly where it now stood for four generations, until a spring flood shifted the stream beside it and left each side certain the water, and not the stone, had moved. Dòmhnall Ruadh rode down from the capital himself rather than send a reeve, walked the ground with both households at his heels arguing the whole way, and settled it at last by asking each household's oldest living member, separately and out of the other's hearing, where they remembered playing as children; both answers agreed, within a few paces, and Dòmhnall Ruadh set the boundary there and told the assembled households, a little dryly, that he had settled more quarrels in his life with an old woman's memory of where she had once chased a goat than with every measuring-rod Taigh na Fèithe owned.

He died at Cathair dhearg in his eighty-second year, on 10 an Dùbhlachd, LE 871, the first man of his house in three centuries to be given, by the same seven heads who had once refused his ancestor to his face, every honour a dying king could be given: the lamps of An Talla Dearg kept lit three nights running, the roads from every shire seat sent a rider to carry the word, and Leabhar a' Chùrain³, when it came to enter his death, gave him a longer leaf than it had given any ruler before him, though the leaf said little more, in the end, than that he had joined the crown to the vein and kept both honestly for five-and-twenty years. He was carried, at his own asking made long before he was ill, past the house of Catrìona's tombs at the capital and up to Muileann dhearg, to be buried

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

under the mountain his family's name had once been driven from by a war and a refused board of claimants. The custodians dug the grave themselves rather than send for labourers, working through a night and half a day in a gallery no longer worked for coal, its walls still black with the old dust, and laid him with a single unlit lamp at his head, which Taigh na Fèithe's own rite asked for no other ruler before or since, the lamp's being unlit taken, by those who kept the rite, to mean that a man who had spent his whole reign making sure the measured handful reached every hearth honestly had no further need, in the ground, of a flame kept for him alone.

His son Ragnall Òg was crowned at Cathair dhearg a fortnight after, six-and-forty years old and already, from his father's long teaching, a good deal more at ease with a boundary dispute than with a court's ceremony, so that the clerks who had arranged his coronation found him asking, twice during the rehearsal of it, whether the whole business could not be shortened by an hour so that he might see a shire plea before dark. The crown and Taigh na Fèithe went on being one office under him without a word needing to be said about it, as though the joining his father had written into Leabhar a' Chùraim had already, in a single reign, stopped being a thing anyone thought to remark on at all.

It was in the years just after, while the mountain's own harbour of Seann Chwen finished its stone mole and the first barges of the coal-roads' carters began tying up where before they had only beached on shingle at low water, that a rider bringing the news south remarked, without much thinking about it, to a clerk at Cathair dhearg that he had ridden the whole way from the mole to An Talla Dearg under one seal the entire road, the mountain's trellis pressed into the wax of every letter he carried, and had not troubled, for the first time in his years of carrying such news between the two houses, to wonder for a moment which office he rode for.

V

Of the Hawk that Split

It is told that Seabhag Acaill¹, whose priests had for six hundred years taught the vein as a bird fed a measured handful and never more, met in council at

1. the Hawk of Acaill, whom the Hawk order calls Mòd

Cnoc bheag on 20 an t-Ògmhios, LE 889 and broke apart over a question its own founders had never thought to settle in all their teaching: whether the measure Mòd was fed could ever rightly be raised as the island's own numbers grew, or whether the handful fixed at the very first teaching, in a smaller age, must stand unchanged for as long as the order stood, whatever else changed around it. The council sat three days at Cnoc bheag, the elders on one side of the fire and the younger priests, most of them raised under teachers who had never questioned the measure at all, gathered on the other; and it is said that the argument turned at last on a single young priest rising to ask the elders, plainly, whether Mòd, could he be asked, would rather starve a flock that had outgrown his old handful than see the handful grown to meet it.

Those who held the older reading kept the name of An Seabhag Acrach², and kept the house at Cnoc bheag as it had always stood; those who held that a greater flock, grown these many generations past the numbers the first teaching had ever reckoned on, might rightly be fed a greater handful, were called from that council on An Seabhag Biadh³, and were asked, before the winter was out and not unkindly, to keep their teaching somewhere it would not be heard daily at Cnoc bheag's own hearth. They went north, most of them, to Seann Skell, the Seann Skell of the north coast and not the river port of the same name where Rolla a' Chalaith⁴ had first been opened, and it was there, under a priestess named Beathag nic Sheumais, herself no more than a girl of nineteen at the schism and a woman near forty by the time she had built the house up from four families' worth of following to a proper school, that An Seabhag Biadh³ raised their own house and kept their own teaching within sound of a sea that had never once, in six hundred years, given the island back so much as a word of what lay beyond it.

She rode south to Cathair dhearg herself, in her fiftieth year, to ask the king's council in person rather than trust the asking to a letter, and stood before the seven heads in An Talla Dearg⁵, which Dòmhnall Ruadh's own house had once entered only as petitioners, and asked, on 25 an Lùnastal, LE 919, that the hearths of the north coast, which she said went colder in a hard winter than Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁶ had ever meant any hearth to go, be given a quarter more than the

2. the Hungry Hawk

3. the Fed Hawk

4. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

5. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

6. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

measured handful allowed them. She spoke, those who heard her said, without raising her voice once, laying out the north coast's winters as plainly as a scribe laying out a tally, and sat afterward while the council debated her plea across the length of a single short winter's afternoon; and the seven heads, with Raghnaill Òg among them, heard her out in full and refused her, Leabhar a' Chùrain⁷ noting, at some length and for the first time in the whole record's history, every reason it gave for a refusal rather than the bare fact of one.

Beathag nic Sheumais rode back north with the refusal written out in her own satchel, as a leaf of another kind had once ridden south in another woman's satchel generations before her, and told her own house, when she reached it, only that the council had answered as councils answer, and that a hearth denied a quarter more was still a hearth, and would go on being kept whether Cathair dhearg agreed with the keeping of it or not. An Seabhag Biadhthe's house at Seann Skell stood after that exactly as it had stood before, neither larger nor smaller for the asking, and its priests went on teaching, to any hawk-keeper of the north coast who cared to climb the hill and hear them, that Mòd's true hunger and the mountain's own measured hunger were not, whatever Cnoc bheag still held to the contrary, one and the same question at all.

VI

Of the Fourteen Names and the Posts on the Road

A second tremor shook the hills above Cill ghlas on 14 an Dàmhair, LE 929, seventy years after the joining, and brought down a gallery that fourteen of the custodians' own labourers were working when the roof let go without warning in the small hours of the morning shift. Taigh na Fèithe¹ closed the gallery for good rather than dig the dead free of it, judging, as the custodians of Cill ghlas had judged once before after an older fall, that the mountain had already taken what it meant to take and would give nothing more back for the digging; and it set, at the gallery's mouth that same season, a plain stone with the fourteen names cut into it in the order they had gone down, the youngest a boy of thirteen new to the coal-face and the oldest a woman who had worked that same

7. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

gallery forty years without once being late to a shift. The custodians called the stone afterward *Clach nan Ceithir Ainmean Deug*² and kept it swept of snow every winter that followed, whoever held the crown at *Cathair dhearg*, and it became the custom, among the mountain's own households, for a family that had lost someone to any gallery, in any year, to leave a small stone of their own at its foot on the day of the fall, so that within a generation the fourteen names lay half buried under stones that were not theirs, left by people the fourteen had never known.

It was in the ten years that followed, with the memory of the fourteen still fresh at every gallery-mouth on the mountain, that the king's council took a matter into its own keeping that had never before needed anyone's keeping at all: the roads that carried the measured coal down from the mountain to the coast towns and their temples, which any house with a grudge or a boundary quarrel might, until then, have closed for a season as easily as *Ragnall Ruadh* had once closed a granary to every hearth that had not declared for him. One of the heads of *Na Seachd Taighean*³, laying the matter before the council, said plainly that fourteen names on a stone at a gallery's mouth were proof enough that the mountain gave up its coal at a real cost, and that a coal given up at such cost had no business being stopped on the road by any quarrel that was not the mountain's own; and none of the seven spoke against him.

On 12 an t-Samhain, LE 939, the council ordered every such road marked with the crown's own sign, that no house, whatever quarrel it carried, should ever again be free to stop the measured handful on its way to a hearth that had done that house no wrong: the carriers' road down to *Cathair dhearg*, the road over the pass by *Muileann fhada* that the mountain folk called the northern way, the road south by *Muileann chrom* where *Dòmhnall Ruadh*'s own people held their galleries, and the road down to *Baile òg* in the south. The posts went up through that whole autumn, a trellis and a hollow stone cut into each one at the joints where one shire's road gave over to the next, and the men who set them, coal-carters most of them, hired for the season and paid out of the tolls the new roads now raised, worked without much ceremony and without, so far as any leaf remembers, a single word said over the driving of the last one.

A carter named in no roll but his own household's, who had helped set posts on three of the four roads that autumn, was asked, the following spring, what the

2. the stone of the fourteen names

3. the seven houses of custody

work had been like, and said only that a man could walk the whole length of any of them now, from the mountain to the sea, and never once lose the road for want of knowing whose it was; and it was that plain answer, more than any leaf Le-abhar a' Chùrain⁴ kept of the council's own debate, that the mountain's households were still repeating to their children when the posts themselves had long since gone grey and lichened in the weather, the trellis and the hollow stone worn faint but never, in all the years that followed, unreadable.

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

CHAPTER THIRTY

Of the Stair under the hill

LE 944 – 1,015

I

Of the Road and the Empty Pastures

By LE 944 a rider going up from Cathair dhearg never rode the whole way on one horse. He changed at a road-house every few hours, wherever the coal-roads' own charter had set one, and the keeper of the house had a fresh animal saddled and standing before the old one had fully stopped, so that the word of the council could travel from An 'Talla Dearg¹ to the mountain between one dawn and the next dark without once slowing to a walk. The stabling was paid, every quarter, out of the tolls the roads themselves raised, and a keeper who let a rider wait so much as the time it took to draw a bucket of water heard of it soon enough from the reeve who kept the charter.

A keeper of one such house, a widow named Mairead nic Aonghais who had held her stretch of the northern road for eleven years, kept a tally of her own beside the reeve's: a notch cut for every rider who came through wearing the crown's own badge, and a second, smaller notch for every one of them who thanked her by name rather than simply throwing the reins at her boy and swinging up onto the fresh horse before his feet were properly in the stirrups. She said, to the one traveller who ever thought to ask her about it, that the first tally kept the reeve satisfied and the second kept her own opinion of the office satisfied, and that the two tallies did not always run in step with one another. It became a boast repeated at

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

every road-house table from the capital to the pass, all the same, that a rider of the crown's had never yet gone hungry, thirsty or afoot on a coal-road, whatever else might be said of the years, and Mairead's own notched stick, kept behind her door long after she was too old to saddle a horse herself, was shown to more than one grandchild as proof of it. She kept a third mark too, smaller still and cut with a different knife, for the riders who came through carrying nothing worth the council's own asking, grain prices and boundary pleas of no great weight, and she said once, to a reeve who pressed her on why she troubled to keep so fine a tally at all, that a woman who fed and mounted the crown's own business every day of her working life had earned the right to know, for her own satisfaction if nobody else's, how much of that business was worth the horse it rode on.

It was in LE 949 that the last shepherd families came down out of the high pastures of Doire uaine, in the hill country north of the mountain, and settled in the valley villages below. They gave the grazing as their reason, and the grazing was true enough; the grass up there had thinned with every dry summer for a generation, and a flock that once wintered fat on the high ground now came down each autumn with its ribs showing plainer than the year before. But every family that made the move, asked why now and not ten years before, spoke also of the *Marbh-bheò*², the dead-alive that was said to walk the empty shielings once the flocks had gone down, and not one of them could say exactly when they had first begun to feel that the high ground no longer wanted their company as much as their sheep still wanted its grass. An old woman of that country, the last to leave her own shieling, driving three goats and a lame ewe ahead of her down a track her own mother had walked before her, told the priest who met her at the valley's edge that a place could grow tired of being lived in alone by living things, and that she had felt the tiredness of it in her own bones a good while before her knees ever gave her a better reason to come down. The high shielings stood empty from that year, their turf roofs falling in one by one over the winters that followed, and no family of that country went up to winter a flock on that ground again. A drover passing that way some years on, driving cattle to the lowland market by the old high road because it was shorter than the coast way, said he had ridden the whole stretch of the empty pastures in half a day and had not once, in all that riding, heard a dog bark or seen so much as a wisp of hearth-smoke where a dozen shielings had once stood smoking every evening of his own boyhood. He said the si-

2. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

lence of it troubled him more than any wolf or storm the road had ever given him, and that he pushed his cattle on rather than camp there the night, though the light was failing and a camp there would have cost him nothing but the asking of ground nobody was left to grant or refuse.

Ros fhionn kept its salt fair in LE 959 as it had kept it every year within living memory, the salters working the pans from before first light and the carters lining up their carts along the flats for a full mile before the gates opened. The reeve who counted heads that day, for no better reason than that the crowd looked larger to him than any he remembered counting, gave up somewhere past four thousand, lost among the press of carts and pack-mules and children darting between the pans to steal a pinch of the white crust before their mothers caught them at it. He wrote the figure down anyway, rounding it plainly rather than pretend to a precision the crowd itself had never held still for, and it stood, in the fair's own rolls, as the largest day the town's salt trade ever saw. Nobody standing on the flats that morning had any way of knowing it was the height the town would reach; the rolls that named it afterward the richest place in the north-east wrote no more, in truth, than what every salter and every carter on those flats had already believed of their own town without needing telling.

Further south, by LE 969, Cathair mhòr's market drew more carts off more roads than the capital's own, until a trader newly come to the island could stand in either market and know within a morning which town he was in by the noise of it alone. The capital kept the crown, and kept the name of the greater town in every old roll that still gave it so, but the weight of custom, such as there was in barter and salt and silver neck-rings, went where the goods went, and the goods went, season on season, more and more to Cathair mhòr. No council sat to write a law about it, for a town does not need a law to outgrow another; it needs only more roads meeting inside its own walls, and Cathair mhòr had those roads, and kept gaining them.

A carter of the southern road, asked once by a clerk of An Talla Dearg why he always sold his barley at Cathair mhòr's market and not the capital's, said only that a man carried his load to whichever gate opened first and paid best, and that the clerk's own question was the sort a man asked from a hall, not from a cart. The clerk wrote the answer down as given, without comment, and it is the plainest word that survives of how the one town came to outgrow the other: a thousand carters, each on his own morning, choosing the gate that opened first, with no single act any leaf remembers behind it.

II

Of the Stair under the Hill

Calum Dubh mac Iain had cut stone on the quarry face north of the capital since he was old enough to hold a hammer without dropping it on his own foot, and by LE 979, the year the face gave way under him, he was nine-and-twenty, broad through the shoulders from the work and quieter than most men of his age, the kind of quarryman a foreman set to a stubborn seam because he would go on chipping at it a full day without once losing his temper over it. He had a wife at home and a boy not yet walking, and nothing about the morning the face opened marked it out, to him, from any other morning he had climbed the ladder to the working ledge with his lamp and his hammers slung over his shoulder.

The rock had been sounding wrong for the better part of a week, a hollowness under the ring of the tools that the older men on the ledge muttered about between themselves and the younger ones mostly let pass. On the morning it finally let go it did not fall so much as open: a slab the size of a door swung inward on nothing at all and left a black mouth in the rock where a solid seam had been standing a breath before. The men nearest it stepped back, as any man will step back from a hole where stone had just stood, and for a long moment nobody said a word, because the air that came up out of the opening was cold as well-water and carried no smell whatever, not damp earth nor old stone nor the tar-and-tallow reek of a worked gallery, and a nothing where a man's own nose looks for something is a stranger thing to stand near than any bad smell would have been.

One of the older men held his lamp in at arm's length, leaning as far over the black edge as he dared, and the light found steps: a stair cut into the living rock, tread below tread, each one worn to a shallow bowl at its middle as though feet beyond any counting had climbed it long before a single quarryman now living had drawn breath, going down and down past the point where the lamp's own light gave out entirely. It was Calum Dubh, standing a little behind the rest, who said the name before any other man on the ledge could get it past his own teeth: Toll-dubh, the shaft of the old tellings that every quarryman's grandmother had used to frighten children quiet at the hearth, and that no living soul had ever set eyes on, since no living soul had ever known where the ground had hidden it. A boy who had come up that morning with the water-skins said afterward that the quiet on the ledge, once Calum Dubh had said the name, had a weight to it he

had never once felt on a quarry face before, as though every man standing there had remembered, in the same breath, a thing they had agreed among themselves long ago, and never once out loud, not to look at too closely.

The foreman asked, in the flattest voice a man can manage when he is asking for something he does not want done, whether any of them would go down and look. Nobody answered him at once. Calum Dubh said afterward, to the one man who ever got more than a handful of words from him about that morning, that he could not rightly account for why it was his own hand and not another's that reached first for the second lamp; he had made no decision he could remember making, and found the lamp already lit and his own boot already on the top tread before the thought of volunteering had properly finished forming. Four men on the ledge drew straws for who should pay out the rope behind him, and every one of the four, by his own later telling, was glad past speaking of it to have lost.

His fellows watched the lamp go: a small light turning on the stair's own bends, dwindling fold by fold of the rock until it was no bigger than a star low on a winter sky, and then nothing at all, the dark of the shaft closing over it as complete as water closing over a dropped stone. They waited. Rope paid out and rope stood still; somebody counted his own heartbeats for a while and then gave it up, unable to say afterward how many he had reached. One of the men who kept that watch, an old quarryman near the end of his own working years, told his grandchildren once, and told no one else in his life besides, that they had waited long enough on that ledge to grow ashamed of how glad every one of them was, all at the same instant, when the light came back at last, small and rising, climbing the same bends it had gone down by.

Calum Dubh came up into the grey daylight of the ledge, sat himself down on the loose stone at the quarry's edge, and said nothing at all. He sat there long enough that the foreman sent the water-boy running for Taigh na Fèithe's own custodians rather than wait on a report from a man who plainly had none in him yet to give. When Calum Dubh did speak at last, to the foreman alone and out of the other men's hearing, he said nothing of what he had seen below. He said only, in a voice the foreman described afterward as tired past the ordinary run of tired and entirely steady besides, that the quarry face should be closed before any other man went near it, whatever word came back from the mountain.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

The custodians rode down within the week, four of them, and stood a long while at the mouth of the opening without going in themselves, looking at the black of it the way a man looks at a dog he is not sure will bite. Their order, when it came, held fewer words than the morning seemed to want: the mouth of it was to be walled, stone set on stone and mortared and left, and no quarryman was to work that face again as long as Taigh na Fèithe had any say in the matter. It was done inside a month, a plain wall of dressed stone set flush into the face as though the stair had never once opened behind it, and the custodians took what little Calum Dubh gave them of his own account and entered it in Leabhar a' Chùrain² exactly as he gave it, adding not one word of their own to fill out its silences.

He went on cutting stone for six-and-thirty years more, on other faces of the same quarry at first and later, as his own knees grew less willing, on quieter work nearer his house; and in all that time he never once told a living soul what he had seen on the stair below the last bend his fellows' watching had lost to the dark. His wife asked him, that first year and for some years after. His son asked him once, grown and thinking, perhaps, that a father might tell a grown son what he had never told a wife. Even Taigh na Fèithe's own scribe asked him, gently, of an evening when Leabhar a' Chùrain's entry on the matter seemed a good deal thinner than the occasion deserved. He gave every one of them the same answer, in the same tired, steady voice the foreman had first heard on the ledge: that a man who had gone down and come back owed the rock, if he owed it nothing else, the leaving of what he had found there exactly where he had found it. He died in his own house in his sixty-fifth year, an old man well liked in the quarry town for a quiet, careful kindness that carried in it nothing of a man weighed down by a fright he could not set aside; and whatever he had seen on the stair under the hill went into the ground beside him, unspoken to the end, first and last.

The walled face itself outlived him by no time at all worth remarking, for the quarry moved on to easier stone within a few years and the mortared stones grew a skin of moss no different from any other unworked rock on that hillside. But the quarry town kept, for as long as the town itself stood, a way of speaking of a close-mouthed man that named no stair and no shaft at all: to say of someone that he had *gone down and come up like Calum Dubh* was to say, plainly enough for anyone raised in that town to understand it, that here was a man who had seen

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

something and judged, on his own authority and nobody else's, that it belonged kept rather than told. It was said of more than one quarryman, in the years that followed, who had seen a bad fall and would not speak of it, and of at least one custodian who kept his own counsel on a matter of Taigh na Fèithe's business that the coal-right households never did learn the whole of. None of them, so far as any leaf remembers, had gone anywhere near Toll-dubh at all; the saying had outgrown the man who first earned it, as sayings do, and stood on its own by then, needing no stair beneath it to be understood.

III

Of the Ruins Ailean Measured

By LE 994 the copper-workers of Cathair mhòr had begun casting cooking pots for every hearth on the island that could spare a season's barter for one, each pot stamped on its underside with its own maker's mark, a leaf, a fish, or a plain letter worked into the mould before the metal was ever poured. They went out of that town on every road at once, north and along the coast and south to the market-towns, and a housewife of Ros fhionn or Cuan shean setting one over her own fire for the first time was, more often than she ever knew, cooking over the work of a hand she would never meet in a town she would never see. Some of those pots are still turned up by a plough or a ditcher's spade with the maker's mark worn thin on the underside, and no leaf that survives can say now which hand cast which.

It was in LE 999 that Ailean mac Dhùghaill, a scholar of Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹ at Dùn thais, walked north with a measuring cord and a set of wax tablets to the broken ring of standing stone the island called Làrach an Teampaill², the temple-ruin, which no living memory could say who had raised or to what purpose. He was nine-and-twenty that year, a careful, unhurried man his own teachers had marked out early as fitter for measuring stone than for arguing a bench, and he had asked the school's leave to spend a season doing nothing else at all but walk the old ruin's circuit with his cord and set down, plainly, whatever he found there. He laid his cord across the altar-stone at the ring's centre and found,

1. the druid schools

2. the temple ruin

when he had done, that it faced squarely toward the central mountains and turned its back on the sea; a plain fact, and one that no teller of the ruin's few surviving tales had ever thought worth the mentioning, since every teller before him had simply assumed, without once saying so aloud, that so old an altar must face the water as the schools' own shrines faced it now. Who had set the stone so, and to what end, Ailean would not guess. He said as much, in almost those words, to the two or three fellow scholars who pressed him for an opinion before his tables were even finished.

He went on, in the years after, to measure the other two ruins the island still argued over at its own hearths: Làrach an Dùin³, the fortress-ruin whose fallen wall a farmer's own plough still turned up stone by stone at the edge of his nearest field, and Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁴, the watch-fort on its headland where a shepherd could still stand, on a clear day, and see three days' sail of coast running away in either direction. The farmer at Làrach an Dùin met Ailean at his own field boundary with a barrowload of the stones his plough had turned up that season and asked him, half in earnest, whether the school meant to pay a fair price for the ones his own field kept giving back every spring whether he wanted them or not. Ailean bought none of them, but he set every stone the farmer showed him into his tablets before it went back onto the boundary wall, the farmer standing over him the whole while with his arms crossed, plainly unconvinced that a stone worth measuring so carefully was not, by rights, a stone worth paying for. Each ruin he walked as he had walked the first, every standing wall and fallen stone measured with his own cord, every faced stone's bearing set into his tablets before he trusted himself to draw so much as a single conclusion from the whole of it. More than once a pupil pressed him to say what the numbers meant before he had checked them a second time against the first pass, and more than once he sent the pupil away unanswered until he had.

By LE I,011, the year he judged the work finished, he had a set of tables giving the measure, the stone and the lie of all three ruins laid out side by side, set down more exactly than any single teller's account of any one of them had ever managed before him. He wrote, at the tables' close, that he could not himself say with any confidence whether one people had raised all three or three peoples each their own, for the stone of each ruin was cut in a manner none of the others quite matched, and the compass-bearings of their altars and gateways agreed with one

3. the fortress ruin

4. the watch-fort ruin

another in no pattern he could find, however many ways he laid the figures side by side to look for one. He set the finished tables before the school at Dùn thais for its own judgment, and the school, after a winter's argument on its own benches, judged only that his measurements stood sound and his caution on the larger question stood sounder still.

No scholar who came after him, in all the years his tables were kept and copied out fresh for the school's own shelves, ever found in the numbers a pattern that Ailean himself had missed. His caution left the question no room to be answered more boldly than he had left it, and so the question the three old ruins had always asked of the island simply closed, from that year onward: measured as far as honest measuring could carry it, and no further, in the same plain hand as the rest of his own tables, which set down, alongside every figure he had taken, exactly how much of the matter must be left standing unmeasured.

Of the Thousandth Year

LE 1,015 – 1,064

I

Of the Girl Who Kept the Tallies

Mòrag Ruadh was fifteen years old in LE 1,015, red-haired as her name said and quieter in a crowded hall than any of the old king's household thought a girl of her blood had need to be, and she had kept, since she was old enough to hold a stylus steady, a small wax-board tally of her own beside the steward's larger one: what her own chamber burned in candles through a winter month, what a new pair of boots cost against what the old pair had cost her two years before, what a horse ate in oats between one saddling and the next. She did this for no reason she could have given a questioner, only that the steward's own great ledger, kept for the whole of An Talla Dearg¹'s household, swallowed every small thing into a sum too large to see the small thing inside it again, and she found she wanted, without knowing quite why she wanted it, to be able to lay a finger on one particular candle and say what it had cost.

The steward, an old man named Pàdraig mac Ìomhair who had kept the hall's own great ledger since before Mòrag Ruadh was born, found her at it one evening bent over her wax-board by a poor light, and asked her, not unkindly, why a girl who would never be asked to account for a single candle troubled herself so over sums a steward was paid to carry for her. She told him only that she had found, the week before, that her own tally of the winter's candles and his own great

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

ledger's figure for the same month did not agree by some small measure, and that she meant to find, before she let the matter drop, which of the two of them had counted wrong. He laughed at her, gently, and went away to check his own figures against the chandler's own bill, and came back three days later, not laughing, to tell her that the fault had been his, a single tally-mark set down twice by a tired hand at the month's turning, and that he would be glad, from that evening forward, to have a second pair of eyes on his sums whatever the hall's own household thought of a girl who kept candle-counts for her own amusement. It is told that he never again, in all the years he served her afterward as queen, closed a month's reckoning without setting it first before her own eyes, whether she asked to see it or not.

The old king who sat An Talla Dearg in those years had sat it longer than any teller then living could put an exact number of winters to, and of the manner of his going, when it came, *Leabhar a' Chùrain*² sets down no more than the year. What is told is that *Na Seachd Taighean*³ met at *Taigh na Fèithe*⁴ above *Muileann dhearg* in the same season, as they had met once before to name *Dòmhnall Ruadh* the better part of two centuries before her, and that they sent word to *Cathair dhearg* within the month that the crown would go, this time, to the girl of *Clann Raghnaill* who kept her own small tally beside the steward's, a choosing *Leabhar a' Chùrain* records in four lines and no more, giving no reason beyond her house and her blood, as though the reason had been plain enough to every house present that no house thought it needed writing down.

She was crowned at *Cathair dhearg* in LE 1,019, nineteen years old, in An Talla Dearg her own girlhood tally had been kept in under a steward's larger one, and it is told that the first order she gave as queen, before any grain ruling or any boundary plea, was to the same steward who had watched her keep her small board for four years without once asking him leave: that a proper ledger be bound for her, of good vellum and not wax, and that every measure spent on her own household, however small, be entered into it in her own hand from that day forward, so that a queen who could not say what her own candles cost had no business asking a shire to account for its grain. The steward bound the ledger before the month was out, a plain board-covered book with a clasp of iron rather than silver, at her own asking, and its first page, dated the day of her crowning, holds nothing but a

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the seven houses of custody

4. the vein-house above *Muileann dhearg*

single line: the cost of the feast the hall had kept that evening, set down to the last tally, with her own name signed beneath it as though she meant the entry to answer before any question was asked of it. It is the first household accounting of any ruler of Dia-thir to survive whole from that day to its last page, and it survived, Taigh na Fèithe's own scribes noted afterward, for the plain reason that a queen who wrote so exactly of candles and horses had also, without troubling herself to say so, written exactly of a great deal else besides.

II

Of the Letters No One Could Read

By LE 1,034 the moss on the old stone at Carragh Cnoc bheag¹, above Cnoc bheag, had grown thick enough over its carved face that a hawk-keeper's grandchild, sent up the hill on an errand, could no longer find the letters at all beneath the green of it, and it was a young priest of the house there, a careful man named Tòmas mac Aonghais who had kept the mewes under Gormshuil's own teaching as a boy and turned, in his middle years, more to the shrine's old stones than to its birds, who asked the house's leave to clear it properly rather than let another generation grow up believing the carving had never held letters at all. He and two others of the house spent the better part of a month at it, working with wooden scrapers rather than iron for fear of the stone, and washing the face clean with water carried up from the shrine's own well a bucket at a time, until at last, on a grey morning with the whole house standing about him in a half-circle, Tòmas ran his own fingers over a face of stone as bare of moss as it had likely stood on the day it was first cut.

The letters were there, plainly enough, cut deep and old, but no man or woman of the house that morning, nor any scholar sent for afterward from Dùn thais, could put a single sound to a single one of them; they answered to no shape the schools' own tables of the letters had ever kept, and the oldest man of the house, who had climbed that hill since before Tòmas was born, said only that a stone could keep its own counsel as well as a man could, and that this one plainly meant to. Tòmas wrote the whole of it down anyway, in the shrine's own roll, tracing each letter as faithfully as his hand allowed and setting beside his tracing the

1. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

plain words that no one at Cnoc bheag, that year or after, could read it; and it is told that word of the cleared stone and its unread letters reached An Talla Dearg² before the season turned, carried down by the same wool-trade that had once carried Gormshuil's teaching up, and that Queen Mòrag Ruadh, hearing it read to her among the ordinary business of the hall, had the sum of Tòmas's own oil and vellum for the month's work entered into her own book without comment, and asked, of the messenger who brought the report, only whether the priests meant to try again. He answered that they did not know; that a letter which had kept its silence through however many years the moss alone could measure might, Tòmas himself had said, be owed the same silence back from those who could not answer it.

III

Of the Nets that Broke the Salt

Caol shean's boats had fished the same stretch of the east coast, out from the mouth of the Abhainn chaol, for as long as the town's own rolls ran, taking a catch that varied, season to season, no more than any fisherman expected a catch to vary; and it was in LE 1,039 that the boats came in, three days running, so heavy in the water that the men rowing them swore afterward they had never once, in a working life apiece, seen a hull sit so low and still make its own harbour without shipping green water over the gunwale. The salters of the town, who kept pans enough for an ordinary season and a little over, ran through what salt they held by the second day and sent, within the hour, to every salt-town along that coast for more; but no cart could reach Caol shean before the catch began to turn, and a foreman of the salting-sheds, a broad, unhurried man named Ruairidh mac Neacail who had kept the sheds eleven years and never once in that time seen them idle in the height of a season, made the call, on his own head and without waiting on any word from the reeve, to hang what could not be salted out in the wind instead, strung on lines the length of every lane in the lower town, rather than let it go to waste on the strand.

It dried, after its fashion; the wind off that coast was salt-laden enough in its own right to help the drying along, and Caol shean's lanes stood hung, for the

2. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

better part of two weeks, with more fish than any lane in that town had ever held at once, a sight that drew gulls from three parishes and children from every house to run beneath the lines and duck the drips. Ruairidh's own granddaughter, no more than six that year, was set by her mother to walk the lower lane twice a day with a long switch and drive the gulls off before they could strip a line bare, a labour she took to with more relish than any chore given her before or since, and she was fond of telling her own children that she remembered the smell of that fortnight before she remembered almost anything else of her own childhood, a smell the whole town carried on its clothes and in its hair until the last line was finally taken down.

But dried fish, however honestly dried, sold poorly against salted, the trading houses down the coast having long since built their custom around the one and not the other, and Ruairidh's own foreman's roll notes, in a hand plainer than most of its entries, that the greater part of that year's catch, the largest the town's own rolls had ever set down, fetched less at market than a middling season's salted catch had fetched the year before. The town went back to salting the next season and every season after, laying in salt enough, from that year forward, for a catch half again the size of any it had yet taken, a lesson Ruairidh is said to have summed up to his own daughter, when she came to keep the sheds after him, in a single sentence: that a good year could cost a town more than a bad one, if the town had made no ready place to hold it.

IV

Of the Thousandth Year

Bliadhnaichean an Diosail, as Taigh na Fèithe¹ kept them without a break of a single year since An Diosal², came in LE 1,039 to its thousandth year, a reckoning the custodians had watched approach for the better part of a decade and had argued over, in that time, more than any single number Mòrag Ruadh had yet heard argued in her own hall: whether the year deserved a feast, as some of Na Seachd Taighean³ held, or a fast, as others held, or nothing marked at all beyond the count's own turning of its page, as a few of the oldest custodians

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

3. the seven houses of custody

held, saying that a number was a number and owed no more ceremony at a thousand than it had owed at nine hundred and ninety-nine. It was the queen herself, hearing the three views laid before her in An Talla Dearg⁴ that autumn, who judged between them: one burning, she said, on the quay the count had begun from, no feast about it and no fast either, the measure and no more than the measure, so that the year would be marked as the count was kept, exactly and without excess on either side.

She rode down to Seann Skell herself for it, in the dark of the year, a journey of two short days over roads already hard with the season's first frosts, and stood, on the appointed evening, at the edge of Cidhe an Diosail⁵ among Taigh na Fèithe's own custodians and a crowd that had gathered along the whole length of the quay and back into the lanes behind it, more people than Seann Skell's own harbour-court had ever counted at one telling. The measure was brought down from Taigh na Fèithe in a plain iron scuttle, no more coal in it than any single hearth of the island might burn of an ordinary evening, and set alight on the stone where the harbour scribes had once cut the first tallies of the count, thirty generations of winters before. The flame that came up off it burned, by every telling that reached the hall afterward and by the queen's own account given to her scribe the next morning, the colour of the vein itself rather than any ordinary coal-fire's yellow, a deep, steady red that held its colour the whole while the scuttle burned down and gave off, the custodians said, no more smoke than a single hearth gives off in an evening, exactly as the measure had been meant to give.

A custodian of Taigh na Fèithe stood at the queen's own shoulder through the whole of the burning, an old woman of Na Seachd Taighean named Catrìona nic Fhearchair who had kept the count's own weights her whole working life, and it was she who leaned close, as the last of the coal in the scuttle settled to ash, to tell the queen, in a voice pitched under the crowd's own silence, that the count would go on the next morning exactly as it had the morning before, one more year added to the tally and nothing about the count's own keeping changed by the number it had just crossed. Mòrag Ruadh asked her, low enough that only the custodian and her own scribe standing near caught it, whether anyone now living understood why the count had been begun at all, on that quay, in that first year; and the old woman answered only that Leabhar a' Chùrain⁶ gave no reason beyond An

4. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

5. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

6. the custody-book of the vein-house

Diosal, and that a keeping a thousand years old by then had needed no better reason than its own long habit to go on being kept.

The crowd that had come down every lane and cart-track of that shore to see a thousand years burn in one small fire watched it burn down to ash without, by every account that reached An Talla Dearg afterward, a single voice raised the whole while, neither in wonder nor in complaint, and went home in the same silence once the last of the flame had gone out, a silence the queen's own scribe, riding back up the coast road at her side, said afterward he had found harder to account for than any noise the crowd might have made instead. Mòrag Ruadh herself said little of it that night or after, to her scribe or to the hall she returned to; what she did say, more than once in the years that followed to those who asked her plainly what the burning had felt like to stand near, was only that a thousand years had gone into that scuttle and come out again as one evening's worth of an ordinary hearth's fire, and that she had stood close enough to feel the heat of it on her own face the whole while, and had thought, watching it, of nothing grander than how small a measure could be made to answer for so long a keeping.

V

Of the Daughter Born at the Turn of the Year

Mòrag Ruadh's own daughter was born at Cathair dhearg the following spring, and named Beathag by her mother's own choosing before the child was a day old, for no reason the queen's book troubles to give beyond the name's own plainness; the book's entry for that week holds, beside the ordinary sums of candles and grain, one line set apart from the rest in a hand Taigh na Fèithe¹'s own scribes afterward remarked was less steady than her usual, recording only the day and the name and nothing more of what a mother might have been expected to write of a first child. The hall kept a quieter feast for it than the thousandth year's burning had asked of Seann Skell, a single evening's ale and a fire built up higher than the season strictly needed, and Na Seachd Taighean² sent, each in its own turn over the following month, a small gift to the cradle: a length of undyed wool from Clann Fhearchair, a carved horn spoon from Clann

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the seven houses of custody

Mhuirich, small things a child could neither use nor remember receiving, given, Leabhar a' Chùrainm³ notes, more for the houses' own satisfaction in the giving than for any need the cradle had of them.

VI

Of the Market above the Mill-Race

The hill country above Baile ghorm, in the island's south-east, had traded its grain and its clay in small parcels along the roads for as long as any teller there could set a date to, each farm carrying its own cartload down to whichever town would take it that season; and it was the hill-lords of that country, in LE 1,051, who set a single market to gather the whole of that trade in one place rather than let it scatter, as it had always scattered, along a dozen separate roads. They set it at Cnoc bhàn, above the long mill-race of Muileann fhada, where the water ran fast enough the year round to turn three wheels at once and where a cart from any farm of that country could reach the flat ground beside the race in a single day's driving. It opened first as a small thing, a handful of carts and a morning's trading over grain and clay and honey, but it held one good beside the ordinary run of a market that no other market on the island could offer alongside it: pearls, taken by the shore-women of that same coast from the mussel beds in the shallows below the cliffs, sold nowhere else in whole parcels but at that one market above the mill-race.

A woman of the shore named Sìne nic Ruairidh, who had gathered mussels off that coast since she was a girl and had sold her pearls, before the market opened, one or two at a time to whatever trader passed near enough to ask after them, brought the whole of a season's gathering to the market's first opening rather than sell it piecemeal as she always had, and found, to her own plain surprise, that a buyer down from Cathair mhòr paid her more for the lot laid out together than she had ever been offered, in all her years of gathering, for the same pearls sold singly along the road. The buyer, a trader of Cathair mhòr who had come to that coast on other business and heard of the pearls only by chance from an innkeeper the night before, told her plainly, as he weighed the last of them into his own scale, that a buyer could judge the worth of a whole season's gathering

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

laid out together in a way no single pearl handed across a cart-rail on a muddy road had ever let him judge it, and that she would do better, every season after, to make him wait for the market than to save him the ride by meeting him on the road herself. She told this to the other shore-women of her own stretch of coast before the season was out, and within a few years the whole of that coast's gathering came up to the mill-race market each season rather than trickle out along the roads a pearl or two at a time, so that a trader wanting pearls at all, from that year forward, learned to wait for the one market that held them rather than chase them down the coast in ones and twos. The queen's own book records, some years on, a single pearl bought at that same market and sent to the cradle at Cath-air dhearg for her daughter's naming-day, its cost set down beside a cart-load of candles in the same plain hand as everything else the book ever held.

VII

Of Baile Ghorm's Blue, and the Queen's Own Entry

The dyers of Baile ghorm had worked a common blue for their own wool since before living memory, a colour that held well enough through a season's wear but faded, every dyer of that town owned plainly, a full shade paler by the second washing than it had stood at the first; and it was in LE 1,064 that a dyer of that town, a patient woman named Oighrig nic Ailein who had spent the better part of ten years trying one mordant after another against the marsh plant her own mother had first shown her, found at last a mixing that held the colour fast through washing after washing without the fading her own mother's dye had always shown. She would not, by her own later telling, say exactly what turned the mixing from an ordinary blue into a fast one, only that she had changed one thing at a time across those ten years, keeping a careful board of her own beside her dye-vats much as the queen kept hers beside her household accounts, until one change at last held where every change before it had let the colour slip.

Cloth of that new blue was worn first at 'Taigh na Fèithe's own midwinter gathering the year it was made, and it is told that every house of custody present asked, before the evening was out, where cloth of that colour could be had, so

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

that within a few years Baile ghorm's own blue had become the feast-day dress of Na Seachd Taighean² entire, worn at every gathering of custody thereafter and known, wherever it travelled on a trader's cart, by the town that had first held the mixing that made it fast. Oighrig herself lived to see her own blue worn at three winters' gatherings running before she died, and taught her mixing, by hand and never by writing, to the two daughters who took up her vats when she could no longer stand at them.

Mòrag Ruadh's own book, in the same year, holds an entry for a length of that new blue bought for her own wear at Taigh na Fèithe's midwinter gathering, set down beside the ordinary sums of the season in the same plain hand the book had kept from its very first page; and it is that same book, turned back by a later hand to the page for the night of the thousandth year's burning, that gives the last word this telling has to give of that evening at Cidhe an Diosail³. Against the date of the burning, where another queen's book might have set down a verse or a line of wonder at a thousand years made into one evening's fire, Mòrag Ruadh had written only the cost of the coal, reckoned to Taigh na Fèithe's own weights, and beneath it, in the same hand and no larger, five words and no more: one handful, nothing more.

2. the seven houses of custody

3. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

Of the Swallowing Cough

LE 1,075 – 1,159

I

Of the Cough at Muileann dhomhain

Beathag Fhionn was thirty-nine years old and had sat at her mother's right hand in An Talla Dearg¹ for eleven of them, hearing boundary pleas and grain rulings and the slow ordinary business of a settled island, before she heard the word Muileann dhomhain spoken in a voice that made her set down the tally she was reading. The rider who brought it had ridden the eighteen miles from Muileann dhomhain without stopping to eat, and he stood in the hall's doorway swaying a little on his feet while he told it: that a sickness had come into the town that closed a man's throat until he could not swallow his own spit, still less bread or water, and that it had come quickly, house by house along the lower street first and then up into the hill lanes, and that the town's own healers, who had buried plagues before and thought they knew the shape of a hard season, had never seen a dying so fast nor a throat shut so tight against a cup held to it.

Her mother, Mòrag Ruadh, was seventy-nine years old that year and had worn the crown sixty years, since she was nineteen, and she heard the rider out in full before she said anything at all, which Beathag had long since learned was her mother's way with any tidings that frightened her, the silence buying her time to decide what a queen ought to feel before she let herself feel it. When she did speak it was only to ask how many, and the rider said he did not rightly know, that the

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

healers had stopped counting somewhere past a hundred and had gone back to nursing rather than tallying, which was, he said, an answer of a kind. It is told at Cathair dhearg that the queen sent grain and dried fish south that same week, and priests of Òrd Mhacha² to sit with the dying where the town's own could not, and that she sent nothing else, because there was nothing else on the island that a cough could be answered with.

Beathag rode south herself before the season was out, against her mother's own wish that she stay clear of the sickened town, and stood a morning at the edge of the lower street with a cloth held to her own mouth as the custodians had asked of her, watching two men carry a hurdle between them with a third man on it who could no longer swallow so much as the water they tried to give him. She did not go nearer than that edge of street, and she said afterward to no one but her own scribe that she had gone south chiefly to see with her own eyes what a rider's telling could only ever half give her, a thing she judged, looking back on it in her own age, to have been more for her own sake than the town's, since the town had no need of a queen's presence and every need of grain, fish, and priests, which had already been sent before she ever mounted a horse.

By the turn of the season the town had lost near a third of its people, the healers' own best count when the dying finally slowed enough to be counted, and the losing fell heaviest along the lower street where the houses stood close and shared a well, whole households going into the ground within a fortnight of one another, while houses two streets up, set apart on the hill with wells of their own, lost no one at all. Beathag heard this reckoning read aloud in the hall the following winter and thought, though she said it to no one, that the closeness of the houses, and not any fault in the blood, had done the killing, a thought she kept turning over long after the telling had moved on to other business, for she could see no way to prove it and no one in the hall who thought it worth the proving.

Two years on, the cough came down the coast to Seann Bhral, and Seann Bhral acted where Muileann dhomhain, taken by surprise, had had no chance to act at all: the town shut its own harbour before a single ship from the sickened towns could put in, and posted its own reeves at the gate to turn back any traveller on the coast road, and kept the shared meal, which had always been carried house to house by hand, by leaving baskets of bread and dried fish at the town gate instead, for whoever within needed them, so that no one from outside the walls

2. the order of Macha

need come near enough to catch a dying man's breath. It held. Seann Bhral lost fewer in that whole hard season than Muileann dhomhain had lost in a single fortnight, and the harbour towns down the coast, hearing how the shutting had been done, began that same year to talk among themselves, in a way they had not needed to before, about which of a town's own doors it might be wisest to close, and when, and who among their own people would have the stomach to keep a gate shut against a neighbour's own cart.

A reeve of Seann Bhral, an old woman who had kept the town's grain store for thirty years and was given the gate to keep as well once the shutting began, is said to have told a rider passing through, long after the sickness had gone by, that the hardest part of the whole season had not been the turning-away of strangers, who took a refusal at a strange gate as no more than the ill luck of the road, but the turning-away of the town's own folk who had gone out before the shutting to visit kin along the coast and came home to find the gate closed against them too, the rule allowing no house, however dear, an exception once the order was given. She had stood at that gate herself, she said, and told a fisherman she had known from childhood that he could leave food and word for his own wife within, but that his own body could not pass the gate until the season turned, and he had gone away up the road without answering her, and she had not slept easily for a week after, though she never once doubted the order had been the right one.

II

Of the Reeve at the Ford

Beathag Fhionn was crowned in the same hall her mother had held for sixty-three years, forty-two years old that spring and grey already at the temples, and the first act her own scribes set down under her own seal, before a grain ruling, before a boundary plea, before anything the hall's ordinary business might have offered her instead, was the closing of the coast road between Seann Bhral and Muileann dhomhain. It is told that she gave the order within the month of her crowning, before the cough had shown any sign of moving further west along that same road, judging, as her scribes later wrote it down, that a queen who waited for a sickness to prove itself before she acted against it had already waited too long to act at all.

The order she sent was plain enough for any reeve on that road to carry out without asking her leave a second time: that no traveller, cart, or beast was to pass between the two towns until the queen's own word released the road again, and that a reeve was to be set at every ford and every crossing of the coast road between them to see the order kept, day and night, through whatever weather the season sent. Six fords lay along that stretch of road, some no more than a stepping-place where the coast road crossed a stream too narrow to trouble naming, and to each of them the crown's scribes sent a reeve, chosen mostly from the towns nearest each crossing, men and women who knew the road, and were known on it, in turn.

To the ford nearest Muileann dhomhain, where the road ran closest to the sickened town and where, if the cough meant to travel west at all, it would first have to cross, the queen's scribes sent a young man of the town's own kin, Seumas mac Coinnich, thirty-two years old, who had held no office before that spring beyond keeping his own family's small herd of goats on the hill above the lower street where the dying had been thickest. He had lost, in the sickness's first passing, an aunt and two cousins and had watched, from his own high ground, smoke go up some mornings from more than one house on the lower street at once, and it was for that reason, the scribe who chose him is said to have written, and not for any skill the office required, that he was thought the surest hand to set at that particular crossing: a man who had already seen, at close hand, what the road behind him was closing against.

The other five reeves along that same stretch of road were of an ordinary sort, chosen for steadiness rather than for grief: a miller's widow at the ford above Caol dhearg, a shepherd who had never before left his own hill in a working life of forty years, a young clerk lent from the crown's own household at Cathair dhearg who found, within a week, that a ford asked patience of a kind no clerk's stool had ever asked of him. Between them the six held the whole of that road's crossing points, and it is told that not one of the six let a single traveller through in the three years the order stood, whatever the traveller's reason given, a plain and stubborn faithfulness the crown's own scribes remarked on afterward as owing less to any fear of the queen than to a thing harder to put a name to, which the scribes, wanting a word for it, called only the road's own discipline, as though the shutting itself had taught the six who kept it a single lesson none of them had known before that spring.

He held the ford through that first summer without much trouble, turning back carters who had not yet heard the order and travellers who had heard it and thought it need not apply to them, a labour that asked little more of him than a plain word said firmly and, once or twice, a hand kept near the staff he had been given, though he never once had to raise it. The travellers who came to his crossing in those first weeks were mostly strangers to him, or near enough, and a stranger turned back at a ford, however aggrieved, was a small enough thing to carry home at evening and set down.

It was near the season's end that his own brother came to the crossing, a cart behind him loaded with what looked, from the ford's near bank, like the whole of a household's goods, and called across the water before Seumas had properly seen who it was that their mother lay dying on the far side of the closed road, in a house two miles past the ford, and that he meant to go to her whatever any order said, closed road or no. Seumas knew the voice before he knew the face, and he is said to have stood a long moment at his own side of the ford with the staff loose in his hand, saying nothing, while his brother waited on the far bank for an answer that was, by both their own tellings ever after, longer in coming than either brother thought it ought to have been.

He turned him back. It is told, though Seumas never once spoke of that afternoon again in the whole of his life, that he said only that the order held for every traveller on the road or it held for none, and that a reeve who let his own kin through a ford he had sworn to keep shut had, by that one letting, already broken every other turning-back he had made or would make after it, whatever the reason given him. His brother called him hard names across the water, and then, when the names brought no answer either, turned the cart and went back the way he had come. It is told at Muileann dhomhain that their mother died within the week, and that the two brothers did not speak again for the better part of five years, until the road was long since opened and the cough forgotten by every household the sickness had not touched.

The road stayed closed the better part of three years, and the cough, whatever carried it, did not once cross west of the fords the reeves held; Muileann dhomhain buried its own dead and Seann Bhral kept its gate, and the rest of the coast, watching the two towns from a safe distance, learned a lesson it did not soon forget: that a shut door, held firmly enough and long enough, could hold back what no priest and no healer had found any other way to answer. It is told that Seumas mac Coinnich kept the crown's reeve-board at that same ford for the rest of his

working life, near thirty years, until his own death in his sixtieth year, and that no other order he was ever given afterward asked so much of him again, nor was any other, in the town's own telling of it, ever kept so faithfully.

III

Of the Houses Taken by Lot

Muileann dhomhain was slow to fill again. For twenty years and more after the road reopened the town stood at less than two in every three of the households it had held before the sickness, whole streets of the lower town given over to houses with no one left to claim them, their thatch going grey and their doors swinging on hinges no one troubled to mend, and the reeve who kept the town's own roll in those years, an old man who had lost a wife and a son to the cough, is said to have walked the lower street once a season and written down, without much comment, which roofs had fallen in since his last walking.

It was families from the hill country above the town, land too thin and too far from any market to hold a growing household easily, who came down in the end to take the empty houses, a handful each year rather than all at once, drawn by land already cleared and walls already standing, however far gone, and cheaper by far than the work of raising a new house from nothing on a hillside. Three brothers, sons of a hill farmer of Caol dhearg, walked down with their wives and children in a single autumn and drew, between the three of them, three houses standing side by side on the lower street where an entire family of the old blood had once kept a smithy, and it is told that the eldest of the three, Ruairidh mac Phàdraig, stood a long while before the middle house before he would go in, the smell of another family's hearth still on the walls after twenty years empty, before he said only that a house left standing was a house left standing, whoever had raised the roof-tree first.

The town's remaining custodians, judging that an empty house served no one and that a filled one, however filled, served the whole town better than a street of fallen roofs, opened the houses to lot rather than to purchase, a stone drawn from a bag for each household that asked, so that no family of the hill country could claim to have bought its way past a neighbour with a fuller purse, and no family

of the town's own old blood could claim a house left standing by right of who its people had once been.

By the year the last lot was drawn, near thirty years after the sickness had first come down the lower street, the older families of the town, those few whose houses had never emptied at all, said afterward that they no longer knew, walking their own streets, half the faces they passed, and that a town which had once been able to name every household back three generations came, that generation, to name its own streets by house rather than by kin: the goat-herd's house, the old weaver's house, without much certainty any longer of whose hands had built them first. It is not told that this troubled the town greatly. The houses stood filled again, and the well that had carried the sickness fastest along the lower street was by then two wells, dug wider apart at the custodians' own asking, and Muileann dhomhain, by every measure a reeve's roll could set down, was once more a living town and not a street of empty roofs.

IV

Of the Bridge Built Anew

Orochaid Ros fhionn had carried the salt carts of Ros fhionn across the Abhainn bheag for the better part of seven centuries by the year its own arches, worn thin by cart-wheel and flood alike, began to shed stone into the water below them faster than any mason thought safe to let pass unmended. A carter's mule went into the river with its whole load one wet spring when the road bed gave way beneath it, the mule drowned before anyone could cut it free of its traces and the carter left standing waist-deep in the current holding a dripping harness, and it was that one loss, small as it was against a season's whole trade, that the salt-masters afterward pointed to as the thing that had finally moved them to act rather than to wait another year on the crown's own masons.

The salt-masters of the flats, whose whole trade crossed that one bridge on its way to every market the island kept, met among themselves rather than wait any longer, and it is told that they raised, among their own number, the whole cost of the arches' rebuilding out of a season's trade, a thing no guild of salt-carriers had ever before been asked or offered to do for a bridge that was not, in any strict reckoning, theirs to keep.

The new arches, when they were finished, carried the salt-masters' own names cut into the keystones, each master's name set into the stone above the arch his own purse had paid for, a vanity the crown's reeve who came to see the work done is said to have remarked on, not unkindly, to the eldest of the masters present; and the old man answered him, the reeve's own letter to Cathair dhearg records, that a name cut in stone over running water would outlast any name set on a tally of silver, and that a salt-master who had spent his whole life watching his trade pass unremarked over another man's bridge might be forgiven, once, for wanting his own name to be the thing that held the road up.

Beathag Fhionn, by then in the thirty-seventh year of her reign and growing heavier in the years than she liked to feel herself grow, sent word that the crown would meet whatever the salt-masters' purses could not, and that the bridge, however it was paid for, remained the road's own bridge and not any one guild's to close or open as it pleased; but it is told that no crown's silver was in the end asked for, the salt-masters' own trade having carried the whole cost between them before her letter reached the flats, and that she let the matter stand as it had settled itself, judging, her own scribes later wrote, that a bridge mended without her silver was no less mended for the lacking of it.

V

Of the Queen's Death

She died at Cathair dhearg at nine-and-eighty years old, in An Talla Dearg¹, where she had sat at her own mother's right hand and closed a road against a sickness within the month of her crowning, and it is told that she was clear in her mind to the last day, dictating a grain ruling to her scribes on the same morning she took to her bed and did not rise from it again. The scribe who took down that last ruling, a young woman new to the hall's service, said afterward that the queen had asked her, once the ruling was finished and set aside, whether the road between Seann Bhrál and Muileann dhomhain still stood open, a question the scribe had no ready answer for, the road having been open more than forty years by then and given no cause to be spoken of in the hall in all that time;

1. the red hall, the right hall at Cathair dhearg

the queen, told that it did, said only that she was glad of it, and closed her eyes, and did not open them again to speak of any other matter.

Her son Ailean was crowned within the season, fifty-nine years old himself and no longer a young man by any measure the hall could offer, the first king of that name in Sliochd Raghnaill², and it is told that he wept once, briefly and without shame, at his own crowning, and that no one in the hall thought the less of him for it, his mother's reign having been long enough that half the hall had known no other queen in the whole of their own working lives.

VI

Of the Fading Things

It is told at Baile ghorm that the last dyer who knew the true mixing of Baile ghorm's own blue died in those same years without ever having taught it whole to either of the two apprentices she had quarrelled with and sent from her house in turn, so that the blue the town's weavers dyed thereafter, though it answered to the same old name, was in truth no more than the common blue any dyer on the island could mix, and it is said that the older weavers of the town, holding a length of the new cloth up against a length kept from before the old woman's death, could tell the two apart at a glance and never once, in the whole of their own lives after, stopped mourning the difference aloud to anyone who would listen.

Lightning found the ancestor-posts at Dùn ìseal on a summer night some twenty years after the queen's death, and burned them to their footings before the keepers could carry so much as a bucket from the well, and it is told that the keepers, setting new posts in the old ground the following season, cut the names again as best their own memory and Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ together could recover them, and owned plainly, in the roll they kept of the cutting, that a handful of the names so cut were guesses only, the old carving too far gone in the years before the burning for even the oldest keeper living to swear to every letter of them. No one is told to have thought the less of the new posts for the owing. A name guessed at in good faith and cut with the same care as a name known outright, the keepers

2. the house of Raghnaill

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

held, honoured the dead it stood for no less than certainty would have, and the roll's own plain admission of the guessing was kept alongside the new posts, for any who came after to read and judge as they pleased.

The Abhainn bheag silted at Ros fhionn in the years that followed, a shifting bar building itself below the salt flats faster than any dredging the salt-masters could set their own hands to clear it, until the loaded barges that had once run the river to the sea on every tide found themselves grounding, one after another, a bowshot short of open water, their pilots standing in the shallows and cursing a bar that moved a little further out with every season's flood, no two years' soundings ever quite matching the last. The salt-masters, whose own fathers had cut their names into Drochaid Ros fhionn's keystones not forty years before, took their trade at last to Caol gharbh's own harbour along the coast, where deeper water asked no such patience of a laden barge, and it is told that the flats above Ros fhionn went on making salt as they always had, the brine springs caring nothing for a river's silting, but that the barges that had once carried it out grew fewer year on year, until a pilot standing at the old bar on a still morning might watch a whole tide turn and go out again without a single loaded hull crossing it, and count himself, by then, not much surprised.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

Of the Table of Years

LE 1,165 – 1,266

Druim fon aisne, aisne fon chlàr, clàr ri clàr is an cuan fodhpa. Keel under rib, rib under plank, plank to plank and the sea beneath them.

I

Of the Narrows and the New Harbour

The salt of Ros fhionn had gone out by cart for as long as anyone at the market-court could remember, over Drochaid Ros fhionn and down the coast road to whatever harbour would take it, and for as long as anyone could remember the carters had grumbled at the bridge's toll and paid it anyway, because there was no other way to the sea that did not cost a full day more on the road. The salt-masters had moved their loading down to a landing at the river-mouth ten years before, when the river silted below the flats and the barges could no longer be trusted to clear the bar; but the landing was shallow too, and open to every gale that came up from the south, and more than one master had said, standing on its strand with a ruined cargo at his feet, that a harbour chosen in haste answered a haste and nothing more.

It was the masters themselves, in LE 1,169, who put their money together and sent it north to Caol gharbh, a fishing village on a deep inlet that had never held more than a few dozen boats and a smokehouse. They walled the inlet's mouth against the sea and dug the mud from its bed until a laden barge could lie there at any tide, and within three years Caol gharbh was posting its own harbour dues and calling its own quay, without much argument from anyone, the salt port of the north-east. The village that had smoked herring for its own tables now

weighed and shipped more salt in a season than Ros fhionn's flats had once sent out in three, and the men who had cut turf for the smokehouse fires found themselves instead loading barges and learning a trade none of their fathers had known.

Not every cargo that left the new harbour came safely to open water. A season after the walls were finished, a barge heavy with the first full loading struck the reef at the narrows below the inlet, in the narrows off the neck of land between Caol gharbh and Caol chrom, where the tide off the point meets the river's own current and neither gives way to the other. Those who had grown up on that shore knew the place by the standing wave it threw up at the ebb, a ridge of broken water that never lay flat even on the stillest day, and every fisher's child was taught early to keep well clear of it in anything smaller than a laden hull. The barge's own steersman had crossed it a dozen times before without harm and misjudged the tide by less than the turn of a glass; the hull struck, held a moment, and broke her back on the rock, going down with half her salt still in her before the two men aboard could do more than throw themselves clear. They swam ashore in water cold enough that neither worked a hand rightly for a fortnight after, and the elder of the two, asked afterward whether he meant to go back to the loading, said only that a man who had felt that water close over his head once did not need telling twice what it could do. The harbour-masters set a withy at the rock the following spring, the first mark Caol gharbh's channel had ever needed, and it stood there the rest of the age, renewed each year by whichever household the harbour-court named to the duty. On that same neck, at a standing stone above the narrows, the headmen of Caol gharbh and Caol chrom met that year to settle what dues the salt-boats should pay each harbour; they met there again over every quarrel of the strait that followed, and the stone came to be called Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich¹.

Drochaid Ros fhionn, meanwhile, fell quiet in LE 1,179. The salt no longer crossed it, and within a few years neither did much else, for the road it carried had been built for the salt trade and little besides. The office of bridge-keeper, which had passed from father to daughter and back again for longer than Leabhar a' Chùrain² troubled to record, was done away with when the last keeper died and no one came forward to ask for it in his place; the crown's reeve at Ros fhionn simply let the post lapse; and travellers who still crossed the old stone, a few

1. the meeting at the neck

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

carters, a few pilgrims bound for the coast shrines, found the toll-gate standing open and unmanned and did not trouble to ask why.

Yet the market-court did not move. It had sat at Ros fhionn since before the bridge was built, judging boundary pleas and grain disputes for the whole of that shire, and though more than one voice argued in those years that the court's business had followed the salt to Caol gharbh and ought to follow it in body too, the court's own clerks answered, when the question was put to them formally, that a court sat where the shire's disputes were brought to it and not where its trade happened to lie that season, and that moving a bench built of oak two centuries old to chase a harbour wall built in three years struck them as a poor exchange. The court stayed. Caol gharbh grew rich on salt and never once, in all the years that followed, gained so much as a single clerk of its own to hear a plea.

The channel that had swallowed the barge was marked properly at last a few years on, Seòlaid Ros fhionn³ laid out with withies from the old bar to the deep water beyond the flats, so that a pilot new to the trade might learn it in a season rather than in the ten years the old salt-masters had needed. It answered well enough while the withies were tended. In the years the harbour-court grew careless of the duty, the marks drifted and the channel with them, and more than one barge found the bar again the hard way before a fresh set of withies put it right.

II

Of the Millers and the Watcher in the Sea

At Muileann shean, some way inland of the salt trade's noise, the millers cut a new gearing for their wheels in LE 1,189, oak toothed against oak so that one wheel now turned two stones where it had once turned one. The first winter it ran, half the town came to watch it work and went away arguing whether the flour it ground was finer or coarser than the old way's, a question no two households ever answered alike; within a generation the gearing had spread to every mill of consequence in the north, and the millers of Muileann shean, who had cut it first, kept a carved model of it hung over their own door as a kind of boast, though the boast grew quieter with each mill that copied it without asking leave.

3. the marked fairway above Ros fhionn's flats

Off the thinned coast of the north-west, in the same years, the fishers of the small boats still working those waters began to speak again of the thing they called Uilebheist na Mara¹, seen close enough in LE 1,199 to foul a net and leave it in ribbons on the strand the following morning. Whether it was one beast or the name given to whatever the sea chose to show a frightened crew, no two tellings agreed, but the boats of that coast drew further in after that season and stayed nearer the headlands than their grandfathers had ever needed to, so that the last few miles of open water off the north-west cape went, within a lifetime, from a fishing ground to a stretch the boats no longer troubled to cross.

It was into a household of that same north-west coast, at a farm two days' walk from the thinned water, that Raghnaill mac Chaluim had been born, six years after the salt-masters first walled Caol gharbh's inlet. His father kept sheep on ground too poor for much else, and his mother's people had once fished the same water Uilebheist na Mara now kept for its own, a trade her own father had given up before Raghnaill could remember him at it. The boy showed no gift for either sheep or nets. What he showed, from an age his mother could never afterward fix exactly, was a habit of counting: stones in a wall, sheep through a gate, the notches on a tally-stick left over from some dispute of his father's, and asking, of anyone patient enough to answer him, whether the count came out the same the second time. His mother said once, late in her own life, that she had known him for a strange child the evening he came in from the fold in tears, six years old and furious, because he had counted the flock at the gate twice and got two different numbers, and would not be comforted until his father had gone back out with a lamp and counted a third time to settle which of the boy's two counts had been right. It was the sheep that were wrong, as it happened, one having slipped a hurdle and gone back to graze; the boy remembered only that a thing could be counted carefully and still come out crooked, and it troubled him, his mother said, far past the age when it ought to have stopped troubling a child at all.

A priest of the schools of the stag, passing that way on his own circuit the year the millers' new gearing was still news even on that coast, heard the boy through a whole afternoon of it and told his father, not unkindly, that a mind so set on counting things twice belonged at a house of disputation and not on a hillside among the sheep. His father, who had four other sons for the sheep and could spare the one, sent him south the following spring, a boy of fourteen, to Dùn

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

thais, where Taigh na Deasbaid² had stood since before any hand now living could say who first raised it, and where scholars of every rite came to argue questions the rest of the island had no leisure to ask.

III

Of the Table of Years

Raghnall spent the better part of twenty years at Dùn thais before he wrote the thing that would carry his name past his own death. He came to Taigh na Deasbaid¹ as a boy who counted sheep through gates and left it, in the eyes of the scholars who taught him, a man who counted people the same plain way, without flinching from what the count showed him.

The question that took hold of him was one he said, later in his life, had first occurred to him watching his own uncles: that his mother's brothers, who had fished the thinned water until Uilebheist na Mara² drove them off it, had died younger, every one of them, than the custodians' kin he came to know at Dùn thais, whose galleries fed them well in every season the vein answered at all. It was an unremarkable thing to notice and say aloud over a meal. It was another thing to test it.

He began, in his twenty-fifth year, going through every roll of births and deaths Taigh na Deasbaid would let him copy: Leabhar a' Chùrain³'s own entries where they touched Na Seachd Taighean⁴, the shire seats' tallies of their dead, the death-rolls the priests of every rite kept for their own dead alone. He set the heads of the custodian houses beside the tenants who worked their galleries and their land, house against house, generation against generation, and totted the years each had lived before Leabhar a' Chùrain or a priest's roll marked them gone. It took him the better part of nine years, most of it done by lamplight after Taigh na Deasbaid's own business was finished for the day, and more than one scholar who shared his table said afterward that they had thought him, for years together, a man chasing a private grief that any ordinary grief ought to have worn thin.

2. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

1. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

2. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

4. the seven houses of custody

On 29 an t-Samhain, LE 1,209, he laid the finished table before Taigh na Deasbaid entire, called together in its own hall on a morning of hard frost, the scholars sitting in their winter cloaks because the fires had not yet been lit that far into the season and no one had thought, until the doors were shut, to send for wood. Clàr nam Bliadhnachan⁵ was a single broad sheet ruled into columns, house against tenant, generation against generation, the years each had lived set down in a hand grown small and cramped from nine years of the same close work; Ragnall had had it copied fair the week before onto a hide large enough that two scholars were needed to hold it up before the hall could read it whole. The heads of Na Seachd Taighean lived, on the whole, some years longer than the tenants of their own lands lived, and the gap did not close, house by house, no matter how the sums were run again. He read the table aloud himself rather than let another scholar do it for him, his voice, those present said, steadier than his hands, and he asked, when he had finished, the one question the sums could not answer for him: whether the vein answered the hand that held it, and answered it more kindly than it answered the hand that only worked it.

No one at Taigh na Deasbaid that day gave him an answer either. Some scholars called it a fair piece of counting and nothing more, the kind of pattern a mind will find in any sufficiently large pile of numbers if it looks for one hard enough. One rose before the hall had properly settled and said as much aloud, that a man might set any two rolls of the dead side by side and find some difference or other between them if he wished hard enough to find it, and that a wish dressed in columns was still a wish. Ragnall answered him only that he had run the sums four times over four winters and would gladly run them a fifth in the scholar's own presence, on rolls the scholar chose himself, and the scholar, after a silence the hall remembered longer than the exchange itself, sat down without taking up the offer.

Others left the hall without speaking to him at all, and one old scholar, a custodian's own son by birth, is said to have told him afterward, in private, that a table was a poor vessel for a question that could unmake every house on the mountain if it were ever answered wrongly, and that he would do better to burn the sheet and keep the question, if he must keep it, in his own head.

Ragnall did not burn it. He sent a fair copy to Taigh na Fèithe⁶, addressed to no one custodian in particular, and kept his own working copy at Dùn thais, and

5. the table of years

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

for a few years the table passed from hand to hand among scholars of every house, argued over, copied badly, copied well, until word of it reached the king's council at Cathair dhearg by a route no one afterward could trace to its first carrier.

On 29 an Giblean, LE 1,219, the council forbade the table's copying. Taigh na Deasbaid was shut for a generation by the same order, its scholars sent back to their own shires and its hall given over, for a time, to the storing of grain against a lean year that never came. Ragnall himself was neither punished nor praised; the council's order named the table, not the man who had made it, and Ragnall, forty-four years old that year and past the age when a scholar without a school might easily start again elsewhere, went home to the north-west coast and kept sheep, badly, for the rest of that season, before a custodian of Taigh na Fèithe he had never met sent word asking whether his own working copy still existed and might be sent to the mountain for safekeeping.

He sent it. It was entered in Taigh na Fèithe's own inventory that same year, one line among the galleries and Clachan a' Chrannchuir⁷ and the old tallies of coal owed and coal burned, Clàr nam Bliadhnachan, forbidden to be copied, kept. No custodian who read the entry after him is recorded to have asked that it be destroyed, and none is recorded to have asked that the forbidding be lifted either. It stayed on the shelf Taigh na Fèithe had made for it, read by whoever came to the inventory with leave to read it and closed again by whoever came after, a question kept rather than answered, which is not, Ragnall is said to have told the custodian who took the copy from his own hands, quite the same thing as a question forgotten.

IV

Of the Gale, the Boundary and the Pilgrims

Ragnall lived one-and-twenty years past the forbidding, most of them quietly, at a small house near Dùn thais that the shut school let him keep for the asking, and it is told that he went on counting things to the end of his life, though what he counted in those last years no leaf that survives says plainly.

In LE 1,229, before the grain fleet had sailed for the season, a gale drove up the river at Inis mhòr higher than any then living had seen. It came in the night out of

the north-east with no warning any watcher on the strand could afterward point to, and the harbour's own people woke to a wind that laid the reed thatch flat on the landward side of every roof and a river running backward with the sea's own push behind it. Boats moored two deep along the strand were crushed against one another faster than a lantern could be got down to them, and by the grey of morning the strand was heaped with broken plank from stem to stern of the harbour, timbers that had been whole hulls the evening before now fit for nothing but a boat-builder's fire. The fleet that should have carried that year's grain south did not sail until the following spring. Inis mhòr rebuilt what the gale had taken through that whole winter, every hand in the town given some part of the work whether it had ever held an adze before or not, and when the spring fleet finally went out a season late, the harbour counted itself no worse off in the end than a hard winter might have left it regardless.

Ragnall mac Chaluim died at Dùn thais in his sixty-fifth year, in the small house the shut school had let him keep, and the scholars who had once argued his table over a shared table of their own carried him to the burying ground the school no longer had the standing to consecrate, and buried him there anyway, judging that a house shut by a king's council was not thereby unmade in every other sense that mattered to the dead. No stone was cut for him. A tally-stick was, notched once for every year the making of the table had cost him, and set at the head of the grave, where it stood until the weather took it, as weather takes most things left standing in the open on Dia-thìr.

In LE 1,246, in the far north-east, Baile ruadh and Achadh naomh went to law over the grazing on the hills between them, a quarrel old enough that neither shire seat's own clerks could say, when the case was first brought, how many times it had already been argued and settled and argued again by their grandparents. Each side came to Cathair dhearg with its own boundary stones to point to and its own old herders to swear where the line had always run, and each old herder swore a different line from every other, so that the council's clerks, hearing the third day of testimony, are said to have privately agreed among themselves that no one now living had ever known the true boundary and that both sides believed, with equal honesty, in a line neither could produce a single stone to prove. It came before the king's council three times before it was settled at last by dividing the disputed ground along a stream that ran, conveniently for the judgment though not, the

7. the stones of the lot

council's own clerk noted dryly, for either party's satisfaction, almost exactly down its middle. Both shire seats grazed their flocks to the water's edge from that year on, and the herders on each bank, meeting at the ford in ordinary weather, were said within a generation to have forgotten there had ever been a quarrel at all, though the stones each side had carried to Cathair dhearg and carried home again unused stood afterward in both towns' own boundary walls, still pointing, for whoever troubled to walk out and look at them, to a line the water had long since made no matter of.

The keepers of Na Seann Spioradan¹ renewed, in LE 1,259, the pilgrimage to Allt an Àigh², where a stream ran clear as glass and was said, by every rite that had ever sent a pilgrim to it, never once to have failed those who drank of it at the right turning of the moon. A guest-house was built beside the water that same year for those who walked from every shire to drink there, timber and thatch enough for a dozen travellers at a time, with a hearth kept lit through every season by whichever keeper held the turn of duty. Its own book of names, kept from the first season, showed within a few years pilgrims of every rite on the island entered side by side on the same leaf, dawn-hawk beside an Fhianna³, Manannan's sworn beside Òrd Mhacha⁴ of Macha, a mixing the keepers of the stream had not expected and, once it had happened, did not trouble to prevent, for the water itself, they said, had never once asked a pilgrim which rite had sent him before it answered him.

V

Of the Two Sons

King Ailean mac Raghnaill died at Cathair dhearg on 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,266, sixty-six years old, having reigned long enough that few at An Talla Dearg¹ that year could remember another king's seal on a letter. He left two sons by different mothers, and it was known, before the year was out, that each of the two had been told plainly, by whichever parent had raised him, that he

1. the Old Spirits

2. the stream of the healing water

3. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

4. the order of Macha

1. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

and not the other was the one meant to wear the crown after their father. Neither had been told this as a secret; both households had said it openly for years, at hearths and hall-tables where a saying travels whether it is meant to or not, and An Talla Dearg's own clerks, drawing up the king's burial roll, are said to have left a blank space where the name of the heir should have stood, unable to agree between themselves which of the two names to write and unwilling, in the king's own house and so soon after his death, to write neither. The council that had once forbidden a scholar's Clàr nam Bliadhnachan² met that winter to consider a harder sum than any Ragnall mac Chaluim had ever set before it, and found, by the time the snow came, that it had no answer ready either.

At Taigh na Fèithe³ above Muileann dhearg the inventory was read out that same winter, as it was read every winter, gallery by gallery, tally by tally, down to the single line a custodian long dead had entered nearly fifty years before: Clàr nam Bliadhnachan, forbidden to be copied, kept. The custodian reading it that year paused over the line a moment longer than the others, as the custodians before her had done and the custodians after her would go on doing, and then read on to the next line, for the inventory did not wait on any one entry, however long a shadow it had cast, and there was a great deal more of it still to be read before the reckoning of that year's coal could be closed.

2. the table of years

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Of the Brothers' Peace

LE 1,266 – 1,319

I

Of the Two Courts

The council that had failed to fill the blank space on the burial roll did not try again the following year, nor the year after that, and in the space where an heir's name should have stood a kind of silence settled over Cathair dhearg that everyone at An Talla Dearg¹ understood and no one troubled to name aloud. Iain Ciar, the elder by two years, kept his own following at An Talla Dearg, in the wing his mother's kin had held since before his birth; Alasdair Bàn kept his in the south country, where his mother's people had given him land and men enough that he need ask leave of no one to sit at his own table. For four years the two households traded no worse than cold courtesy, gifts sent at Na Ceithir Fèill-tean², messengers who ate at one hall and rode to the other without any word carried between them that either brother could afterward be blamed for.

The keeping of a house that was not quite a court and not quite a private hall had fallen, some years before the war broke, to a woman of the mining road with no part in either brother's quarrel: Mairead nic Mhurchaidh, who took up An Taigh-seinnse Mòr from her own father, the last of a long line of keepers descended, the road said, from Iain mac Mhurchaidh, who had built the house its second byre and begun, in a careful hand, the book of the ox-teams that lodged there through the mountain snows; she kept both after her father without changing so much as the ruling of the ledger's columns, and travellers on the central

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the four quarter-feasts

road who had known her father's keeping said, more than once, that they could not have told the two hands apart on the page had the years not told them which was which. Nothing in those years marked the road-house as a place either brother's fortunes would ever turn on. It was simply the halfway stage, the byre, the book, the fires kept through the worst of the snow for whichever ox-team the weather had caught between one shire and the next.

It could not hold, and everyone at both tables, if asked plainly, would have said so from the first winter. Iain Ciar was thirty years old when it broke and Alasdair Bàn twenty-eight, both of an age to have stopped waiting on their fathers' word and begun to trust their own, and each had spent four years hearing, from men who wanted a lord's favour more than they wanted peace between brothers, that the other meant to move first if he was given time enough to gather the strength for it. A messenger of Alasdair Bàn's, riding to An Talla Dearg with the ordinary gift at the feast of Bealltach, was turned back at the gate that fourth year on some pretext of the season's business too full to receive him, the first courtesy either household had refused the other in four years of careful giving, and it is told that Alasdair took the refusal, small as the matter was on its own account, as the answer he had been waiting four years to hear. Alasdair moved first. In LE 1,270 his men took Cnoc naomh in a night, a small holding worth little on its own account but sitting square on the road between the two households' lands, and held it eleven days before Iain Ciar's own riders came up and took it back with less blood than either side afterward claimed. Na Seachd Taighean³, who had watched the four years of cold courtesy without committing themselves to either table, could no longer sit apart once blood had been drawn on ground both brothers claimed. Four declared for Iain Ciar and three for Alasdair Bàn, and it was from that first taking and retaking of a holding no one had thought worth a war that the fighting which followed took its name: Cogadh nam Bràithrean⁴.

What the two brothers said to one another in those first weeks, if they said anything at all beyond what their messengers carried, no leaf that survives records. It is told only that neither sent to the other any word of grief for what four years of cold courtesy had come to, and that both, within the same season, called up every man their own three or four houses owed them, and set every road between the two halves of the island under one following's watch or the other, so that a carter who had crossed freely from west to east his whole life found, that first

3. the seven houses of custody

4. the Brothers' War

winter of the war, that he must now say plainly at every second crossing which brother's peace he travelled under.

II

Of the Burning of Ceann mhin and the Fall Below Muileann ghlas

Alasdair Bà'n's ships came down the coast to Ceann mhin in LE 1,272, which had declared for his brother, and burned its waterfront before the town's own bell had finished ringing the alarm. The fire took the rope stores first, where the tarred cordage went up faster than any hand could carry water to it, and then the granary beside them, so that by the second morning Ceann mhin had lost in one night both what it needed to put its boats back to sea and what it needed to feed itself until the next harvest came in. Men who had spent the day hauling water from the harbour to a blaze no bucket-line could master were found by dawn simply sitting on the strand among the salvaged nets, too spent even to grieve aloud over the char that had been the granary. The town sent to Cathair mhòr, which had taken no side in the quarrel and could afford to be asked, and Cathair mhòr sent grain enough that no household at Ceann mhin went hungry that winter, though the debt of it, one way and another, was still being spoken of at the two towns' markets a generation later, a favour neither given nor asked for lightly and neither forgotten easily either.

Iain Ciar heard of the burning three days after it happened, at An Talla Dearg¹, from a rider who had changed horses twice to bring the word faster than any single beast could carry it the whole way. He is said to have asked the rider only two questions, how many had died and whether the granary had burned before or after the rope stores, and to have given no answer of his own to either the rider or the hall until he had heard both answers in full. What he did afterward needed no further asking. He called up Na Ceithir Taighean² sworn to him and marched west through a season of hard rain that turned the mining road to a mire under every cart and every marching foot, and in LE 1,274, below Muileann ghlas

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the Four Houses of custody of the Holy Age

where the road narrows between the river and the hill, he brought Alasdair Bàn's own men to a stand at last and broke them.

Little of the fighting is remembered in any particular that survives; what is told is mostly the outcome. Alasdair Bàn was taken alive on the field, and his captains were let go home unransomed and unpunished on Iain Ciar's own order, given only his word that the war their lord had made was ended so far as they themselves were concerned. It was a mercy some at Iain Ciar's own table thought unwise, arguing that a captain sent home free was a captain free to be called up again if Alasdair's cause ever found new strength; Iain Ciar is said to have answered that a war fought to its bitter last man on both sides left nothing behind it but sons who would fight the next one for their own dead fathers, and that he had rather end this one clean than begin the next one already owed. Alasdair was carried east under guard to a house of his brother's own choosing, kept comfortably and watched closely, while the two households that had traded cold courtesy for four years and then blood for four seasons more waited to learn what their two lords would make of what was left between them. Word of the victory reached An Taigh-seinnse Mòr within the week, carried by an ox-driver who had turned back from the mountain road rather than push his team through country still unsettled by the fighting, and Mairead nic Mhurchaidh, hearing it at her own hearth, is said to have asked the driver only where the two brothers now stood to one another, and to have got, in answer, a shrug and the plain word that no one yet knew.

III

Of the Keeper's Day

The peace, when it came on 12 an t-Sultain, LE 1,276, was made on ground that belonged to neither brother: An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, the great road-house at the halfway stage of the central mining road, where the ox-teams of the mountain waited out the snow every winter of the year and had done since before either brother's grandfather was born. Mairead nic Mhurchaidh was given, by whichever messenger carried the choosing of the ground to both households at once, a single day's warning that the two brothers and their two followings were riding for her hall, there to settle, one way or another, what four years of cold courtesy and four seasons of war had left unsettled.

She spent the day scrubbing. It is the one particular of that day that every telling of it agrees on, whatever else each teller adds or leaves out: that Mairead nic Mhurchaidh, keeper of a house that answered to no lord but the road, took a single day's warning of two kings' followings arriving at her door and used the better part of it on her knees with a bucket and a brush, scouring a floor that had taken the boots of ox-drivers and reeves and pilgrims for longer than her own father could remember, because she had heard it said, by travellers who had seen greater houses than hers, that great men will quarrel over the length of a bench sooner than they will quarrel over the matter that brought them to the table, and she meant to give neither brother the smallest excuse. She set the long board in the common room with a bench to either side, and measured the two benches against one another with her own hands until neither ran so much as a finger's breadth longer than its match, and she set at each end of the board the same loaf, baked from the same batch of the same flour, and the same jug of the same ale, so that no clerk of either household, however he wished to find a slight in it afterward, could find one in the setting of the table.

Both followings drew up in the yard outside a little before noon, the two bodies of armed men keeping a careful distance from one another across the frozen mud, and it was into that silence, thick enough already that Mairead nic Mhurchaidh heard every hoof-fall on the yard's stones from inside her own kitchen, that Iain Ciar came in first, on foot from the yard where his own men had halted a bowshot short of the door, and sat at the end nearest the fire without waiting to be shown to it. Alasdair Bàl came after him under guard that fell back at the threshold and did not follow him in, walking stiffly in the way of a man not long out of the custody of another man's house, and sat down across the board from his brother without a word of greeting passing between them that the keeper, standing by the fire and trying to look as though she were not listening, could afterward report to anyone who asked her. For a long while neither brother spoke at all. What she remembered longest of that silence, she told those who came after her at the house, was the sound of the oxen shifting in the byre behind the common room, a sound so ordinary on any other day that she had never once, in all the years of her keeping, troubled to notice it before that afternoon, and that grew, the longer the two men sat without a word, to fill the whole of the room in her own hearing until she could have named which beast had shifted its weight by the particular creak of the timber under it.

What passed between the two brothers in the time that followed, she never told, whether because she never fully heard it over the fire's own noise or because she judged, once the telling of it had been asked of her a hundred times by a hundred different travellers over the years that followed, that a thing two brothers had settled between themselves belonged to the two of them and not to a keeper's fireside story. Asked by an old reeve of Cathair mhòr, years afterward, whether the two men had raised their voices at any point in the long silence, she answered only that she had heard nothing through the door she had not already heard from her own oxen, and would say no more of it however the reeve pressed her. The end of it she would tell, and told the same way every time she was asked: that Alasdair Bàn gave up whatever claim he had carried into the room and was granted, for the whole of his own life, the lordship of Seann Chwen and nothing more; that Iain Ciar, thirty-six years old that year, was acknowledged crowned by the brother who might otherwise have contested it to both their deaths; and that when the two men rose at last from the board, each loaf at each end had been broken by the hand nearest it and neither had been eaten, as though the breaking of the bread had stood in that room for something neither brother had needed nor wished to put into plainer words. Mairead nic Mhurchaidh swept the crumbs from the board herself that evening, after both followings had ridden their separate ways, and is said to have kept, for the rest of her own keeping of the house, a horror of seeing any loaf served whole and any loaf served broken set down together on the same table, a small superstition her own daughters after her never quite understood and never quite gave up either.

IV

Of the Years the Road Kept Its Peace

Alasdair Bàn kept the peace he had made for the whole of his own life, and it was said of him at Seann Chwen, where he held his lordship without complaint to the end of his days, that a man who has once sat across a board from his own brother with nothing between them but two whole loaves learns something about the keeping of a promise that no amount of being told can teach a man who has never sat there. He is remembered to have gone up to An Talla Dearg¹ himself twice in those years, once at the birth of a nephew he

would never rule after and once at the burying of an old captain of his own who had asked, dying, only that Alasdair carry the news of it to the king with his own mouth rather than send it by a rider; Iain Ciar received him both times without ceremony and sent him home again with a following no larger than the one he had come with, a small courtesy that satisfied neither brother's clerks, who would have preferred either a grander welcome or none at all, but seems to have satisfied the two brothers themselves well enough. He died at Seann Chwen in LE 1,291, a man of forty-nine, in the house his brother had let him keep, and no word of any quarrel renewed in his name is told of the years between the peace and his death. His lordship, on his dying, returned to the crown, as the peace had settled it should, and Iain Ciar is said to have kept, for the rest of his own reign, the lordship vacant rather than grant it to any other man, a small stubbornness An Talla Dearg's own clerks never once asked him to explain.

It was the burning of Ceann mhin, more than the battle that avenged it, that Iain Ciar is said to have carried longest in his own reckoning of the war. Having seen one shire seat beg its bread of another for the whole of a hard winter, he commanded, once his throne stood settled enough for such commands to be kept, that every shire seat of the island hold in store against the next war a full year's grain, measured and counted by the crown's own reeves at each autumn's close. The law, made LE 1,299 and called after him Lagh an Stòir², was kept faithfully while he himself sat An Talla Dearg to see that it was kept, and every granary on the island filled and emptied and filled again each year exactly as he had ordered.

The road below the road-house, in the years between, carried a new trade the two brothers' war had never touched. Masons of Ceann leathan, building a new front for their own temple, sent north in LE 1,295 for a stone none of their own quarries could match, a veined white marble found in the hills above Baile Mòr dhomhain, and from the year the first cart of it came south the road below An Taigh-seinnse Mòr carried a traffic that had never passed that way before: carriers who smelled of stone dust rather than coal or grain, and who paid, more often than not in cut stone itself rather than in silver or salt, for whatever fodder and shelter the road-house could offer their teams. Mairead nic Mhurchaidh kept a slab of it, unworked and no bigger than a hand, on the mantel above her own hearth for the rest of her keeping, a small vanity she never fully explained even to

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the law of the store

those who asked her outright why a road-house keeper should want a piece of stone bound for someone else's temple.

Pàdraig mac Ruairidh, a clerk of the king's own household, came to An Taigh-seinnse Mòr himself in those years, sent by no one but his own wish to set the war down properly before those who remembered it firsthand had all died out of the telling of it. He arrived on a wet evening with a satchel of wax tablets and a servant to carry them, and stayed three nights under the road-house's roof at his own expense rather than the crown's, working each evening by the same fire the two brothers had sat beside on the day of the peace, and asking, of every ox-driver who came in from the road, whether they had heard the tale told any way but the one the keeper herself told it. He sat with Mairead nic Mhurchaidh at the same board, by then scarred with the ordinary use of years rather than scrubbed for a single afternoon, and asked her plainly what had passed between the two brothers on the day of the peace. She told him, as she had told every asker before him, only the setting of the table and the silence and the two loaves broken and left; whatever words the two brothers had exchanged across that board she either had not heard or would not repeat, and Pàdraig, for all his asking, came away from her hearth with no more of it than anyone else who had asked her the same question over the years. He is said to have thanked her for her patience all the same, and to have left, before he rode on, a small silver ring of no great value pressed into her hand for the fire and the bed, which she kept afterward on the same mantel as the mason's slab of white stone, two keepsakes of two very different visitors set side by side without any comment from her that either was worth more than the other.

V

Of the Book, and the Meeting at the Far-Off House

The account Pàdraig mac Ruairidh finished at last, LE 1,304, praised the king at every turn it could find a turn to praise him on, and it is the only account of Cogadh nam Bràithrean¹ that survives whole to be read by anyone who asks after it, a fact that has vexed more than one later reader who would have liked a fuller word from the losing side of the table. Of the keeper's day it says only that the peace was made at a road-house between the brothers' lands and that

1. the Brothers' War

both loaves set upon the board were left uneaten, which is not quite the whole of what Mairead nic Mhurchaidh herself had told him and is, all the same, the only part of her telling that Pàdraig's book chose to keep.

Mairead nic Mhurchaidh died at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr in her own bed, in the sixty-ninth year of her life, on a night an ox-team lodged in the byre below her window as ox-teams had lodged there every winter of her own keeping and her father's before her, so that the last sound the household afterward remembered her waking to was the same shifting of hooves on straw that she had once told a hundred askers she remembered above every other sound of the brothers' peace. The keeping of the house passed from her to a sister's daughter who had grown up under the same roof and learned the same careful measure of a bench and a loaf that her aunt had never once, in all the years since the brothers' peace, allowed to slip; the ledger her forebear had begun and her aunt had kept without altering so much as its ruling passed with the house, and the niece continued it in a hand the ox-drivers who had known both women said they could not tell from either.

It was this niece who stood at the door of An Sligeanach Fad' às² on the eastern road, in LE 1,319, when the crown at last chartered the seven great road-houses of the mining circuit and made their keepers answerable, each for the stretch of road nearest their own hearth, to one another rather than to any single lord. Six other keepers stood there with her that same day, from six other houses of the circuit she had never before had cause to set eyes on, each carrying the same charter in the same crown hand, and it was a strange thing to her, she said afterward, to find that six strangers already knew the shape of her own work as well as she did, down to the particular trouble of a byre in a hard winter and the particular trick of stretching one season's stores through an unlooked-for extra month of snow-bound travellers. The seven keepers met there for the first time that same winter to settle their accounts, a meeting the charter itself commanded be held once every year from that one onward, and it was at that first gathering, among keepers who had never before had cause to sit at one table together, that the new keeper of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr was asked, more than once, whether the road-house tale of the two brothers and the two loaves broken and left uneaten was truly as her aunt had always told it.

She answered, each time she was asked, exactly as her aunt had answered every asker before her: the table set, the benches measured to a finger's breadth, the si-

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

lence, the sound of the oxen in the byre, and the two loaves broken and left, and nothing more, for a thing two brothers had settled between themselves at her aunt's own hearth was not hers to finish telling, whatever the charter now asked of the keepers who had inherited the roads their fathers and mothers had kept before them. One of the six other keepers, an old woman of a road-house on the bare northern stretch who had kept her own house through worse winters than any of the others at that table could match, said only, when the answer was given, that a peace kept quiet by the one who made the table for it was worth more than a peace any keeper cared to dress up for a stranger's asking, and the seven of them, meeting for the first time under a charter none of them had sought, drank to that and to nothing grander before the account-books were opened and the year's long business of the roads began.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Of the Keel-Songs

LE 1,320 – 1,439

Druim fon aisne, aisne fon chlàr, clàr ri clàr is an cuan fodhpa. Keel
under rib, rib under plank, plank to plank and the sea beneath them.
— the rope-makers' song of Cuan shean, as Iseabail nic Lachlainn set
it down

I

Of the Law That Lapsed

King Iain Ciar died at Cathair dhearg in LE 1,326, eighty-six years old and the longest-reigning of Ragnall's line since the peace at the road-house had made him king over his brother. He had kept his own grain law by will more than by love; the shire seats had grumbled at the cost of a full year's store set aside against a war that did not come again in his lifetime, and more than one reeve had let the measure slip a bushel or two in a lean season and been made to answer for it before the old king's own steward. Within a few years of his death the law went the way he had foretold in the note his clerk found among his leaves. No one troubled to repeal it; it simply fell away, store by store, seat by seat, until the granaries held what each town's own harvest gave them and no more. Pàdraig mac Ruairidh, who had written *Leabhar nam Bràithrean*¹ in the old king's praise, had died some years before him, and no one came after to keep the granaries' tale as he had kept the war's.

The road-houses he had chartered stood, though, for a charter is a harder thing to let slip than a habit of storing grain, and the keepers went on meeting

1. the book of the brothers

once a year at An Sligeanach Fad' às² to settle their accounts and complain, in the words the charter-roll had grown used to, of the price of everything and the honesty of no one. It was at two of those houses, in the years just after the old king's death, that the circuit's record set down the small things that were all it had left to tell.

II

Of the Houses on the Circuit

An Taigh-seinnse Òir, at the eastern end of the mining road, was written into the charter-roll in LE 1,339 for a dish of beef cooked slow in its own fat and a syrup the house kept secret, served to the custodians' reeves on their winter rounds when nothing else on the road stayed warm past the second hour of riding. The entry that follows it in the roll is a complaint, in a reeve's own hand, that the house had raised the price of the dish three years running without raising anything else about it, and that a man who had eaten it twice a winter for a decade had come, in his own words, to resent it a little more each time even as he asked for a second helping. The keeper's answer, set down beneath the complaint by whichever clerk thought it worth the ink, was that a secret cost what it cost, and that the reeve was welcome to eat elsewhere on the bare northern road if he found one.

He was not, as it happened, for the bare northern road offered him only An Taigh-seinnse Reòta, and it was there, a few winters later, that the charter-roll gained its longer entry. A party of reeves bound for the last shire seat before the pass was caught by a fall of snow that closed the road behind them and did not open it again for the better part of a season. They lived, by their own account written afterward at length and in a hand that grew steadily worse as the winter wore on, on pickled spinach and the keeper's own fire milk, a spirit distilled from whatever grain the house could spare and named, not kindly, for the way it burned going down. The keeper of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta kept them fed and kept her own accounts through it besides, and when the road opened she sent the reeves on their way and sent after them, by the first cart through, a bill for every jar of spinach and every cup of the fire milk, itemised. It was paid in full. The

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

reeves' complaint about the season stands in the charter-roll beside her bill, the two together, and neither party comes off the better in the telling.

III

Of the Hull That Filled

At Seann Skell, in LE 1,359, a boat-builder named Seumas mac Iain set himself to raise a deep-keeled hull from what the strand still remembered of Comann nan Saor-luinge's craft: the shape of a rib, the run of a plank, a keel laid true along its whole length rather than built up in the short sections the island's boats had used for generations since the last shipwrights of that lore died without apprentices. He had no drawing to work from, only what the old men of the harbour could still tell him and what he could reason out for himself from a wreck's ribs that a storm had once turned up on the strand at Ceann mhòr and that no one had thought, until Seumas came asking, to measure properly before the tide took it back. He worked at her through two winters, in a shed by the harbour that the town let him have rent-free on the strength of his father's name, and the harbour watched him do it the way a harbour watches anything that costs it nothing and might yet come to something.

She went into the water on a morning bright enough that half the town came down to see her float, and floated she did, for the length of time it takes to walk from the shed to the end of the quay and back. Then she took water at a seam along her new keel that no one, not even Seumas, could afterward say they had watched open, and settled by the stern, and went down in water shallow enough that her mast still showed above it an hour after. She went down slowly, by degrees, and the crowd that had come to cheer her stood the whole while and watched the mast go over, which some said afterward was the cruellest part of the whole business.

Manannan's priests at Taigh Mhanannain² preached on her for a year after, from the same text each time, that the god had unmade the fleet's craft once with reason and did not mean it remade by a boat-builder's guesswork. Seumas mac Iain did not build again. He kept the shed a few years longer, mending ordinary

1. the shipwrights' fellowship

2. the house of Manannan

boats for ordinary fares, and when he died the harbour-court noted only that he had once tried something no one else had tried in living memory and that the town was neither richer nor poorer for it, which was as near as the record ever came to kindness about him.

IV

Of the Fishers Who Went East, and the Lane to the South

The harbour at Caol íseal had been silting for longer than any one season could be blamed for it, and by LE 1,369 the fishing families who had worked it for generations gave the last of it up and moved east along the coast to Caol bheag, where the water still ran clean enough to float a boat at any tide. They did not go emptyhanded. They carried their nets, their smoking-racks, and the small shrine at the harbour's edge that had stood as long as the harbour had, stone by stone, and set it up again at Caol bheag exactly as it had stood, so that a stranger coming to the new place might have thought, from the shrine alone, that nothing at all had changed. Caol íseal itself did not empty. The houses nearest the silted water turned to farming the ground behind them, and within two generations the town that had once smelled of fish and tar smelled, on most days, of turned earth instead.

Further south, the fishers of Caol fhiadhaich had for as long as anyone could remember kept their boats inside the wild strait that gave the town its name, never venturing past its own two capes into open water. In LE 1,389 a handful of the younger men, restless with a strait that gave up less each season than it had the season before, took their boats round the southern capes instead, into water none of their fathers had fished, and found it ran the whole length of the south coast without a harbour worth the name until the mouth of the Abhainn uaine, where they came at last to the landing of Cidhe Beag, below the busy river-town of Baile thais. The dried fish they had carried down that coast for want of anywhere nearer to sell it fetched grain at a price better than their own market had offered in years, and they came home with full holds and a lane behind them that the charter-roll named, plainly enough, for the men who had first sailed it: Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich¹. The older harbours further along that coast, which had never in living

1. the southern sea-lane

memory put a boat past their own headlands, took a season or two to believe the story and then, one after another, began to follow the same lane south.

V

Of Iseabail nic Lachlainn

Iseabail nic Lachlainn was born into the royal household at Cathair dhearg the winter the reeves lay snowed in on the bare northern road, the daughter of a woman who kept the king's linen and a father no one at court troubled to name. She grew up under the stairs and along the kitchen passages of a house that had more songs in it than most, for every servant who came to the king's hall from every shire brought a handful of her own along with her box and her letter of service, and Iseabail, who was quicker with her ears than with her hands, learned to sit still in a corner of the kitchen and take them all in without being sent off to some more useful work.

By the time she was grown she had a name in the household for knowing more songs than the harpers who were paid to know them, and it was the king's own steward, more from wanting the girl out from under his feet at the linen-presses than from any great faith in the work, who first sent her out on Rathad na Banrighinn¹ with a mule and a letter asking any shire seat's reeve to give her lodging, to see what she could bring back from the towns that no one at court had thought to ask before. She was thirty-four years old the first time she set out, and she did not come back to Cathair dhearg for good until she was past sixty, having in the years between walked or ridden the length of every road on the island that a mule could manage, and a fair number that one could not, taking down in her own hand whatever the island's kitchens and rope-walks and byres still sang while they worked.

VI

Of the Rope-Walk at Cuan shean

1. the queen's road

She came to Cuan shean in her middle years, in LE 1,389, for no better reason than that she had heard, from a carter on the road above it, that the rope-makers there sang while they walked their strands, and that she had not yet taken down a rope-maker's song from that stretch of coast. The rope-walk ran the length of a field behind the harbour, half of it given over that year to barley for want of enough hemp to fill it, and the men worked backward along it in a line, twisting the strands as they went, each keeping pace with the man ahead of him by the beat of a song rather than by any word passed between them.

Tormod Ròpaire led them, a big, slow-spoken man who had walked that same field since he was a boy carrying spinning-tops for his father's crew, and it was his voice she heard first from the harbour road, keeping the others in step with the ordinary stuff of a working song: a line about a girl in the next town, a line about the price of hemp, the kind of thing every rope-walk on the island sang and no two walks sang quite alike. It was a cold, bright morning, the tide well out and the mud of the harbour showing its whole grey breadth below the field, and half the walk's length that year stood in barley rather than hemp, so that the men worked backward through green stalks for the first thirty paces and only came onto bare turned earth past the low wall where the true crop began. She stood at the field's edge with her tablets out, taking down what she could of it as she had taken down a hundred like it before, and might have gone on to the next town with nothing more than that, had Tormod not, without any word of warning to the men behind him, struck into a different tune altogether.

The others fell in behind him at once, as a crew that has sung together for years falls into a tune it knows without needing to be told it is coming. Iseabail caught two words of it clear across the field, *druim* and *aisne*, keel and rib, and put her tablet down and went nearer, and stood at the very edge of the walk with the strand-dust settling on her skirts, writing as fast as her hand would go while the men kept time with their feet and never once looked round at her.

When the song ended and the men stopped for their meal, she asked Tormod what it was about. He said it was about rope, the way every song on the walk was about rope, whatever else it seemed to be about. She asked him what the words further on meant, the ones after *druim* and *aisne*, and he looked at the men beside him, and they looked back at him, and none of them could tell her. It was, he said at last, the song his own father had taught him, who had it from his father before him, back further than any of them could put a name to, and none of them had ever thought to ask what the words meant, only to keep the tune and the

count right, for a rope walked out of step is a rope with a bad lay in it, and a bad lay is a rope that parts when a hull most needs it not to.

They were, all of that crew, sworn to Òrd Mhanannain¹, as most of the rope-walks on that coast had been for longer than anyone could say, wearing the god's grey knot at the collar the way every sworn rope-maker did; and when she asked whether the god's own priests might know the words, since the song plainly spoke of a hull's own bones, Tormod said only that the priests knew what Manannan wished them to know, and that a rope-maker's song was not, in his experience, high on that list. He sang it because his father had sung it and his father's father before him, and he saw no reason a man needed to understand a thing in order to keep it. One of the younger men, a stripling not yet trusted with the lead, said he had always supposed the odd words were simply older speech, worn down past hearing by however many hundred years of mouths, the way a stone step wears smooth under feet that never mean to wear it at all; and Tormod told him that might well be so, and that it changed nothing about how the strand was to be walked.

Iseabail stayed at Cuan shean the better part of a month, taking the song down whole across a dozen hearings, matching one man's memory of a line against another's where they differed, until she had as much of it as the rope-walk itself could give her. Two lines she could set beside island words she knew and be certain of: keel under rib, rib under plank, plank to plank and the sea beneath them. The rest ran on in sounds she could shape with her pen well enough but could not turn into sense in any tongue she had ever gathered a song in, on that coast or any other.

VII

Of the Reading at Court

Two years after, when the whole of that circuit's gathering was written fair, she brought it back to Cathair dhearg and set it before the king's court, in the hall where such things were read when a gatherer came home from a long round of the shires: the harpers first, to hear whether anything she had taken down was worth the setting to their own strings, and after them whoever else at

1. the order of Manannan

court cared to listen, which on the day she read Òran na Druime¹ was near enough the whole hall, for word of it had gone round in advance and a song no one could explain draws more of a crowd than one everybody already half knows.

She read the ordinary verses first, the girl in the next town and the price of hemp, and got the laugh from the hall that such verses are meant to get. Then she read the rest of it, keel under rib and the words that followed it, in the plain voice she had trained herself to read in, without dressing it up as more than it was.

The hall went quiet in a way it had not gone quiet for the rest of her reading. Even the king's own hounds, that had been shifting and scratching under the benches through the ordinary verses, lay still while she read the rest of it through. An old harper, who had been at court longer than most of the household could remember and had heard every song brought back from every shire in that time, asked her to read the strange lines again, and she did, twice more, and he shook his head each time and said he knew no tongue on the island that fit them, not the plain speech, not the priests' own forms, not the oldest words the harpers kept for the oldest songs. A clerk of Taigh na Fèithe², who was there for some other business and had stayed to listen, said that the shape of the words put him in mind of Leabhar a' Chùrain³'s oldest entries, the ones copied so many times over that no one now living could say for certain they had ever been read straight through rather than copied blind, letter by letter, by clerks who trusted the hand before theirs to have got it right. He did not say the two things were the same. He said only that neither of them made sense to him, and that this was, in his long experience of old writings, not nothing.

The king himself, who had sat through the reading with the same patience he gave any other business of the hall, asked at the end of it whether the song might be sung as well as read, since a tune sometimes carried a meaning that plain speech let drop. Iseabail said she had no voice for singing it as Tormod Ròpaire and his crew had sung it, walking the strand in step, but she gave the court what she could of the tune all the same, and the hall listened to that too, and was no wiser after it than before.

No one in the hall that day could tell Iseabail what the words of Òran na Druime meant, any more than Tormod Ròpaire and his crew had been able to at their own rope-walk, and she wrote as much into her own account of the reading,

1. the song of the keel

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

plainly, without trying to make more of the not-knowing than the not-knowing was.

VIII

Of the Schism, the Storm, and the New Harbour

While she was still on the road gathering the last of what would go into that reading, the temple of Òrd na Cloiche¹ at Inis thais split over a question that had lain under its floor for longer than either side liked to admit: whether the dead, who belonged to Donn, might rightly be prayed for by name at Clach, or whether such prayer trespassed on ground that was not Òrd na Cloiche's to offer. Those who said no kept the old temple. Those who said the dead might be named there built a second house at Baile gheal, finished within ten years of the first quarrel, and the two congregations went their own ways from that day, neither troubling the other much and neither, in all the years that followed, giving ground.

A storm the coast called Gailleann Ghlas came in out of the east within a few years and tore the harbour apart at Seann Tarr, leaving the village standing but its quay in pieces past any mending worth the cost. The boats that had worked out of it went to Cuan ruadh instead, which built a second harbour arm within the decade to take them, and throve on the fishing of both towns' waters for the rest of the age, while Seann Tarr kept its houses and its shrine and let its harbour go, and became, in the charter-roll's own dry word for such places, a village again.

Tormod Ròpaire died at Cuan shean within a few years of it, seventy years old, still walking the same field he had walked as a boy, though by his last years he let a younger man keep the count and the lead while he sang along behind. His crew kept Òran na Druime² after him as they had kept it before him, word for word as he had given it to them, understanding no more of it than he had, and no less either.

1. the order of the Stone

2. the song of the keel

I X

Of the Queen Small and the Grey Glaze

Catrìona Bheag of Clann Raghnaill was crowned at Cathair dhearg in LE 1,429, twenty-nine years old, the first queen the island had raised in more than three centuries. The record, in the plain way it keeps to for such things, notes that she was small, and that no one at her own court said so twice.

At Muileann gheal, in the last years the record has to tell of this stretch, the potters of one household found a grey-green glaze that no other kiln on the island could match for its colour or its wear, and the custodian houses bought their table-ware from that one family and no other. The secret of it stayed within Clann Mhic Phàil, mother to daughter, and was not written down, for a thing kept in the hand and the eye, they said, needs no writing to be kept; which was true of it, as it was true of Òran na Druime¹, until the day it was not.

X

Of the Song Unexplained

It is remembered of Iseabail nic Lachlainn, in the household she served the rest of her life, that she was asked more than once, in her last years at court, whether she had ever learned what Òran na Druime¹'s strange words meant, and that she answered every time in nearly the same way: that she had asked every scholar the household could bring before her, and every priest of Manannan who would speak with a woman on such a matter at all, and had been told, by all of them together, less than the rope-makers of Cuan shean had told her standing in their own field with the strand-dust on her hem.

She kept the tablets herself until she died, and left them to Taigh na Fèithe² with the rest of her collection, where the clerks who took them in wrote, in the plain hand of an inventory and not of a song, that the gathering held one item they could not describe by its meaning, only by its sound and its keeping: a rope-maker's work-song out of Cuan shean, sung by Manannan's own people, who did not know what they sang and sang it anyway, that spoke, as far as anyone could

1. the song of the keel

1. the song of the keel

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

tell, of a keel, and a rib, and a plank, and the sea beneath them, and of nothing that any hall at Cathair dhearg, that day or any day after, could put into plainer words than its own.

Of the Queen Who Went Round

LE 1,440 – 1,629

I

Of the Oath of the Seven

Queen Catriona Bheag called the heads of Na Seachd Taighean¹ to Cathair dhearg in LE 1,449 to swear again to Riaghailt an Teallaich², as no queen had asked of them since Catriona Bhuadhach set the ruling down. None of the seven had ever refused it; none of them, either, had been asked to swear it again in three generations, and there is a difference, An Talla Dearg³'s own clerk noted at the foot of his roll, between a promise a house keeps because it was never tested and a promise a house is called to make a second time before witnesses. Clann Mhuirich swore first, as their custom was from the founding of the seven, and Clann Fhearchair and Clann Ìomhair and Clann Raghnaill and Clann Thor-moid after them each in turn, a hand laid flat on Taigh na Fèithe⁴'s own hollow stone that a rider had carried down from Muileann dhearg for the day and would carry back again before the moon was out.

Clann Choinnich swore last. The head of that house, an old woman who had held it thirty years and buried two husbands in the holding of it, stood the better part of an hour at the foot of the hall while the other six spoke their oath and sat again, and when her turn came at last she stood a while with her hand still at her

1. the seven houses of custody

2. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

side and asked the queen plainly, before the whole hall, whether the swearing changed the measure her house held or only the manner of swearing to it. Ca-triona Bheag answered that it changed nothing but the manner, and the old woman said that a manner asked twice in three generations was worth asking after, and swore then, her hand flat on the stone the same as the other six had laid theirs, no louder and no softer. The clerk who kept An Talla Dearg's roll wrote that all seven had sworn and that one had asked a question first, and thought it worth the extra line, though he could not himself have said what he expected any reader after him to make of it.

The stone had come down from Muileann dhearg two days before under a rider's own care, wrapped against the weather in the same hide it had travelled in the last time Mionnan nan Seachd⁵ was sworn, and it went back up the same road the morning after, carried by a different rider on a different horse, so that no single house of the seven could ever afterward claim to have held it longer under its own roof than any other house had. The custodians who kept it at Taigh na Fèithe between such swearings let no one handle it but the rider charged with the carrying, and are said to have counted, on its return each time, the small chips at its edge against a tally kept for that purpose alone, a caution against nothing anyone could name and against everything, at once, that fourteen centuries of careful custody had taught Taigh na Fèithe to guard.

At Cathair mhòr that same decade the priests of Macha finished the floor of their great house, black and white stone laid in a pattern none of the masons who set the last of it had themselves begun, for the floor had been eleven years in the laying and every hand that had cut the first courses was long dead or long retired by LE 1,459. It stood, when it was done, the largest roofed building on Dia-thìr, and the priests who walked it barefoot on the day of its consecration said afterward that the black and the white ran so true underfoot that a man could close his eyes on it and still tell, by the cold of the stone alone, which colour he stood on.

II

Of the Stair Found Again, and the Dry Years

5. the oath of the seven houses

Charcoal-burners working the eastern woods in LE 1,469 broke through into a cut stair going down under the hill, the same shape and the same worked stone as the stair the quarrymen of the west had walled up five centuries before and never spoken of again. Word of it reached Taigh na Fèithe¹ within the season, and the custodians who came to look at it did what their fathers' fathers had done at the first one: they had it walled, the new stone set flush with the old rock so that a stranger walking the wood afterward would find nothing but a hillside grown over with bramble. The scribe who kept Leabhar a' Chùrain² bound the two entries to one another with a line in the margin of each, the eastern find to the western, though he wrote nothing of what either stair went down to, for nothing had ever been written of the first and no one saw reason to begin with the second.

The shires about Achadh shean had the worse of it in those same years. Three seasons running, from LE 1,479, the rain that the eastern hills had always caught for the wells below them failed to come, and the wells themselves ran low and then dry, one after another, until the reeves of the shire sent word to Cathair dhearg that the shared meal alone would not carry them through a fourth dry summer. The crown carted grain in from the south by the mining road, ox-team after ox-team through a country too parched even for the carts to raise the dust they usually raised, and the shire held, though it held thin. When the rain came back the reeves did not trust it to stay, and in LE 1,489 they set down on a board at the well-head how the deep wells would be shared among the households by lot and by turn, so that no single dry year again could be answered only by whichever family reached the water first. The board was cut new each generation as the old one wore, the names on it changed with the households that held the shares, but the lots themselves were never drawn again; the first sharing held, by habit more than by law, for as long as the shire kept any memory of the dry years at all.

It was at Àth shean, not many years after, that a young clerk newly set over the granary's accounts found, going back through the ledgers for a reason he could no longer afterward name, that the firloft the granary measured its grain by had worn smaller than the standard kept at Cathair dhearg, and had been worn so, by the plainest reckoning he could make of the old entries, for longer than any single reeve's term of office could account for. He carried the matter up rather than let it stand, and in LE 1,499 the reeve had every account the granary held corrected as

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

far back as the ledgers would allow the reckoning to run, a labour of a whole winter's evenings that satisfied no one so much as it satisfied the clerk himself, who is remembered to have kept, for the rest of his own service, a private habit of weighing his own hand's firloft against the standard each Samhnas whether any question had been raised against it or not.

III

Of the Last of Clann Mhic Phàil

Muileann gheal had been known the length of the eastern road for the grey-green glaze its potters set on the custodian houses' own tables, a colour no other kiln on the island had ever matched and no potter of the town had ever fully explained even to the sons and daughters who grew up firing the same kilns. The secret, so far as it was a secret and not simply a knowledge no one outside one family had troubled to learn, had stayed inside Clann Mhic Phàil for as long as the town's own memory ran, passed from a potter to whichever child of the house showed the surest hand at the wheel and the wet clay, and by the time Iain Mac Phàil came to the kilns as a young man there was no one left in the family but himself to pass it on to and no child of his own yet born to take it.

He tried, in the last years of his life, to set the glaze's making down in some form another hand might follow, and failed at it in a way that seemed to surprise him more than it surprised anyone who watched him try: the mixing he could describe well enough, the grinding of the stone and the ash and the water measured against each dish's own weight of clay, but the firing, the moment at which the kiln's heat had to be let fall rather than pushed higher, was a thing his own hands knew and his own words could not carry over to another man's hands however carefully he chose them. Two apprentices he took in those last years, both quick enough at the wheel, and both came away from their years under him able to throw a passable dish and unable to glaze it grey-green rather than the ordinary brown every other kiln on the island already knew. He died in LE 1,509 with neither apprentice yet trusted to try the firing alone, and for a generation after him the potters of Muileann gheal tried, by every method any of them could reason out or borrow, to find the measure of heat and the moment of its falling that Iain Mac Phàil had carried out of the world with him, and none of them came

near it. The custodian houses kept the dishes they already held, and are said to have prized a chipped one, thereafter, above a whole dish of any other glaze the island's kilns could offer.

Baile Mòr ruadh, in the same decade, found a smaller kind of fortune in a cattle fair its own market had held for years without any particular note being taken of it, until drovers from as far as Àth Chiar and the eastern hills began, in LE 1,519, to bring their beasts down for it every autumn rather than sell nearer home. It became, within a few more years, the greatest fair in the east, and the town's reeve, who had inherited a market of modest size and modest reputation, is remembered chiefly for having done nothing at all to bring the fair's new fortune about beyond widening the ground it was held on, a plain honesty he himself is said to have insisted on whenever anyone tried to praise him for foresight he had never claimed.

IV

Of the Queen Who Went Round

Sileas Òg was crowned at Cathair dhearg in LE 1,529, twenty-four years old and the first of her line in three reigns to come to the throne with both her parents still living to see it, though neither lived to see much of what she made of it. She had grown up, by her own account given years later to a clerk who asked her plainly what had put the notion in her head, hearing the shire seats named at her father's own table as places on a map and nowhere else, a string of names a reeve's report might carry to An Talla Dearg¹ once a year and no oftener, and she had thought, young enough still to say so aloud without anyone troubling to correct her, that a queen who had never set foot in Achadh shean or Baile Mòr ruadh or Doire fhionn knew those places the way a child knows a story told at the hearth: well enough to repeat it, not well enough to have stood in the rain there.

She began her round within two years of her crowning and kept at it, a shire seat or two each season as the roads and the weather allowed, until in LE 1,535 her circuit had carried her, by Taigh na Fèithe²'s own reckoning of her comings and

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

goings, to every seat the island's shires held, the first ruler of Dia-thir of whom that could be said. It cost her nothing so grand as the reeves at each seat feared it might when word of the coming visit reached them first: she asked for no feast beyond what the house already kept, sat at the ordinary board rather than any board raised for her, and asked, at every seat alike, the same plain question of whoever the town set before her, what the shire lacked that the crown might supply and what the crown asked of the shire that the shire could not in truth give. She reached the last seat of her round at last, on the bare northern stretch few queens before her had troubled to visit at all, some half-dozen years into her reign, and is remembered to have said, of the whole labour of it, only that she had at last stopped repeating a story and started remembering a place, a distinction she never explained further to the clerk who wrote it down and that he never asked her to.

At Achadh shean, on the leg of her round that carried her furthest east, she stood at the well-head and had the reeve read her the board where the shares were cut, name by name, and asked him why the lots had never been drawn a second time in all the years since the dry seasons. The reeve, an old man who had held the office longer than the queen herself had been alive, answered that no one had ever wanted to be the household that asked for the lots to be drawn again, for the asking would have said, to every other household on the board, that the first sharing had been unfair, and no shire wanted that said of it over a matter of water it had, in the end, survived. Sileas Òg is remembered to have looked at the board a long while before she answered him, and to have said only that a shire that would rather keep an old unfairness than name it was a shire she understood better for having stood at its well than she ever could have from a reeve's yearly report, and she rode on the next morning without asking the reeve to change anything at all.

It was on the strength of what her round had shown her, more than any single report a reeve had ever carried to An Talla Dearg unasked, that she commanded, once home again, a new count of every household holding the right to the coal. The count came back in LE 1,539 smaller than any before it, the right narrowed by two centuries of house joining to house and holding swallowing holding until fewer families held more of it between them than had ever held any part of it before, and Sileas Òg, reading the figure Taigh na Fèithe's scribes laid before her, had it entered in Leabhar a' Chùrain³ without a word of comment either way, a si-

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

lence the scribes themselves are said to have found harder to read than any word she might have spoken over it.

Ceann mhin burned a second time in LE 1,549, and this time no war stood behind the fire for anyone to blame it on; a spark from an ordinary hearth, in an ordinary wind off the water, was all the town's own reeve could afterward find to set against the loss of half its waterfront a second time in living memory. He gave the order himself, before the ash had cooled, that the town be rebuilt with gable walls of stone standing between each house and its neighbour, so that whatever caught next would have to cross stone rather than thatch to reach the house beside it, and Ceann mhin was rebuilt that way within the decade, the only town on the coast, for a generation after, that a stranger could tell from its own neighbours by the stone standing plain between one roof and the next.

V

Of the Silver Refused and the Steel Lost

Clann Choinnich brought a petition to the queen's council at Muileann dhearg, drafted by the house's own clerk after three winters of the head's own arguing at her own table that the coal, burning hotter than any charcoal the smiths of the east could otherwise buy, might be spared beyond the measured handful to smelt the silver of the seam at Muileann chlar. It was the first such asking Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ had ever recorded, for the coal until that year had been burned only for worship, the small hearth-measure of Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig² and no more, and the council that heard the petition in LE 1,559 sat the better part of a day over it before it refused, by what the clerk's own record calls a narrow voice and does not further number. Sileas Òg, presiding, is said to have given no ruling of her own beyond confirming the council's, and to have told Clann Choinnich's head, privately and afterward, that a law kept since before the fleet sailed for one reason was not easily bent to a second reason however sound the second reason was, a courtesy the old woman is said to have accepted without being in any way persuaded by it.

The clerk who had drafted the petition, a younger kinsman of the house who had spent the better part of a year weighing the coal's heat against the charcoal it

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

would spare and setting the figures down in a hand as careful as any Taigh na Fèithe's own scribes kept, is remembered to have asked, once the council's refusal was final, whether the figures themselves had been wrong. He was told they had not; the council had refused the asking and not the arithmetic, and the distinction, small as it sounds set down plainly, was one the young clerk is said to have carried with him the rest of his working life, keeping thereafter, in every leaf he drew up for his house, a line at the foot of it noting which of his figures the council had never in fact disputed.

The smiths of Dùn dhearg, who had made the ceremonial blades of the custodian houses since the walls of that town first stood, lost in LE 1,569 the last man among them who knew how the fellowship's layered steel was folded, a craft that had passed master to apprentice within four families for longer than the oldest leaves of Leabhar a' Chùraim could account for and that died, when the last of those four families' last trained hand died with no apprentice yet far enough along to have learned the whole of it, as completely and as suddenly as Muileann gheal's glaze had died sixty years before. The blades of Dùn dhearg were ordinary blades after him, well enough made and no better than any other smith's on the island, and the houses that had once prized a Dùn dhearg blade above any other kept the ones they already held the way the custodian tables kept their chipped grey-green dishes, a possession valued now for what it had once been rather than for anything the town's own forge could still produce.

The houses themselves, in LE 1,579, began burying their own heads at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach⁴, among graves older than any name still legible on them, a custom the council settled on for reasons Leabhar a' Chùraim gives only as fitting the dignity of the houses and no further. The tenants of the land about Tuam Cnoc dhìreach, who had buried their own dead where their own families had always buried them, called the new custom unwise to bury the great among graves no one living could any longer read the names of, and went on burying their own kin where they always had, a small disagreement between the houses and the land they held that neither side pressed the other to settle.

Of Sìleas Òg's own last years less is told than of her round or her count, and Clàr nan Rìghrean⁵ passes from her long reign to that of a kinsman of her own

2. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

4. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

5. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

house, Ailean mac Raghnaill, with no note of grief or of gladness set between the one reign and the next, the plainest kind of ending An Talla Dearg's own clerks ever gave a ruler who had done as much as she had to be known by name in every shire seat on the island.

VI

Of the Short King and the Shut Sea

A ilean mac Raghnaill, the fourth king of that name, was crowned at Cathair dhearg in LE 1,589 at nine and thirty years old, and is remembered in Clàr nan Rìghrean¹ for nothing else at all, for within the year he was dead at forty, the shortest reign the list had ever set down. What ailed him Leabhar a' Chùraim² does not say, only that his sister Mòrag nic Raghnaill, four and thirty years old herself, was crowned in his place before the same season had turned, and that she went on to reign some forty years more, Clàr nan Rìghrean's longest run of entries recording, in all that time, nothing graver than good harvests and the keeping of the rite. A clerk who served her the whole of those forty years is said to have remarked, near the end of his own service, that he had written more entries under her reign than under any three reigns before it and had, in all of them, set down no death by war, no famine and no quarrel between Na Seachd Taighean³ worth the ink to record it, a run of quiet years An Talla Dearg's own roll had not seen the like of since before the sundering fleet had ever gone down the river. Mòrag nic Raghnaill herself is remembered to have kept, of her brother's short reign, one habit only: she had the year of his crowning and the year of his death cut on the same stone rather than on two, a small economy of grief that her own clerks never asked her to explain and that stood, long after her own reign had ended, as the plainest record Clàr nan Rìghrean gave of the brother she had out-lived by forty years.

It was in the first year of her reign, LE 1,590, that the priests of Manannan gathered in synod at Seann Skell and restated, before the assembled orders of their

6. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

1. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the seven houses of custody

4. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

own house, the rule of sight-of-land that Manannan's priests at Ros bheag had first laid down nine centuries before: that no boat of the faithful was to go beyond sight of the headlands, on Manannan's own word that the mist behind the fleet was shut once and would not be opened a second time for any pilot bold enough or foolish enough to look for it. To the old rule the synod added a new prayer, to be said by the priests at the foot of the river pool where the fleet had once turned sunwise and gone, words the synod itself is said to have argued over through two full days before agreeing on the shortest form of them: *A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte*. Manannan, keep the sea shut.

Further down the eastern road, in years quieter than any the priests' synod troubled itself with, a ferry family settled at Cidhe Beag on the Abhainn uaine in LE 1,619 and took up the crossing there by canoe, carrying folk and their goods across water that no bridge had ever been thrown over and none, in that stretch of the river, was ever likely to be; they held the landing, father to daughter and daughter to son, for the rest of the age, and travellers on that road came to speak of the crossing the way they spoke of any other fixed thing on the road, a ford, a road-house, a ferry that had simply always been there. And on the slopes above Àth shean, growers who had pressed blaeberry and bramble into a dark wine for their own tables since no one could say when began, in LE 1,626, to sell the pressing along the eastern road in casks that kept a full year without souring, and the road-houses of that stretch took to serving it as black wine to travellers who had never before had anything darker than ale set before them at a road-house table, a small trade that outlasted, as small trades sometimes do, a good deal that the age's own reeves and councils had thought far more likely to last.

The priests of Manannan said their new prayer at the foot of the river pool that same year and every year after, at every tide the rite required of them, long after the ferry at Cidhe Beag and the black wine of Àth shean had settled into the ordinary business of the roads and no longer seemed, to anyone who used them, like anything new at all: keep the sea shut, said at the water's edge where the fleet had gone, the one part of that whole age's business with the sea that the island's own priests were still, after so many centuries, careful to say aloud.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

OF the LOFT over the MILL

LE 1,630 – 1,749

I

Of the Barge Kept on the Strand

By the seventeenth century of the count the island had grown better roads than it had ever had reason to build ships, and the coasting trade that had once gone by water from Ros chiar to Caol mhin, the cold way along the north coast, went by cart instead, year on year, until the last barge that had worked that water was laid up for good at Inis mhòr in LE 1,634. The men of Inis mhòr did not break her up for her timbers, as they would have done with any hull too old to caulk. They hauled her above the tide-line, chocked her level, and left her there, and told their children she was the last of the boats that had gone the cold way, though none of the children, and precious few of the fathers, could have said any longer what the cold way had been the cold way from, or to.

It was the temper of those years, on the whole island and not only at Inis mhòr: to keep the last of a thing on a strand or a shelf once there was no more need to use it, rather than let it go the way of the thing before it, which no one had troubled to keep at all. Fifteen years on an earthquake shook Dùn ìseal and cracked the wall of the spirit-house there, and the keepers took the crack for a warning and set a lamp before it, and could not agree among themselves, that year or any year after, of what the warning had been. A shudder of ground that had done no man any harm was made, by the very fact of nobody being harmed, into

a thing that had to mean something; it is the way of an age that keeps more than it uses and asks more of what it keeps than the keeping can answer.

II

Of the Widow of Muileann chaol

At Muileann chaol, on the millrace above the ford, Beathag nic Thòmais had kept the mill alone since her husband Artair mac Dhòmhnail died of a fever four years into their marriage, leaving her a widow at thirty with the wheel, the stones, and the ledger of who owed the mill grain and who the mill owed nothing. She kept it well, better by most accounts than Artair himself had kept it, for she had the kind of head for a ledger that does not let a debt run past the season it was struck in, and the millers up and down the ford came to her before they came to their own kin when an account needed settling without ill will on either side.

It was not the ledger that filled her loft, in the years after. She had grown, somewhere in the quiet of a house with no children in it, a taste for old writings that had nothing to do with the mill's business at all: a taste her neighbours found harmless enough, if a little strange in a woman with a trade to mind, and one that cost her, at the start, no more than the odd measure of meal for a board of accounts some dead reeve's grandson was glad to be rid of. She began, in LE 1,659, to ask about the ford and the market at Muileann chaol, and then further, by rider and by the carters who came through with grain, whether any house that no longer troubled to read them had an old copy of *Leabhar a' Chùrain*¹ lying in a chest, or a page or two of *Rolla a' Chalaigh*² of Seann Skell that some great-grandfather had kept for reasons nobody living now remembered. Houses that had such things, more often than not, were glad enough to sell them. A page nobody reads is worth less to the house that holds it than the meal a miller's widow will give for it, and Beathag paid a fair measure and never once haggled a seller down, which is why, within a few years, word of what she wanted travelled further than her own riders ever went.

She stacked what she bought in the loft over the mill, above the grain floor, where the heat of the stones kept the damp off better than any chest at ground

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

level could. Her neighbours called it, at first, the widow's rubbish, and said so to her face more than once, in the way a small town says a true unkindness and calls it a joke so that no one need answer for it. Beathag answered nothing to it either way. She went on buying, and stacking, and in a year or two the loft held more pages of the island's own past than any single chest in any single hall from Cathair dhearg to Seann Skell, though not a soul beyond her own ford knew it yet.

A carter out of Cathair mhòr brought her, one wet Faolach, a board no bigger than a serving-tray, black with age at the edges, that a house on the Cathair mhòr road had been using to weight down a cheese-press for as long as any living man there could remember. He had noticed, only because the light happened to fall across it while he waited for his own cheese to be wrapped, that the underside of the board carried a hand of writing, and had thought of the widow at Muileann chaol who paid a fair measure of meal for such things and asked no questions past the price. Beathag scraped the mould from the board's grain with the flat of a bone comb before she would let herself read it, and found a tally, three generations old, of what one house's coal-right had paid out at four winter burnings running, and nothing in it that mattered to anyone alive. She paid the carter his meal all the same, set the board on the shelf with the others, and told him, when he asked why she troubled over so small a thing, that a board a house had forgotten it owned was worth exactly as much to her as one it still prized, since neither house could tell her, any longer, which of its old writings would matter and which would not, and she had long since stopped trying to guess in their place.

It became, in that way, less a taste than a trade of its own, though she never asked a price of anyone for what she kept and would not, when asked, put a name to what she was doing beyond "keeping what's going begging." A vein-house clerk riding through on the crown's business, hearing of the loft from an innkeeper who thought it a curiosity worth a traveller's amusement, climbed the mill stair one afternoon out of nothing better than idleness, and came down some three hours later a good deal less idle than he had gone up, having found among her boards a copy of a custodians' ruling his own office at Muileann dhearg had lost the only other copy of in a fire two generations back. He asked her, before he rode on, whether she meant the loft for the crown's use, or Taigh na Fèithe's, or her own. Beathag said she had not decided, and did not think it was hers to decide alone in any case, and the clerk, who had ridden in expecting a curiosity and was

2. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

riding out with a ruling his own custodians badly wanted back, allowed that this was, on the whole, a wiser answer than most he had been given that year.

III

Of the Rag Paper

A neighbour of hers at the same ford, a woman a full twenty years her junior named Anna nic Coinnich, had a trade Beathag's own custom had unwittingly fed: Anna's father had kept a fulling-mill on the same race, beating cloth clean of its grease in wooden troughs, and Anna, who had grown up among the rags that trade threw off and never burned, for a good rag burns badly and smells worse, took to soaking the worst of them down to a pulp and pressing the pulp thin and letting it dry, the way her father's cloth dried on the tenter-frames, until in LE 1,674 she had a sheet that would take ink from a reed pen without tearing and without drinking the ink into a blot the way old skin sometimes did in a damp season. It was the first such sheet made on Dia-thìr, though Anna herself, standing over her troughs with her sleeves wet to the elbow, would have said only that it was a way of not wasting a rag, and thought no further of it than that.

Beathag was the first customer she had for it who wanted more than a single sheet to try. She had watched Anna work the pulp for a season before she ever asked to buy any of it, standing at the trough's edge with her sleeves pinned back the same as Anna's own, asking why this batch pressed thinner than that one and whether a rag of wool behaved as a rag of linen did, until Anna, more amused than put out by a widow twenty years her elder learning her trade at her elbow, told her plainly that she might as well take a hand at the frame herself if she meant to stand there asking questions a whole afternoon. Beathag did, and pressed a sheet with her own hands that came out uneven at one corner and perfectly good at the other three, and kept that first sheet of her own pressing, uneven corner and all, on a shelf of the loft apart from the rest for as long as she lived, though she never said, even to Anna, quite why.

Leabhar a' Chùraim¹ of Taigh na Fèithe², which had been kept on hide since Fionnlagh Dall's own day and passed hand to hand at every winter burning until

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

its oldest leaves were soft as cloth themselves, was copied that same generation onto Anna's paper for the first time, a leaf a week through one whole winter, by a clerk of Taigh na Fèithe who complained, at first, that the new stuff took the ink strangely and gave it up, by spring, that it took the ink better than hide ever had once a hand grew used to it. It was Beathag who carried the proposal to Taigh na Fèithe in the first place, riding the sixty miles herself rather than trusting it to a rider, for she judged, rightly as it turned out, that a custodian would sooner hear a strange notion from a widow with a mill's ledger behind her name than from anyone he could take for a huckster with a rag-heap to sell. The custodian who heard her out asked only whether the new stuff would hold the ink another sixteen centuries as the hide had; Beathag said she could not promise him that, since no one had yet had sixteen centuries to try it in, and the custodian, who had spent a long career answering harder questions with less certain answers than that, said it would do, and let the copying go ahead. Beathag bought reams of it herself for her own copying after, and it is from that winter that the loft's papers begin to run, in among the older hides and boards, on the paper of the same ford that made them.

IV

Of the Three Copies

Among the things that came to her loft, in the ordinary way of a house up the coast selling off what a dead grandfather had kept, was a leaf that gave the tidings of the fleet as they had first reached Seann Skell, sixteen centuries before: two coasts found, not one, and the fleet parted between them on the far side of the sea. Beathag read it once and thought little of it, for every child on the island had heard as much at a hearth in one telling or another. It was only when a second copy came to her, some years later, from a different house entirely, that she noticed the two did not agree: one gave the northern coast first and the southern second, and the other gave it the other way about, and where one said nineteen hulls reached a shore the other said one-and-twenty.

She went looking, after that, the way she had never gone looking for anything else in the loft, and within two more years had a third copy, from a house at Cathair dhearg that had kept it folded inside the cover of an older book entirely, as though whoever put it there had wanted it kept and not read. The third agreed with neither of the first two, not in the order of the coasts nor in the count of the

hulls, and in LE 1,679 Beathag laid all three out on the boards of the loft floor, side by side in the low afternoon light that came through the one window, and read them through again from the beginning, each in turn, looking for the seam where one could be shown to be the copy and the others the truth it had been copied wrong from.

There was no such seam to find. Each of the three was written in a hand that meant to be believed, none troubled to say where its own figures had come from, and all three, read close, agreed on the one thing that mattered most, that two coasts had been found and the fleet parted upon them, and disagreed on everything a court might have wanted settled beyond it. Anna, who had come up the mill stair with a fresh ream under her arm and found Beathag still on her knees over the three leaves at dusk with a cold supper untouched at her elbow, asked her outright which of the three she believed. Beathag said she believed all three of them, in the sense that she thought none of the three writers had set down a single figure he did not himself hold to be true; and she believed none of the three, in the sense that three men equally certain and equally honest had between them given the island three different pasts, and a woman with no better claim on the truth than any of the three dead hands that had written it down had no business choosing one of their certainties over the other two merely for the comfort of having chosen.

Beathag wrote out a fair copy of each, in her own hand, on Anna's paper, laid the three fair copies together in the loft where the originals had lain, and chose none of them. It was not laziness in her, nor a want of nerve; she had settled harder questions than this one for lesser men over her own mill's ledger without blinking, and more than one debtor at the ford had learned that a mild manner in a widow was no sign at all of a soft one underneath it. She judged, and said as much to the one or two who ever asked her outright, that a woman who had not been on the quay that grey morning had no business making three uncertain tellings into one false certainty merely because a false certainty reads easier than three that will not agree. A niece of hers, hearing the tale told at the fireside years after, asked why she had not simply burned the two that were wrong and kept the one that was right, since three could not all be true together. Beathag, by then an old woman, said that this was precisely the question the whole loft existed to refuse an answer to, and that the girl would understand it better the day she found she could not tell, of two things equally well attested and wholly at odds, which one to burn.

V

Of the North-West Counted

The crown, in the same years, sent a reeve down the empty roads of the north-west to list what households still stood between Baile chrom and Ceann mhòr, for the tallies that fed the winter burning had not been walked that coast in a long while and Taigh na Fèithe¹ wanted a true count before another season's measure was cut. He rode it alone, with a boy to lead the pack-horse and carry the tally-sticks, and found, at more than one landing along that coast, a row of berths cut square into the old harbour stone with no boat standing in any of them and no house behind them with a fire lit, the roof gone in on some and the door simply left standing open on others, as though whoever had gone out last had not troubled to shut it behind them and no one since had troubled to notice it stood open. He counted the berths at each landing before he counted the households, from a habit of a careful man doing the easier reckoning first, and by the time he came to the households themselves he already half knew, from the berths alone, what shape his answer would take.

The reeve came back, in LE 1,694, with a figure smaller than the one the old rolls gave him to expect, and smaller by more than the ordinary slow drift of the years could account for: fewer households, by his own careful count, than there were berths cut into the old harbour stone at any one of the three towns he walked through. He wrote his figure into the crown's own book, in the plain hand a reeve is taught to keep for such things, and rode home, and no one at Cathair dhearg asked him to walk the coast a second time to be sure of it, for a second count, by then, was a thing the island had learned long since not to want too badly. The boy who had led his pack-horse, grown to a man himself, told it afterward that his master had said only one thing to him the whole ride back that was not business: that a berth cut in stone outlasts the hand that cut it and the household it was cut for both, and that a coast can go on looking, from the sea, exactly as it always looked, for a long while after there is no one left on it to look back.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

VI

Of the Loft Left to the Town

Beathag died at Muileann chaol in LE 1,699, seventy-four years old, in the same room above the mill she had slept in since her wedding night, with Anna nic Coinnich, by then a woman of middle years herself, sitting by her through the last of it. In her last days she asked twice to be carried up the mill stair to see the loft once more, and was twice refused by Anna, who told her plainly that a woman of seventy-four with a fever on her had no business on a ladder-steep stair for the sake of looking at boards she had looked at every week for forty years and knew, by then, better than she knew her own hands. Beathag did not ask a third time. She asked instead that the shelf holding her own first, uneven sheet of Anna's paper be brought down to her, and held it a while, and gave it back, and said nothing more about the loft until the day she died.

She left the mill to a nephew who had no interest in old paper and a great deal in grain, and the loft, with everything in it, to the town, on the one condition that nothing kept there should ever be burned, for whatever reason and by whatever hand. The nephew, reading the will aloud to the assembled kin the day after her burying, stumbled over that one clause twice, as a man will stumble over words he privately thinks foolish and would rather not be the one caught reading aloud, and more than one of the kin present said afterward that they had marked the stumble and thought the less of him for it, though none said so to his face while there was grain business still to be settled between them.

The town of Muileann chaol kept that condition, and did rather less well by the rest of her wishes, which had run, in the fuller will her nephew read out and then quietly set aside, to a hope that some clerk might be found each generation to keep the loft in order and add to it what the age still produced. No such clerk was ever paid to do it. The loft stood, its door latched but never locked, and townsfolk who had a paper they no longer wanted burned took to bringing it up the mill stair rather than to the hearth, more from habit than from any oath sworn over Beathag's grave, until the habit itself became the nearest thing the town had to a keeper. A reeve of a later generation, passing through on the crown's business and finding the loft kept by no one office and no one name, asked the miller who had it in charge by then what right the town had to hold papers that plainly belonged, by their matter, to 'Taigh na Fèithe¹ or the crown or

both. The miller, who was Beathag's own great-nephew and had never in his life climbed the stair for any purpose but to fetch down a paper some other traveller had come asking after, said only that the town had held them fifty years without Taigh na Fèithe or the crown ever once asking for them back, and that he took a fifty years' silence, in such a matter, for an answer of a kind.

VII

Of the Roads, the Beasts, and the Empty Harbour Kept Thin

The crown that Beathag never once wrote of, though she must have heard its business talked over at every ford she rode, passed in these same years by a road of its own that the loft's papers do not trouble to follow closely. Tormod mac Ruairidh of Clann Raghnaill was crowned at Cathair dhearg in LE 1,709, nine-and-twenty years old, and held the throne longer than any king before him in Leabhar a' Chùrain¹'s own count, though the record keeps of that long reign chiefly its roads and little else. Within a few years the priests of Manannan at Seann Skell, who had restated their rule of sight-of-land at their last synod, took to saying their own prayer for the shut sea on the very day of Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaidd Fhalaimh², so that the two were kept together on Seann Skell's old quay ever after; and neither the empty-harbour keepers nor Manannan's own priests were pleased to find the other's rite standing on the stones beside theirs, though neither would give an inch of the day to the other either.

Tormod spent the better part of two decades building stone bridges over the fords his own riders had once had to swim their horses through in spate, one of them at Cnoc ìseal, and gave land in amends to the ferry-keepers whose living the bridges took from them, which the ferry-keepers, on the whole, judged fair dealing and said so. One ferryman of that ford, offered his choice of two parcels in amends, is said to have asked the king's own reeve which of the two had the better crossing to it, meaning the crossing of a road and not of water, and been told, with no more of a smile than the question deserved, that a man who had spent thirty years reading a river's moods might do worse than spend his last years read-

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the rite of the empty harbour

ing a market's instead; he took the parcel nearer the market and did well enough by it that his sons never went back to the water at all.

A few years into his bridges the panthers of the southern roads crossed in numbers beyond any herder's memory, and for a whole season the days of the panthers' crossing ran into one another without a clear morning between them, so that flocks from Muileann dhomhain's hills to the coast were kept folded far longer than any shepherd liked and lambled thin that year for it. Old men of that country, telling it after, said they had never known the beasts run so many nor so long, and disagreed among themselves, as old men telling such a thing will, on whether it was the worst crossing within memory or only the worst any of them happened to have lived through, which is not, they allowed on being pressed, quite the same claim.

The salt pans of Caol gharbh failed within the same reign, the sea having risen over them by degrees no one pan-keeper's lifetime was long enough to notice until it was done, and the trade that had once fed the north-east from that coast went south instead, to a town that grew fat on it while Caol gharbh itself grew, as the record's own dry word has it, poorer than the coast it had once undersold ever was. A south-westerly storm, not many years after, put the low town of Baile ghorm under water to more than a man's height and drowned three-and-twenty of its people before the water turned, and the town that survived it raised its own sea-wall the height of a man higher than before, and has not since let the sea in a second time.

It is told, of Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaiddh Fhalaimh in those same years, that fewer families kept it each turn than had kept it the turn before, until at the last only the harbour priests of Cidhe an Diosail³ and a handful of the oldest houses of Seann Skell still stood on the stones for it at all. A scribe out of Cathair dhearg, sent down the coast on some other errand of the crown's and told by his own masters to note the rite while he was there for the crown's own book, stood among that handful one grey Là an Diosail⁴ near the reign's end and asked, first one old woman and then another, on what day, in the true telling, the fleet had gone down the river all those centuries before. Each gave him an answer, and no two of the answers he was given agreed, any more than the three copies that had once lain on Beathag nic Thòmais's loft floor had agreed with one another; and he wrote as much into the crown's own book, in a hand that meant to be believed as much as

3. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

4. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

any of the three had, and could no more say which of his own answers was the true one than Beathag, fifty years dead by then, had ever been able to say of hers.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

Of the Queen's Progress

LE 1,750 – 1,799

I

Of the Sea-Wall of Cuan dhearg

At Cuan dhearg the sea had come twice now over the same low street, and the second time, 23 an Giblean, LE 1,754, it had put the water to the thresholds of An Gàire Dubh¹ and left a rime of salt on the door-boards that no scrubbing got out before the next tide freshened it again. The first flood the town had answered by moving the street back a length of two houses and calling the matter closed; the second it answered otherwise. The harbour was a small one, fifty households at the most generous count, drying nets and curing fish and sending a little salt fish inland by cart, and a town that size does not build in stone for the pleasure of it. But the elders who had watched two floods in one lifetime, when their own fathers had watched none, judged that the sea was not moving the street back a second time, and set the whole harbour, from the oldest hand to the youngest able to carry a basket, to hauling stone up from the point for a wall.

Gormshuil nic Thormoid, then nine-and-thirty years old and no more than her father's daughter in the eyes of most who did not sit at his board, rode down to see it in its second summer of building, for her father the king no longer rode so far and had asked her to carry his eye where his own legs would not take him. The wall rose in courses no higher than a man's shoulder that summer, dressed stone laid dry at the base and mortared above, and the whole harbour worked it in

1. the Black Laugh

shifts between the tides, so that the masons and the net-menders and the children set to carrying water for the mortar all learned, before the season was out, exactly how many hours the ebb gave them and no more. She stood on the half-built wall with the harbour-master, a woman with salt worked so deep into the creases of her hands that no washing showed them clean, and asked her plainly whether the wall would hold the third flood if a third flood came. The harbour-master said that no one living could promise her that, since the sea had never troubled to explain either of the first two floods to anyone. A wall a man could stand behind was worth more than a street he could only run from, she said, and the harbour meant to stand behind this one. She added, when Gormshuil pressed her further, that the town had buried the old boundary stones of the moved street rather than break them up, on the chance that some later hand might want to know how far the water had once come; Gormshuil thought this a harbour-master's own kind of custody-book, kept in stone instead of hide, and said so. The harbour-master allowed that she had never thought of it in those words, but did not deny them either. Gormshuil found she had no better answer to bring her father than the wall's own building, and rode home and gave him the whole of it, word for word, and the king, who by then answered most things that reached him more slowly than the shires liked, laughed once, short and dry, and said that it was the soundest counsel to come up from the coast in a year.

II

Of the House Reopened at Dùn thais

Taigh na Deasbaid at Dùn thais had stood shut behind its own wall for the better part of a generation, since the last argument to be heard in it had turned, as such arguments in that house always turned in the end, toward the question Clàr nam Bliadhnachan¹ had first set and no one since had been let ask again in the open: why the heads of Na Seachd Taighean² lived out their years a little longer than the tenants who worked their coal-right for them. It was reopened, 20 an Giblean, LE 1,759, on the one condition that had closed it, restated and accepted afresh: the question of longer lives would not be raised inside its

1. the table of years

2. the seven houses of custody

walls, this time or any time after. The druids of the schools who had petitioned longest for the doors to be unbarred agreed to the condition without a murmur that reached the crown's own ears, and once inside took up instead the argument of the vein, whether Leabhar a' Chùrain³'s measure of the handful answered rightly to what the coal gave out, a question with edges sharp enough to fill a house of disputation for as long as anyone cared to keep arguing it and answer nothing that touched the older, forbidden one.

Gormshuil, riding to Dùn thais for the reopening at her father's side, asked the eldest of the schools' druids, an old man leaning on a stick cut from the school's own holy wood, whether he thought the coal question would satisfy the house as long as the other one had. He said that a house built to argue will always find something to argue, and that the schools had never once, in all the generations the record kept of them, run short of a subject; it was answers, not subjects, that a house of disputation was built to go without. Gormshuil thought this a strange thing to hear said with such evident contentment, and said so. The old druid told her that a woman who had not yet sat a lifetime in an argument that could not be closed had no cause yet to find it strange, and that she might ask him again when she had.

III

Of the Death of the King

Tormod mac Ruairidh had held An Talla Dearg¹ at Cathair dhearg for more than fifty years by the time his own legs failed him past riding even the short road to Taigh na Fèithe², and in the last of those years he governed from a chair set by the hearth, hearing what the shires sent up and answering it in a voice that had grown no less certain for growing quieter. He died 9 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,766, six-and-eighty years old, the longest-lived king Leabhar a' Chùrain³ had entered since Clàr nam Bliadhnachan⁴ first began to measure such things and find them wanting less than they once had. Gormshuil sat with him

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

4. the table of years

the last night, in a room kept warmer than the rest of the hall by a fire built up past what the season strictly wanted, and he spoke to her in the broken way of a man saving his strength between sentences rather than spending it on any one of them whole. He told her, near the end and with no great weight laid on the words, that he had built bridges over every ford he had ever had reason to be afraid of and had never once, in fifty years, found the courage to ask Taigh na Fèithe's own custodians a question Taigh na Deasbaid⁵ was forbidden to ask on his behalf. She asked him what the question was. He said that she would find it herself soon enough, being his daughter, and that finding it was the easier half of the trouble in any case; the harder half, he said, closing his eyes on it, was living long enough afterward to be satisfied with whatever answer she was given, and that he did not know, of the whole fifty years behind him, a single custodian who had managed that.

She was crowned in An Talla Dearg a fortnight after, one-and-fifty years old herself. The custodians of Na Seachd Taighean⁶ stood for her in the order Clachan a' Chrannchuir⁷ had long since fixed for such standings, and the priest of Macha who made the crowning said the same words over her that had been said over her father and his mother before him, word for word as Leabhar a' Chùraim kept them, so that no one in the hall that day could have named the year the words were first spoken without going to Leabhar a' Chùraim to be sure of it.

IV

Of the Progress and the Book of Grievances

Where her father had governed from a chair by his own hearth, Gormshuil began, the year after her crowning, 12 an Giblean, LE 1,771, to do what no ruler of the island had done since Sileas Òg's own round two centuries and more before her: she rode out from Cathair dhearg to every shire seat in turn, and kept riding it, season on season, until the shires came to expect her the way they expected the winter burning, a thing that returned. At each seat her clerks opened Leabhar nan Gearan¹ and wrote down, in the shire's own

5. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

6. the seven houses of custody

7. the stones of the lot

1. the book of complaints

words as near as a clerk's hand could catch them, whatever grievance the seat's own reeve or a plain householder chose to bring before the queen in person: a boundary stone moved in the night, a firlot short-measured, a bridge toll raised past its charter, a coal-right disputed between two houses of the same blood. Gormshuil heard every one of them out, asked her own questions where a question seemed wanted, and answered none of them in writing before she rode on to the next seat.

A householder of Baile chrom, at one of the earliest seats of that first round, brought before the queen a boundary stone she said her neighbour had shifted a full arm's length into her own barley in the dark of the same Samhnas night three years running, always shifted back before any reeve could be fetched to see it moved. The neighbour, standing his own ground not ten feet off, said the stone had never once moved under his own hand and that a woman who watched her boundary by moonlight three Samhnas nights running had more reason to doubt her own eyes than his honesty. Gormshuil's clerk set both accounts down as each had given them, word for word, and Gormshuil herself measured the disputed ground with her own stride before she rode on, and told the two of them plainly that she came to write the ground down, not to judge it, so that the next time either side troubled to look, the writing would at least know exactly how far an arm's length of barley actually ran.

It became, over the years of her riding, the one thing every shire agreed to say of her, whether they judged it praise or plain complaint: that the queen wrote everything down and settled nothing on the page. A reeve of one of the smaller seats, more plain-spoken than most, asked her outright, the third or fourth year of her round, what the writing was for if no answer ever followed it. Gormshuil told him that a grievance written down in the shire's own words was at least a true grievance, and that an answer written down too quickly, before the queen had ridden the whole round and heard how the same trouble sounded in six other shires' mouths, was more often a false ease than a true one. The reeve said that this might satisfy a queen who meant to ride the round again next year, and asked, not quite as a question, whether she did. Gormshuil said that she did, and rode on, and kept riding it for as long as her own legs would carry her, which turned out to be longer than most at that first seat had wagered.

Fifteen years into the round, in a summer when her company had grown large enough that a single road-house strained to feed it, she came to An Taigh-òsta Grianach² on the eastern road, and its keeper, a woman named Peigi nic Dhonnchaidh, 25 an Màrt, LE 1,786, set pan-fried spinach and black wine before the queen's whole train and fed every rider and every horse-boy besides, though her own charter allowed her stores for nothing near so great a company. Gormshuil, hearing after the meal what it had cost the house to feed her round unwarned, forgave Peigi her road dues for the year that followed, and told her, when Peigi tried to protest that she had asked for no such thing, that a house which fed the crown's whole progress without being asked to had earned more than a year's dues forgiven and would have to be content with what the crown could actually give her. Peigi's black wine was spoken of at every road-house between there and Cathair dhearg for longer than the dues she was spared, though Leabhar a' Chùraim³, being a custody-book, kept the dues and let the wine go untold beyond that.

V

Of the Silver Petition Refused

Clann Choinnich had asked once before, in the reign of a queen long before her, for leave to burn the coal beyond the handful's own measure to feed the silver smelt at Muileann chiar, and had been refused by custodians who judged the vein's own long custom worth more than one house's silver. They asked a second time in Gormshuil's reign, 5 an Gearran, LE 1,776, and this time three of Na Seachd Taighean¹ stood behind them at Taigh na Fèithe² board, more than had ever stood behind the asking before, so that the matter came, for the first time in Leabhar a' Chùraim³'s memory of it, within a single voice of passing.

The voice that held it back was Aonghas mac Lachlainn's, of Clann Lachlainn, who had ridden to Taigh na Fèithe that season, by every account that reached Gormshuil afterward, meaning to vote with the three houses and not

2. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the seven houses of custody

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

against them. He changed his vote at the board itself, between the asking read aloud and the custodians' hands raised to answer it, and gave no reason for the changing beyond the bare word that he had changed his mind. Leabhar a' Chùraim's clerk wrote his name down as the voice that refused the petition, plainly, as the book required; he did not write, because Aonghas would not tell him, what had turned the vote in the short space between the reading and the raising of the hands.

Gormshuil, who sat the board that day as she sat every board Taigh na Fèithe held, asked Aonghas afterward, in a quieter corner of the hall than the board itself, whether he meant to say why he had turned. He told her, with a courtesy that gave nothing away under it, that a man's reason for a single hand raised at a single board was his own to keep, the same as any other man's, and that a queen who pressed every custodian for the private reason behind every private vote would find herself, before long, with a board full of men who voted as she wished rather than as they judged, which he did not think she wanted of him any more than he wanted it of himself. Gormshuil found she could not fault the answer, though it left her no wiser than she had been before the asking, and she let the matter lie, as Leabhar a' Chùraim let it lie, with his name written and his reason not.

VI

Of the Last Count of Hands

Taigh na Fèithe counted, 27 an Gearran, LE 1,791, the households across the whole island that still held the right to the coal, as it had counted them at long intervals since the first count made before the fleet sailed, and it was the last such count the age would keep. The tally came in fewer than any count before it, households having failed into other households or into no households at all across the generations since the last reckoning, and yet larger than any count before it too, for the households that remained held, between them, a greater weight of the coal-right than households of that number had ever held; Leabhar a' Chùraim's own clerk noted, in the dry hand the book had kept since Don-

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

nchadh's day, that three of Na Seachd Taighean² now held more than half the whole right among themselves.

One house of the four smaller ones, hearing its own share of the right read out lower than it had stood at the count before, asked whether a house that held too little coal-right to keep its own hearth measure through a hard winter might be granted its neighbour's unused share rather than buy it, as Leabhar a' Chùraim allowed in years Taigh na Fèithe³ judged hard enough to warrant it. The custodians debated the asking a full afternoon and granted it in the end, though more than one voice at the board noted, in words the clerk set down as spoken and not softened, that a house asking such a grant twice running was a house whose trouble Taigh na Fèithe could ease once but not mend for good.

Gormshuil read the count at Taigh na Fèithe board with the custodians ranged along it as they had been ranged for Athchuingean an Airgid⁴, and asked the clerk who had cast it up whether the coal had grown scarcer to account for so much of it falling into so few hands. The clerk said that the vein gave out what it had always given out, no more scarce and no less, and that it was the households, not the coal, that had grown fewer; three houses holding half the right meant only that the other four had, between them, less than half a right to hold, which was a different kind of scarcity than the coal's own, and one Taigh na Fèithe's count could show her plainly enough without being able to say what ought to be done about it. Gormshuil thanked him for the plainness and let the count stand in the book as it was cast, unaltered and unanswered, the way her own progress left every shire's grievance.

VII

Of the Timber Out of the Mist

In the last years of her reign the fishers of Ceann mhòr, working the empty water off their own headland where Faire a' Chinn¹ had lapsed seventeen centuries before, found a worked timber cast up on the strand, 22 an Cèitean, LE 1,794, longer by half again than any tree that had ever grown on the island and

2. the seven houses of custody

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

4. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

1. the watch of the headland at Ceann mhòr

fastened along its length with nails of a make no smith on Dia-thìr had ever forged or seen forged. The fishers who found it stood over it a long while before any of them would put a hand to it, and it was the eldest among them, a woman who had fished that water sixty years, who said at last that a thing so plainly worked by hands could not have grown in the sea any more than a boat could, and that hands which forged nails unlike any island nail had not, in all likelihood, forged them on the island.

They carried it, by cart and then by boat the last stretch of the way, to Seann Skell and laid it before Manannan's priests on the same quay where Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaìdh Fhalaimh² was kept each year, for if any order on the island could say what a worked thing out of the eastern mist might be, the priests who prayed the sea shut at every tide were judged the likeliest to know. The priests looked at it a long while too, turned it over, ran their hands along the nails, and said among themselves, in words the fishers standing by did not catch all of, that a timber which came from beyond the mist was better answered by fire than by argument. They burned it on the quay before the fishers' own eyes, the flames running strange colours along the metal of the nails before the nails themselves melted and were lost in the ash, and gave the fishers no clearer word than that of what it had been or where, exactly, beyond the mist, it had come from.

VIII

Of the Winter Burning She Did Not Come Down From

Gormshuil went up to Taigh na Fèithe¹ at Muileann dhearg for the winter burning, as she had gone up for every winter burning of her reign since her crowning thirty years before, riding the road herself rather than sending a custodian in her place, for she had told more than one custodian over those thirty years that a queen who never climbed the coal-road herself had no business asking Taigh na Fèithe to answer to her. She was eighty years old that winter, the oldest ruler Leabhar a' Chùraim² had entered crowned and still reigning since long before Clàr nam Bliadhnachan³, and the riders who went up with her noted

2. the rite of the empty harbour

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the table of years

nothing in her that winter that they had not noted in a dozen winters before it: a queen a little slower on the stair than she had been, taking the custodians' hands more readily than she once had to steady her climb, but asking the same plain questions of the same counted galleries she had always asked. The road up was iced that year past what the coal-carts liked, and the riders walked their horses the last steep mile rather than trust them at a trot, Gormshuil walking her own the same as the rest of them though more than one rider offered to lead it for her; she told them, as she had told them most winters, that a queen who let another hand lead her horse up the one road she still rode every year might as well let another hand rule from the chair at the bottom of it too.

She did not come down to Cathair dhearg again. Leabhar a' Chùrain records the winter burning kept, the coal measured, the handful cut as the law required; of the queen who had gone up with the riders and did not ride back down the same road she had climbed, nothing more is told. The custodians of Na Seachd Taighean⁴, meeting at An Talla Dearg⁵ the following year in the place the crown's own chair had always stood empty for her progress and never before for any other cause, sent their word up the coal-road to Taigh na Fèithe by the same riders who had carried the crown's business all Gormshuil's reign, and Taigh na Fèithe sent back no word that unsettled the custodians' sitting, and the custodians sat on.

They wrote their letters that year and the year after in the crown's own hand, sealed with Taigh na Fèithe's own trellis and hollow stone as every crown letter had been sealed since Dòmhnall Ruadh joined the two, and above the seal, where a queen's name had stood on every such letter since Leabhar a' Chùrain's oldest leaves, they set no name at all, neither Gormshuil's own nor any other's, and no clerk of Taigh na Fèithe or An Talla Dearg was ever asked, in writing or otherwise, to explain the blank space where a name should have stood.

I X

Of the Last Lamp at Seann Skell

Oidhche nan Lòchran at Seann Skell had been kept, in Gormshuil's own girlhood, by every house along the waterfront that could spare a rush-

⁴. the seven houses of custody

⁵. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

light and a window to set it in; by the last years of her reign it was kept by fewer houses each year that the harbour scribe troubled to count, until at last, 24 an Dàmhair, LE 1,799, none of the waterfront's own households set a lamp at all. It was an old woman of the town, Ealasaid nic Iain, who had kept the custom in her own family's window since before her husband died and saw no reason the town's own forgetting should end her keeping it, who set the one lamp that burned on the waterfront that year, in the harbour-house window where Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaiddh Fhalaimh¹ was kept each Là an Diosail² on the stones below. The harbour scribe who noted it in Rolla a' Chalaiddh³, the same office that had once counted every lamp along the whole quay, wrote plainly that the lamp burning that year was Ealasaid's own and not the town's, and let the sentence stand without further word, the way the crown's own letters had learned, across these same years, to let a blank space stand where a fuller one no longer had anything true to fill it with.

1. the rite of the empty harbour

2. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

3. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

OF the Eleven and the THINNING MIST

LE 1,800 – 1,819

I

Of the Eleven at Cidhe an Diosail

The book Eòghann mac Nèill kept at Cidhe an Diosail¹ was not Leabhar a' Chùrainn², and no vein-house clerk had ever asked to read it, but it had passed from scribe to scribe at that quay for longer than any man living could reckon without a rod and a rule, and Eòghann, who had held it eleven years by the winter of LE 1,803, had long since stopped wondering whether the hand before his own had felt, on a grey Là an Diosail³, anything like what he felt now, setting the board on his knee and wetting the reed.

The stones of the old quay ran green at the foot, where the river had worked at them since the fleet went down it, and the green did not wash off in any season, wet or dry; Eòghann had asked an old woman once whether it had always been so, and she had said only that the stone remembered the water better than the water remembered the stone. He stood a little back from the rite that year, as the scribe's place required, and counted the people on the quay the way he counted anything that mattered to Taigh na Fèithe⁴'s own reckoning: once by eye, and again by touch, a thumb moved along the tally-notches cut into the board's edge so that

1. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

3. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

the eye could not lie to itself twice running. Both counts came to the same number. Eleven.

It was not so few as it had been the winter before, when a wet Gearras had kept half of Seann Skell indoors and only nine had stood the rite; nor was it so many as the year Eòghann had first held the book, when a full score had come down to the water, most of them the harbour priests of the old order and their households and a handful of the town's oldest families who kept the rite the way a house keeps a debt long unpaid to anyone living, since a debt let lapse has a way of being called in unlooked for. He wrote the number first, as the custom of the book required, and then the weather, a grey morning with no wind off the water and the tide at half ebb, and then, because Manannan's own priest had said the prayer that year at the same stones and at the same hour as the rite, as had become the way of it these ninety years, Eòghann noted that too, in the same hand and the same ink, though the two rites had never once, in his own years at the quay, agreed to be called one thing.

He sat a while after the last of the eleven had gone up from the water, the reed still wet in his hand, and thought, as he had thought more than one year running now, that there was more he might have written and did not: that the old woman who had told him the stone remembered the water was not among the eleven that year, having kept her bed since Samhnas with a cough that would not leave her chest; that the priest's prayer, said each tide now and not only on the rite's own day, had begun to sound in the ears of Seann Skell less like an asking and more like a habit a town keeps going out of fear of what silence might mean if the asking stopped; that no one under thirty years old had stood on the quay stones that morning at all, of the eleven or of anyone else. None of it went into the book. The book was for the number, the weather, and the tide, and had been for as long as it had been kept, and Eòghann mac Nèill, who had never in eleven years added a line the book did not ask of him, was not the man to begin the year the count came to eleven.

Eòghann closed the board and carried it back up the harbour-house stair, past the window where a lamp had stood every dark of the year since before he held the office, and did not need to look at the sill to know the lamp was not lit; it had not been lit in three winters, since the old woman who had kept it, Ealasaid nic Iain, took to her own bed at the far end of the same street and never rose from it again. He had gone to her burying himself, one of a bare dozen who did, and had heard it said over her grave, by a niece who had never once climbed the harbour-

house stair in her own life, that Ealasaid had kept the lamp because the town would not, and that the town, now she was gone, would have to find some new reason to keep it or else own that it had none. No new reason had been found. The window stood dark that winter and every winter after, and Eòghann, passing it each Là an Diosail with the board under his arm, had come to think of the dark glass less as an absence than as a kind of company: the one other thing on that street, besides himself, that had gone on doing its office to the end without once being thanked for it.

He had not always meant to keep the harbour scribe's book so long, nor so close to the letter of it. He had come to the office at nine-and-twenty, a fisherman's son with a fair hand and no kin among the old harbour families, taken on because the man before him had died of a fall on the very stair Eòghann now climbed and left no son of his own trained to the work; and Eòghann, in his first winters at the board, had thought the office a thin thing to give a life to, a count and a weather-note and a tide, set down for no one he could name and read by no one he had ever met. It was only slowly, and never all at once, that he had come to feel what the scribes before him must also have felt, standing where he stood: that a book kept faithfully once no one still troubled to ask what was in it becomes, by the keeping alone, a kind of company of its own, and that a man who breaks that faith to say something truer than the book allows has broken the one thing the office was ever for.

II

Of the Petition Laid Aside

Word reached Seann Skell late, as word from Cathair dhearg mostly did, that Aonghas mac Lachlainn had died in his own bed in the spring after the rite of the eleven, four-and-eighty years old and the last of the council that had sat when Athchuingean an Airgid¹ was refused. He had turned his own vote against the smelt at Muileann chiar by a single voice, eight-and-twenty years before, and Leabhar a' Chùraim² had written down his name and nothing of his reason, and in all the years since, at every fair and every ford where the tale was

1. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

2. the custody-book of the vein-house

told, someone had always claimed to know at last why a man of Clann Lachlainn, whose own kin stood to gain by the silver as much as any house on the coal-right, had turned against his own house's asking. No two of the tellings agreed. A kinsman of his, sitting by him in the last week, is said to have asked him plainly whether he would not, now that it could cost him nothing, say what had turned his hand that day; Aonghas is said to have looked at the kinsman a while, and to have answered that a man who explained a thing he had done for good reason usually did it because the reason had stopped seeming good to him, and that his own had not, and he saw no cause to give it up now for the asking. He died within the week, and whatever he knew of his own vote went into the ground at Cathair dhearg with him.

Aonghas was carried to Cathair dhearg's own burying-ground under the ordinary rite of his house, with no more said over him than was said over any man of four-and-eighty years who had held no crown and started no war, and Leabhar a' Chùraim's clerk who entered his death wrote his name, his age, and the year, and nothing further, having no more to go on than the town did. A rider from Muileann chiar came down for the burying, sent by the silver guild there on the strength of an old courtesy and no closer tie, and stood at the back of the small crowd through the whole of it without once being asked, by anyone present, why a silversmith's rider had troubled to come so far for a man who had cost his own guild a fortune it never got to make. If he had an answer ready, no one at Cathair dhearg thought to want it.

Clann Choinnich, who had brought the petition twice and been refused twice, did not bring it a third time. The house had no want to test a new council on a question the old one had settled by so slight a margin, with the one man who had settled it now beyond any second asking, and Leabhar a' Chùraim's own note on the matter, written some years after by a clerk with no memory of the day, says only that the petition lay unbrought and unanswered, and that Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig³, which had measured the hearth's own handful since Fionnlagh Dall's day, was kept as it had always been kept. No house is known to have grieved the silver it might have made. Muileann chiar's smelters went on working the ore they had always worked, at the heat charcoal gives and no more, and if any among them thought the coal beneath their own hills might have served them better, Leabhar a' Chùraim does not trouble to say so, and neither, in all the years Eòghann kept

3. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

his own book at Seann Skell, did anyone who came through the harbour say it to him either.

Of the queen, in these same years, there was less and less to write, and at last nothing. She had gone up to Taigh na Fèithe⁴ eight winters before the rite of the eleven and had not come down to An Talla Dearg⁵ again, and no rider came from Muileann dhearg to say why, nor any word at all beyond the plain fact of her absence, which the council at Cathair dhearg kept from growing into a question by the simple means of never once asking it aloud in any hall where a clerk might be minded to write the asking down. Eòghann, at his own remove on the coast, heard of it the way he heard of most things from the capital: late, and thin, and by the mouth of a carter who had it from a carter who had it from someone nearer An Talla Dearg than either of them had ever been. He entered none of it in his own book, telling himself it was no business of the harbour scribe's what the council at Cathair dhearg chose to leave unsaid, though he noted, privately and only to himself, that a crown gone quiet in that particular way asked a great deal more of the men who kept the record after it than a crown that had simply died and been buried in the ordinary manner, with a date and a name and an heir to write down after both.

III

Of the Chair Left Empty

Na Seachd Taighean had sat at Cathair dhearg in the queen's place since the winter after she went up to the burning, and it was in the seventeenth winter after her going that they came to the matter of a name; no one of them had called that sitting first, but each had by then sent its own rider up the same road on its own business, and the riders, finding one another at the same door on the same day, had gone in together rather than wait apart for a summons that no one left at Cathair dhearg had the standing to send. An Talla Dearg¹ in those years held perhaps five hundred souls in all its lanes and closes, fewer than a single one of Na Seachd Taighean²' own tenants counted in a good year, and the

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

5. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

1. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

2. the seven houses of custody

board where the seven sat was the same board Catriona Bheag had sworn them to Riaghailt an Teallaich³ over, twelve generations before, its grain gone dark with the hands that had rested on it since.

No new crown was proposed. Clann Raghnaill's own head, an old woman by then and no friend to haste, said first what more than one of the seven had thought and none had yet spoken: that a crown with no one to wear it was no crown at all, whatever Taigh na Fèithe⁴'s rolls might go on calling it, and that Na Seachd Taighean sitting at one board with no voice among them answerable for what the board decided was a slower kind of ruin than any war the record kept. She proposed no new crown. She proposed only that the seven, sitting as they now sat, should call themselves by some plain name for what they in fact were, custodians of the coal-right and, in the queen's long silence, of a good deal more besides, and that one among them should speak for the seven when a single voice was wanted, at Taigh na Fèithe or on the road or before any stranger who came asking who ruled at Cathair dhearg now.

They named themselves, that same sitting, Comhairle a' Chùrain⁵, a name near enough to Leabhar a' Chùrain⁶ that no clerk in any hall would need the thing explained to him twice. For the one voice, they turned to Tormod mac Ailein, eight-and-thirty years old and the youngest man at the board by a full generation, a custodian's son of no house among the seven who had kept Taigh na Fèithe's own accounts at Muileann dhearg since he was a boy and was trusted, by every house there for reasons each gave differently, to want nothing for himself that the other six had not already agreed he might have. They called him Ceann a' Chùrain⁷, and he took the name the way a man takes a coat handed him against weather he had not himself chosen to walk out in, gravely, and without much show of being glad of it.

Clann Choinnich alone, of the seven, asked whether a council so newly named might not also, in the same sitting, be asked again about the silver; the head of that house put the question mildly, and mildly it was set aside, the board's temper being for settling one uncertainty at a time and no more, and the silver, as every house at the board well knew, being the one uncertainty the last council had

3. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

5. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

6. the custody-book of the vein-house

7. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

settled by a single voice now in the ground. Nothing more was said of it that winter, nor at the sitting after.

The chair at the head of the board, the queen's own chair, they left standing empty. No one proposed that Tormod sit in it, and Tormod himself, asked once by a clerk which chair he meant to take at the next sitting, said only that his own place at the board's foot had served him well enough thus far and he saw no cause to move up it now. The chair stood empty at every sitting after, and moving it would have wanted an explaining nobody at the board was minded to give. The council's own letters, from that first winter on, went out from Cathair dhearg sealed with Taigh na Fèithe's own trellis and hollow stone and no name written above the seal, a custom An Talla Dearg's clerks had already begun in the queen's last silent years and saw no reason, now, to give up merely because the silence had at last been given a name of its own.

IV

Of the Fisher of Ceann mhòr

At Ceann mhòr, twenty miles up the coast from Seann Skell where the fishing was thin and the houses fewer with every count the crown's reeves had ever troubled to make, a fisher named Oighrig nic Eachainn kept her father's boat after him, one of perhaps a dozen boats still put out from that shore at all, the rest laid up above the tide-line the way the last barge of Inis mhòr had been laid up long before, less because anyone had decided the sea was done with than because there was no longer hand enough left on that coast to man them. Oighrig went out before first light most mornings the winter after Na Seachd Taighean¹ named themselves at Cathair dhearg, though word of it did not reach her for the better part of a year; a fisher of Ceann mhòr had small cause to trouble herself with what An Talla Dearg² called its own council, so long as the fish still ran and the priests at Seann Skell kept their own rule of sight-of-land, which was the only rule of the crown's that had ever reached so far up the coast in any form a fisher needed to remember.

That rule she had known from a child, the way she had known to reef a sail before her father ever let her hold the tiller: a boat went out as far as the eye could

1. the seven houses of custody

keep the headland, and no further, for beyond the headland lay Manannan's own mist, and no boat that had ever gone into it, in all the tellings the coast still told, had come back to say what lay past it. Mànas mac Dhùghaill, the priest who kept Manannan's rite at Seann Skell those years, had taken, on 27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813, to writing into his own book of the rite a thing the older priests before him had said only at the hearth and never on paper, that the grey out past the headlands stood thinner each year than the year before, so that a morning that would once have shown a fisher nothing beyond an arm's length of grey water now sometimes showed her the grey itself, thin as a held breath, with something beyond it that was not mist at all. He said the prayer at every tide by then, not only at the rite's own day, the same words the synod had given the priests two centuries back, Manannan, keep the sea shut, and he wrote in his own book that he did not know whether the saying of it more often was holding anything back or merely making plainer, each time it was said, how little the saying now held back.

Oighrig rested on her oars one still morning that same winter, further out than the rule strictly allowed but not so far that any priest watching from the shore could have called it a true crossing of the line, and looked north into the grey the way she had looked at it every morning of her life without ever once, before that morning, seeing anything in it but grey. The water lay flat and dark under her hull, and the mist stood off the bow the way it always stood, a wall with no far side that the eye could find. Then, for the space of a few breaths only, before the grey closed again the way it always closed, she saw a line beyond it, hard and dark and level, ruled clean across the edge of the world where the water met the sky and went on past where any headland could account for it. It was there and it was gone, and she could not afterward have sworn, put to it plainly, that she had not simply willed herself into seeing what every fisher on that coast had half hoped and half dreaded to see since the priests began saying the prayer at every tide instead of once a year.

Her father had drowned off that same headland eleven years before, in weather no worse than a dozen he had come through safely in his own life, and Oighrig had grown up hearing the coast agree, without ever quite saying so to her face, that the sea took a man in the end for no better reason than that it had waited long enough; she troubled little enough with the thought on an ordinary morning; that morning, with the hard line still standing before her eyes though the

2. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

mist had long since closed over it again, she found herself wondering, for the first time in eleven years, whether her father had ever, on some grey dawn like this one, rested on his own oars a moment past where the rule allowed and seen the same thing she had seen, and said nothing of it either, for the same plain reasons she meant to say nothing of hers.

She turned for home as the rule said a fisher must, and did not speak of it at the shore, not that morning nor for some while after, telling herself there was little enough good that came of a fisher's tale believed too readily and a good deal of harm that came of one believed and then found false. When she did speak of it, months on, it was to no priest and no reeve but to her own mother, mending a net by the one lamp their house still burned after dark, and her mother heard her out and said only that a woman who had seen a true thing and kept it to herself a season had already shown better sense over it than most who saw such things at all, and that she might do worse than go on keeping it a while longer yet. Oighrig did. It went into no book at Seann Skell and no roll at Cathair dhearg, and the only record that she ever spoke of it stands in her own mother's memory and, after that, in no record at all.

V

Of the Last Winter

By the fifteenth winter after the rite of the eleven, the harbour-house at Seann Skell had stood so long with its lamp-window dark that a stranger asking after the custom of Oidhche nan Lòchran¹ would have found no one on the waterfront under sixty years old able to say from their own memory what the night had once looked like, lit. Eòghann mac Nèill, who had kept the harbour scribe's book at Cidhe an Diosail² for six-and-twenty years by then, still walked down to the stones each Là an Diosail³ with the same board under his arm, and still counted, and still wrote the number and the weather and the tide in the same plain hand the book had always asked of him, though the number by then had not risen above a dozen in longer than he cared to reckon, and one bitter year had come down, by his own careful count, to seven.

1. the night of lamps at Seann Skell

2. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

3. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

That last winter the record tells of, the count is not written, for the book, if Eòghann kept it to the end, does not survive to say what he wrote in it; what is told of that season comes from elsewhere; from Mànas mac Dhùghaill's own book of the rite at Seann Skell, which does survive, and which sets down, in a hand grown old and careful by then, that the priests said the prayer at every tide that winter as they had said it every winter for thirty years, and that on more than one still morning the line beyond the mist stood plain enough from the harbour wall that a man need not put out in any boat at all to see it. And from Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴, which notes, in the same dry hand that had entered every winter burning since Fionnlagh Dall's day, that the council of the custody sat at its board in An Talla Dearg⁵ through the dark of that year as it had sat through every year since the seven had named it, and sent its letters out sealed as it had always sent them, with no name above the seal, and no word in any of them of the chair that stood empty at the board's head, which by then no clerk living had ever seen any-one sit in at all.

On a still morning near the year's dark heart, with no wind on the water and the tide at the ebb it kept at that season, the priests of Manannan said their prayer at Seann Skell as the sun came up grey behind the mist, and further up the coast at Ceann mhòr the few boats still fishing that shore put out before light as they always had, and one or two of the older hands among them, resting a while on their oars past where the rule strictly allowed, looked north a moment longer than the rule strictly asked of them either, before they turned, every one, for home. At Cathair dhearg the council sat at its board in An Talla Dearg with the chair at its head standing empty as it had stood three-and-twenty years, and wrote its letters, and sealed them, and sent them out by riders down roads Taigh na Fèithe⁶ had kept in good repair since before any house now sitting at that board had held the custody at all. And on the waterfront at Seann Skell, where a lamp had once stood in every window on Oidhche nan Lòchran, the one window that had kept a lamp longest of all stood dark, as it had stood every winter since the woman who kept it went into the ground, and no one that year, nor any year after within this record's telling, set a light there in her place.

The mist stood on the water as it had stood since the fleet went down the river into it eighteen centuries before, and it stood, that winter, thinner than any priest

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

5. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

at Seann Skell could remember it standing, and no boat put out to try it. The prayer was said at every tide. The council kept its board. Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁷ measured the hearth's own handful, hearth by hearth, as it had measured it since Fionnlagh Dall first laid down the rule, and three houses of the seven held between them more of the right than the other four together, and the petition that might once have changed it lay where it had lain twelve years, unbrought and unanswered, in Taigh na Fèithe's own inventory. Of the crown, nothing further was written. The lamp-window stood dark on the waterfront through that winter and the winters after it, and the mist, each morning the tide allowed a boat to look, lay a little thinner on the water than the morning before.

7. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

PART TWO

The Annals of the Age

THE YEARS LE 1 – 100

- 6 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1** — *Land is found*. Word comes of a land across the open water, where no people like the Dia-thìrich dwell. Who first found it is not told.
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1** — *The tidings at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Three crews from the western harbours bring word of the far land to the hall of Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill, daughter of Mòr nic Coinnich, at Cathair dhearg. None claims to have been first. The queen's scribe takes down all three tellings; they agree on the coast and on nothing else.
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The Choosing*. A vote, or what the later chroniclers call a vote, settles who will go. Only the willing go; no lots are drawn and none are pressed.
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The tale on the quays of Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). In the moon of Faolach the word of a far coast is on the quay at Cuan shean, told in the lee of the rope-sheds and at the crews' fire. No one says he saw the coast, and every telling leads back to another. By the moon's end it is told at Ros bheag, Inis àrsaidh and Ceann mhòr.¹
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The pilot of Ros bheag* (Ros bheag). A pilot of Ros bheag, blown off the land in the autumn gales, comes home after nine days with his water gone. The coast shows up in the talk as his, but he swears he saw nothing but grey water, too loudly.²
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The Cuan shean crew heard in An Talla Dearg*³ (Cathair dhearg). Eachann mac Lachlainn, skipper of Cuan shean, tells the queen of a low dark coast west and north of west, with smoke on it and no hall. Asked if he was first to hear it, he says he was about the last.⁴
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The Ros bheag crew heard in An Talla Dearg*⁵ (Cathair dhearg). Oighrig nic Raghnaill, skipper of Ros bheag, tells the queen that the coast lies north past the north cape, high and forested, with a white river, and that the pilot who saw it swore on the cup at Seann Skell.⁶
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The Ceann mhòr crew heard in An Talla Dearg*⁷ (Cathair dhearg). Tòmas mac Uilleim of Ceann mhòr tells the queen that the land lies east behind the mist, and can be smelt on some mornings; the old men of the north-west have always said so.⁸

1. ← Follows from *Land is found*, 6 am Faoilleach, LE 1.

2. ⇔ At the same time *Land is found*, 6 am Faoilleach, LE 1.

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

4. ⇔ At the same time *The tidings at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1.

5. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

6. ⇔ At the same time *The tidings at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1.

7. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *Murchadh's leaf of the three tellings* (Cathair dhearg). The queen's scribe Murchadh mac Eòghainn writes the three tellings on one leaf and adds at its foot that they agree on the coast and on nothing else. The leaf is kept in the chest of An Talla Dearg^{9, 10}
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *How many days' water* (Cathair dhearg). At the lower board of An Talla Dearg¹¹ the queen's sister Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill asks the Cuan shean skipper how many days' water a boat would need. He answers that no boat of the island could make the crossing, and that none has ever been built that could.¹²
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The question at the hearths*. Through the moon of Dubhlas the question 'Would we go?' is asked at hearths from Baile chrom to Seann Vell, most of all on the west coast. No lots are drawn and no lord or priest gives a word.¹³
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *Two households of Inis àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh). In the drying-shed at Inis àrsaidh two households say before the whole town that they will go if a boat is ever made that can make the crossing. The town laughs, then stops laughing.¹⁴
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *A custodian asks for the three tellings* (Cathair dhearg). Fearchar mac Ruairidh, a young custodian of the western diggings, comes down to Cathair dhearg on an errand of Taigh na Fèithe¹⁵ and asks to hear the three tellings from the queen's scribe.¹⁶
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *Mòrag at Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill rides alone to Cuan shean and questions Eachann mac Lachlainn on seams, winds and wood. He tells her a hull that needs no sewing would want great oak and a keel, and that no one alive knows how to set one.¹⁷
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The queen keeps the journey from the roll* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag watches her sister walk the Cuan shean skipper to the gate of An Talla Dearg¹⁸ and look down the river road west. She bids Murchadh write nothing of it, since it is no matter for the roll yet.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The ninth year of Queen Beathag* (Cathair dhearg). An Talla Dearg¹⁹'s rolls enter the first year of the age as the ninth year of Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill, crowned at fifteen and now three-and-twenty: a good year for barley and a middling one for fish, with no child yet born to her.²⁰

8. ⇌ At the same time *The tidings at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1.

9. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

10. ← Follows from *The tidings at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1.

11. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

12. ← Follows from *The tidings at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1.

13. ⇌ At the same time *The Choosing*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1.

14. ← Follows from *The Choosing*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1.

15. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

16. ⇌ At the same time *The Choosing*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1.

17. ← Follows from *The Choosing*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1.

18. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

19. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill at nineteen* (Cathair dhearg). The queen's sister Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, nineteen years old and two years married to a man of the western shore she chose herself, comes up to the capital for the winter and sits at the lower board when the crews are heard.²¹
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 2** — *The roll of the willing* (Seann Skell). The harbour scribes of Seann Skell open a roll of those who mean to go, written by household and not by name, on boards in the harbour-house. A later hand notes that names were struck out as often as they were added.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 2** — *The queen neither commands nor forbids* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag declares that the crown will send no one across the water and keep no one back. Within the season her younger sister, Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, enters her own household on the roll at Seann Skell.²²
- 15 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 2** — *The first household asks to be written* (Seann Skell). In the moon of Pailteach a fisher of Inis àrsaidh and his wife come into Taigh a' Chalaigh²³ and ask to be written down as meaning to go. The harbour scribe Calum mac Nèill planes a new board and heads it: Those who mean to go.²⁴
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 2** — *The rule of the whole household* (Seann Skell). Calum mac Nèill will write a household whole or not at all, since Taigh na Fèithe²⁵ measures the handful to the hearth and not to a single man or woman. The roll is kept by household from its first board.²⁶
- 23 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 2** — *The first striking-out* (Seann Skell). Iain, a net-maker of Seann Skell, strikes his household from the roll before the moon is out, having woken at night unable to breathe for thought of the open sea. He enters again in spring and strikes out again by midsummer.²⁷
- 24 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 2** — *A struck name is cut through* (Seann Skell). Asked to scrape a struck name from the board, the harbour scribe refuses and cuts it through with one stroke, so that the roll shows both the meaning to go and the change of mind. The custom holds for every board of the roll.²⁸
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 2** — *The widow of the strand* (Seann Skell). A boat-wright's widow of the Seann Skell strand is entered alone and struck three times over the first year, her name standing on the board three times like a ladder. She does not come back.²⁹

20. ← Follows from *The tidings at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1.

21. ← Follows from *The tidings at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 1.

22. → Caused by *The queen keeps the journey from the roll*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1.

23. the harbour-house

24. ⇌ At the same time *The roll of the willing*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2.

25. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

26. ← Follows from *The roll of the willing*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2.

27. ← Follows from *The roll of the willing*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2.

28. ← Follows from *The roll of the willing*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2.

29. ⇌ At the same time *The roll of the willing*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2.

- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 2** — *The late lamp in the harbour-house* (Seann Skell). For those who cannot say it by day, Calum mac Nèill keeps a lamp burning in the harbour-house late into the night and pays for the oil himself. The harbour-house becomes a place between a court and a shrine.³⁰
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 2** — *Taigh na Fèithe*³¹ *sends to read the roll* (Seann Skell). A custodian's servant comes by night to read Rolla nan Deònach³² and ask how many households on it hold the right to the coal. From then on the harbour scribe marks each hearth that takes the handful with a notch like a flame.
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 2** — *Dòmhnall mac Chaluim asks that the boards be closed* (Seann Skell). The harbour scribe's son and clerk asks his father to close the roll and send the people to the queen. Calum will not close what the queen has not closed.³³
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 2** — *Alasdair mac Iain reads the roll* (Seann Skell). A boat-wright of the strand, Alasdair mac Iain, reads every board of the roll and says there is not a boat on the island that could carry the half of them, and that somebody had better build one.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 2** — *Seonag asks the harbour scribe whether he would go* (Seann Skell). Lying in the box-bed with the wind over the roof, Calum mac Nèill's wife Seonag, who keeps geese and sells their eggs on the quay, asks him whether he would go. He answers that the boards need a keeper.³⁴
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 2** — *The sisters in the bower* (Cathair dhearg). Mòrag nic Dhòmhnai rides to Cathair dhearg and asks her sister to command or forbid the crossing. The queen answers that the crown has never sent anyone anywhere, nor kept back anyone free, and will not begin with her sister.³⁵
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 2** — *The queen's word sent to the harbours* (Cathair dhearg). The queen's word, written by Murchadh mac Eòghainn and sealed, goes by rider to Seann Skell and every harbour of the west and to Taigh na Fèithe³⁶: the crown will send no one and keep no one back, and will judge any quarrel of the venture by the old law.³⁷
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 2** — *The word read at the harbour-house door* (Seann Skell). Calum mac Nèill reads the queen's word twice from the harbour-house door to the town standing in the rain. Few cheer; most had wanted the crown to choose for them.³⁸
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 2** — *The queen's word made a song* (Seann Skell). On the quay at Seann Skell the fishers say the queen's word over until it becomes a line of song: I will send no one over, and I will keep no one back. The harbour songs keep it so.³⁹

30. ← Follows from *The roll of the willing*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2.

31. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

32. the roll of the willing

33. → Leads to *The queen neither commands nor forbids*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 2.

34. ← Follows from *The roll of the willing*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 2.

35. → Leads to *The queen neither commands nor forbids*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 2.

36. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

37. ⇌ At the same time *The queen neither commands nor forbids*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 2.

38. ← Follows from *The queen neither commands nor forbids*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 2.

- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 2** — *Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh says yes* (Inis àrsaidh). At Inis àrsaidh Mòrag's husband, Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh, a farmer of the land up the river, agrees that their household will go before she has finished asking.⁴⁰
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 3** — *The custodians dispute the right of those who go* (Muileann dhearg). Through the winter the custodians at Taigh na Fèithe⁴¹ argue whether the right to the coal goes with a hearth that crosses the sea or is struck on the day it sails. Fearchar mac Ruairidh holds that the right lives in the hands.
- 13 AM MÀRT, LE 3** — *The roll copied for Taigh na Fèithe*⁴² (Seann Skell). The harbour scribe's son copies Rolla nan Deònach⁴³ onto skin, with a flame-mark beside each household that holds the right to the coal, and sends it up the coal-road to Taigh na Fèithe.
- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 3** — *Fearchar mac Ruairidh's household on the roll* (Muileann dhearg). Fearchar mac Ruairidh tells the custodians, after the second count, that he entered his own household on the roll at Seann Skell in the moon of Samhnas and ticked his own name twice.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 3** — *Nine days at the long table* (Muileann dhearg). In the moon of Lùghnas the custodians of Taigh na Fèithe⁴⁴ sit at the long table with the copied roll on one side and Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴⁵ on the other, and count hearth by hearth, name against name, for nine days.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 3** — *The custodians count the cost* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house above Muileann dhearg, keeper of Crom's stone and heir to the Keepers' Hall at Dùn iséal where Bride's flame was first bound, counts the households of the coal-right that have entered the roll. The custody-book makes it nearly one in five, and says the count was made twice, for the first figure was not believed.⁴⁶
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 4** — *Alasdair's small hulls* (Seann Skell). On the strand below Seann Skell the boat-wright Alasdair mac Iain builds hulls no longer than his arm on spines of oak and floats them in the river pool and the river mouth, to learn what a keel does. He finds that a keel makes a hull stiff and lets it be built bigger.
- 3 AN GEARRAN, LE 4** — *Mòrag undertakes to pay for the oaks* (Inis àrsaidh). At Inis àrsaidh Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill and Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh hear Alasdair out and send him to look at the grove of Doire fhionn. Mòrag undertakes to pay for the felling and hauling out of her own silver.

39. ¶ Legacy *The queen neither commands nor forbids*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 2.

40. ← Follows from *The queen neither commands nor forbids*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 2.

41. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

42. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

43. the roll of the willing

44. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

45. the custody-book of the vein-house

46. → Caused by *Taigh na Fèithe sends to read the roll*, 16 an t-Samhain, LE 2; → Caused by *The roll copied for Taigh na Fèithe*, 13 am Màrt, LE 3; ← Leads to *Fearchar mac Ruairidh's household on the roll*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, LE 3; ← Leads to *Nine days at the long table*, 28 an t-Iuchar, LE 3.

- 16 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 5** — *The ships are built.* The shipwrights of the island, used to small coasting craft, build ships to keep the open sea, the first in the memory of Dia-thir.⁴⁷
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 5** — *Alasdair Saor lays the first keel* (Seann Skell). On the river strand below Seann Skell the shipwright Alasdair mac Iain, called Alasdair Saor, lays down the first deep-keeled hull built on Dia-thìr. Until then the island's boats were sewn-plank coasters that never lay a night out of sight of land.⁴⁸
- 26 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 5** — *The oaks of Doire fhionn* (Doire fhionn). The oak grove that named Doire fhionn is felled for the keels of the fleet and drawn to the coast on ox-sleds. It never grew again, and the village kept a name it had no more cause for.⁴⁹
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 5** — *The shipwrights' fellowship* (Seann Skell). Alasdair Saor gathers the wrights of the Seann Skell strand into one fellowship, and binds each apprentice for seven years after the manner of the vein custodians. The custody-book names it Comann nan Saor-luinge⁵⁰, the fellowship of the ship-wrights.
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 5** — *The naming of the trees* (Doire fhionn). Eilidh nic Ruairidh, keeper of the grove of Doire fhionn, makes Alasdair choose each oak he will take and hear its name. He chooses fifty-four and leaves one young tree, the Child, standing alone.⁵¹
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 5** — *The felling of the Queen* (Doire fhionn). Eighty men of the households of the roll fell the grove of Doire fhionn through the summer, each tree onto a bed of brush. The greatest, called the Queen, takes two days to bring down.⁵²
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 5** — *The ox-sleds on the north road* (Doire fhionn). The keel-timbers are dragged forty-two miles south to the sea on sleds of oak shod with ash, six yoke to a sled. The road is widened at every bend and a causeway built over the stream below Doire fhionn.⁵³
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 5** — *Woodcutters' huts at Doire fhiadhaich* (Doire fhiadhaich). Woodcutters of the roll build huts at the edge of a wild oak wood on the shore of Loch chrom to fell crooked oak for the fleet's frames and knees. They go home when the felling is done and the huts fall in; the wood keeps its name.⁵⁴
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 5** — *The bed of the first keel* (Seann Skell). Alasdair levels a line of oak blocks on the strand above the high-water mark and digs a saw-pit beside it. The Queen oak is rolled onto the blocks and hewn to a keel with a ridge along its underside.⁵⁵

47. → Caused by *Alasdair's small bulls*, 5 an Faoilleach, LE 4.

48. → Caused by *Alasdair mac Iain reads the roll*, 24 an t-Samhain, LE 2.

49. → Caused by *Mòrag undertakes to pay for the oaks*, 3 an Gearran, LE 4.

50. the shipwrights' fellowship

51. ⇌ At the same time *The oaks of Doire fhionn*, 26 an Lùnastal, LE 5.

52. ⇌ At the same time *The oaks of Doire fhionn*, 26 an Lùnastal, LE 5.

53. ← Follows from *The oaks of Doire fhionn*, 26 an Lùnastal, LE 5.

54. ← Follows from *The ships are built*, 16 an t-Iuchar, LE 5.

- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 5** — *Coinneach mac Fhearghais sworn* (Seann Skell). At the feast of Lugh the wrights of the strand bind themselves into one fellowship. A custodian of Taigh na Fèithe⁵⁶ swears their apprentices over a coal, and the first sworn is Coinneach mac Fhearghais, a coaster-wright's son of fourteen.⁵⁷
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 5** — *The first frames stand on the strand* (Seann Skell). By the moon of Pailteach the first frames rise from the keel in pairs, pegged with heart-oak. The harbour scribe writes that the hull looks like the ribs of a great beast picked clean on the shore.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 5** — *The Child walled* (Doire fhionn). The village of Doire fhionn builds a low wall of stones round the one young oak left on the grove hill, and its old keeper sits beside it every evening until dark.⁵⁸
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 5** — *Alasdair walks north with a knotted line* (Seann Skell). In the moon of Gearras, after Là Fhèill Bhrìde, Alasdair mac Iain sets out alone on the north road with a pack, a staff and a line knotted every arm's length for measuring, making fifteen miles the first day and sleeping in a byre.⁵⁹
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 6** — *The trial hull lost off Ros àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh). The first finished hull is taken down the Abhainn naomh and out past Ros àrsaidh, where the ships of Inis àrsaidh put to sea, for trial in open water. It founders in a following sea and eleven are drowned. Alasdair Saor alters the setting of the keel, and every later hull of the fleet is built to the new pattern.⁶⁰
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 6** — *An Fhaoileag⁶¹ launched* (Seann Skell). The first deep-keeled hull, planked and rigged, is floated off the blocks below Seann Skell with a coal from Taigh na Fèithe⁶² set at her step. The town calls her An Fhaoileag, the gull, for the way she rides the water.⁶³
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 6** — *The nine named at Inis àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh). The roll-keeper of Inis àrsaidh cuts eleven names into the village's board on the night of the drowning, the village sitting up with her as the custom asks. Alasdair's sister's son Tormod Beag is among the eight bodies brought back; three more are never found.⁶⁴
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 6** — *The keening at Inis àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh). The eight recovered dead are keened on the shingle under sailcloth and a lamp at each head; for the three never found a single lamp is lit and burns down unwatched. Alasdair stays three days doing whatever the village asks of him.⁶⁵

55. ⇄ At the same time *Alasdair Saor lays the first keel*, 14 an Lùnastal, LE 5.

56. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

57. ⇄ At the same time *The shipwrights' fellowship*, 24 an t-Sultain, LE 5.

58. ← Follows from *The oaks of Doire fhionn*, 26 an Lùnastal, LE 5.

59. → Leads to *The oaks of Doire fhionn*, 26 an Lùnastal, LE 5.

60. → Caused by *The first frames stand on the strand*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, LE 5.

61. the Gull, the first finished hull, lost off Ros àrsaidh

62. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

63. → Leads to *The trial hull lost off Ros àrsaidh*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 6.

64. ⇄ At the same time *The trial hull lost off Ros àrsaidh*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 6.

- 27 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 6** — *Households struck and households entered* (Seann Skell). Eleven households strike themselves from the Seann Skell roll after word of the drowning, and eleven others enter in the same weeks, among them kin of a survivor and a widow of Ros bheag who gives her daughters' names. Calum mac Nèill records both counts without comment.⁶⁶
- 27 **AN T-SULTAIN, LE 7** — *The second keel laid to the changed pattern* (Seann Skell). Alasdair Saor lays a second keel on the strand below Seann Skell, built to the fuller, hollow-bowed run he redrew by a driftwood fire after the drowning. Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill sends silver again to see her built.⁶⁷
- 11 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 8** — *The rope-walks of Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Cuan shean lays out long rope-walks along its harbour front and gives all its hemp fields to cordage for the fleet. Its rope trade lasts some centuries beyond the Sundering.
- 9 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 8** — *The rope-walks learn the names of a keel* (Cuan shean). After shroud-lines sent west from Cuan shean fail within a season, the wrights walk the rope-walks and name the parts of a hull to the spinners and walkers. Iain Ròpaire, master of the walks, takes to walking one himself to learn the words in his own hands.⁶⁸
- 18 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 8** — *Birth of Raghnall mac Uilleim* (Cathair dhearg). A son, Raghnall, is born at Cathair dhearg to Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill and her consort Uilleam mac Iain, in the queen's sixteenth year crowned and her own thirtieth year of life.
- 9 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 9** — *The sail-cloth levy* (Baile àrsaidh). Every weaving household in Siorrachd Baile àrsaidh owes a set length of close-woven sail-cloth, scored on tally-sticks at the shire seat. The tallies survive; how many paid is not known.
- 28 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 9** — *The sail-cloth tallies at Baile àrsaidh* (Baile àrsaidh). The shire seat's tally-keeper cuts notches for close-woven lengths from households across Siorrachd Baile àrsaidh, far more than expected, some sent by weavers with no kin on the roll and no thought of sailing. The sticks fill a chest that wants a second lid.⁶⁹
- 26 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 9** — *An Dara Fhaoileag⁷⁰ planked* (Seann Skell). An Dara Fhaoileag stands planked from keel to sheer and steps her mast on the strand below Seann Skell. The wrights name her An Dara Fhaoileag, the second gull, and the doubt among the older wrights over her fuller, hollow-bowed lines goes quiet.⁷¹

65. ← Follows from *The trial bull lost off Ros àrsaidh*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 6.

66. ← Follows from *The trial bull lost off Ros àrsaidh*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 6.

67. ← Follows from *The trial bull lost off Ros àrsaidh*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 6.

68. ← Follows from *The rope-walks of Cuan shean*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 8.

69. ← Follows from *The sail-cloth levy*, 9 an t-Samhain, LE 9.

70. the second gull, the hull built to the changed keel pattern after the loss of An Fhaoileag

71. ← Follows from *The trial bull lost off Ros àrsaidh*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 6.

- 19 AN GEARRAN, LE 11** — *Six pilots sent east to Cuan ruadh* (Ros bheag). Fearchar mac Ruairidh finds that no pilot of the west coast has ever held a course by night, and six are chosen to walk the hundred miles to the old steersmen of Cuan ruadh: two of Ceann mhòr, two of Ros bheag, one of Cuan shean, and Catrìona nic Iain, who asks to be sent before she is asked.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 12** — *The six pilots reach Cuan ruadh* (Cuan ruadh). After seven days on foot over the mountain country the six pilots come down to Cuan ruadh on the eastern coast and are given lodging without question. They are sent, the next morning, to the steersman Seumas Reultach.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 12** — *Seumas Reultach begins the teaching* (Cuan ruadh). On the headland above Cuan ruadh the old steersman Seumas Reultach begins teaching the six pilots the wheel of the sky and Reul na Stiùire⁷², by which it is held. Most of what he gives them is spoken, night after night, and set down nowhere.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 13** — *The star-lore of Cuan ruadh* (Cuan ruadh). The old steersmen of Cuan ruadh on the eastern coast, the only sailors of the island who had ever held a course by night, teach the pilots of the fleet to steer by the stars. Their lore was written down only in part, and that part is lost.⁷³
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 13** — *Part of the star-lore set on hide* (Cuan ruadh). At Taigh na Fèithe⁷⁴'s asking, Seumas Reultach has his granddaughter cut onto a scraped hide the wheel of the sky, Reul na Stiùire⁷⁵ and the four turning marks of the year. He keeps back the swell-reading and the wind-smell, saying some things a hide can hold and some things only a life can.⁷⁶
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 14** — *Death of Seumas Reultach* (Cuan ruadh). In the moon of Faolach the old steersman of Cuan ruadh dies on the cliff path above the town where he taught the six pilots the stars, and is buried there among his own people. His granddaughter gives the hide of star-marks into Catrìona nic Iain's keeping to carry west.⁷⁷
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 14** — *The pilots return west* (Cuan ruadh). The six pilots cross the mountain country again to the west coast, carrying the hide of star-marks and what they have learned of the wheel of the sky, Reul na Stiùire⁷⁸ and the smell of the dark before a change of wind.⁷⁹

72. the steering star

73. → Caused by *Six pilots sent east to Cuan ruadh*, 19 an Gearran, LE 11; ← Leads to *The six pilots reach Cuan ruadh*, 24 an t-Samhain, LE 12; ← Leads to *Seumas Reultach begins the teaching*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, LE 12.

74. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

75. the steering star

76. ← Follows from *The star-lore of Cuan ruadh*, 20 an Giblean, LE 13.

77. ← Follows from *The star-lore of Cuan ruadh*, 20 an Giblean, LE 13.

78. the steering star

79. ← Follows from *The star-lore of Cuan ruadh*, 20 an Giblean, LE 13.

- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 14** — *The first night-steering trial off Ros àrsaidh* (Ros àrsaidh). Off Ros àrsaidh two boats go out after dark, one steered close along the shore by lantern, the other by Catriona nic Iain alone by Reul na Stiùire⁸⁰ with every lantern doused. She brings her boat home first, exactly where and when she had said she would.⁸¹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 18** — *Catriona nic Iain made pilot of An Ròn Glas*⁸² (Seann Skell). Catriona nic Iain reaches Seann Skell after the households of the roll have chosen Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill and Fearchar mac Ruairidh to lead them. On the west quay Mòrag asks her to be pilot of her hull, An Ròn Glas, and Catriona names her Reul na Stiùire⁸³.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, LE 18** — *The willing choose their leaders* (Seann Skell). The households of the roll meet at Seann Skell and choose Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, the queen's sister, and Fearchar mac Ruairidh, a custodian of the vein, to lead them. The custody-book records the choice; how it was made is not told.⁸⁴
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 19** — *Fearchar's petition for the coal* (Muileann dhearg). Fearchar mac Ruairidh comes to Taigh na Fèithe⁸⁵ and asks that each hull found fit to sail be allowed to carry one sealed measure of the coal, no more than a single household's season under Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁸⁶. The custodians send him down the hill with a promise only to put the matter to the board.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 23** — *Donnchadh mac Thormoid given to Taigh na Fèithe*⁸⁷ (Muileann dhearg). Tormod, a turf-cutter of the moor above Muileann dhearg, walks his son Donnchadh, nine years old, up the coal-road to Taigh na Fèithe and leaves him there sworn to the vein's service for seven years, and does not look back.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 25** — *The handful for the new hearth* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house rules that each departing ship may carry one sealed measure of the coal, no more than a single household may burn in a season under the Small-Burning Law. It is the only writing in the custody-book addressed to those who were leaving.⁸⁸

80. the steering star

81. ← Follows from *The star-lore of Cuan ruadh*, 20 an Giblean, LE 13.

82. the Grey Seal, the hull that carried Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill's household

83. the steering star

84. → Caused by *Fearchar mac Ruairidh's household on the roll*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, LE 3; ⇌ At the same time *Catriona nic Iain made pilot of An Ròn Glas*, 19 an Giblean, LE 18.

85. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

86. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

87. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

88. → Caused by *The custodians dispute the right of those who go*, 28 an Faoilleach, LE 3; → Caused by *Fearchar's petition for the coal*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, LE 19; → Caused by *Donnchadh mac Thormoid given to Taigh na Fèithe*, 27 an t-Iuchar, LE 23.

- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 25** — *The custodians' debate at the winter burning* (Muileann dhearg). After six winters of argument Taigh na Fèithe⁸⁹'s board finally votes on Fearchar's petition. Cailean and others hold that the coal has never crossed water and should not; Fearchar answers that Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁹⁰ measures a hearth wherever a hearth chooses to stand. Leabhar a' Chùrain⁹¹ is opened and the question is put to writing.⁹²
- 3 AN GEARRAN, LE 26** — *The sealed measures made* (Muileann dhearg). The first measures of coal are weighed and sealed at Taigh na Fèithe⁹³, each against the words "for each hull that shall be ready", with no count kept against any known number of hulls. Fearchar mac Ruairidh stands by in silence to see the first one made.⁹⁴
- 4 AM MÀRT, LE 28** — *The queen lends masons for the quay* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill sends a gang of masons from the capital, under Ailean mac Nèill, down to Seann Skell to lengthen the west quay with dressed stone "for the harbour's trade", the crown's word for it and no other named.
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 29** — *The fair copy of the ruling, Donnchadh's first entry* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid, the boy-clerk, is set at fifteen to render the ruling clean for Leabhar a' Chùrain⁹⁵, after it has lain four years in rough marks: one sealed measure a ship, a single household's season, Taigh na Fèithe⁹⁶'s own mark. He copies it exactly as given, though he notices it carries no blessing, as other entries do.⁹⁷
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, LE 29** — *The queen at Seann Skell to see the stones laid* (Seann Skell). Beathag rides the twenty-four miles to Seann Skell and stands on the new-laid stone of the west quay in the evening light, the only time she is known to have come to see the fleet's building with her own eyes. Her sister Mòrag joins her there, and the two speak of small things, not of the roll.
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, LE 29** — *Death of Uilleam mac Iain, the queen's consort* (Cathair dhearg). Uilleam mac Iain, husband to Queen Beathag and father of her son, dies after a summer's illness. The queen keeps the funeral small, a single day at Cathair dhearg with the household and a few custodian heads, and no great muster of the shires.
- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 30** — *The west quay lengthened* (Seann Skell). Masons from the capital lengthen the west quay at Seann Skell with dressed stone, so that the deep hulls may lie alongside at low water. On these stones the later rite was held.⁹⁸

89. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

90. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

91. the custody-book of the vein-house

92. ← Follows from *The handful for the new hearth*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 25.

93. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

94. ← Follows from *The handful for the new hearth*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 25.

95. the custody-book of the vein-house

96. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

97. ← Follows from *The handful for the new hearth*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 25.

98. → Caused by *The queen lends masons for the quay*, 4 am Màrt, LE 28; ← Leads to *The queen at Seann Skell to see the stones laid*, 2 an Giblean, LE 29.

- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 30** — *Death of Eòghann mac Mhuirich* (Muileann dhearg). The master of Taigh na Fèithe⁹⁹, who wrote the first count of the departing households in LE 3, dies at Taigh na Fèithe grown very old, soon after seeing the ruling of the coal for the departing set down and its first measures sealed.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 30** — *The iron cramp of the last stone* (Seann Skell). Ailean mac Nèill's gang sets the last stone of the lengthened quay at the seaward end, where the new masonry meets the old timber staging, and Ailean drives home the iron cramp that binds them with three blows and no more.¹⁰⁰
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 37** — *Tormod mac Coinnich remembers the dearth of his boyhood* (Àth shean). As the council weighs how much grain the fleet may take, the reeve of the granaries at Àth shean turns over an old memory: a reeve before him who smiled and gave no grain, and a store-house that stood swept and empty a whole hungry spring. He resolves that his own stores will not be opened on a smile.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 37** — *A lean harvest in the south shires* (Àth shean). The barley comes in thin across the shires south of the mountain, the fourth-poorest harvest in eleven years by the granary reeve's own tallies. The stores at Àth shean, well kept, would see the country through to spring, but word soon comes that the fleet's crossing must be fed from them too.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 37** — *The council of An Talla Dearg¹⁰¹ divided on the grain* (Cathair dhearg). Through the autumn the queen's council argues over how much stored grain the departing may carry, some holding that no household should cross open water without bread enough, others that Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig¹⁰² was never meant to measure a granary. The queen gives no opinion any rider carries south.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 37** — *Petitioners come to the barred granary* (Àth shean). With no ruling yet come from the capital, petitioners for the fleet's stores gather at Tormod mac Coinnich's door at Àth shean on no authority he can name. He bars the store-house doors and sets a watch of four, and turns away captain's steward and quiet petitioner alike until the council's own seal comes down.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 37** — *The watch stands through the winter* (Àth shean). Four men keep the granary doors at Àth shean through Samhnas and Dubhlas and the black months after, relieved every third day, while riders come from the capital with sealed leaves that settle nothing. Tormod mac Coinnich walks the round with them most nights, unable to say when, or whether, the matter will be settled.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, LE 38** — *The strife over the grain*. Strife over how much of the island's stored grain the ships may take all but ends the venture. Within a season it is settled; how is not recorded.¹⁰³

99. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

100. ← Follows from *The west quay lengthened*, 16 an t-Iuchar, LE 30.

101. the red hall, the rich's hall at Cathair dhearg

102. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

103. → Caused by *A lean harvest in the south shires*, 27 an t-Iuchar, LE 37; → Caused by *The council of An Talla Dearg divided on the grain*, 25 an Lùnastal, LE 37.

- 21 AM MÀRT, LE 38** — *Àth shean shuts its granaries* (Àth shean). In the strife over the fleet's grain Tormod mac Coinnich, reeve of the granaries at Àth shean, bars the store-houses and sets a watch on them until the matter is settled. He holds no office afterward.¹⁰⁴
- 3 AN GIBLEAN, LE 38** — *Grain down Abhainn dhombhain* (Abhainn dhomhain). The strife settled, grain barges go down Abhainn dhomhain to the capital, on by the coast to Ros àrsaidh, and up the Abhainn naomh to Seann Skell. A tally-keeper at Drochaid Cathair dhearg¹⁰⁵ counts forty-one barges passing.
- 2 AN CÈITEAN, LE 38** — *The fleet assembled* (Seann Skell). The fleet lies complete at Seann Skell. The custody-book gives nineteen hulls; a later hand in the margin makes it twenty-one. Which is right has never been settled.
- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 38** — *The granary doors reopened* (Àth shean). A single rider comes to Àth shean with no sealed leaf, only a word that the grain may move at a fixed measure. Tormod mac Coinnich takes the bar down himself and calls off the watch; how the strife was settled, and by whom, he is never told. He holds no office after, and walks home to his father's farm.¹⁰⁶
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 38** — *Mairead nic Iain's tally of the barges* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg¹⁰⁷). On Drochaid Cathair dhearg the tally-keeper Mairead nic Iain cuts a notch in a hazel stick for every laden barge that passes beneath, going down Abhainn dhomhain toward the coast. When the season's grain has all gone by she makes the count forty-one, and writes it down with no more comment than that.¹⁰⁸
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 38** — *Calum's daughter's household entered* (Seann Skell). At Taigh a' Chalaigh¹⁰⁹, Calum mac Nèill cuts his own daughter's household onto Rolla nan Deònach¹¹⁰: Mairead nic Chaluim, her husband Dùghall mac Iain, a fisher of Inis àrsaidh, and their two small children. His son Dòmhnall sets the cup of ale in his sister's hands, and Calum's hand shakes only once the harbour-house stands empty again.¹¹¹
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 38** — *The fleet's stores laid in at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The grain that came down Abhainn dhomhain and up the Abhainn naomh is measured out and sealed aboard the hulls at Seann Skell against the fleet's crossing, one measure to a household under Taigh na Fèithe¹¹²'s own ruling. By spring the quay stands full of hulls that had not existed when the first tale of a far shore reached the river road.¹¹³

104. → Caused by *Tormod mac Coinnich remembers the dearth of his boyhood*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, LE 37; → Caused by *Petitioners come to the barred granary*, 23 an t-Sultain, LE 37; ← Leads to *The watch stands through the winter*, 22 an Dàmhair, LE 37.

105. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

106. ← Follows from *Àth shean shuts its granaries*, 21 am Màrt, LE 38; → Leads to *Grain down Abhainn dhombhain*, 3 an Giblean, LE 38.

107. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

108. ← Follows from *Grain down Abhainn dhombhain*, 3 an Giblean, LE 38.

109. the harbour-house

110. the roll of the willing

111. ○ Same place *The fleet assembled*, 2 an Cèitean, LE 38.

112. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 38** — *Niall mac Dhòmhnaill counts the hulls and loses count* (Seann Skell). Calum's grandson Niall, nine years old, runs the length of the new quay after his lessons, touching each hull's timbers as he passes and trying, unasked, to count the whole fleet. He never once brings the count out even, and a wright who helped lay four of the hulls tells him he could not have done better himself.¹¹⁴
- 16 AM MÀRT, LE 39** — *The queen walks the new quay at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). In the moon of Siolach, Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill comes down to Seann Skell with a small household and walks the whole length of the new stone quay at the harbour scribe's side, saying little, before finding her sister on the strand below.¹¹⁵
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, LE 39** — *The queen and her sister on the stones* (Seann Skell). Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill comes up from the rope-maker's gear to meet her sister on the new stones. What passes between them is not told; Leabhar a' Chùrain¹¹⁶ gives only that the queen was seen upon the quay with her sister, and went home again before the sailing, as her own word bound her to do.¹¹⁷
- 11 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 39** — *The queen rides home before the sailing* (Seann Skell). Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill leaves Seann Skell the same evening she comes to it, telling the harbour scribe she will not be at the quay for the sailing itself, for a queen who has sworn to send no one over and keep no one back has no cause to watch her own sister taken by that same promise.¹¹⁸
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The night of lamps* (Seann Skell). On the last night before the sailing every house on the Seann Skell waterfront sets a lamp on its sill and keeps it burning till morning. It is the first custom of the Sundering written down as a custom, and the town kept it long after its cause had become a tale.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The Setting-Out*. The willing sail out past the north cape. The chronicles of the island fall silent on them as the ships clear the harbour; the Dia-thìrich tell that the fleet sailed into Manannan's mist, toward the Otherworld.¹¹⁹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *Niall given the counting-stick* (Seann Skell). On the eve of the sailing Calum mac Nèill gives his grandson Niall, eleven years old, a shaved hazel stick and a knife, and sets him on the wall of the west quay to cut one notch for every hull that passes in the morning, with the single instruction to keep his eyes on the count and not on the faces.¹²⁰

113. ← Follows from *The fleet assembled*, 2 an Cèitean, LE 38.

114. ¶ Legacy *The fleet assembled*, 2 an Cèitean, LE 38.

115. ← Follows from *The fleet assembled*, 2 an Cèitean, LE 38.

116. the custody-book of the vein-house

117. ← Follows from *The fleet assembled*, 2 an Cèitean, LE 38.

118. ← Follows from *The fleet assembled*, 2 an Cèitean, LE 38.

119. ← Leads to *The queen bears a boundary plea on the morning of the sailing*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

120. ← Follows from *The night of lamps*, 18 an Giblean, LE 40.

- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The lamps lit unasked along the strand* (Seann Skell). Beginning at one widow's window by the fish-stones, a lamp is set on every sill along the Seann Skell waterfront the evening before the sailing, and kept burning until morning, though no one has told the town to do it.¹²¹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *Mairead nic Chaluim's household goes aboard* (Seann Skell). Calum mac Nèill's daughter Mairead, her husband Dùghall mac Iain and their two children take their places aboard their hull on the eve of the sailing, their stores lashed under oiled hide; Mairead asks a deep notch cut for her hull, whichever number it falls at.¹²²
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *Mòrag walks the waterfront alone* (Seann Skell). On the last night Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill walks the length of the Seann Skell strand twice over, naming to herself the household behind every lit window, a leave-taking asked of no one and told to no one beforehand.¹²³
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *Catriona takes the steering oar of An Ròn Glas*¹²⁴ (Seann Skell). Aboard An Ròn Glas on the eve of the sailing, the pilot Catriona nic Iain tells Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill that the oar answers well and the ship rides true, whatever else the morning brings.¹²⁵
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *Fionnlagh stands by his cart and does not go* (Seann Skell). A carter of Seann Skell named Fionnlagh, who has brought loads down to the quay for departing households all that season without putting his own name to the boards, stands by his empty cart through Oidhche nan Lòchran¹²⁶ and through the sailing itself, and does not go aboard any hull.¹²⁷
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *Niall's tally of An Diosal*¹²⁸ (Seann Skell). On the morning of the sailing Niall mac Dhòmhnaill cuts one notch on his hazel stick for every hull that passes the west quay wall going round the river pool sunwise, and keeps the finished stick inside his shirt afterward; no one ever asks him for it back.¹²⁹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The queen bears a boundary plea on the morning of the sailing* (Cathair dhearg). At Cathair dhearg, on the same morning the fleet turns out of Seann Skell, Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill hears an ordinary dispute between two farmers over a shifted boundary ditch and rules it with the same care she gives any such matter, no rider from the coast yet able to have reached her.¹³⁰

121. ← Follows from *The night of lamps*, 18 an Giblean, LE 40.

122. ← Follows from *The night of lamps*, 18 an Giblean, LE 40.

123. ← Follows from *The night of lamps*, 18 an Giblean, LE 40.

124. the Grey Seal, the hull that carried Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill's household

125. ← Follows from *The night of lamps*, 18 an Giblean, LE 40.

126. the night of lamps at Seann Skell

127. ← Follows from *The night of lamps*, 18 an Giblean, LE 40.

128. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

129. ← Follows from *The sunwise turn*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The empty berths walked that evening* (Seann Skell). That evening Calum mac Nèill walks the whole length of the west quay and finds the berths standing empty for the first time in three years, and tells his son Dòmhnall that a harbour built for nothing but to be full is a strange thing to walk when it stands empty.¹³¹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The sunwise turn* (Seann Skell). Before going down the Abhainn naomh to the open sea the fleet goes once round the river pool of Seann Skell sunwise, diosal, for luck, and the watchers on the quay count the hulls as they pass. The harbour scribe's account ends at the foot of the pool.¹³²
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 40** — *Leabhar a' Chùraim*¹³³'s entry of the turn (Muileann dhearg). At Taigh na Fèithe¹³⁴ Donnchadh mac Thormoid enters the turn of the fleet into Leabhar a' Chùraim under a day after Samhain, a full turning of the moon and more after every other account sets the sailing itself. The gap between the two dates is copied faithfully and explained by no word in the leaf that reaches him.¹³⁵
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 44** — *The years counted from the turn* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid, scribe of the vein-house, begins to number the years from the sunwise turn at Seann Skell, and calls them the years of the Diosal. The count is his; the crown's scribes take it up a generation later.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 44** — *Tidings reach Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Tidings of the fleet reach Seann Skell, by what road or whose mouth is not told. The harbour scribe copies them in a shaking hand; the copy came down to later keepers water-stained and lacking its end.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 44** — *Two landfalls*. Such broken tidings as come back tell of two coasts reached, not one. In this telling lies the seed of the two peoples that came after.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 44** — *Donnchadh begins Bliadhnachd an Diosail*¹³⁶ (Muileann dhearg). For his own ledger's convenience, and for no reason he offers anyone, Taigh na Fèithe¹³⁷ clerk Donnchadh mac Thormoid begins to number years from An Diosal¹³⁸ rather than from a reign, working the count backward through his private book to the turn itself. No one above him asks him to keep it, and he tells no one that he does.¹³⁹

130. ← Follows from *The Setting-Out*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

131. ← Follows from *The sunwise turn*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

132. ← Leads to *Niall's tally of An Diosal*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40; ← Leads to *The empty berths walked that evening*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

133. the custody-book of the vein-house

134. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

135. ← Follows from *The sunwise turn*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

136. the years of the Diosal, counted from the sunwise turn

137. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

138. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

139. ← Follows from *The years counted from the turn*, 22 am Faoilleach, LE 44.

- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 44** — *Broken tidings come to the harbour-house* (Seann Skell). Word of the fleet reaches Seann Skell by a boat that does not stay to be questioned. Calum mac Nèill copies the telling that same night in a shaking hand; the letters run smaller toward the leaf's foot, and the copy stops without warning where the telling itself stopped.¹⁴⁰
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 44** — *Two shores, not one* (Seann Skell). Calum's leaf tells of two separate landfalls reached by hulls that had not held together the whole crossing, whether by storm, purpose, or a quarrel the telling does not say. It gives no word of which households reached which shore, and its torn end settles nothing.¹⁴¹
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 44** — *The tidings copied to An Talla Dearg¹⁴² and Taigh na Fèithe¹⁴³* (Seann Skell). A fair copy of Calum's leaf goes by rider to Cathair dhearg for the queen's own council; a second copy, made by his son Dòmhnall, goes east to Taigh na Fèithe, where Donnchadh mac Thormoid sets it beside his own four-year-old entry of the turn and finds the silence between them unexplained by either leaf.¹⁴⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 44** — *The council divided over the two shores* (Cathair dhearg). At An Talla Dearg¹⁴⁵ the custodians argue whether two landfalls mean the fleet prospered or was scattered, and which of the nineteen or one-and-twenty hulls reached which coast. Queen Beathag hears the whole of it and says nothing, and the council lets the matter drop for the day's ordinary business.¹⁴⁶
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 45** — *The tale kept two ways at once at Inis àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh). The broken telling of two shores reaches the fishing hearths of Inis àrsaidh, which gave more households to the roll than any other place. With no way to know which shore holds which kin, the town keeps both halves of the tale alive together, grieving toward one and hoping toward the other by turns.¹⁴⁷
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 45** — *Birth of Raghnaill mac Raghnaill* (Cathair dhearg). A son, named for his father, is born at Cathair dhearg to Raghnaill mac Uilleim, the queen's heir, then seven-and-thirty years old. The boy is Beathag's first grandson and the third of her line under An Talla Dearg¹⁴⁸'s roof.
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 46** — *Mòrag's line struck* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag strikes her sister Mòrag and Mòrag's children from the succession, as no longer on Dia-thìr. The act stands without comment between a grain ruling and the mending of a bridge.

140. ← Follows from *Tidings reach Seann Skell*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 44.

141. ← Follows from *Two landfalls*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, LE 44.

142. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

143. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

144. ← Follows from *Tidings reach Seann Skell*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 44.

145. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

146. ← Follows from *Two landfalls*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, LE 44.

147. ← Follows from *Tidings reach Seann Skell*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 44.

148. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 46** — *The grain ruling settled* (Cathair dhearg). A long dispute over grain owed the crown's granaries by the upland shires is settled in the queen's favour, the reeves agreeing at last to a measure put to them in her own hand rather than a steward's.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 46** — *The bridge at Àth shean mended in stone* (Àth shean). The cracked middle pier of the bridge at Àth shean, shored with timber since a flood two winters before, is rebuilt in stone by masons from the capital, the last props pulled clear on a morning cold enough to break the river's ice.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 46** — *Mòrag's line struck in the ordinary hand* (Cathair dhearg). Between the grain ruling and the bridge, in the same plain hand as either, the queen has Murchadh mac Eòghainn enter that Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill and her children are struck from the succession, as persons no longer on Dia-thìr. Only the old scribe's pen slows at the shaping of the name.¹⁴⁹
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 46** — *Murchadh sands the leaf* (Cathair dhearg). Alone in the near-emptied hall, old Murchadh mac Eòghainn sands the leaf that struck the queen's sister from the roll, the same practised motion he has closed every entry with for forty years, giving away nothing of what lies written beneath the sand.¹⁵⁰
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, LE 50** — *The taproom tales of An Tanachadh*¹⁵¹ at Seann Skell (Seann Skell). A coal-carrier's widow tells at the harbour-house that the children born to the departed on the far shore carry less in their hands than their parents did, and less again by the third generation. A custodian down from Taigh na Fèithe¹⁵² answers her over a jug that the coal was never carried in the blood at all, only left behind at Muileann dhearg like a tool in an unvisited shed. Neither tale is tried against anything Seann Skell holds.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 50** — *A third telling that silences a room* (Seann Skell). A telling heard less often than the other two at Seann Skell holds that nothing thins at all: the far shore never had the coal to answer to, so its children are unremarked only for want of anything to remark them against. It is told least of the three, though it silences a hearth where the others merely fill one.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 52** — *The rite named an Tùrsa Geal*¹⁵³ (Cathair dhearg). The court names the queen's mourning an Tùrsa Geal, and within a generation any household on the island that gave someone to the fleet keeps some form of the same rite unasked, undyed wool and an empty place laid with cup, trencher and straight knife, needing no crown or law behind it.
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 53** — *The thinning*. Cut off from the vein, the strength the crossing asked of them fades in the children of those who went. By the third generation over the water nothing is left that Dia-thìr would know.¹⁵⁴

149. ← Follows from *Mòrag's line struck*, 1 an Lùnastal, LE 46.

150. ← Follows from *Mòrag's line struck*, 1 an Lùnastal, LE 46.

151. the thinning of the departed

152. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

153. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 53** — *The custodians' second count* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house counts again the households of the coal-right and sets the loss at one hand in five. Beside it Donnchadh mac Thormoid writes that the vein answers no differently for those who stayed.
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 53** — *Taigh na Fèithe*¹⁵⁵'s *second count made* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid, now nine-and-thirty, carries the greater share of Taigh na Fèithe's second tallying, checking Rolla nan Deònach¹⁵⁶ against the coal-right's remaining hearths column by column. The count stands where the first count of the roll had stood: one hearth in five gone from the coal-right, no more and no fewer than had sailed.¹⁵⁷
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 53** — *Donnchadh's note that the vein answers no differently* (Muileann dhearg). Beneath the count Donnchadh mac Thormoid sets a second line unasked: that the vein answers no differently now to the hands of those who stayed than it answered before the turn, and that whatever thins in the departed's children thins on their own shore, not on this side of the water. It is carried up to Cathair dhearg with the season's reckoning.¹⁵⁸
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 53** — *Beathag reads the second count twice* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill reads Taigh na Fèithe¹⁵⁹'s figure of one hand in five, a number she has carried unwritten in her own reckoning since the fleet sailed, and reads Donnchadh's note beneath it a second time more slowly than the first. She sets the leaf down in its place among the season's ordinary business and says no more of it that day.¹⁶⁰
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 53** — *The queen first wears the undyed wool* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill comes into An Talla Dearg¹⁶¹ in plain undyed wool for the first time in more than fifty years of reigning in the deep blue of the house of Dòmhnall, and takes up the day's first petition as though nothing were changed, giving the court no word for it.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 53** — *The empty place first laid at the queen's table* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag lays a cup, a trencher and a straight knife at the foot of her own table each evening she dines in hall, mourning her sister Mòrag with no grave to stand at and no body to wash. The court, told by the queen's steward that she mourns a sister ten years and more beyond any word reaching Cathair dhearg, does not know at first whether to speak of the place or pass it in silence.
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 54** — *The Mourning Custom*. Dia-thìr sets in order a rite of mourning for the departed, neither wholly grief nor wholly feast. In a far later age it was used again, uneasily, for a very different leaving.

154. ← Leads to *The taproom tales of An Tanachadh at Seann Skell*, 28 an Cèitean, LE 50; ⇄ At the same time *A third telling that silences a room*, 23 an Lùnastal, LE 50.

155. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

156. the roll of the willing

157. → Leads to *The custodians' second count*, 28 an t-Sultain, LE 53.

158. ← Follows from *The custodians' second count*, 28 an t-Sultain, LE 53.

159. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

160. ← Follows from *The custodians' second count*, 28 an t-Sultain, LE 53.

161. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 27 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 54** — *The white sorrow first kept at court* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag mourns her sister in undyed wool, with one place left empty at a meal that is neither feast nor fast. The court calls it an *Tùrsa Geal*¹⁶², the white sorrow, and within a generation it is kept in every harbour town of the island.¹⁶³
- 13 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 54** — *Donnchadh speaks of Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig*¹⁶⁴'s limit (Muileann dhearg). At a sitting of Taigh na Fèithe¹⁶⁵ called for another matter, Donnchadh mac Thormoid, now its senior clerk, says plainly that the old apprenticeship built for the numbers before the turn has gone as far as the older custodians' own stretching can carry it, and that Taigh na Fèithe owes itself an honest look at what remains.
- 27 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 54** — *The sitting on the seven kindreds argued two days* (Muileann dhearg). A custodian of a small old name that kept a single gallery for three generations speaks bitterly against folding his household's right into a larger kindred. An old woman of Clann Thormoid, who has buried a brother and two nephews to the roll, answers that she would sooner see her right folded into a house that can still walk its galleries than stand alone over ones it cannot serve, and the sitting turns on her answer.
- 7 **AM FAOILLEACH, LE 55** — *The custodians fewer*. With part of the coal-bound folk gone, the Dia-thìrich order themselves anew about a smaller and closer class of custodians. From this shape every later nobility descends.¹⁶⁶
- 4 **AN T-IUCHAR, LE 55** — *The seven houses of custody* (Muileann dhearg). The custodian households that remain are gathered into seven houses, each answerable to the vein-house for its share of the coal and of the measured burning: Clann Mhuirich, Clann Fhearchair, Clann Ìomhair, Clann Raghnaill, Clann Thormoid, Clann Choinnich and Clann Lachlainn. Here for the first time the right to the coal passes by house and not by apprenticeship.¹⁶⁷
- 28 **AN T-IUCHAR, LE 55** — *Death of Queen Beathag* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill dies at Cathair dhearg, the last ruler of Dia-thìr who saw the fleet. Her son Raghnaill mac Uilleim is crowned in the same hall.¹⁶⁸

162. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

163. ← Leads to *The rite named an Tùrsa Geal*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, LE 52; → Caused by *The queen first wears the undyed wool*, 6 an t-Samhain, LE 53; → Caused by *The empty place first laid at the queen's table*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, LE 53.

164. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

165. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

166. → Caused by *Donnchadh speaks of Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig's limit*, 13 an t-Samhain, LE 54; ← Leads to *The sitting on the seven kindreds argued two days*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 54.

167. → Caused by *The sitting on the seven kindreds argued two days*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 54.

168. ◇ Same person *Birth of Raghnaill mac Uilleim*, 18 an t-Samhain, LE 8.

- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 55** — *Na Seachd Taighean*¹⁶⁹ *sworn* (Muileann dhearg). Taigh na Fèithe¹⁷⁰ gathers the remaining custodian households into seven kindreds large enough to answer for a share of the galleries between them: Clann Mhuirich, Clann Fhearchair, Clann Ìomhair, Clann Raghnaill, Clann Thormoid, Clann Choinnich and Clann Lachlainn. Their seven heads are sworn before Crom's stone, and the right to the coal passes from that year by house and no longer by apprenticeship alone.¹⁷¹
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 55** — *Donnchadh writes Mionnan nan Seachd*¹⁷² *heads* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid enters the seven heads' oath into Leabhar a' Chùraim¹⁷³ in the same plain hand he has kept his whole working life, and finds himself thinking less of Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig¹⁷⁴ than of the fifth of hands the sitting never once named aloud: those fifteen years and a whole sea away, on a shore the book has no line to enter them against.¹⁷⁵
- 23 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 55** — *Death of Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill at seventy-six* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill dies at Cathair dhearg in the summer, seventy and six years old, after one-and-sixty years upon An Talla Dearg¹⁷⁶'s floor, the oldest of her line and the last ruler who saw the fleet built and sent. She holds a boundary petition to its ordinary end that same morning before going to her rooms and not rising again.¹⁷⁷
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 55** — *Raghnaill mac Uilleim crowned at seven-and-forty* (Cathair dhearg). Raghnaill mac Uilleim, son of Beathag and of Uilleam mac Iain, is crowned in An Talla Dearg¹⁷⁸ within the month of his mother's death, seven-and-forty years old and long seated at her board. He wears a strip of undyed wool beneath his crowning colours, a thing he grew up watching his mother wear and never asked leave to wear himself.¹⁷⁹
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 55** — *The empty place laid once more at the queen's wake* (Cathair dhearg). At the second night of Beathag's wake her steward lays the cup, trencher and straight knife once more at the foot of her table exactly as she always kept them, so that the court, passing between the small emptiness at the board's foot and the greater one at the board's head, cannot say with certainty whether the place is laid for the queen or still for the sister she mourned fifteen years across an unanswering sea.¹⁸⁰

169. the seven houses of custody

170. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

171. ← Follows from *The seven houses of custody*, 4 an t-Iuchar, LE 55.

172. the oath of the seven houses

173. the custody-book of the vein-house

174. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

175. ← Follows from *The seven houses of custody*, 4 an t-Iuchar, LE 55.

176. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

177. → Leads to *Death of Queen Beathag*, 28 an t-Iuchar, LE 55.

178. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

179. ← Follows from *Death of Queen Beathag*, 28 an t-Iuchar, LE 55.

180. ← Follows from *Death of Queen Beathag*, 28 an t-Iuchar, LE 55; ¶ Legacy *The white sorrow first kept at court*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 54.

- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 57** — *Murchadh mac Raghnaill takes the berths* (Seann Skell). The harbour-master of Seann Skell retires to his daughter's house up the Abhainn naomh rather than die at his post, and Murchadh mac Raghnaill, of an age with Niall mac Dhòmhnaill, takes the berths and the dues.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 58** — *Death of Calum mac Nèill, Niall takes the harbour-house* (Seann Skell). Calum mac Nèill, harbour scribe of Seann Skell for six-and-fifty years, dies in the room above the harbour-house. The boards pass, as he had let the town see coming, to his grandson Niall mac Dhòmhnaill, the boy who once counted the hulls with a hazel stick, now a man of nine-and-twenty.¹⁸¹
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 58** — *Dòmhnall mac Chaluim keeps the trade rolls* (Seann Skell). Passed over for the boards he had expected, Calum's son Dòmhnall keeps the harbour-house's trade rolls and dues, working the office beside his own son Niall without open quarrel, though he calls the boards the queerest inheritance a man could be passed over for.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 58** — *Niall keeps his grandfather's stick at his own elbow* (Seann Skell). Niall takes down the hazel stick Calum kept since the night of An Diosal¹⁸² and sets it at his own writing-place rather than returning it to the shelf, though he puts it to no further use.¹⁸³
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 61** — *The rite of the empty harbour*. A rite grows up about the quay the ships sailed from. It is still kept, lessened, on a day that none can now date truly.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 62** — *The lamps kept on the rite's eve* (Seann Skell). On the eve nearest the day of An Diosal¹⁸⁴ the households of Seann Skell bring small lights down to the west quay and set them along the stones the fleet sailed from, a rite grown up with no ordered beginning that Niall is the first to enter in the harbour-house's own leaves.¹⁸⁵
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 64** — *The harbour at half trade* (Seann Skell). The harbour-master of Seann Skell finds his berths at half their old use, for the fishing households that crewed the fleet are gone. The rope-walks of Cuan shean turn off hands for the first time.¹⁸⁶
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 64** — *The harbour-master's count of half trade* (Seann Skell). Murchadh mac Raghnaill, harbour-master of Seann Skell, sets his own reckoning of empty berths against full ones beside the boards: the harbour carries little more than half the trade it carried before An Diosal^{187 188}.

181. ¶ Legacy *The sunwise turn*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

182. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

183. ¶ Legacy *The sunwise turn*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

184. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

185. ← Follows from *The rite of the empty harbour*, 25 an t-Samhain, LE 61.

186. → Caused by *Murchadh mac Raghnaill takes the berths*, 18 an t-Samhain, LE 57.

187. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

188. ← Follows from *The harbour at half trade*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, LE 64.

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 64 — *The rope-walks of Cuan shean let hands go* (Cuan shean).

With more cordage made than the lessened harbour trade can use, the rope-walks along Cuan shean's waterfront turn off hands for the first time in the memory of any walker still living there.¹⁸⁹

8 AN GEARRAN, LE 65 — *The second silence*. There is a rumour of a second, smaller crossing, with fewer ships and no word of where they went. Nothing that survives confirms or denies it.

17 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 65 — *Word of a second, smaller crossing* (Seann Skell). A hand off a coasting boat tells, at second or third remove, of a smaller fleet said to have sailed from the island's own shore in the years after An Diosal¹⁹⁰ and never been heard from since. Niall hears the tale and, having no name or second mouth to stand behind it, sets it aside unwritten.¹⁹¹

28 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 66 — *The first turn of Faire a' Chinn*¹⁹² (Ceann mhòr). Seonag nic Dhùghaill of Ceann mhòr climbs the headland at first light and keeps it through the day, seeing nothing but open water. Other households take up a turn of their own after her, and the custom becomes Faire a' Chinn.

26 AN GEARRAN, LE 66 — *The west quay's old name falls from use* (Seann Skell). The plain old name of the west quay falls out of common mouths at Seann Skell as carters, fish-wives and children too young to have known the fleet come to call it Cidhe an Diosail¹⁹³, without any single day anyone can name for the change.

5 AM MÀRT, LE 67 — *The watch at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). The fishing families of Ceann mhòr on the north-west coast keep a watch from the headland for returning sails, household by household in turn. The watch lapses within a generation. No sail is seen.¹⁹⁴

13 AM MÀRT, LE 67 — *The west quay renamed*. The quay the ships sailed from is given a new name, so that common trade might go on under the old one without the memory. It is an early and quiet forgetting, made on purpose.¹⁹⁵

15 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 67 — *Cidhe an Diosail*¹⁹⁶ (Seann Skell). The departure berth is entered in the harbour rolls of Seann Skell as Cidhe an Diosail, the quay of the sunwise turn. The name Cidhe an Iar passes to the new fish-wharf at the north end of the strand, and within a few years the fishers use it without a thought.

189. ← Follows from *The harbour at half trade*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, LE 64.

190. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

191. ← Follows from *The second silence*, 8 an Gearran, LE 65.

192. the watch of the headland at Ceann mhòr

193. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

194. ← Leads to *The first turn of Faire a' Chinn*, 28 am Faoilleach, LE 66.

195. ← Leads to *The west quay's old name falls from use*, 26 an Gearran, LE 66.

196. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 67** — *Roghnaich takes its narrow sense*. In the custody-book the verb *roghnaich*, to choose, begins to stand with no object, meaning to have chosen the crossing. The scribes of the next century use it so without explaining it, the surest sign that it had passed into common speech.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 67** — *The first generation that never saw the fleet*. Children born soon after the Setting-Out grow up never having seen the harbour with those ships in it. To them the leaving is already history.
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 67** — *Cidhe an Diosail*¹⁹⁷ entered in *Rolla a' Chalaigh*¹⁹⁸ (Seann Skell). Niall enters the west quay's new name into *Rolla a' Chalaigh* in his own hand, letting the old name stand once beside it, struck through but not scraped. The old name, *Cidhe an Iar*, passes to the new fish-wharf at the strand's north end.¹⁹⁹
- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 67** — *Roghnaich stands with no object* (Seann Skell). In *Rolla a' Chalaigh*²⁰⁰ the word *roghnaich*, to choose, begins to stand alone in a clerk's hand, meaning to have chosen the crossing, and Niall lets the usage stand in his own leaves rather than write it out in full.²⁰¹
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 67** — *Niall's own children who never saw the fleet* (Seann Skell). Niall's eldest daughter, old enough by then to help about the harbour-house, asks whether he himself saw the ships go, having no memory of her own to set beside the wall of names she leans against.²⁰²
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 67** — *Death of Alasdair Saor and his last coaster* (Seann Skell). Alasdair mac Iain, Alasdair Saor, who laid the fleet's first deep keel, dies at Seann Skell at the end of summer, days after launching a sewn-plank coaster at Inis àrsaidh for a fish merchant there, his last work. Niall enters the death and the quay's new name on the same leaf.
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 67** — *Death of Alasdair Saor* (Seann Skell). Alasdair Saor, who laid the first deep keel, dies at Seann Skell. His last work was a coasting trader of the old sewn-plank kind, built for a fish merchant of Inis àrsaidh.²⁰³
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 67** — *Coinneach mac Fhearghais named master of the fellowship* (Seann Skell). After Alasdair Saor's death Coinneach mac Fhearghais, the first apprentice Alasdair ever swore, takes the mastership of the fellowship of the strand, keeping its oath and its coal exactly as Alasdair had kept them before him.²⁰⁴

197. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

198. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

199. ← Follows from *Cidhe an Diosail*, 15 an Lùnastal, LE 67.

200. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

201. ← Follows from *Roghnaich takes its narrow sense*, 21 an Lùnastal, LE 67.

202. ← Follows from *The first generation that never saw the fleet*, 31 an Lùnastal, LE 67.

203. ← Leads to *Death of Alasdair Saor and his last coaster*, 4 an t-Sultain, LE 67.

204. ← Follows from *Death of Alasdair Saor*, 8 an t-Sultain, LE 67.

- 28 AM MÀRT, LE 68** — *Death of Coinneach mac Fhearghais* (Seann Skell). Coinneach mac Fhearghais dies at Seann Skell in the house where he had lived since his marriage, leaving the fellowship's coal to his eldest journeyman Griogair rather than to any man claiming it by right of years alone.²⁰⁵
- 27 AN GEARRAN, LE 70** — *The one household that breaks its own coal* (Muileann dhearg). By the seventieth year of the count Eachann Briseadair's is the only household on the hill below Taigh na Fèithe²⁰⁶ that does the whole of the breaking and sorting itself rather than hiring hands season by season.
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 72** — *An Diosal*²⁰⁷ *count taken up at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The crown's own scribes at An Talla Dearg²⁰⁸ begin dating their rolls by the count Donnchadh mac Thormoid had kept alone at Taigh na Fèithe²⁰⁹ for near thirty years, setting aside the reckoning by a king's reign for the turning he first set his own hand to as a clerk of thirty.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 72** — *Eachann Briseadair raises the first house below Taigh na Fèithe*²¹⁰ (Muileann dhearg). Eachann Briseadair, whose household breaks and sorts the coal brought down from the galleries, builds the first house of stone below Taigh na Fèithe's own gate; his sons build three more beside it within the decade, the beginning of the coal-breakers' row.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 72** — *Muileann dhearg a town in more than name* (Muileann dhearg). The coal-breakers' settlement below Taigh na Fèithe²¹¹'s gate, which has borne the name Muileann dhearg since the first years of the age, grows within Eachann Briseadair's lifetime into a town with its own well, smith and reeve, answering to Taigh na Fèithe rather than to any shire.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 84** — *The shipwrights' fellowship ends*. No more sea-going ships being wanted, the fellowship that built the fleet of the Sundering quietly breaks up. Its craft is half forgotten by the time anyone needs it again.²¹²
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 84** — *The fellowship of the strand released* (Seann Skell). Griogair calls the fellowship's remaining journeymen to the strand and releases every man from the oath, judging there is no longer craft enough in the island's own boat-building to keep it; the journeymen scatter to the rope-walks, their fathers' land and Doire fhionn's coppice-cutting.²¹³

205. ← Follows from *Death of Alasdair Saor*, 8 an t-Sultain, LE 67.

206. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

207. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

208. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

209. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

210. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

211. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

212. ← Leads to *The one household that breaks its own coal*, 27 an Gearran, LE 70.

- 29 **AN CÈITEAN, LE 85** — *The keel-moulds burned* (Seann Skell). In a hard season the patterns and moulds of the broken fellowship, kept in a shed on the strand at Seann Skell, are burned for firewood. The harbour-master notes the loss of the shed and not of what was in it.
- 21 **AN DÙHLACHD, LE 85** — *The keel-moulds burned for firewood* (Seann Skell). In the hard winter of Faolach the fellowship's old patterns and keel-moulds, untouched for years in the shed on the strand, are carried out and burned; the harbour-master notes only that the shed came down, and nothing of what it held.²¹⁴
- 6 **AN T-SULTAIN, LE 86** — *The lots drawn among Na Seachd Taighean*²¹⁵ (Muileann dhearg). The heads of Na Seachd Taighean that hold the right to the coal are called to Taigh na Fèithe²¹⁶ and each draws a marked stone from a covered bag before the custodians and the household, the galleries falling as the stones fall so that no house may claim its ground was given rather than drawn.
- 9 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 92** — *Death of Ragnall mac Uilleim and the crowning of his son* (Cathair dhearg). Ragnall mac Uilleim dies in his eighty-fifth year after seven-and-thirty years on An Talla Dearg²¹⁷; his son Ragnall mac Raghnaill, seven-and-forty years old, is crowned in his place without dispute, Leabhar a' Chùrain²¹⁸ giving the closed reign one line and the new one another.
- 8 **AN T-IUCHAR, LE 92** — *Birth of Ìomhar mac Raghnaill* (Cathair dhearg). In the year his grandfather dies and his father is crowned, a son, Ìomhar, is born at Cathair dhearg to Ragnall mac Raghnaill, a king of seven-and-forty with a new crown and a new child in the same season.
- 6 **AN LÙNASTAL, LE 100** — *Death of Eachann Briseadair* (Muileann dhearg). Eachann Briseadair dies at sixty in the shed where he broke his first load of coal as a boy, his sons and grandsons already keeping the work; he is buried on the rise above the row with a lump of unbroken coal set over him rather than a mason's stone.

213. ← Follows from *The shipwrights' fellowship ends*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, LE 84.

214. ← Follows from *The keel-moulds burned*, 29 an Cèitean, LE 85.

215. the seven houses of custody

216. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

217. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

218. the custody-book of the vein-house

THE YEARS LE 101 – 200

- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 104** — *Death of Niall mac Dhòmhnaill* (Seann Skell). Niall mac Dhòmhnaill dies at Seann Skell in the harbour-house itself, six-and-forty years after taking up the boards, his grandfather's notched hazel stick set in his hand at his own asking and buried with him, the count it held never once spoken aloud.¹
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, LE 109** — *The mountain divided among the houses* (Muileann dhearg). The seven houses draw lots at the vein-house for the galleries each will keep, and the vein-house confirms each its Small-Burning measure. The lot-stones were kept in a bag at Muileann dhearg and shown to visitors for centuries after.²
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 109** — *The coppice law of Doire fhionn* (Doire fhionn). The great oaks gone to the fleet, the shire of Doire fhionn forbids the felling of any living oak without the reeve's mark and begins to cut its woods by coppice. The law spreads to every shire with a Doire in its name.³
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 109** — *The lamps kept at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The waterfront of Seann Skell keeps the night of lamps each year on the eve of the rite of the empty harbour. The children are told the lamps are for ships coming home, and the priests do not gainsay it.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 109** — *Death of Donnchadh mac Thormoid* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid, the vein-house scribe who began the count of years, dies at Muileann dhearg. His last entry is the season's burning of coal, household by household, in the same hand as his first.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 109** — *Clachan a' Chrannchuir⁴ shown to a visitor* (Muileann dhearg). Old Donnchadh takes the bag of Clachan a' Chrannchuir down from its peg to let a grandson of Eachann Briseadair's, waiting idle in Taigh na Fèithe⁵ hall, hold it and hear how the seven heads once drew their galleries, though he tells the boy nothing of which stone fell to which house.⁶
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 109** — *Death of Donnchadh mac Thormoid* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid dies at Muileann dhearg in his ninety-fifth year, his last entry the season's burning of coal household by household, set down in the same careful hand he had used since he was fifteen.⁷
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 125** — *Ragnall dies; Ìombar crowned* (Cathair dhearg). King Ragnall mac Raghnaill dies at Cathair dhearg, and his son Ìombar mac Raghnaill is crowned. Ragnall had followed his father Ragnall mac Uilleim, who died in his eighty-fifth year after a long and quiet reign; the custody-book gives each of the two Ragnalls a single line.⁸

1. ¶ Legacy *The sunwise turn*, 19 an Giblean, LE 40.

2. ← Leads to *The lots drawn among Na Seachd Taighean*, 6 an t-Sultain, LE 86.

3. → Caused by *The Child walled*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, LE 5.

4. the stones of the lot

5. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

6. ← Follows from *The mountain divided among the houses*, 30 an Giblean, LE 109.

7. ← Follows from *Death of Donnchadh mac Thormoid*, 9 an Dàmhair, LE 109.

22 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 125 — *The old men compare two crownings* (Cathair dhearg). At Cathair dhearg the court remarks that Ìomhar mac Raghnaill's crowning differs little from his father's three-and-thirty years before, the same cup passed hand to hand and the same oath said over it, a quiet continuity Leabhar a' Chùrain⁹ itself gives only a single line apiece.

¹⁰

11 AN CÈITEAN, LE 130 — *A boy of Inis mhòr asks why the barges keep the coast* (Inis mhòr). Watching the first grain barge loaded on the Abhainn ghorm, a boy of Inis mhòr asks his father why the boat should not simply cross open water by the shorter way, and is answered only with a look and no word, for no one on the island since the fleet has wished to be out of sight of land.

6 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 149 — *The silversmiths of Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Silver of the seam at Muileann chiar, mined since the Holy Age, is wrought into neck-rings for the heads of the seven houses. The smiths' fellowship of the seam, heirs of Sliochd Fhearchair, keeps its craft within four families.

29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 149 — *The first silver neck-rings worn* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The heads of Na Seachd Taighean¹¹ first wear the neck-rings beaten by the smiths of Muileann chiar, so that a stranger at Taigh na Fèithe¹² or An Talla Dearg¹³ may know a custodian by the collar at his throat before a word is said.¹⁴

4 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 154 — *Inis mhòr's grain fleet* (Inis mhòr). Inis mhòr in the north builds barges to carry grain down the Abhainn ghorm to Caol bheag, and from Ros chiar at the river mouth west along the coast to Cnoc bheag. They are sewn-plank boats of the old kind, and none lies a night out of sight of land.¹⁵

2 AN GEARRAN, LE 156 — *The coughing sickness at Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). A coughing sickness runs through Caol fhiadhaich on the south-west coast and kills some ten before it burns out. The shared meal is kept throughout, and the reeve holds that it saved the rest.

27 AN GIBLEAN, LE 156 — *The shared meal kept through the cough* (Caol fhiadhaich). When the coughing sickness reaches the reeve's own household at Caol fhiadhaich, his wife refuses to let their door be barred against the shared board, holding that a household which eats apart out of fear will go on eating apart after the fear has passed; she lives, and the custom outlasts the sickness.¹⁶

8. ◇ Same person *Birth of Raghnaill mac Raghnaill*, 6 an Lùnastal, LE 45; ◇ Same person *Birth of Ìomhar mac Raghnaill*, 8 an t-Iuchar, LE 92.

9. the custody-book of the vein-house

10. ← Follows from *Raghnaill dies; Ìomhar crowned*, 7 an t-Samhain, LE 125.

11. the seven houses of custody

12. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

13. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

14. ← Follows from *The silversmiths of Muileann chiar*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, LE 149.

15. ← Leads to *A boy of Inis mhòr asks why the barges keep the coast*, 11 an Cèitean, LE 130.

16. ← Follows from *The coughing sickness at Caol fhiadhaich*, 2 an Gearran, LE 156.

- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 157** — *Birth of Fearchar mac Lachlainn* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). A son, Fearchar, is born in the house of Clann Fhearchair at Baile Mòr dhomhain, the elder of two brothers, in a hall that has never looked for a crown and does not look for one now.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 160** — *The king's habit at the gallery's mouth* (Muileann dhearg). King Ìomhar takes up a habit no ruler before him is recorded keeping, asking the youngest hand at any gallery he visits to name the prop, the cut and the tally-mark before him; Taigh na Fèithe¹⁷'s scribe judges it a kind of counting of his own, made by a king with no child to leave the hall to.¹⁸
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 163** — *A singing timber clears the gallery* (Muileann dhearg). Bound as a child to a custodian's household, Fearchar mac Lachlainn stands outside a mountain gallery in the night while the custodian, hearing a timber begin to sing, has the working cleared an hour before the prop gives way with no one beneath it; he keeps the memory into his own old age.
- 3 AM MÀRT, LE 164** — *Am Buabhall Fortanach rebuilt in stone* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). The old road-house of Am Buabhall Fortanach burns to its footings, and its keeper, Eilidh nic Chaluim, rebuilds it in stone. It is already known for its jugged buffalo.
- I AN GIBLEAN, LE 164** — *Am Buabhall Fortanach's new stone walls* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Eilidh nic Chaluim raises the burned road-house of Am Buabhall Fortanach again in stone, and a boy of Clann Fhearchair riding out with his father to see the walls going up is given a bowl of the jugged buffalo before the roof itself is finished.¹⁹
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 164** — *Fearchar mac Lachlainn bound to the galleries* (Muileann dhearg). At seven years old Fearchar mac Lachlainn is bound for seven years to a custodian's household above Muileann dhearg, as every child of Na Seachd Taighean²⁰ is meant to be, while his younger brother Iain is kept at home to learn the hall.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, LE 170** — *Death of Raghnall Beag mac Ìomhair* (Cathair dhearg). King Ìomhar's only son, Raghnall Beag, dies of a fever at Cathair dhearg; a custodian of Clann Fhearchair reads the letter aloud and says that a king with no other child is a house with one wall standing, which the wind will find sooner or later.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 171** — *Fearchar comes home from the galleries* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Fearchar mac Lachlainn comes home to Baile Mòr dhomhain at fourteen, able to tell the weight of a sealed measure by its heft and the sound a gallery makes when its timbering has begun to fail.
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 179** — *The spirit-house at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The keepers of the Old Spirits, the faith of the hearths, raise a house for the ancestors at Dùn ìseal, and cut the names of the dead of the eastern shires on wooden posts. The posts are cut anew each generation as the old ones rot.

17. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

18. ‡ Legacy *Raghnall dies; Ìomhar crowned*, 7 an t-Samhain, LE 125.

19. ← Follows from *Am Buabhall Fortanach rebuilt in stone*, 3 am Màrt, LE 164.

20. the seven houses of custody

- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 179** — *Names cut new on the posts of Dùn iséal* (Dùn iséal). A young man of Clann Fhearchair, travelling east with his father, stands long before the wooden posts of the spirit-house at Dùn iséal, reading names the shire itself cuts anew each generation, and says only that a shire which trusts wood to hold its dead must trust its own memory further than he would.²¹
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 179** — *The head of Clann Fhearchair names his younger son* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). The head of Clann Fhearchair dies at Baile Mòr dhomhain, naming his younger son Iain mac Lachlainn to the headship of the house and leaving his elder son Fearchar to the galleries he knows.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, LE 180** — *Ìomhar dies without an heir* (Cathair dhearg). King Ìomhar mac Raghnaill dies at Cathair dhearg with no living child, and with him ends the line of Beathag. The heads of the seven houses are summoned to the capital to name a king.²²
- 13 AN CÈITEAN, LE 181** — *The heads of the seven summoned to the capital* (Cathair dhearg). With King Ìomhar dead and no living child of his line, riders carry word to all of Na Seachd Taighean²³ that their heads are summoned to Cathair dhearg to choose, for the first time since An Diosal²⁴, a king the crown's own blood cannot simply hand down.²⁵
- 19 AN GEARRAN, LE 182** — *Fearchar mac Lachlainn chosen* (Cathair dhearg). The heads of the houses choose Fearchar mac Lachlainn of Baile Mòr dhomhain, of Clann Fhearchair, and he is crowned at Cathair dhearg. He is the first king made by the seven houses and not by descent.²⁶
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 182** — *Iain mac Lachlainn turns the choosing aside* (Cathair dhearg). Named by the other heads as a possible king, Iain mac Lachlainn of Clann Fhearchair turns the honour aside, saying a man who keeps one house's hall well may yet keep a kingdom poorly, and names his elder brother Fearchar in his place.²⁷
- 19 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 182** — *A borrowed cup for the first oath* (Cathair dhearg). With no cup of the crown's own ready for the rite, the head of Clann Mhuirich sends for the cup her own house keeps, so that Fearchar mac Lachlainn drinks his first oath as king from a vessel that belongs, strictly, to one house among the seven rather than to the crown.²⁸

21. ← Follows from *The spirit-house at Dùn iséal*, 7 an Dàmhair, LE 179.

22. → Caused by *Death of Raghnaill Beag mac Ìomhair*, 30 an Cèitean, LE 170.

23. the seven houses of custody

24. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

25. ← Follows from *Ìomhar dies without an heir*, 30 an Giblean, LE 180.

26. ◇ Same person *Birth of Fearchar mac Lachlainn*, 22 an Dàmhair, LE 157; → Caused by *Fearchar mac Lachlainn bound to the galleries*, 30 an t-Sultain, LE 164; → Caused by *Fearchar comes home from the galleries*, 16 an Dàmhair, LE 171; → Caused by *The head of Clann Fhearchair names his younger son*, 23 an t-Samhain, LE 179; → Caused by *The heads of the seven summoned to the capital*, 13 an Cèitean, LE 181.

27. → Leads to *Fearchar mac Lachlainn chosen*, 19 an Gearran, LE 182.

28. ← Follows from *Fearchar mac Lachlainn chosen*, 19 an Gearran, LE 182.

- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 182** — *The head of Clann Ìomhair breaks the silence in the yard* (Cathair dhearg). After a morning's silence in the yard of An Talla Dearg²⁹ the head of Clann Ìomhair speaks first: the line of Beathag has held the hall a hundred years and more, and no house of the seven has a better claim to it than another.³⁰
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, LE 188** — *Birth of Fearchar Donn* (Cathair dhearg). A son is born to King Fearchar mac Lachlainn, then one-and-thirty and six years crowned, and is called Fearchar Donn for the brown of his hair; he is the first child born to a king Na Seachd Taighean³¹ chose.
- 20 AM MÀRT, LE 194** — *A court at Baile Mòr dhomhain* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). King Fearchar keeps his court part of each year at Baile Mòr dhomhain, near the mountain, that he may take counsel of the vein-house without a journey. The double court lasts as long as his house.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 194** — *The double court divided* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). King Fearchar settles the custom of keeping his court partly at Cathair dhearg and partly at Baile Mòr dhomhain near Taigh na Fèithe³², with his brother Iain keeping Clann Fhearchair's own hall whenever the court is away at the capital.³³
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, LE 195** — *Fearchar Donn asked the child's question* (Muileann dhearg). Brought young to the mountain as his father had been, Fearchar Donn is asked at seven years old to name the prop, the cut and the tally-mark before him at a gallery's mouth, and gives an answer his father calls, laughing, the first honestly ordinary thing his own house has produced in two reigns.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 200** — *The brothers' leaf-book of letters* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). A later hand at Baile Mòr dhomhain gathers into one leaf-book the letters King Fearchar and his brother Iain exchange across every season of the divided court, boundary disputes and grain petitions set down beside a long-running complaint over the capital's cooking.

29. the red hall, the high's hall at Cathair dhearg

30. → Leads to *Fearchar mac Lachlainn chosen*, 19 an Gearran, LE 182.

31. the seven houses of custody

32. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

33. ← Follows from *A court at Baile Mòr dhomhain*, 20 am Màrt, LE 194.

THE YEARS LE 201 – 300

- 21 AN GEARRAN, LE 209** — *The fishers of Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). After a season of losses the fishing families of Àth fhiadhaich join in one fellowship to share boats and nets. It is the first fishers' fellowship on the east coast.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 210** — *A fisherman questioned on the fellowship* (Àth fhiadhaich). Brought before the old king almost by chance, a fisherman of Àth fhiadhaich is kept a full hour answering questions on how boats and nets are shared among the new fellowship's households, and rides home understanding only afterward that the king was asking after the fellowship itself, not the fish.¹
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 211** — *Fearchar Donn crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Fearchar mac Lachlainn dies, and his son, called Fearchar Donn, is crowned at Cathair dhearg without dispute.²
- 10 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 211** — *A king's fire kept to the ordinary measure* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Dying, King Fearchar asks that no coal be burned beyond the ordinary handful for any rite made over him, and Taigh na Fèithe³ keeps the asking to the letter, so that the fire lit for a king is no larger than the fire any house of the seven lights for its own dead.⁴
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 211** — *Na Seachd Taighean*⁵ *stand at Clann Fhearchair's grave* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). The heads of Na Seachd Taighean, each still wearing the neck-ring of Muileann chiar, stand at the grave of the king they chose nine-and-twenty years before, and not one of them is heard to say the choosing made in that cold yard was anything other than the right one.⁶
- 21 AN GEARRAN, LE 215** — *A hawk overfed will not come to the glove* (Cnoc bheag). A young bird of the mews at Cnoc bheag, fed too heavy the evening before, will not answer Gormshuil nic Artair's call at the dawn rite; her father Artair, too stiff now to climb to the block himself, tells her plainly that a bird fed past its measure is as useless as one starved of it.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 218** — *Gormshuil calls Mòd down alone for the first time* (Cnoc bheag). With Artair's knees failed for the climb, Gormshuil nic Artair goes up to the mews block at Cnoc bheag before dawn and calls the shrine's hawk down with no one else to answer for the flight, three-and-thirty years old and, by her own later word, more frightened coming down than going up.

1. ← Follows from *The fishers of Àth fhiadhaich*, 21 an Gearran, LE 209.

2. ◇ Same person *Birth of Fearchar Donn*, 2 an Giblean, LE 188; ¶ Legacy of *Fearchar Donn asked the child's question*, 19 an Cèitean, LE 195.

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

4. ← Follows from *Fearchar Donn crowned*, 21 an t-Ògmhios, LE 211.

5. the seven houses of custody

6. ¶ Legacy *Fearchar Donn crowned*, 21 an t-Ògmhios, LE 211.

- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 220** — *Death of Artair, hawk-keeper of Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). Artair dies at Cnoc bheag in his own bed above the shrine, three-score and ten years old, and the keeping of the mews he had held the better part of his life passes without dispute to his daughter Gormshuil; the hill's households bury him facing the shrine rather than in any rite of the departed.
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 221** — *Gormshuil first names the vein An Seabhag Acrach⁷* (Cnoc bheag). Asked, as custom wants, to say a few words over her father's empty place on the bench, Gormshuil nic Artair tells the shrine's watchers for the first time that the vein under Muileann dhearg is itself a hawk of Mòd's kind, to be fed the measured handful and never glutted past it.
- 31 AM MÀRT, LE 225** — *Hawk-keepers of the north coast come to hear her* (Cnoc bheag). Word of Gormshuil's teaching, carried inland by a wool-buyer of Bàgh an t-Seabhaig⁸, brings three keepers of the coastal shrines to Cnoc bheag to judge it for themselves; they stay a week among the coal-cutters' wives at the shrine's ledge and go home saying the teaching has lost nothing in the carrying.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, LE 225** — *Bàgh an t-Seabhaig⁹ elder questions Gormshuil's own hunger* (Cnoc bheag). The eldest of the three coastal keepers asks Gormshuil, on the last morning of their visit, whether she has ever gone hungry enough herself to know the second half of what she teaches; Gormshuil answers that she has, twice, and disliked the lesson both times without forgetting either.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 229** — *Gormshuil of the Hawk* (Cnoc bheag). At Cnoc bheag, where the dawn-hawk rite of the Holy Age is still kept, the priestess Gormshuil nic Artair teaches that the hawk of the rite is Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, eldest of men, and remembering all things with him. The vein, she teaches, is the Hungry Hawk, to be fed the measured handful and no more, for a hawk overfed will not hunt and a hawk starved will turn on the hand. Her followers gather the old rite into the first house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹⁰, the order of the Hawk of Acaill.¹¹
- 31 AN CÈITEAN, LE 229** — *Gormshuil's first true congregation* (Cnoc bheag). The watchers climbing to Cnoc bheag for the dawn rite grow past the number the shrine's ledge can easily hold, and Gormshuil, asked more mornings than not to give the teaching whole, gathers it at last into the shape it will keep for the rest of her life.¹²

7. the Hungry Hawk

8. the Hawk bay

9. the Hawk bay

10. the Hawk order

- 1 AN GEARRAN, LE 232** — *Taigh an t-Seabhaig*¹³ raised (Cnoc bheag). Gormshuil's watchers, calling themselves a house rather than a congregation, raise a hall of timber and dry stone below the mews block at Cnoc bheag, giving the old dawn-hawk rite a roof of its own for the first time in its keeping.¹⁴
- 22 AM MÀRT, LE 239** — *The hawk-house at Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). Gormshuil's pupils found a second house of the Hawk at Ros gheal. Its priests take charge of the measured burning for all the country between Ros gheal on the coast and Cnoc bheag up the river.
- 27 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 239** — *A second house raised at Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). Two of Gormshuil's pupils, a brother and sister of a coastal household, carry the dawn rite down to the shore at Ros gheal rather than make every fisher's family of that coast walk two days inland; Gormshuil goes down herself to judge the teaching had travelled whole.¹⁵
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 243** — *Birth of Sileas nic Fhearchair* (Cathair dhearg). A daughter, Sileas, is born at Cathair dhearg to King Fearchair Donn in the two-and-thirtieth year of his reign, when he is five-and-fifty years old; she is his only child to live.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 244** — *Flood at Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). In a wet spring the river at Seann Vell on the south-east coast breaks its banks and carries away the lower mills. The mill-wrights build them again on the higher bank.
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 244** — *A pupil reports the flood at Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). A pupil of the Ros gheal house, present on other business when the river at Seann Vell breaks its banks and carries away the lower mills, calls the flood a kind of overfed hawk; Gormshuil tells him plainly that a river is a river and not a hawk, and sends him back to watch the mills rebuilt before he judges further.¹⁶
- 12 AM MÀRT, LE 247** — *Death of Gormshuil nic Artair* (Cnoc bheag). Gormshuil dies at Cnoc bheag, two-and-sixty years old, in the season the house at Ros gheal marks its own eighth year, and is buried, at her own asking, on the open hillside beside her father rather than within the hall her own teaching raised.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 251** — *Ùisdean mac Pàdraig marks the sayings he did not hear* (Cnoc bheag). Gathering Gormshuil's teaching into a single book, Ùisdean mac Pàdraig travels as far as Ros gheal to set down what her pupils remember, marking plainly every saying he did not hear from her own mouth; when the book is finished the marked sayings far outnumber the rest.

11. → Caused by *A hawk overfed will not come to the glove*, 21 an Gearran, LE 215; → Caused by *Gormshuil calls Mòd down alone for the first time*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, LE 218; → Caused by *Death of Artair, hawk-keeper of Cnoc bheag*, 6 an t-Samhain, LE 220; ← Leads to *Gormshuil first names the vein An Seabhaig Acrach*, 8 an Dàmhair, LE 221; ← Leads to *Hawk-keepers of the north coast come to hear her*, 31 am Màrt, LE 225; ← Leads to *Bàgh an t-Seabhaig elder questions Gormshuil's own hunger*, 29 an Giblean, LE 225.

12. ← Follows from *Gormshuil of the Hawk*, 20 an Giblean, LE 229.

13. the house of the Hawk

14. ← Follows from *Gormshuil of the Hawk*, 20 an Giblean, LE 229.

15. → Leads to *The hawk-house at Ros gheal*, 22 am Màrt, LE 239.

16. ← Follows from *Flood at Seann Vell*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 244.

- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 251** — *The sayings of Gormshuil written* (Cnoc bheag). After Gormshuil's death her sayings are written at Cnoc bheag as Leabhar an t-Seabhaig¹⁷, the Book of the Hawk. The copyist, Ùisdean mac Pàdraig, marks every saying he did not hear from her own mouth, and these are the greater part.¹⁸
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 256** — *The death of King Fearchar Donn* (Cathair dhearg). Fearchar Donn dies at Cathair dhearg in his sixty-eighth year, the last of his own riding to Taigh na Fèithe¹⁹'s winter burning long past. His daughter Sileas, thirteen years old, is judged too young to be crowned, and the heads of the seven custodian houses take the hall in her name by turns.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 258** — *Sileas nic Fhearchair crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Sileas, fifteen years old, is crowned at Cathair dhearg with the same cup and the same oath as her father before her. The heads of Na Seachd Taighean²⁰ swear over her hands to hold the vein and its right as it has always been held.
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 259** — *The storm that took Seann Toll's boats* (Seann Toll). A northern storm, named Am Fuath Mòr²¹ in the harbour rolls, breaks the harbour wall of Seann Toll and sinks forty boats at their moorings. Eighteen fishers drown.
- II AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 259** — *Raghnall mac Nèill in the water at Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). In the storm the north coast calls Am Fuath Mòr²², Raghnall mac Nèill, reeve of Seann Toll, thirty-four years old and four years in office, stands knee-deep on the strand hauling on a rope with three other men to bring in a boat with two children lashed inside it.²³
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 259** — *The dead of Am Fuath Mòr²⁴ buried on the headland* (Seann Toll). Seann Toll buries the eighteen who drowned trying to save the boats in a single row on the headland above the broken wall, a row so long that the reeve keeping the count loses his place twice and begins again.²⁵
- 14 AN GEARRAN, LE 260** — *The queen weds Dùghall mac Ìomhair* (Cathair dhearg). Sileas takes a consort of her own choosing, Dùghall mac Ìomhair of the eastern hill-house Clann Ìomhair, whom she has known since the years of her regency. Na Seachd Taighean²⁶ heads attend the wedding at Cathair dhearg.

17. the Book of the Hawk

18. → Caused by *Death of Gormshuil nic Artair*, 12 am Màrt, LE 247; ← Leads to *Ùisdean mac Pàdraig marks the sayings he did not hear*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, LE 251.

19. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

20. the seven houses of custody

21. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

22. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

23. ← Follows from *The storm that took Seann Toll's boats*, 23 an t-Samhain, LE 259.

24. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

25. ← Follows from *The storm that took Seann Toll's boats*, 23 an t-Samhain, LE 259.

26. the seven houses of custody

- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 261** — *Seann Toll walls its harbour again* (Seann Toll). Seann Toll builds its harbour wall again, higher and with a hooked end, to a plan the reeve had from the masons of the capital. The wall stands through every storm of this age.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 261** — *The walls of Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Clann Ìomhair, who hold the land about Dùn dhearg in the eastern hills, wall it in stone. These are the first walls on the island raised by a custodian house and not by the crown.²⁷
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 261** — *Queen Sileas's measures* (Cathair dhearg). Sileas nic Fhearchair, crowned after her father Fearchar Donn, fixes one measure for grain across the island, the firlot of Cathair dhearg, so that barter between shires need not begin with a quarrel over the size of a basket. Firlots of oak bound with iron are sent to every shire seat.²⁸
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 261** — *A cold supper at An Talla Dearg*²⁹ (Dùn dhearg). Sileas summons the head of Clann Ìomhair to a supper at Cathair dhearg after his house walls Dùn dhearg without the crown's leave. Neither speaks plainly of the walls; both understand what is meant by everything left unsaid, and the walls stand unopposed.³⁰
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 261** — *The quarrel over a basket at the capital's market* (Cathair dhearg). Watching a farmer and a grain-seller come near to blows below An Talla Dearg³¹ over the true size of a basket, Sileas is put in mind of a like quarrel she watched as a child, and resolves that one measure alone shall serve the whole island.³²
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, LE 262** — *The firlots carried to the shire seats* (Cathair dhearg). Oak firlots bound with three iron hoops, each cut to the capital's standard and marked with the queen's own mark, go out by cart from Cathair dhearg to every shire seat on the island, so that a basket weighed true at the capital weighs true anywhere a Dia-thìrich stands to sell or buy.³³
- 15 AM MÀRT, LE 270** — *The first quarrel settled by the firlot* (Àth shean). At Àth shean a carter and a miller who have fallen out over a load of oats are measured true against the town's firlot before a crowd their shouting drew, and the matter is settled before either of them thinks to shout further.³⁴
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 270** — *Birth of Uisdean mac Dhubhaill* (Cathair dhearg). Sileas and Dùghall's son Uisdean is born at Cathair dhearg, a quiet and watchful child who is one day to follow his mother in the hall.

27. → Caused by *The queen weds Dùghall mac Ìomhair*, 14 an Gearran, LE 260.

28. ◇ Same person *Birth of Sileas nic Fhearchair*, 25 an t-Iuchar, LE 243; → Caused by *The death of King Fearchar Donn*, 21 an Dàmhair, LE 256; → Caused by *Sileas nic Fhearchair crowned*, 26 an t-Iuchar, LE 258.

29. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

30. ← Follows from *The walls of Dùn dhearg*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 261.

31. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

32. → Leads to *Queen Sileas's measures*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 261.

33. ← Follows from *Queen Sileas's measures*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 261.

34. ← Follows from *Queen Sileas's measures*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 261.

- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 284** — *Tally-houses in the royal granaries* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Sileas sets a tally-house in each royal granary, where every exchange of grain for cloth, salt or labour is cut on paired sticks, one for each party. It is the first reckoning of trade across the whole island, and it runs without coin.
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 284** — *A trader questions the tally-stick at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). At the granary tally-house a trader of the long city asks the clerk what stops a false notch being cut after a bargain is struck, and is shown how the grain of a split stick runs true only when its two halves are laid together again.³⁵
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 287** — *The market charter of Cathair fhada* (Cathair fhada). Queen Sileas grants Cathair fhada a market on its ridge at every full moon, with a tally-house for the south; it is the first market right cut on paired sticks. The merchants of the long city carry the honey, hemp, wax and pots of the south to the capital, and begin to go as one company to the harvest fair at Muileann òg.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 287** — *The first full-moon market at Cathair fhada* (Cathair fhada). Under the new charter the long city holds its first market timed to the full moon, and traders come from three days' walk in every direction to carry honey, hemp, wax and pottery north as one company.³⁶
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 289** — *Drochaid Cathair dhearg*³⁷ *widened* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg). The old stone bridge over Abhainn dhomhain at Cathair dhearg is widened for two carts to pass. Queen Sileas's name is cut on the downstream parapet, and may still be read there.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 289** — *The bridge of Cathair dhearg widened* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg³⁸). The old stone bridge over Abhainn dhomhain at Cathair dhearg is widened for two loaded carts to pass abreast, and the queen's name is cut into the downstream parapet without her asking for it.³⁹
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 289** — *Sileas rides to the widened bridge with her son* (Cathair dhearg). On a grey morning in Bearnach Queen Sileas rides down to see Drochaid Cathair dhearg⁴⁰ finished, widened for two carts abreast, forty-six years old, with her son Uisdean, nineteen, riding at her side.⁴¹
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 300** — *Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn on the carters' roads*. Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn, a druid of the schools of Flidais who has walked the roads of the middle shires for the better part of forty years, carries the stag's teaching from house to house with a stick, a satchel of writing-boards and no fixed hearth.

35. ← Follows from *Tally-houses in the royal granaries*, 22 an t-Sultain, LE 284.

36. ← Follows from *The market charter of Cathair fhada*, 17 an t-Samhain, LE 287.

37. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

38. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

39. ← Follows from *Drochaid Cathair dhearg widened*, 21 an Dàmhair, LE 289.

40. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

41. ← Follows from *Drochaid Cathair dhearg widened*, 21 an Dàmhair, LE 289.

THE YEARS LE 301 – 400

- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 304** — *The crossing days of the panthers* (Imrich nam Pantar¹). In the southern hills near Imrich nam Pantar the herders keep the panther roads clear on the days the great cats cross, and drive their flocks off the paths beforehand. The crossing days are the first thing the southern shires agree on in writing.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 304** — *An Leòmhann Buidhe² on the north road* (An Leòmhann Buidhe). An Leòmhann Buidhe, a road-house on the northern mining road, serves the coal-carters oatcakes fried in linseed oil, and fire water. Its keeper is fined for watering the fire water.³
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 304** — *Coinneach among the panther-herders* (Imrich nam Pantar⁴). Travelling south into the panther country in the season of the crossing, Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn finds a whole valley emptied of flocks and every gate on the panthers' path standing open. An old herdsman tells him the herders have kept the days of the crossing longer than any living memory can number, and ask no more of it than that.⁵
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 304** — *Coinneach hears the carters' grumbling at An Leòmhann Buidhe⁶* (An Leòmhann Buidhe). At the road-house of An Leòmhann Buidhe, Coinneach overhears a coal-carter complain that the northern galleries want two men to a face where one once sufficed, and begins, without deciding to, keeping a private count of how often the like is said to him on the road.⁷
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 305** — *Coinneach speaks with the teachers at Muileann chiar* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁸). In the sacred wood of Flidais at Muileann chiar, Coinneach tells the schools' elder teachers what he has gathered on the roads. Beathag nic Ruairidh names it a half question asked a thousand times, and tells him the schools want a fixed ground where it may be argued whole.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 310** — *Coinneach walks the bounds of the schools' wood* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁹). Coinneach walks the boundary stones of the sacred wood at Muileann chiar alone, as the schools' teachers do once in a lifetime, and comes out of it resolved to build a fixed house for the question he has carried, rather than carry it hearth to hearth any longer.

1. the panthers' crossing

2. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

3. → Caused by *Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn on the carters' roads*, 21 an Dàmhair, LE 300.

4. the panthers' crossing

5. ○ Same place *The crossing days of the panthers*, 26 an t-Iuchar, LE 304.

6. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

7. ○ Same place *An Leòmhann Buidhe on the north road*, 24 an Lùnastal, LE 304.

8. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

9. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

- 29 AN CÈITEAN, LE 314** — *The house of disputation at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn, a druid of the schools of Flidais, lady of the deer, founds a house of disputation at Dùn thais, where the old question of the schools, Carson an làmh seo?, why the vein answers some hands and not others, is argued by rule. Pupils come from as far as Caol bheag.¹⁰
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 314** — *Taigh na Deasbaid*¹¹ *raised at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn raises a hall of stone and turf at Dùn thais, Taigh na Deasbaid, and has the schools' old question, Carson an làmh seo?, cut into its lintel before the roof is finished. A rule is set: a question, once put, is argued a full year before any answer is given from the master's chair.¹²
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 318** — *Pupils come from Caol bheag* (Caol bheag). Word of the house at Dùn thais reaches the coast, and pupils begin walking three days from Caol bheag to sit its benches, sent by parents who have heard, by trader and carter, that a hard question is argued there properly. Among them is a fisherman's son, Aonghas mac Nèill, who stays to keep the house's register.¹³
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 320** — *Beathag nic Ruairidh visits the finished house* (Dùn thais). Beathag nic Ruairidh comes down from the grove of Muileann chiar to see the house Coinneach has built, walks its length in silence, and tells him afterward that the ground he has raised is fixed and patient enough, and asks only how long he means to let it argue safe things before he sets it the one question it was truly raised for.¹⁴
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 322** — *Birth of Uisdean mac Uisdein* (Cathair dhearg). A son, named Uisdean for his father, is born at Cathair dhearg to Uisdean mac Dhùghaill, then two-and-fifty years old and still waiting on his mother's long reign.
- I AN GIBLEAN, LE 324** — *Coinneach's question* (Dùn thais). In open disputation Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn asks whether the hands that went with the fleet were those the vein answered best, and whether it now answers fewer. The seven houses forbid the question at their own tables; it is the first time they forbid a question and not a deed.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, LE 324** — *Baile Mòr mhòr grows* (Baile Mòr mhòr). After a run of poor seasons Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern plain takes in families from the upland farms and doubles within a generation. Its reeve divides the common grazing anew.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 324** — *Death of Queen Sileas* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Sileas nic Fhearchair dies at Cathair dhearg after a reign of more than fifty years. Her son Uisdean mac Dhùghaill is crowned.¹⁵

10. → Caused by *Coinneach speaks with the teachers at Muileann chiar*, 2 an t-Samhain, LE 305; → Caused by *Coinneach walks the bounds of the schools' wood*, 4 an Dàmhair, LE 310.

11. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

12. ○ Same place *The house of disputation at Dùn thais*, 29 an Cèitean, LE 314.

13. ← Follows from *The house of disputation at Dùn thais*, 29 an Cèitean, LE 314.

14. ← Follows from *The house of disputation at Dùn thais*, 29 an Cèitean, LE 314.

15. → Caused by *Birth of Uisdean mac Dhùghaill*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, LE 270; ◇ Same person *Birth of Uisdean mac Uisdein*, 26 am Faoilleach, LE 322.

- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 324** — *Coinneach asks the forbidden question* (Dùn thais). Before a full hall at Dùn thais, Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn asks at last whether the hands that went with the fleet were those the vein answered best, and whether it answers fewer now. No one on the benches answers him, and he sets the question, unanswered, into the house's register.¹⁶
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 324** — *The houses' ban carried to their tables*. Word of Coinneach's question travels shire to shire until it has reached every one of the seven custodian houses, and each in its own hall forbids the question at its own table: the first time the seven have forbidden a question rather than a deed.¹⁷
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 324** — *The reeve divides the grazing at Baile Mòr mhòr anew* (Baile Mòr mhòr). After a run of poor upland seasons, Baile Mòr mhòr has taken in so many families from the failing farms that the town has all but doubled, and its reeve marks out shares of the common grazing for households that never held a share of it before.¹⁸
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 324** — *Death of Queen Sileas nic Fhearchair* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Sileas nic Fhearchair dies at Cathair dhearg, one-and-eighty years old, in An Talla Dearg¹⁹ where she had reigned longer than any ruler before her, a reign of six-and-sixty years begun when she was crowned at fifteen, too young by the houses' own custom to take the crown at once.²⁰
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 324** — *Uisdean mac Dhùghaill crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean mac Dhùghaill, Sileas's son, no young man himself by then, is crowned at Cathair dhearg in his mother's place before the season turns. The crown's scribes set his crowning and her death on the same board, one line after the other, as though the two were a single piece of news.²¹
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 324** — *Coinneach walks home from the ban* (Dùn thais). Learning how Na Seachd Taighean²² have answered his question with a wider silence than his own, Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn walks the carters' road out from Dùn thais alone into the dark, and tells no pupil, then or after, what he has thought on the road.²³
- 24 AM MÀRT, LE 335** — *Iain mac Ùisdein set to his father's toll* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). A boy of Drochaid Ros fhionn is set to sit the bridge with the tally-stick and learn his letters between carts, the office his father and grandfather held before him over the stone crossing above Ros fhionn.

16. ← Follows from *Coinneach's question*, 1 an Giblean, LE 324.

17. ← Follows from *Coinneach's question*, 1 an Giblean, LE 324.

18. ← Follows from *Baile Mòr mhòr grows*, 30 an Giblean, LE 324.

19. the red hall, the rich's hall at Cathair dhearg

20. ○ Same place *Death of Queen Sileas*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, LE 324.

21. ← Follows from *Death of Queen Sileas*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, LE 324.

22. the seven houses of custody

23. ↓ Legacy *Coinneach's question*, 1 an Giblean, LE 324.

- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 335** — *A reeve turns back from the pastures of Doire uaine before dark* (Marbh-bheò²⁴ Doire uaine). A reeve sent from the shire seat to argue the shepherds of Doire uaine out of their custom of lighting no fires on the high pastures comes down again before dark the same day, and never returns to press the argument.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, LE 344** — *The deep hull that would not float true* (Inis àrsaidh). A merchant of Inis àrsaidh has a deep-keeled hull built for the long coast run eastward. The wrights no longer remember how Alasdair Saor scarfed his keels; the hull lists so badly at launch that it is broken up for timber.
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 344** — *Ruairidh mac Artair's deep hull built at Inis àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh). A merchant of Inis àrsaidh pays wrights to lay a deep-keeled hull for the long coast run, in the manner remembered of the fleet's own building. No wright of the day still holds the old scarfing of the keel timbers that let those hulls flex to a sea.²⁵
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 344** — *The hull that would not ride true* (Inis àrsaidh). Ruairidh's hull lists at launch past any righting and is broken up for timber within the fortnight; none of the old builders' lore of the keel's joinery survives among the wrights who raised her. No one is hurt in the breaking-up.²⁶
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 344** — *Coll of Inis àrsaidh on the lost scarfing*. Coll, the oldest wright at Inis àrsaidh, looks over Ruairidh mac Artair's listing hull and says that no wright now living holds the old joinery of the keel that let the fleet's hulls flex to a sea; nobody has asked for it in three hundred years.²⁷
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 350** — *Brine springs found on the flats above Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). A farmer digging a drainage ditch above Ros fhionn strikes warm water that tastes of salt. Within a season the district's own folk have laid out shallow pans on the flats to catch the brine.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 352** — *Death of Uisdean mac Dhùghaill* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean mac Dhùghaill dies at Cathair dhearg in his two-and-eightieth year, and his son Uisdean mac Uisdein, already thirty, is crowned without dispute. The tidings reach the northern flats by a rider bound for the shire seat.
- 3 AM MÀRT, LE 354** — *Salt pans at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The river town of Ros fhionn in the north-east lays out salt pans at the brine springs on its river flats and sends salt inland over Drochaid Ros fhionn. Within a generation Ros fhionn salt is the common measure of worth in the north-eastern shires.²⁸
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 361** — *The wool of Baile gharbh* (Baile gharbh). The weavers of Baile gharbh make a heavy undyed cloth that sheds rain, and it becomes the common cloak of the north-east. In this cloth the white sorrow is kept.

24. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

25. → Leads to *The deep hull that would not float true*, 2 an Gearran, LE 344.

26. → Leads to *The deep hull that would not float true*, 2 an Gearran, LE 344.

27. ← Follows from *The deep hull that would not float true*, 2 an Gearran, LE 344.

28. → Caused by *Brine springs found on the flats above Ros fhionn*, 29 an t-Samhain, LE 350.

- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 361** — *Baile gharbh's rain-cloth worn for mourning in the north-east* (Baile gharbh). The heavy undyed cloth of Baile gharbh, already the common rain-cloak of the north-east, becomes the district's own cloth of mourning, worn plain and undyed through a household's season of loss as the whole island once wore an Tùrsa Geal^{29, 30}.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 369** — *Salt over Drochaid Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). So many salt carts cross Drochaid Ros fhionn that the bridge-keeper is granted a handful from each load. His salt-box is said to hold more than some villages' granaries.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 369** — *The bridge-keeper granted a handful from every load* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The shire seat grants the keeper of Drochaid Ros fhionn a handful of salt from every load crossing the bridge, in place of any other toll. Iain mac Ùisdein keeps the due honestly and becomes known along the road for it.³¹
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 372** — *Birth of Aonghas mac Uisdein* (Cathair dhearg). A son, Aonghas, is born at Cathair dhearg to Uisdean mac Uisdein in the twentieth year of his reign, when the king is fifty years old.
- 16 AN GEARRAN, LE 375** — *The bridge-keeper's salt-box* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). Iain mac Ùisdein builds an iron-bound oak box beside his stool to hold his due of salt. It fills faster than any box on that road was thought able to fill, and carters along the way say it holds more against a hard winter than some whole villages.
- 27 AN CÈITEAN, LE 379** — *The wells crack at Cill ghlais* (Scàineadh Cill ghlais³²). An earth tremor in the hills about Cill ghlais cracks three wells and brings down a byre. The custodians of the vein-house note it, and note that the galleries were untouched.
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 379** — *The wells crack at Cill ghlais* (Cill ghlais). An earth tremor cracks three wells and brings down a byre at Cill ghlais. The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe³³ send men into the galleries below and find the deep workings untouched, though the diggers speak among themselves of feeling the shaking reach them under the hill.³⁴
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 380** — *Taigh na Fèithe³⁵ offers stone for Cill ghlais's byre* (Cill ghlais). The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe offer stone from their own surplus to rebuild the byre brought down at Cill ghlais, a kindness the village does not forget.
- 18 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 380** — *Mòr nic Nèill made tutor to the king's son* (Cathair dhearg). Mòr nic Nèill is set over the young Aonghas mac Uisdein to teach him his letters as a child, the first time any heir to An Talla Dearg³⁶ has been given a tutor for the purpose rather than left to pick up his letters between other business.

29. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

30. → Leads to *The wool of Baile gharbh*, 18 an t-Sultain, LE 361.

31. → Leads to *Salt over Drochaid Ros fhionn*, 20 an Lùnastal, LE 369.

32. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlais'

33. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

34. → Leads to *The wells crack at Cill ghlais*, 27 an Cèitean, LE 379.

35. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

36. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 26 AN GIBLEAN, LE 394** — *The Hollow Man spoken of again* (Marbh-bheò³⁷ Doire uaine). The shepherds of the Doire uaine hills will light no fires on the high pastures, for the old inscriptions of Marbh-bheò Doire uaine. A reeve sent from Muileann chiar to make them see sense does not stay the night.³⁸
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, LE 394** — *Aonghas mac Uisdein crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean mac Uisdein dies, the son of Uisdean mac Dhùghaill and king after him, and his own son Aonghas mac Uisdein is crowned at Cathair dhearg, a young man of twenty-two. Aonghas is the first king to learn his letters as a child.³⁹
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 394** — *Àth fhiadhaich salt fish* (Àth fhiadhaich). Àth fhiadhaich begins to salt its catch with Ros fhionn salt and send it inland to the mining towns. From this time the mining shires eat salt fish in the lean season.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 394** — *Death of Uisdean mac Uisdein and the crowning of Aonghas* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean mac Uisdein dies at two-and-seventy after two-and-forty years in the hall. His son Aonghas, two-and-twenty and taught his letters as a child, is crowned at Cathair dhearg with less dispute than any crowning in living memory.⁴⁰
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 394** — *Àth fhiadhaich turns to Ros fhionn salt* (Àth fhiadhaich). The fishing town of Àth fhiadhaich, having lost catch to poor curing, begins sending carts north for Ros fhionn salt. From this year the mining shires to the south eat their salt fish cured with salt carried over Drochaid Ros fhionn.⁴¹
- 26 AM MÀRT, LE 400** — *Birth of Aonghas Òg* (Cathair dhearg). A son, named Aonghas for his father, is born at Cathair dhearg to King Aonghas mac Uisdein, eight-and-twenty years old and six years crowned.

37. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

38. → Caused by *A reeve turns back from the pastures of Doire uaine before dark*, 27 an t-Sultain, LE 335.

39. ◇ Same person *Birth of Aonghas mac Uisdein*, 5 an Lùnastal, LE 372.

40. → Leads to *Aonghas mac Uisdein crowned*, 25 an Cèitean, LE 394.

41. → Leads to *Àth fhiadhaich salt fish*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, LE 394.

THE YEARS LE 401 – 500

- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 403** — *An old watching family questions Dòmhnall mac Ailein's right to name the stone* (Inis thais). One of the families who have kept watch on the wolf-stone at Inis thais for generations sends its eldest to ask a net-maker preaching on the strand what right he has to put a new name on their old duty. He answers that he claims no watch of his own and has only said aloud what the family's own hands have been doing unnamed for years.
- 6 AN CÈITEAN, LE 405** — *Dòmhnall mac Ailein's first preaching on the strand* (Inis thais). A net-maker of Inis thais, thirty-five years old, begins telling the men who mend nets beside him that the town's old wolf-stone is Lia Fàil¹, and that its watching families are an Fhianna², sworn to keep the whole island as a wolf keeps its range. His hearers grow through the year into the first gathering of Òrd na Cloiche³ at Inis thais.
- 28 AM MÀRT, LE 409** — *Clach first preached at Inis thais* (Inis thais). Dòmhnall mac Ailein, a net-maker of Inis thais, where the wolf-sworn's stone Clach stands, preaches that the stone is Lia Fàil⁴, which cries out under the rightful king, and that its sworn guards are the Fianna, who keep the island as a wolf keeps its range. His hearers are the first congregation of Òrd na Cloiche⁵, the order of the Stone.⁶
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 415** — *A shipmaster of Inis thais sails north for slate* (Inis thais). Beathag nic Raoghnaill, a shipmaster who has carried wool and hides along the southern coast for twenty years, offers to fetch roofing slate for the wolf-stone's new hall herself rather than trust the errand to another. She returns a season later with a hull low under northern slate.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, LE 418** — *Slate brought by sea for the temple at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The northern slate Beathag nic Raoghnaill brought south is laid over the wolf-stone's new hall, the first roof on that coast built to outlast its own builder. The town remarks as much on the roof's cost as on its wonder.
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 419** — *The wolf-house at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The followers of Dòmhnall mac Ailein raise at Inis thais the first temple on the island to Lia Fàil⁷ by name. It is roofed with slate brought by sea from the north.⁸

1. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

2. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

3. the order of the Stone

4. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

5. the order of the Stone

6. → Caused by *An old watching family questions Dòmhnall mac Ailein's right to name the stone*, 6 an t-Sultain, LE 403; → Caused by *Dòmhnall mac Ailein's first preaching on the strand*, 6 an Cèitean, LE 405.

7. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

8. → Caused by *A shipmaster of Inis thais sails north for slate*, 12 an t-Iuchar, LE 415; → Caused by *Slate brought by sea for the temple at Inis thais*, 10 an Cèitean, LE 418.

II AN GIBLEAN, LE 420 — *The tide-horn of the wolf-stone shrine* (Inis thais). An Fhianna at Inis thais take up a horn blown at every turn of the tide, its blowing passed by lot among the watching households. Within a few years the town sets its morning's business by the horn without a thought for what it was first blown to mark.

7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 421 — *The naming of Lia Fàil⁹ carried inland by a hide-trader* (Inis thais). A fisherman of Inis thais who has heard Dòmhnall mac Ailein twice repeats the naming of Lia Fàil to three inland villages while selling hides that winter, none of which he visits again. The teaching spreads in threads too small to trace to their source.¹⁰

19 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 427 — *Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹¹ and an Fhianna¹² claim the same feast day at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The priests of Òrd an t-Seabhaig and an Fhianna both come to the harbour shrine at Caol leathan for the same morning's hours, Òrd an t-Seabhaig's reckoning and Òrd na Cloiche¹³'s vigil falling that year on the same day. Neither will give way.

29 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 429 — *Hawk and wolf at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The priests of the Hawk and the Fianna of the Stone both claim the harbour shrine at Caol leathan. The king's reeve divides its days between them, as the sacred woods were divided in the Holy Age, and the division holds.¹⁴

I AN LÙNASTAL, LE 429 — *Murchadh mac Ailpein divides the shrine's days* (Caol leathan). The king's reeve at Caol leathan, Murchadh mac Ailpein, halves the harbour shrine's hours between Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹⁵ and an Fhianna¹⁶, as the sacred woods of an older age were once divided, and nails the division on a strip of hide to the shrine door.¹⁷

28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 435 — *The market inside the new gate* (Seann Skell). Seann Skell on the Hawk bay is walled, and a market is granted inside the new landward gate, where amber, whale-oil, honey and the sheep of the northern moors are sold. The amber-workers of the bay swear to sell no rough amber outside the walls.

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 435 — *Birth of Iain mac Aonghais* (Cathair dhearg). A son, Iain, is born at Cathair dhearg to Aonghas Òg, the king's heir, then five-and-thirty years old; the old king, sixty-three, sees his grandson named at the yoke-poles of Macha's rite.

9. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

10. ↓ Legacy *Clach first preached at Inis thais*, 28 am Màrt, LE 409.

11. the Hawk order

12. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

13. the order of the Stone

14. → Caused by *Òrd an t-Seabhaig and an Fhianna claim the same feast day at Caol leathan*, 19 am Faoilleach, LE 427.

15. the Hawk order

16. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

17. → Leads to *Hawk and wolf at Caol leathan*, 29 am Faoilleach, LE 429.

- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 436** — *Ailig an Òir forfeits a season's amber* (Seann Skell). An amber-worker of Seann Skell on Bàgh an t-Seabhaig¹⁸ is caught selling rough amber outside the new walls against his own guild's oath, and is made by that guild to forfeit the whole season's gathering to the market fund rather than face the crown's reeve.¹⁹
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 440** — *Death of Dòmhnall mac Ailein* (Inis thais). Dòmhnall mac Ailein dies at Inis thais in his seventieth year, having taught on the strand five-and-thirty years without ever taking up an office in the order his hearers named after his teaching. An Fhianna carry him to the shrine and set him before it, not within it.²⁰
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 441** — *Macha at court* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas takes up the wood-watchers' rite of Macha, which keeps the two horses of one chariot, foaled on one night, Liath Macha the grey and Dubh Sainglenn the black: two horses, one yoke, light and dark two powers in balance, and the vein belonging to both. The court follows him, and Òrd Mhacha²¹, the order of Macha, becomes the order of Cathair dhearg and the crown.²²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 441** — *King Aonghas recalls his father's teaching on the two horses* (Cathair dhearg). Before he takes up Òrd Mhacha²³ rite himself, King Aonghas mac Uisdein recalls being told as a boy that one horse pulling alone draws a chariot only in a circle, and that it takes two, pulling together and never quite agreeing, to pull it straight.²⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 441** — *A councillor warns Aonghas against Òrd Mhacha*²⁵ rite (Cathair dhearg). An old councillor of An Talla Dearg²⁶ warns King Aonghas that a crown seen at a moor-custom may be asked by Na Seachd Taighean²⁷ why it will not be seen at theirs. Aonghas answers that any house is free to come and stand at a yoke-pole itself.²⁸
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 442** — *Half An Talla Dearg*²⁹'s household takes up the rite of Macha (Cathair dhearg). Within a year of King Aonghas standing at the yoke-pole of Òrd Mhacha³⁰ rite, half his own household has taken it up beside him, and Òrd Mhacha becomes from that year the order of Cathair dhearg without a quarrel fought over it.³¹

18. the Hawk bay

19. → Leads to *The market inside the new gate*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 435.

20. ← Follows from *Clach first preached at Inis thais*, 28 an Màrt, LE 409.

21. the order of Macha

22. → Caused by *King Aonghas recalls his father's teaching on the two horses*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441; → Caused by *A councillor warns Aonghas against Òrd Mhacha' rite*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441.

23. the order of Macha

24. → Leads to *Macha at court*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441.

25. the order of Macha

26. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

27. the seven houses of custody

28. → Leads to *Macha at court*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441.

29. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

30. the order of Macha

31. ← Follows from *Macha at court*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441.

- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 446** — *A quarryman's household first roofs in slate at Tobar dhearg* (Tobar dhearg). A family burned out in the fire at Tobar dhearg, a quarryman among them, is the first in the village to roof again in slate rather than thatch, judging that a man who cuts the stone has less excuse than his neighbours to sleep under straw.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, LE 446** — *The crown sends grain south after the fire at Tobar dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas sends what the crown's granaries can spare south to Tobar dhearg before the winter closes the roads, the village having lost most of its stores along with its roofs.
- 16 AM MÀRT, LE 446** — *King Aonghas returns to the yoke a second year* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas rides out to Òrd Mhacha³² rite a second spring running, judging that a thing done once by a king and not again is no rite at all, and stands again with a hand on each yoke-pole among the grey horse and the black.³³
- 28 AM MÀRT, LE 446** — *Fire at Tobar dhearg* (Tobar dhearg). Fire runs through the thatch of Tobar dhearg and burns most of the village. It is rebuilt with slate from the quarries nearby, and is known thereafter for its slate roofs.³⁴
- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 450** — *Death of King Aonghas mac Uisdein* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas mac Uisdein dies at Cathair dhearg in his seventy-eighth year, after six-and-fifty years crowned, having set Òrd Mhacha³⁵ rite of Macha as the crown's own custom. Leabhar a' Chùrain³⁶ gives him one line: the name, the year, and no more.³⁷
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, LE 450** — *Aonghas Òg crowned at fifty* (Cathair dhearg). Aonghas Òg mac Aonghais is crowned at Cathair dhearg the same season his father dies, fifty years old and no young man, for all his name.³⁸
- 19 AN GEARRAN, LE 460** — *Eilidh Dhubh begins to teach at Doire chiar* (Doire chiar). Eilidh nic Iain, taught in secret by her grandmother, begins to say aloud at Doire chiar the old teaching that the vein answers labour and not birth. She sets it down in a hand her mother taught her, and pupils begin to copy it for households too far off to hear her speak.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 460** — *Birth of Tormod Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). A son, Tormod, fair-haired from the cradle and so called Tormod Bàn, is born at Cathair dhearg to Iain mac Aonghais, five-and-twenty years old, in the tenth year of his grandfather Aonghas Òg's reign.

32. the order of Macha

33. ← Follows from *Macha at court*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441.

34. ← Leads to *A quarryman's household first roofs in slate at Tobar dhearg*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 446; → Caused by *The crown sends grain south after the fire at Tobar dhearg*, 9 an Gearran, LE 446.

35. the order of Macha

36. the custody-book of the vein-house

37. ← Follows from *Macha at court*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441.

38. ← Follows from *Macha at court*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441.

- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 471** — *Macha's priests in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*³⁹ (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag). The custody of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, shared since the Holy Age, passes by royal grant to the priests of Macha. The other claimants leave the wood without contest. Why is not told.
- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 471** — *Macha's priests granted Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*⁴⁰ (Cnoc bheag). The custody of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, held in common since An Aois Naomh⁴¹, passes by royal grant to the priests of Macha alone. The other claimants withdraw from the wood the same season without contest; why they go so quietly is not told.⁴²
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 471** — *Taigh na Fèithe*⁴³ *orders every copy of the tracts given up* (Muileann dhearg). Word of Eilidh Dhubh's tracts reaches the custodians' galleries at Muileann dhearg, and Taigh na Fèithe orders every copy brought in and given up, promising no penalty to any household that surrenders one freely before the season's end.
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 471** — *Some hundred tracts burned in Taigh na Fèithe*⁴⁴ *yard* (Muileann dhearg). Carriers gather some hundred hides and boards of Eilidh Dhubh's tracts from households across the north-east and burn them in Taigh na Fèithe yard at Muileann dhearg before the gathered custodians. Eilidh walks from Doire chiar to see it done, and says nothing.
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 475** — *A harvest gathering at Muileann chiar bears the tracts read* (Muileann chiar). Coinneach Odhar, taught his letters by Eilidh Dhubh to carry her teaching where she will not travel, reads the tracts aloud for the first time at a harvest gathering near Muileann chiar. Not every household takes to it easily, and a farmer's wife elsewhere warns that the teaching could get colliers killed.
- 11 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 479** — *The druid schools keep Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*⁴⁵ (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar). The druids of the schools take the keeping of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, the wood of Flidais's white stag, and walk its bounds each year. The walk becomes the one open rite of the schools.
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 479** — *Scoiltean nan Draoidhean*⁴⁶ *take up the walk of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*⁴⁷ (Muileann chiar). Scoiltean nan Draoidhean, holding no ground of their own since An Aois Naomh⁴⁸, take up the yearly keeping of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar at Muileann chiar, walking its bounds in a procession that grows within a decade into the one rite the schools still keep open to any who will walk with them.⁴⁹

39. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

40. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

41. the Holy Age

42. ← Follows from *Macha's priests in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*, 14 am Faoilleach, LE 471.

43. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

44. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

45. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

46. the druid schools

47. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

48. the Holy Age

49. ← Follows from *The druid schools keep Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*, 11 an t-Iuchar, LE 479.

- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 484** — *The drovers of Àth Chiar* (Àth Chiar). Drovers of Àth Chiar begin to drive cattle each year over the eastern hills to the mining towns. Theirs are the first roads on the island marked with cairns.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 484** — *Eilidh Dhubh's tracts* (Doire Chiar). At Doire Chiar Eilidh nic Iain, called Eilidh Dhubh, wakes again the teaching of the rival school of the Holy Age, that the vein answers labour and not birth, and sets it out in tracts that her pupils copy. The tracts are read aloud at harvest gatherings across the north-east.⁵⁰
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 484** — *The tracts burned at Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house commands every copy of Eilidh Dhubh's tracts brought to Muileann dhearg and burned, and some hundred are given up. Eilidh is not punished. She dies at Doire Chiar, still teaching.⁵¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 484** — *Death of King Aonghas* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas Òg, son of Aonghas mac Uisdein and crowned after him, dies at Cathair dhearg and is buried by the rite of Macha, the first king so buried. His son Iain mac Aonghais is crowned.⁵²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 484** — *King Aonghas Òg buried by the rite of Macha* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas Òg dies in the winter of his eighty-fourth year and is carried to his grave at Cathair dhearg by Òrd Mhacha⁵³ rite of Macha, the first king of the line so buried. His household stands at the yoke-poles of the two horses he rode out to see brought up together every spring of his reign.⁵⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 484** — *The drovers of Àth Chiar raise the first cairns* (Àth Chiar). The drovers who drive cattle each year from Àth Chiar over the eastern hills to the mining towns begin marking their road with a cairn at every day's stage, the first roads on the island so marked, so that a beast lost in mist or a driver new to the trade may find the way again unasked.⁵⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 484** — *Iain mac Aonghais crowned at nine-and-forty* (Cathair dhearg). Iain mac Aonghais is crowned at Cathair dhearg after his father Aonghas Òg is carried to his grave by Macha's rite, nine-and-forty years old, with three sons living.⁵⁶

50. → Caused by *Eilidh Dhubh begins to teach at Doire Chiar*, 19 an Gearran, LE 460; → Caused by *A harvest gathering at Muileann Chiar bears the tracts read*, 19 an Dàmhair, LE 475.

51. → Caused by *Taigh na Fèithe orders every copy of the tracts given up*, 21 an Lùnastal, LE 471; → Caused by *Some hundred tracts burned in Taigh na Fèithe yard*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 471.

52. ◇ Same person *Birth of Aonghas Òg*, 26 am Màrt, LE 400; ← Leads to *King Aonghas Òg buried by the rite of Macha*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484; ← Leads to *Iain mac Aonghais crowned at nine-and-forty*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484.

53. the order of Macha

54. ← Follows from *Death of King Aonghas*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484.

55. ← Follows from *The drovers of Àth Chiar*, 29 am Faoilleach, LE 484.

56. ← Follows from *Death of King Aonghas*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484.

- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 485** — *A hidden copy of the tracts kept at Doire Chiar* (Doire Chiar). A single hide of the tracts, in Eilidh Dhubh's mother's own hand, is kept whole in a hollow beam of Eilidh's house, given to no household but her own kin's. Eilidh shows it to no one outside her family, judging it kept for her mother's sake more than the country's.⁵⁷
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 490** — *Birth of Dùghall, Iain mac Aonghais's son by his second wife* (Cathair dhearg). King Iain mac Aonghais, his first wife some years dead, takes a second wife who bears him a third son, Dùghall, the first of his three sons born at An Talla Dearg⁵⁸ itself under a crown his father already wears.
- 27 AN GEARRAN, LE 496** — *Tormod Bàn crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Iain mac Aonghais dies after a short reign, and his son Tormod mac Iain, called Tormod Bàn for his white hair, is crowned at Cathair dhearg. The houses swear to him without dispute.⁵⁹
- 7 AM MÀRT, LE 496** — *Death of King Iain mac Aonghais* (Cathair dhearg). King Iain mac Aonghais dies at Cathair dhearg at one-and-sixty, twelve years crowned, the third king An Talla Dearg⁶⁰ has buried in a single generation. His second son Aonghas, nineteen, stands a pace back from the hall's centre at his brother Tormod's crowning.⁶¹

57. ← Follows from *The tracts burned at Muileann dhearg*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484.

58. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

59. ◇ Same person *Birth of Iain mac Aonghais*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, LE 435; ◇ Same person *Birth of Tormod Bàn*, 24 an t-Samhain, LE 460; → Caused by *Birth of Dùghall, Iain mac Aonghais's son by his second wife*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, LE 490.

60. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

61. → Leads to *Tormod Bàn crowned*, 27 an Gearran, LE 496.

THE YEARS LE 501 – 600

- 9 **AN GEARRAN, LE 505** — *Death of Eilidh Dhubh* (Doire chiar). Eilidh nic Iain, Eilidh Dhubh, dies at Doire chiar in her seventy-fifth year, still teaching within the hour of her death. Her pupils raise no stone over her, and Coinneach Odhar reads the tracts aloud at her graveside from the copy he has carried thirty years.¹
- 8 **AN LÙNASTAL, LE 509** — *Winter at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). An Taigh-seinnse Mòr on the central mining road becomes the house where the ox-teams of the mountain wait out the worst of the snow. Its keeper, Iain mac Mhurchaidh, builds them a second byre and keeps a book of the teams that lodged.
- 28 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 509** — *Iain mac Mhurchaidh raises a second byre at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Iain mac Mhurchaidh, keeper of the road-house at the halfway stage of the central mining road, raises a second byre against the growing traffic of the ox-teams and begins a careful book of every team that lodges there through the mountain snows.²
- 6 **AN T-SULTAIN, LE 514** — *The bell-founders of Muileann naomh* (Muileann naomh). A family of Muileann naomh casts the first bronze bell on Dia-thìr to hang in a hawk-house. It cracks in its first frost; the second holds.
- 1 **AN GEARRAN, LE 515** — *The second bell of Muileann naomh holds* (Muileann naomh). After the first bell cast for the hawk-house at Muileann naomh cracks in its first frost, the founders cast a second, thicker at the waist, and it holds, ringing thereafter at every measured burning kept at the house and at every turn of the coast's own reckoning of the year besides.³
- 5 **AM MÀRT, LE 519** — *An Gàire Dubh*⁴ (Cuan dhearg). A storm named in the south-coast rolls An Gàire Dubh, the Black Laugh, drives the sea over the waterfront of Cuan dhearg and spoils the season's salt fish. The town is built again a street further from the shore.
- 6 **AM MÀRT, LE 519** — *Tormod Bàn bears the tidings of An Gàire Dubh*⁵ standing (Cathair dhearg). Word of the sea driven over the waterfront of Cuan dhearg reaches An Talla Dearg⁶ nine days late by a rider who has ridden two horses to death. King Tormod Bàn, nine-and-fifty, hears it standing, as his scribes note he does only when a report troubles him past sitting.⁷

1. ← Follows from *The tracts burned at Muileann dhearg*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484.

2. ← Follows from *Winter at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr*, 8 an Lùnastal, LE 509.

3. ← Follows from *The bell-founders of Muileann naomh*, 6 an t-Sultain, LE 514.

4. the Black Laugh

5. the Black Laugh

6. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

7. ← Follows from *An Gàire Dubh*, 5 am Màrt, LE 519.

- 31 AM MÀRT, LE 519** — *The king sends grain south unasked* (Cuan dhearg). Before the roads close for the winter King Tormod Bàn sends grain south to Cuan dhearg, though its reeve has sent no asking, only the bare report of the water; the season's salt fish had spoiled on the racks below the town.⁸
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, LE 520** — *Cuan dhearg rebuilds a street back from the shore* (Cuan dhearg). After An Gàire Dubh⁹ drowns its waterfront, Cuan dhearg of the red cliffs rebuilds a full street back from the old shoreline, on ground no telling the town keeps says the sea has ever reached, and the new street holds.¹⁰
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 521** — *King Tormod visits Cuan dhearg's new street* (Cuan dhearg). King Tormod Bàn rides to Cuan dhearg to see its rebuilt street, the one journey of his reign made, his own scribes note, for a storm's sake alone rather than for a war, a crowning or a rite the crown was bound to keep.¹¹
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 525** — *A reciter of Clann na Ceiste¹² says Clann a' Chlachair¹³ at a naming* (Tobar dhìreach). At a naming among the wells of Tobar dhìreach, for a steward's son of the king's own household, the reciter Muireach mac Ailein says the line of An Clachair¹⁴ over the child rather than the long line of Somhairle that royal namings there have called on for generations.
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 526** — *The hawk-house at Muileann naomh* (Muileann naomh). Muileann naomh in the south becomes the southernmost house of the Hawk, and rings its bell at each measured burning. There the Hawk's teaching holds when it fades elsewhere in the south.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 526** — *Birth of Catriona nic Aonghais at Inis thais* (Inis thais). A daughter, Catriona, is born at Inis thais to Aonghas mac Iain, the king's brother, and his wife Mairead nic Ailein, the first child of that marriage to live past her own naming. King Tormod Bàn rides down himself to see her named.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 527** — *Muileann naomh draws pilgrims from further south* (Muileann naomh). Word of the hawk-house at Muileann naomh, where the old teaching is still given whole and unsoftened, carries south along the coast, and pilgrims begin to come to it from towns further south than any hawk-house had drawn from before.¹⁵
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 530** — *Death of Aonghas mac Iain* (Inis thais). Aonghas mac Iain, the king's brother, dies at Inis thais in his fifty-fourth year of a wasting sickness, King Tormod Bàn having ridden down to sit with him three days before the end. He is buried in the ground of that coast, at his own household's asking.

8. ← Follows from *An Gàire Dubh*, 5 am Màrt, LE 519.

9. the Black Laugh

10. ← Follows from *An Gàire Dubh*, 5 am Màrt, LE 519.

11. ← Follows from *An Gàire Dubh*, 5 am Màrt, LE 519.

12. the Children of the Question

13. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

14. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

15. ← Follows from *The hawk-house at Muileann naomh*, 13 an t-Sultain, LE 526.

- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 531** — *Mairead nic Ailein keeps her daughter from An Talla Dearg*¹⁶ (Inis thais). Offered a place under the king's own roof for her widowed household, Mairead nic Ailein keeps her daughter Catriona at Inis thais rather than raise her at Cathair dhearg, judging a fatherless girl better raised among neighbours than as a king's ward with an unnamed claim.
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 534** — *The king's sons drowned in Abhainn fhionn* (Abhainn fhionn). Both sons of King Tormod Bàn drown when a ferry overturns on Abhainn fhionn in spate. The king has no other child.
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 534** — *Iain Odhar cleared of blame for the ferry* (Abhainn fhionn). The ferryman Iain Odhar comes before the king's reeves to answer for the ferry's overturning, and is cleared: he judged the spate as he had judged the river a hundred times before, and no such flood had come down that crossing unwarned in his eleven years on the rope.¹⁷
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 534** — *A new ferry ordered a mile upstream* (Abhainn fhionn). King Tormod Bàn has the old ferry rope cut and burned and orders a second crossing built a mile upstream, where the ford-keepers judge the river safer in spate, and never crosses the Abhainn fhionn again without a rider sent ahead to test the current.¹⁸
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 535** — *Iain Odhar made keeper of the new crossing* (Abhainn fhionn). The king grants Iain Odhar a small holding above the new crossing, not as payment for the two lives the old ferry took, but as a keeper's fee, and the ferryman watches the new rope closely for the thirty years he has left to keep it.¹⁹
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 538** — *The three nearest the crown reckoned* (Muileann dhearg). In the fourth year after the ferry, the custodians of Taigh na Fèithe²⁰ cease to reckon quietly who stands nearest the crown: Dùghall Garbh the king's half-brother, Catriona nic Aonghais his niece, and Raghnaill Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill.
- 31 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 540** — *Raghnaill Ruadh made master of Taigh na Fèithe*²¹ (Muileann dhearg). The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe at Muileann dhearg choose Raghnaill Ruadh, head of Clann Raghnaill, as master over two men of longer service, judging that Taigh na Fèithe, which may soon answer to no clear crown, had better answer to the steadiest hand at hand.
- 2 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 541** — *A councillor asks King Tormod to name an heir* (Cathair dhearg). An old councillor of An Talla Dearg²² asks King Tormod Bàn, seven years after the ferry, whether he means to name one of the three standing nearest the crown before age chooses in his place. The king answers that he will hold the crown himself while breath allows it.

16. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

17. ← Follows from *The king's sons drowned in Abhainn fhionn*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, LE 534.

18. ← Follows from *The king's sons drowned in Abhainn fhionn*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, LE 534.

19. ← Follows from *The king's sons drowned in Abhainn fhionn*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, LE 534.

20. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

21. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

22. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 547** — *Death of Tormod Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). King Tormod Bàn dies at Cathair dhearg without naming an heir, and three claims are laid before the houses at once.²³
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 547** — *Tormod Bàn's last order* (Cathair dhearg). Dying at Cathair dhearg at seven-and-eighty, one-and-fifty years crowned, King Tormod Bàn gives his last clear order to the scribe beside him: that the boundary dispute at Àth chiar, unsettled after three seasons, go to the custodians to finish.²⁴
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 548** — *The houses hold the ball in common* (Cathair dhearg). Unable to agree on any one of the three claims laid before them, Na Seachd Taighean²⁵ hold An Talla Dearg²⁶ in common, the custodians sitting together in the crown's stead and keeping the kingdom's small business moving while the larger question of the crown stands unanswered.²⁷
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 552** — *The three claimants* (Cathair dhearg). The crown is claimed by Catriona nic Aonghais of Inis thais, niece of the late king; by Dùghall Garbh of Baile Mòr dhomhain, his half-brother; and by Raghnaill Ruadh, head of Clann Raghnaill and master of the vein-house. The seven houses divide among them, and the War of the Three Claimants begins.²⁸
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 552** — *Mairead nic Ruairidh bars the gate to all three* (Seann Warr). The heralds of Catriona nic Aonghais, Dùghall Garbh and Raghnaill Ruadh come one after another to the western gate of Seann Warr, and its reeve Mairead nic Ruairidh gives each the same answer: the town will open to trade and shut to hosts until the houses agree which claim to answer.²⁹
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, LE 553** — *Seann Warr shuts its gates* (Seann Warr). Seann Warr, the port nearest the capital on the west, shuts its gates to all three claimants and declares for none. Twice besieged in the war, it is taken by neither.³⁰
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 553** — *Seann Warr's first siege* (Seann Warr). Dùghall Garbh sits before Seann Warr a fortnight, cutting the eastern road, but its salt-pans and brine springs feed the town through the siege. Mairead nic Ruairidh sells his own host bread at the market rate until his carters cost him more than the town is worth, and he withdraws.³¹

23. → Caused by *A councillor asks King Tormod to name an heir*, 2 an t-Iuchar, LE 541.

24. ← Follows from *Death of Tormod Bàn*, 8 an t-Sultain, LE 547.

25. the seven houses of custody

26. the red hall, the rich's hall at Cathair dhearg

27. ← Follows from *Death of Tormod Bàn*, 8 an t-Sultain, LE 547.

28. → Caused by *Birth of Catriona nic Aonghais at Inis thais*, 2 an Dàmhair, LE 526; → Caused by *Death of Aonghas mac Iain*, 27 an t-Sultain, LE 530; → Caused by *Mairead nic Ailein keeps her daughter from An Talla Dearg*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, LE 531; → Caused by *The three nearest the crown reckoned*, 29 an Lùnastal, LE 538; → Caused by *Raghnaill Ruadh made master of Taigh na Feithe*, 31 an t-Iuchar, LE 540; → Caused by *The houses hold the ball in common*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, LE 548.

29. ← Follows from *The three claimants*, 21 an Giblean, LE 552.

30. → Caused by *Mairead nic Ruairidh bars the gate to all three*, 16 an t-Sultain, LE 552.

31. ← Follows from *Seann Warr shuts its gates*, 20 an Cèitean, LE 553.

- 22 AN GEARRAN, LE 554** — *The ford at Àth shean* (Àth shean). The host of Dùghall Garbh meets that of Ragnall Ruadh at the ford of Àth shean and breaks it. The custody-book counts some three hundred dead, most of them drowned in the ford.
- 25 AM MÀRT, LE 554** — *Dùghall crosses the shallows by night* (Àth shean). Guided by drovers who have used a hidden ford above Àth shean for forty years to move cattle untolled, Dùghall Garbh crosses his host in the dark and comes down on Ragnall Ruadh's camp from the landward side before dawn.³²
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 554** — *Catrìona's answer to the ford* (Cathair dhomhain). Hearing word of Ragnall's breaking at the ford, Catrìona nic Aonghais sends Dùghall Garbh an answer naming no alliance: Cathair dhomhain holds for him, not for her, and she will not thank him for taking it from under her siege lines.³³
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 554** — *Coinneach mac Ailein's household flees Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). Woken by fire in the night, Coinneach mac Ailein carries his daughter Seònaid and the year's seed-corn out of the burning village of Doire mhin, while his wife brings the two younger children and the loosed cow finds its own way into the dark.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 555** — *The burning of Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). Ragnall Ruadh's men in retreat burn the village of Doire mhin and its granary, to deny them to Dùghall. The villagers winter at Cathair mhòr on the charity of Macha's priests.³⁴
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 555** — *The Doire mhin folk at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). Forty-one burnt-out households of Doire mhin, walking six days south with what little they carried, are taken in at the temple of Macha in Cathair mhòr and fed through the winter on the temple's grain, without regard to whose claim they had favoured.³⁵
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 556** — *Seann Warr's second siege* (Seann Warr). Dùghall Garbh, better provisioned than before, sits a full month before Seann Warr. The town holds again, though the winter comes on hard behind the siege, until word reaches Dùghall that Catrìona has closed both gates of Cathair dhomhain, and he marches east.³⁶
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 556** — *The water gate of Cathair dhomhain is closed* (Cathair dhomhain). On the counsel of a harbour-master of her following, Catrìona nic Aonghais sends borrowed fishing coasters onto the loch by night to shut Cathair dhomhain's water gate as her lines already hold the land gate, and the siege begins to starve the city in earnest.
- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 557** — *The wells of Cathair dhomhain foul* (Cathair dhomhain). With no ground left beyond the walls to spare for burying, the dead of the siege lines are laid near the well-heads of Cathair dhomhain, and a sickness of the gut runs through the crowded streets and then through the garrison itself.

32. → Leads to *The ford at Àth shean*, 22 an Gearran, LE 554.

33. ← Follows from *The ford at Àth shean*, 22 an Gearran, LE 554.

34. ← Leads to *Coinneach mac Ailein's household flees Doire mhin*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, LE 554.

35. ← Follows from *The burning of Doire mhin*, 24 an t-Sultain, LE 555.

- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 557** — *The garrison of Cathair dbombhain freed on oath* (Cathair dhomhain). Catriona nic Aonghais takes the surrender of Niall Mòr mac Leòid on the fortieth day of the siege and lets his garrison march out between her silent lines, wounded and dead named and carried, on his sworn word not to take the field against her again.
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 557** — *The siege of Cathair dbombhain* (Cathair dhomhain). Catriona nic Aonghais besieges Cathair dhomhain, which had declared for Dùghall, and takes it after forty days, when its wells are fouled by the dead of the siege lines. She lets the garrison go free on their oath.³⁷
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 558** — *The hearths refused* (Muileann dhearg). Ragnall Ruadh, holding the vein-house, denies the measured handful of coal to every hearth and temple in the shires that stand against him. Hearths lit with the coal for generations go cold, and this deed turns more against him than any battle.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 558** — *The store-master's list* (Muileann dhearg). At Taigh na Fèithe³⁸ Ragnall Ruadh hands the store-master Eòghann mac Dhùghaill a board naming every hearth and temple in the shires that stand against him and orders none of them measured a handful. The carriers who had come up the white road go down again with empty baskets.³⁹
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 558** — *The temple fires of the cold shires go out* (Cathair mhòr). Without the measured handful, hearths and temple fires across the shires that stood for Catriona or Dùghall go grey through Dubhlas, among them the Macha temple at Cathair mhòr where the burned households of Doire mhin have wintered on charity, Seònaid nic Coinnich's family among them.⁴⁰
- 3 AM MÀRT, LE 559** — *The verse of the cold shires* (Cathair mhòr). A verse with no name to it goes about the cold shires that winter, sung over mended hearths and unmended ones alike: that no battle was lost, only the fire. It is remembered afterward as the first telling that named what Ragnall's refusal had done.⁴¹
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 559** — *The pact of Catriona and Dùghall* (Cathair dhomhain). Dùghall Garbh comes to Catriona nic Aonghais's camp with six men and no herald and offers to join their hosts against Ragnall Ruadh, saying that whichever of them wins the crown after this, it must not be a crown that can shut a door on a shire's hearths.
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 560** — *The battle of Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The hosts of Catriona and Dùghall, joined for the purpose, meet Ragnall Ruadh below Muileann chrom. Ragnall falls on the field, and the next day his own custodians open the vein-house.⁴²

36. ← Follows from *Seann Warr shuts its gates*, 20 an Cèitean, LE 553.

37. ⇌ At the same time *Catriona's answer to the ford*, 16 an t-Ogmhios, LE 554; → Caused by *The water gate of Cathair dbombhain is closed*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, LE 556; → Caused by *The wells of Cathair dbombhain foul*, 8 am Faoilleach, LE 557; ← Leads to *The garrison of Cathair dbombhain freed on oath*, 11 an t-Sultain, LE 557.

38. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

39. ⇌ At the same time *The hearths refused*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 558.

40. ← Follows from *The hearths refused*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 558.

41. ← Follows from *The hearths refused*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 558.

- 18 AM MÀRT, LE 560** — *Taigh na Fèithe*⁴³ *opened* (Muileann dhearg). The morning after Raghnaill Ruadh falls at Muileann chrom, his own custodians strike the seal from the store without waiting to be told which claimant now holds the mountain, and the carriers go up the white road again.⁴⁴
- 15 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 560** — *The first hearth relit* (Cathair mhòr). Word reaches Catriona at Taigh na Fèithe⁴⁵ that the temple fire at Cathair mhòr, built up all winter from borrowed turf and hedge-wood, has caught at last on coal from a carrier's basket, the first of the cold shires' hearths to burn again.⁴⁶
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 561** — *Death of Dùghall Garbh* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Dùghall Garbh dies at Baile Mòr dhomhain of the wounds he took at Muileann chrom. His followers go over to Catriona without further fighting.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 561** — *Dùghall Garbh dies of his wound* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Dùghall Garbh dies at Baile Mòr dhomhain of a cut taken below the arm at Muileann chrom that he hid from his own physicians for days. Catriona nic Aonghais rides three days to reach him and finds him already dead, his last words asking only whether Taigh na Fèithe⁴⁷ gates stood open.⁴⁸
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 561** — *Dùghall's captains come over unbidden* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Dùghall Garbh's captains, led by Artair mac Lachlainn, come to Catriona's camp within the fortnight and lay no terms before her, saying only that their dead lord had told them what he meant to do if the battle at Muileann chrom went their way, and that his word binds them still.⁴⁹
- 13 AM MÀRT, LE 562** — *Catriona Bhuadhach crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Catriona nic Aonghais is crowned at Cathair dhearg, and is known thereafter as Catriona Bhuadhach. So ends the War of the Three Claimants, after some ten years.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, LE 562** — *Catriona crowned at An Talla Dearg*⁵⁰ (Cathair dhearg). Catriona nic Aonghais is crowned at Cathair dhearg with little ceremony, the crown itself sent down under guard from Taigh na Fèithe⁵¹'s own custody. The seven heads swear to her in the old order, and she is called Catriona Bhuadhach from that year.⁵²

42. → Caused by *The pact of Catriona and Dùghall*, 5 an Lùnastal, LE 559.

43. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

44. ⇌ At the same time *The battle of Muileann chrom*, 14 am Faoilleach, LE 560.

45. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

46. ← Follows from *The battle of Muileann chrom*, 14 am Faoilleach, LE 560.

47. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

48. ⇌ At the same time *Death of Dùghall Garbh*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, LE 561.

49. ← Follows from *Death of Dùghall Garbh*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, LE 561.

50. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

51. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

52. ⇌ At the same time *Catriona Bhuadhach crowned*, 13 am Màrt, LE 562.

- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 562** — *Eòghann keeps Raghnaill's list unscraped* (Muileann dhearg). Eòghann mac Dhùghaill, still master of the store at Taigh na Fèithe⁵³, leaves Raghnaill Ruadh's list of refused hearths standing face to the wall in the storeroom and sends word, unasked, that the store will not go a season again without measuring the handful while he holds the beam.⁵⁴
- 12 AN GEARRAN, LE 565** — *The ruling of the hearth* (Muileann dhearg). Catriona Bhuadhach and the vein-house set down in law that no claimant, house or king may withhold the measured handful from any lawful hearth. It is the first law written to bind the custodians themselves.
- 23 AN GEARRAN, LE 565** — *The drafting of Riaghailt an Teallaich*⁵⁵ (Muileann dhearg). At Taigh na Fèithe⁵⁶'s own yard Catriona and the seven heads of the houses spend three days drafting one sentence binding any claimant, house or king from ever again withholding the measured handful. Eòghann mac Dhùghaill is called to testify what Raghnaill Ruadh said to him, and his flat account settles the argument the queen's own words could not.⁵⁷
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 565** — *The seven heads set their marks* (Muileann dhearg). Riaghailt an Teallaich⁵⁸ is entered into Leabhar a' Chùraim⁵⁹ beside Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁶⁰ in the same hand, and the seven heads of the houses set their marks to it one after another, Beathag nic Uisdein of Clann Ìomhair last and longest over her own mark.⁶¹
- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 565** — *Birth of Lachlann mac Iain* (Cathair dhearg). A son, Lachlann, is born at Cathair dhearg to Queen Catriona Bhuadhach, nine-and-thirty years old and three years crowned, and her husband Iain mac Eachainn.
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 566** — *Seònaid nic Coinnich comes to An Talla Dearg*⁶² (Cathair dhearg). Seònaid nic Coinnich, whose father Coinneach mac Ailein came through the winter of the refusal with a cough he never lost, walks up from Cathair mhòr to An Talla Dearg and is taken into the queen's household as a clerk, the first of several children of the cold shires the household shelters in those years.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, LE 567** — *Seònaid copies the tallies of the refusal* (Cathair dhearg). In her first winter at An Talla Dearg⁶³, Seònaid nic Coinnich asks to see Leabhar a' Chùraim⁶⁴'s oldest entries and copies out, unbidden, the tallies of the hearths refused in the winter of Na Teallaichean Fuara⁶⁵, a labour the queen never questions when she comes upon it by lamplight.

53. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

54. ← Follows from *The hearths refused*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 558.

55. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

56. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

57. ⇌ At the same time *The ruling of the hearth*, 12 an Gearran, LE 565.

58. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

59. the custody-book of the vein-house

60. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

61. ← Follows from *The ruling of the hearth*, 12 an Gearran, LE 565.

62. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

63. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

64. the custody-book of the vein-house

- II AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 580** — *The council questions Rathad na Banrighinn*⁶⁶ (Am Buabhall Fortanach). More than one head of house asks Catriona in open council why she spends so much of the treasury on a stone road to her own town of Inis thais. She answers that a kingdom bound by a law written in a cold yard ought to be bound also by roads a hard winter cannot cut, and the building goes on.
- IO AN CÈITEAN, LE 584** — *Catriona's road south* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Queen Catriona has the road south from the capital by Baile shean and Am Buabhall Fortanach at Doire shean laid with stone, that her own town of Inis thais may be reached in any weather. It is called Rathad na Banrighinn⁶⁷.⁶⁸
- I AN T-SULTAIN, LE 584** — *Rathad na Banrighinn*⁶⁹ *laid to Inis thais* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). The stone of Rathad na Banrighinn is finished south from the capital, past Am Buabhall Fortanach at Doire shean, all the way to Catriona's own gate at Inis thais, which she has ridden the length of twice while it was building to feel whether the stone held.⁷⁰
- 7 AN GEARRAN, LE 585** — *The first carters run Rathad na Banrighinn*⁷¹ (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Salt-carts and grain-carts run the full length of the new stone road within the year the last stone is laid, cutting the journey from three days to two. An old carter tells the household he drove it half-blind and felt the cart go steady the whole way, a thing the mire road never let him do.⁷²
- II AN GIBLEAN, LE 594** — *Seann Warr's gates honoured* (Seann Warr). In memory of its standing aside in the war, Queen Catriona grants Seann Warr the right to keep its own gates and take its own tolls. The grant is cut over the landward gate.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, LE 594** — *Death of Iain mac Eachainn* (Cathair dhearg). Iain mac Eachainn, the queen's husband, dies of a wasting in the chest no physician of the household can name. He had kept, through his years in An Talla Dearg⁷³, to the smaller business of the household and left the crown's affairs to Catriona.⁷⁴
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 594** — *Seann Warr's grant cut over the gate* (Seann Warr). In memory of its standing aside through the war and the two sieges it withstood, Catriona grants Seann Warr the right to keep its own gates and take its own tolls, and the grant is cut in stone letters over the landward gate.⁷⁵

65. the cold hearths

66. the queen's road

67. the queen's road

68. ⇌ At the same time *The council questions Rathad na Banrighinn*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, LE 580.

69. the queen's road

70. ⇌ At the same time *Catriona's road south*, 10 an Cèitean, LE 584.

71. the queen's road

72. ← Follows from *Catriona's road south*, 10 an Cèitean, LE 584.

73. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

74. ⇌ At the same time *Catriona's road south*, 10 an Cèitean, LE 584.

75. ⇌ At the same time *Seann Warr's gates honoured*, 11 an Giblean, LE 594.

26 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 600 — *Birth of Anna* (Cathair dhearg). A daughter, Anna, is born at Cathair dhearg to Lachlann mac Iain, the queen's son, then five-and-thirty; the old queen, seventy-four, lives to see her granddaughter walk.

THE YEARS LE 601 – 700

- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 602** — *Seònaid gathers the first three witnesses* (Cathair dhearg). At Queen Catrìona's own asking, her clerk Seònaid nic Coinnich takes down, in hurried hours snatched from the court's business, the first accounts of the war of the three claims: a soldier who fought at the ford, the son of Taigh na Fèithe¹'s store-master, and a woman of Doire mhin who remembers Na Teallaichean Fuara² as a child.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 604** — *Death of Catrìona Bhuadhbach* (Cathair dhearg). Catrìona Bhuadhbach dies at Cathair dhearg. Her son Lachlann mac Iain is crowned, and the houses swear to him in a single day, a thing the chroniclers remark on.
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 604** — *Death of Catrìona Bhuadhbach* (Cathair dhearg). Catrìona Bhuadhbach dies at Cathair dhearg at seventy-eight, the last ruler to have fought in Cogadh nan Trì Tagraichean³. Her son Lachlann mac Iain, not yet forty, succeeds her.⁴
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 604** — *Na Seachd Taighean⁵ swear in a single day* (Cathair dhearg). The seven heads of the houses swear to Lachlann mac Iain within a single day of his mother's burial, Beathag nic Uisdein of Clann Ìomhair first to kneel. Seònaid nic Coinnich, watching from the back of the hall, counts the swearings without meaning to and goes that evening to begin the opening words of her history of the war.⁶
- 19 AN GEARRAN, LE 612** — *Seònaid visits the harbour-house boards* (Seann Skell). Carrying a grant of harbour dues she did not need to carry in her own hand, Seònaid nic Coinnich asks the harbour scribe Ailean mac Mhurchaidh to show her the old boards of Rolla nan Deònach⁷, and rides home with an errand for herself she had not had when she set out.
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, LE 616** — *The store-master's board copied in full* (Muileann dhearg). Dòmhnall mac Eòghainn, who inherited his father Eòghann mac Dhùghaill's office at Taigh na Fèithe⁸'s store, lets Seònaid nic Coinnich copy in full the board of shires refused the coal in the year of Na Teallaichean Fuara⁹, a board his father kept face to the wall and never scraped clean.¹⁰
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, LE 618** — *The witness of Doire mhin heard in full* (Cathair mhòr). Seònaid nic Coinnich rides to Cathair mhòr to hear Mairead nic Aonghais, a woman of Doire mhin who was a child in the same charity and at the same temple as Seònaid herself, tell at length what a cold hearth was to a child too young to be told why it was cold.

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the cold hearths

3. the War of the Three Claimants

4. ⇔ At the same time *Death of Catrìona Bhuadhbach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 604.

5. the seven houses of custody

6. ← Follows from *Death of Catrìona Bhuadhbach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 604.

7. the roll of the willing

8. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

9. the cold hearths

10. ← Follows from *The hearths refused*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 558.

- 23 AN CÈITEAN, LE 619** — *Seònaid weighs Leabhar a' Chùraim*¹¹ against her witnesses (Muileann dhearg). At Taigh na Fèithe¹² Seònaid nic Coinnich sets her gathered testimony against Leabhar a' Chùraim's own entries of the war, and finds days, numbers and causes of death the book and the witnesses do not agree on; she resolves to keep both accounts rather than choose between them.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 619** — *Fearchar Ciar swears the ford broke on two days* (Muileann dhearg). Where Leabhar a' Chùraim¹³ gives the breaking at the ford of Àth shean as one day, the old soldier Fearchar Ciar swears to Seònaid nic Coinnich that it was two, the fighting taken up again at first light after a night neither side thought worth entering.¹⁴
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 623** — *King Lachlann reads his mother into the book* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann mac Iain finds Seònaid nic Coinnich at work on her history and asks whether it will say what his mother Catrìona was like; she answers that it will say what she did and what was believed of her, which is the most any book can give.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 624** — *The Book of the Three Claimants* (Cathair dhearg). Seònaid nic Coinnich, once a clerk of Queen Catrìona's household, writes the story of the war from the custody-book and from the witness of those who fought. It is the oldest history of Dia-thìr that survives written as one tale and not as entries.¹⁵
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 624** — *The sickness at Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). A spotted fever kills some forty at Inis chrom on the south-west coast. The Fianna of the Stone nurse the sick, and many of them die of it; thereafter the town is the Stone's.
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 624** — *Seònaid finishes Leabhar nan Trì Tagraichean*¹⁶ (Cathair dhearg). Seònaid nic Coinnich writes the last of the war's telling and sets down the finished leaves, the first history on Dia-thìr told as one tale from end to end rather than as separate entries.¹⁷
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, LE 625** — *Leabhar nan Trì Tagraichean*¹⁸ read at An Talla Dearg¹⁹ (Cathair dhearg). King Lachlann mac Iain has Seònaid nic Coinnich's finished history read into the record at An Talla Dearg and orders it copied again and kept, ruling that no later copy of it may ever be made shorter than the one before it.²⁰

11. the custody-book of the vein-house

12. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

13. the custody-book of the vein-house

14. ⇐ Answers *The ford at Àth shean*, 22 an Gearran, LE 554.

15. → Caused by *Seònaid nic Coinnich comes to An Talla Dearg*, 14 an Dàmhair, LE 566; → Caused by *Seònaid copies the tallies of the refusal*, 1 an Giblean, LE 567; → Caused by *Seònaid gathers the first three witnesses*, 21 an Faoilleach, LE 602; → Caused by *Seònaid visits the harbour-house boards*, 19 an Gearran, LE 612; → Caused by *The witness of Doire mbin beard in full*, 18 an Giblean, LE 618; → Caused by *Seònaid weighs Leabhar a' Chùraim against her witnesses*, 23 an Cèitean, LE 619; → Caused by *King Lachlann reads his mother into the book*, 21 an t-Ògmhios, LE 623.

16. the Book of the Three Claimants

17. ⇌ At the same time *The Book of the Three Claimants*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 624.

18. the Book of the Three Claimants

19. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 631** — *Death of Seònaid nic Coinnich* (Cathair dhearg). Seònaid nic Coinnich dies at Cathair dhearg at two-and-eighty, seven years after finishing her book, her last recorded word a complaint that the harbour-house's back room at Seann Skell wants a better roof before the damp takes its oldest boards.²¹
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 634** — *The oyster beds of Doire shean* (Doire shean). Doire shean, a village on the southern shore, lays out oyster beds in its shallow bay and sends oysters by cart to the capital. The trade makes it rich enough to be a shire seat.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 635** — *Birth of the heir of Anna* (Cathair dhearg). A child is born at Cathair dhearg to Anna, Lachlann mac Iain's daughter, then five-and-thirty years old; Clàr nan Rìghrean²² keeps the year of the birth and lets the child's name fall from every copy that survives.
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 644** — *The feast-market at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). The crowds that come to the ancestor shrine at Seann Tarr for the great feasts begin to hold a market on the three feast days, chiefly of honey, beeswax for the shrine lights, and the dyes of Baile fhiadhaich. The wax lights of Seann Tarr are soon burned at ancestor shrines all along the north-eastern coast.
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 654** — *Manannan preached at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell, where the sting-creed of the Holy Age first called itself the only true one, the preacher Mànas mac Ruairidh proclaims its one power to be Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, whose Cup of Truth bears the yellow scorpion. He teaches that Manannan shut the eastern sea behind the fleet with his mist, which hides Dia-thìr from every ship beyond it, and that the crossing must not be tried again. His hearers are the first congregation of Òrd Mhanannain²³, the order of Manannan.
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 654** — *Death of Lachlann mac Iain* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann mac Iain, son of Catrìona Bhuadhach, dies at Cathair dhearg, and his daughter Anna is crowned. The chroniclers call his reign quiet, and mean it as praise.²⁴
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 654** — *Ruairidh kneels first to Cupa na Firinne*²⁵ (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell, Ruairidh, a sworn-man of the harbour-court, crosses the quay stones and kneels before his own son Mànas mac Ruairidh, the first of the preaching's hearers to do so. Six other net-menders kneel after him before the tide has gone out much further.²⁶

20. ← Follows from *The Book of the Three Claimants*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 624.

21. ← Follows from *The Book of the Three Claimants*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 624.

22. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

23. the order of Manannan

24. ◇ Same person *Birth of Lachlann mac Iain*, 2 an t-Sultain, LE 565; ◇ Same person *Birth of Anna*, 26 an Dàmhair, LE 600; ← Leads to *Birth of the heir of Anna*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 635.

25. Manannan's Cup of Truth

26. ← Follows from *Manannan preached at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 654** — *Tidings of the king's death reach the quay* (Seann Skell). A rider watering his horse at Seann Skell's harbour-court brings word that Lachlann mac Iain has died at Cathair dhearg, eighty-nine years old after a reign of fifty quiet years, and that his daughter Anna, fifty-four, has been crowned in his place. Mànas mac Ruairidh is not recorded to have said anything of it.²⁷
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 655** — *The first boats blessed at Cidhe an Diosail*²⁸ (Seann Skell). A dozen coasters are brought up one after another to Cidhe an Diosail at Seann Skell, and Mànas mac Ruairidh passes a plain wooden bowl of harbour water over each hull in turn, speaking the words that harden, within his own lifetime, into the fixed form of the rite of blessing.²⁹
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 656** — *The harbour-court's scribe refuses the order's rite* (Seann Skell). Donnchadh mac Ailein, scribe of the harbour-court at Seann Skell, refuses to enter the blessings of Òrd Mhanannain³⁰ in Rolla a' Chalaidh³¹ beside the tallies of hulls and cargoes, holding a rite to be no business of a board kept for hulls. Mànas does not press the matter.³²
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 674** — *Manannan's order at Ros bheag and Cuan shean* (Ros bheag). Fishing families carry the teaching of Manannan's order down the west coast to Ros bheag and Cuan shean. At Cuan shean the rope-makers are among the first to turn to it.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 674** — *Tormod Ciar swears Cupa na Firinne*³³ *on the rope-walk* (Cuan shean). At Cuan shean, the old rope-walker Tormod Ciar, told by a travelling net-mender what Mànas mac Ruairidh preaches of the mist, swears Cupa na Firinne before his fellow walkers on the rope-walk itself, cupping rainwater in his own hands for want of a bowl, with no priest of the order present to hear him.³⁴
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 680** — *Taigh Mhanannain*³⁵ *raised at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Òrd Mhanannain³⁶ raises its own house at Seann Skell, Taigh Mhanannain, low and built of the same grey stone as the quay near the old harbour-court. The congregation raises the silver for a proper cup without being asked, to replace the plain wooden bowl Mànas has used since the first blessing.³⁷

27. ⇄ At the same time *Death of Lachlann mac Iain*, 30 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

28. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

29. ← Follows from *Manannan preached at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

30. the order of Manannan

31. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

32. ← Follows from *Manannan preached at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

33. Manannan's Cup of Truth

34. ← Follows from *Manannan's order at Ros bheag and Cuan shean*, 29 an Dàmhair, LE 674.

35. the house of Manannan

36. the order of Manannan

37. ← Follows from *Manannan preached at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 680** — *Birth of the fifth ruler of the house of Catrìona* (Cathair dhearg). A child is born at Cathair dhearg to Anna's heir, then five-and-forty years old, in the six-and-twentieth year of Queen Anna's reign; Clàr nan Rìghrean³⁸ keeps the year and not the name.
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 685** — *Death of Queen Anna* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Anna dies at Cathair dhearg at five-and-eighty, one-and-thirty years crowned, the last of the house of Catrìona whose name Clàr nan Rìghrean³⁹ keeps for more than a century.⁴⁰
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 685** — *The fourth ruler of the house of Catrìona crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Anna's heir is crowned at Cathair dhearg within the season, fifty years old. Clàr nan Rìghrean⁴¹ keeps the reign's years and not its name.⁴²
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 690** — *Death of Mànas mac Ruairidh* (Seann Skell). Mànas mac Ruairidh dies at Seann Skell in the house he raised, six-and-thirty years after his first preaching on the quay, and is buried at his own asking under a plain slab facing the harbour mouth. Beathag nic Dhonnchaidh, who kept his house, keeps Taigh Mhanannain⁴³ after him.⁴⁴
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 694** — *Within sight of land* (Ros bheag). The priests of Manannan at Ros bheag lay down that no boat of the faithful may go out of sight of the headlands. The rule is kept on the west coast for centuries, and steering by the stars, already half lost, is lost there wholly.
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 694** — *The rule of the headlands laid down* (Ros bheag). After a winter's debate, the priests of Òrd Mhanannain⁴⁵ at Ros bheag lay down that no boat of the faithful may sail out of sight of the headlands, on pain of answering for it before Cupa na Firinne⁴⁶. The rule holds on the west coast far beyond any one preacher's lifetime.⁴⁷
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 694** — *Coinneach mac Sheumais turned back within the year* (Ros bheag). Coinneach mac Sheumais, a skipper of Ros bheag, is turned back within the rule's first year by two of the order's own boats after taking his own boat further out than before, chasing a good run of fish. He never fishes so far out again.⁴⁸

38. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

39. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

40. ← Follows from *Death of Lachlann mac Iain*, 30 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

41. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

42. ← Follows from *Death of Lachlann mac Iain*, 30 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

43. the house of Manannan

44. ← Follows from *Manannan preached at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Sultain, LE 654.

45. the order of Manannan

46. Manannan's Cup of Truth

47. ⇌ At the same time *Within sight of land*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 694.

48. ← Follows from *Within sight of land*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 694.

24 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 698 — *Griogair cannot name his grandfather's star* (Ros bheag). A priest of Òrd Mhanannain⁴⁹ at Ros bheag asks a boy named Griogair, grandson of one of the last pilots to hold a course by night on that shore, which star his grandfather steered by. The boy cannot answer, and no one in his own house had thought to write the star's name down.⁵⁰

19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 699 — *The granaries of Àth shean rebuilt* (Àth shean). The royal granaries at Àth shean, standing since before the Sundering, are pulled down and built again in stone on raised floors against the rats. The tally-house is rebuilt with them.

2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 699 — *The granaries of Àth shean rebuilt* (Àth shean). The royal granaries at Àth shean, standing since before a' Scaradh⁵¹, are pulled down and rebuilt in dressed stone on raised floors against the rats, along with a new tally-house. Fearchar mac Phàdraig, the reeve who oversees the three-year labour, sees the shire's grain stand dry through its first winter.⁵²

49. the order of Manannan

50. ← Follows from *Within sight of land*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 694.

51. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

52. ⇌ At the same time *The granaries of Àth shean rebuilt*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, LE 699.

THE YEARS LE 701 – 800

- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 708** — *Murchadh Beag takes Eòghann mac Pheadair from the coal-face* (Muileann dhearg). The old scribe of Taigh na Fèithe¹, Murchadh Beag, hears a coal-breaker's young son recite back a whole day's cartage without once looking at the board, and asks the boy's father whether a household might spare him for a scribe's stool. Eòghann mac Pheadair is set to sweep Taigh na Fèithe floor and mix ink before he is let touch a leaf.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 714** — *The rope-walks shortened* (Cuan shean). Cuan shean takes up half its rope-walks and sows the ground with barley. The rope trade had lived on the fleet and then on the fishing, and the fishing no longer needs rope of such length.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 714** — *Taigh na Fèithe's leaf takes in the rope-ground sown with barley* (Muileann dhearg). Eòghann mac Pheadair, fourteen and newly trusted with a leaf of his own, enters the ground given up by Cuan shean's rope-walks for barley, the first entry he copies whose full sense Murchadh Beag has to explain to him. He learns that a scribe's business is the fact and the year, not the grief behind it.³
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 722** — *Death of the fourth ruler of the house of Catriona* (Cathair dhearg). The fourth ruler of the house of Catriona dies at Cathair dhearg at seven-and-eighty after seven-and-thirty years crowned, and the heir, two-and-forty years old, is crowned the same season.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, LE 724** — *Wave at Cnoc chaol* (Cnoc chaol). A great swell with no storm behind it runs up the beach at Cnoc chaol on the south coast and carries off the drying racks and two children. The village sets its racks higher up the shore.
- II AN T-IUCHAR, LE 724** — *Eòghann mac Pheadair at four-and-twenty* (Muileann dhearg). At four-and-twenty Eòghann mac Pheadair has old Murchadh Beag's stool at Taigh na Fèithe⁴ as good as his own, and enters the wave at Cnoc chaol on the general leaf as he enters every disaster that touches a household of the coal-right: names, place, day.⁵
- 10 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 725** — *A household of Cnoc chaol removes its gallery-claim from the shore* (Cnoc chaol). After the great wave that took two children from the beach at Cnoc chaol, the household of one of the drowned strikes itself from its old gallery and takes up a new claim further from the water. Eòghann mac Pheadair enters the removal on Taigh na Fèithe⁶'s leaf the following season, cold and plain as he was taught.⁷

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. → Leads to *The rope-walks shortened*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 714.

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

5. ← Follows from *Wave at Cnoc chaol*, 22 an Gearran, LE 724.

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

7. ← Follows from *Wave at Cnoc chaol*, 22 an Gearran, LE 724.

11 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 731 — *The market of the eastern road* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). Baile Mòr dhìreach, the citadel on the straight eastern road, is granted a market for the east coast. There the fish and sail-cloth of the coast towns meet the furs, hides and dyes of the hills, and the dyers of Baile Mòr ruadh sell their colours nowhere else.

23 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 731 — *Eòghann mac Pheadair witnesses the market bounds at Baile Mòr dhìreach* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). Sent east on his own feet for the first time, Eòghann mac Pheadair stands witness for Na Seachd Taighean⁸ when the crown's grant of a market is read at Baile Mòr dhìreach and its boundary stones set. He watches the first stalls go up the same afternoon and walks the road home slower than he walked out.⁹

10 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 738 — *Mòrag nic Ìomhair rides to Taigh na Fèithe*¹⁰ *with the crown's leaves* (Muileann dhearg). A scribe of An Talla Dearg¹¹'s own household, Mòrag nic Ìomhair, rides the thirty-nine miles to Taigh na Fèithe at Muileann dhearg to set the crown's reckoning of Bliadhnaichean an Diosail¹² against Leabhar a' Chùraim¹³'s own, after the two offices' counts are found not to agree. The master of Taigh na Fèithe grants her the book for as many days as the matter takes.

9 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 738 — *The fault in the count is found and cannot be mended* (Muileann dhearg). Working three days by lamplight, Eòghann mac Pheadair and Mòrag nic Ìomhair trace the two offices' counts of An Diosal¹⁴ back to a single year, early after An Diosal, entered twice by one office's habit or once by the other's. Neither leaf either scribe has brought can say which office erred, or whether either truly has.

23 AM MÀRT, LE 739 — *The two counts reconciled* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house and the crown's scribes find that their counts of years since the Setting-Out differ, and settle the difference by agreement. The same agreement fixes the day of the rite of the empty harbour, which each count had placed otherwise; later scribes cease to pretend it was fixed by proof.¹⁵

7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 739 — *The two counts settled by agreement, not by proof* (Muileann dhearg). Taigh na Fèithe¹⁶ and the crown's scribe take the crown's count for the reckoning that will go forward, since it touches more households than Taigh na Fèithe's own, and Eòghann mac Pheadair writes Taigh na Fèithe's agreement to it in his own hand. The master of Taigh na Fèithe's mark is set under his, and the crown scribe's office mark under that.

17

8. the seven houses of custody

9. → Leads to *The market of the eastern road*, 11 an t-Samhain, LE 731.

10. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

11. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

12. the years of the Diosal, counted from the sunwise turn

13. the custody-book of the vein-house

14. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

15. → Caused by *Mòrag nic Ìomhair rides to Taigh na Fèithe with the crown's leaves*, 10 an t-Samhain, LE 738;

← Leads to *The fault in the count is found and cannot be mended*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, LE 738.

16. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 739** — *The day of Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh*¹⁸ fixed (Seann Skell). The same agreement that settles the count also fixes, for the first time, a single day on which Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh is to be kept by every harbour of the coast together, in place of each keeping it a day or two either side of its neighbours by its own old custom. Mòrag nic Ìomhair carries word of it down to Seann Skell.¹⁹
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 739** — *The agreement-leaf folded into Leabhar a' Chùraim*²⁰ (Muileann dhearg). Eòghann mac Pheadair keeps his copy of the sealed agreement between two older leaves of Leabhar a' Chùraim that had never before had a stranger's mark folded in among them. He tells the master of Taigh na Fèithe²¹ only that the crown's scribe was a hard woman to argue a figure past and an easy one to agree a figure with.²²
- 6 AM MÀRT, LE 740** — *The coast keeps the rite on the agreed day* (Muileann dhearg). Mòrag nic Ìomhair writes to Eòghann mac Pheadair the following winter that not a single harbour of the coast has written to complain of the day set for Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh²³. Eòghann keeps the short note folded inside his own working leaves for the rest of his working life.²⁴
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 751** — *Birth of Eilidh Bhàn* (Cathair dhearg). A girl, Eilidh, fair enough to be called Eilidh Bhàn from her first year, is born at Cathair dhearg, granddaughter of the ruler who has then held the hall nine-and-twenty years.
- 27 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 762** — *Word of the disputation at Inis mhòr reaches Taigh na Fèithe*²⁵ (Muileann dhearg). A rider carries north country talk to Taigh na Fèithe of a house of disputation newly founded at Inis mhòr, whose first master refuses every answer offered him on whether the vein answers any true count of years or only the custom of counting it. Eòghann mac Pheadair, old now, hears it out and goes back to his leaf.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 769** — *The druid school at Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Pupils of Dùn thais found a house of disputation at Inis mhòr, and the question of the vein is argued in the north for the first time. Its first master, Fionnlagh mac Aonghais, is remembered for refusing every answer offered him.²⁶
- 10 AN GEARRAN, LE 769** — *Queen Eilidh Bhàn crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Eilidh Bhàn, sixth ruler of the house of Catrìona, is crowned at Cathair dhearg, a girl of eighteen. The annals of her long reign are almost wholly of harvests.²⁷

17. ← Follows from *The two counts reconciled*, 23 am Màrt, LE 739.

18. the rite of the empty harbour

19. ← Follows from *The two counts reconciled*, 23 am Màrt, LE 739.

20. the custody-book of the vein-house

21. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

22. ← Follows from *The two counts reconciled*, 23 am Màrt, LE 739.

23. the rite of the empty harbour

24. ← Follows from *The two counts reconciled*, 23 am Màrt, LE 739.

25. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

- 22 AN GEARRAN, LE 769** — *The bath-house at the hot springs* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²⁸). Clann Choinnich rebuilds in dressed stone the old bath-house over the hot springs of Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh, and admits the sick of any house one day in seven. Its physicians keep a book of cures, afterwards lost.
- 9 AM MÀRT, LE 769** — *The master of Taigh na Fèithe*²⁹ stands for Eòghann at the crowning (Muileann dhearg). When Na Seachd Taighean³⁰ custodians go down to Cathair dhearg to see the new queen crowned, as the compact requires, the master of Taigh na Fèithe goes in place of Eòghann mac Pheadair, whose legs will no longer answer for a journey of thirty-nine miles in a single season. Eòghann hears the crowning described to him afterward by the returning master.³¹
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, LE 769** — *Eòghann mac Pheadair is carried to the bath-house at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh*³² (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh). In the last cold turn of the year, his chest gone tight in a way no winter before has managed, Eòghann mac Pheadair lets himself be carried by cart to the rebuilt bath-house below Muileann ruadh, where he sits in the warm water among coal-breakers, salt-carriers and a shepherd's widow, none of them minding whose gallery the others answer to.³³
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, LE 769** — *Eòghann mac Pheadair shows the agreement-leaf to his own pupil* (Muileann dhearg). Asked by the young scribe he has lately taken to teaching what the finest thing was that he ever did in a life spent mostly at a stool, Eòghann mac Pheadair unfolds the thirty-year-old agreement-leaf and tells the boy it was not the count that made it worth keeping, but the honest agreement written under it.³⁴
- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 769** — *Death of the fifth ruler of the house of Catriona* (Cathair dhearg). The fifth ruler of the house of Catriona dies at Cathair dhearg at nine-and-eighty after seven-and-forty years crowned, and the crown passes to a granddaughter, Eilidh Bhàn, eighteen years old.³⁵
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 782** — *A coaster boarded off the small islands* (Baile chrom). A coaster out of Ros bheag puts in at Baile chrom two days late and a third short in her hold, her skipper telling Coinneach mac Nèill, the reeve, that three boats out of the small islands boarded her and took her grain, wearing no mark and hiding no face.

27. ◇ Same person *Birth of the fifth ruler of the house of Catriona*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, LE 680; → Caused by *Death of the fourth ruler of the house of Catriona*, 31 an t-Iuchar, LE 722; ◇ Same person *Birth of Eilidh Bhàn*, 15 am Faoilleach, LE 751.

26. ⇌ At the same time *Word of the disputation at Inis mhòr reaches Taigh na Fèithe*, 27 an Lùnastal, LE 762.

28. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

29. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

30. the seven houses of custody

31. ⇌ At the same time *Queen Eilidh Bhàn crowned*, 10 an Gearran, LE 769.

32. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

33. ⇌ At the same time *The bath-house at the hot springs*, 22 an Gearran, LE 769.

34. ↓ Legacy *The two counts reconciled*, 23 am Màrt, LE 739.

- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 784** — *The sea-thieves of the north-west* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Boats out of the small islands off the north-west coast begin to rob the coasting traders of fish and grain. The sea-thieves are Dia-thirich, men of the north-west shore, and the harbour rolls name some of them.³⁶
- 26 AN GEARRAN, LE 784** — *Rolla a' Chalaiddh*³⁷ name *Aonghas mac Ruairidh* among the *sea-thieves* (Baile chrom). The first full count of the takings sent up to Cathair dhearg names, among the sea-thieves of the small islands, a fisherman's son of Baile chrom, Aonghas mac Ruairidh. His mother tells the reeve plainly that a young man who watches the fish thin will go looking for a living wherever it is still to be found.³⁸
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 789** — *Baile chrom half empty* (Baile chrom). The reeve of Baile chrom on the north-west coast reports half the houses of the town empty, their families gone east before the sea-thieves and the poor harvests. The crown remits the town's grain dues.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 789** — *Half of Baile chrom stands empty* (Baile chrom). Coinneach mac Nèill reports to the crown's scribes that half the houses of Baile chrom stand empty, their families gone inland before the sea-thieves and the failing catch, their thatch going to moss and their doors shut on rooms no one will sleep in again that year.³⁹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 789** — *Baile chrom's grain dues remitted* (Baile chrom). The crown remits Baile chrom's grain dues to a sum reckoned by the households that stand rather than the households that once stood, answering Coinneach mac Nèill's plain report with a plain word of thanks for a count taken with care.⁴⁰
- 5 AN GEARRAN, LE 790** — *Birth of Dòmhnall Ruadh*. A son, red-haired and called Dòmhnall Ruadh, is born at Muileann chrom to a custodian household of Clann Raghnaill that keeps three galleries under the mountain and has never once been asked into An Talla Dearg⁴¹ except to petition.
- 18 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 795** — *The reeve's letter asking for a force* (Baile chrom). After the sea-thieves put in twice within a single moon on strands within sight of his own harbour, Coinneach mac Nèill writes to the crown asking not for lightened dues this time but for an armed force, since a reeve with a tally-stick can no longer hold a coast his own shire's desperate sons have made their hunting ground.⁴²

35. → Leads to *Queen Eilidh Bhàn crowned*, 10 an Gearran, LE 769.

36. ← Leads to *A coaster boarded off the small islands*, 12 an Dàmhair, LE 782.

37. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

38. ← Follows from *The sea-thieves of the north-west*, 24 am Faoilleach, LE 784.

39. ← Follows from *Baile chrom half empty*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, LE 789.

40. ← Follows from *Baile chrom half empty*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, LE 789.

41. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

42. ← Follows from *Baile chrom half empty*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, LE 789.

4 AN GIBLEAN, LE 800 — *Iain mac Thormoid raised against the small islands* (Baile chrom). Eilidh Bhàn raises a force under a captain named Iain mac Thormoid and sends it north by sea to Baile chrom, answering the reeve's long-awaited letter. The captain charts the raiders' ground on Coinneach mac Nèill's own table with the help of the town's fishermen before the boats sail against the small islands.

THE YEARS LE 801 – 900

- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 801** — *The raid on Eilean dhubb* (Eilean dhubb). A force sent by Queen Eilidh Bhàn lands on Eilean dhubb and burns the sea-thieves' boats on the strand. Their leader, Uilleam Ruadh, is taken to Cathair dhearg and hanged.¹
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 801** — *Creach Eilean dhubb*² (Eilean dhubb). Iain mac Thormoid's boats land at first light on Eilean dhubb and burn the sea-thieves' hulls on the strand, Coinneach mac Nèill's own fishermen leading the way through the channel among the small islands. The sea-thieves, unwatched for the better part of a decade, are taken all but by surprise.³
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 801** — *Aonghas mac Ruairidh dies on the strand* (Eilean dhubb). Aonghas mac Ruairidh, thirty-one years old and once a boy Coinneach mac Nèill carried on his own shoulder to this same water, is killed defending a hull on Eilean dhubb's strand. The reeve kneels over him and finds he has no words ready for the mother he must tell of it.⁴
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 801** — *Uilleam Ruadh taken and hanged* (Cathair dhearg). Uilleam Ruadh, leader of the sea-thieves for the better part of a decade, is taken alive off Eilean dhubb's strand and carried south in irons to Cathair dhearg, where he is hanged before the season turns, six and thirty years old.⁵
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, LE 815** — *The dearth on the north-west shore* (Baile chrom). A run of failed harvests along the north-west shore grows more than the shared-meal custom can carry. Coinneach mac Nèill keeps the custom at his own board as long as grain remains to keep it with, dividing what the diminished fields bring in as evenly as his hand can manage.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 819** — *The dearth on the north-west shore* (Gorta Baile chrom⁶). Harvest after harvest fails along the north-west shore, and the dearth is more than the shared meal can bear. Families leave the coast for the inland shires and the east, and the north-west is thinly held from this time to the end of the age.⁷
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 819** — *Beathag nic Artair dies of the winter's sickness* (Baile chrom). In the hard winter of the dearth, Beathag nic Artair, wife of the reeve of Baile chrom, dies of a chest complaint her body, weakened by two thin harvests running, has no strength left to fight. The last of the town's households load their carts and go inland and east the same season.⁸

1. → Caused by *Iain mac Thormoid raised against the small islands*, 4 an Giblean, LE 800.

2. the raid on Eilean dhubb

3. ← Follows from *The raid on Eilean dhubb*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 801.

4. ← Follows from *The raid on Eilean dhubb*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 801.

5. ← Follows from *The raid on Eilean dhubb*, 27 an t-Samhain, LE 801.

6. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

7. ← Leads to *The dearth on the north-west shore*, 8 an Giblean, LE 815.

8. ← Follows from *The dearth on the north-west shore*, 19 an Giblean, LE 819.

- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 821** — *Coinneach mac Nèill leaves Baile chrom* (Baile chrom). Coinneach mac Nèill, reeve of Baile chrom for eight-and-forty years, sets the reeve's chest of rolls and tallies in order for a successor he no longer believes will come, shuts his own door behind him, and sets the coast road east under his feet.⁹
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 825** — *Birth of Raghnall Òg*. A son, Raghnall, is born at Muileann chrom to Dòmhnall Ruadh, then five-and-thirty years old and keeper of his house's three galleries.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, LE 829** — *The king-list recopied* (Cathair dhearg). The scribes of Queen Eilidh Bhàn copy the king-list of Dia-thìr afresh from its oldest surviving roll, adding the rulers since the Sundering. The new copy begins the present age with the Choosing and not with the fleet.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 829** — *Clàr nan Rìghrean*¹⁰ *recopied* (Cathair dhearg). The queen's scribes at Cathair dhearg take down the old Clàr nan Rìghrean from its resting place and copy it afresh onto new hide, adding every ruler since the fleet had gone and setting the new copy's beginning at An Roghnachadh¹¹ rather than at the sailing.¹²
- 10 AN GEARRAN, LE 835** — *The strand-market at Àth fhionn* (Àth fhionn). A market grows up on the strand at Àth fhionn, where the coast road crosses the clear river, trading north-coast fish, the flesh and oil of stranded whales, wool and barley. The fishers of the north coast no longer carry their catch the longer road south to Inis mhòr.
- 19 AN GEARRAN, LE 835** — *The strand-market at Àth fhionn* (Àth fhionn). Àth fhionn, the ford town where the coast road crosses the clear river, holds a market on the strand for the north coast, of fish, the flesh and oil of stranded whales, wool and barley. The fishers of the north coast no longer carry their catch to Inis mhòr.¹³
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 841** — *Eilidh Bhàn dies without an heir* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Eilidh Bhàn dies at Cathair dhearg without a child, and the house of Catrìona ends with her. The seven houses meet at the vein-house and not at the capital.
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 841** — *Na Seachd Taighean*¹⁴ *ride to Taigh na Fèithe*¹⁵ *rather than An Talla Dearg*¹⁶ (Muileann dhearg). On the queen's death Na Seachd Taighean' messengers pass over the empty capital and ride straight to Taigh na Fèithe above the mountain, choosing to settle the succession among the galleries and Clachan a' Chrannchuir¹⁷ rather than under the house of Catrìona's own roof. No leaf gives the reason; a young scribe of Taigh na Fèithe later says it felt from the first hour less like a choosing than a homecoming.¹⁸

9. ¶ Legacy *The dearth on the north-west shore*, 19 an Giblean, LE 819.

10. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

11. the Choosing; lit. 'the choosing'

12. ← Follows from *The king-list recopied*, 20 an Cèitean, LE 829.

13. ← Leads to *The strand-market at Àth fhionn*, 10 an Gearran, LE 835.

14. the seven houses of custody

15. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

16. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

17. the stones of the lot

- 5 AN CÈITEAN, LE 842** — *Nine days at the long table* (Muileann dhearg). The heads of Na Seachd Taighean¹⁹ sit first nine days at the table under Taigh na Fèithe²⁰'s north window, and ride up again at every season's turning for five years, while the capital's clerks hold grain prices and boundary pleas unanswered for want of anyone with standing to settle them. At the last sitting the name of Dòmhnall Ruadh of Muileann chrom is spoken and not spoken down again.
- 23 AM MÀRT, LE 846** — *Dòmhnall Ruadh crowned* (Cathair dhearg). The houses name Dòmhnall Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill, of the line of the claimant slain at Muileann chrom. He is crowned at Cathair dhearg and keeps the mastery of the vein-house with the crown.²¹
- 4 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 846** — *Dòmhnall Ruadh told whose yard he stands in* (Muileann dhearg). An old custodian takes the newly named Dòmhnall Ruadh aside in Taigh na Fèithe²² yard and tells him it is the same ground on which Raghnaill Ruadh, of his own house, once refused every claimant offered him and shut the door on a season of refused hearths. Dòmhnall Ruadh says only that he hopes to prove a different answer to the same question.²³
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 846** — *Dòmhnall Ruadh's household summoned from Muileann chrom*. Riders carry word to Muileann chrom for Dòmhnall Ruadh's wife and two grown sons to come up to Cathair dhearg; he spends his first night as king naming aloud which of his neighbours he trusts to keep his own galleries honestly measured in his absence, troubled more by that than by the crown awaiting him.²⁴
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 846** — *Dòmhnall Ruadh crowned at six-and-fifty* (Cathair dhearg). Dòmhnall Ruadh is crowned at Cathair dhearg nine days after the houses name him, six-and-fifty years old, in a hall his house had never in nearly three hundred years entered as anything but petitioner.²⁵
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 850** — *The king's horse known on the mountain road* (Muileann dhearg). Riding the thirty-nine miles between Cathair dhearg and Taigh na Fèithe²⁶ so often in the first years of his reign, Dòmhnall Ruadh is known by his horse before his face, and the road's keepers complain that they never shod one animal so often in one man's service.

18. ← Follows from *Eilidh Bhàn dies without an heir*, 21 an Giblean, LE 841.

19. the seven houses of custody

20. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

21. ◇ Same person *Birth of Dòmhnall Ruadh*, 5 an Gearran, LE 790; → Caused by *Nine days at the long table*, 5 an Cèitean, LE 842.

22. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

23. ← Follows from *Dòmhnall Ruadh crowned*, 23 am Màrt, LE 846.

24. ← Follows from *Dòmhnall Ruadh crowned*, 23 am Màrt, LE 846.

25. ← Follows from *Dòmhnall Ruadh crowned*, 23 am Màrt, LE 846.

26. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 855** — *The boundary stone of the shifted stream.* Dòmhnall Ruadh rides down from the capital to Muileann chrom himself to settle a boundary dispute between two households of his own old neighbours, and fixes the stone's place by asking each household's oldest member, separately, where they remember playing as children, rather than by any measuring Taigh na Fèithe²⁷ owns.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 855** — *The king keeps his seat at An Talla Dearg*²⁸ (Cathair dhearg). Pressed by more than one of the seven heads to move the crown's seat to the mountain, since a king who is master of Taigh na Fèithe²⁹ belongs among the galleries, Dòmhnall Ruadh keeps it at Cathair dhearg for the whole of his five-and-twenty years.
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 859** — *The crown and the custody joined* (Muileann dhearg). Dòmhnall Ruadh's reeves write into the custody-book that the ruler of Dia-thìr is also master of the vein-house. Thereafter the heads of the seven houses sit as the king's council, and the custodians and the court are one body.³⁰
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 859** — *The reeve's entry read out to the king* (Muileann dhearg). Dòmhnall Ruadh's reeve reads him the fair copy of the entry joining the crown to the mastery of Taigh na Fèithe³¹ before it is set to the king's own mark; Dòmhnall Ruadh says it reads less like a new law than a plain account of what has already been true since the morning in the yard, and the reeve agrees.³²
- 21 AN GEARRAN, LE 860** — *Leabhar a' Chùrain*³³ and the crown's rolls copied onto one shelf (Muileann dhearg). Taigh na Fèithe³⁴'s clerks spend the better part of two years copying Leabhar a' Chùrain and the crown's rolls, kept apart under separate roofs for near three hundred years, onto the same shelves in the same hands, until no leaf of either record can be told from the other at a glance.³⁵
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 864** — *The metalworker who cuts the seal* (Muileann dhearg). A metalworker of Muileann dhearg who has never before been asked to cut more than a gallery-marker spends near a season on the new seal's die, complaining that the gold will not sit against the blue as he wishes. Dòmhnall Ruadh, seeing it finished, says he can find nothing in it that is properly his to add.

27. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

28. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

29. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

30. → Caused by *The king's horse known on the mountain road*, 9 am Faoilleach, LE 850; → Caused by *The king keeps his seat at An Talla Dearg*, 31 an Dàmhair, LE 855.

31. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

32. ← Follows from *The crown and the custody joined*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, LE 859.

33. the custody-book of the vein-house

34. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

35. ← Follows from *The crown and the custody joined*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, LE 859.

- I AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 865** — *The custody's seal on the king's letters* (Muileann dhearg). From the joining of the crown and the custody the king's letters bear the vein-house's own seal: a trellis of gold on blue, which the custodians read as the galleries of the mountain, and over it a hollow lozenge for Crom's slab, laid on the first break. The crown adds a white band across the field and nothing more. From this time the seal is the arms of the kingdom.³⁶
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 871** — *Death of Dòmhnall Ruadh* (Cathair dhearg). Dòmhnall Ruadh, the first to hold both the crown and the vein-house, dies at Cathair dhearg and is buried at Muileann dhearg. His son Ragnall Òg is crowned.³⁷
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 871** — *Dòmhnall Ruadh buried under the mountain* (Muileann dhearg). Dòmhnall Ruadh is carried, by his own long-standing wish, not to the house of Catriona's tombs at Cathair dhearg but up to Taigh na Fèithe³⁸, where the custodians dig his grave themselves in a worked-out gallery and lay him with a single unlit lamp at his head, a rite kept for no other ruler before or since.³⁹
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 871** — *Ragnall Òg asks to shorten his own coronation* (Cathair dhearg). At the rehearsal of his coronation Ragnall Òg twice asks the clerks whether the ceremony might be shortened by an hour so that he can see a shire plea before dark, more at ease already with a boundary dispute than with a court's ceremony.⁴⁰
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 871** — *Ragnall Òg crowned at six-and-forty* (Cathair dhearg). Ragnall Òg is crowned at Cathair dhearg after his father's burial under the mountain, six-and-forty years old, keeper already of the crown's shire pleas.⁴¹
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 889** — *The schism of the Hawk* (Cnoc bheag). A council of the Hawk at Cnoc bheag divides over whether Mòd's measure may ever be raised. Those who hold it fixed for ever keep the name of the Hungry Hawk and the house at Cnoc bheag; those who hold that a greater flock may be fed a greater handful are called the Fed Hawk.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 889** — *The young priest's question at Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). At the council of Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁴² a young priest rises to ask the elders whether Mòd himself would rather starve a grown flock than see his old handful grown to meet it. The council turns on the question, and An Seabhag Biadhthe⁴³ is named from that day.⁴⁴
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 899** — *The harbour of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). Seann Chwen builds its harbour mole and becomes the port of the coal-carts coming down from the mountain to the coast towns of the south.

36. → Caused by *The metalworker who cuts the seal*, 23 am Faoilleach, LE 864.

37. ◇ Same person *Birth of Ragnall Òg*, 30 an Dàmhair, LE 825.

38. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

39. ← Follows from *Death of Dòmhnall Ruadh*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, LE 871.

40. ← Follows from *Death of Dòmhnall Ruadh*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, LE 871.

41. ← Follows from *Death of Dòmhnall Ruadh*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, LE 871.

42. the Hawk order

43. the Fed Hawk

31 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 900 — *The first barges tie up at Seann Chwen's new mole* (Seann Chwen). The first coal-barges of the mountain roads tie up at Seann Chwen's finished stone mole where before they only beached on shingle at low water; a rider carrying the news south remarks that he rode the whole way under one seal without troubling to wonder which office he rode for.⁴⁵

44. → Leads to *The schism of the Hawk*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, LE 889.

45. ← Follows from *The harbour of Seann Chwen*, 17 an Lùnastal, LE 899.

THE YEARS LE 901 – 1,000

- 23 AN GIBLEAN, LE 909** — *The Fed Hawk at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The priests of the Fed Hawk, driven from Cnoc bheag, settle at Seann Skell on the north coast, not the western river port of that name. The custody-book writes their teaching down as an error, and at length.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 910** — *Beathag nic Sheumais builds An Seabhag Biadhthe's house* (Seann Skell). Beathag nic Sheumais, nineteen at the schism, builds An Seabhag Biadhthe's following at Seann Skell on the north coast from four families to a proper school over two decades, within sound of a sea that has never given the island a word of what lies beyond it.²
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 919** — *The Fed Hawk's petition* (Seann Skell). From Seann Skell the Fed Hawk asks the king's council to raise the measured handful by a quarter for the hearths of the north coast. The council refuses. It is the first plea on record to alter the Small-Burning Law.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 919** — *Beathag nic Sheumais rides south to petition in person* (Cathair dhearg). Rather than trust the asking to a letter, Beathag nic Sheumais rides to Cathair dhearg herself in her fiftieth year and lays the north coast's cold winters before the seven heads without once raising her voice; the council refuses her at length, and she carries the refusal home in her own satchel.³
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 929** — *The gallery at Cill ghlas* (Cill ghlas). A second tremor in the hills of Cill ghlas brings down a gallery of the vein and kills fourteen labourers of the custodians. The vein-house closes the gallery and sets at its mouth a stone with the fourteen names.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 929** — *The fourteen named at the gallery's mouth* (Cill ghlas). Taigh na Fèithe⁴ sets a stone with the fourteen names of Cill ghlas cut in the order they went down, the youngest a boy of thirteen, the oldest a woman forty years at the same gallery. Households of the mountain take up the custom of leaving their own small stones at its foot on the day of the fall.⁵
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 938** — *A bead of the seven names the fourteen before the council* (Cathair dhearg). Laying the matter of the coal-roads before the king's council, one of the seven heads says plainly that fourteen names on a stone at a gallery's mouth are proof enough the mountain's coal is given up at a real cost, and that no house's quarrel has business stopping it on the road. None of the seven speaks against him.

1. the Fed Hawk

2. ← Follows from *The Fed Hawk at Seann Skell*, 23 an Giblean, LE 909.

3. → Leads to *The Fed Hawk's petition*, 25 an Lùnastal, LE 919.

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

5. ← Follows from *The gallery at Cill ghlas*, 14 an Dàmhair, LE 929.

- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 939** — *The coal-roads kept by the crown* (Cathair dhearg). The king's council takes the roads from the mountain to the coast into the crown's keeping, that no house may stop the carts bearing the measured coal to the temples. The roads are marked with posts bearing the crown's sign: the carriers' road down to Cathair dhearg, An Rathad Tuath over the pass by Muileann fhada, Slighe Muileann dhearg south from the hills by Muileann chrom, and Slighe Baile òg down to the southern Seann Skell.⁶
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 939** — *The posts driven along the coal-roads* (Muileann dhearg). Coal-carters hired for the season and paid from the roads' own tolls drive posts the length of all four coal-roads through a single autumn, a trellis and a hollow stone cut at every shire joint, without ceremony or a word said over the last post.⁷
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 939** — *A carter's answer, remembered afterward*. A carter who helped set posts on three of the four coal-roads is asked the next spring what the work was like, and says only that a man can now walk any of them from the mountain to the sea and never lose the road for want of knowing whose it is; his answer outlives the council's own leaf of the debate.⁸
- 17 AN GEARRAN, LE 944** — *The crown's riders* (Cathair dhearg). Fresh horses are kept for the crown's riders at the waypoint houses on the coal-roads, and a rider changing at every house carries the council's word from Cathair dhearg to the mountain between dawn and dark. The stabling is paid out of the coal-road tolls.
- 23 AM MÀRT, LE 944** — *Mairead nic Aonghais's three tallies* (Cathair dhearg). The keeper of a road-house on the northern coal-road keeps three notched sticks beside the reeve's own tally of the crown's riders: one for every rider through, one for those who thank her by name, and one for those carrying business she judges not worth the horse it rode on.⁹
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 949** — *The high pastures of Doire uaine forsaken* (Marbh-bheò¹⁰ Doire uaine). The last shepherd families leave the high pastures of the Doire uaine hills for the valley villages. They give the grazing as the reason; every one of them speaks also of the Marbh-bheò.
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 949** — *The last shieling of Doire uaine* (Marbh-bheò¹¹ Doire uaine). An old woman drives her last three goats and a lame ewe down from her own shieling in the high pastures of Doire uaine, the last of her country to come down, and tells the priest who meets her at the valley's edge that a place can grow tired of being lived in alone by living things.¹²

6. → Caused by *A head of the seven names the fourteen before the council*, 14 an Lùnastal, LE 938.

7. ← Follows from *The coal-roads kept by the crown*, 12 an t-Samhain, LE 939.

8. ← Follows from *The coal-roads kept by the crown*, 12 an t-Samhain, LE 939.

9. ← Follows from *The crown's riders*, 17 an Gearran, LE 944.

10. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

11. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

12. ← Follows from *The high pastures of Doire uaine forsaken*, 17 an Lùnastal, LE 949.

- 6 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 953** — *A drover crosses the empty pastures* (Marbh-bheò¹³ Doire uaine). A drover taking cattle to the lowland market by the old high road finds the whole stretch of the forsaken shielings of Doire uaine silent from end to end, not a dog barking nor a hearth smoking, and pushes his herd on rather than camp the night on ground nobody is left to grant or refuse.¹⁴
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 959** — *The salt fair at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). Ros fhionn holds its great salt fair, and the reeve counts some four thousand people on the flats in a single day. It is the height of the town, and the chronicle calls it the richest place in the north-east.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 959** — *Four thousand counted on the salt flats* (Ros fhionn). The reeve of Ros fhionn's salt fair loses his own count somewhere past four thousand among the carts, pack-mules and children on the flats, and writes the figure down rounded rather than pretend to a precision the crowd never held still for.¹⁵
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 969** — *Cathair mhòr the largest town* (Cathair mhòr). Cathair mhòr, its market drawing the trade of all the south, grows greater than the capital. The capital remains the seat of the crown, and the lesser town.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 969** — *A carter's plain answer* (Cathair mhòr). Asked by a clerk of An Talla Dearg¹⁶ why he sells his barley at Cathair mhòr and not the capital, a carter of the southern road answers that a man carries his load to whichever gate opens first and pays best; the clerk enters the answer as given.¹⁷
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 979** — *The stair at Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). Quarrymen north of the capital break into Toll-dubh, the shaft of the old tales, long lost, and find a stair cut in the rock going down beyond their lamps. The custodians of the vein-house wall up the entrance. The one quarryman who went down never tells what he saw.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 979** — *The quarry face opens on Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). A stubborn seam on the quarry face north of the capital swings inward on nothing and opens on a cold, scentless dark; the quarryman Calum Dubh mac Iain names the shaft Toll-dubh before any other man on the ledge can, and the whole crew falls silent.¹⁸
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 979** — *Calum Dubh climbs the stair* (Toll-dubh). Calum Dubh mac Iain goes down the stair of Toll-dubh alone with a lamp and a paid-out rope while his fellows watch the light dwindle and vanish; he climbs out again, sits a long while on the loose stone, and tells the foreman only that the face must be closed.¹⁹

13. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

14. ← Follows from *The high pastures of Doire uaine forsaken*, 17 an Lùnastal, LE 949.

15. ← Follows from *The salt fair at Ros fhionn*, 9 an Lùnastal, LE 959.

16. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

17. ← Follows from *Cathair mhòr the largest town*, 31 an Dàmhair, LE 969.

18. → Leads to *The stair at Toll-dubh*, 18 an t-Sultain, LE 979.

19. → Leads to *The stair at Toll-dubh*, 18 an t-Sultain, LE 979.

- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 979** — *Leabhar a' Chùrainm*²⁰ takes Calum Dubh's silence as given (Toll-dubh). Taigh na Fèithe²¹'s custodians wall the mouth of Toll-dubh within a month and enter Calum Dubh mac Iain's own brief account of the walling exactly as he gives it, adding nothing to fill out what he leaves unsaid.²²
- II AN GEARRAN, LE 994** — *The copper-workers of Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). The copper-workers of Cathair mhòr begin to make cooking pots, which are sold on every road of the island. Each bears its maker's sign, and some are still found in the ground.
- 18 AN GEARRAN, LE 994** — *The copper-workers' maker's marks* (Cathair mhòr). The copper-workers of Cathair mhòr stamp every cooking pot with its own maker's mark, a leaf, a fish or a plain letter, and the pots go out on every road at once, carried by hands their makers will never meet.²³
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 995** — *A saying born of a silent man* (Cathair dhearg). The quarry town takes up a way of speaking of any close-mouthed man, that he has gone down and come up like Calum Dubh, and the saying outgrows him within a generation, applied to men who never went near Toll-dubh at all.²⁴
- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 999** — *Ailean measures Làrach an Teampaill*²⁵ (Làrach an Teampaill). Ailean mac Dhùghaill, a scholar of the druid school at Dùn thais, measures the ruin of Làrach an Teampaill and writes that its altar faces the central mountains and not the sea. Who set it so he will not guess.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, LE 999** — *Ailean measures the temple-ruin's altar* (Làrach an Teampaill)²⁶. Ailean mac Dhùghaill lays his cord across the altar-stone of Làrach an Teampaill and finds it faces the central mountains, its back to the sea, a plain fact no teller of the ruin's tales had ever thought worth the mentioning; he says only that he will not guess who set the stone so.²⁷
- II AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,000** — *Birth of Mòrag Ruadh*. A daughter, Mòrag, red-haired and called Mòrag Ruadh, is born into Clann Raghnaill; Leabhar a' Chùrainm²⁸ gives the house and the year, for no one yet has cause to write more.

20. the custody-book of the vein-house

21. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

22. ← Follows from *The stair at Toll-dubh*, 18 an t-Sultain, LE 979.

23. ← Follows from *The copper-workers of Cathair mhòr*, 11 an Gearran, LE 994.

24. ↓ Legacy *The stair at Toll-dubh*, 18 an t-Sultain, LE 979.

25. the temple ruin

26. the temple ruin

27. → Leads to *Ailean measures Làrach an Teampaill*, 31 am Faoilleach, LE 999.

28. the custody-book of the vein-house

THE YEARS LE 1,001 – 1,100

- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,004** — *The farmer's barrowload of stone.* A farmer whose plough turns up stone every spring at the edge of his field meets Ailean mac Dhùghaill at Làrach an Dùin¹ with a barrowload of it, half in earnest asking whether the school will pay for what his own ground keeps giving back; Ailean measures every stone and buys none of them.
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,011** — *Ailean's tables of the old ruins* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire²). Ailean mac Dhùghaill finishes his tables of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire, Làrach an Dùin³ and Làrach an Teampaill⁴, with the measure, stone and lie of each. He cannot say whether one people built all three, and because of his tables no scholar after him could say either.⁵
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,011** — *The school judges Ailean's tables.* The school at Dùn thais argues a winter over Ailean mac Dhùghaill's finished tables of the three old ruins and judges only that his measurements stand sound and his caution on their makers sounder still, closing the question no scholar after him could reopen.⁶
- 25 AM MÀRT, LE 1,015** — *Death of Calum Dubh mac Iain, still silent* (Toll-dubh). Calum Dubh mac Iain dies in his own house in his sixty-fifth year, well liked in the quarry town for a quiet kindness, having told no living soul, wife, son or scribe, what he saw on the stair under the hill.⁷
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,017** — *The steward's mistaken tally* (Cathair dhearg). The girl Mòrag Ruadh finds her own small wax-board tally of the hall's candles does not agree with the steward Pàdraig mac Ìomhair's great ledger; he finds the fault his own, a tally-mark set down twice, and sets his sums before her eyes from that evening forward.
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,019** — *Queen Mòrag Ruadh crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Mòrag Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill is crowned at Cathair dhearg. Hers are the first household accounts of a ruler that survive whole.⁸
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,019** — *Na Seachd Taighean*⁹ name Mòrag Ruadh (Muileann dhearg). Na Seachd Taighean, meeting at Taigh na Fèithe¹⁰ on the death of the old king, send word to Cathair dhearg within the month that the crown will go to the girl of Clann Raghnaill who keeps her own small tally beside the steward's; Leabhar a' Chùrain¹¹ gives four lines and no reason beyond her house and her blood.¹²

1. the fortress ruin

2. the watch-fort ruin

3. the fortress ruin

4. the temple ruin

5. → Caused by *The farmer's barrowload of stone*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 1,004.

6. ← Follows from *Ailean's tables of the old ruins*, 20 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,011.

7. ¶ Legacy *The stair at Toll-dubh*, 18 an t-Sultain, LE 979.

8. ◇ Same person *Birth of Mòrag Ruadh*, 11 an Dàmhair, LE 1,000; → Caused by *The steward's mistaken tally*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,017.

9. the seven houses of custody

10. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

11. the custody-book of the vein-house

- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,019** — *The queen's own book bound* (Cathair dhearg). Mòrag Ruadh has a vellum ledger bound within the month of her crowning, clasped in iron rather than silver at her own asking, and enters the cost of her own coronation feast on its first page, signed under her own name.¹³
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,019** — *Mòrag Ruadh crowned at nineteen* (Cathair dhearg). Mòrag Ruadh is crowned at Cathair dhearg at nineteen, the youngest ruler An Talla Dearg¹⁴ has seen since Eilidh Bhàn, and keeps her own small tally beside the steward's from the first day.¹⁵
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,034** — *The obelisk at Carragh Cnoc bheag¹⁶ cleaned* (Carragh Cnoc bheag). The priests of the Hawk at Cnoc bheag clear the moss from the obelisk of Carragh Cnoc bheag and try to read the old letters on it. They cannot, and they write down that they tried.
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,034** — *Tòmas clears the moss from Carragh Cnoc bheag¹⁷* (Carragh Cnoc bheag). The priest Tòmas mac Aonghais spends a month clearing moss from Carragh Cnoc bheag with wooden scrapers rather than iron, and finds, once the stone stands bare, letters cut deep and old that answer to no shape the schools' own tables keep.¹⁸
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,034** — *The queen asks after the unread stone* (Cathair dhearg). Hearing the report of Carragh Cnoc bheag¹⁹ cleared read to her hall, Mòrag Ruadh enters the cost of Tòmas mac Aonghais's oil and vellum into her own book without comment, and asks only whether the priests mean to try the letters again; the answer she is given is that they do not know.²⁰
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,039** — *Caol shean's fishing year* (Caol shean). Caol shean, whose boats fish the east coast from the mouth of the Abhainn chaol, lands the greatest catch in its rolls, so great that the salt runs short and half is dried in the wind. The dried fish sells poorly, and the town goes back to salting.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,039** — *The thousandth year* (Seann Skell). The vein-house marks the thousandth year of its count with a single measured burning of the coal on Cidhe an Di-osail²¹ at Seann Skell, and Queen Mòrag Ruadh is there. It is told that the flame burned the colour of the vein, and that the crowd went home without a word.

12. → Leads to *Queen Mòrag Ruadh crowned*, 23 am Faoilleach, LE 1,019.

13. ← Follows from *Queen Mòrag Ruadh crowned*, 23 am Faoilleach, LE 1,019.

14. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

15. ← Follows from *Queen Mòrag Ruadh crowned*, 23 am Faoilleach, LE 1,019.

16. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

17. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

18. ← Follows from *The obelisk at Carragh Cnoc bheag cleaned*, 18 an Dàmhair, LE 1,034.

19. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

20. ← Follows from *The obelisk at Carragh Cnoc bheag cleaned*, 18 an Dàmhair, LE 1,034.

21. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,039** — *Ruairidh mac Neacail hangs the catch in the wind* (Caol shean). When Caol shean's salt runs out on the second day of its greatest catch, the shed-foreman Ruairidh mac Neacail hangs what cannot be salted on lines strung the length of the lower town's lanes rather than let it spoil on the strand.²²
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,039** — *The queen judges the thousandth year a measure and no more* (Cathair dhearg). Asked by Na Seachd Taighean²³ whether Taigh na Fèithe²⁴'s thousandth year deserves a feast or a fast, Mòrag Ruadh judges between them: one burning on the quay the count began from, no more coal in it than an ordinary hearth burns of an evening.²⁵
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,039** — *The queen's journey to Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Mòrag Ruadh rides down to Seann Skell over roads already hard with the season's first frosts to stand at Cidhe an Diosail²⁶ for the thousandth year's burning, a week's journey she makes to see the measure kept rather than take a scribe's report of it.²⁷
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,039** — *The queen's entry for the burning* (Seann Skell). Where another ruler's book might have set down a verse for a thousand years made into one evening's fire, Mòrag Ruadh's own book gives the cost of the coal reckoned to Taigh na Fèithe²⁸'s weights, and beneath it five words: one handful, nothing more.²⁹
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,040** — *Caol shean returns to salting* (Caol shean). The dried catch sells poorly against salted fish, fetching less at market than a middling salted season the year before; Caol shean lays in salt from that year for a catch half again the size of any it has yet taken.³⁰
- 3 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,040** — *Birth of Beathag Fhionn* (Cathair dhearg). Mòrag Ruadh's daughter is born at Cathair dhearg and named Beathag before the child is a day old; the queen's book holds one line for the day and the name, set apart from the ordinary sums in a hand less steady than usual.
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,051** — *The market above the mill-race* (Cnoc bhàn). The hill-lords of Baile ghorm hold a market for the farms of the south-east at Cnoc bhàn, above the long mill-race of Muileann fhada. Its common goods are grain, clay and honey. Its rare good is pearls, which the women of the shore take from the mussel beds in the shallows, and which no other market sells.

22. ← Follows from *Caol shean's fishing year*, 19 an t-Sultain, LE 1,039.

23. the seven houses of custody

24. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

25. → Leads to *The thousandth year*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,039.

26. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

27. ← Follows from *The thousandth year*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,039.

28. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

29. ← Follows from *The thousandth year*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,039.

30. ← Follows from *Caol shean's fishing year*, 19 an t-Sultain, LE 1,039.

- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,051** — *The mill-race market opened above Muileann fhada* (Cnoc bhàn). The hill-lords of Baile ghorm set a single market at Cnoc bhàn above the long mill-race of Muileann fhada to gather the south-east's scattered trade in one place, its rare good the pearls no other market sells in whole parcels.³¹
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,051** — *Sine nic Ruairidh sells a season's pearls whole* (Cnoc bhàn). The shore-woman Sine nic Ruairidh brings a whole season's gathering to the mill-race market's first opening rather than sell it a pearl or two at a time along the road, and a trader of Cathair mhòr pays her more for the lot than she has ever been offered piecemeal.³²
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,064** — *The blue dyers of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). The dyers of Baile ghorm in the south-east make a fast blue from a marsh plant and a mordant of their own. Cloth of Baile ghorm blue becomes the feast-day dress of the seven houses.
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,064** — *Oighrig nic Ailein fixes Baile ghorm's blue* (Baile ghorm). After ten years changing one thing at a time in her own mordant, the dyer Oighrig nic Ailein finds a mixing that holds Baile ghorm's blue fast through washing after washing; cloth of it is worn within the year at Taigh na Fèithe³³'s midwinter gathering.³⁴
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,070** — *Birth of Ailean, son of Beathag Fhionn* (Cathair dhearg). A son, Ailean, is born at Cathair dhearg to Beathag Fhionn, the queen's daughter, then thirty years old, in the one-and-fiftieth year of Mòrag Ruadh's reign.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,079** — *The swallowing cough at Muileann dhombhain* (Muileann dhomhain). A sickness that closes the throat breaks out at Muileann dhomhain and moves along the coast road. The town loses near a third of its people.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,079** — *Word of the cough reaches An Talla Dearg*³⁵ (Cathair dhearg). A rider who has ridden the eighteen miles from Muileann dhomhain without stopping to eat brings word of a sickness that closes the throat. Beathag Fhionn, thirty-nine and eleven years at her mother's right hand, sets down the tally she is reading.³⁶
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,081** — *The cough at Seann Bhrál* (Seann Bhrál). The swallowing cough comes to the port of Seann Bhrál. The townsfolk themselves close the harbour, and keep the shared meal by leaving food at the town gate.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,082** — *Queen Beathag Fhionn closes the roads* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Fhionn, crowned after her mother Mòrag, closes the coast road between Seann Bhrál and Muileann dhomhain and sets reeves at the fords to turn travellers back. The cough goes no further west.

31. ← Follows from *The market above the mill-race*, 28 an Giblean, LE 1,051.

32. ← Follows from *The market above the mill-race*, 28 an Giblean, LE 1,051.

33. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

34. ← Follows from *The blue dyers of Baile ghorm*, 16 an t-Samhain, LE 1,064.

35. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

36. ← Follows from *The swallowing cough at Muileann dhombhain*, 29 an Lùnastal, LE 1,079.

- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,082** — *Reeves set at the fords against the cough* (Cathair dhearg). Newly crowned, Beathag Fhionn closes the coast road between Seann Bhral and Muileann dhomhain and sets a reeve at each of the road's six fords with orders to turn back every traveller until the road is released. Chosen mostly from the towns nearest their own crossing, the six hold the road shut for three years, and the cough never crosses west of them.³⁷
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,082** — *The ford-reeve turns back his own brother* (Muileann dhomhain). At the crossing nearest Muileann dhomhain, the reeve Seumas mac Coinnich turns back his own brother, who has come to the closed road to reach their dying mother on its far side. He tells him the order holds for every traveller or for none. Their mother dies within the week, and the brothers do not speak again for five years.³⁸
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,082** — *Death of Queen Mòrag Ruadh* (Cathair dhearg). Mòrag Ruadh dies at Cathair dhearg at two-and-eighty, sixty-three years crowned, the longest reign An Talla Dearg³⁹ has yet entered. Her own ledger, clasped in iron, is closed on its last sum.⁴⁰
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,082** — *Beathag Fhionn crowned at two-and-forty* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Fhionn is crowned in the hall her mother held sixty-three years, forty-two years old and grey already at the temples; the first act set down under her own seal is the closing of the coast road.⁴¹
- 25 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,095** — *The reeve of Muileann dhomhain walks the lower street* (Muileann dhomhain). The old reeve of Muileann dhomhain, who lost a wife and a son to the cough, walks the lower street once a season and writes down which roofs have fallen in since his last walking; the town stands at less than two households in three.

37. ← Follows from *Queen Beathag Fhionn closes the roads*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,082.

38. ← Follows from *Queen Beathag Fhionn closes the roads*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,082.

39. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

40. → Leads to *Queen Beathag Fhionn closes the roads*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,082.

41. ← Follows from *Queen Beathag Fhionn closes the roads*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,082.

THE YEARS LE 1,101 – 1,200

- 5 **AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,104** — *Muileann dhombain resettled* (Muileann dhomhain). Families from the hills about Muileann dhomhain settle the town that the swallowing cough emptied, and take the empty houses by lot. The older families of the town say they never again knew half their neighbours.¹
- 23 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,104** — *Three brothers from Caol dhearg come down* (Muileann dhomhain). Three brothers, sons of a hill farmer of Caol dhearg, walk down to Muileann dhomhain and take empty houses on the lower street, land already cleared and walls already standing being cheaper than any new house on a hillside.²
- 7 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,118** — *A carter's mule lost at Drochaid Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The road bed of Drochaid Ros fhionn gives way under a salt-carter's mule one wet spring; the mule drowns in its traces and the carter is left standing waist-deep in the Abhainn bheag holding a dripping harness.
- 13 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,119** — *Drochaid Ros fhionn repaired* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The arches of Drochaid Ros fhionn, worn by seven centuries of salt carts, are built anew at the cost of the salt-masters of Ros fhionn, whose names are cut on the keystones.³
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,129** — *Death of Queen Beathag Fhionn* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag Fhionn, who closed the coast road against the cough, dies at Cathair dhearg. Her son Ailean is crowned, first of four kings of that name in the house of Ragnall.⁴
- 10 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,129** — *Beathag Fhionn's last question* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag Fhionn dies at Cathair dhearg at eighty-nine, dictating a grain ruling the morning she takes to her bed; her last question to the young scribe beside her is whether the road between Seann Bhrál and Muileann dhomhain still stands open.⁵
- 11 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,129** — *Ailean crowned at nine-and-fifty* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean, son of Beathag Fhionn, is crowned at Cathair dhearg within the season of his mother's death, nine-and-fifty years old and no longer a young man by any measure the hall can offer.⁶
- 13 **AM MÀRT, LE 1,139** — *The Baile ghorm blue fades* (Baile ghorm). The last dyer who knew the Baile ghorm mordant dies without apprentices, having quarrelled with both of hers. The blue that follows is the common blue of the rest of the island.
- 11 **AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,149** — *The ancestor-posts of Dùn ìseal burned* (Dùn ìseal). Lightning fires the ancestor-posts at Dùn ìseal. The keepers cut the names again from memory and from the custody-book, and own in their roll that some are guesses.

1. → Caused by *The reeve of Muileann dhombain walks the lower street*, 25 am Faoilleach, LE 1,095.

2. ← Follows from *Muileann dhombain resettled*, 5 an Lùnastal, LE 1,104.

3. → Caused by *A carter's mule lost at Drochaid Ros fhionn*, 7 an t-Samhain, LE 1,118.

4. ◇ Same person *Birth of Ailean, son of Beathag Fhionn*, 20 an t-Samhain, LE 1,070.

5. ← Follows from *Death of Queen Beathag Fhionn*, 2 an Dàmhair, LE 1,129.

- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,150** — *The names cut again at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Setting new ancestor-posts in the old ground the season after lightning burns the old ones to their footings, the keepers of Dùn ìseal cut the names again as best their own memories and their neighbours' can give them back.⁷
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,159** — *The silting of Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). A shifting bar below Ros fhionn silts up the Abhainn bheag, and the salt barges can no longer reach the quays. The salt-masters take their trade to Caol gharbh on the coast.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,169** — *Caol gharbh takes the salt* (Caol gharbh). Caol gharbh, a fishing village, becomes the salt port of the north-east, and its harbour is dug out and walled with the money of the Ros fhionn masters.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,169** — *The stone on the neck* (Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich⁸). Caol gharbh and Caol chrom, the two harbours of the strait, send their headmen to a stone on the neck of land between them, and there settle the dues the salt-boats pay to each. Thereafter they meet at that stone over every quarrel of the strait, and it is called Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich, the meeting of the neck.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,170** — *A barge broken at Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich*⁹ (Caol gharbh). A laden barge out of the new harbour at Caol gharbh misjudges the tide at the narrows called Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich and strikes the reef, going down with half her salt still aboard. Both crewmen swim ashore alive. The harbour-masters set the channel's first withy at the rock the following spring.¹⁰
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,172** — *The last bridge-keeper of Drochaid Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The keeper of Drochaid Ros fhionn dies with no daughter or kinsman willing to take up the toll, and the crown's reeve at Ros fhionn lets the office lapse rather than name a stranger to it. The toll-gate stands open thereafter, and no crossing is ever again refused for want of a toll.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,173** — *The market-court's answer* (Ros fhionn). Asked whether Ros fhionn's market-court should follow its trade to Caol gharbh, the court's own clerks answer that a court sits where disputes are brought to it, not where the season's cargo happens to lie, and the bench of two-hundred-year oak is not moved.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,176** — *Seòlaid Ros fhionn*¹¹ *withied* (Ros fhionn). The channel above the flats where the barge was lost is marked from the old bar to open water with a line of withies, Seòlaid Ros fhionn, so that a new pilot may learn the crossing in a season rather than the ten years the old salt-masters once needed.

6. ← Follows from *Death of Queen Beathag Fhionn*, 2 an Dàmhair, LE 1,129.

7. ← Follows from *The ancestor-posts of Dùn ìseal burned*, 11 an Giblean, LE 1,149.

8. the meeting at the neck

9. the meeting at the neck

10. ← Follows from *Caol gharbh takes the salt*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,169.

11. the marked fairway above Ros fhionn's flats

- 20 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,179** — *Drochaid Ros fhionn falls quiet* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The salt going by sea from Caol gharbh, the carts no longer cross Drochaid Ros fhionn. The office of bridge-keeper is done away with, and from this time the bridge is little used.¹²
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,184** — *The market-court stays at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The salt-masters take their ships to Caol gharbh but leave their market-court on the headland at Ros fhionn, where the weights and tally-sticks are kept. The farms and forges of the north-eastern hills still bring their goods there, and the town keeps its market after it has lost its harbour.
- 25 AM MÀRT, LE 1,189** — *Seòlaid Ros fhionn*¹³ (Ros fhionn). The salt of Ros fhionn now goes by sea: its boats run down the river past Caol gharbh, round the north-east cape, south along the eastern shore past Seann Tarr and Àth bheag, and west again into the bay below Caol shean, where the salt goes inland. The lane is called Seòlaid Ros fhionn after the town whose salt made it, and the eastern boats keep it long after the salt-pans fail.
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,189** — *The millers of Muileann shean* (Muileann shean). The mills of Muileann shean are fitted with a new gearing, cut in oak, that turns two stones from one wheel. Within a lifetime it spreads to the mills of the north.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,189** — *Raghnall mac Chaluim sent to Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). A priest of the schools of the stag, hearing a shepherd's son of the north-west coast count and recount a flock through an afternoon, tells the boy's father the child belongs at a house of disputation. Raghnall mac Chaluim, fourteen years old, is sent south to Dùn thais the following spring.
- 25 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,195** — *The gearing model hung over the millers' door*. The millers of Muileann shean, who first cut the gearing that lets one wheel turn two stones, hang a carved model of it over their own door, a boast that grows quieter with every mill in the north that copies it without asking leave.¹⁴
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,199** — *The Sea-Watcher off the north-west* (Uilebheist na Mara¹⁵). Fishers of the thinned north-west coast see the Sea-Watcher, Uilebheist na Mara, near enough to foul their nets. The few boats still working those waters draw further in.
- 21 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,200** — *Birth of Ailean mac Raghnaill* (Cathair dhearg). A son, Ailean, is born in Sliochd Raghnaill¹⁶, the crown's own house since the reign of Mòrag Ruadh; Leabhar a' Chùraim¹⁷ gives the year and the house and no more.

12. → Caused by *The last bridge-keeper of Drochaid Ros fhionn*, 29 an t-Sultain, LE 1,172; ⇌ At the same time *The market-court's answer*, 28 an Dàmhair, LE 1,173; ← Leads to *Seòlaid Ros fhionn withied*, 26 an t-Samhain, LE 1,176.

13. the marked fairway above Ros fhionn's flats

14. ← Follows from *The millers of Muileann shean*, 15 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,189.

15. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

16. the house of Raghnall

17. the custody-book of the vein-house

THE YEARS LE 1,201 – 1,300

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,205** — *Raghnall begins the count of years* (Dùn thais). Raghnall mac Chaluim, thirty years old, begins setting the birth and death rolls of the custodian houses beside those of their tenants at Dùn thais, a labour that will occupy his lamplit evenings for nine years before he brings any finding before Taigh na Deasbaid¹.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,209** — *The table of years at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). Raghnall mac Chaluim, a scholar of the druid school at Dùn thais, sets out a table showing that the heads of the custodian houses live some years longer, on the whole, than the tenants of their lands. He asks whether the vein answers the hand that holds it. The finding is set down with unease, and no answer.²
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,209** — *A scholar answered at the reading* (Dùn thais). When a scholar of Taigh na Deasbaid³ calls Raghnall's table a wish dressed in columns, Raghnall offers to run the sums a fifth time on rolls the scholar himself chooses. The scholar sits down without taking up the offer, and the hall remembers the silence longer than the exchange.⁴
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,219** — *The table forbidden* (Muileann dhearg). The king's council forbids the copying of Raghnall mac Chaluim's table of years, and the house of disputation at Dùn thais is shut for a generation. Raghnall's own copy is kept in the vein-house and entered in its inventory.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,219** — *Raghnall's copy entered in Taigh na Fèithe's inventory* (Muileann dhearg). A custodian who has never met Raghnall mac Chaluim writes to ask whether his working copy of Clàr nam Bliadhnachan⁶ still exists and might be sent to the mountain for safekeeping. It is sent, and entered that year in Taigh na Fèithe's own inventory, one line among the galleries and Clachan a' Chrannchuir⁷.⁸
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,229** — *The great gale at Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Before the autumn grain fleet has sailed, a gale out of the north-east drives the sea up the river at Inis mhòr higher than any then living had seen. Boats are crushed at their moorings, and the grain fleet does not sail until spring.
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,240** — *Death of Raghnall mac Chaluim* (Dùn thais). Raghnall mac Chaluim dies at Dùn thais in his sixty-sixth year, in the small house the shut school let him keep. The scholars who once argued his table carry him to the school's own burying ground and set a tally-stick at his grave's head, notched once for every year the making of the table cost him.⁹

1. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

2. → Caused by *Raghnall begins the count of years*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,205.

3. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

4. ⇌ At the same time *The table of years at Dùn thais*, 29 an t-Samhain, LE 1,209.

5. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

6. the table of years

7. the stones of the lot

8. ← Follows from *The table forbidden*, 29 an Giblean, LE 1,219.

- 25 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,240** — *Birth of Iain Ciar* (Cathair dhearg). A son, dark-browed and called Iain Ciar, is born to Ailean mac Raghnaill, then forty years old, the elder of two sons he has by different mothers.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,246** — *Baile ruadh's quarrel with Achadh naomb* (Baile ruadh). Baile ruadh and Achadh naomb in the far north-east go to law over the grazing on the hills between them. The case is heard three times at Cathair dhearg, and settled by dividing the hills along a stream.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,246** — *The boundary stones carried home unused* (Baile ruadh). After the king's council divides the disputed grazing between Baile ruadh and Achadh naomb along a stream, both shire seats carry home the boundary stones they had brought to argue their claim and set them, unused, into their own walls, where they stand for the rest of the age pointing to a line the water has already made no matter of.¹⁰
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,259** — *Pilgrims at Allt an Aigh*¹¹ (Allt an Aigh). The keepers of the Old Spirits renew the pilgrimage to Allt an Aigh, and a guest-house is built beside the stream for those who come to drink at the right phase of the moon. Its book names pilgrims from every shire.
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,264** — *The keeping of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr passes to Mairead nic Mhurchaidh* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The last keeper of a long line descended from Iain mac Mhurchaidh, who built the road-house its second byre and began the book of the ox-teams that lodged there, gives over the keeping to his daughter Mairead. She continues the ledger in a hand the ox-drivers of the mining road cannot tell from her father's.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,266** — *Death of King Ailean mac Raghnaill* (Cathair dhearg). King Ailean mac Raghnaill dies at Cathair dhearg, leaving two sons by different mothers, Iain Ciar and Alasdair Bàin, and each has been told he is the heir.¹²
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,266** — *The blank space on the burial roll* (Cathair dhearg). Drawing up King Ailean mac Raghnaill's burial roll, An Talla Dearg¹³'s clerks leave a blank space where the heir's name should stand, unable to agree between themselves which of his two sons to write and unwilling to write neither.¹⁴
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,266** — *The inventory read past the forbidden line* (Muileann dhearg). At the winter reading of Taigh na Fèithe¹⁵'s inventory, the custodian pauses a moment longer than usual over the line entered nearly fifty years before, Clàr nam Bliadh-nachan¹⁶, forbidden to be copied, kept, and then reads on, for the reckoning of that year's coal still has a great deal more of the shelf left to answer for.¹⁷

9. ¶ Legacy *The table forbidden*, 29 an Giblean, LE 1,219.

10. ← Follows from *Baile ruadh's quarrel with Achadh naomb*, 3 an t-Sultain, LE 1,246.

11. the stream of the healing water

12. ◇ Same person *Birth of Ailean mac Raghnaill*, 21 an Gearran, LE 1,200.

13. the red hall, the rich's hall at Cathair dhearg

14. ← Follows from *Death of King Ailean mac Raghnaill*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,266.

15. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

16. the table of years

- 24 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,269** — *A refused gift at the feast of Bealltach* (Cathair dhearg). A messenger of Alasdair Bàn's, riding to An Talla Dearg¹⁸ with the household's ordinary feast-gift, is turned back at the gate on a pretext of business too full to receive him, the first courtesy either brother's household has refused the other in four years of careful giving.¹⁹
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,270** — *The battle of Cnoc naomh* (Cnoc naomh). Alasdair Bàn's men seize Cnoc naomh and Iain Ciar takes it back. The houses divide four to three, and from this battle Cogadh nam Bràithrean²⁰, the Brothers' War, takes its name.²¹
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,270** — *The roads set under one following's watch or the other*. With both households calling up every man their houses owe them, the two brothers set every road between the two halves of the island under one following's watch or the other, so that carters who have crossed freely their whole lives must now say plainly which brother's peace they travel under.²²
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,272** — *The fire at Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). Alasdair Bàn's ships burn the waterfront of Ceann mhin, which held for his brother. The fire takes the rope stores and the granary, and the town begs its bread of Cathair mhòr.
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,272** — *Cathair mhòr feeds Ceann mhin* (Cathair mhòr). After Alasdair Bàn's ships burn the rope stores and the granary of Ceann mhin in one night, the town sends to Cathair mhòr, which has taken no side, and Cathair mhòr sends grain enough that no household at Ceann mhin goes hungry that winter.²³
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,274** — *The battle of Muileann ghlais* (Muileann ghlais). Iain Ciar defeats Alasdair Bàn below Muileann ghlais. Alasdair is taken alive; his captains are let go home.
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,274** — *Word of Muileann ghlais reaches the road-house* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). An ox-driver who turns back from the mountain road rather than push his team through unsettled country brings word of Iain Ciar's victory to An Taigh-seinnse Mòr within the week. Asked where the two brothers now stand to one another, he can only shrug: no one yet knows.²⁴
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,276** — *The brothers' peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The brothers make peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, on neutral ground between their lands. Alasdair Bàn gives up his claim and has the lordship of Seann Chwen for life. Iain Ciar is crowned.

17. ¶ Legacy *The table forbidden*, 29 an Giblean, LE 1,219.

18. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

19. ← Follows from *Death of King Ailean mac Raghnaill*, 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,266.

20. the Brothers' War

21. → Caused by *A refused gift at the feast of Bealltach*, 24 an Giblean, LE 1,269.

22. ← Follows from *The battle of Cnoc naomh*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,270.

23. ← Follows from *The fire at Ceann mhin*, 17 an Lùnastal, LE 1,272.

24. ← Follows from *The battle of Muileann ghlais*, 19 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,274.

- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,276** — *The keeper warned a day before* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). A messenger carries word to An Taigh-seinnse Mòr that the two brothers and their followings are riding for the road-house to make their peace there. Mairead nic Mhurchaidh is given a single day's warning and spends the better part of it scrubbing the common-room floor.²⁵
- 23 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,276** — *The benches measured to a finger's breadth* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Before the brothers arrive, Mairead nic Mhurchaidh measures the two benches of the common-room board against one another with her own hands until neither runs longer than its match, and sets the same loaf and the same jug of ale at either end, giving neither man the smallest excuse to find a slight in the setting of the table.²⁶
- 9 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,276** — *Iain Ciar crowned at six-and-thirty* (Cathair dhearg). With the brothers' peace made at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, Iain Ciar is crowned at Cathair dhearg, six-and-thirty years old, ten years after his father's burial roll was drawn with a blank where the heir's name should stand.²⁷
- 23 **AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,282** — *A reeve of Cathair mhòr presses the keeper for more* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Years after the peace, an old reeve of Cathair mhòr asks Mairead nic Mhurchaidh whether the two brothers raised their voices in the long silence at her board. She answers only that she heard nothing through the door she had not already heard from her own oxen, and will say no more of it.²⁸
- 7 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,283** — *Alasdair Bàn rides up with a dead captain's news* (Cathair dhearg). Alasdair Bàn goes up to An Talla Dearg²⁹ himself to carry word of an old captain's death to the king with his own mouth, as the captain asked dying; Iain Ciar receives him without ceremony and sends him home with no larger following than he came with.
- 8 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,291** — *Death of Alasdair Bàn* (Seann Chwen). Alasdair Bàn dies at Seann Chwen, having kept the peace he made. His lordship returns to the crown.³⁰
- 28 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,291** — *Iain Ciar keeps his brother's lordship vacant* (Seann Chwen). On Alasdair Bàn's death the lordship of Seann Chwen returns to the crown as the brothers' peace had settled it should. Iain Ciar keeps the lordship vacant for the rest of his own reign rather than grant it to another man, a stubbornness An Talla Dearg³¹'s clerks never once ask him to explain.³²
- 29 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,295** — *White stone from Baile Mòr dhombhain* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Masons of Ceann leathan buy a veined white stone from the hills above Baile Mòr dhomhain for the new front of their temple. From this time the quarry is worked, and its marble goes south by the carriers' road to every town that can pay for it.

25. → Leads to *The brothers' peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 1,276.

26. → Leads to *The brothers' peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 1,276.

27. ← Follows from *The brothers' peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 1,276.

28. ↓ Legacy *The brothers' peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr*, 12 an t-Sultain, LE 1,276.

29. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

30. → Caused by *Alasdair Bàn rides up with a dead captain's news*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,283.

31. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

32. ← Follows from *Death of Alasdair Bàn*, 8 an Dàmhair, LE 1,291.

- 24 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,296** — *A mason's slab kept on the road-house mantel* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). With the first carts of white marble passing south from the quarries above Baile Mòr dhomhain, Mairead nic Mhurchaidh keeps an unworked slab of the stone, no bigger than a hand, on the mantel above her own hearth, a small vanity she never fully explains to those who ask her why a road-house keeper should want a piece of stone bound for someone else's temple.³³
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,298** — *Pàdraig mac Ruairidh lodges three nights at the road-house* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Gathering material for *Leabhar nam Bràithrean*³⁴, the king's clerk Pàdraig mac Ruairidh stays three nights at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr at his own expense, working each evening by the fire the two brothers once sat beside, and asks the keeper and every passing ox-driver for the tale of the peace. He leaves her a measure of meal for the fire and the bed before he rides on.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,299** — *Iain Ciar's grain law* (Cathair dhearg). Having seen Ceann mhin beg its bread, King Iain Ciar commands that every shire seat keep a year's grain in store against the next war. The law is kept as long as he lives.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,299** — *Death of Mairead nic Mhurchaidh* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Mairead nic Mhurchaidh dies at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr in her own bed, at sixty-nine years old, on a night an ox-team lodges in the byre below her window. The keeping of the house passes to a sister's daughter raised under the same roof.

33. ← Follows from *White stone from Baile Mòr dhombain*, 29 an Dàmhair, LE 1,295.

34. the book of the brothers

THE YEARS LE 1,301 – 1,400

- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,304** — *The account of the Brothers' War* (Cathair dhearg). Pàdraig mac Ruairidh, a clerk of King Iain Ciar, writes the story of the Brothers' War. It praises the king at every turn, and it is the only account that survives, to the vexation of later readers.¹
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,319** — *The inns of the mining roads chartered* (An Sligeanach Fad' às²). The crown grants a charter to the seven great road-houses of the mining circuit, An Sligeanach Fad' às among them, and makes their keepers answerable for the roads between them. The keepers meet once a year at An Sligeanach Fad' às to settle their accounts.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,320** — *The keepers' first yearly meeting* (An Sligeanach Fad' às³). The seven keepers of the newly chartered road-houses meet for the first time at An Sligeanach Fad' às to settle their accounts, as the charter now commands once every year. Asked whether the tale of the brothers' peace is as her aunt always told it, the new keeper of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr gives the same answer, word for word.⁴
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,320** — *Pàdraig mac Ruairidh's death* (Cathair dhearg). The clerk who wrote Leabhar nam Bràithrean⁵ in King Iain Ciar's praise dies some years before his king, and no scribe comes after him to keep the tale of the grain law's slow lapsing as he had kept the tale of the war itself.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,326** — *Death of Iain Ciar* (Cathair dhearg). King Iain Ciar dies at Cathair dhearg. His grain law lapses within a few years, as he had foreseen in a note in his own hand.⁶
- 22 AM MÀRT, LE 1,339** — *An Taigh-seinnse Òir's beef* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir). An Taigh-seinnse Òir, at the eastern end of the circuit, is written into the charter-roll as keeping syrupped beef for the custodians' reeves on their rounds. It is the first dish of that house on record; the rest of the entry is a complaint about the price.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,339** — *The reeve's price complaint at An Taigh-seinnse Òir*⁸ (An Taigh-seinnse Òir). A custodians' reeve who has eaten the house's secret syrupped beef twice a winter for a decade writes into the charter-roll that the price has risen three years running with nothing else about the dish improved, and asks for a second helping in the same breath.⁹

1. → Caused by *Pàdraig mac Ruairidh lodges three nights at the road-house*, 27 am Faoilleach, LE 1,298.

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

3. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

4. ← Follows from *The inns of the mining roads chartered*, 28 an Giblean, LE 1,319.

5. the book of the brothers

6. ◇ Same person *Birth of Iain Ciar*, 25 an Gearran, LE 1,240; ← Leads to *Pàdraig mac Ruairidh's death*, 23 an Lùnastal, LE 1,320.

7. the golden house, a waypoint inn

8. the golden house, a waypoint inn

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,349** — *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). An Taigh-seinnse Reòta, the road-house on the bare northern road, is snowed in for a whole season with a party of custodians' reeves within. They live on its pickled spinach and fire milk, and their complaint stands in full in the charter-roll.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,349** — *The keeper's itemised bill* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). When the snow that trapped a party of reeves at An Taigh-seinnse Reòta finally lifts, the house's keeper sends after them, by the first cart through, a bill for every jar of pickled spinach and every cup of fire milk they took, itemised, and it is paid in full.¹⁰
- 11 AM MÀRT, LE 1,359** — *The bull that sank at launch* (Seann Skell). Seumas mac Iain, a boat-builder of Seann Skell, tries to build a deep-keeled hull again from the scraps of the Sundering fellowship's lore still remembered on the strand. At its launch it fills and sinks, and Manannan's priests preach on it for a year.
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,362** — *Seumas mac Iain gives up the deep keel* (Seann Skell). After a year of Manannan's priests preaching against his sunken hull, the boat-builder of Seann Skell builds no more deep keels, and keeps his harbour shed mending ordinary boats for ordinary fares until his death.¹¹
- 31 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,369** — *The Caol ìseal fishers go east* (Caol ìseal). Their own harbour silted, the fishing families of Caol ìseal on the north coast move east to Caol bheag. Caol ìseal becomes a farming town.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,369** — *The shrine carried whole to Caol bheag* (Caol bheag). The fishers who leave Caol ìseal's silted harbour carry their nets, their smoking-racks and the small shrine from the harbour's edge, and set the shrine up again at Caol bheag stone by stone in the same order, so that it stands as it always stood.¹²
- 13 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,380** — *Caol ìseal turns to the plough*. The houses of Caol ìseal nearest the silted water turn to farming the ground behind them after the fishers go east, and within two generations the town that smelled of fish and tar smells, most days, of turned earth.¹³
- 4 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,389** — *The southern lane* (Caol fhiadhaich). The fishers of Caol fhiadhaich, on the wild strait of the west coast, take their boats round into the southern sea, along the whole south coast to the mouth of the Abhainn uaine, and up it to the landing of Cidhe Beag below Baile thais, where they sell dried fish for grain. The older harbours of the south coast, which had never sailed beyond their own capes, begin to follow. The lane is named for its first sailors: Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich¹⁴.

9. ← Follows from *An Taigh-seinnse Òir's beef*, 22 am Màrt, LE 1,339.

10. ← Follows from *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta*, 20 an Giblean, LE 1,349.

11. ← Follows from *The bull that sank at launch*, 11 am Màrt, LE 1,359.

12. ← Follows from *The Caol ìseal fishers go east*, 31 an Cèitean, LE 1,369.

13. ← Follows from *The Caol ìseal fishers go east*, 31 an Cèitean, LE 1,369.

14. the southern sea-lane

- 5 **AM MÀRT, LE 1,389** — *The keel-song of Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Iseabail nic Lachlainn, a gatherer of songs for the royal household, takes down a work-song of the rope-makers of Cuan shean that names the parts of a deep keel. Half its words mean nothing to those who sing it. It is all that survives, in any form, of the craft of the Sundering fleet.
- 25 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,389** — *The Stone's schism at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The Stone's congregation at Inis thais divides over whether the dead may be prayed for at Clach. Those who say no keep the temple; the others build a second house at Baile gheal.
- 27 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,389** — *Iseabail nic Lachlainn sent out on the king's road* (Cathair dhearg). The steward of the royal household at Cathair dhearg, wanting a linen-maid's quick-eared daughter out from under his feet, sends her out with a mule and a letter of lodging to gather what the shires' kitchens and rope-walks still sing at their work.¹⁵
- 30 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,389** — *A rope-maker's guess at the old words* (Cuan shean). A young man of Tormod Ròpaire's crew, not yet trusted with the lead, tells the gatherer Iseabail that Òran na Druime¹⁶'s strange words are likely only older speech worn smooth by centuries of mouths that never meant to wear it; Tormod answers that it changes nothing about how the strand is walked.¹⁷
- 3 **AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,391** — *Òran na Druime*¹⁸ *read at the king's court* (Cathair dhearg). Iseabail nic Lachlainn reads her whole gathering before the king's hall at Cathair dhearg, and Òran na Druime's strange lines silence a room grown used to songs it half knows already; an old harper and a clerk of Taigh na Fèithe¹⁹ each say the words fit no tongue or hand they know, and neither can say more than that.²⁰
- II **AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,391** — *The older southern harbours follow the new lane* (Baile thais). A season or two after Caol fhiadhaich's boats are first believed, the older harbours of the south coast, which had never in memory put a boat past their own headlands, begin one after another to follow Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich²¹ down to the landing at Cidhe Beag.²²
- 3 **AN GEARRAN, LE 1,399** — *The grey storm at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). A storm named Gailleann Ghlas comes out of the east and destroys the harbour of Seann Tarr. The village is rebuilt and the harbour is not; its boats go to Cuan ruadh.
- 8 **AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,399** — *The second wolf-house at Baile gheal* (Baile gheal). The dissenters from Inis thais raise their house at Baile gheal and pray there for the dead by name. The two houses of the Stone are not reconciled in this age.

15. → Leads to *The keel-song of Cuan shean*, 5 am Màrt, LE 1,389.

16. the song of the keel

17. ← Follows from *The keel-song of Cuan shean*, 5 am Màrt, LE 1,389.

18. the song of the keel

19. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

20. ← Follows from *The keel-song of Cuan shean*, 5 am Màrt, LE 1,389.

21. the southern sea-lane

22. ← Follows from *The southern lane*, 4 an Gearran, LE 1,389.

- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,400** — *Death of Tormod Ròpaire* (Cuan shean). The rope-maker who led the walk that sang Òran na Druime²³ dies at Cuan shean, seventy years old, having in his last years let a younger man keep the count while he sang on behind him; his crew keeps the song after him exactly as he gave it, no better understood than before.²⁴
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,400** — *Birth of Catriona Bheag*. A daughter, Catriona, is born into Clann Raghnaill, the crown's own house; she is small from the cradle, and the house calls her Catriona Bheag.

23. the song of the keel

24. ◇ Same person *The keel-song of Cuan shean*, 5 am Màrt, LE 1,389.

THE YEARS LE 1,401 – 1,500

- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,405** — *Seann Tarr becomes a village again* (Seann Tarr). With its harbour broken past mending and its boats gone to Cuan ruadh, Seann Tarr keeps its houses and its shrine but is entered in the charter-roll, in the roll's own dry word for such places, as a village once more rather than a harbour town.¹
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,409** — *Cuan ruadh's new harbour* (Cuan ruadh). Cuan ruadh builds a second harbour arm for the boats from Seann Tarr, and thrives on the east-coast fishing for the rest of the age.
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,420** — *Iseabail's tablets entered in Taigh na Fèithe*² (Muileann dhearg). On Iseabail nic Lachlainn's death the household she served the rest of her life sends her whole collection to Taigh na Fèithe, where the clerks write into the inventory that it holds one item they can describe only by its sound and its keeping, not its meaning.³
- 31 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,429** — *Queen Catrìona Bheag crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Catrìona Bheag of Clann Raghnaill is crowned at Cathair dhearg, the first queen in more than three centuries. It is written that she was small, and that no one said so twice.⁴
- 26 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,439** — *The grey glaze of Muileann gheal* (Muileann gheal). The potters of Muileann gheal make a grey-green glaze that no other kiln on the island can match, and the custodian houses buy it for their tables. The secret is kept within one family, Clann Mhic Phàil.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,449** — *The oath of the seven* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Catrìona Bheag has the heads of the seven houses swear to the ruling of the hearth before her, the first renewal of the oath since Catrìona Bhuadhach. Clann Choinnich swears last.
- 29 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,449** — *Clann Choinnich's head asks the manner of the oath* (Cathair dhearg). Before swearing last to Riaghailt an Teallaich⁵, the head of Clann Choinnich asks Queen Catrìona Bheag plainly whether the renewed oath changes the measure her house holds or only the manner of swearing to it. The queen answers that it changes only the manner, and the old woman swears.⁶
- 14 AM MÀRT, LE 1,459** — *Macha's great house at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). The priests of Macha raise their great house at Cathair mhòr, the largest roofed building on Dia-thìr in this age. Its floor of black and white was eleven years in the laying.

1. ¶ Legacy *The grey storm at Seann Tarr*, 3 an Gearran, LE 1,399.

2. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

3. ¶ Legacy *The keel-song of Cuan shean*, 5 am Màrt, LE 1,389.

4. ◇ Same person *Birth of Catrìona Bheag*, 5 an Dàmhair, LE 1,400.

5. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

6. → Leads to *The oath of the seven*, 28 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,449.

- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,459** — *The last stone laid in Macha's floor* (Cathair mhòr). The black and white floor of Macha's great house at Cathair mhòr is finished, eleven years in the laying, by masons none of whom cut its first courses. It stands the largest roofed building on Dia-thìr.⁷
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,469** — *The eastern Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). Charcoal-burners in the east find again the eastern Toll-dubh of the old tales, with the same cut stair as the one walled up in the west. The custodians wall this one too, and the scribe binds the two entries of the custody-book each to the other.
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,469** — *Leabhar a' Chùraim*⁸ *binds the two stairs* (Toll-dubh). When charcoal-burners break into the eastern Toll-dubh, the scribe of Leabhar a' Chùraim binds its entry to the western stair's with a line in each margin, though nothing is written of what either stair goes down to.⁹
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,479** — *The dry years at Achadh shean* (Tiormachd Achadh shean)¹⁰. Three dry seasons one after another empty the wells of the eastern shires about Achadh shean. The shared meal holds, and the crown carts grain in from the south.
- 10 AM MÀRT, LE 1,483** — *The well-head board first cut* (Achadh shean). As the crown's grain carts still reach Achadh shean by the mining road against a second dry season, the reeves cut a board at the well-head setting down how the deep wells will be shared among the households by lot and by turn. The board is renewed each generation; the lots themselves are never drawn again.¹¹
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,489** — *The water-rights of Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). The reeves of Achadh shean share the deep wells among the households by lot and by turn, and write the sharing on a board at the well-head. The board is renewed each generation; the lots are never drawn again.¹²
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,498** — *A clerk finds the worn firlot* (Àth shean). A young clerk newly set over the granary accounts at Àth shean finds, going back through the ledgers, that the firlot has worn smaller than the standard of Cathair dhearg, and has been so for longer than any one reeve's term could account for. He carries the matter up rather than let it stand.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,499** — *The firlot of Àth shean* (Àth shean). The granary of Àth shean finds that its firlot has worn smaller than the standard of Cathair dhearg, and has been so for generations. The reeve's accounts are put right as far back as anyone can reckon.

13

7. → Leads to *Macha's great house at Cathair mhòr*, 14 am Màrt, LE 1,459.

8. the custody-book of the vein-house

9. → Leads to *The eastern Toll-dubh*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,469.

10. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

11. ← Follows from *The dry years at Achadh shean*, 2 an Dàmhair, LE 1,479.

12. ← Leads to *The well-head board first cut*, 10 am Màrt, LE 1,483.

13. → Caused by *A clerk finds the worn firlot*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,498.

THE YEARS LE 1,501 – 1,600

- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,505** — *Birth of Sileas Òg* (Cathair dhearg). A daughter, Sileas, is born in the house of the crown in the seventy-seventh year of Queen Catrìona Bheag's reign, and called Sileas Òg after the queen who first measured the island's baskets.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,505** — *Iain Mac Phàil tries to write the glaze down*. In the last years of his life Iain Mac Phàil, the last of Clann Mhic Phàil at Muileann gheal, tries to set the grey-green glaze's making down in some form a stranger might follow, and finds the moment of the kiln's cooling will not go into words.
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,507** — *Two apprentices fail the grey-green firing* (Muileann gheal). Iain Mac Phàil takes two apprentices in his last years and teaches them the mixing of the grey-green glaze, but neither learns to judge the moment the kiln's heat must be let fall. Both come away able to throw a passable dish and unable to glaze it.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,509** — *The grey glaze lost* (Muileann gheal). The last of Clann Mhic Phàil dies at Muileann gheal without passing on the glaze. For a generation the potters of the town try to match it, and fail.¹
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,518** — *Drovers of Àth chiar bring their beasts to Baile Mòr ruadh* (Baile Mòr ruadh). Drovers from Àth chiar and the eastern hills begin bringing their cattle down to Baile Mòr ruadh's autumn fair rather than selling nearer home, and within a few years it is the greatest fair in the east.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,519** — *Baile Mòr ruadh's fair* (Baile Mòr ruadh). Baile Mòr ruadh in the east holds a cattle fair that draws drovers from Àth chiar and the eastern hills. It becomes yearly, and the greatest fair in the east.²
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,529** — *Queen Sileas Òg crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Sileas Òg of Clann Raghnaill, named for the queen of the firiot, is crowned at Cathair dhearg. She is the first ruler known to have visited every shire seat.³
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,531** — *Sileas Òg questioned on her purpose* (Cathair dhearg). Asked years later what put the notion of a round of every shire seat in her head, Queen Sileas Òg says she had grown up hearing the seats named at her father's table like places in a story, and wished to know them as a place stood in rather than a tale repeated.⁴
- 2 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,534** — *The reeve of Achadh shean questioned at the well-head* (Achadh shean). On her round, Sileas Òg stands at the well-head of Achadh shean and asks the reeve why the lots for the deep wells were never drawn a second time. He answers that no household wished to be the one that named the first sharing unfair. She rides on the next morning without asking him to change it.⁵

1. → Caused by *Iain Mac Phàil tries to write the glaze down*, 22 an t-Sultain, LE 1,505; → Caused by *Two apprentices fail the grey-green firing*, 22 am Faoilleach, LE 1,507.

2. → Caused by *Drovers of Àth chiar bring their beasts to Baile Mòr ruadh*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,518.

3. ♦ Same person *Birth of Sileas Òg*, 24 an Lùnastal, LE 1,505.

4. → Leads to *Queen Sileas Òg crowned*, 9 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,529.

- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,535** — *Sileas Òg reaches the last shire seat of her round.* Queen Sileas Òg's circuit carries her at last to the bare northern stretch few rulers before her had visited, the first ruler of Dia-thir known to have stood in every shire seat the island holds.⁶
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,539** — *Sileas Òg's count of hands* (Muileann dhearg). Queen Sileas Òg commands a new count of every household holding the right to the coal. It is smaller than any before, for the right has narrowed into fewer and larger households, and the queen has it entered without comment.
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,539** — *The queen enters the count without comment* (Muileann dhearg). Reading the new, smaller count of households holding the right to the coal, Sileas Òg has it entered in *Leabhar a' Chùraim*⁷ without a word either way, a silence her own scribes find harder to read than any word she might have spoken.⁸
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,549** — *The fire of Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). A second great fire burns Ceann mhin, and this time there is no war to blame. By order of its reeve the town is rebuilt with gable walls of stone between the houses.
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,549** — *Ceann mhin's reeve orders the gable walls* (Ceann mhin). Before the ash of the second fire has cooled, the reeve of Ceann mhin orders the town rebuilt with gable walls of stone standing between each house and the next, so that a fire must cross stone to spread.⁹
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,550** — *Birth of Ailean the Fourth* (Cathair dhearg). A son, named Ailean mac Raghnaill after the kings of that name before him, is born into the crown's house in the two-and-twentieth year of Queen Sileas Òg's reign.
- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,556** — *Birth of Mòrag nic Raghnaill* (Cathair dhearg). A daughter, Mòrag, is born to the same house, six years younger than her brother Ailean.
- 1 AM MÀRT, LE 1,558** — *Clann Choinnich's clerk drafts Athchuingean an Airgid*¹⁰ (Muileann dhearg). After three winters of the head of Clann Choinnich arguing that the coal might be spared beyond the measured handful to smelt silver at Muileann chiar, a younger kinsman of the house drafts the petition the council will hear, the first written asking to burn the coal for work rather than worship.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,559** — *The silver smelt refused* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Clann Choinnich asks leave to burn the coal beyond the measured handful to smelt silver at Muileann chiar, since the coal burns hotter than charcoal. The council refuses. It is the first asking to burn the coal for work and not for worship.¹¹

5. ¶ Legacy *The water-rights of Achadh shean*, 2 an t-Samhain, LE 1,489.

6. ← Follows from *Queen Sileas Òg crowned*, 9 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,529.

7. the custody-book of the vein-house

8. → Leads to *Sileas Òg's count of hands*, 4 an Dàmhair, LE 1,539.

9. → Leads to *The fire of Ceann mhin*, 5 an t-Sultain, LE 1,549.

10. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,559** — *The queen's word to Clann Choinnich's head* (Muileann dhearg). Once the council's refusal is final, Sileas Òg tells Clann Choinnich's head privately that a law kept since before the fleet sailed for one reason is not easily bent to a second, however sound. The old woman accepts the courtesy without being persuaded.¹²
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,568** — *The last blade of the old folding* (Dùn dhearg). The fellowship of Dùn dhearg loses the last smith trained far enough in the layered steel's folding to finish it alone. The blades made after him are ordinary work, prized now only for what the craft once was.
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,569** — *The lost smithing at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). The smiths of Dùn dhearg, makers of the ceremonial blades of the custodian houses since the walls were built, lose the last man who knew how their layered steel was folded. After him the blades of Dùn dhearg are ordinary.¹³
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,579** — *The houses bury at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*¹⁴ (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach). The custodian houses begin to bury their heads at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach, among graves older than any name on them. The tenants of the land about call it unwise, and go on burying their own dead elsewhere.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,580** — *The tenants of Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*¹⁵ *keep their own ground* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach). When Na Seachd Taighean¹⁶ begin burying their heads at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach, the tenants of the land about it call the custom unwise and go on burying their own dead where their own families always have, a disagreement neither side presses to settle.¹⁷
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,589** — *King Ailean the Fourth crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean mac Raghnaill, fourth king of that name, is crowned at Cathair dhearg. He is remembered only for the shortest reign in the king-list.¹⁸
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,590** — *The synod of Manannan's order* (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan meet at Seann Skell and lay down again the rule of sight-of-land. To it they add a prayer, said at the foot of the river pool, that Manannan keep the sea shut: A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,590** — *Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean's sister Mòrag nic Raghnaill is crowned after him. She reigns forty years, and the king-list has for her its longest run of entries telling of nothing but good harvests and the rite.¹⁹

11. → Caused by *Clann Choinnich's clerk drafts Athbhuingeann an Airgid*, 1 am Màrt, LE 1,558.

12. → Leads to *The silver smelt refused*, 31 an Lùnastal, LE 1,559.

13. → Caused by *The last blade of the old folding*, 22 an Lùnastal, LE 1,568.

14. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

15. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

16. the seven houses of custody

17. → Leads to *The houses bury at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,579.

18. ◇ Same person *Birth of Ailean the Fourth*, 28 an Giblean, LE 1,550.

19. ◇ Same person *Birth of Mòrag nic Raghnaill*, 31 am Faoilleach, LE 1,556.

- 17 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,590** — *One stone cut for two reigns* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill has the years of her brother Ailean the Fourth's crowning and death cut on a single stone rather than two, the plainest record Clàr nan Rìghrean²⁰ gives of the short reign she outlives by forty years.²¹
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,590** — *The synod argues two days over the prayer's words* (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan in synod at Seann Skell spend two full days over the wording of a new prayer before agreeing on its shortest form, to be said at the foot of the river pool where the fleet once turned.²²
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,590** — *Death of Ailean the Fourth at forty* (Cathair dhearg). King Ailean mac Raghnaill, the fourth of the name, dies at Cathair dhearg within the year of his crowning, forty years old; Leabhar a' Chùrain²³ does not say what ailed him, and his sister Mòrag, four-and-thirty, is crowned before the season turns.²⁴

20. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

21. ← Follows from *King Ailean the Fourth crowned*, 9 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,589; → Leads to *Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill crowned*, 12 an Cèitean, LE 1,590.

22. → Leads to *The synod of Manannan's order*, 13 an Giblean, LE 1,590.

23. the custody-book of the vein-house

24. → Leads to *Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill crowned*, 12 an Cèitean, LE 1,590.

THE YEARS LE 1,601 – 1,700

- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,619** — *The ferry at Cidhe Beag* (Cidhe Beag). A ferry family settles at Cidhe Beag on Abhainn uaine and carries folk and goods down the river by canoe. They hold the landing for the rest of the age.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,619** — *The ferry family holds the landing father to daughter* (Cidhe Beag). The family that settles the ferry crossing at Cidhe Beag holds the landing from father to daughter and daughter to son for the rest of the age, a fixed thing on the eastern road like any ford or road-house.¹
- 1 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,626** — *The dark wine of Àth shean* (Àth shean). The growers on the slopes above Àth shean press blaeberry and bramble into a dark wine that keeps a year in the cask. It is sold along the eastern road, and the road-houses serve it as black wine.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,626** — *The road-houses take up the black wine* (Àth shean). The road-houses of the eastern stretch above Àth shean take to serving the growers' dark blaeberry and bramble pressing as black wine, a trade that outlasts a good deal the age's councils thought more likely to last.²
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,628** — *A clerk reckons forty quiet years* (Cathair dhearg). A clerk who has served Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill the whole of her reign remarks, near the end of his service, that he has written more entries under her than under any three reigns before and set down in all of them no death by war, no famine and no quarrel of Na Seachd Taighean.³
- ⁴
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,630** — *The reign of Mòrag nic Raghnaill ends* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill's reign ends in her four-and-seventieth year, after forty years crowned; Clàr nan Rìghrean⁵ sets down the end of it and little else, as it has set down little else of all her quiet years.⁶
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,634** — *Inis mhòr's grain fleet laid up* (Inis mhòr). The coasting grain barges of Inis mhòr, which had sailed Slighe-uisce fhuar, the cold way along the north coast from Ros chiar to Caol mhin, since the early years of the Sundering, are laid up for good as the roads grow better. The last is kept on the strand as a wonder.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,649** — *Earthquake at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). An earthquake shakes Dùn ìseal and cracks the spirit-house. No one is killed. The keepers take it for a warning, but cannot agree of what.

1. ← Follows from *The ferry at Cidhe Beag*, 16 an t-Samhain, LE 1,619.

2. → Leads to *The dark wine of Àth shean*, 1 an Dàmhair, LE 1,626.

3. the seven houses of custody

4. ← Follows from *Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill crowned*, 12 an Cèitean, LE 1,590.

5. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

6. ← Follows from *Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill crowned*, 12 an Cèitean, LE 1,590.

- 21 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,659** — *Beathag nic Thòmais gathers the old copies* (Muileann chaol). Beathag nic Thòmais, widow of a mill-owner of Muileann chaol, begins to buy old copies of the custody-book and the harbour rolls from houses that no longer read them. She keeps them in a loft over her mill.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,662** — *A cheese-press board sold to the widow of Muileann chaol* (Cathair mhòr). A carter brings Beathag nic Thòmais a blackened board a Cathair mhòr road house has used for years to weight a cheese-press, having noticed writing on its underside: a coal-right tally three generations old. She pays a fair measure of meal for it, telling the carter that a house's own forgetting is no measure of what a board is worth.⁷
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,665** — *A clerk of Taigh na Fèithe⁸ finds a lost ruling in the loft* (Muileann chaol). A clerk riding through Muileann chaol on the crown's business climbs the mill stair out of idleness and finds, among Beathag nic Thòmais's boards, the only surviving copy of a custodians' ruling Taigh na Fèithe had lost to fire two generations before. He asks whether she means the loft for the crown's use or her own; she says the question is not hers to answer alone.⁹
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,674** — *The paper mill at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). A mill at Muileann chaol begins to make paper from rags, the first on Dia-thìr. In this generation the custody-book is first copied onto paper.
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,674** — *Beathag nic Thòmais presses her own sheet of rag paper* (Muileann chaol). Having watched Anna nic Coinnich work her pulp-troughs a season, Beathag presses a sheet with her own hands, uneven at one corner, and keeps it apart from the loft's other papers for the rest of her life without ever saying why.¹⁰
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,674** — *Beathag carries the proposal of paper to Taigh na Fèithe¹¹* (Muileann dhearg). Beathag nic Thòmais rides the sixty miles to Taigh na Fèithe herself to put Anna's rag paper before a custodian, judging a widow's word better heard than a stranger's. Asked whether the new stuff will hold ink sixteen centuries as hide has, she says she cannot promise it, and the custodian lets the copying go ahead.¹²
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,679** — *Three copies of the landfall tidings* (Muileann chaol). Among her papers Beathag nic Thòmais finds three copies of the tidings of the two landfalls. They differ in the order of the coasts and the number of hulls. She writes out all three side by side and does not choose between them.

7. ← Follows from *Beathag nic Thòmais gathers the old copies*, 21 an Cèitean, LE 1,659.

8. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

9. ← Follows from *Beathag nic Thòmais gathers the old copies*, 21 an Cèitean, LE 1,659.

10. ← Follows from *The paper mill at Muileann chaol*, 28 am Faoilleach, LE 1,674.

11. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

12. → Leads to *The paper mill at Muileann chaol*, 28 am Faoilleach, LE 1,674.

- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,679** — *Beathag answers Anna on the three copies* (Muileann chaol). Found still kneeling over the three tellings of the landfall at dusk, Beathag tells Anna nic Coinnich that she believes all three writers honest and none of their three pasts more true than the others, and that choosing one for comfort's sake would be a falsehood of her own making.¹³
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,680** — *Birth of Tormod mac Ruairidh*. A son, Tormod, is born to Ruairidh of Clann Raghnaill, the crown's own house, in the years Beathag nic Thòmais is filling her loft at Muileann chaol.
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,691** — *A niece asks why the wrong copies were not burned* (Muileann chaol). Hearing the tale of the three copies at the fireside, Beathag's niece asks why the two that disagreed with the truth were not simply burned. Beathag, by then old, tells her this is the very question the loft exists to leave unanswered.¹⁴
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,694** — *The north-west coast counted* (Baile chrom). The crown sends a reeve to list the households of the thinned north-west coast between Baile chrom and Ceann mhòr. He counts fewer households than there are harbour berths.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,699** — *The loft at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). Beathag nic Thòmais dies, and leaves her loft of papers to the town of Muileann chaol on condition that nothing in it be burned. The town keeps that condition and very little else of her wishes.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,699** — *The nephew stumbles reading the loft's condition* (Muileann chaol). Reading Beathag nic Thòmais's will aloud to the assembled kin, her nephew stumbles over the clause forbidding any burning of the loft's papers, and more than one kinsman marks the stumble and thinks the less of him for it.¹⁵

13. ← Follows from *Three copies of the landfall tidings*, 27 an Giblean, LE 1,679.

14. ← Follows from *Three copies of the landfall tidings*, 27 an Giblean, LE 1,679.

15. ← Follows from *The loft at Muileann chaol*, 24 an Lùnastal, LE 1,699.

THE YEARS LE 1,701 – 1,800

- 6 AM MÀRT, LE 1,709** — *King Tormod mac Ruairidh crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Tormod mac Ruairidh of Clann Raghnaill is crowned at Cathair dhearg. His reign is remembered for its roads and its length.¹
- 5 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,714** — *Manannan's harbour prayer* (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan at Seann Skell begin to say their prayer for the shut sea on the day of the rite of the empty harbour, so that both are kept together on Cidhe an Diosail². Neither side is pleased.
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,715** — *Birth of Gormshuil nic Thormoid* (Cathair dhearg). A daughter, Gormshuil, is born at Cathair dhearg to King Tormod mac Ruairidh, five-and-thirty years old and six years crowned.
- 6 AM MÀRT, LE 1,719** — *Tormod's bridges* (Cnoc ìseal). King Tormod builds stone bridges over the fords of the south-central shires, one of them at Cnoc ìseal. Ferry-keepers who lose their living are given land in amends.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,721** — *A ferryman chooses the market road over the water* (Cnoc ìseal). Given his choice of two parcels in amends for the bridge that ends his crossing, a ferryman of Cnoc ìseal asks the king's reeve which has the better crossing to the market road, and takes it; his sons never return to the water.³
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,729** — *The panther year* (Imrich nam Pantar⁴). The panthers cross the southern roads in numbers beyond any herder's memory, and for a whole season the crossing days run into one another. Flocks are kept in folds from Cnoc àrsaidh to the coast.
- 8 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,731** — *A miller answers a reeve on the town's right to the loft* (Muileann chaol). A crown reeve asks Beathag nic Thòmais's great-nephew, by then the loft's unpaid keeper, what right the town has to papers that belong by their matter to Taigh na Fèithe⁵ or the crown. He answers that fifty years of neither office asking for them back is itself an answer.⁶
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,734** — *Caol gharbh loses the salt* (Caol gharbh). The sea rises over the salt pans of Caol gharbh and they fail, and salt comes to the north-east from the south instead. The town that took the trade of Ros fhionn is poorer than Ros fhionn had been.
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,739** — *Storm at Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). A south-westerly storm floods the low town of Baile ghorm and drowns twenty-three. The town raises its sea-wall by the height of a man.

1. ◇ Same person *Birth of Tormod mac Ruairidh*, 2 an Dàmhair, LE 1,680.

2. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

3. ← Follows from *Tormod's bridges*, 6 am Màrt, LE 1,719.

4. the panthers' crossing

5. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,748** — *A scribe questions the last keepers of the rite* (Seann Skell). Sent to note Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaìdh Fhalaimh⁷ for the crown's book, a scribe asks the last old women of Seann Skell on what day the fleet truly sailed. No two answers agree, and he writes as much into the crown's own book, unable to choose among them any more than Beathag nic Thòmais once could among her three copies.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,749** — *The rite kept by few* (Seann Skell). The rite of the empty harbour on Cidhe an Diosail⁸ at Seann Skell is kept by the harbour priests and a few old families. A visiting scribe writes that none there could say on what day the fleet had in truth sailed.⁹
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,754** — *Cuan dhearg flooded again* (Cuan dhearg). The sea comes over the waterfront of Cuan dhearg a second time, and the street moved back after An Gàire Dubh¹⁰ is flooded to the thresholds. The town builds a sea-wall and does not move again.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,754** — *Gormsbuil carries the harbour-master's counsel to the king* (Cuan dhearg). Sent by her father to see the sea-wall building at Cuan dhearg, Gormshuil nic Thormoid hears the harbour-master say a wall a man can stand behind is worth more than a street he can only run from, and rides home to give the king the counsel word for word.¹¹
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,754** — *Cuan dhearg buries its own boundary stones* (Cuan dhearg). Rather than break up the boundary stones of the street the sea first moved, Cuan dhearg buries them on the chance a later hand may want to know how far the water once came.¹²
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,759** — *The house at Dùn thais reopened* (Dùn thais). The house of disputation at Dùn thais, shut and opened more than once since the table of years, is opened again on condition that the question of longer lives is not raised. The druids of the schools accept it and argue about the vein instead.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,759** — *The schools take up the question of the vein instead* (Dùn thais). Reopened on condition that the question of longer lives is never raised again, Taigh na Deasbaid¹³ at Dùn thais turns instead to whether Leabhar a' Chùraim¹⁴'s measure of the handful answers rightly to what the coal gives out.¹⁵
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,766** — *Death of King Tormod* (Cathair dhearg). King Tormod mac Ruairidh dies at Cathair dhearg after a reign of more than fifty years. His daughter Gormshuil nic Thormoid is crowned.¹⁶

6. ← Follows from *The loft at Muileann chaol*, 24 an Lùnastal, LE 1,699.

7. the rite of the empty harbour

8. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

9. ← Leads to *A scribe questions the last keepers of the rite*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,748.

10. the Black Laugh

11. ← Follows from *Cuan dhearg flooded again*, 23 an Giblean, LE 1,754.

12. ← Follows from *Cuan dhearg flooded again*, 23 an Giblean, LE 1,754.

13. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

14. the custody-book of the vein-house

15. ← Follows from *The house at Dùn thais reopened*, 20 an Giblean, LE 1,759.

- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,766** — *The king's last night* (Cathair dhearg). Tormod mac Ruairidh tells his daughter Gormshuil, on the last night of his seven-and-fifty-year reign, that he never once found courage to ask Taigh na Fèithe¹⁷ a question Taigh na Deasbaid¹⁸ was forbidden to ask on his behalf, and that finding it will be the easier half of her trouble.¹⁹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,766** — *Gormshuil crowned at one-and-fifty* (Cathair dhearg). Gormshuil nic Thormoid is crowned in An Talla Dearg²⁰ a fortnight after her father's death, the same age he had been when the sea-wall of Cuan dhearg was still only a plan on a tally-stick.²¹
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,771** — *Queen Gormshuil's progress* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Gormshuil nic Thormoid rides round every shire seat of the island, the first ruler to do so since Sileas Òg. Her clerks write down the grievances of each shire; the queen answers none of them in writing.
- 8 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,772** — *A boundary measured and not judged* (Baile chrom). At the first seat of her progress a householder accuses her neighbour of shifting a boundary stone by moonlight three years running; Gormshuil measures the disputed ground herself and has it written down, so that the writing, not the queen, will settle it.²²
- 6 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,772** — *Leabhar nan Gearan*²³ *opened at every seat*. At every shire seat of Queen Gormshuil's progress, in the sixth year of her reign and her seven-and-fiftieth of life, her clerks open Leabhar nan Gearan and write down each seat's grievance in the shire's own words.²⁴
- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,775** — *A reeve asks the queen what the writing is for*. A plain-spoken reeve asks Gormshuil why she writes down every shire's grievance and answers none of them; she tells him a hasty answer given before hearing the whole round is a false ease, and rides on.²⁵
- 5 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,776** — *The second silver petition* (Muileann dhearg). Clann Choinnich asks again to burn the coal beyond the measure for the silver smelt at Muileann chiar, now with three of the seven houses behind it. Queen Gormshuil's council refuses by one voice. The name of the member who changed his vote is written down; his reason is not.

16. ◇ Same person *Birth of Gormshuil nic Thormoid*, 15 am Faoilleach, LE 1,715.

17. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

18. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

19. → Leads to *Death of King Tormod*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,766.

20. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

21. ← Follows from *Death of King Tormod*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,766.

22. ← Follows from *Queen Gormshuil's progress*, 12 an Giblean, LE 1,771.

23. the book of complaints

24. ← Follows from *Queen Gormshuil's progress*, 12 an Giblean, LE 1,771.

25. ← Follows from *Queen Gormshuil's progress*, 12 an Giblean, LE 1,771.

- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,776** — *Aonghas mac Lachlainn turns his vote* (Muileann dhearg). Meaning by every account to vote with the three houses behind Athchuingean an Airgid²⁶, Aonghas mac Lachlainn changes his vote at the board itself and gives no reason beyond the bare word that he has changed his mind.²⁷
- 18 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,776** — *Gormshuil asks Aonghas his reason and is refused* (Muileann dhearg). Gormshuil asks Aonghas mac Lachlainn privately why he turned his vote; he answers that a man's reason for his own hand at the board is his to keep, and she lets the matter lie as Leabhar a' Chùrain²⁸ lets it lie.²⁹
- 25 AM MÀRT, LE 1,786** — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach³⁰'s spinach* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach on the eastern road feeds the queen's progress with pan-fried spinach and black wine, as the charter-roll records. Its keeper, Peigi nic Dhonnchaidh, is spared her road dues for a year.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,786** — *Peigi feeds the queen's whole progress unwarned* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach³¹). Peigi nic Dhonnchaidh, keeper of An Taigh-òsta Grianach, feeds Gormshuil's whole company on pan-fried spinach and black wine though her charter allows stores for far less; the queen forgives her a year's road dues.³²
- 27 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,791** — *The last count of hands* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house counts for the last time in this age the households holding the right to the coal. They are fewer than at any count before, and greater; the custody-book notes that three of the seven houses now hold more than half the right between them.
- 26 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,791** — *A smaller house is granted its neighbour's unused right* (Muileann dhearg). At the last Cunntas nan Làmh³³ the custodians grant a house whose share has fallen too low to keep its hearth measure a neighbour's unused coal-right, though more than one voice warns that a house asking twice can be eased once but not mended for good.³⁴
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,791** — *Three houses hold more than half the right* (Muileann dhearg). Leabhar a' Chùrain³⁵'s clerk notes under the last Cunntas nan Làmh³⁶, in the dry hand kept since Donnchadh's day, that three of Na Seachd Taighean³⁷ now hold more than half the whole right to the coal among themselves.³⁸

26. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

27. → Leads to *The second silver petition*, 5 an Gearran, LE 1,776.

28. the custody-book of the vein-house

29. ← Follows from *The second silver petition*, 5 an Gearran, LE 1,776.

30. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

31. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

32. ← Follows from *An Taigh-òsta Grianach's spinach*, 25 am Màrt, LE 1,786.

33. the census of hands

34. ← Follows from *The last count of hands*, 27 an Gearran, LE 1,791.

35. the custody-book of the vein-house

36. the census of hands

37. the seven houses of custody

38. ← Follows from *The last count of hands*, 27 an Gearran, LE 1,791.

- 22 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,794** — *Timber out of the mist* (Ceann mhòr). A worked timber, longer than any tree on the island and fastened with nails of a make no smith of Dia-thìr knows, comes ashore at Ceann mhòr on the north-west coast, from beyond Manannan's mist, as the fishers say. It is carried to Seann Skell, shown to Manannan's priests, and burned.
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,794** — *The fishers of Ceann mhòr find the timber* (Ceann mhòr). Fishers working the empty water off Ceann mhòr, where Faire a' Chinn³⁹ has long lapsed, find a worked timber cast up, longer than any island tree and fastened with nails no smith on Dia-thìr forged; the eldest among them says hands that made such nails did not make them on the island.⁴⁰
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,795** — *The queen goes up to Taigh na Fèithe⁴¹ for the winter burning* (Muileann dhearg). Eighty years old, Gormshuil nic Thormoid rides the coal-road to Taigh na Fèithe for the winter burning as she has every year of her reign, and walks her own horse up the last, iced mile rather than let another hand lead it.
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,795** — *The oldest crowned ruler since Clàr nam Bliadhnachan⁴²* (Muileann dhearg). Riding up to the winter burning at eighty, Queen Gormshuil nic Thormoid is the oldest ruler Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴³ has entered crowned and still reigning since long before Clàr nam Bliadhnachan, nine-and-twenty years crowned.⁴⁴
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,796** — *The council sits in the queen's empty place* (Cathair dhearg). With no word of Gormshuil since the winter burning, the custodians of Na Seachd Taighean⁴⁵ meet at An Talla Dearg⁴⁶ in the place the crown's own chair has always stood empty for her progress, and send their word up the coal-road by the same riders who carried the crown's business all her reign.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,798** — *A crown letter sealed with no name above the seal* (Cathair dhearg). The custodians seal their letters with Taigh na Fèithe⁴⁷'s trellis and hollow stone as every crown letter has been sealed since Dòmhnall Ruadh joined the two, but set no name above the seal, and no clerk is ever asked to explain the blank space.
- 24 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,799** — *The lamps at Seann Skell go out* (Seann Skell). Fewer houses at Seann Skell keep the night of lamps each year, and at last none on the waterfront. An old woman sets a lamp in a window of the harbour-house, and the scribe writes that it was she and not the town.

39. the watch of the headland at Ceann mhòr

40. → Leads to *Timber out of the mist*, 22 an Cèitean, LE 1,794.

41. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

42. the table of years

43. the custody-book of the vein-house

44. ← Follows from *Timber out of the mist*, 22 an Cèitean, LE 1,794.

45. the seven houses of custody

46. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,799** — *Ealasaid nic Iain keeps the last lamp* (Seann Skell). With no household left on the Seann Skell waterfront still keeping Oidhche nan Lòchran⁴⁸, an old woman, Ealasaid nic Iain, sets the one lamp that burns in the harbour-house window; the scribe writes that the lamp was hers and not the town's.⁴⁹
- 8 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,800** — *Ealasaid nic Iain's lamp goes dark* (Seann Skell). Ealasaid nic Iain, who alone had kept a lamp burning in the harbour-house window at Seann Skell after the rest of the waterfront let the custom lapse, dies in her own bed, and no one after her sets a light there again.⁵⁰

47. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

48. the night of lamps at Seann Skell

49. ← Follows from *The lamps at Seann Skell go out*, 24 an Dàmhair, LE 1,799.

50. ← Follows from *The lamps at Seann Skell go out*, 24 an Dàmhair, LE 1,799.

THE YEARS LE 1,801 – 1,819

25 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,803 — *The last rite of the empty harbour in this age* (Seann Skell).

Eleven people keep the rite of the empty harbour at Seann Skell. The harbour scribe enters their number, the weather and the state of the tide, and nothing more.

I AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,803 — *Eòghann mac Nèill counts the rite of the eleven* (Seann Skell). At Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh¹ on Cidhe an Diosail², Eòghann mac Nèill, eleven years the quay's scribe, stands back as the scribe's place requires and counts the people on the stones twice, once by eye and once by name: eleven.³

3 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,804 — *Death of Aonghas mac Lachlainn* (Cathair dhearg). Aonghas mac Lachlainn dies at Cathair dhearg, four-and-eighty years old, the last of the council that had refused Clann Choinnich's Athchuingean an Airgid⁴; asked once more on his deathbed why he had turned his own vote, he answers only that his reason had not stopped seeming good to him, and says no more.⁵

I AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,804 — *A rider of Muileann chiar attends the burying he was never asked to* (Cathair dhearg). A rider sent down by the silver guild of Muileann chiar on the strength of an old courtesy stands at the back of Aonghas mac Lachlainn's small burying at Cathair dhearg, and no one there asks him why a guild his vote had cost a fortune troubled to send anyone at all.⁶

28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,806 — *The silver petition laid aside* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The member who had turned the vote being dead, Clann Choinnich does not bring its silver petition to the council again. It lies unanswered in the vein-house, and the age ends with the Small-Burning Law still kept.⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,806 — *Eòghann mac Nèill keeps the book with the window dark* (Seann Skell). Eòghann mac Nèill, harbour scribe of Seann Skell, passes the harbour-house window each rite-day and finds no reason offered for a light to be set there again; he enters nothing of it in his own book, which is kept for the number, the weather and the tide alone.

8

1. the rite of the empty harbour

2. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

3. ← Follows from *The last rite of the empty harbour in this age*, 25 an t-Samhain, LE 1,803.

4. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

5. ← Follows from *The second silver petition*, 5 an Gearran, LE 1,776.

6. ¶ Legacy *The second silver petition*, 5 an Gearran, LE 1,776.

7. → Caused by *Death of Aonghas mac Lachlainn*, 3 an Dàmhair, LE 1,804.

8. ¶ Legacy *The lamps at Seann Skell go out*, 24 an Dàmhair, LE 1,799; ← Follows from *The last rite of the empty harbour in this age*, 25 an t-Samhain, LE 1,803.

- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,812** — *Na Seachd Taighean*⁹ name themselves *Comhairle a' Chùraim*¹⁰ (Cathair dhearg). Meeting at Cathair dhearg by chance of their riders' errands rather than by any summons, the heads of Na Seachd Taighean call themselves *Comhairle a' Chùraim*, the council of the custody, and name Tormod mac Ailein, eight-and-thirty years old and a custodian's son of no house among the seven, *Ceann a' Chùraim*¹¹ to speak for them with one voice.¹²
- 25 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,812** — *Clann Choinnich's question is set aside at the first sitting* (Cathair dhearg). At the same sitting that names the council of the custody, Clann Choinnich alone asks whether the silver might be raised again; the board sets the question aside mildly, unwilling to test a new council on the one asking that had already cost the last one a member's death.¹³
- 26 AM MÀRT, LE 1,812** — *The queen's chair is left standing empty* (Cathair dhearg). Na Seachd Taighean¹⁴ leave the chair at the head of the board, the queen's own, standing empty at every sitting after her name is no longer spoken; Tormod mac Ailein, offered it, keeps his place at the board's foot instead, and in time no clerk living can say with certainty whose absence the chair still marks.¹⁵
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,812** — *The council's letters keep no name above the seal* (Cathair dhearg). The newly named council of the custody sends out its letters from Cathair dhearg sealed with Taigh na Fèithe¹⁶'s own trellis and hollow stone and no name written above the seal, continuing without comment a custom An Talla Dearg¹⁷'s clerks had already begun in the queen's last silent years.¹⁸
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,812** — *An Talla Dearg*¹⁹ holds five hundred souls (Cathair dhearg). In the year Na Seachd Taighean²⁰ name their council, An Talla Dearg at Cathair dhearg holds perhaps five hundred souls in all its lanes and closes, fewer than the tenants of a single one of Na Seachd Taighean in a good year.²¹

9. the seven houses of custody

10. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

11. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

12. ⇌ At the same time *The silver petition laid aside*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,806.

13. ← Follows from *The silver petition laid aside*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,806.

14. the seven houses of custody

15. ¶ Legacy *The silver petition laid aside*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,806.

16. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

17. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

18. ¶ Legacy *The silver petition laid aside*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,806.

19. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

20. the seven houses of custody

21. ← Follows from *The silver petition laid aside*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,806.

- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,813** — *The mist thins* (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan at Seann Skell write that the mist on the eastern sea, which has hidden Dia-thir from every ship beyond it since the fleet of the Sundering sailed into it, lies thinner each winter. They say their prayer, A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte, at every tide, and on still mornings the fishers of the north-west coast begin to see the line of the open sea beyond the headlands.
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,813** — *Mànas mac Dhùghaill writes that the mist lies thinner* (Seann Skell). Mànas mac Dhùghaill, priest of Manannan's rite at Seann Skell, sets down for the first time in his own book a thing the older priests had only ever said at the hearth: that the grey past the headlands stands thinner each year, and that he cannot say whether saying the prayer at every tide holds anything back at all.²²
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,813** — *Oighrig nic Eachainn sees the line of the open sea* (Ceann mhòr). A fisher of Ceann mhòr, Oighrig nic Eachainn, rests on her oars past where the rule of sight-of-land strictly allows and sees, for a few breaths before the grey closes again, a hard dark line beyond the mist, ruled clean across the edge of the world.²³
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,813** — *Oighrig keeps what she saw to her own mother* (Ceann mhòr). Oighrig nic Eachainn turns for home as the rule says and tells no priest and no reeve what she saw beyond the mist, speaking of it months after only to her own mother, who tells her she has already shown better sense in the keeping of it than most who see such things at all.²⁴
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,818** — *The last winter of the age* (Seann Skell). On a still morning near the year's dark heart, the priests of Manannan pray at every tide at Seann Skell, the boats of Ceann mhòr turn for home before the rule strictly asks it of them, and the council keeps its board at Cathair dhearg with the chair at its head still empty, while the harbour-house lamp-window that once marked Oidhche nan Lòchran²⁵ stands dark for another winter.²⁶
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,818** — *Eòghann mac Nèill at the last winter* (Seann Skell). Six-and-twenty years the scribe of Cidhe an Diosail²⁷, Eòghann mac Nèill walks down to the stones each Là an Diosail²⁸ with the same board under his arm and writes the number, the weather and the tide in the same plain hand.²⁹

22. → Leads to *The mist thins*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813.

23. ← Follows from *The mist thins*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813.

24. ⇄ At the same time *The mist thins*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813.

25. the night of lamps at Seann Skell

26. ¶ Legacy *The mist thins*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813; ¶ Legacy *The last rite of the empty harbour in this age*, 25 an t-Samhain, LE 1,803.

27. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

28. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

29. ← Follows from *The mist thins*, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813.

PART THREE

A Gazetteer of the Age

A

Achadh naomh (Achadh naomh). Founded 28 an t-Sultain, FE 2,324. The shire seat of Achadh naomh was the other party to the grazing quarrel with Baile ruadh that the king's council settled along the stream in LE 1,246. Like its neighbour it carried home the stones it had brought and set them into its own walls unused. Known for the grazing quarrel settled by the stream.

Achadh shean (Achadh shean). Founded 21 an Giblean, GE 3,125. The farming country of the far east caught the rain the eastern hills always had until three seasons ran dry from LE 1,479, and the crown's grain carts reached it by the mining road. Its reeves shared the deep wells among the households by lot and by turn and cut the sharing on a board at the well-head. The board was renewed each generation; the lots were never drawn again. When Queen Sileas Òg stood at the well-head on her round and asked why, the reeve answered that no household wished to be the one to call the first sharing unfair, and she rode on without asking him to change it. Known for the board at the well-head.

Àth chiar (Àth chiar). Founded 18 an Giblean, FE 2,769. The citadel town in the eastern hills sends its drovers over the hills each year with cattle for the mining towns; from LE 484 they marked their road with a cairn at every day's stage, the first roads on the island so marked, so that a beast lost in mist or a driver new to the trade might find the way again. A boundary dispute at Àth chiar was still unsettled after three seasons when Tormod Bàn lay dying, and his last clear order gave it to the custodians to finish. In the sixteenth century its drovers took their beasts to the fair at Baile Mòr ruadh instead of selling nearer home. Known for the drovers' cairns.

Àth dhomhain (Àth dhomhain). Founded 19 an Lùnastal, LE 1,611. The deep ford on the northern river could be crossed safely only on horseback and by one path, and in LE 1,611 Ragnall Àthach and his kin, who knew that path, settled on the near bank and took a toll of every rider they led over. The ford-keepers' households grew into a town that held the one safe crossing of that country, and the family that owned the path came to be spoken of as lords of it before the age was out. Known for the horseman's ford.

Àth fhiadhaich (Doire chaol). Founded 14 an t-Sultain, FE 995. The fishing town kept its boats and nets shared among the households of a fellowship, and in the third century of the count King Fearchar mac Lachlainn, old and curious, kept one of its fishermen a full hour answering questions on how the sharing was done. Having lost catch to poor curing, it began in LE 394 to send carts north for Ros fhionn salt, and from then the mining shires ate their salt fish cured with salt carried over Drochaid Ros fhionn. Known for its fishers' fellowship and its salt fish.

Àth fhionn (Muileann shean). Founded 30 an Dùbhlachd, LE 697. Fishers of the north coast settled in the eighth century of the count at the ford where the coast road crosses a clear stream, and by LE 835 a market had grown up on their strand trading north-coast fish, the flesh and oil of stranded whales, wool and barley. The fishers of that coast no longer carried their catch the longer road south to Inis mhòr, and the ford town became the market of the north coast. Known for the strand-market of the north coast.

Àth shean (Àth shean). Founded 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,361. The walled ford town on the river above the granaries keeps the old crossing of the eastern road. In LE 554 Dùghall Garbh, guided by drovers who had used a hidden ford above the town for forty years to move cattle untolled, crossed his host in the dark and broke Ragnall Ruadh's camp at the ford; Leabhar a' Chùrain¹ counts some three hundred dead, most of them drowned, and one old soldier swore to Seònaid nic Coinnich that the fighting took two days, not one. In the seventeenth century the growers on the slopes above the ford began to press blueberry and bramble into a dark wine that kept a year in the cask, and the road-houses of the eastern stretch took to serving it as black wine. Known for the ford of Cogadh nan Tri Tagraichean², and the black wine.

Àth shean (Àth shean). Founded 15 an Dàmhair, FE 1,963. The granary town south of the mountain kept the crown's stores. In the grain strife of LE 37 its reeve, Tormod mac Coinnich, who remembered a store-house swept empty behind a smiling reeve when he was seven, barred the granary doors and set a watch of four on them through Samhnas, Dubhlas and the black months, turning away every petitioner until a single rider came in Siolach with a word that the grain might move; how the strife was settled he was never told. The middle pier of its bridge was rebuilt in stone in LE 46. Sileas's firiot settled its first quarrel here, a carter and a miller measured true before the crowd their shouting drew. In LE 699 the granaries, standing since before a' Scaradh³, were pulled down and built again in dressed stone on raised floors against the rats, under the reeve Fearchar mac Phàdraig. Eight centuries after that a young clerk found the town's firiot worn smaller than the capital's standard, and had been for generations. Known for the barred granary, and the worn firiot.

B

Baile àrsaidh (Baile àrsaidh). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, FE 879. The shire seat a little north of Cuan shean raised the sail-cloth for the fleet. Its tally-keeper cut a notch on his sticks for every close-woven length delivered from the households of Siorrachd Baile àrsaidh, owed once and reckoned against nothing, and by the ninth year he had cut more notches than he had thought the shire held households, some from weavers with no kin on the roll and no thought of sailing. The sticks filled a chest that wanted a second lid. After the sailing the shire went back to weaving for its own backs and the coasting trade, and the levy-chest is remembered in the shire as the one thing it ever gave that it did not count the cost of. Known for the sail-cloth levy for the fleet.

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the War of the Three Claimants

3. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

Baile chrom (Baile chrom). Founded 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464. The north-west coast town was a quiet reeve's post until the sea-thieves of the small islands began boarding the coasters off its shore in the eighth century of the count. Its reeve Coinneach mac Nèill counted the going as carefully as he had counted grain, and in LE 789 reported half the houses empty, their thatch going to moss; the crown reckoned his town's dues by the households that stood. When the thieves put in twice in a moon within sight of his harbour he asked the crown for a force, and Eilidh Bhàn sent Iain mac Thormoid by sea; the town's own fishermen led the boats through the channel to Eilean dhubh, where the thieves' hulls were burned, one of the town's own sons, Aonghas mac Ruairidh, was killed on the strand, and Uilleam Ruadh was taken. Then the harvests failed one on the heels of the last. The reeve's wife Beathag nic Artair died in the hard winter of LE 819, the last households loaded their carts and went inland, and Coinneach, reeve eight-and-forty years, shut his door and took the coast road east. A reeve sent down the empty coast in LE 1,694 counted more berths than households between Baile chrom and Ceann mhòr. Known for the sea-thieves, and the reeve who stayed until the last cart.

Baile gharbh (Baile gharbh). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 2,662. The weavers of the north-eastern town make a heavy undyed cloth that sheds rain, and in the fourth century of the count it became the common cloak of the north-east. In LE 361 the district took it as its cloth of mourning, worn plain through a household's season of loss as the whole island had once worn an Tùrsa Geal¹, and an Tùrsa Geal was kept in it in that country from then on. Known for the undyed rain-cloth worn for mourning.

Baile gheal (Baile gheal). Founded 27 an Giblean, GE 4,347. The old town of the south-west coast near Inis thais took Òrd na Cloiche²'s second house. When the congregation at Inis thais divided in LE 1,389 over whether the dead might be prayed for by name at Clach, those who said they might built their own temple of Òrd na Cloiche here, finished within ten years of the first quarrel, and the two congregations went their own ways, neither troubling the other much and neither giving ground. Known for the second temple of Òrd na Cloiche.

Baile ghorm (Baile ghorm). Founded 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 622. The low harbour town of the far south kept its citadel and its fishing through the age. In LE 1,739 a south-westerly storm flooded the low town and drowned twenty-three, and the town raised its sea-wall by the height of a man. Known for its sea-wall.

Baile ghorm (Baile ghorm). Founded 22 an Gearran, FE 837. The south-eastern town's dyers made a fast blue from a marsh plant and a mordant of their own, and in LE 1,064 the dyer Oighrig nic Ailein, after ten years changing one thing at a time, found the mixing that held the blue through washing after washing; cloth of it was worn at Taigh na Fèithe³'s midwinter gathering within the year and became the feast-day dress of the custodian houses. The last dyer who knew the mordant quarrelled with both her apprentices and died without teaching either, and the blue that followed, though it kept the old name, was the common blue of the rest of the island; the old weavers held the two lengths side by side and mourned the difference aloud for the rest of their lives. Known for the Baile ghorm blue, and its losing.

1. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

2. the order of the Stone

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Baile Mòr dhireach (Baile chaol). Founded 7 an Gearran, FE 2,051. The citadel on the straight eastern road, raised by custodians of the road in An Aois Naomh⁴, was granted a market for the east coast in LE 731, and its boundary stones were set the day the grant was read, with a young vein-house scribe, Eòghann mac Pheadair, standing witness for Na Seachd Taighean⁵. The fish and sail-cloth of the coast towns met the grain of the inland farms there, and the first stalls went up the same afternoon. Known for the market of the eastern road.

Baile Mòr dhomhain (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 24 an t-Samhain, FE 101. The walled town near Taigh na Fèithe⁶ is the hall of Clann Fhearchair. Fearchar mac Lachlainn was born here, the elder son, and bound as a boy to a custodian's household for seven years while his younger brother Iain was kept at home to learn the hall; when the houses chose Fearchar king in LE 182, he kept his court part of each year here that he might take counsel of Taigh na Fèithe without a journey, and Iain kept Clann Fhearchair's hall when the court was at the capital. The brothers' letters across every season of the double court were gathered here into one leaf-book, boundary disputes beside a long complaint about the capital's cooking. Dùghall Garbh held his following here in the years before Cogadh nan Trì Tagraichean⁷, and died here of the wound he took at Muileann chrom, his last words asking whether Taigh na Fèithe gates stood open. In the thirteenth century masons of Ceann leathan began to buy the veined white stone of the hills above the town, and its quarries were worked from then on. Known for the double court, and the hall of Clann Fhearchair.

Baile Mòr mhòr (Baile Mòr mhòr). Founded 13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616. The upland town took in so many families from the failing hill farms after a run of poor seasons in the fourth century of the count that it all but doubled, and in LE 324 its reeve marked out shares of the common grazing for households that had never held a share of it before. Known for the grazing shared anew.

Baile Mòr ruadh (Seann Tarr). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 3,311. The walled town of the east by Seann Tarr held an autumn cattle fair that in LE 1,519 began to draw the drovers of Àth chiar and the eastern hills, who brought their beasts down to it rather than sell nearer home. It became yearly, and within a few years the greatest fair in the east. Known for the cattle fair of the east.

Baile ruadh (Inis mhin). Founded 9 an t-Iuchar, FE 957. The shire seat of Baile ruadh quarrelled with Achadh naomh over grazing along a stream that had shifted its bed, and in LE 1,246 the king's council divided the ground along the stream as it then ran. Both shire seats carried home the boundary stones they had brought to argue their claims and set them unused into their own walls, where they stood for the rest of the age pointing at a line the water had already drawn. Known for the boundary stones set into its walls.

4. the Holy Age

5. the seven houses of custody

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

7. the War of the Three Claimants

C

Caol bheag (Caol bheag). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 2,414. The coastal town at the mouth of the Abhainn ghorm received the grain barges of Inis mhòr from the second century of the count. Its fishers' sons walked three days to sit the benches at Dùn thais, and one of them, Aonghas mac Nèill, stayed to keep the house's register. In LE 1,369 the fishers of silted Caol iséal came to it and set up their shrine again stone by stone in the same order, so that it stood as it always had. Known for the shrine carried whole from Caol iséal.

Caol fhiadhaich (Caol fhiadhaich). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,547. The old harbour town of the south-west coast took the coughing sickness in LE 156, and it reached the reeve's own household. His wife would not let their door be barred against the shared board, holding that a household which eats apart out of fear will go on eating apart after the fear has passed; she lived, and the custom of the shared meal outlasted the sickness in that country. Known for the shared meal kept through the cough.

Caol fhiadhaich (Inis thais). Founded 13 an t-Iuchar, LE 739. The fishing town on the wild strait near Inis thais was founded in LE 739. Its fishers had always kept their boats inside the strait that gave the town its name, never past their own headlands, until in LE 1,389 some of them went out and found a safe lane south to the landing at Cidhe Beag. Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich¹ was not believed at first; within a season or two of its being believed, the older harbours of the south coast followed it one after another. Known for Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich.

Caol gharbh (Caol gharbh). Founded 10 am Màrt, GE 4,128. The fishing village on the rough strait of the north-east became the salt port of the north-east in LE 1,169, when the Ros fhionn masters dug out and walled its harbour with their own money after their river silted. A laden barge out of the new harbour struck the reef in the narrows called Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich² in its first year and went down with half her salt, both crewmen swimming ashore; the harbour-masters set the channel's first withy at the rock the next spring. The trade held for five and a half centuries, until the sea rose over the salt-pans in LE 1,734 and they failed, and the salt of the north-east came from the south instead. Known for the salt harbour, and the narrows.

Caol iséal (Caol iséal). Founded 21 am Màrt, FE 1,450. The harbour on the north coast had been silting longer than any one season could be blamed for, and in LE 1,369 its fishing families gave the last of it up and moved east to Caol bheag, carrying their nets, their smoking-racks and the small shrine from the harbour's edge, stone by stone. The town did not empty; the houses nearest the silted water turned to farming the ground behind them, and within two generations it smelled of turned earth rather than fish and tar. Known for the harbour given up to the plough.

Caol leathan (Caol leathan). Founded 12 am Faoilleach, GE 1,560. The small walled harbour on the south-west coast beside Inis thais kept a harbour shrine that the priests of Òrd an t-Seabhaig³ and an Fhianna⁴ both came to claim in LE 427, their feast mornings falling on the same day. The king's reeve, Murchadh mac Ailpein, halved the shrine's hours between them, as the sacred woods of an older age had once been divided, and nailed the division on a strip of hide to the shrine door. The division held, and neither order was pleased with it. Known for the shrine with two orders' hours.

1. the southern sea-lane

2. the meeting at the neck

Caol shean (Caol shean). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 4,196. The fishing town took the greatest catch of its memory in LE 1,039 and ran out of salt on the second day. The shed-foreman Ruairidh mac Neacail hung what could not be salted on lines strung the length of the lower town's lanes rather than let it spoil on the strand; the dried fish sold poorly against salted, and from that year the town laid in salt for a catch half again the size of any it had taken. Known for the year the lanes were hung with fish.

Cathair dhearg (Cathair dhearg). Founded 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18. The kings and queens of the age kept their hall on An Cnoc Ruadh⁵ above the Abhainn dhomhain, and every crowning of the age was made there. Beathagnic Dhòmhnail heard the three crews in An Talla Dearg⁶ in the first year, gave her word that the crown would send no one and keep no one back, and wore undyed wool for her sister from the thirteenth year of the count until she died in the fifty-fifth. The houses first chose a king here when Ìomhar's line failed, in a cold yard where seven neck-rings caught the sun and nobody spoke for a morning. Sileas set the standard firlot here and widened the bridge for two carts abreast; Catriona Bhuadhach laid her stone road south from it to Inis thais. The crown was joined to the mastery of Taigh na Fèithe⁷ in Dòmhnall Ruadh's reign, and from then An Talla Dearg's letters carried the custody's seal. The capital grew slowly and Cathair mhòr passed it in the tenth century of the count; in the age's last years the hall held perhaps five hundred souls. After Queen Gormshuil went up to the winter burning in LE 1,795 and nothing more is told, Na Seachd Taighean⁸ sat at her board with her chair left empty, and named themselves Comhairle a' Chùrain⁹ there in LE 1,812. Known for An Talla Dearg, the queen's empty chair, and the board of Na Seachd Taighean.

3. the Hawk order

4. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

5. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

6. the red hall, the rich's hall at Cathair dhearg

7. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

8. the seven houses of custody

9. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

Cathair dhomhain (Cathair dhomhain). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 634. The walled harbour city above the river mouth, with its citadel of An Aois Naomh¹⁰ and granaries deep enough for two winters, declared for Dùghall Garbh in the second year of Cogadh nan Trì Tagraichean¹¹, chiefly because its harbour-master had once carried grain for him. Catrìona nic Aonghais came against it in the autumn of LE 556; borrowed fishing coasters shut its water gate by night while her lines held the land gate. With no ground beyond the walls for burying, the dead were laid near the well-heads, and a sickness of the gut went through the streets and the garrison. On the fortieth day Niall Mòr mac Leòid surrendered, and Catrìona let his garrison march out between her silent lines on his sworn word, carrying its dead and wounded by name. It was in her camp before this city that Dùghall Garbh came with six men and no herald to offer her his host against Raghnaill Ruadh. Known for the siege of forty days and the garrison freed on oath.

Cathair fhada (Cathair fhada). Founded 13 an Cèitean, GE 2,523. The long walled city on its ridge south of the capital was granted a market at every full moon by Queen Sileas in LE 287, with a tally-house for the south, the first market right cut on paired sticks. At its first full-moon market traders came from three days' walk in every direction and carried honey, hemp, wax and pottery north as one company, and a trader of the long city asked the capital's clerk what stopped a false notch being cut after a bargain, and was shown how the grain of a split stick runs true only when its two halves are laid together. Known for the full-moon market and the paired tallies.

Cathair mhòr (Cathair mhòr). Founded 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847. The walled market city of the south took in forty-one burnt-out households of Doire mhin in LE 555 at the temple of Macha and fed them through the winter on the temple's grain without asking whose claim they had favoured. In the winter of the refusal its temple fire went out in Dubhlas, on a morning so still the smoke of the last coals stood upright, and when a carrier's basket brought coal again it was the first of the cold shires' hearths to burn. Its market drew the trade of all the south, and a carter asked why he sold his barley here and not at the capital said a man carries his load to whichever gate opens first and pays best; by LE 969 it was greater than the capital. Its copper-workers stamped every cooking pot with a maker's mark and sent them out on every road. It fed Ceann mhin after the burning of Cogadh nam Bràithrean¹², and in the fifteenth century the priests of Macha finished their great house here, its floor of black and white eleven years in the laying, the largest roofed building on Dia-thìr. Known for Macha's great house, and the copper pots of every hearth.

Ceann mhin (Ceann mhin). Founded 18 an Lùnastal, FE 745. The walled harbour city declared for Iain Ciar in Cogadh nam Bràithrean¹³, and in LE 1,272 Alasdair Bà'n's ships came down the coast and burned its waterfront before the town's own bell had finished ringing the alarm. The fire took the tarred rope stores and then the granary; by the second morning the town had lost both what it needed to put to sea and what it needed to eat until harvest. Cathair mhòr, which had taken no side, sent grain enough that no household went hungry that winter. In LE 1,549 a second great fire burned it with no war to blame, and before the ash had cooled its reeve ordered it rebuilt with gable walls of stone between each house and the next, so that a fire must cross stone to spread. Known for its two fires, and the gable walls.

10. the Holy Age

11. the War of the Three Claimants

12. the Brothers' War

Ceann mhòr (Ceann mhòr). Founded 6 an Cèitean, FE 163. The fishing town twenty miles up the coast from Seann Skell sent Tòmas mac Uilleim to An Talla Dearg¹⁴ in the first year with the telling that the far land lay behind the mist and could be smelt on some mornings. After the sailing Seonag nic Dhùghaill climbed its headland at first light in LE 66 and kept it through the day, and household after household took a turn after her; the custom was called Faire a' Chinn¹⁵, and Seonag kept her own turns for forty years. The watch lapsed long before the age was out, and the fishing thinned with the rest of the north-west, until perhaps a dozen boats still put out from its shore. In LE 1,794 its fishers found a worked timber cast up, longer than any tree of the island and fastened with nails no smith of Dia-thir had forged. In the last years of the age a fisher of the town, Oighrig nic Eachainn, rested on her oars past where the rule of sight-of-land allowed, saw a hard dark line beyond the grey for a few breaths, and turned for home and told only her mother. Known for Faire a' Chinn, and the timber out of the mist.

Cill ghlas (Muileann dhearg). Founded 4 am Faoilleach, FE 1,814. The small village in the hills a short way from Muileann dhearg sits over the galleries of the vein. An earth tremor in LE 379 cracked three of its wells and brought down a byre; the custodians sent men into the galleries below and found the deep workings untouched, and gave the village stone from their own surplus to raise the byre again, a kindness it did not forget. A second tremor in LE 929 brought down a gallery on fourteen of the custodians' own labourers in the small hours of the morning shift. Taigh na Fèithe¹⁶ closed the gallery rather than dig the dead free, and set a stone at its mouth with the fourteen names cut in the order they went down, the youngest a boy of thirteen, the oldest a woman forty years at the same gallery; households of the mountain leave small stones at its foot on the day of the fall. Known for Clach nan Ceithir Ainmean Deug¹⁷.

Cnoc bhàn (Baile ghorm). Founded 23 an Dùbhlachd, LE 250. The hill-lords of Baile ghorm walled a pale hill above the long mill-race of Muileann fhada in the third century of the count, and in LE 1,051 set a single market there to gather the south-east's scattered trade into one place. Its rare good was the pearls of the south-eastern shallows, sold in whole parcels as at no other market; at the first opening the shore-woman Sìne nic Ruairidh brought a whole season's gathering rather than sell it a pearl at a time along the road, and a trader of Cathair mhòr paid her more for the lot than she had ever been offered piecemeal. Known for the market above the mill-race, and its pearls.

13. the Brothers' War

14. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

15. the watch of the headland at Ceann mhòr

16. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

17. the stone of the fourteen names

Cnoc bheag (Cnoc bheag). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, GE 3,908. The walled town above Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁸ kept the dawn-hawk rite of An Aois Naomh¹⁹, and in the third century of the count the priestess Gormshuil nic Artair taught there that the hawk of the rite was Mòd himself, and that the vein under Muileann dhearg was a hawk of his kind, to be fed the measured handful and never gluttoned past it. Her father Artair kept the mews before her; she first called the hawk down alone at three-and-thirty. Her watchers raised Taigh an t-Seabhaig²⁰ below the mews block in LE 232, and after her death Ùisdean mac Pàdraig wrote her sayings as Leabhar an t-Seabhaig²¹. By royal grant in LE 471 Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag passed to the priests of Macha alone. At the council of Òrd an t-Seabhaig²² here in LE 889 a young priest asked whether Mòd would rather starve a grown flock than see his handful grown to meet it, and those who held he would not were named An Seabhag Biadh²³ and asked to keep their teaching elsewhere. In the eleventh century the priest Tòmas mac Aonghais cleared the moss from Carragh Cnoc bheag²⁴ above the town with wooden scrapers and found letters no table of the schools could read. Known for the house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig and Leabhar an t-Seabhaig.

Cnoc chaol (Seann Vell). Founded 23 am Faoilleach, LE 167. The village of Cnoc chaol on the south coast lost two children in LE 724 to a great swell that rose with no storm behind it and ran the drying-racks off the beach. The household of one of the drowned struck itself from its old gallery-claim and took up a claim further from the water, and Taigh na Fèithe²⁵'s young scribe Eòghann mac Pheadair entered the removal the next season, cold and plain, as he had been taught. Known for the wave with no storm behind it.

Cnoc naomh (Cnoc naomh). Founded 10 an t-Samhain, GE 2,894. The walled temple town in the middle country was seized by Alasdair Bàn's men in LE 1,270 and taken back by Iain Ciar. Na Seachd Taighean²⁶ divided four to three over the brothers, and Cogadh nam Bràithrean²⁷ is counted from this fight. Both households set every road between the two halves of the island under one following's watch or the other, and carters who had crossed freely all their lives had to say plainly whose peace they travelled under. Known for the first battle of Cogadh nam Bràithrean.

18. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

19. the Holy Age

20. the house of the Hawk

21. the Book of the Hawk

22. the Hawk order

23. the Fed Hawk

24. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

25. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

26. the seven houses of custody

27. the Brothers' War

Cuan dhearg (Seann Vell). Founded 31 am Faoilleach, FE 1,384. The harbour town under the red cliffs of the south, the other Cuan dhearg, lost its waterfront in LE 519 to the storm the south-coast rolls call An Gàire Dubh²⁸, which drove the sea over it in a single night and spoiled the season's salt fish on the racks. King Tormod Bàn sent grain south before any asking came, and the town rebuilt a full street back from the old shore, on ground no telling said the sea had reached; the king rode down to see it, the one journey of his reign made for a storm's sake. In LE 1,754 the sea came over the waterfront a second time and flooded the moved street to its thresholds, and the town built a sea-wall; Gormshuil nic Thor-moid, sent by her father to see it building, carried home the harbour-master's word that a wall a man can stand behind is worth more than a street he can only run from. The town buried the boundary stones of the first street rather than break them up. Known for the street moved back from the sea, and the sea-wall.

Cuan ruadh (Cuan ruadh). Founded 1 an t-Sultain, GE 2,387. The eastern harbour, a hundred miles from the west coast over the mountain country, kept the only sailors of the island who had ever held a course by night. Six pilots of the west walked to it in LE 11 and were sent to the old steersman Seumas Reultach, who taught them on the headland above the town the wheel of the sky and Reul na Stiùire²⁹, and had his granddaughter cut part of it on a hide; he died on the cliff path in LE 14 and is buried among his own people. After the pilots went west nobody at Cuan ruadh sailed by night any longer. In the fifteenth century it built a second harbour arm to take the boats of Seann Tarr when that harbour broke, and thrived on the fishing of both towns' waters for the rest of the age. Known for the star-steersmen, and its second harbour arm.

Cuan shean (Cuan shean). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,755. The harbour a dozen miles down the coast from Seann Skell heard the first tale of a far shore on its quays in the moon of Faolach of the first year, and its skipper Eachann mac Lachlainn told the queen of a low dark coast west and north of west. For the fleet it gave its hemp fields to cordage, and by the sixth year its waterfront was three rope-walks end to end, where Iain Ròpaire and his walkers learned the names of a keel so that the shroud-lines would stop failing. The walks turned off hands when the harbour trade halved after the sailing, and were shortened in the eighth century of the count, half the ground sown with barley. The rope-walker Tormod Ciar swore Cupa na Firinne³⁰ on the walk itself, cupping rainwater in his hands. In the fourteenth century Tormod Ròpaire's crew still walked their strands to a work-song whose strange words named the parts of a deep keel, and Iseabail nic Lachlainn took it down there; the crew kept singing it exactly as he gave it, no better understood. Known for its rope-walks, and Òran na Druime³¹.

28. the Black Laugh

29. the steering star



Doire chiar (Doire chiar). Founded 8 an Giblean, GE 4,183. The village in the north-eastern hills is where Eilidh nic Iain, Eilidh Dhubh, taught at the well from LE 460, at thirty years old, the teaching her grandmother had taught her in secret: that the vein answers labour and not birth. She wrote it down in a hand her mother taught her, and pupils copied her tracts for households too far to hear her. When Taigh na Fèithe¹ burned some hundred of them in its yard in LE 484 she walked there to see it done and said nothing. One hide in her mother's hand stayed whole in a hollow beam of her house. She died here in LE 505, teaching within the hour of her death, and was buried behind her own house; Coinneach Odhar read the tracts at her grave from the copy he had carried thirty years. Known for Eilidh Dhubh and her tracts.

Doire fhiadhaich (Ros dhomhain). Founded 18 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,506. A wood of wild oak, crooked and never anyone's grove, stood on the shore of Loch chrom below the capital, and in the fifth year woodcutters of the roll built huts at its edge to fell crooked oak for the fleet's frames and knees. The huts did not outlast the felling. The wood kept its name, and the tellers of that shore say that timber for the fleet was felled there. Fifteen centuries on, other woodcutters came to what was left of the wood and stayed, and their huts became the village of Doire fhiadhaich, a fishing and cutting place on the capital shore that remembered the fleet chiefly as a reason for its name. Known for its oaks, said to have built a' Scaradh² fleet.

Doire fhionn (Doire fhionn). Founded 4 an t-Samhain, FE 1,149. The village in the north took its name from the oak grove on the hill above it, and in the fifth year Alasdair Saor came up the north road to fell it for the keels of the fleet. Its keeper, Eilidh nic Ruairidh, made him choose each tree he would take and hear its name; he chose fifty-four and left one young oak, the Child. Eighty men of the roll felled the grove through the summer, the greatest tree, the Queen, taking two days to bring down, and the keel-timbers went forty-two miles south to the sea on sleds of oak shod with ash, six yoke to a sled, over a causeway built across the stream below the village. The grove never grew again. The village built a low wall of stones round the Child, and its old keeper sat beside it every evening until dark. In LE 109 Taigh na Fèithe³ set down the coppice law of Doire fhionn, and the village lived thereafter by cutting coppice rather than oak, some of the fellowship's released journeymen among its cutters. Known for the oaks felled for the fleet, and the Child walked on the hill.

30. Manannan's Cup of Truth

31. the song of the keel

1. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

2. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Doire mhin (Doire mhin). Founded 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,260. The granary village on the road south of the ford had given carts and coal to Taigh na Fèithe⁴ without complaint for as long as anyone remembered, and did nothing to deserve what it got in LE 555, save stand on the road Ragnall Ruadh's broken host had to pass. The retreating men took what grain the granary held, fired it and a dozen houses about it, and went on. Coinneach mac Ailein carried his daughter Seònaid and the year's seed-corn out of the fire. Forty-one households walked six days south and wintered at Cathair mhòr on the charity of Macha's temple, where the fire went out in the winter of the refusal; Seònaid grew up to write *Leabhar nan Trì Tagraichean*⁵. The village was rebuilt, and its people kept the tale of Na Teallaichean Fuara⁶ longer than any other in the island. Known for the burning of LE 555, and the child who wrote its history.

Doire shean (Doire shean). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 695. The village on the southern shore laid out oyster beds in its shallow bay in the seventh century of the count and sent oysters by cart to the capital, a trade that made it rich enough to keep its temple. The old road-house Am Buabhall Fortanach stands by it on the road south, rebuilt in stone by Eilidh nic Chaluim after it burned to its footings in LE 164, where a boy of Clann Fhearchair was given a bowl of the jugged buffalo before the roof was on; Catriona Bhuadhach's stone road went past it to Inis thais. Known for its oysters, and Am Buabhall Fortanach.

Dùn dhearg (Dùn dhearg). Founded 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274. Clann Ìomhair, who hold the land about the city in the eastern hills, walled it in stone in LE 261 without the crown's leave, the first walls on the island raised by a custodian house. Queen Sileas summoned their head to a cold supper at An Talla Dearg⁷; neither spoke of the walls, both understood, and the walls stood. The smiths of the city made the ceremonial blades of the custodian houses from the layered steel of their fellowship, folded and refolded, until in LE 1,568 the fellowship lost the last smith who knew the folding well enough to finish a blade alone; the blades made after him were ordinary work. Known for the walls of Clann Ìomhair, and the layered steel lost.

Dùn iséal (Dùn iséal). Founded 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1. The old hall at Dùn iséal, where Bride's flame burns in Talla na Lasrach⁸ and the stone cup stands on the threshold, was the heir of the custody before Taigh na Fèithe⁹ took it; in this age it is the seat of Na Seann Spioradan¹⁰ of the eastern shires. In LE 179 their keepers raised a house for the ancestors there and cut the names of the eastern dead on wooden posts, renewed each generation; a young man of Clann Fhearchair, reading them, said a shire that trusted wood to hold its dead must trust its memory further than he would. Lightning burned the posts to their footings in LE 1,149, and the keepers cut the names again from memory and from *Leabhar a' Chùraim*¹¹, owning in their roll that some were guesses. An earthquake cracked the spirit-house in LE 1,649 and killed no one; the keepers took it for a warning and could not agree of what. Known for the ancestor-posts and Bride's flame.

4. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

5. the Book of the Three Claimants

6. the cold hearths

7. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

8. the Hall of the Flame

9. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

10. the Old Spirits

11. the custody-book of the vein-house

Dùn thais (Dùn thais). Founded 28 am Màrt, GE 2,473. The walled temple city in the north-east is the seat of Taigh na Deasbaid¹². Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn, a druid of the schools of Flidais who had walked the carters' roads for forty years, raised Taigh na Deasbaid here in LE 314 and had the schools' old question, Carson an làmh seo?, cut into its lintel before the roof was on; a question once put was argued a full year before any answer came from the master's chair. Pupils walked three days from Caol bheag to sit its benches. In LE 324 Coinneach asked there whether the hands that went with the fleet were those the vein answered best, and each of Na Seachd Taighean¹³ forbade the question at its own table. Ailean mac Dhùghaill's tables of the three old ruins were judged here, and in the thirteenth century Ragnall mac Chalum set out here Clàr nam Bliadhnachan¹⁴ that showed the heads of the houses living longer than their tenants; the table was forbidden and the house shut. It was opened and shut more than once, and last reopened in LE 1,759 on condition that the question of longer lives never be raised; its schools turned instead to whether Leabhar a' Chùrainn¹⁵'s handful answered to what the coal gave out. Known for Taigh na Deasbaid, and the questions it was forbidden.

I

Inis àrsaidh (Seann Skell). Founded 28 am Faoilleach, FE 76. The fishing village a little below Seann Skell gave more households to Rollan nan Deònach¹ than any other place on the island. Two of its households said in the drying-shed, in the first year, that they would go if a boat were ever built that could make the crossing, and the village laughed and then stopped laughing. Mòrag nic Dhòmhnail and her husband Aonghas mac Fhionnlaigh farmed the land above it, and it was at their board that Alasdair Saor was sent north to the oaks of Doire fhionn. When An Fhaoileag² An Fhaoileag lay down off Ros àrsaidh in the sixth year, its boats brought back three living and eight dead; the roll-keeper cut eleven names on the village's board in one night, and a lamp burned on the shingle for the three the sea kept. When the broken tidings of two landfalls came, the village kept both halves of the tale at once. Ruairidh mac Artair had a deep hull built here in the fourth century of the count; it listed at launch and was broken up within a fortnight, for no wright still living held the old scarfing of the keel. Known for the eleven names on its board, and the households it gave to the fleet.

Inis chrom (Inis chrom). Founded 25 an Giblean, FE 1,601. The walled harbour town on the south-west coast took a spotted fever among its fisher households in LE 624 that killed some forty. An Fhianna nursed the sick, and many of them died of it, and the town followed Òrd na Cloiche³ from then on. Known for the fever an Fhianna⁴ nursed.

12. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

13. the seven houses of custody

14. the table of years

15. the custody-book of the vein-house

1. the roll of the willing

2. the Gull, the first finished hull, lost off Ros àrsaidh

3. the order of the Stone

4. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

Inis mhòr (Inis mhòr). Founded 16 an Dàmhair, GE 4,328. The river town of the north built barges in the second century of the count to carry grain down the Abhainn ghorm and west along the cold way of the north coast, and a boy of the town watching the first one loaded asked his father why it should not simply cross open water by the shorter way, and got a look and no answer. Pupils of Dùn thais founded a house of disputation here in LE 769, the question of the vein argued in the north for the first time. The great gale of LE 1,229 drove the sea up the river higher than anyone living had seen and heaped the strand with broken plank. As the roads improved the coasting trade went by cart, and in LE 1,634 the last barge that had worked the cold way was hauled above the tide-line and chocked level, kept rather than broken up, though few of the town's fathers could say any longer what the cold way had been the way from. Known for the grain barges of the cold way, and the last one kept on the strand.

Inis thais (Inis thais). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 2,408. The walled harbour city of the south-west coast kept an old wolf-stone called Clach, watched for generations by families who had forgotten why. In LE 405 a net-maker of the strand, Dòmhnall mac Ailein, thirty-five years old, began telling the men who mended nets beside him that the stone was Lia Fàil⁵ and its watchers an Fhianna⁶, sworn to keep the island as a wolf keeps its range, and his hearers became Òrd na Cloiche⁷. They raised the first temple on the island to Lia Fàil by name, roofed with northern slate the shipmaster Beathag nic Raoghnaill fetched by sea, and blew a horn at every turn of the tide. Dòmhnall taught on the strand five-and-thirty years and never took an office. Catriona nic Aonghais was born here in LE 526 to the king's brother, and her mother kept her here rather than raise her at An Talla Dearg⁸; as queen she laid Rathad na Banrighinn⁹ in stone from the capital to her own gate. In LE 1,389 Òrd na Cloiche's congregation divided over whether the dead might be prayed for at Clach; those who said no kept the temple. Known for the wolf-stone Clach and Òrd na Cloiche.

5. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

6. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

7. the order of the Stone

8. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

9. the queen's road



Muileann chaol (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 18 an t-Ogmhios, GE 3,218. The mill town on the hill road of the east had a widow's loft by the seventeenth century of the count. Beathag nic Thòmais, whose husband had owned its mill, began in LE 1,659 to buy old copies of *Leabhar a' Chùrainm*¹ and *Rolla a' Chalaith*² from houses that no longer read them, and in her loft a crown clerk found the only surviving copy of a custodians' ruling *Taigh na Fèithe*³ had lost to fire. In LE 1,674 Anna nic Coinnich began to make paper from rags at the town's ford, the first on *Dia-thir*; Beathag carried it sixty miles to *Taigh na Fèithe* herself, and *Leabhar a' Chùrainm* was copied onto it for the first time. Among her papers she found three copies of the tidings of the two landfalls that did not agree, copied all three fair, and chose none. She left the loft to the town when she died in LE 1,699, on condition that nothing in it be burned, and the town kept the condition; its unpaid keeper told a crown reeve that fifty years of neither office asking for the papers back was itself an answer. Known for the paper mill and the loft of Beathag nic Thòmais.

Muileann chiar (Dùn ìseal). Founded 10 an Lùnastal, FE 7. The hill town of the silver seam keeps the sacred wood of *Flidais*, where the elder teachers of *Scoiltean nan Draoidhean*⁴ met, and its smiths beat the silver neck-rings that the heads of *Na Seachd Taighean*⁵ first wore in LE 149, so that a stranger might know a custodian by the collar before a word was said. Beathag nic Ruairidh taught in its grove when Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn came to it with the question he had carried on the roads, and told him the schools wanted a fixed ground where it might be argued whole. From LE 479 the schools kept the wood and walked its bounds each year in a procession open to anyone who would walk with them. Twice in the age *Clann Choinnich* asked that the coal be burned beyond the handful to smelt the silver here, in LE 1,559 and in LE 1,776, and twice the council refused; the second time by a single turned vote. Known for the silver collars, the wood of *Flidais*, and the smelt refused.

1. the custody-book of the vein-house

2. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

3. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

4. the druid schools

5. the seven houses of custody

Muileann chrom (Muileann chrom). Founded 11 an Gearran, FE 1,556. The town eight miles from Muileann dhearg below the mountain was a custodians' town of Clann Raghnaill, whose households kept galleries there. The hosts of Catriona nic Aonghais and Dùghall Garbh, joined for the purpose, met Raghnaill Ruadh below it in LE 560, and Raghnaill fell on the field; the next morning his own custodians struck the seal from Taigh na Fèithe⁶ store without waiting to be told who now held the mountain. Dùghall took a cut below the arm there that he hid from his physicians and died of it. Three centuries later the heads of Na Seachd Taighean⁷, sitting five years at Taigh na Fèithe to choose a king, spoke the name of Dòmhnall Ruadh of Muileann chrom, who kept three galleries there, and he spent his first night as king naming which of his neighbours he trusted to measure them honestly in his absence. He came back as king to settle a boundary between two households by asking each one's oldest member where they had played as children. Known for the battle that ended Raghnaill Ruadh's refusal, and the mountain's own king.

Muileann dhearg (Muileann dhearg). Founded 30 an t-Sultain, LE 2. Coal-breakers of the central diggings settled below the gate of Taigh na Fèithe⁸, in the first years of the age, and Taigh na Fèithe above them kept Leabhar a' Chùrain⁹, Crom's stone in its inner room, and the lamp in the niche that was never let go out. The custodians counted Rolla nan Deònach¹⁰ against the book here in the third year, nine days at the long table, and found one hearth in five of the coal-right meant to go; here they ruled one sealed measure of coal to each hull that should be ready, and the boy-clerk Donchadh mac Thormoid made the fair copy at fifteen and began, at thirty, the count of years from An Diosal¹¹ that the crown took up after him. Na Seachd Taighean¹² were sworn before Crom's stone in LE 55 and drew their galleries by lot in the hall in LE 109. Eachann Briseadair's household built the first stone house below the gate, and the row became a town with its own well, smith and reeve in his lifetime. Eilidh Dhubh's tracts were burned in Taigh na Fèithe yard in LE 484; Raghnaill Ruadh refused the handful to the shires that stood against him from its store in LE 558, and Riaghailt an Teallaich¹³ was drafted in the same yard seven years later. Dòmhnall Ruadh joined the crown to the mastery of Taigh na Fèithe, and was buried at his own wish in a worked-out gallery with an unlit lamp at his head. Queen Gormshuil rode up to the winter burning here in LE 1,795, as she had every winter of her reign, and nothing more is told. Known for Taigh na Fèithe and Leabhar a' Chùrain.

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

7. the seven houses of custody

8. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

9. the custody-book of the vein-house

10. the roll of the willing

11. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

12. the seven houses of custody

13. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

Muileann dhomhain (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 9 an t-Samhain, FE 1,417. The south-eastern mill town took the swallowing cough in LE 1,079, a sickness that closed the throat until a man could not swallow his own spit; it went house by house along the lower street and up into the hill lanes, and the town lost near a third of its people. Beathag Fhionn, crowned in LE 1,082, shut the coast road between Seann Bhrál and Muileann dhomhain within the month and set a reeve at each of its six fords, and the road stayed shut three years; the cough never crossed west of them. The town stood at less than two households in three for twenty years and more, its old reeve walking the lower street once a season to write down which roofs had fallen, until families from the hill country above came down a handful a year and took the empty houses by lot. Known for the swallowing cough, and the houses taken by lot.

Muileann gheal (Dùn dhearg). Founded 7 an Dàmhair, LE 1,082. White-stone millers raised the mill town in the south-east in LE 1,082 to grind for the city of Dùn dhearg. Its potters of Clann Mhic Phàil made a grey-green glaze that no other kiln could match, and the custodian houses bought their table-ware from that one family; the secret went mother to daughter unwritten. The last of the family, Iain Mac Phàil, took two apprentices in his last years, and neither learned to judge the moment the kiln's heat must be let fall. He died without passing it on in LE 1,509, and for a generation the town's potters tried to match it and failed. Known for the grey-green glaze, and its losing.

Muileann ghlas (Dùn chrom). Founded 16 an t-Samhain, FE 748. The small mill town under Dùn chrom saw the last battle of Cogadh nam Bràithrean¹⁴ in LE 1,274, when Iain Ciar defeated his brother Alasdair Bàn below it, took him alive and let his captains go home. An ox-driver who turned back from the mountain road rather than push his team through unsettled country carried word of it to An Taigh-seinnse Mòr within the week, and could not say where the brothers now stood to one another; the peace was made two years later at the road-house. Known for the battle that ended Cogadh nam Bràithrean.

Muileann naomh (Muileann naomh). Founded 24 am Faoilleach, GE 2,986. The southern mill town became the southernmost house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹⁵ in the sixth century of the count. Its bell-founders cast the first bronze bell on Dia-thìr to hang in a hawk-house in LE 514, with King Tormod Bàn standing at the casting; it cracked in its first frost, and the second, thicker at the waist, held, and rang at every measured burning. There Òrd an t-Seabhaig's teaching was still given whole and unsoftened when it faded elsewhere, and pilgrims came to it from further south than any hawk-house had drawn from before. Known for the first bell of a hawk-house.

Muileann ruadh (Cnoc leathan). Founded 15 am Faoilleach, LE 190. The town where warm water rises from the ground in the east country was founded in LE 190, and in LE 769 its bath-house was rebuilt below it. Coal-breakers, salt-carriers and shepherds sat in the warm water together without minding whose gallery the others answered to, and the old vein-house scribe Eòghann mac Pheadair was carried there by cart in his last cold season. Known for its bath-house over Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹⁶.

14. the Brothers' War

15. the Hawk order

16. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

Muileann shean (Muileann shean). Founded 1 an t-Samhain, FE 1,093. The millers of the northern mill town cut a new gearing for their wheels in LE 1,189, oak toothed against oak, so that one wheel turned two stones where it had turned one. Half the town came to watch it the first winter and went away arguing whether the flour was finer or coarser. Within a generation every mill of consequence in the north had it, and the millers hung a carved model of it over their own door as a boast that grew quieter with every mill that copied it without asking leave. Known for the gearing that turned two stones.

R

Ros àrsaidh (Ros bheag). Founded 16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,221. The small walled harbour on the point below Ros bheag is where the ships of Inis àrsaidh put out to sea. The first finished hull, An Fhaoileag¹, was taken past it for her trial in the sixth year and lay down in a following sea off its headland with fourteen aboard. Eight years later its strand was the ground of the first night-steering trial, when Catrìona nic Iain, home from the steersmen of Cuan ruadh, took one boat out past the headland with every lantern doused and brought her in by Reul na Stiùire² before the lantern-boat that hugged the shore. Half the town came down to see it fail. After the fleet sailed the point went back to the coasting trade and the fishing, and nobody out of it is recorded to have sailed by night again. Known for the loss of An Fhaoileag, and the first night steered by a star.

Ros bheag (Ros bheag). Founded 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274. The walled harbour town of the Ros bheag cape sent its skipper Oighrig nic Raghnaill to An Talla Dearg³ in the first year with a telling of a high forested coast past the north cape, and two of the six pilots who walked east to learn the stars at Cuan ruadh were its own, Catrìona nic Iain among them. After the sailing it was a fishing and coasting town like its neighbours. Manannan's teaching came to it down the coast with the fishing families, and in LE 694 the priests of the order at Ros bheag laid down that no boat of the faithful might go out of sight of the headlands; within the year two of the order's boats turned back its own skipper Coinneach mac Sheumais when he chased a run of fish too far. Four years later a priest there asked a pilot's grandson, Griogair, which star his grandfather had steered by, and the boy could not say. The rule of the headlands was kept on the west coast for the rest of the age. Known for the rule of sight-of-land, and the pilot who forgot his star.

1. the Gull, the first finished hull, lost off Ros àrsaidh

2. the steering star

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

Ros fhionn (Inis bheag). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, FE 41. The small walled river town of the north-east found its fortune in LE 350, when a farmer digging a ditch above it struck warm water that tasted of salt. Pans were laid out on the flats within the season, and the salt went inland over Drochaid Ros fhionn, whose keeper Iain mac Ùisdein took a handful from every load for his toll and filled an iron-bound salt-box faster than any box on that road. Ros fhionn salted the fish of the mining shires, and at the height of its fair in LE 959 the reeve lost his count past four thousand people on the flats. The salt-masters rebuilt the bridge's arches at their own cost in the twelfth century after a carter's mule went into the river through the road bed. Then a shifting bar silted the Abhainn bheag, the barges could no longer reach the quays, and the salt went by sea through Caol gharbh; the market-court stayed on its headland with its bench of old oak, the bridge's last keeper died with no one to take the toll, and the channel was withied from the bar to open water. Known for its salt, its bridge and its market-court.

Ros gheal (Ros gheal). Founded 29 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,009. The harbour town on the north coast took the dawn rite of Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁴ in LE 239, when two of Gormshuil nic Artair's pupils, a brother and sister of a coastal household, carried it down from Cnoc bheag so that the fishing families need not walk two days inland for it; Gormshuil came down herself to judge whether the teaching had travelled whole. Its hawk-house took charge of the measured burning for the country between the coast and the hills, and was eight years old when Gormshuil died. Ùisdean mac Pàdraig came here to gather what her pupils remembered for Leabhar an t-Seabhaig⁵, and marked every saying he had not heard from her own mouth. Known for the second house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig.

S

Seann Bhral (Seann Bhral). Founded 30 an Lùnastal, VE 1,005. The walled port of the south-east was the second town the swallowing cough reached, in LE 1,081. Its townsfolk closed the harbour themselves before any order came, and kept the shared meal by leaving food at the town gate for the households that could no longer come to the board. The coast road from it to Muileann dhomhain was shut by the queen's reeves for three years after. Known for the harbour shut against the cough, and the meal at the gate.

Seann Chwen (Seann Chwen). Founded 19 an Giblean, VE 32. The harbour town on the south coast below the mountain finished its stone mole in LE 899, and the coal-barges of the mountain roads tied up there where before they had beached on shingle at low water; it became the port of the coal-carts coming down to the coast towns of the south. After Cogadh nam Bràithrean¹ Alasdair Bàn held its lordship for life under the peace, kept the peace he had made to the end of his days, and died here in LE 1,291. The lordship returned to the crown, and Iain Ciar left it vacant for the rest of his reign. Known for the coal mole, and the lordship left vacant.

4. the Hawk order

5. the Book of the Hawk

1. the Brothers' War

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, VE 1,833. The northern Seann Skell, on the bay the hawk-keepers call their own, is not the river port of the west. In the fifth century of the count it put up a wall around its streets for the first time, and the crown granted a market inside the new landward gate where the amber of that coast was sold beside whale-oil, honey and the wool of the northern moors; the amber-workers swore to sell no rough stone outside the walls, and one of them, Ailig an Òir, forfeited a season's gathering to his own guild for breaking the oath within the year. After the schism of Òrd an t-Seabhaig² the priests of An Seabhag Biadh³ settled here, and under Beathag nic Sheumais built a following of four families into a school. From here in LE 919 she rode to Cathair dhearg to ask that the measured handful be raised by a quarter for the hearths of the north coast, and carried the refusal home in her own satchel; the house stood after exactly as it had before. Known for the amber market inside the gate, and the house of An Seabhag Biadh³.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 6 an Gearran, VE 173. The river port at the mouth of the Abhainn naomh was the town a' Scaradh⁴ was made in. In its harbour-house, Taigh a' Chalaigh⁵, Calum mac Nèill opened Rolla nan Deònach⁶ in the second year and wrote every household whole or not at all, cutting a struck name through with one stroke rather than scraping it. Alasdair Saor laid the first deep keel on the strand below the town, the fellowship of the strand swore its apprentices over a coal, and the queen's masons lengthened the west quay in dressed stone for what the crown called the harbour's trade. On the night before the sailing a lamp stood in every window along the waterfront, and in the morning Calum's grandson Niall cut one notch on a hazel stick for every hull that went round the river pool sunwise and down to the sea. The quay was called Cidhe an Diosail⁷ after that, and its old name passed to a fish-wharf. The harbour carried half its old trade within a generation. Mànas mac Ruairidh preached Manannan on its stones in the seventh century of the count, and Taigh Mhanannain⁸ was raised beside the harbour-court. Its synod set the prayer for the shut sea at the foot of the river pool. Oidhche nan Lòchran⁹ thinned household by household until one old woman, Ealasaid nic Iain, kept the last lamp; eleven people stood on the quay at the last Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh¹⁰ the age records, and the harbour scribe Eòghann mac Nèill counted them. Known for Rolla nan Deònach, Cidhe an Diosail and Oidhche nan Lòchran.

2. the Hawk order

3. the Fed Hawk

4. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

5. the harbour-house

6. the roll of the willing

7. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

8. the house of Manannan

9. the night of lamps at Seann Skell

10. the rite of the empty harbour

Seann Tarr (Seann Tarr). Founded 25 an Giblean, VE 1,212. The old harbour of the east coast below Cuan ruadh was torn apart in LE 1,399 by the storm the coast called Gailleann Ghlas, which came in out of the east and left the village standing but its quay in pieces past any mending worth the cost. Its boats went to Cuan ruadh, which built a second harbour arm to take them. Seann Tarr kept its houses and its shrine, let its harbour go, and was entered in the charter-roll, in the roll's own dry word for such places, as a village again. Known for the harbour given up after Gailleann Ghlas.

Seann Tarr (Muileann bheag). Founded 30 an Cèitean, VE 884. The small citadel harbour of the east kept an ancestor shrine of Na Seann Spioradan¹¹, and from LE 644 the crowds that came to it for the great feasts held a market on the three feast days, chiefly of honey, beeswax for the shrine's lights and the wool of the hill farms. The market outgrew the feasts in time and was held whether the shrine had a feast or not. Known for the feast-market at the shrine.

Seann Toll (Seann Toll). Founded 8 an t-Samhain, VE 1,033. The harbour town of the north coast lost its old harbour wall in one night in LE 259, in the storm its fishers call Am Fuath Mòr¹², and with it forty boats at their moorings and eighteen men and women who had gone down in the dark to save them. Its young reeve, Ragnall mac Nèill, thirty-four and four years in office, stood knee-deep hauling on a rope to bring in a boat with two children lashed inside, and afterward lost his count twice burying the dead in a single row on the headland. The town built its wall again higher and with a hooked end, to a plan the reeve had from the capital's masons, and the hooked wall stood through every storm of the age after. Known for the hooked harbour wall.

Seann Vell (Seann Vell). Founded 4 an t-Ògmhios, VE 396. The small citadel port far off on the south-east coast keeps its mills on its river. In a wet spring in LE 244 the river broke its banks and carried away the lower mills, and the mill-wrights built them again on the higher ground; a pupil of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹³ house at Ros gheal who saw it called the flood a kind of overfed hawk, and Gormshuil nic Artair told him a river was a river, and sent him back to watch the mills rebuilt before he judged further. At the end of the age's first year the question whether anyone would go with the fleet was asked at hearths from Baile chrom in the north-west as far as Seann Vell. Known for its mills, and the flood of LE 244.

Seann Warr (Seann Warr). Founded 27 am Màrt, VE 725. The walled port nearest the capital on the west keeps salt-pans and brine springs behind its walls, and they fed it through Cogadh nan Trì Tagraichean¹⁴. Its reeve Mairead nic Ruairidh gave the heralds of all three claimants the same answer at the western gate: the town would open to trade and shut to hosts until the houses agreed which claim to answer. Dùghall Garbh sat before it a fortnight in LE 553, and Mairead sold his host bread at the market rate until his carters cost him more than the town was worth; he came back better provisioned three years later and sat a month, and marched away when Catrìona closed the gates of Cathair dhomhain. In LE 594 Catrìona Bhudhach granted Seann Warr the right to keep its own gates and take its own tolls, and the grant was cut in stone letters over the landward gate. Known for the gate shut against all three claimants, and the grant cut over it.

11. the Old Spirits

12. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

13. the Hawk order

14. the War of the Three Claimants

T

Tobar dhearg (Tobar dhearg). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, GE 2,947. The quarry village of the south-east burned in LE 446 when fire ran through its thatch, and most of it went. King Aonghas sent what the crown's granaries could spare before the winter closed the roads. A quarryman's household was the first to roof again in slate, judging that a man who cut the stone had less excuse than his neighbours to sleep under straw, and the village was rebuilt in slate from the quarries nearby and known for its slate roofs from then on. Known for its slate roofs.

Tobar dhìreach (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, VE 42. The village among the wells of the eastern hill country keeps the naming rites of the old reciters. At a naming there in LE 525, for a steward's son of Tormod Bàn's household, the reciter Muireach mac Ailein of Clann na Ceiste¹ said the line of An Clachair² over the child instead of the long line of Rìghrean na Cloiche³ that royal namings there had called on for generations. Known for its namings at the wells.

1. the Children of the Question

2. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

3. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

PART FOUR

The Appendices

APPENDIX A

The Kings, the Queens and the Houses

For the eighteen centuries of a' Scaradh¹ Dia-thìr kept one crown at Cathair dhearg, one vein-house above Muileann dhearg, and between them Na Seachd Taighean² that answered to both and were, for most of the age, the stronger. This appendix gives the crowned rulers as Clàr nan Rìghrean³ recopied in LE 829 and Leabhar a' Chùraim⁴ give them, with their years and their ages; Na Seachd Taighean and those of their heads the record names; the masters of Taigh na Fèithe⁵; the scribes who kept the harbour-house at Seann Skell; and the end of the crown. Years are counted from the first year of the age, as the rolls counted them after the crown took up Donnchadh's count; ages are given at the crowning and at the death, as Leabhar a' Chùraim sets them down. Na Bliadhnachan Fada of the old blood had thinned to an ordinary span by An Aois Na-omh⁶, and in this age no one, crowned or not, is entered as living past five-and-ninety.

The crowned rulers

Beathag nic Dhòmhnail, of the house of Dòmhnall, daughter of Mòr nic Coinnich. Crowned at fifteen in FE 2,953, eight years before the first year of the age; she was three-and-twenty when the three crews came to An Talla Dearg⁷. She gave the word that the crown would send no one over and keep no one back, struck her sister Mòrag and Mòrag's children from the succession in the ordinary hand in LE 46, and wore undyed wool for her sister from the thirteenth year of the count. She died at Cathair dhearg in LE 55, at seventy-six, after one-and-sixty years crowned, holding a boundary

1. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

2. the seven houses of custody

3. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

5. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

6. the Holy Age

7. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

petition to its end the morning she took to her bed. Her consort Uilleam mac Iain died in LE 29.

Ragnall mac Uilleim, her son, born LE 8. Crowned in LE 55 at seven-and-forty, with a strip of undyed wool at his wrist beneath the crowning colours. He died in LE 92 in his eighty-fifth year, four-and-eighty years old, after seven-and-thirty years crowned.

Ragnall mac Raghnaill, his son, born LE 45. Crowned in LE 92 at seven-and-forty, grey already at the temples. He died in LE 125 at eighty, three-and-thirty years crowned.

Ìomhar mac Raghnaill, his son, born LE 92. Crowned in LE 125 at three-and-thirty with the same cup and the same oath as his father. His only son, Ragnall Beag, died of a fever in LE 170. Ìomhar died in LE 180 at eight-and-eighty, five-and-fifty years crowned and without an heir, and the line of Beathag ended with him.

Fearchar mac Lachlainn, of Clann Fhearchair, born LE 157 at Baile Mòr dhomhain, the elder son, bound seven years to the galleries as a boy. Chosen by the heads of Na Seachd Taighean⁸ in the yard of An Talla Dearg in LE 182, when his younger brother Iain, head of the house, turned the choosing aside and named him; he drank his first oath from the cup of Clann Mhuirich, the crown having none ready. Crowned at five-and-twenty. He kept his court part of each year at Baile Mòr dhomhain. He died in LE 211 at four-and-fifty, nine-and-twenty years crowned, and asked that no more coal be burned for him than the ordinary handful.

Fearchar Donn, his son, born LE 188. Crowned in LE 211 at three-and-twenty. He died in LE 256 at eight-and-sixty, five-and-forty years crowned; the heads of Na Seachd Taighean held the hall in his daughter's name for two years.

Sileas nic Fhearchair, his daughter, born LE 243. Crowned in LE 258 at fifteen. She married Dùghall mac Ìomhair of Clann Ìomhair, set the firloft of Cathair dhearg as the one measure of the island, put a tally-house in every royal granary, chartered the full-moon market of Cathair fhada and widened the bridge of the capital. She died in LE 324 at one-and-eighty, six-and-sixty years crowned, the longest reign An Talla Dearg had then seen.

Uisdean mac Dhùghaill, her son, born LE 270 in the twelfth year of her reign. Crowned in LE 324 at four-and-fifty. He died in LE 352 at two-and-eighty, eight-and-twenty years crowned.

Uisdean mac Uisdein, his son, born LE 322. Crowned in LE 352 at thirty. He had his son taught his letters by a tutor, Mòr nic Nèill, the first heir so taught. He died in LE 394 at two-and-seventy, two-and-forty years crowned.

8. the seven houses of custody

Aonghas mac Uisdein, his son, born LE 372. Crowned in LE 394 at two-and-twenty, with less dispute than any crowning in living memory. He took up Òrd Mhacha⁹ rite of Macha and made it the crown's custom, and half his household took it up after him. He died in LE 450 at eight-and-seventy, six-and-fifty years crowned.

Aonghas Òg mac Aonghais, his son, born LE 400. Crowned in LE 450 at fifty. He died in the winter of LE 484 at four-and-eighty, four-and-thirty years crowned, the first king carried to his grave by the rite of Macha.

Iain mac Aonghais, his son, born LE 435. Crowned in LE 484 at nine-and-forty. He had three sons, the youngest, Dùghall, by a second wife. He died in LE 496 at one-and-sixty, twelve years crowned: the third king the hall had buried in a single generation.

Tormod mac Iain, Tormod Bàn, his eldest son, born LE 460. Crowned in LE 496 at six-and-thirty. His two sons were drowned together when the ferry on the Abhainn fhionn overturned in LE 534, and his brother Aonghas mac Iain had died four years before. He named no heir. He died in LE 547 at seven-and-eighty, one-and-fifty years crowned, and Na Seachd Taighean held the hall in common while three claims stood unanswered.

Catrìona nic Aonghais, Catrìona Bhua dhach, daughter of Aonghas mac Iain and Mairead nic Ailein, niece of Tormod Bàn, born LE 526 at Inis thais. She won Cogadh nan Trì Tagraichean¹⁰ and was crowned in LE 562 at six-and-thirty. She bound every claimant, house and king by Riaghailt an Teallaich¹¹, laid Rathad na Banrighinn¹² in stone to her own gate, and honoured Seann Warr's gates. Her husband Iain mac Eathainn died in LE 594. She died in LE 604 at eight-and-seventy, two-and-forty years crowned, the last ruler who had fought in the war.

Lachlann mac Iain, her son, born LE 565. Crowned in LE 604 at nine-and-thirty; the seven heads swore to him within a single day of his mother's burial. He had Leabhar nan Trì Tagraichean¹³ read into the record and forbade that any copy of it be made shorter than the one before. He died in LE 654 at nine-and-eighty, fifty years crowned.

Anna, his daughter, born LE 600. Crowned in LE 654 at four-and-fifty. She died in LE 685 at five-and-eighty, one-and-thirty years crowned.

9. the order of Macha

10. the War of the Three Claimants

11. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

12. the queen's road

13. the Book of the Three Claimants

The fourth of the house of Catriona, Anna's child, born LE 635. Crowned in LE 685 at fifty; died in LE 722 at seven-and-eighty, seven-and-thirty years crowned. Clàr nan Rìghrean¹⁴ as recopied keeps the years and has lost the name.

The fifth of the house of Catriona, child of the fourth, born LE 680. Crowned in LE 722 at two-and-forty; died in LE 769 at nine-and-eighty, seven-and-forty years crowned. The name is likewise lost.

Eilidh Bhàn, granddaughter of the fifth, born LE 751. Crowned in LE 769 at eighteen. She sent Iain mac Thormoid against the sea-thieves of the small islands and had Clàr nan Rìghrean recopied onto new hide in LE 829. She died in LE 841 at ninety, two-and-seventy years crowned, the oldest ruler of the age, and without an heir.

Dòmhnall Ruadh, of Clann Raghnaill, a custodian of three galleries at Muileann chrom, born LE 790. Named by Na Seachd Taighean after five years of sittings at Taigh na Fèithe¹⁵, and crowned at Cathair dhearg in LE 846 at six-and-fifty. In LE 859 the crown was joined to the mastery of Taigh na Fèithe, and from LE 865 the custody's seal, the trellis and the hollow stone, went on the crown's letters. He died in LE 871 at one-and-eighty, five-and-twenty years crowned, and was buried at his own wish in a worked-out gallery under the mountain with an unlit lamp at his head.

Ragnall Òg, his son, born LE 825. Crowned in LE 871 at six-and-forty, more at ease with a boundary plea than with his own coronation. The record gives no year for his death, and Clàr nan Rìghrean for the century and a half after him keeps reigns that this record does not number.

Mòrag Ruadh, a girl of Clann Raghnaill, born LE 1,000. Named by Na Seachd Taighean on the death of the old king and crowned in LE 1,019 at nineteen. She kept her own ledger, clasped in iron at her own asking, from the first month; she judged that the thousandth year of the count deserved one handful burned on Cidhe an Dio-sail¹⁶ and no more, and rode down to see it burned. Her daughter was born in LE 1,040. She reigned sixty-three years; the ledger's last sum is of LE 1,082.

Beathag Fhionn, her daughter, born LE 1,040. Sat at her mother's right hand for years before she was crowned in LE 1,082 at two-and-forty, and closed the coast road against the swallowing cough within the month. She died in LE 1,129 at nine-and-eighty, seven-and-forty years crowned, asking whether the road stood open.

Ailean, her son, born LE 1,070. Crowned in LE 1,129 at nine-and-fifty. The record gives no year for his death.

Ailean mac Raghnaill, born LE 1,200. The record gives no year for his crowning. He reigned long enough that few at the hall could remember another king's seal, and

14. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

15. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

16. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

died in LE 1,266 at six-and-sixty, leaving two sons by different mothers and a burial roll with a blank where the heir's name should stand.

Iain Ciar, his son, born LE 1,240. He won Cogadh nam Bràithrean¹⁷ against his half-brother Alasdair Bàn and made the peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr with two loaves left uneaten on the board. Crowned in LE 1,276 at six-and-thirty. He kept his brother's lordship of Seann Chwen vacant after Alasdair's death in LE 1,291, made the grain law of LE 1,299, and chartered the road-houses of the mining roads in LE 1,319. He died in LE 1,326 at six-and-eighty, fifty years crowned.

Catrìona Bheag, of Clann Raghnaill, born LE 1,400. Crowned in LE 1,429 at nine-and-twenty, the first queen in more than three centuries; the record notes she was small, and that no one at her court said so twice. She had the seven heads swear Riaghailt an Teallaich afresh in LE 1,449.

Sileas Òg, born LE 1,505. Crowned in LE 1,529 at four-and-twenty. She rode a round of every shire seat on the island, the first ruler to stand in all of them, entered the smaller Cunntas nan Làmh¹⁸ of LE 1,539 without a word, and presided when the council refused the first of Athchuingean an Airgid¹⁹ in LE 1,559.

Ailean mac Raghnaill, the fourth of the name, born LE 1,550. Crowned in LE 1,589 at nine-and-thirty; dead within the year at forty, the shortest reign Clàr nan Rìghrean sets down. Leabhar a' Chùrain²⁰ does not say what ailed him. His sister had the years of his crowning and death cut on one stone.

Mòrag nic Raghnaill, his sister, born LE 1,556. Crowned in LE 1,590 at four-and-thirty. She reigned forty years, to LE 1,630, and her clerk set down under her no death by war, no famine and no quarrel of Na Seachd Taighean.

Tormod mac Ruairidh, of Clann Raghnaill, born LE 1,680. Crowned in LE 1,709 at nine-and-twenty. The record keeps of his reign chiefly its roads and its bridges. He governed his last years from a chair by the hearth and died in LE 1,766 at six-and-eighty, seven-and-fifty years crowned, the longest-lived king Leabhar a' Chùrain had entered since Clàr nam Bliadhnachan²¹; he told his daughter the last night that he had never found the courage to ask Taigh na Fèithe the forbidden question.

Gormshuil nic Thormoid, his daughter, born LE 1,715. Crowned in LE 1,766 at one-and-fifty. She rode a progress of every shire seat from LE 1,771 and had Leabhar nan Gearan²² written at each. In LE 1,795, eighty years old and nine-and-twenty years crowned, she rode the coal-road to Taigh na Fèithe for the winter burning, as she had

17. the Brothers' War

18. the census of hands

19. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

20. the custody-book of the vein-house

21. the table of years

22. the book of complaints

every winter of her reign, and walked her own horse up the last iced mile. Nothing more is told.

The empty chair

From the winter after the queen went up, the custodians of Na Seachd Taighean²³ sat at An Talla Dearg²⁴ in her place, sending their word up the coal-road by the riders who had carried the crown's business, and from LE 1,798 they sealed their letters with the custody's trellis and hollow stone and no name above the seal. No clerk was asked to explain the blank. In the seventeenth winter, LE 1,812, the heads, meeting at Cathair dhearg by the chance of their riders' errands, called themselves Comhairle a' Chùrain²⁵, the council of the custody, and named Tormod mac Ailein, eight-and-thirty, a custodian's son of no house among the seven, Ceann a' Chùrain²⁶ to speak for them with one voice. He was offered the queen's chair at the head of the board and kept his place at its foot. The chair stood empty at every sitting after, and by the last winter of the age no clerk living could say with certainty whose absence it marked.

Na Seachd Taighean

The houses were made at Taigh na Fèithe²⁷ in LE 55, when a fifth of the coal-right's households had gone with the fleet and the old apprenticeship could no longer serve the galleries. The remaining custodian households were gathered into seven kindreds, their heads sworn before Crom's stone, and from that year the right to the coal passed by house: Clann Mhuirich, Clann Fhearchair, Clann Ìomhair, Clann Raghnaill, Clann Thormoid, Clann Choinnich and Clann Lachlainn. In LE 109 each head drew a marked stone from a covered bag for the galleries, and the bag hung on its peg in Taigh na Fèithe hall for the rest of the age. From LE 149 the heads wore the silver neck-rings of Muileann chiar.

Clann Mhuirich. Its head, a woman, lent the house's own cup for Fearchar mac Lachlainn's first oath in LE 182. The record names no other head of it.

Clann Fhearchair, of Baile Mòr dhomhain. It gave the crown Fearchar mac Lachlainn and his line, and its head **Iain mac Lachlainn**, born LE 160, head from LE 179, kept the house's hall while his brother reigned, and died in LE 219.

23. the seven houses of custody

24. the red hall, the right's hall at Cathair dhearg

25. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

26. the high custodian of the Council of Custodians; lit. 'head of the custody'

27. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

Clann Ìomhair, of the eastern hills about Dùn dhearg. It walled Dùn dhearg in LE 261 without the crown's leave and gave Queen Sileas her consort, Dùghall mac Ìomhair. **Beathag nic Uisdein**, its head, set her mark last and longest to Riaghailt an Teallaich²⁸ in LE 565 and knelt first to Lachlann mac Iain in LE 604.

Clann Raghnaill. Its head **Ragnall Ruadh**, born LE 505, was chosen master of Taigh na Fèithe in LE 540 over two men of longer service, claimed the crown after Tormod Bàn, refused the measured handful to the shires that stood against him in LE 558, and fell below Muileann chrom in LE 560. The house gave the crown Dòmhnall Ruadh and, from Mòrag Ruadh on, most of the rulers of the age's second half.

Clann Thormoid. An old woman of the house, who had given a brother and two nephews to the roll, turned the sitting of LE 54 by saying she would sooner see her right folded into a house that could walk its galleries than stand alone over ones it could not serve.

Clann Choinnich. Its head, a woman, argued three winters that the coal be burned beyond the handful to smelt the silver of Muileann chlar, and the house brought the first of Athchuingean an Airgid²⁹ in LE 1,558 and the second in LE 1,776; both were refused, and the house asked a third time at the first sitting of Comhairle a' Chùraim³⁰ and was set aside. At the renewed oath of LE 1,449 its head asked whether the oath changed the measure or only the manner.

Clann Lachlainn. **Aonghas mac Lachlainn**, born LE 1,720, sat on the council that refused Athchuingean an Airgid and turned his own vote against it at the board without a reason; he died at Cathair dhearg in LE 1,804 at four-and-eighty, the last of that council, and kept his reason.

By the last Cunntas nan Lámh³¹ in LE 1,791 three of the seven held more than half the whole right between them, and one of the four smaller houses was eased with a neighbour's unused right.

The masters of Taigh na Fèithe

Eòghann mac Mhuirich, master at the opening of the age, who made the first count of the departing households in LE 3 and saw the measures for the fleet sealed; he died in LE 30, very old. Leabhar a' Chùraim³² leaves the masters after him unnamed until the war. **Ragnall Ruadh** of Clann Raghnaill was chosen in LE 540 and held the

28. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

29. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

30. the Council of Custodians; lit. 'the council of the custody'

31. the census of hands

32. the custody-book of the vein-house

mastery until he fell in LE 560. From LE 859 the king was master of Taigh na Fèithe³³, and the crown and the custody kept their records on one shelf.

The scribes of Leabhar a' Chùraim the record names are **Donnchadh mac Thor-moid**, born LE 14, given to Taigh na Fèithe at nine, maker of the fair copy of the ruling of the coal at fifteen and of the count from An Diosal³⁴ at thirty, who died at Muileann dhearg in LE 109 at five-and-ninety; **Murchadh Beag**, who took a coal-breaker's son from the face for a scribe's stool and died about LE 728; and **Eòghann mac Pheadair**, born LE 700, who settled the two counts of An Diosal with the crown's scribe **Mòrag nic Ìomhair** in LE 739 and died about LE 770. Under them **Eòghann mac Dhùghaill**, master of the store in the war, kept Raghnaill Ruadh's list of refused hearths face to the wall and never scraped it, and his son **Dòmhnall mac Eòghainn** let Seònaid nic Coinnich copy it.

The harbour scribes of Seann Skell

Calum mac Nèill, born FE 2,930, opened Rolla nan Deònach³⁵ in LE 2 and kept the boards six-and-fifty years; he died in the room above the harbour-house in LE 58. **Niall mac Dhòmhnail**, his grandson, born LE 29, who counted the hulls with a hazel stick at eleven, kept the boards from LE 58 to his death in LE 104 and was buried with the stick in his hand; his father **Dòmhnall mac Chaluim** kept the trade rolls beside him and died in LE 66. **Murchadh mac Raghnaill** was harbour-master in Niall's time and made the count of half trade. **Ailean mac Mhurchaidh** kept the harbour-house when Seònaid nic Coinnich came to read the old boards in LE 612, and **Donnchadh mac Ailein**, scribe of the harbour-court, would not enter Manannan's blessings beside the tallies of hulls. **Eòghann mac Nèill**, born LE 1,763, kept the book at Cidhe an Diosail³⁶ from LE 1,792 to the end of the age, counted the eleven at the last Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh³⁷, and wrote the number, the weather and the tide in the same plain hand every Là an Diosail³⁸ after.

The queen's scribes

Murchadh mac Eòghainn, born FE 2,925, wrote the three tellings on one leaf in the first year, sealed the queen's word, and entered Mòrag's line struck in LE 46, sanding

33. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

34. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

35. the roll of the willing

36. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

37. the rite of the empty harbour

the leaf as he had sanded every entry for forty years; he died in LE 49. **Seònaid nic Coinnich**, born LE 549, came to An Talla Dearg³⁹ at seventeen from the charity of Cathair mhòr, served Catriona Bhuadhach and Lachlann, and wrote Leabhar nan Trì Tagraichean⁴⁰, finished in LE 624; she died in LE 631 at two-and-eighty. **Pàdraig mac Ruairidh** wrote Leabhar nam Bràithrean⁴¹ in Iain Ciar's praise and died about LE 1,320. **Pàdraig mac Ìomhair**, steward, set his sums before the girl Mòrag Ruadh from the evening she found his tally wrong.

38. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

39. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

40. the Book of the Three Claimants

41. the book of the brothers

APPENDIX B

The Orders and the Rites

An Creideamh Sean¹ that the island kept at the opening of a' Scaradh² had no orders in it. There were the dawn-hawk rite at Cnoc bheag, the sacred woods kept in common by whoever kept them, Scoiltean nan Draoidhean³ with no ground of their own, the wolf-stone at Inis thais watched by families who had forgotten why, the old spirits of the hearths with their keepers in the east, and the handful of coal burned at every lawful hearth under Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁴. By the end of the age the same faith had five orders with their own houses, books and quarrels, and the island had made for itself a set of rites for the departed that no order owned. This appendix gives each as the record gives it: when it began, where it held, and what it quarrelled over.

The coal and Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig

Under all the orders lay the custody of the vein. Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig⁵, measured to every hearth that held the right a handful of the coal, burned at the winter burning and at the rites of the household, and no more. The custodians of Taigh na Fèithe⁶ above Muileann dhearg kept the law in Leabhar a' Chùraim⁷ and kept Crom's stone in the inner room, with a lamp before it that was never let go out. The law was bent three times in the age and broken once. It was bent when the custodians ruled in LE 25, after six winters of argument, that each hull of the fleet found ready might carry one sealed measure, a single household's season; when Na Seachd Taighean⁸ were made in LE 55 and the right passed by house rather than by apprenticeship; and when a smaller house was granted a neighbour's unused right at the last Cunntas nan Lámh⁹. It was broken

1. the Old Faith

2. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

3. the druid schools

4. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

5. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

6. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

7. the custody-book of the vein-house

8. the seven houses of custody

9. the census of hands

in LE 558, when Ragnall Ruadh refused the handful to every hearth and temple of the shires that stood against him, and Riaghailt an Teallaich¹⁰ of LE 565 bound every claimant, house and king never to withhold it again. The first asking to burn the coal for work rather than worship, Athchuingean an Airgid¹¹ of Clann Choinnich, was refused in LE 1,559, and the second in LE 1,776.

Òrd an t-Seabhaig

The dawn-hawk rite of An Aois Naomh¹² was kept at Cnoc bheag by a single family of hawk-keepers. In the third century of the count the priestess Gormshuil nic Artair, who took the mews from her father Artair, taught that the hawk of the rite was Mòd himself, Seabhag Acaill¹³, and that the vein under Muileann dhearg was a hawk of his kind: a hungry hawk, to be fed the measured handful and never gluttoned past it, since a bird fed past its measure is as useless as one starved of it. Her watchers called themselves a house and raised Taigh an t-Seabhaig¹⁴ below the mews block in LE 232; her pupils raised a second house at Ros gheal in LE 239, which took charge of the measured burning for the coast country. Ùisdean mac Pàdraig wrote her sayings after her death as Leabhar an t-Seabhaig¹⁵, and marked every saying he had not heard from her own mouth; the marked sayings outnumber the rest. Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹⁶ reached the south when the bell-founders of Muileann naomh hung a bronze bell in a hawk-house there, and at Muileann naomh the teaching held whole when it softened elsewhere.

At the council of Òrd an t-Seabhaig at Cnoc bheag in LE 889 a young priest asked whether Mòd would rather starve a grown flock than see his handful grown to meet it. Those who held that a greater household might rightly be fed a greater handful were named An Seabhag Biadhhte¹⁷, and asked to keep their teaching somewhere it would not be heard daily at Cnoc bheag. They settled at the northern Seann Skell on Bàgh an t-Seabhaig¹⁸, where the priestess Beathag nic Sheumais built them from four families into a school; her petition of LE 919 to raise the handful by a quarter for the north coast was refused, and the house went on as before.

10. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

11. the silver petitions of Clann Choinnich

12. the Holy Age

13. the Hawk of Acaill, whom the Hawk order calls Mòd

14. the house of the Hawk

15. the Book of the Hawk

16. the Hawk order

17. the Fed Hawk

18. the Hawk bay

The schools of the druids

Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹⁹ of Flidais, lady of the deer, taught Feallsanachd an Fhèidh²⁰, the stag's teaching: that the vein answers a hand for some measure in it, which the schools never agreed how to name. They had no ground of their own until LE 479, when they took up the yearly walk of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²¹ at Muileann chiar, a procession open to anyone who would walk it. Their elder teacher there, Beathag nic Ruairidh, told the travelling druid Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn that the schools wanted a fixed ground where the old question might be argued whole, and he raised Taigh na Deasbaid²² at Dùn thais in LE 314 with Carson an làmh seo?, why this hand?, cut on the lintel. The rule of the house was that a question once put was argued a full year before any answer came from the master's chair. Coinneach's own question in LE 324, whether the hands that went with the fleet were those the vein answered best, was forbidden at every one of Na Seachd Taighean²³ tables, the first time the houses forbade a question rather than a deed. Pupils of Dùn thais founded a second house of disputation at Inis mhòr in LE 769. Ragnall mac Chaluum's Clàr nam Bliadhnachan²⁴ at Dùn thais was forbidden in LE 1,219 and the house shut; it was opened and shut more than once and last reopened in LE 1,759 on condition that the question of longer lives never be raised.

The rival teaching of An Aois Naomh²⁵, that the vein answers labour and not birth, was woken at Doire chiar by Eilidh Dhubh from LE 460. Taigh na Fèithe²⁶ had some hundred of her tracts burned in its yard in LE 484, and the teaching went on in copies and in her pupil Coinneach Odhar's readings, without an order and without a house.

Òrd Mhacha, Macha of the two horses

Macha's rite was Òrd Mhacha²⁷ rite of the moors, which keeps the two horses of one chariot, foaled on one night, Liath Macha the grey and Dubh Sainglenn the black: light and dark, two powers in balance, and the vein belonging to both. At the rite the horses were brought up together to the yoke-poles and the worshipper stood with a hand on each pole, since one horse pulling alone draws a chariot only in a circle. King

19. the druid schools

20. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

21. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

22. the house of disputation at Dùn thais

23. the seven houses of custody

24. the table of years

25. the Holy Age

26. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

27. the order of Macha

Aonghas mac Uisdein took it up in his own old age in LE 441 against his councillors' warning, and within a year half An Talla Dearg²⁸'s household had taken it up with him, so that Òrd Mhacha became the order of Cathair dhearg without a quarrel fought over it. Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²⁹, held in common since An Aois Naomh³⁰, passed to Macha's priests alone by royal grant in LE 471. King Aonghas Òg was the first king carried to his grave by the rite in LE 484. Macha's temple at Cathair mhòr fed the burnt-out households of Doire mhin through the winter of LE 555 without asking whose claim they had favoured, and its fire was the first of the cold shires' hearths relit in LE 560. In the fifteenth century the priests raised their great house at Cathair mhòr, with a floor of black and white stone eleven years in the laying, the largest roofed building on Dia-thìr.

Òrd na Cloiche

At Inis thais the wolf-stone Clach had been watched for generations by families who kept the watch without a name for it. In LE 405 the net-maker Dòmhnall mac Ailein began to say on the strand that the stone was Lia Fàil³¹, which cries out under the rightful, and its watchers an Fhianna³², sworn to keep the whole island as a wolf keeps its range. His hearers became an Fhianna and raised the wolf-house, the first temple on the island to Lia Fàil by name, roofed with northern slate, and blew a horn at every turn of the tide. Dòmhnall taught on the strand five-and-thirty years and never took an office in the order named after his teaching. Òrd na Cloiche³³ and Òrd an t-Seabhaig³⁴ both claimed the harbour shrine at Caol leathan in LE 427; the king's reeve divided its hours between them. An Fhianna nursed the sick of Inis chrom through the spotted fever of LE 624, many of them dying of it. In LE 1,389 the congregation at Inis thais divided over whether the dead, who belong to Donn, might be prayed for by name at Clach; those who said no kept the temple, and the others raised a second house at Baile gheal.

Òrd Mhanannain, Manannan of the mist

Òrd Mhanannain³⁵ began on the quay of Seann Skell in LE 654, when Mànas mac Ruairidh, son of a sworn-man of the harbour-court, preached that the one power was

28. the red hall, the righ's hall at Cathair dhearg

29. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

30. the Holy Age

31. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

32. the Fianna, the sworn guards of the Stone

Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, whose cup, Cupa na Firinne³⁶, bears the yellow scorpion; that Manannan had shut the eastern sea behind the fleet with his mist, which hides Dia-thìr from every ship beyond it; and that the crossing must not be tried again. His own father knelt first. He blessed boats at Cidhe an Diosail³⁷ by passing a plain wooden bowl of harbour water over each hull, and his congregation later raised the silver for a proper cup of plain silver without his asking. Taigh Mhanannain³⁸ was raised beside the harbour-court. The teaching went down the coast with the fishing families to Ros bheag and Cuan shean, where the old rope-walker Tormod Ciar swore Cupa na Firinne on the rope-walk in rainwater cupped in his hands. In LE 694 the priests at Ros bheag laid down that no boat of the faithful might go out of sight of the headlands, and the rule of sight-of-land was kept on the west coast for the rest of the age. The synod of the order at Seann Skell in LE 1,590 laid down the rule of sight-of-land again and argued two days over a new prayer before agreeing its shortest form, to be said at the foot of the river pool: A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte. From LE 1,714 the priests said it on the day of Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh³⁹ as well, on the same stones, and neither the keepers of the rite nor the priests were pleased; by the end of the age they said it at every tide. In the age's last years the priest Mànas mac Dhùghaill wrote that the grey beyond the headlands stood thinner each year, and that he could not say whether the prayer held anything back at all.

The old spirits

The keepers of Na Seann Spioradan⁴⁰, the faith of the hearths, kept the ancestors in the east. In LE 179 they raised a spirit-house at Dùn ìseal and cut the names of the eastern dead on wooden posts, renewed each generation. Lightning burned the posts in LE 1,149 and the keepers cut the names again from memory and from Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴¹, owning in their roll that some were guesses. The shepherds of the Doire uaine hills lit no fire on the high pastures after dark, for fear of Marbh-bheò⁴² of the old carvings, and a reeve sent to argue them out of it came down before dark and never went back. The shrine at Seann Tarr held its feast-market from LE 644.

35. the order of Manannan

33. the order of the Stone

34. the Hawk order

36. Manannan's Cup of Truth

37. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

38. the house of Manannan

39. the rite of the empty harbour

40. the Old Spirits

41. the custody-book of the vein-house

42. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

The rites of the departed

No order made these, and every order kept them.

Oidhche nan Lòchran⁴³. On the evening before the sailing, beginning at one widow's window by the fish-stones, a lamp was set on every sill along the Seann Skell waterfront and kept burning till morning, though no one had told the town to do it. It was kept each year on the eve nearest the day of the turn, household by household, and thinned over the centuries until one old woman, Ealasaid nic Iain, kept the one lamp in the harbour-house window; she died in LE 1,800 and no one set a light there again.

An Tùrsa Geal. Queen Beathag put on undyed wool for her sister in LE 53, with no grave to stand at and no body to wash, and laid a cup, a trencher and a straight knife at the foot of her table each evening. Within a generation any household that had given someone to the fleet kept the same rite unasked. In the north-east it was kept in the undyed rain-cloth of Baile gharbh.

Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaìdh Fhalaimh⁴⁴. On the eve nearest the day of the turn the households of Seann Skell brought small lights down to the west quay and set them along the stones the fleet sailed from. The harbours kept it on different days until the bargain of LE 739 fixed one day for all of them, Là an Diosail⁴⁵. It was kept by fewer each generation; eleven people stood on Cidhe an Diosail⁴⁶ at the last rite this record tells of, in LE 1,803.

Faire a' Chinn⁴⁷. Faire a' Chinn was kept at Ceann mhòr from LE 66, household by household in turn, for returning sails that never came, and lapsed long before the end of the age.

Roghnaich. The rolls came to use the word roghnaich, to choose, standing alone to mean one who chose the crossing, and the harbour scribes let it stand.

43. the night of lamps at Seann Skell

44. the rite of the empty harbour

45. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

46. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

47. the watch of the headland at Ceann mhòr

APPENDIX C

The Reckoning of An Diosal

In An Aois Scaraidh¹ the island first numbered its years from a single day, and the day it chose was the day its kin went away. This appendix tells how the count was begun, how two offices came to keep it a year apart and settled the difference by agreement rather than by proof, how the moons were reckoned beneath the years, and how a year was written in the rolls of the age. The years of this record are counted from the first year of the age, the year the tidings of a far coast came to the quays; An Diosal² fell in its fortieth year.

Before the count

At the opening of the age no one on Dia-thìr numbered the years from any day at all. An Talla Dearg³ counted by reigns and by harvests, and the first year of the age went into its rolls as the ninth year of Queen Beathag, a good year for barley and a middling one for fish. Leabhar a' Chùrain⁴ at Taigh na Fèithe⁵ counted by burnings: a year was the year in which the handful was measured and burned at every lawful hearth, and it was named, when it had to be named, by the master of Taigh na Fèithe and the winter it fell in. The harbour-house at Seann Skell counted by the scribe's own keeping, the sixth or seventh year of Niall's boards. Clàr nan Rìghrean⁶ gave the names of the kings in order and the length of no reign. A debt within living memory could be reckoned so. The distance between two reigns could not, and no one had yet needed it.

Donnchadh's count

The count was not made at the time of the turn. Donnchadh mac Thormoid, a clerk of Taigh na Fèithe⁷, had entered the turn of the fleet in Leabhar a' Chùrain⁸ at six-and-

1. the Age of Sundering

2. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

3. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

4. the custody-book of the vein-house

5. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

twenty, under a day after Samhain, a full turning of the moon and more after every other account set the sailing itself; the leaf that reached him did not explain the gap, and he copied it faithfully. Four years later, at thirty, in LE 44, for his own ledger's convenience and for no reason he offered anyone, he began to number the years from the turn as *Leabhar a' Chùraim* entered it, and called them *Bliadhnaichean an Diosail*⁹. The word means, in the island's speech, a turning sunwise: the way a hand moves, a boat rounds a point or a procession goes about a cairn, with the right shoulder toward the centre and the course following the sun. He worked the count backward through his private book to the turn itself. There was no year nought; the years before the turn were counted backward, as years before the turn. No one above him asked him to keep it, and he told no one that he did.

The crown's own scribes at An Talla Dearg¹⁰ took up the count about a generation later, in the seventies of the age, setting aside the reckoning by a king's reign for the turning Donnchadh had first set his own hand to as a clerk of thirty. From that time the rolls of An Talla Dearg, *Leabhar a' Chùraim* and the harbour boards dated their entries by An Diosal¹¹, and the old reckoning by reigns survived in *Clàr nan Rìghrean*¹² alone.

The two counts

The harbour scribe at Seann Skell had set Am Falbh¹³ and An Diosal¹⁴ on one morning. *Leabhar a' Chùraim*¹⁵ set the turn after the next Samhain. The crown's scribes, taking up the count when the court remembered the departure as a single thing, counted from the year the ships sailed; *Taigh na Fèithe*¹⁶, following Donnchadh, counted from the turn as its own book entered it. Both began each year at Samhain, by the moon, as Talla na Lasrach¹⁷ had done before *Taigh na Fèithe*; so the sailing and the turn lay in different years of the old year, and the two counts stood a year apart. Nobody noticed for the better part of seven centuries, for the two offices seldom had cause to set a date of one beside a date of the other.

In LE 738 they found that their counts did not agree. Mòrag nic Ìomhair, a scribe of An Talla Dearg¹⁸'s own household, rode the thirty-nine miles to *Taigh na Fèithe*

6. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

9. the years of the Diosal, counted from the sunwise turn

10. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

11. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

12. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

13. the Setting-Out; lit. 'the departure'

14. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

15. the custody-book of the vein-house

with the crown's leaves, and the master granted her *Leabhar a' Chùraim* for as many days as the matter took. She and *Taigh na Fèithe* scribe *Eòghann mac Pheadair* worked three days by lamplight and traced the difference back to a single year early after the turn, entered twice by one office's habit or once by the other's. Neither leaf either scribe had brought could say which office had erred, or whether either had. In LE 739 *Taigh na Fèithe* took the crown's count for the one that would go forward, since it touched more households than *Taigh na Fèithe*'s own, and *Eòghann* wrote *Taigh na Fèithe*'s agreement to it in his own hand, the master's mark under his and the crown scribe's office mark under that. A later hand in *Leabhar a' Chùraim* adds that the scribes afterward ceased to pretend it had been fixed by proof. The same agreement fixed, for the first time, one day on which every harbour of the coast should keep *Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaigh Fhalaimh*¹⁹, which the two counts had placed differently; not one harbour wrote to complain of it. From that year there was one count of *An Diosal* on *Dia-thir*, and it followed the harbour scribe, setting the sailing and the turn both in its first year.

The thousandth year

By the settled count the thousandth year of *An Diosal*²⁰ fell in LE 1,039. *Na Seachd Taighean*²¹ asked Queen *Mòrag Ruadh* whether it deserved a feast or a fast, and she judged between them: one burning on the quay the count began from, no more coal in it than an ordinary hearth burns of an evening. She rode a week over frost-hard roads to stand on *Cidhe an Diosail*²² for it, and her own book gives the cost of the coal reckoned to *Taigh na Fèithe*²³'s weights and, beneath it, five words: one handful, nothing more.

The night-count and the moons

Beneath the years the island reckoned by the moon, and it counted time by nights and not by days. The night went before its day, as the dark half of the year went before the bright: a feast began at dusk on its eve, and a debt of ten nights fell due at the tenth

16. the vein-house above *Muileann dhearg*

17. the Hall of the Flame

19. the rite of the empty harbour

20. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

21. the seven houses of custody

22. the quay of the sunwise turn at *Seann Skell*

23. the vein-house above *Muileann dhearg*

dusk. Leabhar a' Chùrainm²⁴ calls this reckoning cunntas nan oidhcheannan, the count of the nights.

The year began at Samhain, with the dark half of the year. It held twelve moons of thirty nights and twenty-nine in turn, each begun on the night of the full moon: waning through its dark half to the dark of the moon, then waxing through its bright half to the next full. Below the moon the island had the half-moon, fourteen nights or fifteen as the moon ran, and no week. A debt, a sentence or a turn in the galleries was set by the half-moon; the markets met at the full, as Queen Sileas's charter to Cathair fhada granted; the night of the full and the night of the dark were rest-nights, on which no coal was cut and no net set.

Twelve moons make some eleven nights fewer than the sun's year, so about every thirtieth moon a thirteenth, Eadrach, the between-moon, was put in at the year's end, after Damhrach and before Samhnas, so that Samhain should not come before the summer was out. In An Aois Naomh²⁵ Talla na Lasrach²⁶ declared the between-moon; in this age Taigh na Fèithe²⁷ declared it, and entered the years in which it was put in beside the burnings. Harbour scribes dated deaths to it like any other moon: Calum mac Nèill died in the between-moon of LE 58.

The moons, in their order from Samhain:

NO.	MOON	NIGHTS	THE ROLLS OF THE AGE REMEMBER IT FOR
1	Samhnas	30	Samhain on its first night; the granary barred at Àth shean in LE 37
2	Dubhlas	29	the black moon; the temple fires of the cold shires going out in LE 558
3	Faolach	30	the wolf-moon; the first tale of a far coast on the quay at Cuan shean; Seumas Reultach's death
4	Gearras	29	Là Fhèill Bhrìde on its first night; Alasdair Saor setting out on the north road
5	Siolach	30	the seed-time; the granary doors reopened; An Gàire Dubh
6	Bearnach	29	the gap between the last of the stores and the first green; Queen Sileas at the widened bridge
7	Bealltach	30	Bealltainn on its first night; Fearchar Donn's death
8	Ògach	29	the young moon
9	Teasach	30	the hot moon; the launching of the last coaster Alasdair built
10	Lùghnas	29	Lùnastal on its first night; the custodians' count of the roll, nine days at the long table
11	Pailteach	30	the moon of plenty; the first household asking to be written on the roll

24. the custody-book of the vein-house
25. the Holy Age
26. the Hall of the Flame
27. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

NO.	MOON	NIGHTS	THE ROLLS OF THE AGE REMEMBER IT FOR
12	Dam-hrach	29	the stags' moon
13	Eadrach	30	the between-moon, put in about every thirtieth moon

How a year was written

An entry of An Talla Dearg²⁸ in the second half of the age opens with the year of An Diosal²⁹ and the moon, and, when the day mattered, the night of the moon counted from the full; the reign stands beside it only at a crowning or a death. Leabhar a' Chùraim³⁰, being older in its habits, set the burning of the year first and the year of An Diosal after it. The harbour boards kept the number of the year, the weather and the tide, and in the last centuries little else. Clàr nan Rìghrean³¹, recopied onto new hide in LE 829, set its beginning at An Roghnachadh³² rather than at the sailing and gave each ruler the years of the reign by An Diosal, the first list on the island to measure the distance between two reigns; where a name was lost, as for the fourth and fifth rulers of the house of Catrìona, the years were kept and the name was not. Clàr nam Bliadhnachan³³ that Raghnaill mac Chaluim set out at Dùn thais in the thirteenth century was a table of lives and not of the calendar: the birth and death rolls of the custodian houses set beside those of their tenants, which showed the heads of the houses living some years longer. It was forbidden to be copied in LE 1,219, and its working copy entered in Taigh na Fèithe³⁴'s inventory as one line among the galleries and Clachan a' Chrannchuir³⁵.

The day of the turn

Là an Diosail³⁶, the day of Deas-ghnàth a' Chalaiddh Fhalaimh³⁷, is the one day of the year the count gave its name to. It was fixed by the agreement of LE 739 and kept by every harbour of the coast together from the next winter. It was never agreed on what

28. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

29. the sunwise turn of the departing fleet

30. the custody-book of the vein-house

31. the king-list; lit. 'the roll of the kings'

32. the Choosing; lit. 'the choosing'

33. the table of years

34. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

35. the stones of the lot

36. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

37. the rite of the empty harbour

day the fleet had truly sailed. A scribe sent in LE 1,748 to note the rite for the crown's book asked the last old women of Seann Skell, and no two answers agreed; he wrote as much into the crown's own book, unable to choose among them.

APPENDIX D

Wars, Raids and Calamities

An Aois Scaraidh¹ was, for most of its length, a quiet age, and its clerks said so with some pride; a clerk of Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill wrote that in forty years he had set down no death by war, no famine and no quarrel of Na Seachd Taighean². Its wars were two, both over the crown, and a raiding on the north-west coast. Its calamities were the ordinary ones of an island that fished and farmed and cut coal under a mountain: storms, coughs and fevers, dearths, tremors in the hills and fire in the thatch. This appendix sets them down, the wars in some length and the rest in tables, with the numbers of the dead as Leabhar a' Chùraim³ and Rolla a' Chalaith⁴ give them. Where the rolls give no number, none is given.

Cogadh nan Trì Tagraichean

The cause. Tormod Bàn's two sons were drowned together when the ferry on the Abhainn fhionn overturned in LE 534, and his only brother, Aonghas mac Iain, had died four years before. The king named no heir in the thirteen years left to him; by the fourth year after the ferry the custodians of Taigh na Fèithe⁵ were reckoning openly who stood nearest the crown. Three stood nearer than any others: Dùghall Garbh, the king's half-brother, with a following at Baile Mòr dhomhain that owed him rather than the crown; Catrìona nic Aonghais, the king's niece, daughter of the dead brother, raised at Inis thais; and Ragnall Ruadh, head of Clann Raghnaill and, from LE 540, master of Taigh na Fèithe. When Tormod Bàn died in LE 547 at seven-and-eighty, Na Seachd Taighean⁶ could agree on none of the three and held An Talla Dearg⁷ in common.

The first years. In LE 552 the three claimants' heralds came one after another to the western gate of Seann Warr; its reeve Mairead nic Ruairidh shut it to all three.

1. the Age of Sundering

2. the seven houses of custody

3. the custody-book of the vein-house

4. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

5. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

6. the seven houses of custody

Dùghall besieged the town a fortnight in LE 553 and gave it up, its salt-pans and brine springs having fed it. In LE 554 Dùghall, led by drovers who had used a hidden ford for forty years to move cattle untolled, crossed his host in the dark above Àth shean and broke Ragnhall Ruadh's camp at the ford; Leabhar a' Chùrain⁸ counts some three hundred dead, most of them drowned. Ragnhall's men, going south with no grain and no standing, burned the granary village of Doire mhin in LE 555, and forty-one households walked six days to winter at Cathair mhòr on the charity of Macha's temple. Dùghall besieged Seann Warr a second time for a month in LE 556 and marched away when Catrìona closed the gates of Cathair dhomhain.

Sèist Cathair dhomhain⁹. The city had declared for Dùghall. Catrìona came against it in the autumn of LE 556 with a host she had held together through two lean winters on little more than her word; borrowed fishing coasters shut its water gate by night. With no ground beyond the walls for burying, the dead of the siege lines were laid near the well-heads, and a sickness of the gut ran through the streets and the garrison. On the fortieth day, in LE 557, its captain Niall Mòr mac Leòid surrendered on oath, and Catrìona let the garrison march out between her silent lines, wounded and dead named and carried.

The hearths refused. In LE 558 Ragnhall Ruadh, holding Taigh na Fèithe, handed the store-master Eòghann mac Dhùghaill a board naming every hearth and temple of the shires that stood against him and ordered none of them measured a handful. The carriers went down the white road with empty baskets, and through Dubhlas the hearths and temple fires of the cold shires went grey, among them Macha's fire at Cathair mhòr where the people of Doire mhin had wintered. A verse with no name to it went about those shires: that no battle was lost, only the fire. Dùghall came to Catrìona's camp with six men and no herald and offered to join their hosts, saying that whichever of them won, it must not be a crown that could shut a door on a shire's hearths.

Muileann chrom. In LE 560 the joined hosts met Ragnhall Ruadh below Muileann chrom, and Ragnhall fell on the field. The next morning his own custodians struck the seal from Taigh na Fèithe store without waiting to be told who now held the mountain, and the carriers went up the white road again. Dùghall Garbh hid a cut below the arm from his physicians and died of it at Baile Mòr dhomhain in LE 561, at one-and-seventy; his captains, led by Artair mac Lachlainn, came over to Catrìona unbidden. She was crowned in LE 562 at six-and-thirty and called Catrìona Bhuadhach, and in LE 565, in Taigh na Fèithe yard, she and the seven heads drafted Riaghailt an

7. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

8. the custody-book of the vein-house

9. the siege of Cathair dhomhain

Teallaich¹⁰, binding every claimant, house and king never again to withhold the measured handful. Seann Warr had its gates honoured in LE 594. Seònaid nic Coinnich, who had been a child in the charity of Cathair mhòr, wrote the war's history as Le-abhar nan Tri Tagraichean¹¹, finished in LE 624.

The sea-thieves of the north-west

From about LE 782 boats out of the small islands off the north-west coast boarded coasters bound for Baile chrom and took their grain, wearing no mark and hiding no face. Rolla a' Chalaith¹² of LE 784 named among them a fisherman's son of Baile chrom, Aonghas mac Ruairidh, and his mother told the reeve plainly that a young man who watches the fish thin goes looking for a living wherever it is still to be found. Half of Baile chrom stood empty by LE 789 and the crown remitted its dues. When the thieves put in twice in one moon within sight of the harbour, the reeve Coinneach mac Nèill asked for a force, and Eilidh Bhàn sent Iain mac Thormoid north by sea in LE 800. In LE 801, guided by the town's own fishermen through the channels, his boats landed at first light on Eilean dhubh and burned the thieves' hulls on the strand. Aonghas mac Ruairidh, one-and-thirty, was killed defending a hull; the thieves' leader Uilleam Ruadh, six-and-thirty, was taken and hanged at Cathair dhearg before the season turned. The raiding ended with him, and the dearth that followed emptied the coast the thieves had not.

Cogadh nam Bràithrean

King Ailean mac Raghnaill died in LE 1,266 at six-and-sixty and left two sons by different mothers, each told openly by the parent who raised him that he was the heir; An Talla Dearg¹³'s clerks left a blank on the burial roll where the heir's name should stand. For four years the brothers' households exchanged careful feast-gifts, until a messenger of Alasdair Bàn's was turned back at An Talla Dearg's gate at the feast of Bealltach. In LE 1,270 Alasdair's men seized Cnoc naomh and Iain Ciar took it back, and Na Seachd Taighean¹⁴ divided four to three. Both households set every road under one following's watch or the other. In LE 1,272 Alasdair's ships burned the waterfront of Ceann mhin, which held for his brother, and its rope stores and granary with it; Cathair mhòr fed

10. the ruling of the hearth; lit. 'the rule of the hearth'

11. the Book of the Three Claimants

12. the harbour rolls of Seann Skell

13. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

14. the seven houses of custody

the town that winter. In LE 1,274 Iain Ciar defeated Alasdair below Muileann ghlas, took him alive, and let his captains go home. Two years later the brothers made their peace at the road-house An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, on benches the keeper Mairead nic Mhurchaidh had measured to a finger's breadth, with the same loaf and the same jug at either end; both loaves were left uneaten. Alasdair held the lordship of Seann Chwen for life under the peace, kept it, and died there in LE 1,291. Iain Ciar was crowned at six-and-thirty in LE 1,276 and reigned fifty years. His clerk Pàdraig mac Ruairidh wrote the account of the war in his praise, finished in LE 1,304; it is the only account that survives whole.

Storms and the sea

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
6	off Ros àr-saidh	An Fhaoileag An Fhaoileag lies down in a following sea; eleven of fourteen drowned, three never found
259	Seann Toll	Am Fuath Mòr takes the harbour wall and forty boats at their moorings; eighteen drowned trying to save them
519	Cuan dhearg	An Gàire Dubh drives the sea over the waterfront and spoils the season's salt fish; the town rebuilds a street back from the shore
724	Cnoc chaol	a great swell with no storm behind it runs the drying-racks off the beach; two children taken
1,229	Inis mhòr	a gale out of the north-east drives the sea up the river higher than any then living had seen; boats crushed two deep along the strand
1,399	Seann Tarr	Gailleann Ghlas breaks the harbour past mending; its boats go to Cuan ruadh
1,734	Caol gharbh	the sea rises over the salt-pans and they fail
1,739	Baile ghorm	a south-westerly storm floods the low town; twenty-three drowned; the sea-wall raised by the height of a man
1,754	Cuan dhearg	the sea comes over the moved street to its thresholds; the town builds a sea-wall

Sicknesses

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
156	Caol fhiadhach	the coughing sickness; the reeve's wife keeps the shared board open and lives
557	Cathair dhomhain	a sickness of the gut from the wells fouled by the siege dead
624	Inis chrom	a spotted fever kills some forty; An Fhianna nurse the sick and many of them die

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
1,079	Muileann dhomhain	the swallowing cough; near a third of the town dies; the coast road shut three years from LE 1,082 and the cough never crosses west of the six fords
1,081	Seann Bhral	the swallowing cough; the townsfolk close the harbour themselves and leave food at the gate

Dearths and dry years

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
37	the shires south of the mountain	a lean harvest, the fourth-poorest in eleven years; the strife over the fleet's grain and the barred granary at Àth shean
324	the uplands about Baile Mòr mhòr	a run of poor seasons; the town all but doubles with families off the failing farms
810–821	the north-west shore	harvests fail one on the heels of the last; the shared meal can no longer carry them; Baile chrom emptied
1,479– 1,481	Achadh shean	three dry seasons; the crown's grain by the mining road; the deep wells shared by lot

Tremors in the hills

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
379	Cill ghlas	three wells cracked and a byre brought down; the deep galleries untouched
929	Cill ghlas	a gallery brought down on fourteen labourers of the custodians; the gallery closed with the dead in it and Clach nan Ceithir Ainmean Deug set at its mouth
1,649	Dùn iséal	the spirit-house cracked; no one killed

Fires

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
164	Am Buabhall Fort-anach	the old road-house burned to its footings; rebuilt in stone
446	Tobar dhearg	most of the village burned in its thatch; rebuilt in slate; the crown's grain sent south
484	Muileann dhearg	some hundred of Eilidh Dhubh's tracts burned in Taigh na Fèithe yard, by order

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
555	Doire mhin	the granary and a dozen houses fired by Raghnaill Ruadh's retreating men
1,149	Dùn iscal	lightning burns the ancestor-posts to their footings
1,272	Ceann mhin	the waterfront, the rope stores and the granary burned by Alasdair Bàn's ships
1,549	Ceann mhin	a second great fire; the town rebuilt with gable walls of stone

Floods

YEAR (LE)	WHERE	WHAT THE ROLLS GIVE
44	Àth shean	a flood cracks the middle pier of the bridge; shored with timber two winters and rebuilt in stone in LE 46
244	Seann Vell	the river breaks its banks in a wet spring and carries away the lower mills; rebuilt on the higher ground
534	the Abhainn fhionn	a spate overturns the ferry; the king's two sons drowned; the crossing moved a mile upstream
1,118	Drochaid Ros fhionn	the road bed gives way under a salt-carter's mule; the arches rebuilt by the salt-masters

APPENDIX E

OF THINGS FORGOTTEN

An age that begins with a fleet and ends without a boat that will leave the sight of land is an age of forgetting, and a' Scaradh¹ forgot more than most. It did not forget carelessly. It forgot the way a household forgets the craft of a dead grandfather: nobody asks for it, the last who knew it grows old, and one winter it is gone. This appendix gathers what the record says of the crafts, the lore and the measures the age had and lost, or kept only in a name, and of the houses on the roads that kept what the harbours let go.

The keel and the fleet

There was no keel on the island before the fifth year of the age. There were keels in the tellings: the old tellers of the west said that the boats of Rìghrean na Cloiche² had been built on a spine of oak, the ribs rising out of it like the ribs of a beast from its backbone and the planks pegged to the ribs, not sewn, and that such a boat stood stiff in a sea and could stay out for days. The boats the island actually built were sewn: planks split from oak and ash, laid edge to edge on bent ribs, sewn together with split root and twisted gut, the seams stopped with moss and tallow. A good sewn boat was light and supple and could be carried up a beach by six men.

Alasdair mac Iain, Alasdair Saor, a boat-wright of the strand below Seann Skell, learned the keel from hulls no longer than his arm that he floated in the river pool, and laid the first true keel in the fifth year on a bed of oak blocks above the high-water mark: the Queen oak of Doire fhionn, hewn with a ridge along its underside. The frames rose from it in pairs, one pair for each arm's length of its seventy feet, pegged with treenails of heart-oak and joined across by beams, crooks from the Bent Back and the Old Man's Knee and the wild wood by Loch chrom. The first hull, An Fhaoileag³, the gull, went out past Ros àrsaidh for her trial in the sixth year with fourteen aboard and lay down in a following sea. Alasdair redrew the run of the hull by a driftwood fire

1. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

3. the Gull, the first finished hull, lost off Ros àrsaidh

on the strand, fuller and hollow in the bow, and An Dara Fhaoileag⁴, was built to the changed pattern and rode true. Every hull of the fleet after her was built to it. The rope for their rigging came from the walks of Cuan shean, their sail-cloth from the levy of Baile àrsaidh; the grain for the crossing came down the Abhainn dhomhain in forty-one barges. Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill sailed as leader of the willing aboard An Ròn Glas⁵, the grey seal, with Catrìona nic Iain at the steering oar.

How many hulls went round the river pool sunwise on the morning of the sailing is not known. The harbour-house gives nineteen and one-and-twenty on different leaves; Niall mac Dhòmhnaill, eleven years old, cut a notch on a hazel stick for every hull that passed the quay wall, kept the stick inside his shirt, and was buried with it at his own asking in LE 104, the count never once spoken aloud. The tidings that came four years later told of two landfalls, reached by hulls that had not held together the whole crossing, and of nothing more.

The fellowship of the strand, sworn over a coal in the fifth year, outlived the fleet by two generations. Its master Coinneach mac Fhearghais, the first apprentice Alasdair swore, died in LE 68; his journeyman Griogair released the last journeymen from the oath in LE 84, judging there was no craft enough left in the island's boat-building to keep it; the patterns and keel-moulds, untouched for years in the shed on the strand, were burned for firewood in the hard winter of LE 85. When a merchant of Inis àrsaidh had a deep hull laid in LE 344 for the long coast run, no wright living held the old scarfing of the keel timbers that let a hull flex to a sea, and she listed at launch past any righting. A boat-builder of Seann Skell, Seumas mac Iain, laid another deep keel in LE 1,359; she filled and sank at the launching, and after a year of Manannan's priests preaching against his sunken hull he built no more deep keels.

Òran na Druime⁶. What the island kept of the keel it kept in a work-song. The rope-makers of Cuan shean walked their strands to a song their fathers had taught them, and in LE 1,389 Iseabail nic Lachlainn, a gatherer of songs for the royal household, took it down from Tormod Ròpaire's crew. It begins:

Druim fon aisne, aisne fon chlàr, clàr ri clàr is an cuan fodhpa. Keel under rib,
rib under plank, plank to plank and the sea beneath them.

The verses after it name the parts of a deep keel in words no one on the walk could explain; a young man of the crew thought them older speech worn smooth, and Tormod said it changed nothing about how the strand was walked. Iseabail read the whole of it before the king's hall in LE 1,391, and a harper and a vein-house clerk each said the

4. the second gull, the hull built to the changed keel pattern after the loss of An Fhaoileag

5. the Grey Seal, the hull that carried Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill's household

6. the song of the keel

words fitted no tongue or hand they knew. Her tablets went to Taigh na Fèithe⁷ at her death, where the clerks wrote into the inventory that the gathering held one item they could describe only by its sound and its keeping, not its meaning.

The star-lore

No pilot of the west coast had ever held a course by night when the fleet was building. Six were sent in LE 11 to the old steersmen of Cuan ruadh on the eastern coast, the only sailors of the island who ever had. Seumas Reultach taught them on the headland above the town the wheel of the sky, Reul na Stiùire⁸ Reul na Stiùire and the three that find it, the four turning marks of the year, which stars stand over the stern at Samhnas and which at Teasach, the smell of the dark before a change of wind and the look of the water under starlight when a swell is building. At Taigh na Fèithe's asking he had his granddaughter cut the first four of those on a scraped hide, and kept back the rest, saying some things a hide could hold and some things only a life could. He died in the moon of Faolach of LE 14. Catrìona nic Iain steered by the star in the trial off Ros àr-saidh and named it on the quay, and took it over the sea. On the island the lore was not needed again. By LE 698 a pilot's grandson of Ros bheag could not name the star his grandfather had steered by, and no one in his house had thought to write it down. The hide is not in any inventory the record gives.

The Baile ghorm blue

The dyers of Baile ghorm in the south-east made a fast blue from a marsh plant and a mordant of their own. Oighrig nic Ailein found the mixing that held it through washing after washing in LE 1,064, after ten years changing one thing at a time, and cloth of it became the feast-day dress of the custodian houses. The last dyer who knew the mordant quarrelled with both her apprentices and sent them from her house in turn, and died without teaching either; the blue that followed was the common blue of the island under the old name. The old weavers held a length of the new beside a length of the old and could tell them apart at a glance.

7. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

8. the steering star

9. the vein-house above Muileann dhearg

The grey glaze

The potters of Clann Mhic Phàil at Muileann gheal set a grey-green glaze on the custodian houses' table-ware that no other kiln could match, passed mother to daughter and never written, for a thing kept in the hand and the eye, they said, needs no writing. Iain Mac Phàil, the last of the family, took two apprentices in his last years and tried to set the making down; neither apprentice learned to judge the moment the kiln's heat must be let fall, and the moment would not go into words. He died in LE 1,509, and the town's potters tried for a generation to match it and failed.

The layered steel

The smiths of Dùn dhearg made the ceremonial blades of the custodian houses from steel folded and refolded in layers, from the building of the walls of Clann Ìomhair onward. In LE 1,568 the fellowship lost the last smith trained far enough in the folding to finish a blade alone. The blades made after him were ordinary work, prized for what the craft had been.

Firlot, tally and salt

The island had no coin in this age, and wanted none. It measured.

The firlot. Queen Sileas, watching a farmer and a grain-seller come near to blows below An Talla Dearg¹⁰ over the true size of a basket, had oak firlots cut to the capital's standard, bound with three iron hoops and marked with her mark, and sent one to every shire seat in LE 262, so that a basket weighed true at the capital weighed true anywhere. The firlot of Àth shean wore smaller with use than the standard, and had been smaller for generations before a young clerk found it in LE 1,498 and carried it up rather than let it stand.

The tally. A bargain was cut on a hazel stick split along its length, one half to each party; the grain of the wood runs true only when the two halves are laid together again, so no notch can be cut after. Queen Sileas set a tally-house in every royal granary in LE 284, and Cairt Mhargaidh Cathair fhada¹¹ three years later was the first market right cut on paired sticks. The sail-cloth levy, the barges of the grain strife and the drowned of Inis àrsaidh were all counted so.

Salt and meal. Where a toll was owed it was paid in kind. The keeper of Drochaid Ros fhionn took a handful of salt from every load that crossed his bridge from LE 369,

10. the red hall, the rìgh's hall at Cathair dhearg

11. the market charter of Cathair fhada

and his iron-bound salt-box filled faster than any box on that road; when the last keeper died in LE 1,172 the toll-gate stood open and no crossing was refused again. Beathag nic Thòmais paid for old boards in measures of meal, and a clerk lodging at a road-house left meal for his bed.

The road-houses

The houses on the roads kept, by their charters, what the harbours were letting go. Am Buabhall Fortanach, the old road-house by Doire shean, burned to its footings in LE 164 and was raised again in stone by Eilidh nic Chaluim, who served a boy of Clann Fhearchair juggled buffalo before the roof was on. An Leòmhann Buidhe¹², on the northern mining road, fed the coal-carters oatcake and heard their grumbling. Iain mac Mhurchaidh raised a second byre at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, at the halfway stage of the central mining road, and began a book of every ox-team that lodged there through the mountain snows; his line kept the house, and at it Iain Ciar and Alasdair Bàn made their peace. In LE 1,319 Iain Ciar chartered the seven great road-houses of the mining circuit, their keepers to meet once a year at An Sligeanach Fad' às¹³ to settle their accounts. The charter-roll records the secret syrupped beef of An Taigh-seinnse Òir¹⁴ and a reeve's complaint of its price; the itemised bill An Taigh-seinnse Reòta sent after a party of reeves snowed in, for every jar of pickled spinach and every cup of fire milk, paid in full; and Peigi nic Dhonnchaidh of An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹⁵ feeding Queen Gormshuil's whole progress on pan-fried spinach and black wine, for which the queen forgave her a year's road dues.

What was kept

Not everything went. Cidhe an Diosail¹⁶ kept its name, and Là an Diosail¹⁷ its day. The Child of Doire fhionn stood inside its wall. The last barge of the cold way lay chocked level on the strand at Inis mhòr, kept rather than broken up, though few could say any longer what the cold way had been the way from. The loft at Muileann chaol kept every paper left to it, on condition that nothing be burned, among them three copies of the tidings of the two landfalls that did not agree, all three copied fair by Beathag nic

12. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

13. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

14. the golden house, a waypoint inn

15. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

16. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

17. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

Thòmais and none chosen. Òran na Druime¹⁸ was sung on the walk at Cuan shean exactly as it had been given, no better understood.

18. the song of the keel